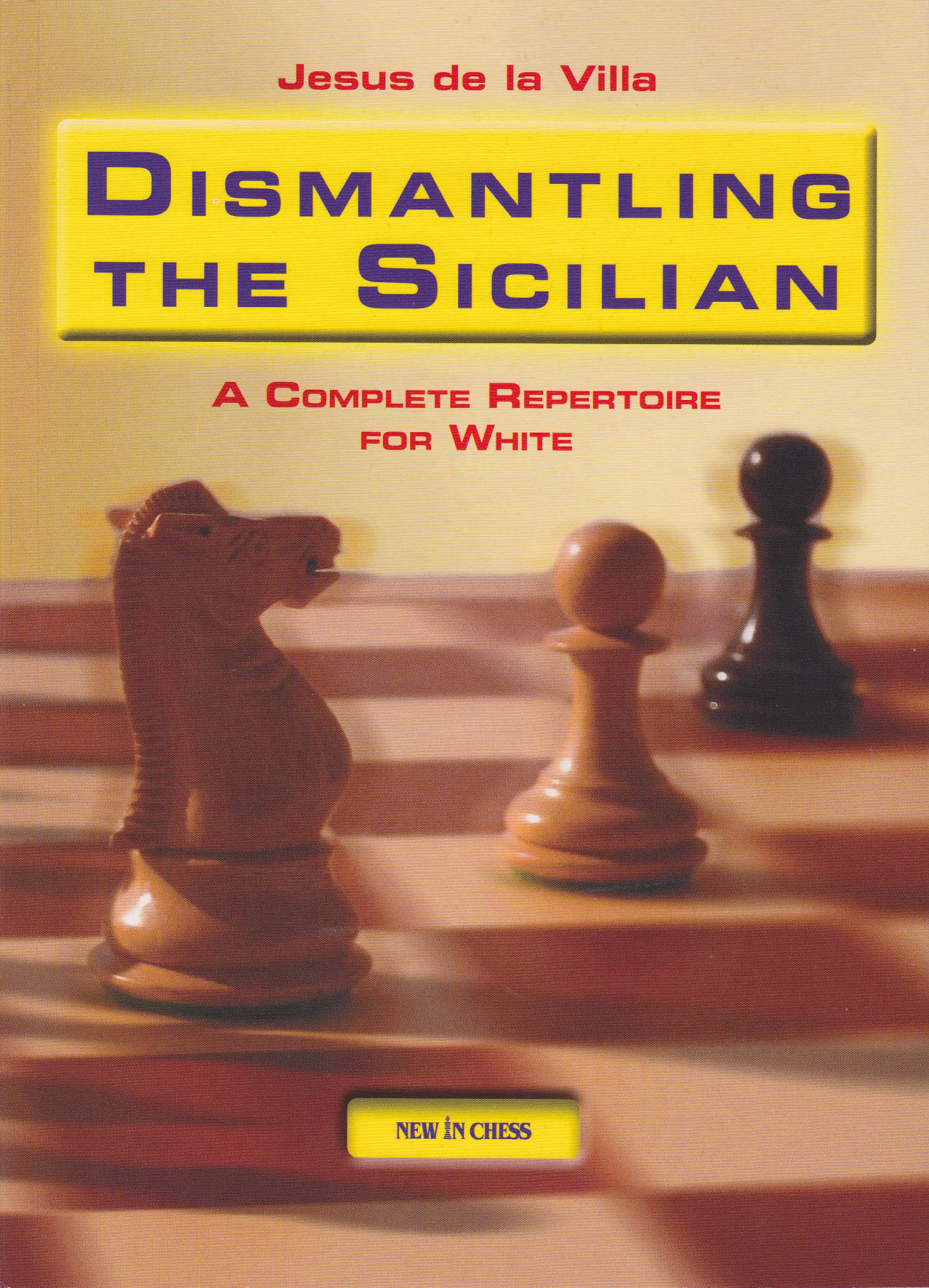
Jesus de la Villa

Dismantling the Sicilian

A Complete Repertoire for White



NEW IN CHESS

Dismantling the Sicilian

Jesus de la Villa

Dismantling the Sicilian

New In Chess 2009

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Introduction

This book deals with the study of the Sicilian Defence; however, the theoretical development has been so significant in recent years, that trying to cover all the variations of such a popular defence is somehow a utopian dream. Therefore, this book is content to offer a repertoire for White based on 1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 followed by 3.d4.

The Sicilian is the most widely used defence. According to different databases and different periods, percentages may vary, but will be around 20%; if we take into account only those games starting with 1.e4, the percentage of Sicilians may reach 40%. Furthermore, those figures have been increasing in recent years.

Therefore, my proposal is a repertoire based on the Open Variation, that starting with 2.♘f3 and virtually always followed by 3.d4. I think it only logical to devote our best studying efforts to a position that will probably arise quite frequently in our games, and to choose secondary lines against defences we won't face so often. Vast practical experience also indicates that, against the Sicilian, the prospects of an advantage with other moves than 2.♘f3 are not great. Flexibility and the surprise factor is one thing, and basing our repertoire on harmless lines is a quite different one.

My general philosophy for developing an opening repertoire is based on the following approach: against main lines, play main lines; against secondary lines, play secondary lines; against unsound lines, play the refutation. Some amateur players have asked me why, and I will try to state my case now:

- Main lines are usually the best and the most frequent in practice. Being the most frequent, it is worth being well prepared against them; being the best, we are not likely to find a way to an edge in secondary lines.
- We won't face secondary lines so often therefore it is less profitable to spend a long time on them in our preparation. A further point is that we would run the risk of reaching a good position, but one in which our opponent has far clearer ideas. A secondary defence is much more likely to offer secondary lines with good prospects for an edge.
- Finally, it is worth searching and finding a refutation against a weak system, since it will work forever. Besides, these defences will usually take us by surprise and we need a convincing preparation against them.

Of course, this is a basic approach and must be adapted to each particular case. Quite frequently, main lines may become secondary and vice versa; even some unsound lines may be rehabilitated, though this is less likely to happen. A flexible approach is always necessary.

Our playing style must have its influence as well when it comes to building our repertoire. However, if our style does not involve an open game against the Sicilian, then we should consider whether 1.e4 is right as our first move after all.

Although this book recommends main lines, from the point of view of the cur-

rent state of chess theory, the repertoire we present also tries to fulfil the principles of economy and coherence, by choosing lines that can transpose into one another, whenever possible, or that share strategic ideas.

Thus, there is one set-up which constitutes the core of this repertoire. It can be used (obviously, with important adjustments) against a wide range of variations (Najdorf, Scheveningen, Classical, Taimanov, Dragon, Kupreichik and some secondary lines). This set-up is based on the moves f2-f3, ♗e3, ♕d2 and 0-0-0.

I have always considered castling on the queenside in the open Sicilian to be rather logical: the rook immediately occupies the only open file (for White).

The position of the f-pawn allows some discussion. For many years, the general trend and almost a sacred rule was the idea that White cannot develop any active play against the Sicilian without the move f2-f4. Although well founded upon a wide experience, I have the feeling that this theory has been indiscriminately applied, thus leading White into trouble in several variations. The reason is that it fuels Black's counterplay along the a8-h1 diagonal, with pressure on e4 and, from that weak point, on White's position as a whole.

In the f2-f3 set-up, the point e4 has a solid defence. There is no need for White to worry about this square, and his plan is clear-cut and easy to carry out. This might be, if not a theoretical, at least a practical reason why White's results with this set-up have generally been so remarkable. Fischer's comment that the Sicilian Dragon was a weak defence because an amateur as White could easily defeat a Grandmaster with the Rauzer Attack, can be applied to a certain extent to other lines.

About the structure of this book

I have decided to present the book as a collection of annotated games, because I think this way the material will appear less dull. The readers may use it as a reference book or read it from beginning to end, in order to become familiar with the most frequent tactical ideas, transpositions and strategic plans.

A division has been made in four main Sections. The first contains minor second moves for Black after 2.♘f3, Section 2 deals with 4...e5, 4...g6 and 4...♘c6 systems after the exchange on d4, and in Sections 3 and 4, respectively the systems with 2...e6 and those with 2...d6 are discussed. Almost all systems have an individual chapter, though some have far less material. In my view, the current preparation and competition methods (I'm thinking especially about open and rapid chess tournaments) force us to possess an accurate knowledge of some specific refutations and favour the use of surprise variations. Many of these surprise weapons, despite their theoretical weakness, pose almost insurmountable complications in over-the-board play.

Furthermore, my aim has been to provide the reader with a complete repertoire and therefore to answer clearly to the question of what to play in all reasonable positions.

At the beginning and at the end of each chapter I have included short sections intended to make the study easier, but not strictly necessary for an experienced player.

The chapters open with the title and the diagram reflecting the starting position

of our study. The stars (* to *****) are a subjective evaluation that can guide the not-so-expert readers on the importance of the variation. For most readers, the stars will show the author's respect towards each set-up. They are intended to evaluate the theoretical strength, the historical importance, the frequency of use and the practical virtues of a specific system; of course, every player could have his own evaluation. In my opinion, there are a lot of underrated variations in the Sicilian (and a few, overrated). I have the feeling, reinforced by writing this book, that many are playable and pose problems for White, if the first player intends to achieve an edge.

The introduction tries to guide the readers on the themes of the chosen line and its relationship with other variations.

The historical note is a small homage to those people who have contributed the most to the development of the variation. Due to obvious space constraints, a deep research on the issue is out of the question. Here I feel obliged to mention the real father of the Sicilian Defence, Louis Paulsen (1833-1891). He was born in Germany but developed as a chess player in the United States. Paulsen investigated most of the important variations and understood the spirit of counterplay inherent in this defence. If the Sicilian wasn't named after him, it was due to random circumstances.

A deeper analysis of the ideas contained in every variation would have been interesting, but the book is already rather thick, so I considered it more important to go deeply into certain lines.

This structure should altogether help black players to choose some lines for their repertoires, though in this case they must complete their study with the attacking lines for White that we don't mention here.

In some cases, transpositions are frequent and, for the sake of clarity, the first moves of a game are not always presented as they were actually played, but following the most frequent theoretical order. I think it is better to explain that here, rather than mention the exact order in every particular case.

We have tried to present the material in a very clear way, without complex trees and with move-by-move explanations, with the exception of the more often repeated moves. We considered it very important to understand the position and to know the purpose of every move, in order to fix our memory and prevent our opening study from becoming useless, if we forget the lines after a few days or weeks. However, in some cases it has been impossible to avoid presenting a potentially disturbing branch.

This book is a revised version of the Spanish original *Desmontando la Siciliana*. We can't talk about a second edition, as most of the material has been changed rather than merely updated. Furthermore, some chapters are completely new and, in those which keep recommending the same lines, many model games are more recent and recommended subvariations have quite often changed as well. Nevertheless, we cannot talk about a new book either, since the structure and base material are the same. In some cases, I have changed my recommendations because some new lines are clearly better or have cast doubts on the old ones; at other times, the previously recommended line is still

equally interesting and the reasons for the change are less conclusive. In those cases (and some others) I refer to the original text, identified with the abbreviation 'DLS'. Of course, comparing both versions may be interesting for those who have the original book.

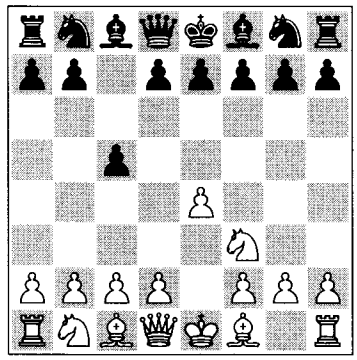
Despite all the hours devoted to this work, I'm perfectly well aware that some variations will not resist the passing of time and I hope the readers will show their sympathy. I also encourage them to continue their research and complete their repertoires, when necessary, consulting other sources and analysing on their own. However, I hope the recommendations from this book can help the readers improve their repertoire, bring them some sporting pleasure and let them have a good time with the analysis of memorable games and interesting positions.

Jesus de la Villa Garcia
Pamplona, May 2009

Section I

CHAPTER 1

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘f6
Nimzowitsch Variation and other moves



Evaluation **

This chapter will be a hodgepodge. Here, we will study all the options for Black on the second move, lacking a chapter of their own. The moves we will consider are 2...♘f6, 2...g6, 2...h6 and 2...♕c7. One of them, 2...g6, does not have its own chapter because the system we propose for White will be covered in the chapters devoted to its big brothers from the nice Dragon family. Two others (2...h6 and 2...♕c7), perhaps don't deserve separate chapters, but the case of the Nimzowitsch could be a bit unfair, so we will actually consider this chapter as the chapter on the Nimzowitsch Sicilian and will bring together the irregular lines here.

The move 2...♘f6 is perfectly sound and offers good prospects of equality, although it doesn't enjoy a vast popularity. The reasons are hard to understand. Perhaps it has to do with the fact that White can choose different ways and thus set the tempo of the game. On the other hand, 2...♘f6 may be appealing because it can transpose to main lines (such as the Najdorf) while avoiding annoying lines such as 3.♗b5 or 3.c3.

Precisely because of this, I have thought it convenient to recommend two lines: one is intended for those players willing to switch to main lines and playing 3.♘c3; the other line is intended for those who prefer to avoid these transpositions and 'punish' a possible bluff from the opponent. Since our repertoire in the main lines always involves ♘c3, our main line should be 3.♘c3 against the Nimzowitsch Sicilian, and this is the move played in our model game.

I think the 'official refutation', 3.e5 and 4.♘c3, is rather debatable and not very economical, as it requires an enormous effort to study, involves a possible minefield and finally, offers only a slight edge in the endgame.

History and Ideas

The move 2...♘f6 is just one more contribution to opening theory from the Hypermodern School. This one fits their ideas especially well: Black attacks White's pawn centre and provokes its advance, in order later to show its weakness. Nimzowitsch used it, quite successfully, many times. Other contemporary players, such as Rubinstein and Tartakower, also incorporated this line into their repertoires. The rise of 4.♘c3 and the alleged refutations lowered its popularity and thus it never reached the top players.

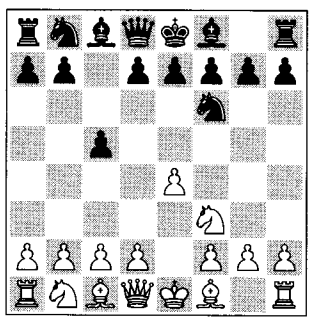
Recently, some investigators have found different improvements for Black and more or less well-prepared players use it now and then. However, it looks like its destiny is to be a surprise weapon.

The main original idea is to provoke White's central pawn to advance in order to attack it later. There are different set-ups, with a quite different nature, but open play, quick development and the search for immediate targets are the top priorities.

GAME 1.01

Yakovenko,Dmitry
Llobel Cortell, Enrique
San Sebastian Open 2006

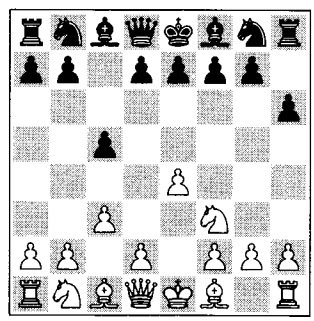
1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘f6



This provocative move characterizes the Nimzowitsch Sicilian. Other alternatives for Black without an individual chapter but deserving attention are:

O 2...g6 3.d4 ♗g7 Black can also choose this move order, but it wouldn't alter our plans, since after 3...cxd4 4.♘xd4 Black has no reasonable follow-up apart from transposing to the Dragon or the Accelerated Dragon: 4...♘c6 (4...♗g7 5.♘c3) 5.♘c3 – see Chapter 5. **4.♘c3** This is the simplest move to switch to the recommended variations against the Dragon or the Accelerated Dragon. Black is almost forced to capture on d4. As I mentioned above, I consider transposition the most effective and economical method, but for those players willing to go deeper and to have a specific treatment for this line, I recommend the following line: 4.dxc5 ♕a5+ 5.c3 ♕xc5 6.♘a3! although, we will stick to our approach and will not delve into this.

O 2...h6 3.c3



The virtues of the Alapin set-up look strengthened here. White is going to build a classical pawn centre, whereas ...h6 doesn't seem useful against this set-up. 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e5 6.♘db5 d6, when the g5-square is defended, illustrates Black's main idea very well. **3...e6** The fact that the main

advocate of the h6 line switches to this set-up, where Black's second move isn't very useful, says a lot. Let's see the most 'orthodox' alternative: 3...g5 4.d4 cxd4 5.cxd4 d5 is the logical reaction. Otherwise, White would strengthen his central position with a quick and active development (5...♗g7 6.♘c3 ♘c6 7.d5 ♘e5 8.d6±). 6.exd5 ♘f6 7.♘c3 ♗g7 (7...♘xd5 8.h4 g4 9.♘e5±) 8.h4 g4 9.♘e5 a6 (9...♘xd5?! 10.♗b5+ and Black also loses the right to castle, though castling wouldn't help much at this point anyway) 10.♗e2 (10.♕a4+!?) 10...h5 11.0-0 ♘bd7 12.♗g5 ♘b6 13.♕b3 0-0 (recovering the pawn wasn't possible yet: 13...♘bxd5? 14.♗xf6; 13...♘fxd5? 14.♘xd5 ♘xd5 15.♗c4+−) 14.♖fe1± (14.♖ae1, fuelling the plan with f2-f3, or 14.f3 directly, looks even stronger) 14...♘h7? 15.♗xe7?! (15.♘g6!+−) 15...♕xe7 16.♕xb6 ♕xh4 with some complications. Sulava went on to win this game against Palac, Montecatini 1995, which must have been a relief for the 'friend' who recommended 2...h6 to him. **4.d4 d5 5.exd5** 5.e5!?± transposes to a kind of Advance Variation of the French with an extra tempo, where Black's counterplay with ...f6 is slightly hindered. **5...exd5 6.♗f4** Again, 6.♗e3 transposes to a favourable version of the Alapin Variation, and 6.♗b5+ followed by ♕e2 isn't a trifle either. **6...♘f6 7.♗d3?!** 7.♗b5+!?; 7.♗xb8?! ♖xb8 8.♕a4+ ♗d7 9.♕xa7 ♖a8 10.♕xb7 ♖b8 with counterplay. **7...c4 8.♗c2 ♗d6 9.♗xd6 ♕xd6 10.0-0 0-0 11.♘bd2 ♘c6=** And finally Black has shown what he wanted to show. That is, that one tempo is not decisive for the outcome of the game, Döry-Bücker, Budapest 1984.

❶ 2...♕c7

A) **3.d4** cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 (4...e6 would eventually transpose) 5.♘c3 a6 with the idea ...e5 is one of Black's main ideas, which doesn't mean this position is entirely harmless for the second player after, for example, 6.g4, but in this case he has an interesting possibility of counterplay: 6...d5!?. Without this move, maybe this would have been the line selected for this book. 7.♘xd5 ♘xd5 8.exd5 ♕e5+ 9.♗e3 ♕xd5 10.♖g1 is a good starting point for research for ambitious readers, but there aren't examples in practical play and, worst, there won't be many opportunities to test it.

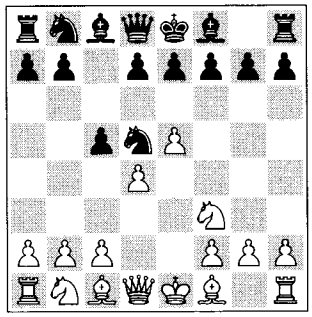
B) **3.♘c3** One step more towards transposition, but Black can still offer resistance with 3...a6 (3...e6 4.d4 cxd4 5.♘xd4 and Black has nothing better than to accept the transposition) 4.♘d5 ♕a5 (4...♕d8 5.d4 e6 6.♘c3 transposing) and now 5.♘e5 is very annoying.

C) **3.c3** Again, an Alapin approach must be the most efficient way against the not-very-flexible sortie of the black queen. **3...♘f6!?** Other moves allow White to set up his beloved classical pawn centre: 3...d6 4.d4±; 3...e6 4.d4±. **4.e5 ♘d5 5.d4** 5.♘a3 may be an attempt at improvement, but it will probably end up transposing as well. **5...cxd4 6.cxd4 d6** Since the queen may be harassed on c7, slower play would be reckless. **7.♘a3!** The white knight intends to occupy e5 or just support an eventual e5 pawn, but a potential jump to b5 is also disturbing. **7...a6** 7...dxe5 8.♘b5 ♕b6 (8...♕d8 9.dxe5 e6 – neither 9...♗g4 nor 9...a6 were possible on account of the threat 10.♕xd5 – 10.♗c4±) 9.dxe5 e6 10.♗d3±. **8.♗d3 e6** 8...dxe5 9.dxe5 ♗g4 10.♕a4+ ♕d7 11.♗b5 ♘c6 12.♗xc6± **9.♘c4 dxe5**

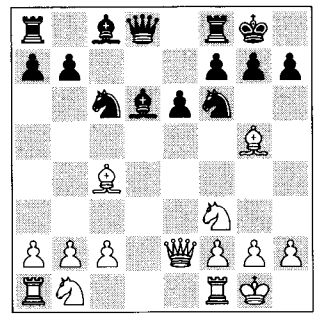
10.♘cxe5± 10.dxe5± **10...f6** 10...♗d6 11.♗d2 followed by ♖c1. **11.♘c4 b5 12.♘e3 ♗b7 13.0-0 ♗d6 14.a4±** Hazai-Csom, Budapest ch-HUN 1979.

3.♘c3

○ 3.e5 ♘d5 4.d4!?



This was the move recommended in DLS and I think it is still enough for a slight edge, but as mentioned in the introduction to this chapter, we consider the transpositional variation as the preferred option. The most theoretical lines start with 4.♘c3, but these require a big effort. If they guaranteed a convincing refutation, it would be worth the effort, but I just don't see it. **4...cxd4** Other alternatives are quite weak: 4...e6?! 5.c4! ♘b6 (5...♘b4 6.a3 ♘4a6 7.dxc5 ♗xc5 8.b4±; 5...♘c7 6.♗g5 ♗e7 7.♗xe7 ♕xe7 8.dxc5 ♕xc5 9.♕d6!±) 6.♗g5 ♗e7 7.♗xe7 ♕xe7 8.a4. The misplaced knight on b6 allows such a direct approach, which gives White an enormous edge. 8...d5 9.exd6 ♕xd6 10.b4!+– Geus Jan-Wonnacott, IECC 1999; 4...d6?! 5.dxc5 dxc5 6.♗c4 e6 7.0-0 ♘c6 8.♕e2± with a kind of classical position where White's space advantage will offer prospects of a comfortable kingside attack. **5.♕xd4 e6 6.♗c4 ♘c6** 6...♘b4 7.♕c3, hindering the f8 bishop's development: 7...♗e7 8.a3 ♘4c6 9.0-0± **7.♕e4 d6** 7...f5 leaves Black in a very clumsy position: 8.♕e2! ♘e7 (according to Rybka, Black equalizes with 8...♗b4+ or 8...♕a5+, but after 9.c3 White has several ways to keep the advantage in both cases) 9.♘c3 a6 10.h4 b5 11.♗b3± Tal-Zaitsev, Sochi Chigorin Memorial 1977. **8.exd6 ♘f6 9.♕e2 ♗xd6 10.0-0** 10.♘c3!? may be more accurate, hindering the plan with ...♕c7: 10...a6 11.♗g5 h6 12.♗h4 b5 13.♗d5 (13.0-0-0!?) 13...♗b7 14.0-0-0± Tkachiev-Shirazi, France tt 1996. **10...0-0** The move 10...♕c7! is perhaps more subtle, delaying castling and introducing ...♘e5 ideas: 11.♘c3 a6 12.♖e1 (12.♗g5 b5 13.♗d3 ♘e5 14.♘e4 ♘xe4 15.♗xe4 ♖b8=) 12...0-0?! (12...b5! 13.♘d5 ♘xd5 14.♗xd5 0-0 15.♗e4 ♗b7=) 13.♘e4!± Savon-Kirov, Sukhumi 1972. **11.♗g5** Again, the sequence 11.♘c3!? a6 12.♗g5 must be better, transposing to the game, but denying Black some options. Now:



A) **11...♕a5** seems dangerous to me, for instance: 12.♗xf6 gxf6 13.♘c3± ♘e5 14.♖ad1 ♘xc4 15.♕xc4 ♕b4 16.♕e2 ♗e7?! (16...♕xb2!?) 17.♘d4 e5?! 18.♘d5+– Jansa-Regan, Budapest 1978.

B) **11...h6** is a natural move and a good argument in favour of the 10.♘c3 a6 11.♗g5 move order: 12.♗h4 ♗e7= Leventic-Majeric, Borovo 2005.

C) **11...♗e7 12.♖d1** The actual order was 12.♘c3 a6 13.♖fd1! (the importance of placing this rook here will become clear in the note to move 15) 13...♕c7. **12...♕c7 13.♘c3 a6 14.♘e4!?** A very concrete way of creating problems. **14...b5** 14...♘xe4 15.♕xe4 h6 16.♗xe7 ♘xe7 17.♗d3 f5 18.♕e5± **15.♗d3 ♘d5** 15...♘g4?! 16.♗xe7± ♘d4? would win if the other rook were on d1: 17.♕e1! ♘xf3+ 18.gxf3 ♕xh2+ 19.♔f1 and Black has no compensation for the piece: 15...♘xe4 16.♗xe7! and Black loses material. **16.c4!** Weakening Black's pawn structure, and undermining the strong point d5. **16...♘f4?!** 16...bxc4 17.♗xc4 ♘f4 18.♕e3± is somewhat better **17.♗xf4 ♕xf4 18.♖ac1?!** 18.cxb5! axb5 19.♗xb5± is enough. **18...b4?!** 18...♘b4 19.♗b1±; 18...♘e5!? 19.♘xe5 ♕xe5 20.c5± **19.c5± ♖d8 20.♘d6 ♖b8 21.♖c4!+−** Santos-Jones, cr. 1981.

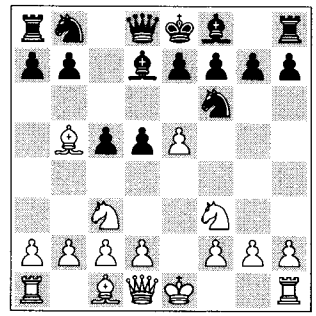
3...d5!?

The old line **3...♘c6** 4.d4 d5 has lost all its charm, since White has a pleasant choice between a slightly better endgame and a more complex position a pawn ahead: 5.exd5 ♘xd5 6.♘xd5 (6.dxc5 is the ambitious line, but after 6...♘xc3 7.♕xd8+ ♔xd8! 8.bxc3 f6± I don't think there is so much advantage) 6...♕xd5 7.♗e3 cxd4 8.♘xd4 ♘xd4 (8...♕a5+ 9.c3 ♘xd4 10.b4 ♕e5 11.♕xd4± isn't very different) 9.♕xd4 ♕xd4 10.♗xd4 f6± is a sad endgame for Black.

4.♗b5+

The alleged refutation 4.exd5 ♘xd5 5.♗b5+ ♗d7 6.♘e5 ♗xb5 7.♕f3 f6!∞ is a minefield. Maybe a perfect analysis can show an edge for White, but I'm not sure. What is clear, though, is that this line is dangerous for White.

4...♗d7 5.e5



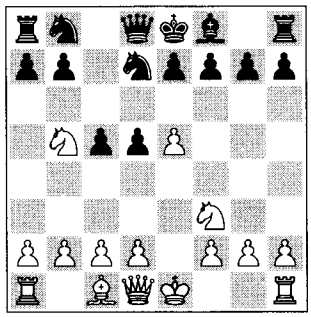
5...♗xb5

The most normal and also the most ambitious.

O 5...♘e4 allows a sacrifice similar to that played in the game, but in better conditions: 6.e6! fxe6 (6...♗xb5 7.exf7+ ♔xf7 8.♘xb5 ♘c6 9.0-0 h6 (Berelovich-Afek, Haarlem 2007) and now 10.♖e1! a6 – 10...e6 11.♕e2 ♕d7 12.d3 ♘f6 13.♗f4± – 11.♘c3 ♘xc3 12.dxc3±) 7.♗xd7+ ♘xd7 8.♘xe4 (8.0-0! and ♖e1 may be better) 8...dxe4 9.♘g5 ♘f6 (Sanchez Castillo-Calzetta, Torino Olympiad 2006) and now 10.d3 exd3 11.cxd3± gives White a good initiative.

O 5...d4! is the most solid option: 6.exf6 dxc3 7.♕e2?! (a not-completely-sound pawn sacrifice, typical for an initiative lover. 7.fxg7 cxd2+ 8.♗xd2 ♗xg7 9.♕e2± is also slightly better for White) 7...cxd2+ 8.♗xd2 gxf6 9.0-0-0 ♕b6 10.♗c4 ♘c6 11.♖he1 0-0-0 12.♗xf7 e5= Motylev-Nisipeanu, Romania tt 2007. Black has no problems.

6.♘xb5 ♘fd7



7.e6!

The point! If Black can reach a French structure without the light-squared bishop, he won't suffer.

7...fxe6 8.0-0!

Finishing development before starting with aggressive moves like ♘g5 or ♕g4 seems the best approach. 8.♘g5 ♕b6!.

8...e5

8...♕b6 is the computer's favourite choice, but 9.c4! leaves Black's structure in a miserable state: 9...♘c6 (9...a6 10.♘c3 d4 11.♘e4 g6 12.d3 ♗g7 13.♕e2±) 10.♖e1! (10.♘g5 dxc4 11.♘xe6 ♖c8 12.♘c3 ♘d4∓ is worse) 10...dxc4 (10...0-0-0 11.♖xe6 dxc4 12.♕a4 a6 13.♘c3± and c4 is going to drop too) 11.♘a3 ♕a6 12.♖xe6±.

9.♘g5!

Less accurate is 9.♖e1 ♕b6 10.♘c3 ♕d6 11.♘g5 a6 12.♕g4 ♘c6 13.d3 (13.♕e6 ♘f6 14.♕f7+ ♔d7) 13...♘f6 14.♕h3 ♘d4 15.f4 exf4 16.♘e6 g5!∓ Landa-Ibarra, Villarrobledo 2007.

9...♕b6

9...♘a6 10.c4! dxc4?! 11.♕f3+–.

10.c4!

The real structural blow; Black will have great difficulties in keeping his pawns without creating big holes in his position.

10...♘a6

10...♘c6 11.♕h5+ g6 12.♕f3 ♘d8 13.♕xd5±; 10...♘f6 11.f4! exf4 12.♘e6 ♘a6 13.♕a4 ♔f7 14.♘xf4±.

11.d3 g6 12.♘c3

12.♕f3! seems even stronger, for example: 12...♘f6 13.♖e1 ♗g7 14.♖xe5+–.

12...d4 13.♘d5 ♕c6 14.♕f3 ♘f6 15.♖e1 0-0-0?

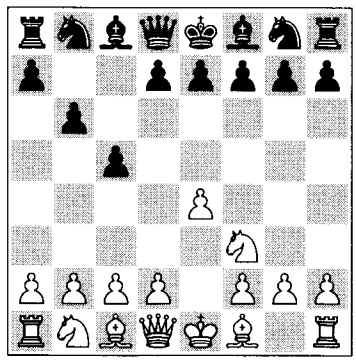
It is hardly surprising that Black loses his patience in this uncomfortable position.

16.♘f7 **1-0**

SUMMARY
1.e4 c5 2.♘f3
– 2...g6: transposes to Chapters 5 or 16
– 2...h6: an Alapin approach 3.c3 takes all the sting out ±
– 2...♕c7: White can choose between an Alapin approach or transposition to the Taimanov with 3.♘c3
– 2...♘f6 3.e5 ♘d5 4.d4!?: guarantees a slight initiative ±
– 2...♘f6 3.♘c3 ♘c6 4.d4 d5: solid, but with few prospects ±
– 2...♘f6 3.♘c3 d5 4.♗b5+ ♗d7 5.e5 ♘e4: better structure and more comfortable for White ±
– 2...♘f6 3.♘c3 d5 4.♗b5+ ♗d7 5.e5 ♗xb5: strong initiative for White ±
– 2...♘f6 3.♘c3 d5 4.♗b5+ ♗d7 5.e5 d4: quite solid for Black; again, but ±

CHAPTER 2

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 b6



Evaluation *

History and Ideas

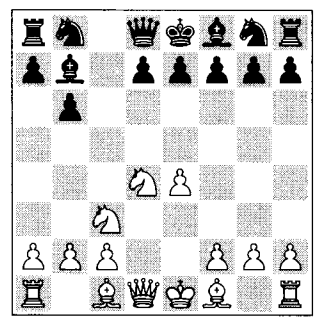
This is a relatively 'modern' variation, though you can always find games from the classical age. The Argentinean researcher Pelikan tested it, and it was later rescued by some Georgian players (especially Alexandria). In the 1980s it was relatively popular, thanks to Psakhis.

Usually its main idea is just to take the opponent out of theory and get a more or less typical position in the Sicilian, similar to the Paulsen. Therefore, it can be a very useful occasional weapon for players who have the Paulsen set-up in their repertoires. One encouraging sign is that some grandmasters have used it now and then with good results, among them Topalov, Vallejo and Korneev; nowadays, the great experts are the GMs Bauer and Cicak. The flexibility of Black's pawn structure allows the second player to get very different positions, with connections with the Dragon and especially the Paulsen. However, we must say that the fianchetto development of the light-squared bishop is somewhat slow and Black must be careful not to get his king trapped in the centre.

GAME 2.01

Panchenko,Alexander N
Psakhis,Lev
Vilnius 1978

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 b6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♗b7 5.♘c3



We reach the first position where Black has to make an important decision. The

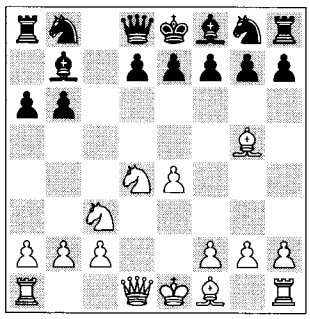
choice of many players is likely to depend on the other Sicilian lines in their repertoire, but not all the transpositions are equally valid.

5...d6

Although I don't think it is the best move, I choose ...d6 as the main line for two practical reasons:

1. The line I recommend against 5...a6, which is the most frequent move, has scarcely been played; and,
2. White's plan against ...d6 is the most standard and deserves more comment.

O 5...a6!? is a move that leads to positions similar to the Paulsen, thus reviving this variation, and the choice of the current experts Cicak and Bauer. **6.♗g5!**



Already recommended in DLS, this move hasn't achieved its well-deserved popularity yet. There is not much theory, but Black's difficulties in developing are huge.

A) **6...h6** 7.♗h4 d6 (7...g5?! leaves plenty of holes – above all, f5 – and looks too risky) 8.♗c4 ♕c8 9.♕e2 ♘d7 10.0-0-0 g6 11.f4 ♗g7 12.e5 dxe5 13.fxe5 ♘xe5 14.♗d5 ♗xd5 15.♘xd5 ♕b7 16.♘f3 ♘c6 17.♖he1 (17.♕e3!± with a crushing attack) 17...♔f8 18.♕e3 Moreno Carnero-Korneev, Dos Hermanas 2003.

B) **6...d6** 7.♗c4 ♕c7 8.♕e2 gives White a tremendous lead in development, too much even for a flexible defence such as the Sicilian. 8...b5 9.♗b3 h6 10.♗h4 ♘d7 11.a4 bxa4 12.♖xa4 ♘c5 13.♘d5 ♕d8 14.0-0! With all his army fighting against just a couple of pieces, White's moves play themselves. 14...g5 15.♗g3 e6 16.♖b4 exd5 17.♖xb7+– Sulskis-Poulsen, Klaksvik 2008;

C) **6...♕c7** is the best attempt to develop. **7.♘d5!** is the key move, which involves a pawn offer, but with obvious compensation: **7...♗xd5** 7...♕e5 is another way to win the pawn: 8.♗e3 e6 9.♘f3 ♕xe4 10.♘c7+ ♔e7 11.♘xa8 ♗xa8+– Groszpeter-Berezjuk, Pardubice 2000. **8.exd5 ♕e5+** 8...e5? is a desperate attempt to go on with development: 9.dxe6 fxe6 10.♕f3 ♖a7 11.0-0-0 g6 12.♕e3 ♔f7 13.♗c4 ♗e7 14.♗b3± Shaw-Sasikiran, Gibraltar 2005; although the move played in the game maintains a clear edge, 14.♘f3!+– seems much stronger and it is doubtful that Black can last many moves. **9.♗e3 ♕xd5 10.♗e2 e5!** 10...♕b7 11.♗f3 ♘c6 12.♘xc6 dxc6 13.♕d4± regaining the pawn with a clear edge. **11.♘b3 ♕b7** 11...♕xd1+ must be relatively the best: 12.♖xd1 b5 13.f4 and White's compensation is enormous. - **12.0-0 ♘f6 13.f4** 13.a4!?, trying to open the queenside, is another promising plan. **13...e4 14.c4 ♗e7 15.g4! 0-0 16.g5 ♘e8 17.f5** And now with 17.♕d4!±, White would regain the pawn while keeping all his assets. **17...♘c6** Rahal Vives-Bauer, France tt 2006.

O 5...♘f6, trying to make White define his position before moving any central pawn, but White turns the tables by not defending the pawn: **6.♗g5!** and now:

A) **6...♘xe4?** is not possible: 7.♘xe4 ♗xe4 8.♕e2! ♗b7 9.♘b5 d5 10.♗f4+−;

B) **6...e6?!** is not healthy either: 7.e5! h6 8.♗h4 g5 9.♗g3 ♘e4 (9...♘d5?! 10.♘e4! − with the threat 11.♘b5 − 10...♗e7 11.♘b5 0-0 12.♘bd6±) 10.♘xe4 ♗xe4 11.h4± Leitao-Limp, Sao Paulo ch-BRA 2005.

C) On **6...♘c6**, 7.♘f5 is very disturbing for Black's development: 7...h6 8.♗xf6 gxf6 9.♗e2 a6 10.♗h5 ♘e5 11.f4 e6 12.fxe5 exf5 13.0-0 ♕c7 14.♖xf5± Psakhis-Dizdarevic, Palma de Mallorca 1989.

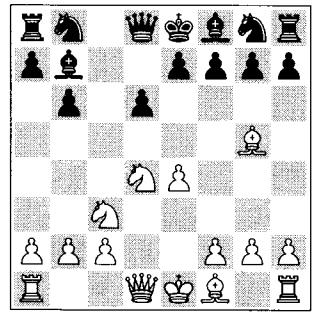
O 5...♘c6?! may be considered one of the weakest moves in this section. Black finds trouble in developing after the thematic move 6.♗f4! ♖c8 (6...e6?! 7.♘db5±; 6...d6?! 7.♗b5 ♕d7 8.e5 dxe5 9.♗xe5 a6 10.♗xc6 ♗xc6 11.♘xc6 ♕xc6 12.♕d5±) 7.♘xc6 dxc6 8.♕f3 ♕d4 9.♖d1 ♕c5 10.e5± is really overwhelming, Beliavsky-Quinteros, Vienna 1986.

O 5...e6?! weakens the dark squares too much: 6.♘db5! d6? (6...♘c6 7.♘d6+ ♗xd6 8.♕xd6 ♕e7 9.♗f4±) 7.♗f4 e5 8.♘d5! ♘a6 9.♗e3 ♗e7 10.♗c4 ♘f6 11.♘xf6+ gxf6 12.♕h5+− 0-0 13.♘c3 ♘c5 14.♗h6 ♘e6 15.0-0-0 ♕c8 16.♗xe6 fxe6 17.♖d3 1-0 Hecht-Velimirovic, Budapest 1973.

O 5...g6?! Not very consistent. White can choose his ideal set-up (♗e3, f2-f3, 0-0-0), while Black's queenside play is rather slower than normal: 6.♗e3! ♗g7 7.♕d2 ♘f6 8.f3 0-0 9.0-0-0 ♘c6 10.g4±.

6.♗g5!

As in many other lines, this move seriously disturbs Black's natural development.



6...♘d7 7.♗c4

Moiseev recommends 7.♘db5!, which forces an edge for White. 7...♘gf6 8.♘d5 ♗xd5 (8...♘xd5? 9.♘xd6++−) 9.exd5±. The light squares are like a sieve and Black has lots of problems in developing.

7...a6

7...♘gf6 is the natural developing move; however, after 8.0-0 ♕c7 (8...e6 9.f4 ♗e7 10.♗xf6 ♘xf6 11.♗b5+ ♘d7 12.f5+− and White fulfils his dream in many attacking variations in the Sicilian, that is, to blow up the light-square defence on d5-e6-f7) 9.♕e2 a6 10.f4± it is hard to complete the development.

8.♕e2 b5?!

8...♘gf6 9.0-0-0 (the plan 0-0 and f2-f4 looks more convincing in this position) 9...b5 (Novikov-Varchenko, Minsk 2005) and now 10.♗d5!, as in the main game, poses the most severe problems for Black.

9.♗d5! ♕c8 10.0-0 ♘gf6

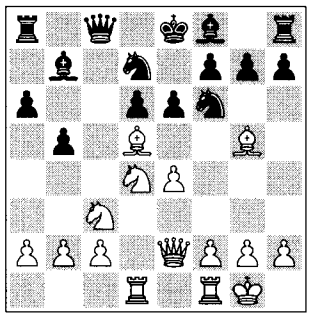
10...b4 11.♘a4 e6 12.♗b3 and now it is more difficult to develop: 12...♘gf6?! 13.♗xf6!± gxf6 14.♕h5+−.

11.♖ad1?!

Rather too harmless a developing move. 11.♖fe1! e6 (11...b4 12.♗xb7 ♕xb7 13.♘d5±) 12.♗xb7 ♕xb7 13.f4 with the usual plan.

11...e6

Black misses an opportunity to complicate: 11...b4! 12.♗xb7 (12.♘a4 ♘xd5 13.exd5 ♗xd5∞) 12...♕xb7 13.♘d5 ♘xd5 14.exd5 ♕xd5±, although White has a lot of compensation.



12.♘xe6!?

A long-term sacrifice, which gives a near-crushing attack in practical play. 12.♗xb7 ♕xb7 13.♗xf6 ♘xf6 14.a3±.

12...fxe6 13.♗xe6 ♕c5

Against 13...♗e7 Moiseev offers: 14.e5! ♕c6 15.♗d5! ♘xd5 16.♘xd5 ♗xg5 17.♕h5+ ♔f8 18.e6 ♘e5 19.f4+–, but maybe 14.♗xf6! is clearer.

14.♘d5 ♗xd5

14...0-0-0 15.b4 ♕a7 16.♘xf6 gxf6 17.♗xf6+–

15.exd5 0-0-0 16.♖d3! ♔b7 17.♖c3 ♕d4 18.a4! ♕e5

18...bxa4 19.♗xd7 ♖xd7 20.♖c6+–; 18...♕xa4 19.♗xd7 ♖xd7 20.♗xf6 gxf6 21.♕e8 b4 22.♕c8+ ♔a7 23.♖c7+ ♖xc7 24.♕xc7+ ♔a8 25.♕d8+ ♔a7 26.♕xf6+–.

19.♗e3 ♘c5

19...♘xd5 20.♗xd5+ ♕xd5 21.axb5 axb5 22.♖d1 ♕f5 23.g4!+–.

20.axb5 a5 21.b6 ♗e7?

21...♕h5! 22.♕c4! (22.♕b5? ♕e8 23.♕xa5 ♖a8 24.♕b4 ♖a4–+) 22...♕e8 23.♖a1 ♖a8 24.♖ca3 ♘xe6 25.♖xa5!+–.

22.♖a1 ♖a8

22...♘xd5 23.♗xd5+ ♕xd5 24.♗xc5+–.

23.♕b5 ♖a6

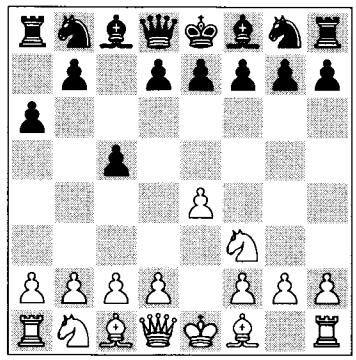
23...♘xd5 24.♖xc5 dxc5 25.♕d7+ ♔xb6 26.♗xd5+–.

24.♕c6+ ♔b8 25.♕c7+ ♔a8 26.b7+! ♘xb7 27.♕c8+ 1-0

SUMMARY
1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 b6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♗b7 5.♘c3
– 5...e6 6.♘db5: Black is on the brink of disaster
– 5...♘c6 6.♗f4: Black has lots of problems
– 5...a6 6.♗g5: Black has problems to complete his development
– 5...d6 6.♗g5: same as the previous line
– 5...g6 6.♗e3: White sets up a Rauzer Attack in good conditions

CHAPTER 3

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 a6 O'Kelly Variation



Evaluation **

History and Ideas

As happened with many other opening ideas, the originator of this line was the Polish grandmaster Savielly Tartakower. He tried it for the first time against Réti in their 1919 match, but probably Tartakower hadn't found the basic ideas. It was the Belgian player Alberic O'Kelly who analysed and used this variation in the 1950s. Thanks to the surprise effect and the success of its basic idea, this variation achieved good results for some time and even enjoyed a certain popularity. This popularity has survived at some levels and thus 2...a6 is the 5th most frequent move after the three big choices (...d6, ...e6, ...♘c6) and ...g6, which normally leads to a transposition. However, 3.c3 and 3.c4 gradually became frequent guests in tournament practice and the virtues of the O'Kelly have gradually disappeared, resulting in its current unpopularity.

This line is based almost entirely upon a clever idea. Black defends the important square b5 in advance, thus turning the characteristic move of the Open Sicilian, 3.d4, into a mistake, due to the sequence 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e5! Now the white knight is deprived of its ideal square b5, and of the reserve square f5 (on account of the typical counterblow 6...d5); a further point is that the dark-squared bishop may develop to b4 and as a result of all this, Black seizes the initiative and has a pleasant game ahead.

But all these virtues vanish if White delays d2-d4, and that is the source of Black's difficulties. White can pose severe problems to his opponent with either an improved version of the Alapin with 3.c3 or an ideal Maroczy with 3.c4. After 3.c4, Black usually switches to a kind of Paulsen Variation, where the early ...a6 is a minor drawback. Sometimes Black follows a path characteristic of the O'Kelly, searching for quick development and a central break. In that case (see Game 3.02) the loss of

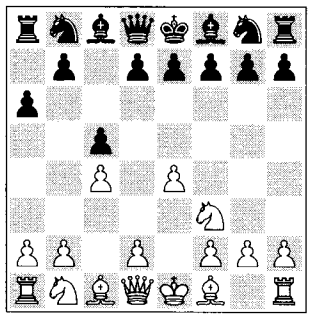
the bishop pair is the main drawback of Black's position.

There is a third group of lines, such as 3...d6, that allow comfortable play for White, with an important space advantage.

Game 3.01

Borkowski,Franciszek
Nazarov,Anvar
Katowice Open 1990

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 a6 3.c4

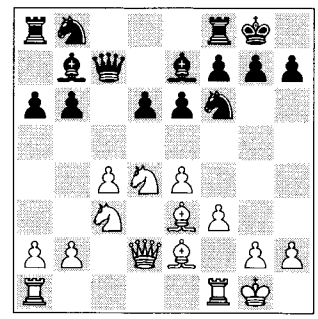


3.c4 is our recommendation against the O'Kelly. The idea is to reach a Maroczy formation in favourable conditions thanks to the time-wasting move 2...a6. White has another possibility well regarded by the theory, 3.c3. What White must clearly avoid is the natural move: 3.d4?! cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e5! and Black gets a favourable version of the Pelikan, thanks to his control of the b5-square. Now it looks as though Black has a fairly wide choice, but actually the number of useful moves is quite small.

3...d6

○ 3...g6?! 4.d4 leads to a very favourable version of the Maroczy set-up against the Dragon, as not only has ...a6 been a waste of time, but it has also weakened the b6-square. **4...cxd4 5.♘xd4 ♗g7 6.♘c3 ♘c6 7.♗e3 d6 8.♗e2 ♘f6 9.0-0 0-0 10.♕d2** 10.♖c1 ♗d7 11.f3± is similar **10...♘g4 11.♗xg4 ♗xg4 12.f3 ♗d7 13.♖fd1 ♖c8 14.b3 ♘xd4 15.♗xd4 ♗e6 16.♖ac1 ♗xd4+ 17.♕xd4 f6 18.♘d5±** Vukic-Pfeiffer, Oberwart 1991.

○ 3...b6 leads to positions typical of the Paulsen Defence or the Hedgehog against the English Opening, but Black's move order isn't very flexible and White's task is easier, as in comparison with the Paulsen he can spare the move a2-a3. **4.♘c3 ♗b7 5.d4 cxd4** Or else, 6.d5. **6.♘xd4 e6 7.♗e3! ♕c7** 7...♗b4, trying to exploit the omission of a2-a3, is harmless, since Black is not in a position to give his dark-squared bishop to capture a pawn: 8.♕b3! ♗xc3+ (8...♗c5 is comparatively better 9.♗e2 ♘c6 10.0-0-0±) 9.♕xc3 ♗xe4 10.0-0-0⩲ and White has more than enough compensation for the pawn, on account of his bishop pair, development lead and pressure along the central files and dark-squared diagonals. **8.f3 ♘f6 9.♗e2 d6 10.0-0 ♗e7 11.♕d2 0-0**



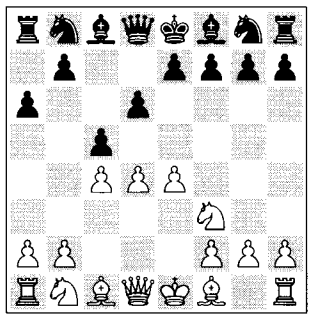
This game illustrates an interesting plan we won't study in detail because this position belongs more properly to the English Opening. In comparison with the Paulsen, White has spared a2-a3

and can launch an immediate assault against Black's queenside. **12.♖fc1!** To prevent tempting liberating moves like ...d5 or ...b5. **12...♘bd7 13.a4!** This forces the creation of weaknesses on Black's queenside. **13...♖fe8 14.a5 bxa5 15.♘b3 ♖ac8 16.♘xa5 ♗a8 17.♘b3 ♕b8 18.♘d4±** Zviagintsev-Fedorov, Samara 1998. The future is bright for White thanks to his space advantage and the weakness of the a6 pawn.

O 3...e6 4.♘c3! Avoiding the transposition to the Paulsen, things go better for White. **4...♕c7** After 4...♘c6 White can (and must, in view of the 'threat' ...e5) play 5.d4 cxd4 6.♘xd4, which leads to a variation we will examine in Game 3.02; 4...♘f6?! 5.e5!±. **5.♗e2 d6** (Leko-Zapata, Yopal 1997) A different approach is 5...♘f6 with the idea 6.0-0 e5, but nobody has played like this yet. **6.0-0 ♘f6 7.d4 cxd4 8.♘xd4 b6 9.♗e3 ♗b7 10.f3 ♗e7** and we have reached the note to 3...b6.

O For **3...♘c6** see Game 3.02.

4.d4



4...♗g4

The most interesting move. Much more passive is **4...♘d7** 5.♘c3 e6 6.♗e2 ♘e7 7.0-0 ♘g6 8.♗e3 ♗e7 9.♕d2 0-0 10.♖ad1± (White has more space and better development, but Black's position is solid and it is not easy to find something concrete) 10...b6 11.b3 ♕c7 12.♔h1 ♗b7 13.d5 e5 14.♘g1± Timmermans-Franklin, London 1997.

4...cxd4 5.♘xd4 ♘f6 6.♘c3 e6 would normally end up in the variation 3...b6 of the previous note.

5.dxc5 ♗xf3

Now Black forces his opponent to capture with the g-pawn.

5...♕a5+ 6.♘c3 ♕xc5 7.♕b3!±.

6.gxf3! dxc5

Trying to get a hold on the dark squares, especially d4. The alternative is not better: **6...♕a5+** 7.♘c3! dxc5 (7...♕xc5 8.♗e3 ♕a5 9.♕b3±) 8.♕b3! ♘d7 9.♕xb7 ♖b8 10.♕c6 e6 11.♕a4±. The compensation for the pawn is nearly non-existent: 11...♕xa4 12.♘xa4 ♘e7 13.♗e3 ♘c6 14.0-0-0 g6 15.f4±.

7.♕xd8+ ♔xd8 8.♗e3 e5

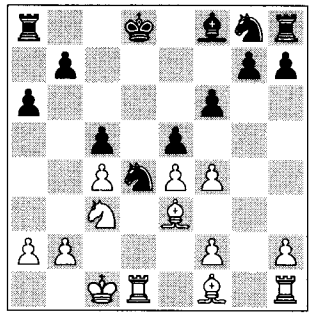
This move is a bit shocking, as it leaves all the light-squared diagonals open, but it is already hard to offer Black good advice: 8...e6 9.♘c3 ♘f6 10.0-0-0+! ♘fd7 (10...♘bd7 11.e5 ♘g8 12.f4±) 11.f4! ♔c7 12.f5±; or 8...♘d7 9.♘c3 ♔c7 10.0-0-0 ♖d8 11.♗h3 e6 12.♗f4+±.

9.f4

9.♘c3 may be a more accurate move order.

9...f6 (9...♗d6) **10.♘c3 ♘c6 11.0-0-0+ ♘d4**

The knight tries to cover all the holes, but White's numerical superiority is too much. 11...♔e8 12.fxe5 fxe5 13.♗h3 ♖d8 14.♖xd8+ ♔xd8 15.♖d1+±.



12.fxe5 fxe5 13.f4 exf4 14.♗xf4 ♔e8 15.♘d5 ♖d8 16.♗c7 ♖d7 17.♗h3 ♖f7 18.♖hf1

18.♗e5!?

18...♘h6

18...♘f6 19.e5; 18...♖xf1 19.♖xf1 followed by ♗c8.

19.♗c8

Finally White forces a material gain, while keeping all his trumps. The game is decided.

19...b5 20.♗xa6 bxc4 21.♖xf7 ♔xf7 22.♗xc4 ♗e7 23.a4 ♗d8 24.a5 ♗xc7 25.♘xc7+ ♔e7 26.a6 ♔d7 27.♘e6 ♔d6 28.♘xd4 cxd4 29.♗d5 ♘f5 30.a7 ♖c8+ 31.♔b1 ♘e3 32.♖c1 d3 33.♖xc8 d2 34.♗b3 1-0

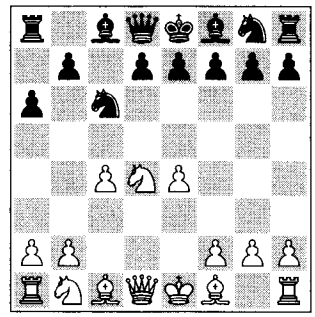
Game 3.02

Kondali,Jovan
Letic,Stevan
cr Vidmar-mem 1978

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 a6 3.c4 ♘c6

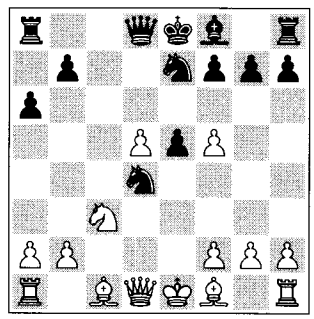
The main line and the best move to restrict White's choice, as it poses the positional threat ...e5, 'drying up' the game.

4.d4 cxd4 5.♘xd4



5...♘f6

Following the most frequent path. Black has two other reasonable alternatives:
O 5...e5 With a similar idea to the main line, but keeping the option of developing the knight on e7, which seems useful in some lines. **6.♘f5 d5** 6...d6 also deserves attention, with the idea of exchanging on f5 and then pressurizing the pawn. 7.♘e3! ♘f6 (7...♗e7 8.♗e2± and the knight on e3 prevents a convenient dark-squared bishops trade) 8.♘c3± reaches a very favourable position in comparison with the similar position in the Kalashnikov Variation. The knight occupies a perfect central position on e3 instead of a3. **7.cxd5 ♗xf5 8.exf5 ♘d4 9.♘c3 ♘e7** Whereas 9...♗b4 10.♗d3 ♕xd5 11.0-0 ♕d7 12.♖e1± (Sherzer-Polovodin, Philadelphia World Open 1991) speeds up White's development, and naturally 9...♘f6 transposes to the main line.



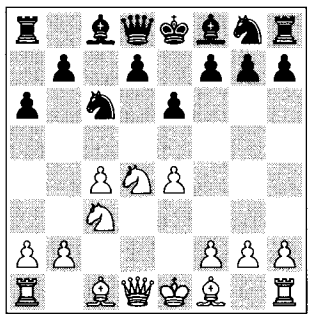
We have reached a critical moment. White has many attractive moves here. Among them, we recommend these two:

A) **10.♗d3** ♘exf5 11.0-0 ♗d6 12.f4 (recommended by Nunn in his book *Beating the Sicilian*. Less clear is 12.♕g4 g6! 13.♕h3 0-0 14.♘e4 ♗e7 15.g4?! ♘d6 16.♗h6 ♘xe4! 17.♗xe4 ♖e8 18.♗e3 ♗g5! 19.♗xd4 exd4∓ Vaskan-Kirillov, Riga ch-LAT 1966) 12...exf4 13.♗xf4 ♕b6 14.♗xd6 ♘b5+ 15.♔h1 ♘fxd6± Santo Roman-Franco Ocampo, Las Palmas 1991.

B) **10.♗f4!** Recommended in the first edition of this book, this hasn't yet been played in practice. 10...♘exf5 (10...f6 11.♕h5+ ♔d7 12.0-0-0±) 11.♗xe5 ♕e7 12.f4 f6 13.d6 ♕e6 14.♕a4+ ♘c6 15.♗c4 ♕d7 16.0-0-0 fxe5 17.fxe5 ♘xe5! 18.♖he1 0-0-0 19.♖xe5 ♕xa4 20.♘xa4 ♘xd6 21.♗b3±.

O 5...e6 The setting is more typical for a Paulsen Sicilian, but from a theoretical point of view it is different, because the knight has been developed on c6. By doing this, Black has strongly committed himself and White will exploit this premature development to achieve an advantage.

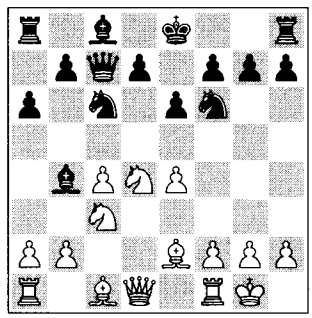
6.♘c3 and now:



A) **6...♘f6** as usual: 7.♘xc6 bxc6 8.e5±.

B) **6...d6** leads to a position similar to other lines, if not to a direct transposition: 7.♗e2±.

C) **6...♕c7 7.♗e2 ♘f6 8.0-0 ♗b4** Or 8...d6 9.♗e3 ♗e7 10.♖c1, immediately setting up ♘d5 ideas, which highlights one of the drawbacks of Black's set-up, for example: 10...♘xd4 (10...0-0 11.♘d5!±; 10...♘e5 11.f4 ♘ed7 – the knight has reached its natural square, but wasting two tempi, which White uses to adopt a more aggressive set-up: 12.♗f3 0-0 13.♔h1 ♖b8 (Galkin-Kalinichev, Internet 2004), and now White should have developed his initiative with 14.g4!±) 11.♕xd4 0-0 12.♖fd1 ♗d7 13.♕d2 ♖ac8 14.♗f4!± forcing Black to make important concessions to defend the d6 pawn.



9.♗g5 9.♘xc6 bxc6 10.♕d3± is another good plan. **9...♗xc3** 9...♕d6 10.♘xc6 ♕xd1 11.♘xd1 (11.♖fxd1!? is more ambitious, for example: 11...♗xc3 12.bxc3 ♘xe4 13.♗e3 bxc6 14.♗d4⩲) 11...dxc6 12.e5± Rublevsky-Fominikh, Elista 1996. **10.♗xf6 gxf6** 10...♗xb2! is the best: 11.♘xe6! (11.♗xg7 ♘xd4 12.♗xd4 ♗xa1 13.♕xa1∞) 11...dxe6

12.♗xb2± and Black will miss his dark-squared bishop but may consolidate his grip on some central squares. **11.bxc3±** Zviagintsev-Malakhatko, Herceg Novi tt 2001.

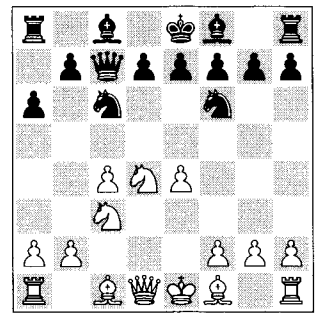
D) **6...♗b4 7.♘xc6! bxc6** After 7...♗xc3+ the dark squares must suffer a lot, but good practical examples are not to be found. **8.♕d4** The point, posing a double threat, one on g7... **8...f6** (8...♕f6 9.e5 ♕e7 (preventing c4-c5 but occupying the ideal square for the knight. Here White has only played 10.♗d2 but now both 10.♗e3!?± and 10.a3! ♗c5 11.♕d3± seem to give him an edge) 10...f6 De La Riva Aguado-Khamrakulov, Spain tt 2003) **9.c5!** This was the other threat. There is an enormous hole on d6 and the dark-squared bishop is doomed to be traded off or misplaced. **9...♕a5 10.♗e3 ♗xc3+** 10...♖b8!? **11.bxc3 ♖b8 12.♗c4 ♘e7 13.0-0 ♕c7 14.♖ab1** In view of the positional threat ♖b6 Black starts going 'mad': **14...♖b5!? 15.♗xb5 cxb5 16.a4 ♗b7 17.axb5 axb5 18.c4! bxc4 19.♕d6+–** Tsarouhas-Gogolis, Greece tt 1996; there is no compensation for the exchange.

6.♘c3 e5

Black goes definitely into the main lines of the O'Kelly Variation, which are somewhat complicated but on the whole unsatisfactory, and are thus the reason for the decline of the popularity of this Sicilian.

However, there is a plausible alternative, though it deviates from the typical ideas of this variation:

O 6...♕c7!? Playing with a certain Paulsen spirit, though less flexible (again, the knight is on c6).



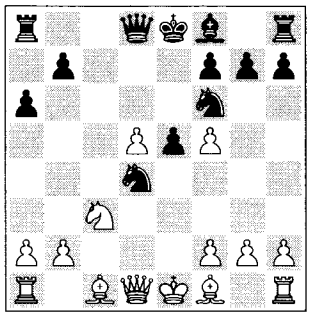
7.♗e3 After 7.♗e2!? e6 8.0-0 Black can transpose to the note to 5...e6, or play 8...♗d6!?, posing unusual problems and not much played. For example: 9.♔h1! ♗e5 (9...♘xd4 10.♕xd4 ♗e5 11.♕d3 d6 12.f4! ♗xc3 13.bxc3 b5 14.e5± (Nataf-Hamdouchi, Reykjavik 2006) and the position will open in White's favour) 10.♗e3 ♗f4 11.♗xf4 ♕xf4 12.♘xc6! bxc6 13.♕d4 0-0 14.♖ad1 preparing e4-e5. 14...e5! 15.♕d6 ♘xe4 16.♘xe4 ♕xe4 17.♗d3 ♕h4 18.♕xe5± (Dominguez Perez-Abreu Delgado, Holguin ch-CUB 2002) and White has a lead in development and the better structure) **7...e6 8.♖c1!** Standing opposite the enemy queen. **8...♗b4 9.♗d3 ♘e5 10.a3 ♗e7** 10...♘xd3+!? 11.♕xd3 ♗e7±; 10...♗d6 11.♗e2 h5 12.h3±) **11.♗e2 d6** An immediate 11...b6?! is worse due to 12.f4 ♘c6 13.e5±; 11...h5?! is too committal. The correct way was to keep along the path of the Hedgehog set-up: 12.h3 ♘g6 13.♕d2 d6 14.0-0 ♗d7 15.b4 h4 16.♖fd1 0-0 17.♗g5 ♖fd8 18.♘f3± Sokolsky-Bastrikov, Kiev ch-URS sf 1957. **12.f4 ♘ed7** To continue ...b6 and ...♗b7 (12...♘g6 13.0-0 0-0 14.b4 ♗d7 15.♕b3± Ibarra-Epishin, Roquetas 2006).

O 6...e6?! is now very dubious on account of 7.♘xc6± followed by e4-e5.

7.♘f5 d5

7...d6 8.♘e3! would reach the position mentioned in the 5...e5 line.

8.cxd5 ♗xf5 9.exf5 ♘d4



The critical moment in this variation. White has an extra pawn and the bishop pair in a very open position. Despite the d4 knight and the sure chances of regaining the pawn, it doesn't look as though Black can equalize completely.

10.♗d3

The most frequent move, but there is a positional approach which offers a more or less equivalent edge in a quiet position: 10.♗g5!? ♗e7 11.♗xf6 ♗xf6 12.♗d3 ♕d7 (12...0-0 13.0-0 b5 14.♕g4±) 13.♕h5±.

10...♘xd5 11.0-0 ♗b4

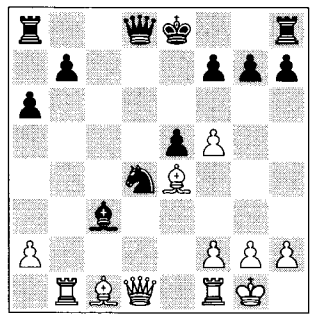
Without this pressure on c3, it would be hard to justify the loss of the light-squared bishop and show Black's idea to oppose the pressure along the diagonal.

11...♗e7 12.♗e4! ♘xc3 13.bxc3 ♘c6 14.♖b1 ♕c8 15.♕g4 (15.♕f3! 0-0 16.♖xb7! is a clear extra pawn) 15...0-0 16.♗h6 ♗f6 17.♖xb7 ♔h8 18.♖b6 gxh6 19.♖xc6 ♕d8 20.♖d1 ♕e7 21.♖dd6 ♖g8 22.♕f3 ♗g5 23.f6 ♕e8 24.♕f5 ♖g6 25.h4 ♗xh4 26.♖c7 1-0 Matanovic-Perez Perez, Belgrade 1961.

12.♗e4 ♘xc3

12...♗xc3 13.♗xd5! ♗xb2 14.♗xf7+ ♔xf7 15.♗xb2±.

13.bxc3 ♗xc3 14.♖b1



14...0-0

Giving back the pawn and offering a dominant position for the white rook. Other options deserve attention: **14...♖b8** 15.♕g4 g6 (15...0-0 16.♗h6 ♕f6 17.♗g5 ♕d6 18.f6 with a promising attack) 16.♗g5 gxf5 (16...♕c8 17.♗f6! gxf5 18.♗xf5±) 17.♗xf5 f6 18.♕h5+ Altshuler-Fink, cr ch-URS-4 1957-60, looks too much for a pawn.

15.♖xb7 ♕h4

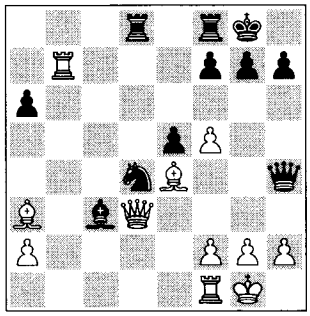
A move that had enjoyed a certain success in correspondence chess tournaments before this game.

O 15...♖c8 16.♗a3 ♖e8 17.♕h5 ♕f6 (17...♖c7 18.f6±) 18.♗d5 g6 19.fxg6 hxg6 20.♖xf7 1-0 Schreiber-Kunkel, cr. 1976.

O 15...♖b8 is a logical continuation to remove White's active rook: 16.♖xb8 ♕xb8 17.♕g4! ♕d6 18.♗g5 and it is impossible to prevent both f5-f6, weakening the castled position, and ♖b1, taking control of the critical file, e.g.

18...f6 19.♗h6 ♖f7 20.♖c1 ♗a5 21.♖c8+ ♗d8 22.g3±;
○ 15...♕d6 16.♕g4 (16.♗g5!± ♖fe8?! 17.♕h5+–) 16...♖ac8 17.♗g5 a5 18.♗e7+– Mastrangelo-Lupi, cr. 1983.

16.♕d3 ♖ad8 17.♗a3



White's pressure reaches its peak.

17...♘b5?!

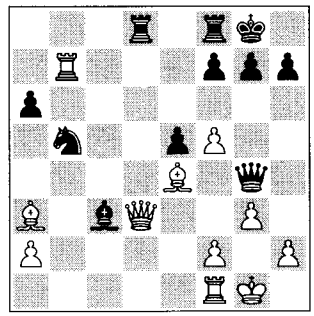
17...♖fe8 18.♕c4 ♕f6 19.♗d5 forces Black to give up the exchange.

18.g3!?

18.♗xf8! ♖xd3 19.♗e7 f6 20.♗xd3 with a crushing attack for White.

18...♕g4

According to Kondali's notes in *Chess Informant*, other moves just lose: 18...♕f6 19.♗xf8 ♖xd3 20.♗e7+–; or 18...♕h5 19.♗xf8 ♖xd3 20.♖b8+–.



19.♖xf7!+–

Now this decides the game.

19...♘xa3

19...♔xf7 20.♕c4+ ♔f6 21.♗e7++–; 19...♖fe8 20.♖e7 ♘xa3 21.♗d5++–.

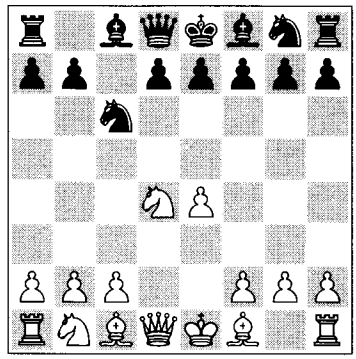
20.♖xf8+ ♖xf8 21.♗d5+ ♔h8 22.♕xc3 ♘b5 23.♕xe5 ♕xf5 24.f4 ♕f6 25.♖c1 ♕b6+ 26.♔g2 ♕a5 27.♖c2 ♕d8 28.♗b7 h6 29.♗e4 ♕d6 30.♕xd6 ♘xd6 31.♗d3 ♘b5 32.a4 ♘d4 33.♖c5 ♖b8 34.h4 g6 35.♖d5 ♖b2+ 36.♔h3 ♘e2 37.♗xg6 ♖b4 38.a5 ♖d4 39.♖e5 ♖d2 40.♖e7 1-0

SUMMARY
1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 a6 3.c4
– 3...g6?!: dubious; a bad Maroczy ±
– 3...b6: logical; a tough Hedgehog ±
– 3...e6 4.♘c3!: a slightly worse version of the Paulsen ±
– 3...d6 4.d4 ♘d7: lots of space for White ±
– 3...d6 4.d4 ♗g4: sharp, but weak ±
3...♘c6 4.d4 cxd4 5.♘xd4
– 5...e5: not enough to equalize ±
– 5...e6: a slightly worse version of the Paulsen ±
– 5...♘f6 6.♘c3 ♕c7: a slightly worse version of the Paulsen ±
– 5...♘f6 6.♘c3 e5: forces some precision from White, but is not very attractive ±

Section II

CHAPTER 4

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♕b6 and others



Evaluation **

Introduction, history and ideas

This chapter is the beginning of our study of a group of variations starting with 2...♘c6. We leave for the next four chapters the best known continuations, ...e5, ...g6 and ...♘f6, and we'll deal here with the other moves; the only important variation is 4...♕b6.

Again the originator of this idea was the father of the Sicilian Defence, Louis Paulsen, but then it remained forgotten until the 1960s, when several Soviet players such as Stein, Suetin and Gufeld started to pay attention to it and to use it as an occasional weapon. Then came the Armenian period, when Akopian, Anastasian and other players from that country turned 4...♕b6 into their hobbyhorse. Nowadays, its popularity has decreased, not for any particular reason, but players like Golod or Grivas often use it.

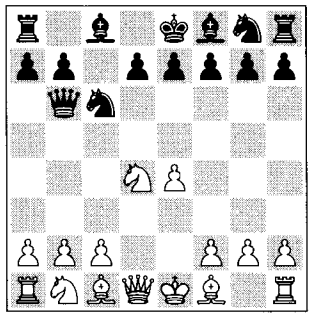
The basic idea of ...♕b6 is to drive the White knight off the d4-square, and later play a normal Sicilian, taking the queen back to c7. Then all the usual Sicilian plans may be possible. Since the knight is generally less active on b3 than on d4, it is hard to explain why this variation doesn't achieve its goals. It may be because it suffers from a certain lack of flexibility.

White has tried several set-ups, most of them involving queenside castling, or pawn assaults on the kingside, in spite of having castled there. However, in this chapter I recommend a very specific and less trodden path. White tries to take advantage of the position of the enemy queen on b6, in order to get a grip on the d6-square by means of ♗f4. First it is necessary to prevent the pin with the move a2-a3. If Black chooses the move order 4...♘f6 5.♘c3 ♕b6, which is rather riskier, I suggest a tactical refutation.

Game 4.01

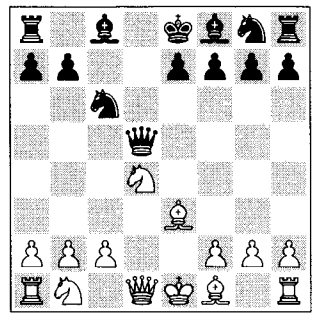
Topalov,Veselin
Morozevich,Alexander
Dortmund 2001

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♕b6



This is the correct move order to play this line. We will consider separately the order 4...♘f6 5.♘c3 ♕b6 in the next game, and recommend another continuation, though White can always transpose. Now we will consider the alternatives at the 4th move.

O 4...d5?! The only alternative in this section which carries a certain weight. As happened with many other opening ideas, the originator was Nimzowitsch, who surprised Rubinstein with this move in 1923. Although it has an awful reputation, some players (Brochet, some time ago, and Szabolcsi more recently), have used it with a certain success. Usually opponents are unprepared and there aren't any thorough theoretical recommendations. With accurate play, White can secure a slight edge but no more. **5.exd5!** The endgames arising after 5.♘xc6 bxc6 6.exd5 ♕xd5 7.♘c3 or 5.♗b5 dxe4 6.♘xc6 ♕xd1+ 7.♔xd1 a6 8.♗a4 (8.♘d4+ axb5 9.♘xb5 ♗g4+ 10.♔e1 0-0-0∓ is even more promising for Black) 8...♗d7 9.♘c3 ♗xc6 10.♗xc6+ bxc6 11.♘xe4 are virtually nothing, as many followers of theoretical recipes have already found out, to their regret. **5...♕xd5 6.♗e3** and now:

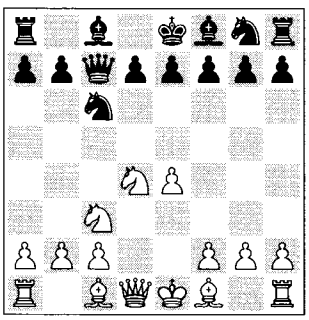


A) **6...♘xd4** is the most sensible option, though it means a theoretical capitulation. The endgame is unpleasant to play as Black. **7.♘c3** This wins a tempo and is an essential subtlety. **7...♕e5?!** Computers, which calculate everything, prefer ruining White's pawn structure with 7...♘f3+ 8.gxf3 (8.♕xf3!? ♕xf3 9.gxf3± may be better, as keeping the right to play 0-0-0 is really interesting) 8...♕xd1+ 9.♖xd1 ♗d7 10.♘b5 (10.♖d2! a6 11.♘d5± looks much stronger) 10...♖c8 11.♗xa7 ♖xc2 12.♗d4± Manik-Zambor, Kosice 1997. **8.♕xd4 ♕xd4 9.♗xd4** This is not a simple endgame for Black, because of his deficit in development: it is even hard not to lose a pawn immediately. The c3 knight is difficult to control. **9...♗d7** 9...a6? 10.♘d5+–; 9...♗f5?! 10.♘b5 ♖d8 11.♗xa7+–. **10.♘b5 ♖c8 11.♘xa7 ♖xc2 12.♗d3!+–** Kortchnoi-Reshko, Leningrad 1951; the black rook has no place to hide.

B) **6...e6** Probably the best practical chance. **7.♘c3** 7.♘b5 is a simple way to pose problems for Black. For example:

7...♕xd1+ (7...♕e5 8.♘d2!+−; there is nothing against ♘c4) 8.♔xd1 ♔d8 and now Fritz recommends the untried 9.♔e2!?± with the idea of speeding up the check on d1 and leaving the long diagonal for the light-squared bishop, which makes a lot of sense. **7...♗b4 8.♘b5!** The weakness of the point c7 is noticeable. Also untried and promising is 8.♕g4!?±. **8...♕e5 9.a3 ♗e7** Neither giving up the bishop, nor allowing the check on d6 seemed a good option, although Black even won the original game. 9...♗xc3+ 10.♘xc3 and it is hard to see any compensation for the loss of Black's bishop, for example: 10...♘ge7 11.♗d3 ♘d5 12.♘xd5 exd5 13.♕e2 0-0 14.0-0-0± and White already enjoys several small trumps. Vuckovic-Popchev, Beograd 2000. **10.♗e2 a6** The annoying knight must be expelled but now the b6-square will suffer. **11.♘d4 ♘f6** (11...♗d7 12.♘f3 ♕c7 13.♘a4!± with an eye on the b6-square. For example: 13...♘f6 14.♗b6 ♕f4 15.♘c5 ♗xc5 16.♗xc5 ♕f5 17.b4±) **12.♗f3** was the continuation of the game Parma-Knezevic, Titograd ch-YUG 1965; but 12.♘xc6!± bxc6 13.0-0 0-0 14.♕d4 ♕xd4 15.♗xd4 looks far better: White has a better pawn structure just for free.

O 4...♕c7!? A very interesting move; although after 5.♘c3



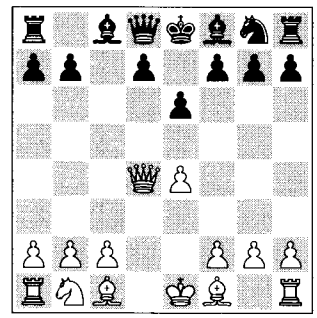
Black must transpose to the Taimanov Variation (with 5...e6), he's happy to have avoided the Maroczy Bind, a real torture for many players. If not, alternatives are not really serious, for instance:

A) 5...g6? 6.♘db5! ♕a5 (6...♕b8 7.♘d5+−) 7.♗d2+− followed by ♘d5;

B) 5...♘f6 6.♘db5 ♕b8 7.♘d5±;

C) 5...a6?! 6.♘d5 ♕e5 (6...♕d8 7.♗e3+−) 7.♗d3 (7.♘f3+− is also good) 7...♕xd4 (7...♘xd4 8.♗f4+−) 8.♗e3 ♕e5 9.♗b6+−.

O 4...♘xd4?! helps White carry out his plan with 0-0-0. **5.♕xd4 e6**



Perhaps the only way to justify the previous move. The knight heads for c6 to win time and drive the white queen off her excellent central position but, despite Khrenov's efforts in his correspondence games, this line will never become very popular. 5...d6 6.♘c3 ♘f6 7.♗g5± doesn't even make sense, as it leads to a Richter with an extra move for White. **6.♘c3 ♘e7 7.♗e3 ♘c6 8.♕d2 ♗b4** 8...♗e7 9.0-0-0± is the kind of set-up we play in other variations with some trumps, for example: 8...a6 9.0-0-0 ♗b4 10.a3 ♗a5 11.♗c5± Azarov-Ortega Hermida, Las Palmas 2003. **9.a3 ♕a5** 9...♗a5 10.b4 ♗b6 11.♘b5±. **10.0-0-0 ♗xc3 11.♕xc3 ♕xc3 12.bxc3 b6 13.♗e2±** and then double rooks on the d-file.

O 4...e5, **4...g6** and **4...♘c6** will be examined in the subsequent chapters.

5.♘b3

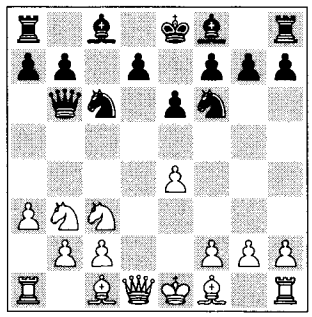
White must accept his knight being displaced and try to show that it has some advantages too.

5...♘f6

Other moves are not so common, but at least one of them has some sting.

5...e6 with the idea of securing the development of the bishop on b4. 6.♘c3 ♗b4!? 7.♕g4! (not very widely played, but it looks quite strong. 7.♗d2 is deeply analysed in DLS, is still playable and quite unknown, for example: 7...♘f6 8.♗d3!? ♘e5 (8...0-0 9.a3 ♗e7 10.0-0 d6 11.♔h1 a6 12.f4 ♕c7 13.♕f3 followed by ♖ae1 and an eventual ♕h3) 9.0-0 0-0 (9...♘xd3 10.cxd3 0-0 11.♗e3±) 10.♗e2 ♘c6 11.♗e3 ♕c7 12.♘b5 ♕b8 13.a3 ♗e7 14.♘c3± is better for White than the usual lines in the Scheveningen) 7...♔f8 (7...g6 8.♕f3 ♘e5 9.♕g3 ♕c7 10.♗d2±) 8.♗d3 ♘f6 9.♕h4 ♘e5 10.0-0±.

6.♘c3 e6 7.a3!?

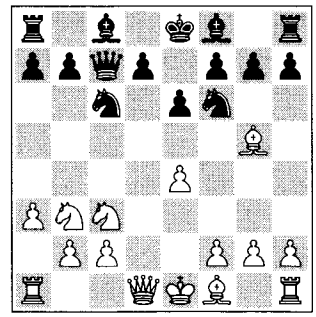


In this case I recommend a very marginal line, but just because I'm convinced that it is not worse than other alternatives and requires less updating effort.

7...♗e7

When you know White's idea (which usually happens the second time you face this line), it is really hard to resist the temptation to prevent it by moving the queen immediately back to c7, but there are other alternatives.

O 7...♕c7!? 8.♗g5 This move, recommended in DLS, has been played just 4 times since then, according to my database, and there is much to be tested (8.♗e3!? and then a similar and also untested development to that in the English Attack).



Black has many options:

A) **8...a6** gives White more options but must transpose. 9.f4! (9.♗xf6 gxf6 10.♕h5. In these structures, the white queen is very well placed here, but... 10...♗d6! 11.0-0-0 ♗e5∞) 9...h6 (9...d6 10.♗xf6! and now, if 10...gxf6, 11.♕h5± with the idea f4-f5-fxe6; 9...♗e7 transposes) 10.♗xf6 gxf6 11.g3! b5 12.♗g2 ♗b7 13.♕h5± Huerga-Kononenko, Cappelle la Grande 2009. There is no safe place for the black king and White will soon castle and then think about central action.

B) **8...d6** 9.f4 is also a transposition;

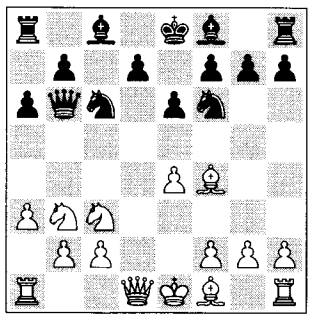
C) **8...♗e7** 9.f4 (with the apparent threat e4-e5) and now:

C1) 9...d6 is very comfortable for White after 10.♘b5! ♕d8 (10...♕b6 11.♗xf6 gxf6 12.♗e2 ♖g8 13.g3 ♕d8 14.♕d2 a6 15.♘5d4±. The white pieces occupy optimal positions in this structure) 11.♗xf6 gxf6 12.♕h5 a6 13.♘5d4±;

C2) 9...h6 10.♗xf6 gxf6 (10...♗xf6 11.e5 ♗e7 12.♘e4) 11.♕d2 a6 12.0-0-0 b5 13.♔b1 ♗b7 14.♘d5!? (14.♗e2±) 14...exd5 15.exd5 ♕d6 16.dxc6 ♕xd2 17.♖xd2 ♗xc6 18.♘d4 0-0-0 19.a4± Bruned-M.Roos, Dresden Ech 2007;

C3) 9...a6! 10.e5 ♘xe5 (10...♘d5 11.♘xd5 exd5 12.♗xe7 ♘xe7 13.♗d3±) 11.♗xf6 ♗xf6 12.fxe5 ♗xe5 13.♕d3! ♗xh2 14.0-0-0 ♗f4+ 15.♔b1 and the white piece definitely outweighs the three pawns.

O 7...a6 8.♗f4!



With a grip on the d6-square and the threat e4-e5. **8...e5** Almost the only move, but it seriously weakens d5, and the queen is misplaced on b6. **9.♗e3** Stronger than the natural 9.♗g5 ♗e7 10.♗xf6 ♗xf6 11.♘d5 ♕d8 12.♘d2 (maybe the idea 12.♕f3!? recommended in DLS, is stronger: 12...d6 13.♖d1 ♗g5 14.h4 ♗e7?! 15.♘xe7 ♔xe7 16.♗c4 ♗e6 17.♗xe6 fxe6 18.♖h3 Filipek-Bezsilko, Ghent 2001; White has a strong initiative) 12...b5 13.a4 ♖b8 14.axb5 axb5∞ and despite the computer's optimistic evaluation, Black managed to get counterplay in the two games played so far, for example: 15.c3 0-0 16.♗d3 b4 17.♘c4 ♗e7 18.0-0 bxc3 19.bxc3 ♗c5= Barua-Gofshtein, Dieren 2007. **9...♕d8 10.g4** There are many other moves: 10.♗e2!? d6 11.g4 h6 12.h4 ♗e6 13.♗f3 ♗e7 14.♘d5 ♗xd5 15.exd5 ♘a5 16.♘d2 ♖c8 17.g5 ♘d7 18.gxh6 gxh6 (Lopez Martinez-Zhang Pengxiang, Spain tt 2005) and now 19.c3!±. **10...h6** 10...d6 11.g5 ♘g4 12.♗c1 and the knight is in trouble. **11.f3** 11.♖g1 d6 12.h4 is an alternative to consider. **11...d6 12.♕d2** 12.♗c4!?; 12.♘a4!? ♗e6 13.♘b6 ♖b8 14.c4. **12...b5 13.0-0-0 ♗e6 14.♔b1 b4 15.♘d5 bxa3? 16.♗b6+−** Heymann-Byhan, Leutersdorf Open 2001.

O 7...d6 8.♗f4! ♘e5 (8...♕d8 9.♕d2 h6 10.0-0-0 e5 11.♗e3 a6± Lopez Martinez-Spraggett, Seville 2007, and now the plan 12.f3 followed by g2-g4 and h2-h4 to exploit the breaking point g5 seems better) 9.♗e3 ♕c7 10.f4 ♘c6 (on 10...♘c4, 11.♘b5! is an important intermediate move: 11...♕c6 12.♗xc4 ♕xc4 13.♕d3±; 10...♘eg4 11.♗g1±) 11.♕f3 (followed by 0-0-0 and g2-g4) 11...a6 and a really curious fact: in 22 out of 23 games from my database where this position has arisen... it was Black's turn! The extra tempo must be useful for the attack; we still need practical tests: 12.g4! h6 13.0-0-0→.

8.♗f4! 0-0

Trying to prevent e4-e5 may be worse: 8...e5 9.♗g5! (9.♗e3!? ♕d8 10.g4 – 10.♗e2± – 10...d6 11.♖g1 h6 is less

clear) 9...d6 10.♗xf6 ♗xf6 (10...gxf6 is too ugly) 11.♕xd6 ♗e6 12.♕c5! and the compensation looks insufficient.

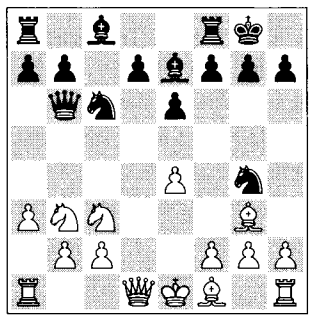
9.♗d6

In the light of recent experiences, this seems far better than 9.e5 ♘e8 10.♗d3 f6! (10...a6 11.0-0 ♕c7 12.♖e1 g6 13.♕d2 d6 14.exd6 ♗xd6 15.♗xd6 ♕xd6 16.♖ad1 ♕c7 17.♘e4± Ljubojevic-Panno, Vina del Mar 1988) 11.exf6 ♘xf6 12.0-0 d5 with a double-edged position.

9...♘g4

Obvious, but perhaps the modest 9...♗xd6 10.♕xd6 ♘e8± followed by ...f5 is better.

10.♗g3!



This bishop is the main character in the game and in this variation. It now defends f2 and the g4 knight is en prise. 10.♕xg4?! ♗xd6 11.♗d3 ♘e5=.

10...♘ge5

Against 10...♘f6!?, the still untried 11.e5! looks critical. Now the position of the bishop on g3 is somewhat better than on f4, for instance: 11...♘e8 12.♗d3 f6! 13.exf6 ♘xf6 14.0-0 d5 15.♘a4 ♕d8 16.c4!± and the black centre will be blown up or blockaded.

11.f4 ♕e3+

11...♘g6 12.♗f2! ♕c7 13.g3 a6 14.♗g2 b5 15.0-0 (the plan with 15.h4 is promising) 15...d6 16.♕d2±.

12.♗e2 ♘g6

12...♘c4? 13.♗f2+–; 12...♘g4 13.♘d2 (13.♕d2!? followed by 0-0-0) 13...f5 14.♘c4 ♕d4 15.♗xg4 ♕xc4 16.♗e2±.

13.♕d3!

Forcing the transition to an endgame which is not only not Morozevich's cup of tea, but also problematic for Black, who has less space and a misplaced knight on g6.

13...♕xd3 14.♗xd3± a6

14...d6!? 15.0-0-0 ♗d7.

15.0-0-0 f6?!

Again, 15...d6!? is better.

16.♘e2!

This way the dark-squared bishop is freed from the defence of f4 and will recover its active role on the g1-a7 diagonal.

16...b5 17.♗f2 ♖b8 18.g3! ♘h8!

18...d6 19.♘ed4±.

19.♖d2 ♘f7 20.♖hd1 ♖e8

20...d6 21.♘ed4±.

21.c3

White's pressure increases step by step. Now the bishop gets a square to open the line for the rooks and move to b3 after the knight jumps to c5.

21...e5 22.c4±

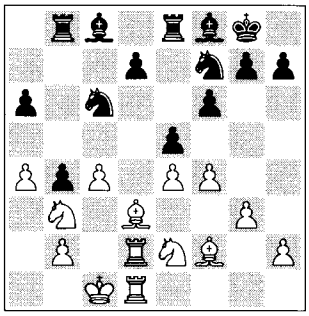
Exploiting immediately the weakness created on the a2-g8 diagonal (another way of doing this was 22.♗b1!?).

22...b4

22...bxc4 23.♗xc4 d6 (23...♖b7 24.♘c3±) 24.♖c2±.

23.a4 ♗f8?!

It was better to play 23...d6! 24.f5±.



24.c5!

Freeing the c4-square for the bishop.

24...exf4 25.gxf4 d6

Liberation is now essential.

26.♔b1 h5?!

Too active. 26...♗g4 27.♗xa6 ♖xe4 28.♗d3 ♖ee8 29.♖g1 ♗e6 30.♗b5±; 26...dxc5 27.♘xc5±.

27.♖c1± ♗b7 28.♗c4

28.♘g3! h4 29.♘f5±.

28...♖xe4 29.♗d5 ♘e7!

29...♖ee8 30.cxd6 ♘d8 31.d7±.

30.♗xf7+

30.♗xe4 ♗xe4+ 31.♔a2±.

30...♔xf7 31.cxd6 ♘d5 32.♘c5 ♘c3+?

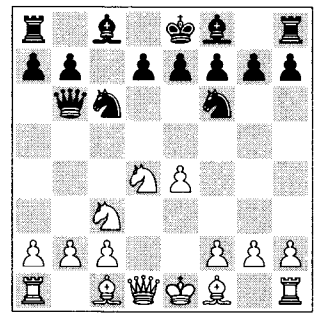
32...♖xe2 33.♖xe2 ♗xd6 34.♖d1±.

33.bxc3 bxc3 34.♖xc3 ♖b4+ 35.♔a2 ♗e4 36.♔a3 a5 37.♘d7! ♖8b7 38.♘xf8 1-0

Game 4.02

Votava,Jan
Voloshin,Leonid
Czechia tt 1998/99

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 ♕b6?!



Some players prefer this order to avoid 6.♘db5, which now fails to 6...a6 and if 7.♗e3 ♕a5. Now White can take it easy and transpose to what we analysed in the previous game, but he can also grab the bull by the horns and try to refute 'completely' this variation with the text move.

6.♗e3! ♕xb2

The principled line, but also the only move in view of the following variations:

O 6...♘g4 7.♘d5 ♘xe3 8.fxe3! (8.♘xb6 has been played a lot, and leads to double-edge positions, but it is unnecessary, as 8.fxe3 gives a clear advantage) 8...♕a5+ (8...♕d8 9.♘b5+−) 9.b4! ♘xb4 10.♘b3! ♘xc2+ 11.♔f2+− and White wins a piece at least.

O 6...♘xd4 7.♗xd4 ♕a5 8.e5 ♘d5 9.♗c4 ♘b6 10.♗b3±.

7.♘cb5

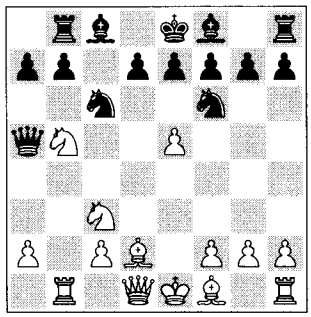
7.♘db5!, as recommended in DLS, 7...♕b4 8.♗d2! looks far stronger, e.g.:

A) 8...♘xe4 9.a3!+− ♘xc3 10.axb4 ♘xd1 11.♘c7+ ♔d8 12.♘xa8 ♘xf2 13.♔xf2 e6 14.c3 b6 15.♗b5 ♗b7 16.♗xc6 ♗xc6 17.♖xa7 b5 18.♗f4 f6 19.♖d1 1-0 Rada Equiza-Vavra, Brno 2006;

B) 8...♕a5 9.♘d5+−;

C) 8...♔d8 9.♖b1 ♕c5 (Tudela Corbalan-Garcia Padron, Santa Cruz de Tenerife 2006) and now 10.♘d5! (threatening 11.♗e3) 10...e5 11.♗e3 ♘d4 12.♘xd4 exd4 13.♗xd4 ♕a5+ 14.♗c3 and White has a crushing position;

D) 8...♖b8 9.♖b1 ♕a5 10.e5!!



This move breaks Black's defensive coordination and gives a decisive advantage. 10...♘xe5 (10...♘g8 11.♗c4! ♘xe5 (11...g6 12.♘d5 ♕a4 13.♘dc7+ ♔d8 14.♗xf7+− a6? 15.♘e6+ dxe6 16.♗a5 mate) 12.♘d5 ♕a4 13.♖b4 ♕a5 14.♘dc7+ ♔d8 15.♗xf7+−) 11.♕e2! d6 (11...♘fg4 12.h3+−) 12.f4 ♗g4 13.♕e3+−.

7...♕b4+ 7...♔d8!? **8.♗d2 ♕a4! 9.♘c7+ ♔d8 10.♘xc6+**

Somewhat better is 10.♘xa8 ♘xd4 (10...♕xd4? 11.♗a5+! b6 12.♕xd4 ♘xd4 13.♘xb6 ♘xc2+ 14.♔d2 ♘xa1 15.♘xc8+ ♔xc8 16.♗a6++−) 11.♗d3 ♕c6 12.♗e3 e5 13.0-0 which still promises White some initiative.

10...♔xc7! 11.♘d4 ♔d8

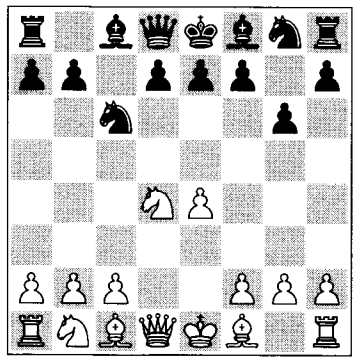
11...e5! 12.♘b5+ ♔b8 favours Black.

12.♗b5 ♕a3 13.e5 ♘e4 14.e6 ♕d6 15.exd7 ♗xd7 16.♗xd7 ♕xd7 17.0-0 e5 18.♘f3 ♘xd2 19.♘xd2 ♗b4 20.♕e2 ♗xd2 21.♖ad1 ♔c7 22.♕xe5+ ♔c8 23.♖fe1 ♗xe1 ½-½

SUMMARY
1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4
– 4...♘xd4: passive, comfortable for White, yet he only gets a slight edge ±
– 4...d5 5.exd5 ♕xd5 6.♗e3 ♘xd4: leads to a very sad endgame for Black ±
– 4...d5 5.exd5 ♕xd5 6.♗e3 e6: White enjoys a comfortable advantage ±
1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♕b6 5.♘b3 and now:
– 5...e6 6.♘c3 ♗b4 7.♕g4: not much played, but looks strong ±
5...♘f6 6.♘c3 e6 7.a3 and now:
– 7...d6 8.♗f4: always very promising for White ±
– 7...a6 8.♗f4: Black has lots of problems ±
– 7...♗e7 8.♗f4: White's position is slightly more free ±
– 7...♕c7 8.♗g5!?: this field is almost virgin for research ±
1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 ♕b6
– 6.♗e3!: Black must capture the pawn and the position is too dangerous ±

CHAPTER 5

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 g6
Accelerated Dragon Variation



Evaluation ****

Introduction, history and ideas

The Accelerated Dragon Variation, called the Simagin Variation by certain sources, is firmly settled among the Sicilian main lines, generally acknowledged as sounder than the Classical Dragon and offering excellent prospects to play for a win as Black. Moreover, its strategic simplicity makes it more 'sympathetic' than other main lines such as the Pelikan or the Najdorf. For these reasons, amateur players as well as grandmasters have it in their repertoire, and the reader will probably have to face it quite often. The line I recommend against the Accelerated Dragon is the most consistent set-up with the rest of the repertoire proposed in the book. Though the Maroczy Bind is considered the 'bogeyman' of the Accelerated Dragon, the prospects of getting an advantage are similar with the line I present. As an extra feature, my line can transpose to the line recommended against the Classical Dragon, or simply to similar positions, thus saving efforts in our preparation.

The Accelerated Dragon emerged strongly in the 1940s as an answer to the success of the Rauzer Attack against the Classical Dragon, and its main defender was the Soviet master Simagin. We can also find many games of prominent players, especially Lasker, from around 1900. Among the great champions, only Botvinnik and now and then Petrosian added it to their repertoires. From the 1960s or '70s onwards, the Accelerated Dragon became a very popular variation, but was neither adopted by the great champions, nor used in the decisive battles for the world title, which was really curious. The explanation must be that the Maroczy Bind reduces Black to passive play against a great strategist.

Nowadays, Tiviakov is the main defender of the black cause, though

world-class players such as Shirov or Ivanchuk now and then use it.

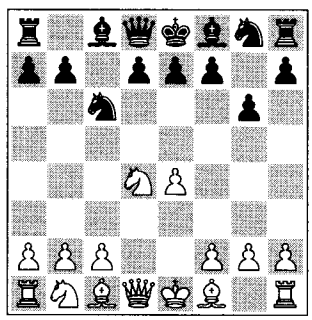
It is well-known that the main idea of the Accelerated Dragon is to avoid the dangerous Rauzer Attack, which is only half-achieved if White insists on following the main line. In many other transpositions to the Dragon, Black makes use of the move ...d7-d5, thus saving a move in comparison with classical variations.

In other aspects, Black's ideas are the same as in the Dragon. The dark-squared bishop is the main character in the game, for better or worse: it defends the king and the dark squares may suffer if it is exchanged off; it aims at the queenside, which is Black's battlefield. Very often the bishop is complemented with play along the c-file, the use of the c4-square for the knight and the classical Sicilian minority attack, that is, pushing the b-pawn forward. Tactical tricks along the a7-g1 diagonal must frequently be taken into account.

Game 5.01

Macieja,Bartlomiej
Ponomariov,Ruslan
Zagan Wch-jr 1997

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 g6



The basic position we are going to study in this chapter.

5.♘c3

The main line and my recommendation. I'm not stating that this is better than the popular Maroczy Bind, which appears after 5.c4 and also gives White good prospects of fighting for an edge, but I have chosen this line because it is more consistent with the rest of the set-ups studied in this book.

5...♘f6?!

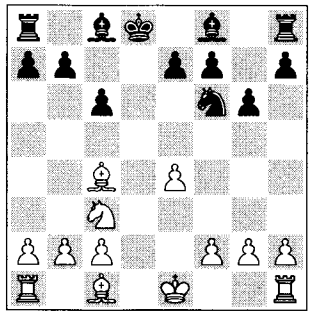
A dubious move which allows White to choose between transposing to the normal path and 'punishing' it with e4-e5. This move does not make sense here, but it does in the order 4...♘f6 5.♘c3 g6, avoiding the Maroczy Bind, and this was the actual move order in the game.

6.♘xc6!

An interesting try is **6.♗c4!?** to prevent ...♘h5 (after ...bxc6) and 8...♔e8 (after ...dxc6), both being quite reasonable moves, but Black has a way to prevent the transposition: 6...♕b6! (6...d6?! 7.♘xc6 bxc6 8.e5!± dxe5?? 9.♗xf7++− is a well-known trick, although there are more than 700 games in my database with 6...d6) 7.♘xc6 dxc6 8.e5 ♘g4 9.♕e2 ♗g7 10.e6 f5 11.♗b3 0-0∞ Lobron-Kagan, Randers Zonal 1982 leads to a complex position, which those who prefer the move order 6.♗c4 should analyse.

6...bxc6

6...dxc6!? is a far less popular, but probably better alternative. It will be hard for White to get more than a slight edge, for example: **7.♕xd8+ ♔xd8 8.♗c4!**



A) **8...♔e8!?** This line can be avoided with the order 6.♗c4!? and offers Black the best chances for equality: 9.e5 ♘d7 (9...♘g4?! 10.f4 h5 11.h3 ♘h6 12.♗e3 ♘f5 13.♗f2 h4 14.♔e2± and the lack of communication between the black rooks will eventually become a serious problem) 10.e6! fxe6 11.♗xe6 ♘c5 12.♗xc8 ♖xc8 13.♗e3± Adorjan-J.C.Diaz, Stockholm Wch-jr 1969. White must be content with a better structure, which is not a big deal, but Black's opening choice is not appealing either;

B) **8...♗g7?!** 9.f4! b5 10.♗d3 e5 (10...b4 wouldn't be an improvement: 11.♘a4 e5 12.a3! ♖e8 13.axb4 exf4 14.♗xf4 ♘d5 15.0-0± with a pleasant edge, though 15.♗g5+!? may be even better) 11.0-0! and now:

B1) 11...♗e6 12.f5 gxf5 13.exf5 ♗d5 14.♘xd5 ♘xd5 15.♗xb5! cxb5 16.♖d1± and White has a nice extra pawn;

B2) 11...♘d7 12.f5± f6 13.♗e3 ♗f8± A.Ivanov-Shabanov, USSR 1986;

B3) 11...exf4?! 12.♗xf4 ♘g4 (12...♘d7 13.♖ad1 f6 14.e5!→) 13.♖ad1± with a clear edge, as the tactical resource 13...♗d4+? (13...♔e8? 14.♘xb5+−; 13...♔e7! 14.♗e2 ♘e5 15.♗e3± and White has a really annoying check on c5) fails to 14.♔h1 ♘f2+ 15.♖xf2 ♗xf2 16.♗xb5++−.

7.e5 ♘g8

7...♘h5!? is the typical ugly and underestimated alternative, not so easy to refute though: 8.♗c4! ♘g7 (8...♕a5 9.0-0 ♕xe5 10.♖e1 ♕c7 11.♕f3⩲ offers compensation for the pawn) 9.0-0 ♘e6 10.f4 ♗a6 11.♗xa6 ♕b6+ 12.♔h1 ♕xa6 13.f5!± Argaya Urdaniz-Zamarbide Ibarrea, Pamplona 2001, and White has the initiative and the better structure.

8.♗c4 ♗g7

This is the most common move in this position. In the event of 8...♕a5 White can give the pawn with 9.0-0, but we won't go deeply into this interesting sacrifice, since it is also possible to transpose to the variation we recommend against 8...♗g7 by means of 9.♗f4 (9.♗f4 ♗g7 10.♕f3).

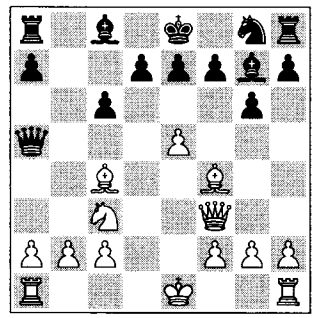
9.♗f4!?

9.♕f3 is also a very promising line, but I have chosen the text due to its simplicity.

9...♕a5

9...f5 10.♕d2! ♕c7 11.0-0-0 ♗xe5 12.♗xe5 ♕xe5 13.♖he1 ♕c5 14.♕f4 ♘f6 15.b4 ♕b6 16.♖xe7+!+−.

10.♕f3

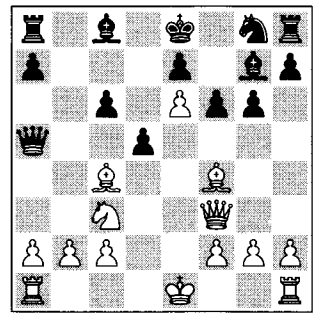


White develops and defends the pawn indirectly. Here it is also possible to play 10.0-0 ♗xe5 11.♗xe5 ♕xe5 12.♖e1 ♕g7, but with his extra pawn, Black can offer a tough resistance.
The text move leaves Black very few options.

10...f6?!

Not the best move. Ponomariov gave it up after this game, but the alternatives aren't satisfactory either:
O 10...♗xe5 Ponomariov's pet move in his youth and probably the most solid choice, but naturally he gave it up when he began to face more dangerous opponents. The alternatives are even worse. **11.♗xf7+!** Of course White didn't want to give a pawn; with this simple sequence, he gets a considerable initiative and Black's play lacks prospects. **11...♔xf7 12.♗xe5+ ♘f6 13.♕f4!** This was the novelty in this game. Previously, Ponomariov had held a draw in the dull position arising after 13.♗xf6 exf6 14.0-0±. Black has now several alternatives at his disposal:
A) **13...g5!?** is an attempt to change the course of events and leads to less defined positions, but White can't complain: 14.♕xg5 (14.♕c4+ ♔g7 15.f4!?→) 14...♖g8 15.♕e3 ♖xg2 16.0-0-0±;
B) **13...d6?** 14.♗xf6 exf6 15.0-0-0+–.
C) **13...♖f8** 14.0-0-0 ♔g8 15.♖he1±.
D) **13...d5** 14.0-0-0 ♗f5 15.f3!± with strong pressure, De La Villa Garcia-Ponomariov, Guardamar 1997.
O 10...e6?! 11.0-0 (11.0-0-0!? is equally effective) 11...♗xe5 (11...♘e7!? 12.♘e4 ♗xe5 13.b4! ♕c7 14.♘f6+ ♔d8 15.♗xe5 ♕xe5 16.♖fe1± with enormous compensation, Sedlak-Gazvoda, Ljubljana 2005) 12.b4! ♕c7 13.♘b5 ♕b8 (13...cxb5 14.♗xe5 ♗b7 15.♗xc7 ♗xf3 16.♗xb5+–) 14.♗xe5 ♕xe5 15.♖fe1 ♕b8 16.♖ad1 d5 17.♗xd5!! cxd5 18.♕xd5 ♔f8 19.♕c5+ ♔g7 20.♖d8 ♘f6 21.♖xh8 ♘d7 22.♕c3+ e5 23.♖e8 ♕xb5 24.♖8xe5 1-0 Palac-Rausis, Kastel 1988.

11.e6! d5



12.♗b5!

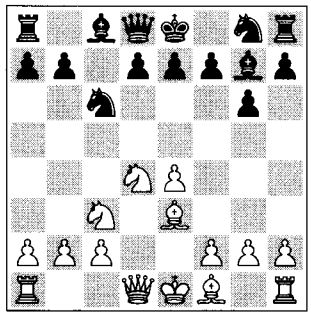
After these two terrible blows, Black's position collapses.

12...cxb5 13.♕xd5 ♕b6 14.♕xa8 ♕xe6+ 15.♗e3+– ♘h6 16.0-0 0-0 17.♗xh6 ♗xh6 18.♖fe1 ♕f5 19.♘d5 ♕xc2 20.♘xe7+ ♔h8 21.♘xc8 ♖xc8 22.♖e8+ ♖xe8 23.♕xe8+ ♔g7 24.♕d7+ ♔g8 25.♕xb5 ♕d2 26.♕b3+ 1-0

Game 5.02

Szelag,Marcin
Macieja,Bartlomiej
Poznan ch-POL 2005

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 g6 5.♘c3 ♗g7 6.♗e3



We move one step forward in our journey to the interior of the Accelerated Dragon. Black answers almost invariably with the text move, but we will consider some minor alternatives.

6...♘f6

O 6...d6!? An interesting way to transpose to a normal Dragon, having avoided 'annoying' variations such as 3.♗b5+ or 4.♕d4, etc. I can't think of anything better than transposing to the recommended lines by means of 7.♗c4, 7.f3 or 7.♕d2.

O 6...♘h6?! The knight is really misplaced here: 7.f3 d6 (7...0-0? 8.♘xc6 dxc6 9.♕c1+−) 8.♘xc6 bxc6 9.♕d2 ♘g8 10.♗c4±.

O 6...♕a5?! has often been played, but makes little sense: 7.♘b3! ♕d8 (7...♗xc3+ 8.bxc3 ♕xc3+ 9.♗d2 is too risky) 8.♗e2 and White has an extra tempo in comparison with the classical lines.

O 6...a6? looks awful, but is the most popular alternative among the unofficial ones (more than 250 games in my database); however, after 7.♘d5! Black's position collapses.

O 6...e6?! Another anti-positional and oddly popular alternative. Now 7.♘db5!+−.

7.♗c4 d6

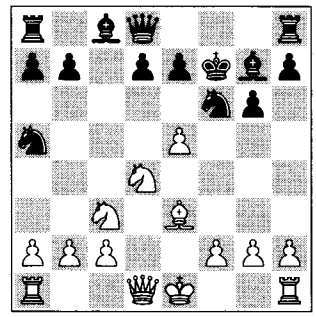
Trying to exploit a certain lack of coordination inherent in White's move order. Black forces f2-f3.

O 7...0-0 is the main line and will be examined from Game 5.04 onwards.

O 7...♕a5 is relatively popular, in order to prevent 0-0-0, and will be analysed in Game 5.03.

O 7...a6?! 8.♘xc6 bxc6 9.e5 ♘g8 10.♕f3! f6 11.0-0-0± with an overwhelming advantage in development and activity.

O 7...♘a5!? This move would be very logical if there weren't a concrete refutation. Boris Savchenko has used it in recent times, with a certain success. **8.♗xf7+!** The idea of ...♘a5 finds justification after any bishop retreat, whereas this move disrupts the black position, though it doesn't completely refute Black's idea. **8...♔xf7 9.e5** and now:



A) **9...d5** 10.exf6 ♗xf6 11.♕f3 e6?! 12.0-0-0 ♔g7 13.h4±;

B) **9...♘h5!?** A typical computer move: 10.g4 d6 (10...♘c4 11.gxh5∞ ♖f8 12.hxg6+! hxg6 13.♕f3+ ♔e8 14.♕e4 ♘xe5 15.0-0-0±) 11.♕f3+! ♔e8 12.gxh5 dxe5 13.♘b3±;

C) **9...♘c4** The only move that has enjoyed a certain success, though ...d5 may lead to the same positions. 10.exf6 ♗xf6 11.♕f3 (11.♕e2!?)

11...♔g7! (11...d5 12.♗g5 – 12.♘xd5? ♘e5! 13.♕e4 ♗f5!–+ – 12...e6 13.0-0-0±) 12.♘d5 (12.0-0 ♘xb2 13.♘d5 ♘c4 14.♖fe1 ♖f8 15.♘xf6 ♖xf6 16.♕d5 ♘xe3 17.♖xe3 ♕f8⩲) 12...♘xb2 (12...♗e5!) 13.♘xf6 exf6 14.0-0⩲.

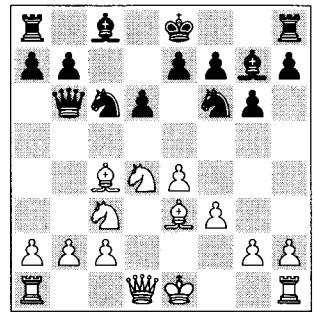
O 7...♕b6?! poses some tactical problems and hasn't been refuted. 8.0-0! is my suggestion, based on the fact that both pawn grabs are unsound: 8...♕xb2 (8...♘xe4?? 9.♘f5 ♕xb2 10.♘xg7+ ♔f8 11.♘xe4+–) 9.♘cb5 ♕b4 10.♘c7+ ♔d8 11.♘xc6+! (11.♘xa8 ♕xc4 12.♘xc6+ bxc6 – 12...♕xc6 – 13.♗xa7±) 11...bxc6 12.♘xa8 ♕xc4 13.♖b1! (13.♗xa7 ♗b7) 13...♘xe4 14.♗xa7 ♕xa2 (14...♗e5 15.♖e1! f5 16.♕d3!±) 15.♗b6+ ♔e8 16.♘c7+ ♔f8 17.♖b3±.

O 7...♕c7 8.♗b3 a6 9.f3 b5 10.♕d2 ♗b7 11.0-0-0 0-0 12.h4± Pilnik-Rubinetti, Buenos Aires 1964.

O 7...♘e5!? This move is also quite unknown and full of sting. 8.♗b3! (8.♗e2 d5! 9.exd5 ♘xd5 10.♗b5+ ♔f8! 11.♘xd5 ♕xd5 12.0-0 ♘g4 13.♗e2 ♘xe3 14.fxe3= Areschenko-Demkovich, Alushta tt 2002) 8...♘eg4 9.♗f4! e5?! (9...d6 10.h3 ♘e5 11.0-0±) 10.♘db5 exf4 (10...d5! 11.♘xd5 ♘xd5 12.♕xd5 ♕xd5 13.♗xd5 exf4 14.♘c7+ ♔e7 15.♘xa8 ♗e5∞) 11.♕d6! ♕a5 12.0-0⩲ with a tremendous attack that probably outweighs the sacrificed piece.

8.f3 ♕b6?!

An ambitious continuation, nowadays obsolete, though it virtually forces White to give up a pawn. It is the only move that gives a certain independence to the 7...d6 line.



O 8...0-0 transposes to the normal Dragon.

O 8...♗d7 This will eventually transpose to lines examined in the chapter on the Dragon.

O 8...♘d7?! A recurring theme in the Dragon and in the whole Sicilian, trying to coordinate the action of the two knights on the c4-square, but starting before the white queen moves to d2 doesn't look very inspired: 9.♗b3! ♘b6 10.h4 ♘a5?! (10...h5 11.♘d5 ♘xd5 12.exd5±) 11.♕d3! ♘xb3 12.axb3±. The knight has moved too many times, to end up on b6 without prospects: 12...0-0 13.h5 d5 14.♘de2 ♗e6 15.0-0-0 ♖c8 16.hxg6 fxg6 17.♗d4 dxe4 18.♕e3 ♗xd4 19.♘xd4 ♕d7 20.♕h6 ♖f7 21.♘xe4 Gheorghiu-Rai. Garcia, Tel Aviv ol 1964.

O 8...♕a5 isn't very flexible; White can seek a transposition with ♕d2 or ♗b3: 9.♗b3 (9.♕d2) 9...0-0 10.♕d2.

O 8...a6 is a very common move in these positions, but impossible to find at top level. White shouldn't worry about it and should go on with the usual plans, with the conviction that Black's move won't be very useful in the attacking race. 9.♕d2±

9.♘f5!

White is forced to enter complications if he wants to get something from the opening.

9...♕xb2 10.♘xg7+ ♔f8 11.♘d5 ♘xd5 12.♗xd5

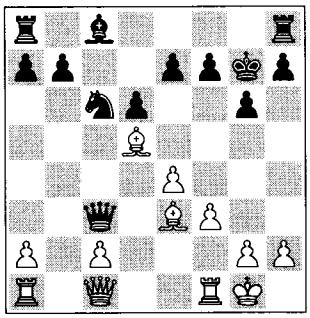
Here wild complications can also arise after 12.♕xd5?!, but once again, it is neither necessary nor economical to delve into this variation: 12...♕xa1+ 13.♔f2 ♕f6 14.♗h6 ♔g8 15.♘e8∞.

12...♔xg7 13.0-0 ♕c3

After this almost forced sequence, White has finally a choice between two important alternatives:

14.♕c1

This is my recommendation, although I suppose that the alternative **14.♖e1!?** has a similar value: 14....♕a5 (14...f6!?) 15.♕c1 h5 16.♕b2+ f6 17.♖ad1±.



The diagram position can be considered fundamental for the evaluation of the whole system. The weakness of the black squares is chronic. Apart from that, Black's position is solid and tempting for players with a certain style. Nowadays, with detailed computer analysis, I think it is a question of time and fashion that this variation is discussed more frequently and by stronger players. Anyway, in practical play, I would feel more comfortable as White.

14...h5

14...h6 is the only logical alternative, since allowing the presence of the white bishop on h6 would be really unpleasant: 15.♖b1 f6 (15...♘d4!? 16.♗d2 ♕c5 17.♕b2 e5 18.♗e3 ♕c3! 19.♗xd4 exd4 20.♖fd1 ♕xb2 21.♖xb2±) 16.♖b3 ♕a5 17.♕b2 (the move ♖b7 is a threat) 17...♕c7 18.f4 ♖b8 19.e5!? (19.f5! g5 20.h4 ♔f8 21.hxg5 hxg5 22.♗xg5±) 19...dxe5 20.♗xc6 ♕xc6 21.fxe5 (White's compensation is more significant than a pawn) 21...♖f8 (21...f5 22.e6+ ♔g8 23.♕e5 ♖a8 24.♗d4 ♖h7 25.♕xf5!+−) 22.exf6+ exf6 23.♖c3 ♕e8 (Gulko-Steinberg, Kharkov ch-URS 1967) 24.♗xa7! ♖a8 25.♖c7+ ♗d7 26.♗d4± with a pressing initiative.

15.♖b1 f6!?

Defending the dark squares. This is the critical move, but it usually fails to the energetic f4-f5 break.

15...e6?! weakens the dark squares, so it seems wrong: 16.♖b3 ♕a5 17.♕b2+ ♔h7 18.♕f6! ♕c7 19.♗xc6 bxc6 20.f4+−.

15...♕a5, redeploying the queen, is more logical. **16.c4!** The isolated pawn also plays its role in the collapse of Black's fortress. This is good, but not the only promising move: 16.f4 f6 17.♖b3 ♕c7 18.♕b2⩲ transposes to lines considered above. **16...e6?** After this the defence on the dark squares collapses. Now it is impossible to doubt that White has an enormous advantage. Let us seek alternatives: 16...♕c7 17.c5 dxc5 18.♕xc5 ♗d7 19.f4⩲; 16...f6 17.c5 (17.♖d1!? and 17.f4 are more ambitious) 17...dxc5 18.♕xc5 ♕xc5 19.♗xc5±. **17.♗xc6** 17.♕b2+! ♔h7 (17...f6 18.♗xe6!; 17...♔g8 18.♗xc6

bxc6 19.♖fd1+–) 18.♗xc6 bxc6 19.♕f6. **17...bxc6 18.c5!±** Tukmakov-Kaplan, Madrid 1973.

16.♖b3 ♕a5 17.♕b2 ♕c7 18.f4 h4

18...♖f8 19.f5!? Exploiting the weakness produced by ...h5. Some games have followed the model game Gulko-Steinberg from the 14...h6 line and in this case, the play and evaluation are the same as those with the pawn on h6 (19.e5!?). **19...♘e5 20.fxg6 ♕d8 21.c4** 21.♗xb7 is already enough for some edge. **21...♗d7? 22.♕c1!+–** Mecking-Deze, Vrsac 1971.
18...b6?! Suggested by Rogozenco. 19.f5!±.
18...♖b8 19.f5!.

19.h3

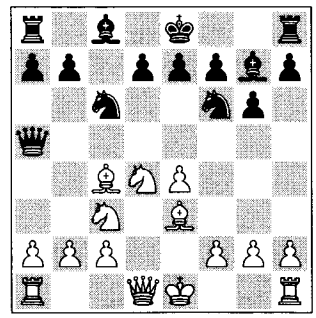
19.f5! gxf5 (19...g5 20.♗xg5) 20.exf5 h3 21.c4±.

19...♖h5 20.♖b5 b6 21.e5 ♗b7 22.♗f3 ♖hh8 23.exf6+ exf6 24.♖g5 ♘e7 25.♗xb7 ♕xb7 26.♗d4 ♖af8 27.f5 ♕d7 28.fxg6 ♕e6 29.♕c3 ♖h6 30.♕c7 ♖xg6 31.♖xg6+ ♔xg6 32.♕xa7 ♘f5 33.♗f2 ♖c8 34.♖e1 ♕d5 35.♕xb6 ♕xa2 36.♖e4 ♖c4 37.♖xc4 ♕xc4 38.♕b3 ♕f4 39.♕g8+ ♘g7 40.♕b3 ♕c1+ 41.♔h2 ♕f4+ 42.♔g1 ♕c1+ ½-½

Game 5.03

Anand,Viswanathan
Van Wely,Loek
Wijk aan Zee 1999

1.e4 c5 2.♘c3 ♘c6 3.♘f3 g6 4.d4 cxd4 5.♘xd4 ♗g7 6.♗e3 ♘f6 7.♗c4 ♕a5



Quite a popular alternative, frustrating White's intentions of castling queenside. Its drawback is that the white knight can retreat with tempo, and White gets a slightly improved version of the Classical Variation against the Dragon.

8.0-0!

Necessary to avoid the multiple tricks. For example:
O 8.♘b3? ♕b4 and White loses a pawn;
O 8.♕d2? ♘xe4 9.♘xe4 ♕xd2+ and again White loses a pawn;
O 8.f3?! ♕b4 9.♗b3?! (9.♘xc6 bxc6∞) 9...♘xe4! and again White loses a pawn.

8...0-0

Once the feared 0-0-0 has been ruled out, Black goes on with his normal development. There is also a 'tricky', but not very advisable, alternative.
O 8...♕b4?! 9.♗b3 (9.♕e2! is even better) 9...♘xe4? (consistent but weak) 10.♘xc6! bxc6 11.a3! ♘xc3 12.♕f3!+– A devastating intermediate move, that would knock out even George Foreman himself.
O 8...d6 lacks individual significance: 9.♘b3!
O Again, it is not the right moment to play **8...♘g4**. White has many satisfactory replies:

A) **9.♕xg4** ♘xd4 10.♕d1 ♘c6! (10...♘e6 11.♕d3 0-0 12.♘d5± with a powerful initiative) 11.♕d2±;

B) **9.♘b3!** is the strongest: 9...♕h5 (9...♕b4 10.♗xf7+ ♔xf7 11.♕xg4±; 9...♘xe3 10.fxe3 ♕g5 11.♗xf7++−) 10.♗f4 ♗e5 11.♗xe5 ♘cxe5 12.h3 ♘xc4 (12...♘f6 13.♗e2 ♕h4 14.f4±) 13.hxg4 ♕e5 14.f4 ♕d6 15.♕xd6 ♘xd6 16.♘d4± with a set of small assets: better development, better central control, better structure, more active pieces.

9.♘b3 ♕c7

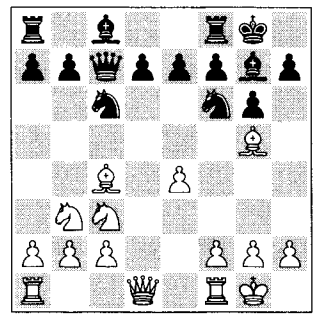
This queen retreat allows White potential ♗xf6 and ♘d5 ideas, which pose big problems for Black's development. Even so, this is the most popular alternative.

O 9...♕h5?! 10.♗e2 ♕h4 11.f3 d6 12.♕d2± and the black queen has an uncomfortable position.

O 9...♕b4?! scores well according to my database, but I wouldn't trust it. 10.♗d3! (threatening 11.♗c5) 10...♕d6 11.f4±.

O 9...♕d8 is the most logical alternative, in my opinion, though the two tempi wasted by the black queen make it look suspicious. **10.♗g5!** Switching to another plan: placing a knight on d5. White has two extra tempi in comparison with the normal Dragon. (10.♖e1 is a similar move order: 10...d6 11.♗g5) **10...d6** 10...a6 11.a4! ♘b4 12.♗e2 d6 13.♕d2 b6 14.a5± Lupo-Ceterski, cr 1998. **11.♖e1 ♘d7 12.♕d2 ♘b6 13.♗e2 ♗e6 14.♗h6 ♖c8 15.♗xg7 ♔xg7 16.♖ad1** 16.♘d5!? or 16.h4!?. **16...♘e5 17.♘d5 ♗xd5 18.exd5 ♕c7** (Perez Candelario-Malakhov, Spain tt 2004) and now **19.f4!** guarantees some pressure on the backward e7 pawn. For example: **19...♘ed7** 19...♘ec4 20.♕c3+ ♔g8 21.♖d4 ♖fe8 22.♖e4±. **20.♗g4 ♖fe8 21.♕d4+ ♔g8 22.♖e2±.**

10.♗g5!



This is the point of the whole plan. The natural move ...d6 is prevented, due to the threat ♗xf6 followed by ♘d5. But, furthermore, that threat will be renewed after f2-f4. Black has an unpleasant choice among different moves unsuitable for his plans. The result is a clumsy, though still playable, position.

10...a6

The most natural option: Black prepares ...b5, which would also make possible a check on a7, delaying White's threat. The alternatives are:

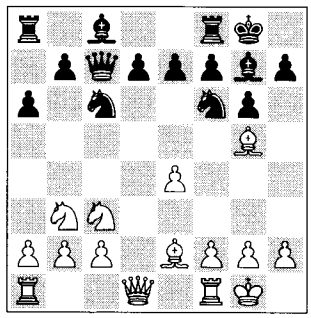
O 10...a5 forces White to choose between surrendering the b4-square to the black knight or allowing his own knight to be expelled. However, none of this constitutes a problem. 11.a3! (11.a4 ♘b4 12.♗e2 d6 13.♘d4± followed by ♘cb5 and c2-c3 also guarantees a comfortable edge) 11...a4 12.♘d2 ♕a5 13.♘d5 (13.♗b5!? with the idea of ♗xa4 or ♘c4) 13...d6 14.c3 (14.♘xf6+ exf6 15.♗f4±) 14...♖e8 (14...♗e6!?) 15.♘xf6+ exf6 16.♗e3 ♘e5 17.♗d5± Kupreichik-Veremei-

chik, Minsk ch-BLA 1976 and Black has no compensation for the wrecking of his pawn structure.

O 10...♘a5?! Trades one piece, but it is White's most passive one. 11.♗e2 ♘xb3 12.axb3± b6 13.f4 ♗b7 14.e5 ♘d5 15.♘xd5 ♕c5+ 16.♖f2 f6 17.c4 ♗xd5 18.b4 ♕c7 19.exf6 1-0 Moreno Carnero-De La Riva Aguado, Barcelona ch-ESP 2000.

10...e6 11.♗e2 and it is hard to find anything more useful than 11...a6, transposing.

11.♗e2



11...e6!?

A radical measure to prevent the white knight from jumping to the d5-square, but it makes some concessions. The weakness of the d6-square becomes especially noticeable, and White will exploit it.

O In the event of **11...b5** White can play quite effectively 12.a4! thanks to the previous bishop retreat, for example: 12...b4 13.♘d5 ♕e5 (running into complications is almost forced: 13...♘xd5 14.exd5 ♕e5 15.♕d2±; 13...♕d8 14.♗xf6±) 14.♗f4! ♕xe4 15.♗f3 ♕c4 16.♗g3 a5 17.♘b6 (17.♘xe7+! is a safe alternative if winning the exchange doesn't look clear; 17...♔h8 18.♖e1±) 17...♕a6 18.♘xa8 ♕xa8 19.♖e1 d5 20.♗h4± Arizmendi Martinez-F.Braga, Mislata Open 2000.

O 11...h6?! is no solution either. Black's castled position will become rather exposed: 12.♗e3 b5 13.♕d2 ♔h7 (13...b4 14.♘d5 ♕e5 15.♘xf6+±) 14.a4 b4 15.♘d5 ♘xd5 16.exd5 ♘e5 17.♗c5 d6 18.♗xb4±.

O 11...d6!? looks complete nonsense, but it has Ivanchuk's stamp. 12.a4! (12.♗xf6 is logical but after 12...exf6 the advantage of the d5-square is hard to prove: 13.♕d2 ♘e7 14.♖ad1 f5 15.♗f3 ♗e5 16.exf5 ♗xf5 17.♘d4 ♗d7 18.♘d5 ♘xd5 19.♗xd5 ♗c6 20.♗b3 ♕b6 21.♔h1 ♖ad8 22.f4 ♗f6 23.♘f3 a5!∓ (Karjakin-Ivanchuk, Warsaw Ech 2005) and Black has seized the initiative) 12...♗e6 13.♖e1 ♖fe8 14.♘d5 (the standard plan) 14...♗xd5 15.exd5 ♘e5 16.a5 ♘e4 17.♗f4± ♘c4?? 18.♕d3 1-0 Areschenko-Wippermann, Gibraltar 2008.

12.♕d2!

Preventing a quick ...d5 that could eventually free Black's pieces 'in one go'.

12...b5

On the contrary, 12...d5 fails now to 13.♗xf6 ♗xf6 14.exd5 ♗xc3 15.♕xc3± with an edge for White, thanks to his better structure and the convenient placement of his pieces.

13.a3!?

The game will run smoothly for White, but 13.♗f4!? is an interesting alternative, still waiting for its debut.

13...♖b8

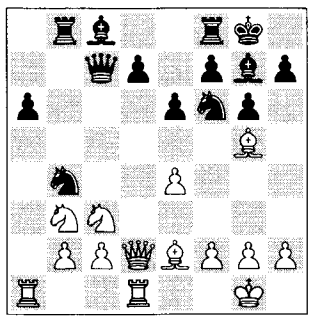
13...♗b7 is an important alternative, stoutly championed by Claudio Minzer:

14.♘c5! ♘d4 (14...♘e5 15.♘xb7 ♕xb7 16.♕f4! ♘h5 17.♗xh5 gxh5 18.♗h6±, Huerga Leache-Tallarico, Mondariz 2007, with a clear edge for White) 15.♘xb7 ♘xe2+ 16.♕xe2 ♕xb7 17.♕f3 ♘h5 18.g4 ♗xc3 19.♕xc3± and the dark squares are horribly weakened: 19...f6 20.gxh5 (20.♗e3!) 20...fxg5 Gomez Anadon-Arpa Pardo, Aragon tt 2005.

14.♖fd1 b4?!

Black tries to launch some counterplay, even at the risk of weakening his position. It is a logical decision, in view of the problems that would arise otherwise, e.g.: **14...♗b7** 15.♘c5!±; **14...♖d8** 15.♕e3 d6 16.♖d2±.

15.axb4 ♘xb4



16.♗f4!+

Finally White has played this appealing move when Black can't interpose his knight on e5, and is forced to make more serious positional concessions.

16...e5 17.♗g5! d6

In order to develop the bishop on e6, the alternative being b7: 17...♗b7 18.♗xf6 ♗xf6 19.♘a5 ♗a8 20.♘c4±.

18.♘a5 ♗e6 19.b3

To use the outpost c4 for the pieces.

19...h6 20.♗xf6 ♗xf6 21.♗c4 ♗g5 22.♕e2 ♗c8?!

An awkward retreat, as the a6 pawn wasn't under threat.

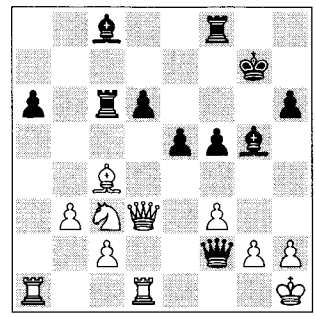
23.♘d5 ♘xd5 24.♗xd5 ♖b5 25.♘c4

Now White's positional grip is overwhelming.

25...♔g7 26.♘b2!

White gets ready to switch the position of his pieces: the knight is better placed on d5, and the bishop on c4.

26...f5 27.♗c4 ♖c5 28.♘a4 ♖c6 29.♘c3 ♕a7! 30.♔h1 ♗h4 31.f3 ♕f2 32.♕d3 ♗g5 33.exf5 gxf5



For the rest of the game, which is beyond our scope, we will make use of Anand's notes for *Chess Informant*. 33...♗xf5 34.♘e4± (34.♕d5±).

34.♘d5

With the idea ♖f1, f4→.

34...f4 35.♖d2?

35.♘b4! ♖b6 36.♕c3! (with the idea ♗d5±) 36...♕c5 37.♘d5 ♖c6 38.♖a5!±.

35...♕c5 36.♕e2 ♗e6! 37.♖dd1 a5± 38.♖d2

38.♖a4!? ♗f5 39.♖da1.

38...♗f7 39.♕d1 ♖d8?!

39...e4? 40.fxe4 f3 41.♕xf3! (41.gxf3? ♗h5 42.♖d3 ♕f2!) 41...♗xd2 (41...♗xd5 42.♖xd5+–) 42.♕f6+ ♔h7 43.♗d3!+–; 39...♗g6 40.♘c3±; 39...♗d8±.

40.♖a4 ♖cc8 41.♘c3! ♗g6 42.♖d5 ♕e3 43.♘e2± ♗f7 44.♖d3 ♕b6 45.♗xf7 ♔xf7 46.♘c3! ♗e7 47.♘e4 ♖g8? 48.c4?

48.♘xd6+ ♗xd6 49.♖xd6 ♕xd6 50.♕xd6 ♖gd8 51.♖xf4+!+–.

48...♖g6 49.♖a2 ♕b4 50.♖a4 ♕b6 51.♖d5 ♖cg8 52.♖a2 a4 53.bxa4 ♕c6 54.c5

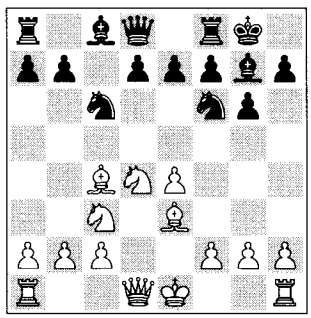
54.♕b3 ♖b8 55.♖b5!+–.

54...dxc5 55.♖xe5 ♖d8 56.♕c1 c4 57.h3 ♔e8 58.♖e2 ♖d7 59.♘c5 ♖c7 60.♕xc4 1-0

Game 5.04

Olivier,Jean Christophe
De La Riva Aguado, Oscar
Montpellier 2000

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 g6 5.♘c3 ♗g7 4.6.♗e3 ♘f6 7.♗c4 0-0



The most flexible and also the most common move in this position. Black reserves many options: queen sorties to b6 or a5, moving his d-pawn to d6 or to d5 in one go, a knight jump to g4 or even a quick (and somewhat anti-positional) advance of the a-pawn. White is reduced to one single possible move if he wishes to keep the option of castling queenside.

8.♗b3!

This is the only way to maintain the threat 0-0-0; the alternatives are:

O 8.f3?! ♕b6, exploiting the vulnerability of the e3 bishop.

O 8.♕d2?! ♘g4;

O 8.h3 allows 8...♘xe4!=.

O 8.0-0 This is normal, but leads to lines we don't examine in this book.

8...♕a5

Another attempt to prevent 0-0-0, now that the knight cannot retreat to b3, winning time. This line is rather popular and usually succeeds in pushing White to castling kingside, but in my opinion White can meet it effectively by playing f2-f3. At this moment, Black has a great range of alternatives:

O 8...a5 analysed in Game 5.05.

O 8...d6 analysed in Game 5.06.

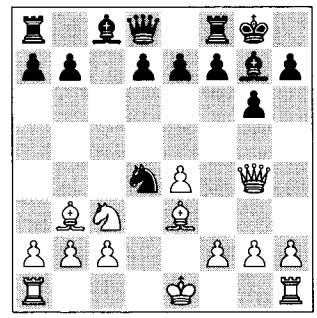
O 8...e6!? A relatively modern and odd-looking line; however, it can lead to a quick initiative for Black if White is too optimistic.

A) The most ambitious modern approach is 9.f4!? d6 10.♕f3 but I'm not sure that after 10...e5 11.♘xc6 bxc6 12.fxe5 ♘g4! 13.exd6 ♘xe3 14.♕xe3 ♕xd6∞ (Carlsen-Malakhov, Sarajevo 2006), White can counter the compensation offered by the powerful dark-squared bishop;

B) **9.0-0!** I still like the natural move. **9...d5 10.exd5 exd5 11.h3!** Once White has castled kingside, I think this is more natural than 11.f3, which could, however, promise a similar edge. **11...♖e8** 11...♗e6 will transpose, for example 12.♖e1 ♕d7 13.♕d3! **12.♖e1 ♗e6** This move deserves serious attention, since Black gets a quick development, a good defence of his isolated pawn and some tricks against White's castled king. 12...a6 is the only alternative explored in practice, and far less logical: 13.♖e2 (13.♕f3!?) 13...♘a5 14.♖d2 (with this plan, White exerts very strong pressure on the isolated pawn and it is not easy for Black to cope with it and find an active plan at the same time) 14...♘xb3?! 15.axb3 ♗d7 16.♖d3 ♗c6 17.♘xc6 bxc6 18.♘a4± Martin Gonzalez-Hernandez Jimenez, Catalunya-ch 2000. **13.♕d3!** A novelty, but actually a logical move, as it prepares some pressure on d5, while preventing the sacrifice on h3. 13.♕f3 is another interesting idea, already recommended in the first edition. 13.♕d2 ♕d7 14.♖ad1 ♗xh3! and Black secures the draw, for example: 15.gxh3 (15.♘xc6 ♗xg2!= Ahn-Ghijsels, Belgium tt 1996/97) 15...♕xh3 16.♘xc6 (16.f3?! ♖xe3 17.♕xe3 ♕g3+=) 16...♕g4+ 17.♔f1 ♕h3+ and it is very dangerous to run away. **13...♕d7** (13...♘e5 14.♕b5!; 13...♘b4 14.♕b5!) **14.♖ad1 a6** (14...♘b4 15.♕b5!; 14...♗xh3? 15.gxh3 ♕xh3 16.♕f1±) **15.♕f1±**.

❍ 8...♘a5? An ambitious idea, refuted since the 1950s and famous for having caused Reshevsky's ruin. 9.e5! ♘e8? (9...♘xb3 10.exf6+−) 10.♗xf7+! (this tactical trick went unnoticed for some time. Nowadays, it appears in all books about opening traps) 10...♖xf7 (10...♔xf7 11.♘e6! ♔xe6 12.♕d5+ leads to checkmate) 11.♘e6+− Bastrikov-Shamkovich, Sochi 1958, and many later games.

❍ 8...♘g4 Although Black wins the bishop pair with this move, the perfectly centralized position of White's pieces and his lead in development guarantees the first player a very pleasant advantage. Nowadays, it is a rare guest at tournament level. **9.♕xg4 ♘xd4**



10.♕d1! I'd like to recommend Nezhmetdinov's stunning and brave queen sacrifice 10.♕h4!? ♕a5 11.0-0 ♗f6 12.♕xf6!!, which is very interesting, but the text move is objectively stronger. **10...♘xb3** 10...♘e6 11.♕d2±. **11.axb3 b6** Black must find a way to develop; 11...d6 12.♗d4! and the a7-pawn is under threat: 12...b6 13.♗xg7 ♔xg7 14.♕d4+ f6 15.h4!± Tiviakov-Mantovani, Ischia 1998. **12.♗d4 e5** Logically, Black doesn't want his bishop pair traded off, but the holes on the d-file are easy targets for White. 12...♗b7 13.♗xg7 ♔xg7 14.♕d4+ f6 15.0-0-0 ♗c6 16.h4±. **13.♗e3 ♗b7 14.0-0 f5 15.f3 fxe4 16.fxe4 ♖xf1+ 17.♕xf1 ♔h8 18.♕d3±** Shamkovich-Veid, Moscow 1962.

❍ 8...♕c7?! Often used, but it allows White to go on comfortably with his

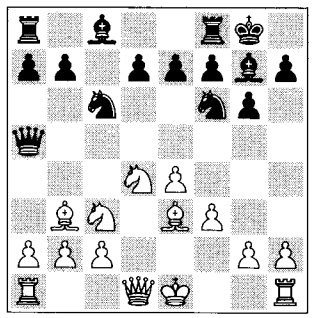
plans. 9.f3 a6 10.♕d2 b5 11.0-0-0 ♗b7 12.h4 ♖ac8 13.h5 ♘a5 14.hxg6 ♘xb3+ 15.♘xb3 fxg6 16.♘c5! ♗c6 17.♘e2 a5 18.♖h4 (Ivanchuk himself suggests 18.♘d4! as an improvement, giving the following line: 18...♗a8 19.♘xb5 ♕b6 20.♘c3 ♖xc5 21.e5!+–, as was later played in Korneev-Pogorelov, Madrid 2002) 18...♗a8 19.♖dh1 ♖f7 20.♔b1±. White's prospects look better here as well, Ivanchuk-Markowski, Polanica Zdroj 1998.

○ 8...a6?! Similar to the previous line. This doesn't pose problems for White, who can therefore go on with his plans and convert his advantage. Let's see an example from Fischer himself: 9.h4 b5 10.h5 b4 11.♘d5 ♘xe4 12.hxg6 hxg6 13.♕g4 e6 14.♕h3 f5 15.0-0-0 ♘a5 16.♕h7+ ♔f7 17.♖h6 ♘xb3+ 18.axb3 ♖h8 19.♕xg6+ ♔g8 20.♖xh8+ ♔xh8 21.♖h1+ ♔g8 22.♖h7 ♕f8 23.♗h6 1-0 Fischer-Reuben, Manhattan blitz 1963.

9.f3!

This is my recommendation. White is still planning 0-0-0 and reckons that the different black ideas involving ...d5 don't work out well yet.

9.♕d2?! loses a pawn after 9...♘xd4 10.♗xd4?! ♘xe4!; **9.0-0** is playable but justifies Black's play.



9...♖d8!?

Black can seek a quick ...d5 or accept the transposition to Chapter 16.

○ 9...d5 10.exd5 ♘b4 11.♕d2 ♘bxd5 This leads to a very depressing endgame, but the alternative ...♖d8 transposes to the game, and the other moves just don't regain the pawn. **12.♘xd5 ♕xd2+ 13.♔xd2 ♘xd5 14.♗xd5 ♖d8 15.c4!** Now, in order to recover the piece, Black's bishop must remain passive. **15...e6 16.♗e4 ♗xd4** 16...e5 17.♗d5 exd4 18.♗g5±; 16...f5!? is a relatively recent attempt to turn this position into a playable endgame: 17.♗d3 ♗xd4 18.♗xd4 ♖xd4 19.♔c3 ♖d8 20.♖he1!±. **17.♗xd4 ♖xd4+ 18.♔c3 ♖d7 19.♖hd1!±** The d-file, the pawn majority and the better king and bishop. A real torture for Black.

○ 9...e6 is the most solid and dangerous for White if he still has the fixed idea of castling queenside; however, if White changes his mind, he has a more comfortable game after 10.0-0! d5 11.exd5 exd5 12.♕d2 ♖d8 (12...♖e8 13.♖ad1 and nothing has happened on the dark squares yet) 13.♖ad1 ♗e6 14.♘cb5 ♕xd2 15.♖xd2± Dely-Kortchnoi, Budapest 1961.

○ 9...d6 10.♕d2 transposes to the Dragon.

10.♕d2 d5

Other moves aren't logical.

11.exd5 ♘xd5!

Somewhat better than the much more popular alternative 11...♘b4? 12.0-0-0 ♘bxd5 13.♘xd5 ♕xd2+ 14.♖xd2 ♘xd5 15.♘b5 and Black is powerless. Jansa-Hölzl, Stary Smokovec 1969.

12.♗xd5

12.♘xd5 ♕xd2+ 13.♗xd2 ♗xd4 14.0-0-0 ♗e6! (14...e6!? 15.♗c3? ♖xd5! 16.♗xd5 ♗e3+∓) 15.♘c7 ♗xb3 16.♘xa8 ♗xa2 17.♘c7 a6 (17...♗c4!?) 18.♗c3 ♗e3+ 19.♗d2 ♗d4= (19...♗b6 20.♗f4 ♖c8 21.♘d5 ♗xd5 22.♖xd5 ♘d4 23.♔b1±).

12...♘b4?!

O 12...♗xd4! is the best: 13.♗xd4 ♘b4 14.♗e4! f5 (14...e5 15.♘e2 exd4 16.a3 ♘c6 17.♕xa5 – 17.0-0-0 ♕b6± – 17...♘xa5 18.0-0-0±) 15.0-0-0! ♘xa2+ 16.♔b1 ♘xc3+ 17.♕xc3 ♕xc3 18.♗xc3 ♖xd1+ 19.♖xd1 fxe4 20.♖d8+ ♔f7 21.fxe4± with a slightly better endgame.

O 12...♘xd4? 13.♗xd4 ♗xd4 14.♕xd4 e6 15.b4!+–.

13.♘b3

13.♗c4? ♗xd4 14.♗xd4 ♖xd4!∓; 13.♗b3 e5!

13...♕c7

13...♗xc3? 14.bxc3+–.

14.♘b5

O 14.♗f4! may be a more 'human' solution.

A) 14...♗e5 15.♗xe5! (15.♖d1 ♗xf4 16.♗xf7+ ♔xf7 17.♕xd8 ♕e5+ 18.♔f1 ♗e6 19.♕d4 ♘xc2 20.♕xe5 ♗xe5⩲) 15...♕xe5+ 16.♘e2 ♘xd5 17.c4 ♗h3! 18.gxh3 (18.cxd5 ♗xg2⩲) 18...♘e3 19.♕c3±.

B) 14...e5 15.♗g5 ♗e6 16.♗xd8 ♖xd8 17.0-0-0 ♘xd5 18.♘xd5 ♗xd5 19.♔b1 and there is not enough compensation.

O 14.0-0-0 ♗f5!⩲ offers Black tremendous compensation for the piece.

14...♕e5 15.c4!

15.f4 is not enough: 15...♕xd5! 16.♕xb4 ♕xg2 17.♖g1 ♕xc2 and Black again has tremendous compensation for the piece.

15...♘xd5

Black keeps complicating the game.

O 15...e6? simply loses due to 16.0-0! exd5 17.♗d4+–;

O 15...♖xd5 doesn't get enough compensation for the exchange: 16.cxd5 ♘xd5 17.♔f2 ♘xe3 18.♕d8+ ♗f8 19.♖he1! ♕d5 20.♕xd5 ♘xd5±.

16.cxd5 ♖xd5 17.♘5d4?

From this point onwards, Black's compensation looks difficult to ward off. 17.f4! was the last chance to fight for the advantage. For example: 17...♖xd2 18.fxe5 ♖xb2 19.♘c7! ♗g4! 20.♘xa8 ♖e2+ 21.♔f1 ♖xe3 22.♘c7±.

17...a5! 18.♖d1

18.f4!? ♕d6 19.a4 b5 20.axb5 a4 21.0-0 ♗b7∓; 18.a4 ♕d6 19.f4!±.

18...♕d6 19.0-0 ♗d7!

19...e5? 20.♘f5+–; 19...a4 20.♘c1 ♗xd4 21.♗xd4 e5 22.♗xe5!+–.

20.f4 ♖d8??

20...♗g4!∓; 20...a4 21.♘c1 ♗g4∓.

21.h3??

21.♕f2! a4 (21...♗a4 22.♖d2!±) 22.♘c1 ♗g4 23.♘b5!±; 21.♘xa5! ♕a6 22.♘ab3 ♗a4 23.♕f2±.

21...a4 21...♗a4∓. **22.♘c1**

22.♘a5 ♕a6!∓.

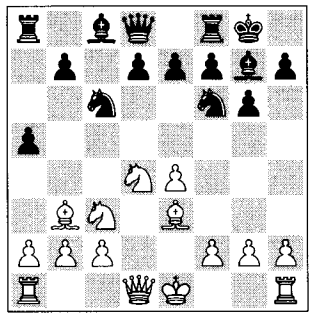
22...♗xd4! 23.♗xd4 ♗b5∓ 24.♘e2 ♗xe2 25.♕xe2 ♖xd4 26.♖xd4 ♕xd4+ 27.♔h2 e6

28.♖f3 ♖d5 29.h4 h5 30.g3 ♕d2
31.♖f2 ♕c1 32.♕c2 ♕e1
33.♖e2 ♕b4 34.♔h3 b5
35.♖xe6 ♖d2! 36.♖e8+ ♔g7
37.♕c8 ♕xb2 0-1

Game 5.05

Radjabov,Teimour
Tiviakov,Sergey
Wijk aan Zee 2007

1.e4 c5 2.♘c3 ♘c6 3.♘f3 g6 4.d4 cxd4 5.♘xd4 ♗g7 6.♗e3 ♘f6 7.♗c4 0-0 8.♗b3 a5



Almost as popular as the main line 8...d6. Though b5 is seriously weakened, some tactical details set the basis for Black's counterplay. Both 9.f3 and 9.a4 are interesting, but I think that the natural line starting with 9.0-0 is still the best option for White to get quite a safe edge.
For 8...d6 see Game 5.06.

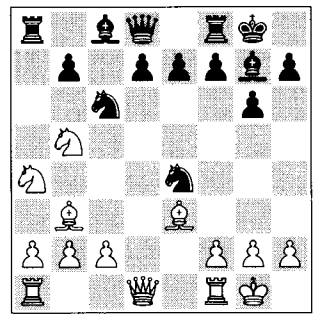
9.0-0!

This is my recommendation. It is true that now White definitely forgoes his most frequent plan, based on 0-0-0, but the radical character of 9...a5 fully justifies this change.

9...♘xd4

This has become a frequent reply in the last few years, the idea being to pre-empt ♘db5. In some senses, it makes White's task easier, but Black has very solid play which is not so clumsy as after 9...d6.

O In the beginning, the favourite move was **9...a4**, but later black players experienced the drawbacks of the resulting position, mainly the product of the holes on the b-file: **10.♘xa4 ♘xe4 11.♘b5** The weakness of b5 and b6 becomes obvious. 11.c4 is an interesting attempt to prevent the new idea ...d5. Black is now at an important crossroads:



A) **11...d6** 12.♗b6 ♕d7 13.♖e1! ♕f5 14.♘c7 ♖xa4 15.♗xa4 ♗xb2 16.g4! (previously suggested by Nataf) 16...♕e5 17.♖b1 ♗c3 (Kosmo-Hurme, Espoo 2002) and now 18.f4! ♕xf4 19.♘d5 ♕e5 20.♖xe4 ♕xe4 21.♘xc3±.

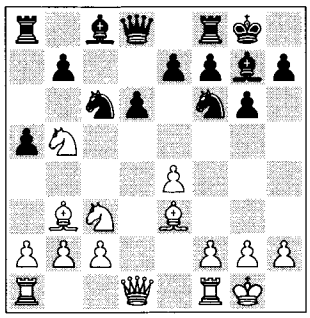
B) **11...♖xa4** This exchange offer has been recommended, but in my view it is not enough: 12.♗xa4 ♗xb2 13.♖b1 ♗g7 14.f3 ♕a5 15.♗b3 ♘c3 16.♘xc3 ♕xc3 17.♕e1± (Bologan-Katz, Bastia Open 1998) 17...♕e5 18.♕d2 ♘d4 19.♖bd1 ♘f5 20.♗f2 ♕c7 (Karjakin-Jones, Heraklion Ech-tt 2007) 21.g4! ♘d6 22.♕b4 b5 23.♕c5±.

C) **11...d5!** is a recent idea, trying to get a grip in the centre, but it also gives White specific targets: 12.♗b6 ♕d7 13.♘c7 ♖xa4 (this sacrifice is the point of the whole black idea) 14.♗xa4

♗xb2 15.♕xd5 ♗xa1 16.♕xe4± and in spite of the apparent equality, I think Black must still solve some problems due to the superior activity of the white pieces: 16...♗g7 17.♘d5 e6 18.♘e3 f5 19.♕h4 ♗f6 20.♕c4 ♕f7 21.♖d1±.

D) **11...♖a6** 12.c4! (preventing ...d5) 12...d6 13.♕e2 ♘f6 14.h3! (and now preventing ...♘g4. The white pieces start to occupy central positions, whereas Black is forced to remain more passive) 14...♗e6 15.♖ad1 ♕b8 16.♘b6! ♖d8 (16...♘d7 17.♘xd7 ♗xd7 18.c5±) 17.♘d5!± Nataf-Balduan, Biel 1999.

O 9...d6 10.♘db5! White avoids exchanges, as they would relieve Black's position, and immediately jumps to one of the weak points instead. This move has radically killed the popularity of ...d6, which has been displaced as the main line by 9...♘xd4.



Black has tried at least four replies:

A) **10...a4** 11.♘xa4 ♘xe4 transposes to the note to the previous move.

B) **10...♗e6** was Tiviakov's choice, which leaves Black in a very passive position: 11.h3 ♘d7 12.♖e1 ♗xb3 13.axb3 ♘c5 14.♕d2 b6 15.♗h6± Anand-Tiviakov, Bastia 2001.

C) **10...b6** 11.a4! ♗a6 12.f4 ♘d7 13.♕f3 ♘c5 (13...♗xc3 14.bxc3 ♘a7 (Zhang Zhong-Malakhov, Poikovsky 2004) and now 15.f5! to exploit the weakness of the dark squares, with a powerful initiative for White: 15...♘e5 16.♕e2) 14.e5 ♘xb3 15.cxb3 ♗xb5 16.♘xb5 ♘a7 (Kosintseva-Harika, Torino ol 2006) and now 17.♘c3! dxe5 18.♖ad1 ♕e8 19.♘d5±.

D) **10...♘g4** The usual way is to harass the bishop. **11.♗g5** 11.♗d2± or even 11.♗c1 have a similar value, little explored due to the youth of this variation. **11...h6 12.♗d2** 12.♗h4 g5 13.♗g3± is also promising, though there are so many holes in Black's position that it becomes difficult to occupy them all. **12...♔h7 13.h3** According to Jaracz' notes in *Chess Informant*, this is more accurate than 13.a4 f5. **13...♘ge5 14.a4** 14.f4 just sends the knight to its appointed destination, that is, c5: 14...♘d7 15.♗e3 ♘c5. **14...f5?!** This is really weakening and postpones the theoretical battle to later games. 14...♘d7!? is the logical plan. Then White can play 15.♗c4 to recycle the bishop, but after 15...♘b6 16.♗e2 f5 17.exf5∞ the black pieces become very active. 15.♗e3 ♘c5 16.♗c4±, to reply to ...f5 with ♗xc5, looks better. **15.exf5 ♗xf5 16.♘d5±** Jaracz-Agdestein, Cappelle la Grande 2001. The new hole created on e6 adds to the list of Black's concerns.

10.♗xd4 d6 11.♕e2

This is the new plan for White: e4-e5 and ♘d5 are latent threats, thanks to the pressure along the central files.

11...♗d7

The bishop heads for c6.

11...♗g4!?, provoking f2-f3, may be a good idea, but we need more examples from practical play: 12.f3 ♗d7 13.♖ad1 a4 14.♗c4 ♗c6 15.a3 (15.e5 is worse

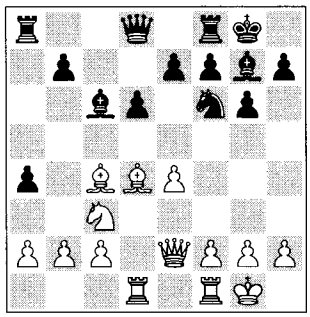
than in the game due to 15...dxe5 16.♗xe5 ♕a5∞) 15...♘d7 (Negi-Bajarani, Dubai 2008) and now White should have followed the game's plan with 16.♘d5, although the pawn isn't any help on f3.

12.♖ad1 a4

This weakens the pawn and the b4-square. But after 12...♗c6!? 13.e5! is strong, e.g. 13...dxe5 14.♗xe5 ♕b6 15.♘a4±.

13.♗c4 ♗c6

13...a3 looks more consistent: 14.b3 ♗c6 (14...♕a5?! 15.♗xf6 ♗xf6 16.♘d5±), but the variation 15.f4! ♘d7 16.e5 dxe5 17.fxe5 e6 18.b4! still poses some problems for Black.



14.a3

White focuses on placing the knight on d5 and pressurizing along the e-file. However, there is another very interesting plan: **14.e5!? dxe5 15.♗xe5** and now:

A) **15...♕a5** 16.♘b5 ♗xb5 17.♗xb5 a3 ½-½ (De La Villa Garcia-Frois, Sanxenxo 2006) and now 18.b3!±.

B) **15...♕c8** (this square is worse for the queen, and the a4 pawn suffers) 16.♖fe1 ♖a5 17.♗b5 ♖e8 18.♖d4 ♘h5 19.♗xg7 ♗xb5 20.♘xb5 ♘xg7 with some advantage for White, who has more centralized pieces and a more compact structure, Carlsson-Robson, Reykjavik 2008. Play can continue: 21.♖c4 ♕e6 22.♖e4 ♕b6 23.c4±.

14...♖a5!?

14...♘d7 15.♗xg7 ♔xg7 16.♘d5±. Now the knight has another strong point on b4. 16...♗xd5 17.exd5± in view of the backward pawn on e7.

15.♘d5!? ♘d7

Exchanges don't bring complete relief for Black: 15...♘xd5 16.exd5! ♗xd5 (16...♗d7 17.♗xg7 ♔xg7 18.♖d4!± and then White will triple along the e-file or switch the rook to h4) 17.♗xd5 ♖xd5 18.♗b6! ♕xb6 19.♖xd5 ♕xb2 20.♕xe7 ♕xa3 21.♕xb7±.

16.♖fe1 ♖e8 17.c3?!

This move leaves the d4 bishop in an awkward position and is an inaccuracy according to Tiviakov. The simplest way was to stick to the plan, that is, 17.♗xg7 ♔xg7 18.♕e3 (intending ♕c3) 18...♗xd5 19.exd5± and the knight can counter the pressure along the e-file.

17...e6! 18.♘b4 ♗f8! 19.f3 ♕c7

19...♕e7 20.♕d2 ♘e5 21.♗f1± and Black's position is still cramped.

20.♕f2 ♘c5 21.♖d2 ♕e7

21...♗b5!? is another suggestion by Tiviakov which doesn't fully equalize either. 22.♗a2!±.

22.♖de2 ♖c8

Now 22...♗b5? is not possible: 23.♘d5! exd5 24.♗xb5 ♖xb5 25.exd5 ♘d3 26.♕f1 ♕d7 27.♖xe8 ♘xe1 28.♕xe1+−.

23.♗a2

Tiviakov's suggestion 23.♘d5! would place Black in trouble: 23...♗xd5 (23...exd5 24.exd5 ♕d8 25.dxc6 bxc6± and ...d5) 24.exd5 e5 25.f4 b5 26.♗xc5 bxc4 27.♗b4±.

23...♗b5 24.♖d2

24.c4! ♗d7 25.♗c3± would keep Black indefinitely restricted.

24...♘d7 25.f4 ♗c4 26.♗b1?!

26.♗xc4 ♖xc4±.

26...♘c5 27.♗c2 ♘b3 28.♗xb3 ♗xb3=

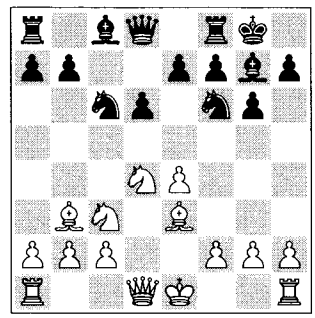
I agree with Tiviakov in that Black has finally equalized. The rest of the game goes beyond our scope.

29.♖d3 ♗c4 30.♖h3 e5?! 31.♗b6! ♖b5 32.f5 f6?! 33.♗e3± gxf5 34.♕xf5→ ♗e6 35.♖g3+ ♔h8 36.♕f2 ♗g7 37.♕d2 ♖g8 38.♖d1 ♗f8 39.♖xg8+ ♔xg8 40.♗h6 ♗b3 41.♖f1 ♖c5 42.♖f3 ♖c8 43.♘d5 ♗xd5 44.♕xd5+ ♔h8 45.♗e3 ♗g7 46.♕b5 ♖a8 47.♗f2 ♕c7 48.♖d3 ♗f8 49.♖d5 ♕c6 50.♕d3 ♗e7 51.♖b5 ♗d8 52.♖d5 ♗c7 53.h3 ♖f8 54.♖b5 ♖a8 55.♖d5 ♖g8 56.♔h2 ♖g6 57.c4 ♖g8 58.♗h4 ♖g6 59.♕f3 ♔g7 60.c5?! dxc5 61.♕f5 ♗d6?? 62.♕e6 f5□ 63.♕xf5 ♕c7 64.♗g3 ♖f6 65.♕h5 ♖e6 66.♕e2 ♔f8 67.♕d1 b5? 68.♕f1+ ♔e8 69.♕xb5+ ♕d7 70.♕e2 ♕f7 71.♕a6 ♕d7 72.♕a8+ ♔f7 73.♕h8 h6 74.♕h7+ ♔e8 75.♕g8+ 1-0

Game 5.06

Topalov,Veselin
Tiviakov,Sergey
Wijk aan Zee 1996

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 g6 5.♘c3 ♗g7 6.♗e3 ♘f6 7.♗c4 0-0 8.♗b3 d6



The main line in the Accelerated Dragon. With his clever move order, Black has lured White into playing ♗b3 before ♕d2, which gives the second player some extra options. As all the other moves transpose to the Classical Dragon, for the moment we will only deal with those extra options.

9.f3

Sticking to the 0-0-0 plan.

9...♗d7

This move can transpose to the Dragon or trigger the standard counterplay of this variation: ...♘xd4 followed by ...b5. There are many alternatives, but they are less frequent:

O 9...a5 is not very logical now, because ...a4 is not a threat; it only makes White forget about 0-0-0. 10.♘db5! (avoiding piece exchanges and immediately occupying the weak square) 10...♘d7 11.0-0! (this is my suggestion: I see no reason to play a4 when

castling queenside is out of the question anyway) 11...♘c5 12.♗c4±. There are many pieces on the board, and the white ones have more space and better outposts. It will be easy to centralize the rooks and create threats.

O 9...♘d7 This manoeuvre, which intends to point both knights to the square c4, is not very logical before the white queen has moved to d2. 10.h4! and now:

A) 10...♘b6 11.h5 ♘a5 12.hxg6 hxg6 13.♕e2!±;

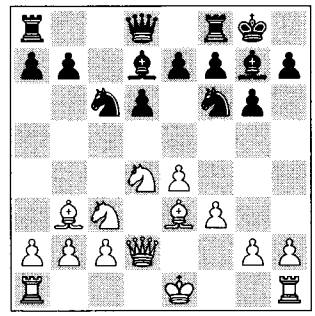
B) 10...h5 11.♕d2 ♘c5 12.0-0-0 ♘xb3+ 13.axb3 The variation with ...h5 looks too dangerous without the defending knight. It doesn't look as though Black can offer much resistance to g2-g4 and h4-h5: 13...♕a5 14.♔b1 ♗d7 15.g4 hxg4 16.h5± with a crushing attack, Sherzer-Larsen, New York Open 1988)

C) 10...♘c5 11.h5 ♕a5 12.hxg6 hxg6 (Martin Gonzalez-Petursson, Biel Interzonal 1985) and White's attack can follow its normal course: 13.♕d2, followed by the classical themes.

O 9...♘xd4 A line that has recently come into fashion. 10.♗xd4 ♗e6. My suggestion for White is to transpose to the Dragon with 11.♕d2, reaching a position that will be examined in Chapter 16.

O 9...♘a5 Although it has its supporters, here this looks slightly less accurate than on the next move. White can be content with transposition (after 10.♕d2) or try something else: 10.g4! ♘xb3 (10...h5 11.gxh5 ♘xh5 12.♕d2 and after 0-0-0, White can launch a very dangerous attack on the enemy castled position) 11.axb3± (11.cxb3 d5 12.e5 ♘e8 13.f4 f6 with counterplay) and now 11...d5 is not so good on account of 12.♘db5! and if 12...dxe4, 13.♕xd8 ♖xd8 14.♘c7 wins material.

10.♕d2



10...♘xd4

At last the game heads for the variation that gives special sense to the Accelerated Dragon. Many books (among them, ECO) include this in the Dragon; however, I consider this to be wrong, as usually this position arises via the order we have just seen. The remaining 'serious' lines transpose to the Dragon, except maybe one:

O 10...a5!? This is possibly the best time to make this move, now that White has defined his development with f2-f3 and ♕d2. However, we don't have many examples:

A) I think **11.♘db5** is still a good alternative to avoid the exchanges, though there are no good examples: 11...♘e5 12.a4 ♕c8 13.♕e2 ♗e6 14.♘d5 ♗xd5 15.exd5 ♖e8 16.0-0 ♘ed7± (M.Hoffmann-Frois, Figueira da Foz 2007) 17.♖fe1! ♘c5 18.♗c4 ♘fd7 19.♘c3!?;

B) **11.a4** ♖c8 (waiting for White to castle. 11...♘xd4 12.♗xd4 ♗c6, with the idea of ...♘d7, may run into 13.g4, Teschner-Gereben, Reggio Emilia 1963/64, but all this needs and indeed

deserves a lot more testing) 12.0-0 (12.0-0-0 ♘e5∞) 12...♘xd4 13.♗xd4 ♗c6 (Rowson-Shaw, Edinburgh ch-SCO 1999) and now Short's suggestion 14.♔h1! with the idea 14...♘d7 15.f4± looks like a very sensible plan.

O 10...♕a5 11.0-0-0 and **10...♘e5** 11.0-0-0 transpose to the standard Dragon.

O 10...♘a5!? is an interesting move order that can lead to the Chinese Dragon variation. White must play 11.h4 (11.0-0-0 makes Black's task easier. 11...♘xb3+!? – 11...♖b8 transposes to the Chinese Dragon – 12.cxb3! (12.axb3 a5!⇄) 12...♕a5 13.♔b1 ♖fc8 14.g4 b5 15.♘cxb5 (15.a3!?) 15...♕xd2 16.♗xd2 a6 (16...♘e8!∓) 17.♘a3? ♘xg4! 18.fxg4 ♗xd4∓ Socko-Bu Xiangzhi, Beijing blitz 2008) 11...h5 (11...♘xb3 12.axb3) 12.0-0-0 ♘xb3+ 13.cxb3 ♕a5 14.♔b1 ♖fc8 15.♗g5 ♕c5 16.a3 b5 17.♗xf6 ♗xf6 18.♘d5 ♔g7 19.♘e2 ♗e6 20.♘ef4± Escobar Dominguez-Garrido Dominguez, Dos Hermanas 2005.

O 10...♖b8, to switch to the Chinese Variation, is inaccurate due to 11.♘xc6 bxc6 12.♗xa7 and there is not enough compensation for the pawn.

11.♗xd4 b5

11...a5 has been tried many times and my suggestion is 12.a4, transposing to the note to the previous move.

12.h4

12.a4!? with the idea of switching to 0-0, is a promising alternative that has had good results and more and more excellent champions. A good suggestion for research, but we can't delve into it here.

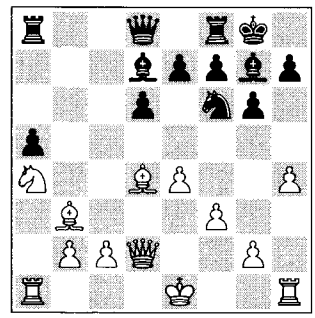
12...a5

Only this would justify the previous moves. Even so, black players have also tried: **12...b4?!** 13.♘d5 ♘xd5 14.♗xg7! ♔xg7 15.♗xd5 ♖c8 16.h5± with a strong attack; and **12...h5** 13.g4! e5 (13...hxg4 14.h5→) 14.♗e3 a5 15.♗g5 (15.gxh5!?) 15...a4 16.♗d5 ♖c8 17.gxh5 gxh5 18.♗h6+– Klundt-De Greiff, Siegen ol 1970.

13.a4 bxa4

13...b4 is not as bad as its rare appearances in practical play would make us think: 14.♘d5 ♘xd5 15.♗xd5 ♖c8 16.♗xg7! (16.h5 ♖xc2∞) 16...♔xg7 17.h5± and Black has an unpleasant choice between the ugly move 18...♖h8 or allowing the white queen to reach h6.

14.♘xa4



14...e5

This is the old main line.

After the stem game, interest has turned to **14...♗e6**, but in my view White has many interesting options here. **15.♗xe6!?** seems to me a simple way of creating problems. 15.♘b6 is the main line analysed in DLS. **15...fxe6 16.0-0 ♖b8** (16...♕c7 has been played just once and resulted in disaster for White, who must play 17.♖fc1± (but not 17.♖a3? ♘xe4!–+) 17...♘h5 18.♗xg7

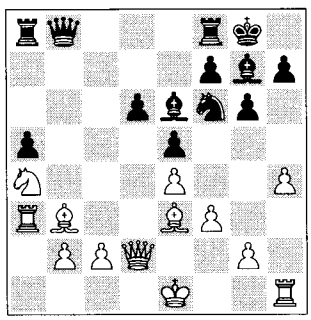
♔xg7 19.c4 ♖ad8 20.♕e3 followed by 21.c5, and Black must still solve a couple of problems) **17.b3!?±** This is the key move, intending to continue ♘b2-c4. I think Black must still prove that he is OK here. Previous practice had seen 17.♕e3 ♘d7 18.♗xg7 ♔xg7 19.b3 ♕c7 20.♖f2 ♖b5 21.♕c3+ ♕xc3 22.♘xc3 ♖c5 23.♘d1 ♖b8 24.♘e3 ♖b4 ½-½ Colovic-Vasovski, Ohrid Ech 2001. **17...♖b4** (17...♘d7 18.♗xg7 ♔xg7 19.♘b2! ♖b5 20.♘c4±) **18.♗c3 ♖b5 19.♕d3 ♕d7 20.♘b2±**.

15.♗b6 ♕b8 16.♗e3!

The old pawn grab 16.♗xa5?! allows good counterplay for Black: 16...♖a6 17.♗c4 ♗h6! 18.♕xh6 ♖xa5 19.b3 d5 (19...♗xa4!?) 20.♗xd5 ♘xd5 21.exd5 ♗xa4⩲ Tseshkovsky-Forintos, Sochi 1974. But the new, more positional, idea leaves Black with his many weaknesses.

16...♗e6 17.♖a3

The necessary follow-up of the previous move, since White neither wants to strengthen Black's grip on the d5-square with ♗xe6, nor surrender that grip with a premature knight errand with ♘b6-d5.



17...♕b4?!

This was the first move, assessed as dubious by the expert Tiviakov himself. After this came the attempts to improve Black's play:

O 17...♖a6 18.♘c3! ♖d8 19.0-0 ♖d7 20.♖fa1± Benares-C.Braga, Itau 2002.

O 17...♕c7!? 18.g4 (18.♘c3± must be the best, as Tiviakov suggests, or 18.0-0±) 18...♕c6∞ Criado Lopez-Fraga Castro, Mondariz ch-ESP jr 2002.

O 17...♖d8?! 18.♘c3 (computers go directly for the exchange with 18.♗xe6! fxe6 19.♖b3, but there is some compensation after 19...♕c7 20.♗b6 ♕c6 21.♗xd8 ♖xd8±) 18...♘h5?! (18...d5!?) 19.0-0 ♕c7 20.♘d5±.

18.♘b6! ♖ab8

Tiviakov analyses in depth the main alternative **18...♕xd2+**, arriving at the conclusion that White keeps the advantage. I agree with this conclusion and find it hard to believe otherwise, in view of Black's weaknesses on d6 and a5: 19.♔xd2! ♖a6 (19...♖ab8 20.♗xe6 fxe6 21.♖xa5±) 20.♖ha1 ♖b8 (20...♗xb3 21.♖xb3±) 21.♘d5!±

19.♕xb4

This improves slightly the position of the weak black pawn, but keeps most assets and eradicates counterchances. It is a logical choice, though analytically 19.c3!? has the same value: 19...♕b5 20.c4 (20.♗xe6!? fxe6 21.♕xd6! ♕xb2 22.0-0±) 20...♕b4 (20...♕c6 21.♕xa5 ♘xe4?! 22.♘d5!+–) 21.♕xb4 axb4 22.♖a4!?±.

19...axb4 20.♖a5!

It is important to keep control of d5.

20...♗xb3?!

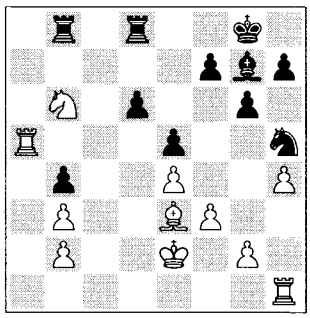
The white knight prevents the black rooks from seizing the most active files and in spite of the poor value of the pawns, the endgame clearly favours White. 20...♘h5? 21.♗xe6 fxe6 22.♘d7+−; 20...♖fd8!? 21.♔f2! with an eye on g3 (21.♔e2 ♘h5!?) 21...h6 22.♖b5±.

21.cxb3 ♖fd8 22.♔e2

Clears the way for the rook and has a good reply in store against the threats on g3 and h4. 22.♔f2!?

22...♘h5?!

22...♗h6 23.♗xh6 ♖xb6 24.♖d1± with the idea 25.♖xe5; 22...d5! 23.♘xd5 ♘xd5 24.exd5±.



23.♖c1!

Taking advantage of the premature bishop swap on b3. We can say that the theoretical battle has finished and White is the winner; the best confirmation of this is the fact that nobody has followed Black's play to this point.

23...f5

Tiviakov analyses several alternatives but in the end, the game will be decided by the penetrations on the 7th or 8th rank, the hold on the d5-square and a well-timed exchange of the white bishop and the black knight. The variations are simple: 23...♖b7 24.♖c8 ♖xc8 25.♘xc8±; 23...♘f4+ 24.♗xf4 exf4 (24...♖xb6 25.♗e3±) 25.♘d5±; 23...♗f6 24.♖c7 ♗xh4 25.♖aa7±.

24.♖c7! fxe4 25.fxe4 ♘f4+ 26.♔d2! ♘e6

26...♘xg2 27.♖aa7±; 26...♗h6? 27.♘d7+−.

27.♖e7 ♖e8

27...♘d4 28.♗xd4 exd4 29.♘d5+−; 27...♘c5 28.♗xc5 dxc5+ 29.♘d5+−.

28.♘d5 ♖xe7 29.♘xe7+ ♔f8

29...♔f7 30.♖a7+−; 29...♔h8 the king is badly placed there.

30.♘d5

30.♘c6!? ♖b7 31.♖a4 ♖c7!? △ 32.♘xb4 ♖b7±.

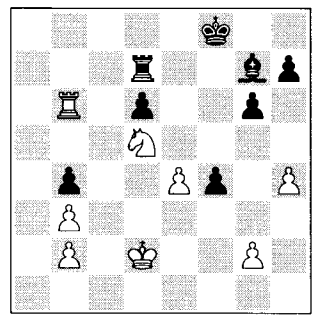
30...♖b7

30...♘d4 31.♗xd4 exd4 32.♖a4+−.

31.♖a6 ♖d7 32.♖b6 ♘f4□

32...♘c5 33.♗xc5 dxc5 34.♖c6+−.

33.♗xf4 exf4



34.♘xf4?!

White could have finished the game with 34.♖xb4 ♗xb2 35.♖b8+

(35.♘xf4+–) 35...♔g7 36.b4+– From now onwards the game enters a phase of technical conversion that Tiviakov analyses in detail in *Chess Informant* 65.

34...♗h6! 35.♔e3 d5 36.exd5 ♖xd5 37.♖xb4 ♖d1 38.g4 ♔g8 39.♖b8+ ♔f7 40.♖b7+ ♔g8 41.g5 ♗g7 42.b4 ♗xb2 43.♘d3? 43.b5! **43...♗c3 44.b5 ♖h1□ 45.♘f4?!** 45.b6!? **45...♖xh4 46.♘d5 ♗d4+! 47.♔d3 ♔f8□**

47...h6?? 48.♘e7++– Δ 49.♘f5.

48.♘f6

48.b6 ♗xb6 49.♖xb6 h6=.

48...h6 49.♖h7 ♗e5? 49...♗xf6□= **50.b6 ♖b4 51.♘d7+??** 51.♖b7□ **51...♔g8 52.♖e7 ♗g7□ 53.gxh6 ♗xh6= 54.♘f6+**

54.b7 ♗f4.

54...♔f8 55.♖e4 ♖b1 56.♘d5 ♗g5 57.♘b4 ♗e7 58.b7 ♗d6 59.♔c2 ♖a1 60.♘c6 ♖a6 61.♘d8 ♖a5 62.♖e6 ♗h2 63.♔c3 ♖b5 64.♔c4 ♖b2 65.♖e1 ♗c7 66.♘e6+ ♔f7 67.♘xc7 ♖xb7 68.♘e8 ♖d7 69.♔c5 ♖d2 70.♘d6+ ♔g7 71.♔c6 g5 ½-½

SUMMARY

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 g6

– 5.♘c3 ♘f6?! 6.♘xc6 bxc6 7.e5: White gets a comfortable edge ±

– 5.♘c3 ♘f6?! 6.♘xc6 dxc6: the game is comfortable, though the advantage is more limited

5...♗g7 6.♗e3 and now:

– 6...d6: leads to a complete transposition to the Dragon

– 6...♘f6 7.♗c4 ♘a5: refuted, but dangerous if unknown ±

– 6...♘f6 7.♗c4 ♘e5: similar to the previous one ±

– 6...♘f6 7.♗c4 ♕b6: similar to the two previous lines ±

– 6...♘f6 7.♗c4 ♕a5: solid, but not very problematic for White ±

– 6...♘f6 7.♗c4 d6: solid if the idea is a transposition; speculative and dangerous if the idea is to play 8.f3 ♕b6 ±

6...♘f6 7.♗c4 0-0 8.♗b3 and now:

– 8...♘a5?: historical, but losing +–

– 8...♘g4: passive, but solid ±

– 8...a5 9.0-0 a4!?: the new line ...d5 poses the most problems for White ±

– 8...a5 9.0-0 d6 10.♘db5: Black is very restricted ±

– 8...a5 9.0-0 ♘xd4: one of the most solid variations in the Accelerated Dragon ±/=

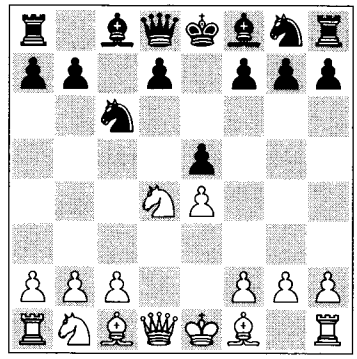
– 8...e6 9.0-0!: interesting, but White can get an edge ±

– 8...♕a5: tries to hinder 0-0-0 but fails due to 9.f3! ±

– 8...d6 9.f3 ♗d7: the critical variation. Black gets close to equality, but still has problems in the current state of theory ±/=

CHAPTER 6

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 e5
Löwenthal Variation



Evaluation **

Introduction, history and ideas

The real pioneer of 4...e5 was La Bourdonnais, who used it three times in his famous matches against MacDonnell. MacDonnell's answer was 5.♘xc6 and these games have not been studied here, because of their lack of theoretical interest. However, one of them is La Bourdonnais' Immortal, in which three connected pawns reach the seventh rank.

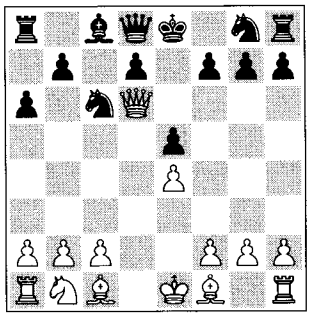
Later on, Löwenthal analysed this variation and gave it his name, but his results against Morphy were worse than La Bourdonnais'. However, it seems that we owe the line with ...a6 and ...♕f6 to Lutikov and Sakharov. It has never enjoyed a good reputation and has never returned to world-class events, but it has kept a degree of popularity among amateur players.

By giving the dark-squared bishop and weakening the d5-square, Black is making very serious long-term concessions. Only vigorous and active play in the first phase of the game may give Black hope. White has tried several plans based on exploiting the dark squares, especially with 8.♕c7 or 8.♕a3, but the plan recommended in this book, though less ambitious, is the soundest option. White focuses on the control of the d5-square and Black will be forced to play actively and, usually, to offer some pawns to prevent a positional wreck. As a consequence, virtually all Black's ideas are of a tactical nature.

Game 6.01

Ganguly,Surya
Gillani ,Tunveer
Dhaka Zonal 2007

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 e5 5.♘b5 a6 6.♘d6+ ♗xd6 7.♕xd6



7...♕f6

This is almost universally played in this position. The alternatives are almost bizarre.

O 7...f5?! A horrible-looking move that has been tested in correspondence games by Cordovil and Kondrak. White must have a great array of pleasant replies: 8.♘c3 ♕f6 9.♕d1 ♘ge7 10.♗c4 b5 11.♘d5 (11.♗b3±) 11...♕d6 (11...♕g6 12.0-0 bxc4 13.♘c7+ ♔d8 14.♘xa8 fxe4 15.♘b6±) 12.♗b3 (12.♗g5!? looks good but leads to complications) 12...♗b7 (12...fxe4 13.♗e3!) 13.♗g5 ♘xd5 14.♕xd5 ♕xd5 15.♗xd5±.

O 7...♕e7 With similar ideas to those in the main line, but the queen stands more actively on f6. 8.♕d1

A) 8...f5?! 9.♘c3 fxe4 10.♘d5 ♕d6 11.♗e3 ♘f6 12.♘b6 ♕xd1+ 13.♖xd1 ♖b8 14.♗c4± Van der Wiel-Theotokatos, Katerini 1992;

B) 8...d6 9.♘c3 ♗e6 10.♘d5 ♕d8 11.♗e3 ♗xd5 12.exd5 ♕a5+ 13.c3 ♘ce7 14.♕b3! ♕xd5 15.♗c4± Moller-Luther, cr. 1984;

C) 8...♘f6 9.♘c3 h6 (9...0-0 10.♗g5±; 9...d6 10.♗g5 ♗e6 11.♘d5 ♗xd5 12.exd5 ♘b8 13.♗e2 ♘bd7 14.0-0 0-0 15.c4± Popovic-Z.Nikolic, Belgrade 1992) 10.♗e3 0-0 11.♕d2 b5 12.0-0-0 ♕e6 13.f3 ♘e7 14.♗c5 ♖d8 15.♕d6 ♕xd6 16.♗xd6 ♘g6 17.a4 bxa4 18.♘xa4 ♘e8 19.♗b4 a5 20.♘b6 ♖a7 21.♗c5 ♗a6 22.♘xd7 ♖axd7 23.♗xa6 ♘f4 24.♗b6 ♖xd1+ 25.♖xd1 ♖a8 26.♗c4± Svidler-Maze, France tt 2005.

8.♕d1!

Other replies, such as 8.♕xf6, 8.♕c7 and 8.♕a3, also offer good prospects for an edge, but the text move has the support of a great deal of practical experience and allows less counterplay.

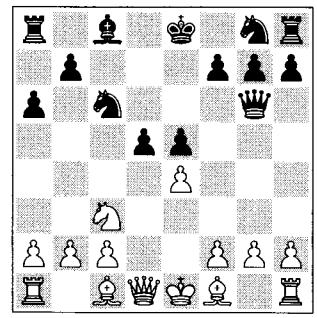
8...♕g6

Black can't do without this move either, if he wants to create problems by active play. The pressure on e4 and g2 and the X-rays over c2 impact a good deal on White's development. The alternatives are very passive and allow White to consolidate his advantage:

O 8...d6 9.♘c3 ♗e6 10.♘d5 ♕d8 11.♗e3± transposes to a variation mentioned in the previous note.

O 8...♘ge7 9.♘c3 0-0 10.♗e3 d6 11.♕d2 b5 12.0-0-0 ♖d8 13.♔b1 (13.h4!?±) 13...♕g6 14.f3 ♗e6 15.♘d5 ♖ac8 16.♗d3 f6 17.♖c1 ♕f7 18.c4 ♖b8 19.♖hd1 bxc4 20.♗xc4± Gligoric-Rossetto, Santa Fe 1960.

9.♘c3 d5?!



This move leads to strong complications and once succeeded in rescuing the Löwenthal Variation from oblivion. Once thoroughly analysed, it is worse than the classical 9...♘ge7 and just works out as a surprise weapon against unprepared opponents. The other alternatives are studied in the next game.

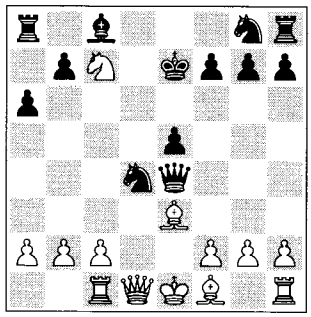
10.♘xd5!

The seemingly neat capture 10.♕xd5 allows strong compensation: 10...♗e6 11.♕d1 ♖d8 12.♗d2 ♘f6⩲; 10.exd5 ♘d4 11.♗d3 ♕xg2∞.

10...♕xe4+ 11.♗e3! ♘d4

11...♘b4? 12.♘c7+ ♔e7 13.♗d3 ♘xd3+?! (13...♕xg2 14.♗c5++–) 14.♕xd3 ♕xg2 15.0-0-0 ♔f6 16.♖hg1 1-0 Dahlhaus-Leschinsky, Germany tt 1997/98.

12.♘c7+ ♔e7 13.♖c1!



The move that has buried 9...d5?!

13...♗g4

The only move to create complications.

14.♕d3 ♕xd3 15.♗xd3 ♖d8

Otherwise, the knight escapes unscathed. Now White must be careful or his c7 knight may be a source of headaches, but, with accurate play, the resulting positions clearly favour White.

16.h3!

16.f4 ♔d6!∞; 16.f3 ♗c8!∞.

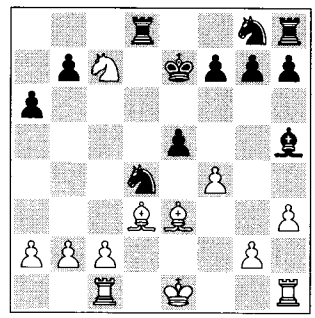
16...♗h5!

The most resilient retreat, although the bishop runs a certain risk of getting trapped.

16...♗c8 17.f4 ♔d6!? The most disturbing move, forcing the knight into an unusual route (17...exf4 18.♗xf4 ♘e6 19.♘xe6 ♗xe6 20.0-0± White's problems are over and he has the bishop pair. The rest no longer depends on theoretical knowledge, Liberzon-Franzoni, Biel 1980). 18.♘a8 f6 (18...♗e6 19.fxe5+ ♔xe5 20.♘b6±) 19.c3 ♘c6 20.♖d1 ♔e7 21.fxe5 fxe5 22.♗b6 ♖d5 23.♘c7± Dann-Wagner, Willingen jr 2008.

17.f4!

With the double threat fxe5 and g2-g4.



17...♔d6!

It is essential to harass the knight. 17...f6 makes life really comfortable for White: 18.g4!? ♗f7 19.fxe5 fxe5 20.0-0±.

18.♘xa6! bxa6 19.g4

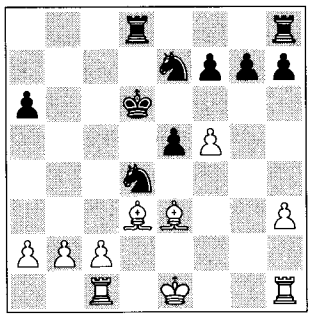
White regains his piece, while keeping the bishop pair and a better structure,

but Black has some compensation based on piece activity.

19...♗g6 20.f5 ♗xf5

20...♘f6 21.c3 (21.♗xd4 exd4 22.0-0±) 21...♘c6?! (21...♘xf5 is slightly better: 22.gxf5 ♔c7 23.♗c2 ♗h5 24.♖g1±) 22.♗xa6 ♖a8 23.♗c4 ♔c7 24.♔e2± Salgado Lopez-Alonso Roselli, Padrun jr 2008.

21.gxf5 ♘e7



22.0-0

My suggestion is **22.♖d1!**, taking advantage of the bad position of the black king: 22...♘d5 (22...♔c7 23.0-0 ♖d6 24.♗xd4 exd4 25.♖f4±) 23.♗c1±, preserving the bishop pair for future use.

22...♘d5 23.♗d2 e4!

A good attempt at counterplay; 23...♖he8 24.♖ce1 ♖b8 25.b3 ♖ec8 26.c4 ♘b4 27.♗b1 ♘bc2 28.♖d1±.

24.♗xe4! ♘e2+ 25.♔f2 ♘xc1 26.♖xc1 ♖he8 27.♔f3±

Black has won the exchange, but with the bishop pair and the passed pawns, the position still favours White.

27...♘f6 28.♗b4+

28.♗f4+ ♔d7 29.♗d3±.

28...♔d7 29.♗d3 ♘d5 30.♗d2 ♘c7?!

30...♔c6 31.♗xa6 ♖a8 32.♗c4 ♔c5 33.♗b3 ♖e5 34.c4 ♘f6∞.

31.a4 ♔c6 32.♗e3 ♖d6 33.♗e4+ ♔d7 34.c4 g6 35.b4± ♖xe4?

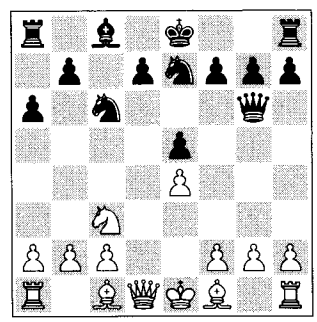
35...♘e6! 36.b5 gxf5 37.♗xf5±.

36.♔xe4 gxf5+ 37.♔xf5 ♖d3 38.♔e4 ♖a3 39.♖f1 ♖xa4 40.♖xf7+ ♔c8 41.♗d2+– a5 42.bxa5 ♖xc4+ 43.♔f3 ♖h4 44.♔g3 ♖h5 45.♔g4 ♖d5 46.♗e1 h5+ 47.♔h4 ♘a6 48.♖f6 ♘c5 49.a6 ♔b8 50.♗g3+ ♔a8 51.♗f2 ♘d7 52.♖h6 ♖f5 53.♖h8+ ♖f8 54.♖xf8+ ♘xf8 55.♔xh5 ♘e6 56.♔g4 ♘c7 57.h4 ♘xa6 58.h5 ♘c7 59.h6 ♘d5 60.♔g5 1-0

Game 6.02

Hodges,Paul
McClure,D
cr USA 1994

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 e5 5.♘b5 a6 6.♘d6+ ♗xd6 7.♕xd6 ♕f6 8.♕d1 ♕g6 9.♘c3 ♘ge7



The oldest variation. Black's main theme is a violent ...d5 combined with ...♘b4 and ...♗f5, and White must play accurately to keep the advantage.

Apart from the move 9...d5, analysed in the previous game, Black has tried **9...♘f6?!**, which looks more active but meets 10.♕d6!, which prevents all reaction. 10...♕g4 (10...b5 is one of the most recent attempts, but defending the attacked pawn by means of 11.f3 is enough to keep a comfortable edge. For example: 11...b4 12.♘a4 ♘h5 – Black has to find a way to castle – 13.♕xg6 hxg6 14.♔f2±) 11.f3 ♕e6 12.♕d1 ♘e7 13.♗g5! (always hindering ...d5) 13...0-0 14.♕d2 b5 15.a3 (15.♖d1!?) 15...♗b7 16.♗xf6 ♕xf6 17.♕xd7 ♗c6 18.♕d2 ♖fd8 19.♗d3± Mikhalets-Kazmin, Yalta Open 1996.

10.h4!

The first of a series of precise moves. This pawn intends to displace the black queen from her active position, which diminishes the effects of the break ...d5. On the other hand, the pawn sets up an important support point for the g5 bishop.

10...h5

The consequences of not preventing h4-h5 are bad:

O 10...f5? is positionally repulsive, but it has been used in quite a lot of games: 11.h5 ♕f7 12.b3 (12.♗e3!?) 12...fxe4 13.♗c4 d5?! 14.♘xd5 ♘xd5 15.♗xd5 ♕c7 16.♗xe4+– Rodriguez Cespedes-A.Herrera, Linares Open 1994.

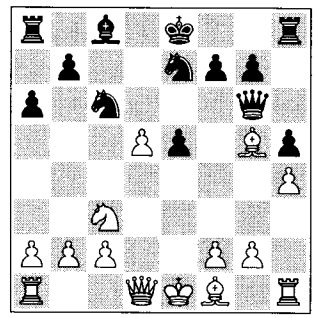
O 10...d5?! is more logical, but it does not work well here due to 11.h5! ♕d6 12.♘xd5 (12.h6!? may be even better) 12...♘xd5 13.exd5 ♘e7 14.c4+– b5 15.b3 ♗f5 16.♗e2 bxc4 17.bxc4 0-0 18.0-0 ♖ab8 19.♕a4 1-0 Illescas Cordoba-Fernandez, Spain ch-jr 1984.

O 10...0-0?! 11.h5 ♕e6 12.♘d5 ♕d6 13.h6! g6 14.♗g5 ♘xd5 15.exd5 ♕b4+ 16.c3 ♕e4+ 17.♗e3 ♘e7 18.c4± Adamski-Johnsson, cr. 1988.

11.♗g5 d5

11...f6 12.♗e3 and now the white queen threatens to come to d6: 12...d5 (12...f5 13.exf5 ♘xf5 14.♗g5±) 13.♘xd5 ♗g4 (13...♘xd5 14.♕xd5, and ...♗e6 is not possible) 14.♘c7+ ♔f8 15.f3 ♖d8 16.♗d3 ♗c8 17.♕d2± Correas Gonzalez-Fenollar Jorda, Valencia 2002.

12.exd5



12...♘b4?!

The classical line, which only offers Black a difficult endgame. The alternative 12...♘d4!?, which has brought about a certain revival of this line, will be examined in the next game.

13.♗xe7

The simplest move, taking the game into an ending where only White can play for a win. 13.♖c1!? is also a good alternative.

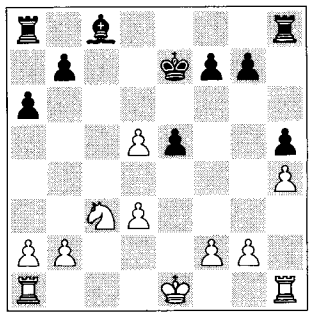
13...♔xe7

13...♘xc2+? 14.♔d2 ♘xa1 15.♗a3+–.

14.♗d3 ♘xd3+ 15.♕xd3 ♕xd3

There is no choice, as 15...♕xg2? fails to 16.0-0-0±; 15...♗f5? 16.♕e2±.

16.cxd3



The starting point for the endgame. White has an extra pawn, though doubled, and while Black struggles to win it back, White can open the game for his rooks by breaking with f4 or d4. Black has tried many moves here, but none of them guarantees a quiet path to the draw, which is the best he can realistically hope for in this position.

16...♖h6!?

16...♔d6 17.0-0-0±; **16...b5** 17.a3 ♗f5 18.♔d2 ♖h6 19.♖he1 ♔d6 20.♖ac1 ♖g6 21.g3± Sveshnikov-Panchenko, USSR 1976.

17.♔d2±

This is the most promising move, freeing the two central files for the white rooks. 17.0-0-0, tried in many games, offers similar prospects: 17...♖g6 18.♖he1 ♔d6 19.d4 exd4 20.♖xd4 ♖xg2 21.♘e4+ ♔d7 22.d6± Domanski-Halwick, cr APCT ch 1989-90.

17...♖b6

Here and on the following moves we can analyse many different alternatives, with little hope of being exhaustive. What is easy to grasp is the idea that White has great scope to improve his position, and his rooks easily occupy the open files.

O 17...f5 18.♖he1 (18.f4!?) 18...♔d6 19.♖e2 b5 20.♖ae1 b4 21.♘d1+–;

O 17...♖g6 18.g3 ♔d6 19.♖ac1 b5?! 20.♘e4+ ♔xd5 21.♖c5+ ♔e6 22.♘g5+ ♔d6 23.♖hc1+–.

18.b3 ♖g6

18...♗f5 19.♖he1 (19.♘e4 ♖d8) 19...♔d6 20.♖ac1 ♖d8 (20...♖b4 21.♘e4+ ♔xd5 22.♖c5+ ♔e6 23.♘g5++–) 21.f4! (21.♘e4+ ♔xd5 22.♖c5+ ♔e6 23.f4 f6 24.fxe5 fxe5 25.♘g5+ ♔f6 26.♖exe5 ♖xd3+∞) 21...exf4 22.♘e2 ♖e8 (22...♖b4 23.♖c4±) 23.♘xf4 ♖xe1 24.♖xe1±.

19.g3 b5

19...f6 20.♖ac1 ♗f5 21.♘e4 ♖d8 22.♖c7+ ♔e8 23.♖xb7 ♖xd5 24.♖c1±; 19...♔d6 20.♖ac1 b5 21.♖he1±; 19...♗f5 20.♖ac1 ♔d6 21.♖he1 ♖c8 22.♔e3 followed by d3-d4 or ♘e4+.

20.♖ac1± b4

20...♗b7 21.♖he1±.

21.♘e4 f5

21...♗f5 22.♖c7+!+–.

22.♘g5 ♖d6 23.♖c5 ♗b7

23...♗d7 24.♖hc1.

24.♖e1

24.♖c7+!? ♖d7 25.♖xd7+ ♔xd7 26.♖e1+–.

24...♔f6

24...♖xd5?! 25.♖c7++−.

25.f4!+−

Finally, it has become clear that Black will not regain his pawn and the white pieces have become too active.

25...exf4

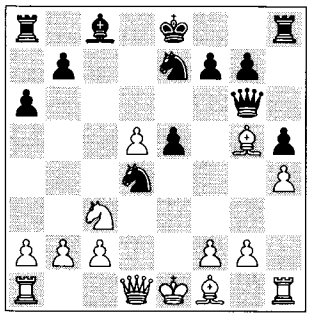
25...♖e8 26.fxe5+ ♖xe5 27.♘h7+.

26.gxf4 ♖ad8 27.♖e6+ ♖xe6 28.dxe6 ♗e4 29.♖c7! ♖xd3+ 30.♔e2 ♖d6 31.♖f7+ 1-0

Game 6.03

Efimenko,Zahar
Vallejo Pons,Francisco
Khanty-Mansiysk 2005

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 e5 5.♘b5 a6 6.♘d6+ ♗xd6 7.♕xd6 ♕f6 8.♕d1 ♕g6 9.♘c3 ♘ge7 10.h4 h5 11.♗g5 d5 12.exd5 ♘d4



This move leads to more active positions than 12...♘b4, and is less studied, but in the end White has many ways to achieve an advantage.

13.♗d3 ♗f5 14.♗xf5 ♘dxf5!?

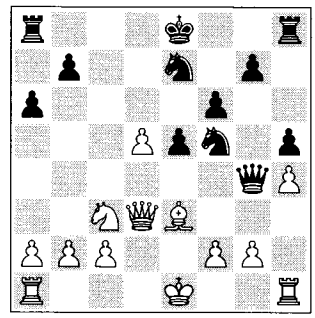
A paradoxical capture, justified by concrete analysis. Also interesting is 14...♘exf5!? 15.♕d3 f6 16.♗e3 ♕g4! (a curious way to hinder White's development. 16...♕xg2?! 17.0-0-0 is too risky) 17.♗xd4! ♘xd4 (17...exd4 18.♘e2 ♕xg2 19.0-0-0 ♕xf2 20.♖d2±) 18.♘e2! 0-0-0 19.♘xd4 ♕xd4 (19...exd4 20.0-0 ♕xh4 21.♖ad1 ♔b8 22.♕xd4± and White comes out with an extra pawn) 20.0-0-0! ♕xf2 21.♖d2±. White has a better king and his passed pawns are slightly more advanced.

15.♕d3

15.♕d2! is an untried move, but looks enough to pose problems for Black: 15...f6 16.♗e3 ♕xg2 (16...♕g4 17.f3!± – this is the difference from ♕d3) 17.0-0-0 0-0-0 18.♗b6±.

15...f6 16.♗e3 ♕g4!?

Again this move, which hinders White's development.



17.g3?!

It is difficult to face new ideas. White has many promising continuations, and it is hard to decide which is best:
17.♗c5!? ♘xh4 18.f3!? (leads to a forced line. Also interesting is 18.♖xh4 ♕xh4 19.0-0-0 with good compensation for the exchange) 18...♕g3+ 19.♗f2 ♘xg2+ 20.♔f1 ♕g5 21.♖g1 ♘f4 22.♕e4 (22.♖xg5 ♘xd3 23.♖xg7

♘xf2 24.♔xf2 ♖d8 25.♘e4± is also appealing) 22...♕f5 (22...♕h6 23.♗c5±) 23.♖xg7 ♕h3+ 24.♔e1 with an interesting initiative which needs practical assessment.

17...♘xe3

Better was 17...0-0-0! 18.♗c5 ♖he8 (18...♖d7? 19.d6 ♔b8 20.♘e4! ♘c8 21.f3 ♕g6 22.0-0-0 ♖hd8 23.♔b1 ♘fxd6 24.♗xd6+ ♘xd6 25.♘c5+–) 19.♗xe7 ♘xe7 20.♖d1 ♔b8 and Black has certain compensation for the pawn.

18.♕xe3 ♖d8 19.♖d1 0-0 20.0-0 ♘f5 21.♕e4 ♘d4 22.♔g2 ♕xe4+

22...f5!? 23.♕xg4 (23.♕xe5 ♕f3+ 24.♔h3 ♕g4+=; 23.♕d3 f4 24.♘e4 ♘f5 25.♖h1⩲) 23...hxg4 and it is hard to see how White is going to consolidate his extra pawn.

23.♘xe4 ♘xc2

Black has regained his pawn, but some of his problems remain unsolved.

24.d6!± ♘d4 25.f4 ♘f5 26.♖d3 ♖fe8 27.d7 ♖e7 28.fxe5 ♖xe5 29.♖c1 ♔f7 30.♖c8

30.♔f3! followed by ♖c7 and Black's problems persist.

30...♔e7 31.♘c5

This looks very strong, but meets an accurate answer.

31...♘d6! 32.♖xd8 ♔xd8 33.b4 b6!

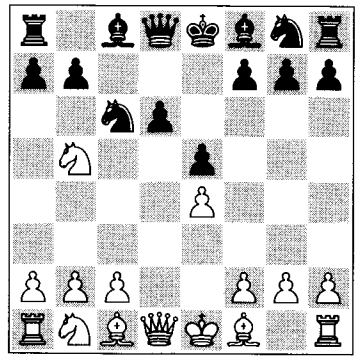
Forcing the draw.

34.♖xd6 bxc5 35.bxc5 ♖xc5 36.♖xa6 ♔xd7 37.♖a7+ ♔e6 38.♖xg7 ♖c2+ 39.♔f3 ½-½

SUMMARY
1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 e5 5.♘b5 a6 6.♘d6+ ♗xd6 7.♕xd6
– 7... f5: clearly anti-positional, but dangerous ±
– 7... ♕e7: more solid but passive and awkward ±
7... ♕f6 8.♕d1 ♕g6 9.♘c3
– 9... d5: playable, as it is complicated and White's advantage is not overwhelming ±
9...♘ge7 10.h4 h5 11.♗g5 d5 12.exd5 and now:
– 12... ♘b4: the classical variation, that leads to a defensible endgame, but depressing for Black ±
– 12... ♘d4!?: a new idea with a certain bite ±
– 12...♘d4 13.♗d3 ♗f5 14.♗xf5 ♘exf5: complicated, but White can eventually get the upper hand ±
– 12...♘d4 13.♗d3 ♗f5 14.♗xf5 ♘dxf5: somewhat more solid ±

CHAPTER 7

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 e5 5.♘b5 d6 Kalashnikov Variation



Evaluation ***

Introduction, history and ideas

The move 5...d6 has only become popular in recent years. In spite of some experiments by Minev and Larsen in the 1950s, and later by the Austrian IM Frank Hölzl, 5...d6 (though far sounder than 5...a6) wasn't taken seriously until Sveshnikov started to use it regularly in 1987. With his games, together with some opening surveys, its popularity skyrocketed and for some time it was called Sveshnikov 2 Variation.

Later a veritable army of players would add it to their repertoires. The success of the 5...d6 lines has remained to this day and the fact that it still lacks its own place among the classical Sicilian variations is due to a few factors:

1) Its theory has very recently developed.

2) The hole on d5 still puts many players off.

3) Last and most important, White can avoid this line by cunningly developing his knights, say, 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.♘c3, though in this case he must be ready to face 3...e5, or 2.♘c3 ♘c6 3.♘ge2, though again 3...e5 is playable here.

In any case, factor 3 means that we must have other Sicilian lines in our repertoire, and 4...e5 and 5...d6 cannot be our only option.

This set-up and its elder sister, the Pelikan Variation, have many common features, not because they are Sveshnikov's offspring, but because the pawn structure is the same. Black gives up the d5-square, but gets active piece development in return. In the early days of the variation, White would try to punish Black's move order by means of 6.c4, with a firm grip on d5, but Black proved that this plan also has a dark side, mainly loosening the control of d4 and turning the light-squared bishop into a miserable spectator.

Black has also concentrated on trying to make the ambitious push ...f5, which

wins space at the expense of a more serious weakening of the light squares, into a playable plan. Sometimes black players attempt to trade dark-squared bishops by means of the manoeuvre ...♗e7-g5, which is impossible in Pelikan positions.

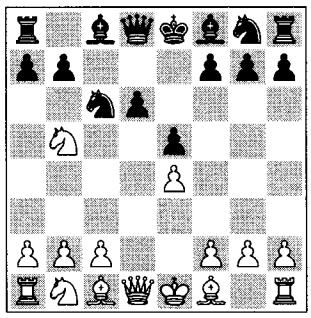
Even though 6.c4 is still one of the main lines, recently the strongest players are shifting towards our suggestion 6.♘1c3, which allows a complete transposition to the first Sveshnikov variation. When there is no transposition, Black can only oppose White's grip on the d5-square by exchanging the knight that occupies that outpost. This leads to positions with a different pawn structure and different strategies: a slight space advantage if White recaptures symmetrically (cxd5) and a straightforward attack on Black's queenside if White recaptures with the other pawn.

Lastly, if White succeeds in recapturing with a piece on d5 in favourable conditions, then he can go on with his classical strategy based on the grip on that square.

Game 7.01

Anand,Viswanathan
Shirov,Alexei
Linares 2002

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 e5 5.♘b5 d6



This move constitutes the Kalashnikov Variation. White has tested many moves here; for many years the main line was 6.c4 and that is still an ambitious set-up, but lately 6.♘1c3 has come into fashion, probably because Black used to get a strong grip on the dark squares, specially on d4, against 6.c4.

6.♘1c3 a6

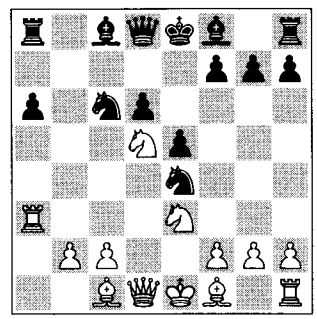
6...♗e6?! doesn't make so much sense: 7.♘d5! ♖c8 8.♗e3 (hindering ...a6) 8...♘f6 and now, instead of 9.c3, 9.f3! is a simple way of keeping the pressure on Black's position. **6...♘f6** transposes inevitably to the Pelikan (see Chapter 8).

7.♘a3 b5

Some players try to transpose now to the Pelikan with 7...♘f6 but White can avoid the transposition with good prospects.

O 7...♘f6 8.♘c4! b5 9.♘e3 ♗e7

Pawn-grabbing is risky here: 9...b4?! 10.♘cd5 ♘xe4 11.a3! bxa3 (Anand regards this move as weak, but the alternative is not very appealing: 11...b3 12.cxb3±) 12.♖xa3.



The real critical moment, where every logical alternative has drawbacks:

A) 12...♗e7 13.♗b5! ♗b7 14.♗xc6+ ♗xc6 15.♕g4±;

B) 12...♗b7 13.♗c4 ♗e7? 14.♕g4+−;

C) 12...♘f6 13.♘xf6+ ♕xf6 14.♕d5 ♗d7 (14...♗b7 15.♗xa6!) 15.♗b5±;

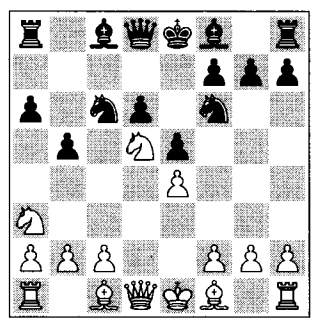
D) 12...♖a7!? 13.b4 g6 14.b5±;

E) 12...g6 13.c3 ♗d7?! (13...f5 would pose more problems but White still has promising moves. Anand indicates b2-b4 and ♘c4. Perhaps ♗c4 is a good alternative as well) 14.♘c4± (14.f3!?) 14...♖b8 15.♗e3 f5 16.♗b6 ♖xb6 17.♘cxb6+− Anand-Ponomariov, Wijk aan Zee 2003.

10.g3!? Anand, who had seen the original game by Shirov, considers this move as the best chance for an edge. Anyway, there seems to be room for improvement in 10.♗d3 as well: 10.♗d3 0-0 11.0-0 ♖b8 12.♘cd5 ♘xd5 13.exd5 (13.♘xd5!± deserves attention) 13...♘a5 14.a4 b4 15.♗d2 f5 16.c3 bxc3 17.♗xc3 e4 18.♗c2 ♗f6 19.g3 ♗d7 20.♖b1 ♘b7 ½-½ Shirov-Ivanchuk, Wijk aan Zee 2003. **10...h5** (10...b4 11.♘cd5 ♘xe4 is another version of the pawn grab, equally promising for White. For example: 12.♗g2 f5 13.♘xe7 ♘xe7 14.♘c4 0-0 15.♘xd6 ♗b7 16.♘xb7 ♕xd1+ 17.♔xd1 ♘xf2+ 18.♔e1 ♘xh1 19.♗xh1±) **11.♗g2 h4 12.0-0** (12.♘cd5!? hxg3 13.hxg3 ♖xh1+ 14.♗xh1 ♘xd5 15.♘xd5 ♗e6 16.c3±) **12...♘d4 13.♘cd5 ♘xd5 14.♘xd5 ♗e6 15.♘e3 hxg3 16.hxg3 ♕d7 17.c3 ♘c6 18.♖e1 ♖b8 19.a4 g6 20.axb5 axb5 21.♘d5±** Anand-Radjabov, Linares 2003, with the usual firm grip.

O 7...♗e6!? is another secondary line deserving attention, though it meets the same treatment. **8.♘c4! b5 9.♘e3 ♘f6** And the white knights, though in total control of the key square d5, at the same time block the rest of his pieces. **10.g3!?** First tried in Shirov-Bareev, this was considered a natural way of controlling the key squares and, if Black captures the pawn, White gets the standard compensation. 10.♗d3 is a solid alternative, with a very simple plan: 10...♗e7 11.0-0 0-0 12.a4 b4 13.♘cd5 followed by ♗d2 and c2-c3. **10...b4** 10...♖c8 11.♗g2 (11.a4!? b4 12.♘cd5 ♘xe4 13.♗xa6±) 11...h5 12.0-0 h4 13.♘cd5 ♘e7 14.♘xf6+ gxf6 15.a4 b4 16.♕d3± Shirov-Bareev, Tilburg 1993. **11.♘cd5 ♘xe4 12.♗g2 f5!** The critical defence, as two recent games by Grigore prove. If 12...♘c5 13.0-0 (13.♘f6+ gxf6 14.♗xc6+ ♘d7 15.♗xa8 is less clear) 13...♖c8 (Hermansson-Wiersma, Kallithea tt 2008) and now 14.b3! followed by a2-a3 offers White a good deal of compensation. **13.0-0 ♖c8** (on 13...♗e7 14.♘xf5! ♗xf5 15.♘e3 ♗g6 16.♕d5± regains the piece with the better structure) **14.a3** (14.g4!? smashes Black's centre, but it is not clear that this is enough to claim an edge: 14...g6 15.f4 ♘f6 16.fxe5 dxe5 17.♘xf6+ ♕xf6 18.gxf5 gxf5 19.♘xf5 ♗xf5 20.♕h5+ ♗g6 21.♖xf6 ♗c5+ 22.♔f1 ♗xh5 23.♗xc6+=) **14...b3** (14...bxa3 15.♖xa3±) **15.c3 ♘c5 16.♘c4** with some compensation, but it is a matter of opinion if it is enough.

8.♘d5 ♘f6



A last offer to transpose to the Pelikan, but here Black has avoided the sharpest variation. White must avoid 9.♗g5 if it is not in his repertoire against the Pelikan, and there aren't many alternatives left.

○ Another sideline is **8...♗e7**, which is also met by **9.c4! b4 10.♘c2 a5** 10...♖b8 11.♗e2 ♘f6 12.♕d3 ♘d7 13.♕g3 g6± Dimitrov-Bönsch, Wattens 1990, and White must be better, since the black position is full of weaknesses. **11.♗e3 ♖b8 12.♗e2 ♘f6 13.♘xf6+!?** Timoschenko preferred 13.♕d3!? **13...♗xf6 14.0-0 0-0±** Christiansen-Seirawan, Chandler ch-USA 1997, and a battle has just begun where White has a slight initiative but Black's position, though somewhat passive, is very solid. The rest of the game is not quite convincing, but it was a blitz game.

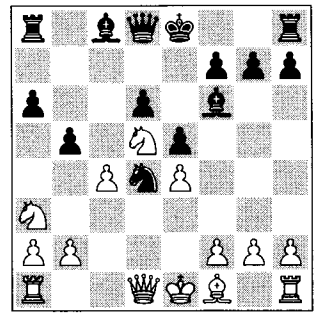
○ The main alternatives **8...♘ge7** and **8...♘ce7** will be studied in the next two games.

○ **8...♖b8** is yet another popular alternative, but after 9.c4 b4 10.♘c2 the transposition to 8...♗e7 or 8...♘f6 is difficult to avoid.

9.c4 b4

Black has at least two serious alternatives:

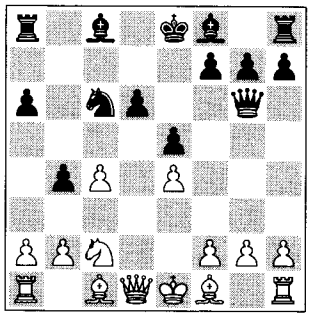
○ **9...♘d4!? 10.♗g5 ♗e7!** 10...♕a5+ 11.♗d2 ♕d8 12.♗d3 ♘xd5 13.cxd5 and White has reached a quite standard position in this variation, but with the slight plus of the extra move ♗d2: 13...♗e7 14.0-0 0-0 15.♗e3 f5 16.♗xd4 exd4 17.exf5 ♕b6 18.♖e1 ♗f6 19.♘c2 a5 20.♕h5 ♗d7 21.g4 h6 22.♖e6 Kotronias-Beshukov, Agios Nikolaos 1995. **11.♗xf6** (11.♘xe7 ♘xe4!) **11...♗xf6**



And we reach a fashionable position in the Pelikan (9.♘d5 ♗e7 10.♗xf6 ♗xf6 11.c4 and now 11...♘d4) that we should study here, because in the Pelikan order this is out of our repertoire. **12.cxb5 0-0 13.bxa6!** (13.♗d3 is the best known variation: 13...axb5 14.♘xb5 ♘xb5 15.♗xb5 ♕a5+ 16.♘c3 d5 17.exd5 e4⩲) **13...♗g5 14.h4 ♗h6** (14...♕a5+ 15.b4 ♕xa3 16.hxg5±) **15.♘c2 ♗g4 16.♕d3** (16.f3 ♗e6 17.♘xd4 ♗xd5 18.exd5 exd4 19.♗d3 seems to me difficult to assess, although possibly White can retain the advantage) **16...♖c8 17.♘xd4 ♕a5+ 18.♘c3 exd4 19.♕xd4 ♗f4 20.♕a4 ♕b6 21.♗b5 ♖c5 22.0-0±** and once White has castled, Black can't find a way to compensate for his pawn deficit, Martinovic-Saric, Nova Gorica 2007.

○ **9...♘xe4?!** doesn't seem to work here, but sets up some confusion. **10.cxb5!** looks the strongest: **10...♘e7** 10...axb5? 11.♕c2+–; 10...♕a5+ 11.♗d2 ♘xd2 12.♕xd2 axb5 13.♗xb5±; 10...♘d4? 11.b6!+–. **11.b6 ♘xf2 12.♔xf2 ♘xd5 13.♕xd5 ♕xb6+ 14.♗e3 ♕xb2+ 15.♗e2+–** and although Black has three pawns for a piece, his position is unsustainable.

10.♘xf6+ ♕xf6 11.♘c2 ♕g6



A slight disruption of White's development seems to be the only possible compensation for the ugly hole on d5. **11...♕d8** 12.♘e3 ♗e7 13.♘d5 0-0 14.♗e3± Rytshagov-Sveshnikov, Riga 2004; **11...♗b7** 12.g3 (12.♗d3!?±) 12...♗e7 13.♗g2 ♗d8 14.0-0 ♗b6 15.♘xb4 ♘xb4 16.♕b3 a5 17.a3 ♗c5 18.axb4 axb4 19.♖xa8+ ♗xa8 20.♕a4+ ♔e7 21.♗e3± Areschenko-Tregubov, Moscow 2005.

12.♕d5!?

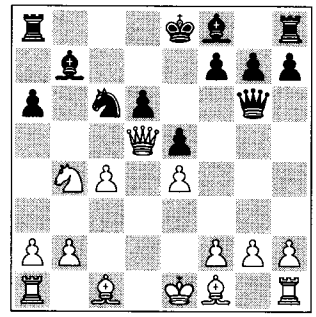
Anand's novelty in this game, which put this variation into a crisis.

12.♘e3!? has lately been the most popular choice, but it looks as though Radjabov's idea solves all Black's problems: **12...♗e7** If 12...♕xe4 13.♗d3 ♕d4 (13...♕h4 14.♘d5 ♕d8 15.♗e4±) 14.♘d5 ♖b8 15.♕e2 intending ♗e3, White has good compensation. **13.g3 ♘d4!** 13...0-0 14.♗g2 ♗g5 15.0-0± Bologan-Tregubov, Belfort 2002. **14.♗g2 ♗b7** Renewing the threat to the e4-pawn. **15.♘f5!?** 15.♘d5 ♗xd5 16.cxd5 0-0 17.♗e3 ♖fc8 18.♗xd4 exd4 19.♕xd4 ♖c2 offers Black good compensation for the pawn. **15...♕xf5!** The only move, but effective. **16.exf5 ♗xg2 17.♖g1 ♗f3 18.♕d3 d5** 18...♗e2 19.♕e4 ♗f3 looks easier, forcing White to hide his queen on b1 or allow a repetition. **19.cxd5 ♖c8 20.♗e3 ♘c2+ 21.♔f1 e4 22.♕xa6 0-0 23.♖b1 ♘xe3+ 24.fxe3 ♖c2 25.h4 ♖d8 26.♕b7 ♔f8 27.a4 ♖d2 28.♖c1 ♖2xd5 29.♖c8 ♖d1+ 30.♔f2 ♖d2+ 31.♔e1 ♖d1+ 32.♔f2 ♖d2+ 33.♔e1 ♖d1+ 34.♔f2 ♖d2+** ½-½, Topalov-Radjabov, Sofia 2008.

12...♗b7

Nobody has been willing to try 12...♗d7!? yet, but the reasons are far from clear, for instance: 13.♘xb4 (13.g3! must be the soundest positional approach S.Nilsson-Wickström, Vadso ch-SWE III 2008) 13...♖c8 14.♘c2 ♗e6 15.♕d3 f5! with quite good compensation.

13.♘xb4



13...♖c8?!

13...♘d8 is a more critical alternative, tried in some later games. Black regains the pawn, but White controls the key square d5 and the black knight must lose some time to get back into the game:

A) 14.♕a5!? is a suggestion from the first edition, still untested, for example: 14...♕xe4+ 15.♗e3 ♘c6 16.♕a4 ♗e7 17.♘d5±;

B) 14.♕d1 ♕xe4+ (14...♗xe4?! 15.♕a4+) 15.♗e3 ♗e7 (15...♘e6?!

16.♕a4+) 16.♘d5 ♗xd5 17.♕xd5 ♕xd5 18.cxd5 f5 19.♖c1 ♗f6 20.b3 0-0 Van Haastert-Van der Wiel, Wijk aan Zee 2007. Here a draw was agreed, but White has good prospects to create problems with the bishop pair and the pawn majority on the queenside.

14.♗e3

Sufficient for a comfortable edge, but Ftacnik also mentions 14.f3!? ♗e7 15.♘xc6 ♖xc6 16.♗e3±.

14...♗e7 15.h4

Again, 15.f3 is possible, for example: 15...0-0 16.♕d2±.

15...0-0 16.h5 ♕g4 17.f3 ♕g3+ 18.♔d1!?

Looks risky, but everything is under control. (18.♗f2!?)

18...♗g5 19.♘xc6! ♗xe3?!

19...♗xc6 20.♕d2 ♗xe3 21.♕xe3 ♗d7 22.h6±.

20.♘e7+ ♔h8 21.♕d3 ♗g5

21...♖c7? 22.♘f5+–.

22.♘xc8+–

There is no compensation for the exchange and the pawn.

22...♖xc8 23.h6 gxh6 24.♔c2 d5?!

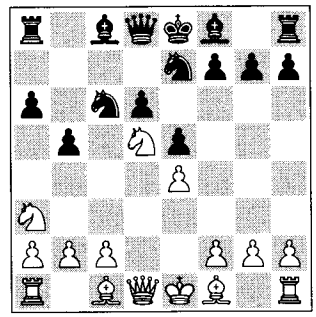
24...f5!?, a suggestion by Ftacnik, creates more complications: 25.exf5 ♕f2+ 26.♗e2 d5±.

25.exd5 ♗xd5 26.♕xd5 ♖d8 27.♕c5! ♖d2+ 28.♔b3 ♔g7 29.a3 e4 30.♖h3 ♕f4 31.fxe4 1-0

Game 7.02

Kotronias,Vasilios
Nikolaidis,Konstantinos
Athens 1993

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 e5 5.♘b5 d6 6.♘1c3 a6 7.♘a3 b5 8.♘d5 ♘ge7



This looks the most natural option but, given that Black is almost forced to exchange on d5, having to move the c6 knight again is annoying.

9.c4

Once again, this pawn push is our suggestion: White gives extra support to the d5 knight and a way back into the game to the a3 knight.

9...♘xd5

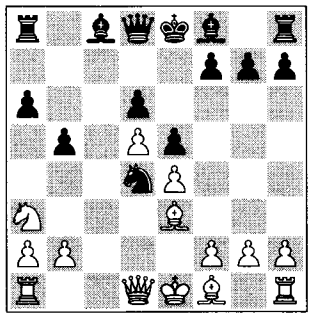
The most common alternative is **9...♘d4**, but it always transposes to the main line after 10.♗e3 ♘xd5 11.cxd5. **9...b4?!** isn't very logical, as after 10.♘c2 the e7 knight (which doesn't want to be exchanged off on d5 now) is an obstacle for its own pieces: 10...♖b8 11.♗e2 ♘xd5 12.cxd5 ♘e7 13.0-0 f5 14.f4! g6 15.fxe5 dxe5 16.♘e3± Maus-Schmittdiel, Bad Wörishofen 1991.

10.cxd5 ♘d4

Other retreats look very ugly: 10...♘e7?! 11.h4! (pre-empting the two logical ways of completing the kingside development, ...♘g6 or ...g6) 11...♗d7 (11...g6?! 12.h5↑; 11...f5 12.♗d3 fxe4 13.♗xe4 ♗f5 14.♕d3±; 11...♘g6?! 12.h5) 12.♘c2 h5 (12...g6 13.h5 ♗g7 14.♗g5! 0-0 15.hxg6 hxg6 16.♕d2±; 12...f5 13.♗d3±) 13.g3 g6 14.♗g2 ♗g7 15.0-0 0-0 16.♘b4± Bologan-Stripunsky, Wijk aan Zee B 1996.

11.♗e3

Paving the way to trading off the black knight. A typical mistake is playing the hasty 11.♘c2?! which runs into 11...♗g4! 12.f3? ♕h4+!∓.



11...♗e7

O 11...f5!? is an interesting alternative championed by Grigore, but looks too optimistic: 12.♗d3 fxe4 13.♗xe4 ♘f5 (Bluvshtein-Miton, Bled ol 2002) and now 14.0-0! ♗e7 (14...♘xe3 15.fxe3 and White has a favourable position thanks to his total grip on the light squares) 15.♘c2 0-0 16.♕d3± followed by ♘b4.

O 11...♕a5+?! has been tried in many games, but isn't logical because the queen swap favours White: 12.♕d2! ♕xd2+ 13.♔xd2 g6 14.♖c1 ♗g7 15.♗d3 0-0 16.♖c7± Munoz Pantoja-Ayas Fernandez, Sitges 2002.

O 11...g6!? The last word in this line, championed by Marcel Kanarek; in spite of its good results, I consider it harmless. **12.♘c2!** and now:

A) **12...♗g4** 13.f3! ♘xc2+ 14.♕xc2 ♗d7 15.♕d2!± preventing the dark-squared bishops swap by ...♗h6.

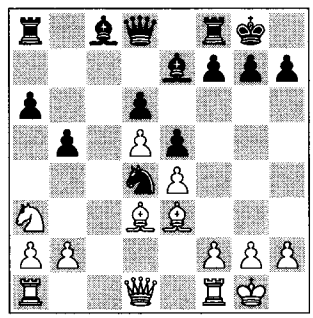
B) **12...♕a5+** 13.♗d2 ♕b6 14.♘xd4 ♕xd4 (14...exd4 15.a4!±) 15.♕c2 ♗d7 16.♗d3±.

C) **12...♘xc2+** 13.♕xc2 ♗d7 14.♗d3 ♗g7 15.0-0 0-0 16.♖ac1± Priyadharshan-Kanarek, Vung Tau City jr 2008 and in all these positions, the space advantage and the weakness of Black's queenside constitute a good starting point for White to develop an initiative.

12.♗d3 0-0

12...♕a5+ 13.♕d2±.

13.0-0

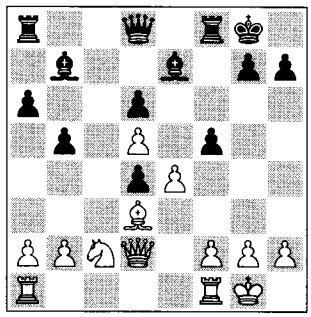


13...♗d7

Here the bishop makes way for the heavy pieces too, and doesn't bite on the granite of White's pawn wall.

O 13...♗b7 The move preferred in the early days of this variation. The bishop remains passive and it is thus understandable that Black has tried a wide range of alternatives: **14.♕d2** 14.♘c2!?

may be sufficient for a small edge, since in the case of 14...♘xc2 15.♕xc2 ♗g5!? 16.♗xg5 ♕xg5 17.♕c7 ♗c8 the white queen gets really annoying and White can shake off the slight pressure with 18.♖fe1 ♗h3 19.♗f1±. But this move is still untested. **14...f5** The logical follow-up of ...♗b7. 14...♕b6?! (it doesn't seem logical to allow the pin) 15.♘c2 ♗f6 16.f4!± (intending 17.♕f2 or 17.fxe5 and 18.♕f2 16...exf4? 17.♖xf4 ♗e5 18.♕f2+–; 14...♗f6 transposes to 13...♗f6. **15.♗xd4** With the queen on d2, far away from the control of the light squares, this is far less convincing than it was against 13...f5 and the theoretical battle is open for the next few moves. 15.f3!? is a solid alternative. **15...exd4 16.♘c2** and Black has tried all logical moves to face the threat of the capture on d4:

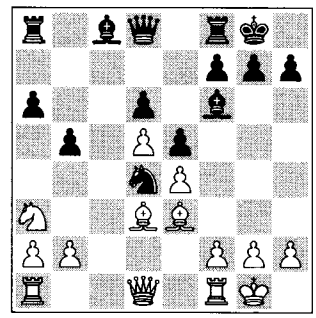


A) **16...♗f6!?** is the most logical, but 17.♘b4! (17.♖ae1!? is a suggestion by Finkel: 17...♖c8 18.f4 fxe4 19.♗xe4 ♕b6 20.♕d3 g6 (20...♖xc2? 21.♗xh7+ ♔h8 22.♕h3+–) 21.♔h1±. Finkel's assessment of this position is a slight edge for White and he must be right because, after 21...♖f7, our suggestion in the first edition of this work, White can play 22.♘b4! ♕c5 23.♘c6 and White is better) 17...♕a5 18.a3 ♖ae8 (18...♖ac8 is more disturbing for White's plan: 19.♖ae1± followed by exf5) 19.♕c2! f4 20.e5 (20.♘c6!?±) 20...♗xe5 21.♗xh7+ ♔h8 22.♗g6 ♖e7 23.♕d3± Bologan-Degraeve, France tt 2001.

B) **16...♗g5?!** I don't think provoking f2-f4 favours Black. Moreover, the white queen may improve her position when retreating: 17.f4 (17.♕b4! ♗f6 18.exf5!± followed by ♘xd4 and then the white knight may jump to c6 or e6) 17...♗f6 (Simic-Pavasovic, Bled 1995) 18.♖ae1 fxe4 19.♗xe4 ♕b6 20.♕d3± g6? 21.♗xg6!+–.

C) **16...♕b6** and now Bologan suggests a simple treatment based on 17.exf5! ♗xd5 18.♖ae1 ♗f6 (18...♖ae8 19.♘b4! ♗b7 20.♗e4±) 19.♗e4± which looks more clear than the previous games.

○ 13...♗f6



Provides the knight with extra support and neutralizes the positional threat 14.f4, but forgoes an eventual ...f5. White must continue with his standard plan and, just exchanging off the knight, he has a slight initiative. **14.♕d2!** Intending ♘c2. **14...♗d7** 14...g6 has given Fedorov good results, but does not prevent White's simple plan: 15.♘c2!? ♗d7 16.♖ac1 ♗g7 17.♘xd4 exd4

18.♗f4±; 14...♗b7 (Ganguly-Bitansky, Canberra 2008) and now 15.f4 ♖c8 16.fxe5 dxe5 17.♘c2 with the usual slight advantage. **15.♖ac1** 15.♘c2!? ♘xc2 16.♗xc2 ♖c8 17.a4±, but maybe Black shouldn't hurry to trade knights. **15...♕b8** 15...♖c8 16.♖xc8 ♕xc8 17.♖c1 ♕b7 18.♕b4 ♕b8 19.♕a5± Stripunsky-Votava, Mlada Boleslav Open 1995. **16.f4! ♕b6 17.♕f2±** followed by fxe5 and ♘c2.

O 13...f5?! This is the most enterprising move, but it has lost popular support in recent years. **14.♗xd4 exd4 15.♘c2! ♗f6** 15...fxe4 16.♗xe4 ♗f6 17.♘xd4±; 15...♕b6 16.exf5 ♕c5 17.♕f3 ♗b7 18.♗e4 ♗f6 19.♘e1!± Bratovic-Shaw, Bled ol 2002. **16.exf5 ♗b7 17.♕f3** 17.♘b4! ♖c8 18.♕b3± and then ♘c6, looks very strong. **17...♖c8 18.a4±** Feigin-Moiseenko, Kharkov 1997. And now, instead of the text move 18...♕b6, Feigin suggests for Black 18...♖c5, but White has a clear advantage after 19.♘b4 a5 20.♘c6! ♗xc6 21.dxc6 bxa4 22.♖fc1±.

14.♕d2!

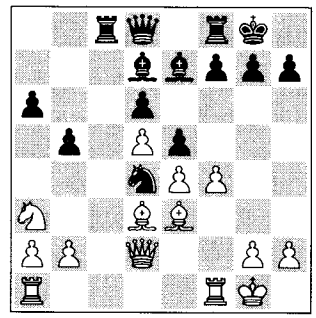
14.♘c2 ♘xc2 15.♗xc2 ♗g5!= Fier-Gullaksen, Barcelona 2008.

14...♖c8

Andrianov and Nikolaidis recommend **14...♕b8** with the idea of ...♗d8-b6, but this is artificial and doesn't look sufficient: 15.f4! (15.♖ae1 is less clear on account of 15...♗d8 16.♗xd4 exd4 17.♘c2 ♗b6!∞; 17...♗f6 18.f4 a5 19.♕f2± as Black can't defend the pawn due to e4-e5, Zeziulkin-Moroz, Lubniewice tt 1994) 15...♗d8 (Tirard-Pap, Timisoara 2005) 16.fxe5 dxe5 17.♘c2 ♘xc2 18.♕xc2 ♗b6 19.♗xb6 ♕xb6+ 20.♕f2 ♕xf2+ 21.♔xf2 ♖ac8 22.♖ac1± and the passed pawn, together with the bad position of the black queenside pawns, guarantees White a comfortable endgame.

15.f4

Finally White starts fighting against the d4 knight, the pride of Black's position.



15...♕b6

15...♗f6 16.♕f2± followed by ♖ac1 and ♘c2; **15...♕c7** 16.♖ac1 (16.f5±) 16...♕b6 17.♘c2±

16.♘c2 ♗f6 17.fxe5!

Andrianov and Nikolaidis criticize this move, but it looks better than their suggestion, 17.♘xd4.

17...dxe5 18.♘xd4 exd4 19.♗f4 ♖ce8!

19...♖fe8? 20.♕f2!!+−.

20.♖ac1 ♗e5 21.b4?!

After 21.♗xe5! ♖xe5 22.♕b4± White has good prospects too.

21...♕d6 22.♗xe5 ♖xe5 23.♕f4 f6 24.a3 h6! 25.♕f2 ♖h5 26.g3 ♖g5 27.♕f4! ♖e5 28.♖c2 a5

28...f5!? 29.exf5 ♖xd5 (29...♗xf5? 30.♖e2+−) is interesting, but White keeps a slightly better endgame with

30.♗e4 ♖e5 31.♖c5 ♖fe8 32.♗c2 ♕f6 33.♕xd4 ♖xf5 34.♕xf6 ♖xf6 35.♖xf6 gxf6 36.♔f2±.

29.bxa5 29.♖c5± **29...♕xa3 30.♕d2 f5!?**

30...♖a8!? should suffice for a draw: 31.♖a2 ♕c3 32.♕xc3 dxc3 33.♖b1 f5! 34.♗xb5 ♗xb5 35.♖xb5 fxe4∞.

31.♖a2 ♕c3 32.exf5 ♖e3?

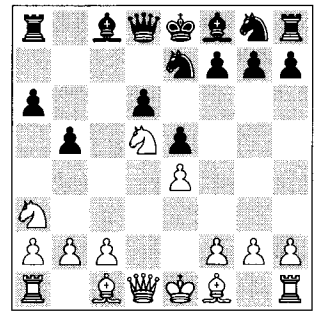
Black can no longer stand the pressure and falls into a bad endgame. He could have got very interesting counterplay with 32...♗xf5! 33.♕xc3 dxc3 34.♖af2 ♗xd3! 35.♖xf8+ ♔h7 36.♖c1! (36.d6? ♗xf1 37.d7 ♖d5 38.d8♕ ♖xd8 39.♖xd8 c2 40.♖c8 ♗c4−+) 36...b4∞ as Andrianov and Nikolaidis suggest.

33.♕xc3 dxc3 34.♗c2± b4 35.d6 ♗b5 36.♖f4! ♖e1+□ 37.♔g2 ♖e2+ 38.♔f3 ♖xc2 39.♖xc2 ♗d3 40.♖c1 b3 41.♖xc3 b2 42.♖b4 b1♕ 43.♖xb1 ♗xb1 44.g4+− ♖d8 45.♖c6 ♖e8 46.♖b6! ♗e4+ 47.♔f4 ♗h1 48.♖b1! ♗d5 49.♖d1 ♗c6 50.♖c1 ♖e4+ 51.♔g3 ♗b5 52.♖c5 ♗a4 53.♖c8+ ♔f7 54.a6 ♖e8 55.♖xe8 ♔xe8 56.♔f4 ♔d7 57.a7 ♗c6 58.♔e5 ♗f3 59.h4 ♗c6 60.g5 hxg5 61.hxg5 ♗f3 62.g6 1-0

Game 7.03

Feigin,Mikhail
Ivanov,Vladimir
Kharkov 1997

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 e5 5.♘b5 d6 6.♘1c3 a6 7.♘a3 b5 8.♘d5 ♘ce7



The trendy line. Black wants to exchange on d5 and deploy his second knight to the most convenient spot.

9.♗g5!

This is my recommendation. This move hampers Black's development, but involves a piece sacrifice. The usual line is 9.c4, but Black is better prepared against this move with his knight on g8.

9...h6

This forces a piece sacrifice, which has had good write-ups, but, up to this moment, very bad results.

O 9...f6!? is an ugly move that weakens the e6-square and consequently the whole a2-g8 diagonal, but its refutation is not clear: **10.♗e3 ♖b8!** 10...♘xd5?! is more frequent but also weaker: 11.♕xd5 ♖b8 and now 12.♕b3! intending ♗c4, is an important improvement: 12...♗b7 13.♗d3 d5 14.0-0-0±. **11.c4** 11.♗e2 ♘xd5 12.♕xd5± because of the weakness of the light squares. **11...♘xd5 12.cxd5!** White gets a far better position than in the main line, 9.c4 **12...f5** and now:

A) **13.exf5** ♗xf5 14.♗d3 ♗xd3 15.♕xd3 ♗e7 16.0-0 ♘f6 (Kurenkov-Yagupov, Moscow 2004) and now there is no excuse not to play 17.♘c2!±.

B) **13.♘c2!** looks very strong, speeding the white knight towards c6. 13...fxe4 (13...f4?! 14.♗d2±) 14.♘b4 ♘e7! (14...♗d7 15.♗e2 ♕a5 16.a3 ♘f6 17.0-0 ♗e7 18.♖c1± followed by ♘c6) 15.♗e2 a5 16.♘c6 ♘xc6 17.dxc6 d5 18.c7 ♕xc7 19.♕xd5 ♗b4+ 20.♔f1±.

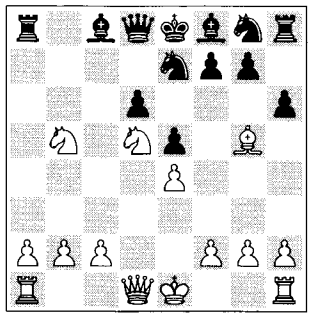
O 9...♕a5+ 10.♗d2 ♕d8 11.c4± improves the position of the main line thanks to the gift of ♗d2.

O 9...♖b8!? 10.c4! b4?! (10...h6 11.♗e3 ♘xd5 12.cxd5 ♘f6 13.f3± is again somewhat better than the 9.c4 line) 11.♘c2 a5 12.♗d3 h6 13.♗d2 ♘xd5 14.cxd5 ♗e7 15.a3!± Timofeev-Sveshnikov, Sochi tt 2008; and this time, comparisons with 9.c4 are out of the question.

10.♗xb5+!?

This is the idea behind 9.♗g5. The resulting positions are purely tactical, and therefore only more practical testing can determine its soundness. However, I think that White's prospects are promising.

10...axb5 11.♘xb5



We have reached the critical position; here Black has tried two different possibilities:

11...♖a7

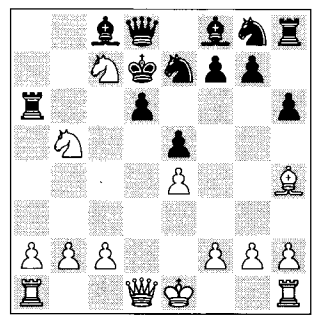
11...♖a6!? appears more often and used to get excellent results until recently. **12.♘dc7+ ♔d7** And now:

A) **13.♗d2** (this recently upset Sveshnikov, but...) **13...♘f6 14.♘xa6 ♗xa6 15.♘xd6** and now:

A1) **15...♔e6?** 16.♕f3 ♔xd6 17.♕a3++− Meister-Sveshnikov, Marianske Lazne 2008.

A2) **15...♕a8!** 16.♗c3 (16.♘xf7 ♕xe4+ 17.♗e3+ ♘ed5 18.♘xh8 ♕xg2 19.♔d2 ♘xe3 20.♔xe3+ ♔c8 21.♔d2 ♘e4+ 22.♔c1 and Black has a draw at least) 16...♘g6! (16...♔e6 17.♗xe5 − 17.f4∞ − 17...♔xe5 18.♘xf7+ ♔e6 19.♘d8+ ♔e5 20.f4+ ♔xf4 21.♕f3+ ♔g5 22.♘f7+ (22.e5 ♗b7! 23.♘xh8+ ♔h7) 22...♔g6 23.♘xh8+ ♔h7 24.♘f7 ♘g6 with a weird material balance. More circumspect seems 17...♘c8) 17.♘xf7+ ♔e6 18.♘xh8 ♕xe4+ 19.♔d2 ♕f4+=.

B) **13.♗h4!**



This is my suggested improvement. Let us see the analysis:

B1) **13...♖c6** Retreating the rook is the most logical and probably the best: 14.♕f3 ♗a6 (14...f5 15.0-0-0 g5 16.♕h5 gxh4 17.♕f7+−) 15.0-0-0 ♗xb5 16.♘xb5 ♕b8 17.♕h3+ f5 18.a4 ♘f6 19.f4 ♕a8 20.b3 ♘xe4 21.fxe5 ♕c8 22.exd6+−.

B2) **13...♖b6** 14.c4 and Black's position is so uncomfortable that perhaps his best move now is a queen sacrifice for the two white knights with 14...♕xc7!? (14...♖xb5 15.♘xb5 ♕a5+ 16.♔f1± ♘g6?? 17.♕g4+ 1-0; Zamarbide-Rebolé, Pamplona 2009), but White can consolidate his position and the black king will be exposed for a long time: 15.♘xc7 ♔xc7 16.b3 ♘c6 17.0-0 ♗e6 18.f3±.

B3) **13...♘f6 14.♕f3**

B31) **14...♘g6** 15.♕h3+ ♔c6 16.♕c3+ ♔d7 17.♗xf6 ♕xf6 18.♘xa6 ♗xa6 19.♕a5 ♗xb5 20.♕xb5+ ♔e7 21.♕b7+ ♔e8 22.g3± and the white rook must be better than the black pieces, thanks to the couple of passed pawns and the unsafe position of the black king;

B32) **14...♖b6** 15.0-0-0 ♘g6 16.♕h3+ ♔c6 17.♕c3+ ♔d7 18.♗xf6 gxf6 19.♕h3+ ♔c6 20.♕b3 ♘f4 21.♕a4 ♗d7 22.c4± with a strong attack.

12.♘xa7

12.♘dc7+?! ♖xc7 13.♘xd6+ but now Black gets too many pieces for his queen: 13...♕xd6 14.♕xd6 ♖c6 15.♕xe5 hxg5∓.

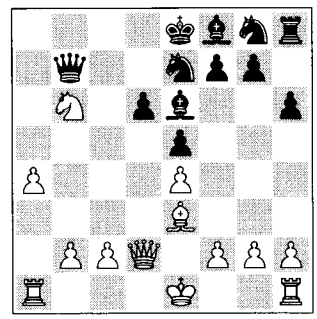
12...♕a5+

Only Feigin and V.I.Ivanov have analysed the logical move 12...hxg5!?: 13.♘xc8 ♕xc8 14.♘e3 (14.a4 ♘xd5 15.♕xd5 ♘f6 16.♕b5+ ♕d7 17.♕b8+ ♕d8=) 14...♘f6 15.♕d3±; or 14...♘c6 15.♕d3 ♘f6 16.c3±; or 14...♕c6 15.♕d3 ♘f6 16.f3 g4 17.♘xg4±, and in all cases the rook and the passed pawns should prevail over the black pieces.

13.♕d2 ♕xa7 14.♗e3 ♕b7 15.♘b6! ♗e6!

It is best to keep the light-squared bishop. 15...♘f6 16.♕xd6 ♘c6 17.♘xc8 ♕xc8 18.♕d3±.

16.a4



16...d5

In *Chess Informant* 69 Feigin and V.I.Ivanov regard this as the only move, but the critical continuation may be: 16...♕xe4!? 17.f3 ♕c6 18.a5 ♘f6 (18...♘c8 19.♕c3! ♕xc3+ 20.bxc3± and it seems that the a-pawn will cost a piece) 19.a6 ♘ed5 20.a7 ♘xb6 21.♗xb6 and the white pawn is finally blocked (21...♕a8±), but on the seventh rank.

17.a5!±

With this brilliant move White just tries to make the most of his trumps, and doesn't mind Black's counterplay.

17...d4

17...dxe4? 18.a6+–.

18.a6 ♕a7 19.♕b4! ♘c6

19...dxe3? 20.♕b5+ ♔d8 21.♖d1++–; 19...f5!? 20.♕b5+ ♔f7 21.♗d2 ♘f6 22.♘c4±.

20.♕b5 ♗b4+

The only way to get some counterplay.

21.c3! ♘e7 22.cxb4

22.♗xd4 exd4 23.cxb4± looks sounder.

22...dxe3 23.fxe3 0-0 24.♕c5 ♘xb4

According to Feigin and Ivanov's analysis, the move that could pose most problems was 24...♖b8! 25.♘d5 ♗xd5 (25...♘xd5 26.exd5 ♗xd5 27.0-0 ♕xc5 28.bxc5 ♘a7 29.♖fd1 ♗c6±) 26.exd5 ♘xd5!, but they underestimated 27.0-0! ♘dxb4 28.♕xa7 ♘xa7± which still brings Black a lot of trouble.

25.♕xb4 ♖b8 26.♕c5 ♖xb6 27.0-0 ♘c8 28.♖fc1!

28.b4!? ♖xa6 29.♕xa7 ♖xa7 30.♖xa7 ♘xa7 31.♖c1 ♘b5 32.♖c5 ♗d7 33.♖xe5 ♔f8 34.♖c5 ♔e7 35.e5±.

28...♔h7 29.b4!

29.♕c7!? ♖xa6 30.♕xa7 ♖xa7 31.♖xa7 ♘xa7 looks a draw.

29...♕a8! 30.a7 ♖b7

And finally Black has managed to eliminate his most dangerous enemy and equalize.

31.b5 ♖xa7= 32.♖xa7 ♘xa7! 33.b6 ♘c8 34.♕c6 ♘xb6!= 35.♕xb6 ♕xe4 36.♕b1 ♕xb1 37.♖xb1 ♗f5 38.♖b5 f6 39.♖b7 h5 40.g3 ♔h6 41.♖f7 ♔g6 42.♖f8 ♗e4 43.♖g8 ♔h7 44.♖c8 ♔g6 45.♖c7 ♔h6 46.h4 g5 47.♖c8 ♔g6 48.♖h8 ♔g7!? 49.♖b8 ♔g6 50.♔f2 gxh4 ½-½

SUMMARY

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cd4 4.♘d4 e5 5.♘b5 d6 6.♘1c3 a6 7.♘a3 b5 8.♘d5

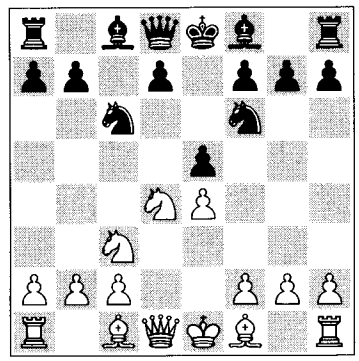
- 8...♘f6: White is not forced to transpose to the Pelikan and it is not enough to equalize ±
- 8...♗e7: comfortable for White, but solid ±
- 8...♘ge7: Black players have struggled a lot in this line, but they haven't managed to neutralize White's positional advantage after 9.c4 ±

8...♘ce7 9.♗g5!? and now:

- 9...f6!?: weakens the diagonal but, even so, ...f5 is playable ±
- 9...♖b8: solid and hard to crack, but comfortable for White ±

CHAPTER 8

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e5
Pelikan Variation



Evaluation *****

Introduction

The Pelikan Variation has become one of the most popular of Sicilian variations. In spite of its anti-positional appearance, it is very appealing to players of all levels, due to the activity achieved by the black pieces. Perhaps its only drawback, from a practical point of view, is that a white player with some theoretical knowledge has several options to play for a draw. Up to this moment, all refutation attempts have been to no avail, and the trendy variations have been shifting.

My suggestion in this book is one of the main lines and has been used in some of the most important theoretical battles in recent years. Even though I cannot guarantee a tangible edge for White in all variations, it is true that the constant theoretical research has confined black players to one variation, that constitutes an ever more besieged fortress. This line offers White, at least, rich play full of possibilities, which is what has led me to choose it.

Nowadays, the main theoretical battle takes place in the more positional 9.♘d5 variation, but the spirit of this book demanded more concrete lines.

History

The set-up starting with 5...e5 was already used in the 19th century by Mieses and Lasker, but it didn't achieve popularity then. The Czech player Jiri (Jorge) Pelikan, a naturalized Argentinean, used it in the 1950s but, in spite of his success, it still looked anti-positional.

It was only in the 1970s, when Sveshnikov started to play the modern variation, including 8...b5, that the Pelikan acquired the respect of top-class players. Suddenly, there emerged the debate whether the misplaced knight

on the a3-square was more important or not than the weakness of the d5-square. Eventually, the good results achieved by black players gave it a definite push. From then on, its popularity has never stopped growing and nowadays, virtually all the top players use the Pelikan, although some of them, such as Kramnik and, more recently, Leko, have been more persevering in its defence.

Curiously enough, the variation has not appeared in World Championship matches yet, perhaps because its tactical nature allows dangerous home preparation.

Ideas

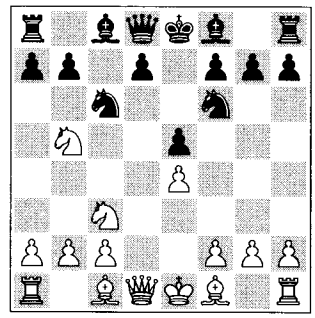
The basic idea, as we have briefly mentioned, involves active piece play, thanks to the central influence achieved through the move ...e5, which should compensate for the weakness of the d5-square. However, in the main line, there are some more concrete typical ideas: the a3 knight is misplaced for some time, and many games are decided by its inability to get into play or, on the contrary, shift to White's advantage when the knight gets to the centre and takes control of the important square d5.

The bishop pair gives Black active play and pawn offers help open the game; another important factor in the middlegame may be the central pawn majority that arises after the exchange on f6. White's plans usually involve the control of the d5-square and we can see many games where Black gets squeezed, once the white pieces occupy the ideal outposts. In some variations, the f5-square may also be used to set up a blockade.

Game 8.01

Hector,Jonny
Karlsson,Lars
Umea ch-SWE 2003

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e5 6.♘db5



This is the position we will study in this chapter. Black generally plays 6...d6, the move examined in the following games, but there are some alternatives deserving attention:

6...h6!?

An underestimated move which has some virtues. Ulf Andersson has used it in several tournament games and thousands of Internet games. Of course, the resulting queenless positions are not to everybody's taste, but this may be an interesting additional weapon for those who like going straight to the endgame. Other possibilities:

O 6...a6?! In comparison with the line chosen in the main game, leaving the g5-square unguarded proves a serious drawback: 7.♘d6+ ♗xd6 8.♕xd6 ♕e7 9.♕xe7+ ♘xe7 (9...♔xe7? 10.♗g5+−) 10.♗g5± b5 (relatively best: 10...♘c6?! 11.♗xf6 gxf6 12.♘d5 ♔d8 13.0-0-0+− Gag Poh Teo-Phillips, cr 1999) 11.0-0-0 ♗b7 12.f3 0-0-0 13.♖d6 ♘fg8 14.♗e2 ♔c7 15.♖hd1 f6 16.♗e3 ♘c8 17.♖6d2

♘ge7 18.a4± Espineira Gonzalez-Vidal del Rio, Santiago jr 2002.

O 6...♗b4 Somewhat sounder than the previous alternative: 7.♘d6+ (7.a3 ♗xc3+ 8.♘xc3± is a simple way to a minimal edge) 7...♗xd6 (the most frequent reply, but not the most logical in my view. After 7...♔e7!? 8.♘xc8+ – 8.♘f5+ ♔f8 9.♗d2 d5∞ is not so clear – 8...♖xc8 9.♗d3 d5 10.exd5 ♕xd5 11.0-0 ♗xc3 12.bxc3 ♖hd8 13.♗a3+± the bishop pair, together with the uncomfortable position of the black king, offers better prospects for White, even though Black also has some assets, Kudrin-Murey, New York 1983) 8.♕xd6 ♕a5 (8...♕e7) 9.♗d2 ♕b6 10.♗d3 ♖b8?! (10...♕xb2?? is not possible due to 11.♖b1+–; 10...♕b4 11.♘b5±) 11.♘d5! ♘xd5 12.exd5 ♕xb2 13.0-0 ♕d4 14.♗e3 ♕b2 15.dxc6+– Tirabassi-Fortini, cr 1997.

O 6...♗c5 is weird, but not so easy to refute: 7.♗e3 and now:

A) 7...♗xe3?! 8.♘d6+ ♔f8 9.fxe3 ♕b6 10.♕d2 ♕xb2 11.♖b1 ♕a3 12.♗c4 ♘a5 13.♗xf7 ♔e7 14.♘cb5 ♕c5 15.♗b3 (15.♕xa5+–) 15...♘xe4 16.♘xe4 ♕xb5 17.♕d6+ ♔d8 18.♘g5 ♔e8 19.♗f7+ 1-0 Roeberg-Loidl, Aschach 2000.

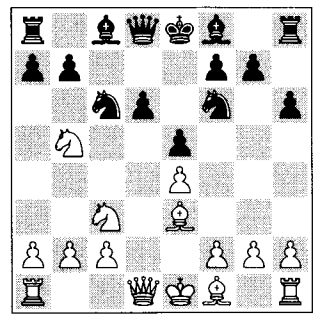
B) 7...d6 8.♗xc5 dxc5 9.♕xd8+ ♔xd8 10.0-0-0+ ♔e7 11.♘c7 ♖b8 12.♘7d5+ ♘xd5 13.♘xd5+ ♔f8, Dochev-Lindgren, Umel 1997, and White has just a minimal edge in the endgame.

7.♗e3!

Waiting for Black to play ...a6 before the check, or ...d6 before jumping to d5 with the knight. 7.♘d5 ♘xd5 8.exd5 a6! 9.dxc6 axb5= and Black gets really active; 7.♘d6+ ♗xd6 8.♕xd6 ♕e7 9.♘b5 ♖b8!∞.

7...d6

7...a6? creates too many weaknesses on the dark squares: 8.♘d6+ ♗xd6 9.♕xd6 ♕e7 10.♗c5!±.



8.a4

8.♘d5!? is a promising alternative, as ♗e3 must be more useful than ...h6 if we compare the similar variation: 6...d6 7.♘d5. However, it leads to some strange positions which require a more detailed analysis: 8...♘xd5 9.exd5 ♘e7 (9...♘b8 10.c4 a6 11.♕a4±) 10.c3 ♘f5 (10...♘g6?! 11.♕a4 ♗d7 12.♕b4±) 11.♗xa7 ♗d7 (Fier-Lucena, Dois Irmaos 2008) and now my suggestion is 12.♗d3 b6 13.♕a4 g6 (13...♗e7? 14.♗xf5!) 14.♕a6 ♗g7 15.g4! and it turns out that the adventures of the white pieces have a happy ending.

8...a6

Expelling the knight is necessary, even though the weakness on the b6-square is serious.

O 8...♗e7 9.♘d5! (now that the knight cannot retreat to e7) 9...♘xd5 10.exd5 ♘b8 11.a5±;

O 8...♗e6 9.♘d5± and Black has to give up his bishop.

9.♘a3 ♗e6 10.♘c4!

A classical manoeuvre to recycle the bad knight to the d5-square, this time via b6.

10...♗e7

10...♘xe4!? is very close to equality and may be the best: 11.♘xe4 d5 12.♘b6 dxe4 (12...♖b8 13.♘c5!±) 13.♘xa8 ♕xa8 14.c3 ♗e7± A.Ivanov-L.B.Hansen, Gausdal 1991; with certain compensation for the exchange.

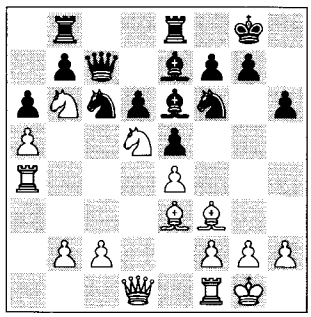
11.♘b6 ♖b8 12.♗e2 ♘b4

Black struggles to play ...d5. 12...0-0 13.♘bd5 ♗xd5 14.exd5 ♘b4 15.a5± (S.Farago-Tomcsanyi, Hungary tt 1997/98) leaves White with a classical space advantage on the queenside and the black knight somewhat exposed.

13.♗f3!

Preventing ...d5.

13...0-0 14.a5 ♕c7 15.0-0 ♖fe8 16.♖a4 ♘c6 17.♘cd5±



White has consolidated his advantage, taking control of the strong points.

17...♕d8 18.♘c4 ♗f8?! 19.♗b6!

Now Black is forced to accept the destruction of his pawn formation.

19...♕d7 20.♘xf6+ gxf6 21.♘e3

Strengthening the grip on the key squares d5 and f5.

21...♘e7 22.♖a3 ♘c8 23.♗g4! ♘xb6 24.axb6 ♗g7 25.♗f5

White follows step by step his plan of dominating the light squares.

25...♔f8 26.♖d3 ♖bd8 27.♘c4?!

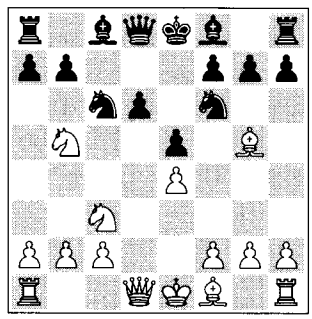
27.c4! ♕c6 28.♕b3+− with total domination.

27...♕c6 28.♖xd6 ♗xc4 29.♖xc6? 29.♖xd8± **29...♖xd1 30.♖xd1 bxc6 31.♖d7 ♖b8 32.b7 ♔g8 33.b3 ♗e6 34.♖c7 ♗xf5 35.exf5 ♗f8∓ 36.♔f1 c5** 36...♔g7!∓ **37.♔e2 e4 38.♔e3 ♗d6 39.♖c8+ ♔g7 40.♖xb8 ♗xb8 41.♔xe4 c4 42.♔d5 cxb3 43.cxb3 ♔f8 44.♔c6 ♔e7 45.b4 ♔d8 46.♔b6 ♔d7 47.♔xa6 ♔c6 48.h3 ♔c7 49.h4 ♔c6 50.g4 1-0**

Game 8.02

Enders,Peter
Sermek,Drazen
Ptuj zt 1995

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 ♘c6 6.♘db5 d6 7.♗f4 e5 8.♗g5



The most popular move. White follows the classical strategy in this structure: to control and occupy the key square, d5.

In order to achieve this goal, White must exchange his dark-square bishop for the enemy knight.

8...a6

Black must immediately expel the enemy knight to avoid trouble. 8...♗e6?! 9.♘d5 ♖c8 (9...♗xd5 10.exd5 ♘e7 11.c3! and the threat ♕a4 poses serious problems for Black, as capturing the pawn is very risky: 11...♘exd5 12.♕a4 ♔e7 13.0-0-0 a6 14.♖xd5 axb5 15.♕xb5± Dutreeuw-Ovezov, Istanbul ol 2000) 10.c3 a6 11.♘a3 ♗xd5 12.♗xf6 gxf6 (12...♕xf6 13.♕xd5 leaves White with a comfortable edge, but maybe that's the least evil) 13.♕xd5 ♕a5 14.♗c4 ♖c7 15.♕xa5 ♘xa5 16.♗d5± Jansa-Danek, Frenstat ch-CSR 1982.

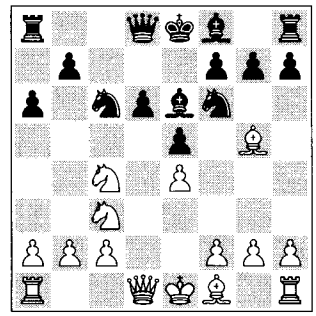
9.♘a3 ♗e6

The drawback of this move is that it allows the stray knight to come back quickly into play. However, Black tries to make good use of the lost tempi to get active piece play, which may compensate for the chronic weakness on d5. White is forced to take this variation very seriously.

O 9...b5 will be examined in the next games.

O 9...d5?! is a radical attempt to solve Black's problems, tested by Velimirovic, but finally abandoned: 10.♘xd5! ♗xa3 11.bxa3 ♕a5+ 12.♕d2! (after the queen swap, the c7-square will be under threat) 12...♕xd2+ 13.♗xd2 ♘xd5?! (13...♖b8 14.f3±) 14.exd5 ♘d4 15.0-0-0 ♗f5 16.c3 ♖c8 17.♔b2+– Sax-Velimirovic, Rio de Janeiro Interzonal 1979. There is no compensation for the pawn.

10.♘c4



The logical reply. The knight leaves its absurd refuge on a3, and comes within two steps of the ideal spot d5.

10...♖c8

The rook gets active quickly and poses some threats along the c-file. Other alternatives are clearly weaker:

O 10...♘d4?! This is premature. Now White's plans will develop almost by force. 11.♗xf6! ♕xf6 (11...gxf6?! creates another weakness on f5: 12.♘e3! ♗g7 13.♗d3 ♖c8 14.0-0 h5 15.♘cd5 h4 16.c3 ♘c6 17.♕f3± and White has a dream position against the Pelikan: absolute control of the key squares d5 and f5, and all pieces working as a coordinated team on the light squares, Hernandez Molina-Ramos, cr Cuba 1990) 12.♘b6 ♖b8 13.♘cd5 ♕d8 14.c3 ♗xd5 (14...♘c6 15.♕a4!±) 15.♘xd5 ♘e6 16.g3 ♗e7 17.a4 0-0 18.♗h3±. White's grip on the light squares is indisputable, Tal-Wade, Reykjavik 1965.

O 10...♗e7?! This leaves the black army in an awkward position after 11.♗xf6 gxf6 12.♘e3± when the dark-squared bishop would rather be on h6.

O 10...b5?! doesn't seem very logical, after having rejected this possibility on the previous move: 11.♗xf6! gxf6 12.♘e3 ♗h6 13.♗d3 ♗xe3 14.fxe3 ♕b6 15.♕f3± Kovacevic-Kosanovic, Bucharest 1997.

11.♘d5!?

This is the move order I recommend. It is not the main line, but I find it sufficiently annoying for Black. The idea is to postpone the exchange on f6 until Black has already exchanged his bishop for the d5 knight. In all cases White gets absolute control of the d5-square and Black needs to seek reactions based on tactical themes.

11...♗xd5

Black cannot do without this move. 11...b5 12.♗xf6 gxf6 13.♘ce3±.

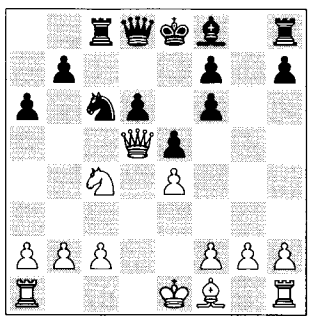
12.♗xf6!

This intermediate exchange is the point of the previous move: now White will capture on d5 with his queen, thus keeping this square under control.

12...gxf6

12...♕xf6 looks sounder but the result is an absolute control of the position for White. Black needs the queen on d8 to set up some tactical play over the next few moves: 13.♕xd5 ♗e7 (13...♘b4? 14.♕xb7 ♘xc2+ 15.♔d1 ♖xc4 16.♗xc4 ♘xa1 17.♗xa6+−) 14.c3 0-0 15.♘b6 ♖c7 16.♗c4±.

13.♕xd5



Here Black has tried a whole set of moves.

13...♘d4

The alternatives are:

O 13...b5 The critical continuation according to some sources. The idea is to speed up tactical actions, in order to exchange the knight or get other compensation. In my view, this is weaker than 12...♘d4, and does not pose problems for White. **14.♘e3** and now:

A) **14...♘e7 15.♕d3! ♗h6 16.♗e2 ♗xe3 17.fxe3** Here Black has also succeeded in exchanging the potential occupant of the holes on d5 and f5, but White still has excellent prospects. The f-file has opened and if Black tries to exchange his backward pawns by means of the standard breaks ...d5 or ...f5, the white bishop will be far stronger than the black knight. **17...d5!?** 17...0-0 18.0-0 ♘g6± and White can choose between attacking the f6 pawn or raiding Black's queenside with 19.a4!? **18.0-0-0 ♕d6?!** Giving the pawn without sufficient compensation. 18...♕c7 19.♗f3 dxe4 20.♗xe4±; 18...♖c5?! 19.♗f3 and Black loses the pawn as well. **19.exd5+−** Korneev-Hernandez Montalvo, Padron 2002.

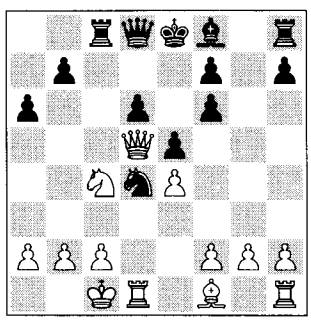
B) **14...♕c7** 15.c3 ♘e7 16.♕d3 ♗h6 17.♘g4 ♗g7 18.♗e2 is completely comfortable for White too, as Black is unable to free his play.

C) **14...♗h6?!** The most frequently-played, but it may not be the best. **15.♘f5! ♘b4** Now there is no choice but to follow the tactical path opened on the previous move, but it leads to a dead end, as proved by the following analysis, basically Blatny's work: 15...♗f8 16.c3+− with an overwhelming positional edge. **16.♘xd6+**

♔d7 16...♔f8 17.♕xf7 mate. **17.♕xf7+** 17.♗xb5+ axb5 18.♕xb5+ ♖c6 19.♘xf7 ♕b6 20.♖d1+ ♔e6 21.♕xb6 ♘xc2+ 22.♔f1 ♖xb6 23.♘xh6+− Simic. **17...♔c6** 17...♔xd6 18.♖d1++−; 17...♕e7 18.♕xe7+ ♔xe7 19.♘xc8++−. **18.♕b7+**+− Smagin-Kharlov, EuroCup 1991.

O 13...♘b4 14.♕d2 d5 15.exd5 ♘xc2+?! (15...♕xd5 is sounder, but leaves White with a slight edge free from complications: 16.♕xd5 ♘xd5 17.0-0-0 ♖d8 18.♗e2 ♗h6+ 19.♔b1 ♔e7 20.♗f3± Rohl Montes-S.Gonzalez, Moscow ol 1994) 16.♕xc2 ♗b4+ 17.♔d1 ♕xd5+ 18.♔c1! 0-0 (18...b5!? is dangerous, but doesn't work: 19.a3! ♗e7 20.♘d6+ ♔d7 21.♘xc8 ♖xc8 22.♗xb5+ ♕xb5 23.♖d1+ ♗d6 24.♖xd6+ ♔xd6 25.♕xc8 ♕f1+ 26.♔c2+− Berndt-Thiel, Germany Bundesliga 1997/98) 19.a3 ♗c5 20.♕d3 ♗d4 21.♔b1 ♖fd8 22.♗e2 ♔f8 23.♘e3 ♕c5 24.♕b3+−. Complications are over and Black hasn't recovered the sacrificed material, Sudakova-Zimina, St Petersburg 2001.

14.0-0-0



The threat is c2-c3 and an exchange sacrifice on d4 is in the air.

14...♕e7

Defending the b7 pawn, in order to trap the white queen with ...♖c5.

O 14...♕d7?! A bit surprising, as the queen can be hit by ♘b6, but White will be forced to give up the exchange, in view of the threat 15...♖c5. **15.♖xd4! exd4 16.♘b6** Black's pawn structure is a kind of joke and offers White a lot of appealing continuations, but it is one thing to have interesting compensation, and a quite different thing to fight for the advantage; for this White needs at least to regain one pawn and to control the eventual breaks on the key squares (d5 and f5). Therefore, this knight jump heading for the d5-square is necessary, though it was possible on the next move. **16...♕g4** The tactical point that saves the rook due to the mating threat on d1. **17.♕xd4 ♕g5+** 17...♖c6 18.♘d5 ♗g7 19.f3 ♕d7 20.♗d3 ♖g8 21.♖e1 ♔f8 22.♕f2 ♕e6 23.g4 h5 24.h3± Mauro-Alderigi, cr Italia 1998. **18.♔b1 ♕c5 19.♕xc5 ♖xc5 20.♘d5±** and White keeps control, as 20...f5? is not possible on account of 21.b4!.

O 14...b5!? The move that poses most problems for White, even though it has not been very deeply investigated: **15.c3! bxc4** 15...♖c5 16.♕b7 bxc4 17.cxd4 ♕c8 18.♕xc8+ ♖xc8 19.♔c2±. **16.cxd4 ♕c7** 16...c3? 17.♗xa6!+−. **17.♔c2!** Not an easy move, but necessary to avoid opening lines. 17.♔b1?! ♗h6! 18.dxe5 c3! 19.bxc3 ♕xc3 20.♕b3 ♕c6 21.exd6 0-0⩲. **17...♗h6** 17...c3 18.b3±; 17...♗g7 18.dxe5 dxe5 19.♕d6±. **18.dxe5 dxe5 19.♕d6 ♕xd6 20.♖xd6 ♔e7 21.♖d5!** 21.♖xa6 ♖hd8⩲ **21...♖hd8 22.♔c3 ♖xd5 23.exd5 f5**

24.♗xc4± Ragger-Lenic, Herceg Novi jr 2006. Black has good drawing chances, though it is not a very pleasant endgame.

15.♔b1!

Setting up the little combination we will see in the next few moves. This continuation, which offers White a very pleasant and risk-free endgame, is my suggestion but, for those who don't like exploiting minimal technical superiorities, there is a radically different approach: 15.♖xd4!? exd4 16.♕xd4 (with a similar position to that in the 14...♕d7 variation) 16...♖c6 17.f4 ♗g7 18.♘e3 0-0⩲ (Ismagambetov-Kuderinov, Astana 2007) and now 19.♗c4 gives White full compensation.

15...♖c5

The only move tried in this position, though it just encourages White to reach the endgame he wants. **15...b5?!** 16.c3± with a far more favourable position than that in the 14...b5 variation, mentioned a few lines above.

15...♖c6?! The natural defence against White's threat. 16.c3 ♘e6 17.g3± and White has complete control of the position.

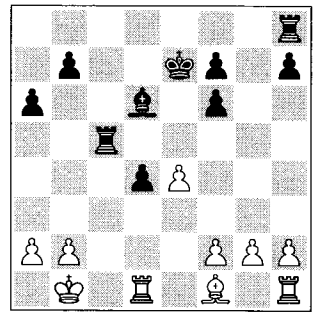
16.♘xd6+

16.♕xd6 leads to the same position; other moves are bad for White.

16...♕xd6 17.♕xd6 ♗xd6 18.c3

White gets the piece back with a clearly better pawn structure. Black's only comfort is the opposite-coloured bishops.

18...♔e7 19.cxd4 exd4



20.♗d3

White has to be content with some positional gains. It is too soon to capture material: 20.♖xd4?! ♖hc8 21.♗e2 (21.♗d3 ♗f4 22.a4 ♖c1+ 23.♖xc1 ♖xc1+ 24.♔a2 ♖d1! 25.♖d5 ♖d2= with enough counterplay) 21...♖c2 22.♗g4 ♖8c6 23.♖f1 ♖xb2+!=; 20.b4?! ♖c3 21.♖xd4 ♖hc8 22.♗e2 ♖c2 23.♗g4 ♖8c6= with some counterplay as well.

20...♖hc8 21.g3

White starts restricting the enemy bishop, taking advantage of his superior pawn structure.

21...h6 22.♖he1 ♖h5 23.h4 ♖hc5 24.♖e2 ♖5c7 25.♗c2±

Now White does threaten the d4 pawn.

25...♗c5 26.e5!?

A slower approach, based on a2-a3, ♖d3 and ♖f3, is perfectly possible too.

26...fxe5 27.♖xe5+ ♔f8 28.♗d3 ♖e8 29.♖d5 a5 30.a3 b6 31.♖f5 ♔g7 32.♔a2

And now the white king can get active through the light squares Black has surrendered on the queenside.

32...♖e6 33.♔b3 ♖f6 34.♖xf6

♔xf6 35.♔a4 ♖e7 36.♗f1 ♖e4 37.♗d3 ♖e7 38.♖c1 ♖e6 39.b4!± axb4 40.axb4 ♗e7 41.♖c7 ♖d6

41...♖e1?! 42.♖d7± and the d-pawn drops.

42.♔b3 ♗d8 43.♖c8 ♔e7 44.♔c4 ♖d7 45.♖b8 ♖d6 46.♗e4 ♔e6 47.f4 ♗f6 48.♔d3 ♗d8 49.b5 ♔e7 50.g4

The black pieces occupy rather passive positions.

50...♔e6 51.g5 hxg5 52.hxg5 ♖d7?

A blunder in a desperate position.

53.♗c6!+– ♖d6 54.♖b7 f5 55.g6 ♗e7 56.g7 ♖d8 57.♖xe7+ 1-0

Game 8.03

Anand,Viswanathan
Lobron,Eric
Dortmund 1996

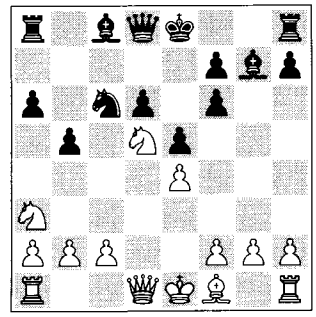
1.e4 c5 2.♘c3 ♘c6 3.♘ge2 ♘f6 4.d4 cxd4 5.♘xd4 e6 6.♘db5 d6 7.♗f4 e5 8.♗g5 a6 9.♘a3 b5!

Sveshnikov's move, which has turned the ...e5 variation, once despised by theory, into one of the most popular Sicilian lines.

10.♗xf6

This move has historically been the main and the most ambitious line, and it is still my recommendation, although the positional line 10.♘d5 is far less risky and has been more popular in recent times.

10...gxf6 11.♘d5 ♗g7



This move enjoyed quite a considerable popularity for more or less a decade, halfway between the 1980s and the 1990s. Nowadays, attention has been completely turned back to 11...f5. Black intends to avoid some lines, among them the violent sacrifices on b5, and get ready to fight for the control of the d5-square, by playing ...♘e7 immediately. Very often, especially in those variations after 12.c3, we can reach a complete transposition to the main line. **11...f5** will be studied in the subsequent games.

O 11...♗e6 is actually the only serious alternative. Black is going to exchange the light-squared bishop for the knight and then drive the white queen off and break on d5. This strategy is dubious because the light-squared bishop is very important. **12.c3** Immediately paving the way for the knight to come to e3. **12...♗g7 13.♘c2 ♗xd5** 13...♘e7?! allows White to consolidate: 14.♘ce3! 0-0 15.♗d3 ♔h8 16.♕f3 ♘g6 17.h4± Suarez Real-Barrio Garcia, Spain tt U20 1996. **14.♕xd5 ♘e7 15.♕d3! f5?!** 15...d5 is somewhat sounder: 16.0-0-0! ♗h6+ 17.♔b1 dxe4 18.♕e2 ♕b6 19.g4!± followed by ♗g2 and ♗e4. **16.exf5 d5 17.g4** Holds onto the extra pawn and makes way to develop the bishop to an ideal diagonal. **17...0-0 18.♗g2 ♕b6 19.0-0 ♖ad8 20.♖ad1**

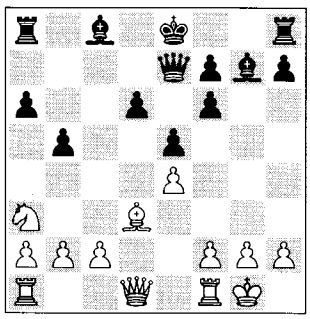
♗h6 21.♕f3± White has an extra pawn and the black centre is under pressure; Thipsay-Saravanan, India 1993.

12.♗d3 ♘e7

The logical follow-up of Black's strategy. The knight swap lessens the weakness on d5. Now Black can play a pawn push on d5 or f5 (sometimes temporarily giving up a pawn) at any time. White's edge is based on the grip on the light squares and in order to consolidate it, the white knight needs a stable central position (sometimes on d5, sometimes on d4 if the black pawn advances).

12...♗e6 is not very flexible and at best will transpose to the main lines, while giving White more options: 13.0-0 ♗xd5 (13...♘e7 14.♘xe7 ♕xe7 transposes to the main line, where ...♗e6 lacks flexibility) 14.exd5 ♘e7 15.c3 (15.♕g4!? is an interesting idea to try to blockade Black's pawn mass: 15...♔f8 16.c4 ♕c8! 17.♕e2 b4 18.♘c2 f5 19.f3±) 15...f5 transposes to the last games in this chapter.

13.♘xe7 ♕xe7 14.0-0



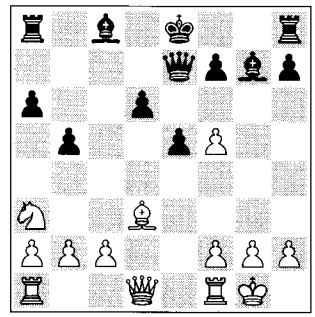
14... f5

14...0-0 will be analysed in the next game.

14...d5!? is a thematic pawn offer that still hasn't received the attention it deserves. **15.c3!** The correct decision, according to Amador Rodriguez. If White grabs the pawn, Black will get long-term compensation which is difficult to assess, since it will depend on the activity of his central pawns and his bishop pair. **15...dxe4** 15...f5 16.exf5± transposes to the note to move 15 and 15...0-0 16.♘c2 f5 17.exf5±. In these two lines Black's pawn centre is more vulnerable to a blockade than in the variations where White captures on d5. **16.♗xe4 ♖b8** More often than not, exchanging light-squared bishops favours White in the Pelikan: 16...♗b7 17.♗xb7 ♕xb7 18.♘c2 f5 (otherwise the blocking piece comes) 19.♘e3± and the knight will get a grip on f5 with the support of the white queen) 17.♕f3!± followed by the manoeuvre ♘c2-e3 and the black pawns are paralyzed, Rodriguez Cespedes-Espinosa, Merida 1997.

15.exf5

This is my recommendation. Both 15.c3 and 15 c4 have a similar value to the text move, but the theory is more developed and thus Black has more chances of confusing matters. Now Black has to make an important decision:



15...♗b7

O 15...0-0 is weak at this moment on account of 16.♗e4 ♖b8 17.c3± and White controls the d5-square.

O 15...d5 The pawns immediately mobilize, but above all Black prevents the blockade. This is the most serious alternative and maybe the move that casts some doubts on the 14.0-0 order. **16.c3 b4** The key move, before the knight can be recycled and the black centre starts to show symptoms of paralysis. 16...0-0 17.♘c2 e4 18.♗e2 ♖d8 19.♘d4 (now Black has to relinquish the bishop pair to regain the pawn) 19...♗xd4 (Psakhis-Dolmatov, Klaipeda 1988) and now 20.♕xd4 ♗xf5 21.a4!± gives White a clear and easy-to-play initiative; 16...♗b7 17.♖e1 e4 18.♘c2 ♗e5 19.♗f1 ♖d8 20.♕h5 ♖g8 21.♖ad1 ♖d6 (Souleidis-Kalinitschew, Senden 1998), and now after 22.♘e3± White is perfectly prepared to meet Black's attack. **17.♘c2** White's queenside pawn structure will get ruined, but the knight has won time to get an excellent position on e3. **17...bxc3 18.bxc3 e4** 18...0-0 19.♘e3 ♗b7 20.♖b1± and the extra pawn must become important. **19.♗e2!** With an eye on d5. **19...♕c5** 19...♗xc3 is critical: 20.♘e3 d4 (20...♗xa1? 21.♕xa1+– and the double threat ♕h8 and ♘xd5, is winning) 21.♘d5 ♕e5 22.♘xc3 dxc3 23.♖c1 0-0 (23...♗xf5?! 24.♕a4+ ♗d7 25.♕b4 and there is no good defence for the c3 pawn) 24.♕b3±. Once the f5 pawn is exchanged for the c3 pawn, White's structure will be more solid and his king's position safer. **20.♘e3 ♗b7 21.♕b3 ♗c6** (Di Berardino-Crosa Coll, Vitoria 2006) and now **22.♖fd1 ♖d8 23.♖ab1 0-0 24.♕b6±**.

16.♖e1 ♕g5?!

Anand regards this move as dubious, but the alternatives at this stage are not enough for Black to equalize, though practical tests are scarce and there is wide scope for research:

O 16...d5 17.c3± transposes to the note to move 15.

O 16...0-0 hasn't been tried despite being the most natural move. Almost everyone has suggested a different refutation, but they haven't reached an agreement. **17.c4** is my suggestion. The idea is not original: as usual, White tries to recycle the knight and at the same time to contain Black's centre. 17.♕g4 seems to be Ftacnik's recommendation, but I don't have more analysis. After 17...d5 18.c3 b4! 19.cxb4 e4⩲, in spite of being two pawns down, I think Black has the typical Pelikan position: unstoppable counterplay; 17.♕h5 e4 18.c3 b4! (again) 19.♘c2 bxc3 20.bxc3 d5∞ and Black has created a new target on c3. **17...e4** 17...bxc4 18.♘xc4. The knight is coming and the obvious reply meets a tactical refutation: 18...d5 19.♘xe5 ♗xe5 20.♕g4+ ♔h8 21.f6 ♗xh2+ 22.♔xh2 ♕xf6 23.♕h5± and Black's structure has as many isolated pawns as there can be. **18.♕g4 ♔h8** 18...♕f6 19.♗xe4 ♗xe4 20.♖xe4 ♕xb2 21.♖b1± apart from the pawn, White seizes the initiative. **19.♗xe4** 19.♖ab1 is possible, but passive. **19...♗xb2** 19...♖fe8?! 20.♖e2! ♗xe4 21.♖ae1±. **20.f6 ♕xf6** 20...♗xf6 21.♗xh7!+–. **21.♗xb7 ♖ab8 22.♖ad1 ♖xb7 23.♘c2±** The knight will get a central outpost and again the structure and the king's safety favour White.

17.g3

Rooting out all threats along the diagonal; now the position of the black pieces allows White to block the enemy central pawns. This situation usually dooms the Pelikan player.

17...0-0

17...d5? fails due to the king's position: 18.f4! ♕e7 19.fxe5 ♗xe5 20.f6!+−.

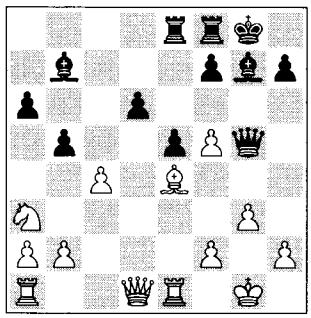
18.c4

Preparing the next move.

18...♖ae8

18...bxc4 19.♘xc4± and here we have evidence that the fact that the queen is not on e7 has terrible consequences for the squares d6 and e5.

19.♗e4!



Forcing Black to trade light-squared bishops, which will lead to a blockade on those squares.

19...♗xe4 20.♖xe4 ♕xf5 21.♕d5± b4 22.♘c2 a5 23.♖d1

It is hard to choose between this move and the other suggestion by Anand: after 23.♘d4!?, 23...♕xe4 may be the reason to have chosen the text move instead, but White's advantage is clear anyway: 24.♕xe4 exd4 25.♕d5± and Black will lose a pawn.

23...♕g6 24.♘e3 24.♖e2± **24...♔h8**

If Black manages to play the break ...f5, half of White's blockade will disappear.

25.♖g4 ♕h5 26.♖h4 ♕g5 27.♕f3!

Preventing ...f5 once again. 27.♕xa5 f5 28.♕xb4 f4 gives Black some counterplay.

27...f5!⇄

Black seizes his only chance: if a white piece occupied the f5-square, Black would inevitably be crushed.

28.♖xd6

28.♖h5 ♕g6 29.♖xf5 e4 30.♕f4+− is another plan.

28...e4

28...f4? 29.♕e4+−.

29.♕d1 f4

Seeking counterplay at all costs, but the white pieces occupy excellent spots and won't be intimidated.

30.♖g4

30.♖h5 ♕e7 31.♘f5 ♖xf5 32.♖xf5 e3 with some counterplay.

30...♕e5 31.gxf4 ♖xf4 32.♖d2 ♖xg4+ 33.♘xg4 ♕g5 34.♔h1 h5??

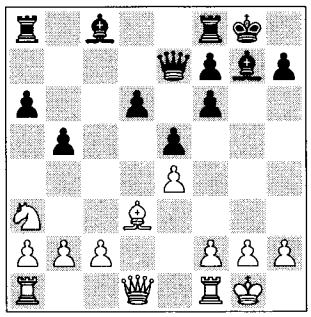
Allowing an ideal combination of pieces on the h5-square. Black could have offered more resistance, but White is a pawn up and his pieces are well placed.

35.♖d5! ♕h4 36.♘f6! 1-0

Game 8.04

Garbisu de Goni,Unai
Gomez Gandara,Emilio
Zamora ch-ESP 1996

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e5 6.♘db5 d6 7.♗g5 a6 8.♘a3 b5 9.♗xf6 gxf6 10.♘d5 ♗g7 11.♗d3 ♘e7 12.♘xe7 ♕xe7 13.0-0 0-0



The most natural move, keeping all options open. However, the experience with this line suggests that Black can't do very much without ...f5, and now White tries to play a very precise move order to pose maximum problems.

14.♕f3

This is my suggestion, although there is not much practical experience with this move. The white queen quickly controls the two key squares (f5 and d5) and Black is forced to act quickly (which involves pawn sacrifices) before the a3 knight finishes its tour and arrives on e3. Of course, 14.c3 is an important and sound alternative for White, and with it the first player could just be content that the move order 13.0-0 and 14.c3 (instead of the more usual 13.c3 and 14.♘c2) has limited Black's choice. Many games have followed this path, with the same ideas as in the variation we will follow, but at this moment the text move seems to me to pose more problems for Black.

14...f5

As we said, Black can hardly do without this, although it is the beginning of a series of pawn offers. There is little experience with other moves, but let's consider the most logical alternatives.

O 14...♕b7 To create doubled pawns on f3 after White captures on f5. 15.c4 (15.c3 f5 16.exf5?! ♕xf3 17.gxf3 ♗b7 18.♗e4 d5∓ would justify Black's idea) 15...f5 (15...bxc4 16.♘xc4± helps recycle the white knight; or 15...b4 16.♘c2) 16.exf5 (16.cxb5 d5! gives strong counterplay) 16...♕xf3 17.gxf3 bxc4 18.♗e4 ♖b8 19.♘xc4 and White has a slight plus thanks to his grip on the key squares, rather than the extra pawn. For example: 19...d5 (19...♖d8 20.♖ad1±; 19...♗b7 20.♖ad1±) 20.♗xd5 ♗xf5 21.♖fe1 ♔h8 22.♖ad1± Timmerman-Lemmens, Enschede 1993.

O 14...d5?! A thematic reaction that fails by inches: 15.exd5 e4 (15...f5?! 16.♗xf5 e4 17.♗xe4 ♗xb2? 18.d6+–) 16.d6! (without this important intermediate move, Black's tactical reaction would succeed) 16...exf3 17.dxe7 ♖e8 18.♗e4 fxg2 19.♖fd1! (this detail is necessary) 19...♖a7 20.♗c6 ♖axe7 21.♗xe8 ♖xe8 22.♔xg2±.

O 14...♗b7 15.c4 ♖fd8 16.♘c2± and the knight immediately gets to e3, when Black's position will be smothered.

O 14...♖b8!? A useful preparatory move. 15.c3 f5 16.exf5 b4 17.♘c4 bxc3 18.bxc3 ♗b7 19.♗e4 d5 20.♗xd5 e4 (Gastanares Lopez-Rahal, San Sebastian Open 1994) and now

21.f6! guarantees a clear edge for White.

15.exf5 d5

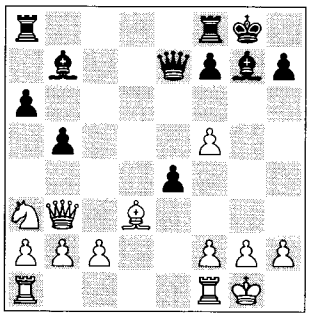
The logical consequence of the previous move. Otherwise, White will play 16.♗e4 and there won't be reaction of any kind.

16.♕xd5 ♗b7 17.♕b3

The white queen is temporarily out of play and the knight still needs some time to activate. But Black has sacrificed two pawns and now his mobile pawn centre isn't so effective, as the d-pawn is missing. If Black can't do something concrete in the next few moves, the enemy queen and knight will come back into play and White will have a solid extra pawn.

17...e4

17...♕g5?! The threat comes first but is not more dangerous, and White's f5 pawn can stay alive: 18.f3 ♖ad8 19.♖ad1 ♕h4 20.c3 ♗h6 21.g3 (pre-empting ...♗f4) 21...♗e3+ 22.♔g2 ♕h5 23.♕c2 ♖d6 24.♗e4+− and there is no longer compensation, Gutierrez-Reinoso, Lima ch-PER jr 2002.



18.♖fe1!

An improvement on the stem game Anand-Kramnik. The idea is to free the f1-square for the bishop, to help organize the defence, and give time for the two stray pieces to come back into play.

18.♗e2 ♕g5 Intending to attack g2 to disrupt the defence along the dark squares. **19.♖ad1 e3 20.f3** This allows Black to carry out the second stage of his plan. 20.g3!? really deserves serious attention, defending the dark squares. Now Kramnik proposes the following variation: 20...♖ae8! (20...exf2+ 21.♖xf2 ♖ad8 22.c3± and compensation seems to be insufficient) 21.♘c4?! (but no-one mentions the natural move 21.c3 ♕xf5 – 21...exf2+ 22.♖xf2 – 22.fxe3 ♕e4 23.♖f3) 21...exf2+ 22.♖xf2 ♖xe2! 23.♖xe2 ♕g4∓. **20...♗e5!⩲ 21.♘c4 ♗f4 22.♖d4 ♗d5 23.♖xf4 ♕xf4 24.♕xe3 ♕xf5 25.♗d3 ♕f6 26.♘b6 ♖ad8 27.♘xd5 ♖xd5 28.♕e4 ♕d4+ 29.♕xd4 ♖xd4 30.♖e1** ½-½ Anand-Kramnik, Wijk aan Zee 1998.

18.♖ae1!? with very different ideas, also looks like an interesting move for further research.

18...♕e5

The logical move, hitting b2, and immediately winning the f5 pawn back. Also worth considering are:

18...♗e5!? 19.♗f1 ♕h4 20.g3 ♕f6 21.c3 ♖fd8!? (21...♖ad8 22.♘c2± – the knight is coming; ...♗d5 doesn't really trouble the queen) 22.♗g2 (22.♘c2?! ♗d5) 22...♕xf5 (22...♖d2? 23.♘c4±) 23.♕c2 (the pressure on e4 gives White a break) 23...♖d3 24.♕e2 and again the knight is ready to be recycled.

18...♕h4!? 19.g3?! (it looks more natural to play 19.♗f1 directly and then g3 only when necessary) 19...♕g4 20.♗e2 (20.♗f1 ♖ad8 21.♘c4 ♕xf5

22.♘e3 ♕f6 23.c3 ♖d2 with great counterplay) 20...♕xf5 21.♖ad1 ♖ad8 22.♕b4 (22.c3?! e3!∓) 22...♖fe8. Black has achieved some counterplay, Rodriguez Lopez-Bernat, Szeged 1996.

19.c3 ♕xf5 20.♗f1

White gets ready to fulfil his dream of getting his knight to e3 or d4. If White succeeds, the game will be almost decided, therefore a critical position has arisen.

20...♖ab8

This prevents ♘c4, but doesn't really oppose the alternative route of the knight. Let us see the alternatives:

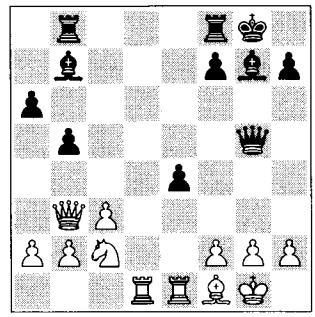
○ 20...♖fd8 21.♘c2 (21.♘c4!?±) 21...♖d2 (21...♗d5?! 22.♘e3!±) 22.♖e2 ♖ad8 23.♘d4!±;

○ 20...♗e5 21.♘c2 ♗d5 22.♕b4 (22.♘e3?? ♕h5−+) 22...♕e6 23.♕c5±;

○ 20...♗d5!? 21.♕b4 a5 (21...♖fd8 22.♘c2 ♗f8 23.♕a5 ♗c5 24.♘e3±) 22.♕xb5 ♖fb8 23.♕e2 a4 24.♖ed1 ♖a5 25.♘c2 (25.g3!±) 25...♖xb2 Smikovsky-Zherebukh, Voronezh 2007.

○ 20...♔h8!? 21.♘c2 ♕h5 22.♖ad1 ♗e5 23.g3 ♖ae8 One of the most dangerous plans. The black pieces are aiming at White's castled position and the break ...f5-f4 is on the way. **24.♖d7!** This causes the enemy bishop to become exposed to the white knight's jump and keeps White alive. 24.c4 f5 25.cxb5 f4 26.bxa6 e3⩲; or 24.a4 f5 25.♗g2 f4⇄ Tamayo Romay-Oussama, Spain tt 2007, are good examples of how easy it is for Black to develop his initiative. **24...♗c6** 24...♗a8 25.♘d4 f5 26.♘e6± **25.♖d2 f5 26.♘b4!** 26.♘d4 ♗a8 27.♘e6 ♖g8 28.f4± ♕h6 29.♘g5 ♕b6+∞. **26...♗b7 27.♕d1±** and it looks as though White's position has been consolidated, but we need more practical examples to reach a reliable assessment: 27...♕h6 28.♘d5 ♖g8 (28...f4? 29.♖xe4!±) 29.♗g2±.

21.♘c2 ♕g5 22.♖ad1±



White is about to finish rearranging his position. The knight can occupy an excellent position on d4 and the rooks are perfectly centralized. Black always has a good bishop pair to make up for the missing pawn.

22...♔h8 23.♖d7 ♕g6 24.♘d4 ♗e5?!

24...b4!? 25.♕xb4 ♗c6 26.♘xc6 ♖xb4 27.♘xb4±.

25.♕b4±

White is seizing the initiative.

25...♗a8 26.♕c5 ♖be8 27.g3 f5 28.♗h3 ♕h5?

A tactical mistake that accelerates his downfall.

29.♘e6!+− f4?!

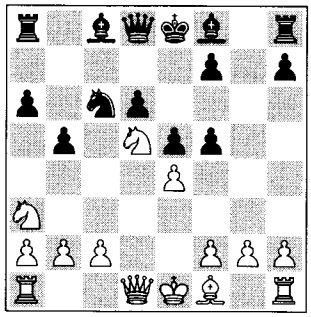
29...♕xh3? 30.♕xe5+; 29...♖f6 was relatively the best: 30.♖e7! ♖xe7 31.♕xe7 ♕f7 32.♕xf7 ♖xf7 33.♖d1+−.

30.♘xf8 ♕xh3 31.♖xh7+ ♕xh7 32.♘xh7 1-0

Game 8.05

De La Villa Garcia,Jesus
Garcia Luque,Agustin
San Roque 1996

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e6 6.♘db5 d6 7.♗f4 e5 8.♗g5 a6 9.♘a3 b5 10.♗xf6 gxf6 11.♘d5 f5



The most natural move, which has given birth to one of the most successful variations in the last 30 years. Black intends to exchange his doubled pawn, to open lines for his dark-squared bishop (which will develop to g7), and above all to undermine the important central white knight.

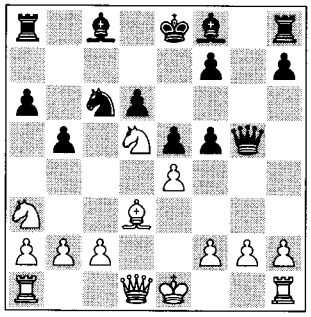
12.♗d3

Finding a more logical and useful move for White than this is very difficult. White develops a piece, threatens exf5 and prevents Black from exchanging on e4, as after 12...fxe4 13.♗xe4 the light-squared bishop would occupy an ideal spot. It is true that it also has some drawbacks: it obstructs the white queen's control of the d5-square.

12...♗e6

Black plays this move in about 98% of games, and it therefore eclipses the rest; however, two alternatives deserve serious attention:

12...♕g5 A speculative move made popular by Javier Ochoa in the 1980s. Computers dismiss this move, but it is not easy to refute over the board and the theoretical recommendations are rather dubious. In short, I think it is a dangerous move if White is not well prepared, and it deserves at least a try.



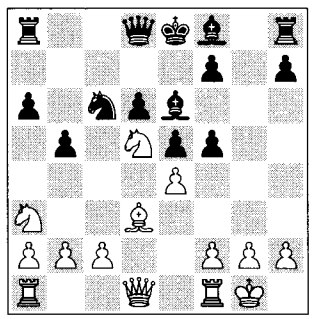
A) **13.g4** This is what theory recommends, but things are far from clear in my view after 13...♔d8 14.gxf5 ♗xf5 15.♘e3 (15.exf5?! ♕g2) 15...♗e6 16.♕d2 ♗h6 17.0-0-0 (17.♗xb5!?) 17...♘d4∞ Lenski-Frilli, cr 1984. This position is full of weaknesses and problems, but the black pieces are really active and therefore I don't think Black's prospects are worse.

B) **13.♘c7+** ♔d8 14.♘xa8 ♕xg2 15.♖f1 ♘d4⩲ has only been tried in the game Vera-Ochoa, Cienfuegos 1977, but Black's compensation seems more than sufficient.

C) **13.exf5!** is the most natural and soundest reply, and now: **13...♖a7** (13...♕xg2?? 14.♘f6+ ♔d8 15.♗e4+−; 13...♔d8 14.♘e3 d5?! 15.♗e4+− Renet-San Marco, Ulm 1984) 14.h4 ♕xg2? (14...♕h6 15.g4±) 15.♘f6+ ♔d8 16.♗e4 ♕g7 17.♘h5 ♕h6 18.♗xc6+− Wendling-Murphy, cr USA 1974-76.

O 12...f4 tries to make White's last move worthless and later to use this advanced pawn to launch an attack on White's castled king. The obvious drawback is that it lifts all pressure from White's centre and thus the first player has a free hand to play with energy. 13.c4! (13.g3 is another good option) 13...♗g7 (13...b4 14.♕a4+–) 14.cxb5 ♘d4 15.bxa6 0-0 16.♘c2. Sometimes it is thematic for Black to give up the whole queenside, but here it doesn't seem justified, since the attack hasn't even started and the enemy knight stays firmly on d5: 16...♘e6 17.b4+– Nunn-Fedorowicz, Reykjavik 1990.

13.0-0



This is my recommendation. It is possible to start with 13.♕h5 and reach the same position after 13...♗g7, but I can't find a way to refute 13...♖g8.

13...♗g7

O 13...♗xd5 is the main line and will be analysed in the next games, but there are other interesting alternatives.

O 13...♘b8!? is Gurgenidze's idea, but has no other supporters. Some sources just ignore it, others regard it as speculative, but no one cares about refuting it, perhaps because it will never become popular in view of its appearance. 14.c4 ♗xd5 15.cxd5 (15.exd5 e4!∞) 15...♘d7 (15...fxe4 16.♗xe4± is not logical, because White takes control of the f5-square) 16.exf5 ♗h6 (played in the original game R. Byrne-Gurgenidze. Pre-empting White's next move with 16...♕h4 is worth considering) 17.♕h5 (overprotects the extra pawn, prevents an active move such as ♕h4 and intends to bring the knight over. 17.♘c2 ♕h4 18.g3 ♖g8 19.♔h1 ♕h3 20.a4 ♖g4!∞ R. Byrne-Gurgenidze, Harare 1983) 17...♕f6 18.♘c2 0-0 19.♘e3± Gerundino-Pantaleoni, Italy cr 1987.

O 13...f4?! is very comfortable for White, as it leaves him a free hand in the centre. **14.c4!** and now:

A) **14...b4?** 15.♕a4+–;

B) **14...♗xd5?!** 15.cxb5!±;

C) **14...♘d4** 15.cxb5 f3 16.g3 ♗xd5 17.exd5 ♕d7 18.♖e1 and the black attack has turned out to be premature: 18...axb5 19.♘c2 ♘xc2 20.♕xc2± Sitnikova-Meshki, Kapsukas 1978;

D) **14...♖g8** The most dangerous move. Black can quickly pose threats against the white castled position. **15.cxb5! ♗h3 16.g3** White shouldn't fear an exchange sacrifice, as the light squares will remain totally under control and the d5 knight will become the real master of the game. **16...♘d4 17.♘c2 ♘xb5 18.♖e1 ♗g4 19.♗e2 ♗d7 20.a4 ♘c7 21.♘cb4 ♘xd5 22.♘xd5 fxg3 23.hxg3±** Black's threats have been stopped and the problems in his position remain, Dvoiris-Jiri Nun, Polanica Zdroj 1989;

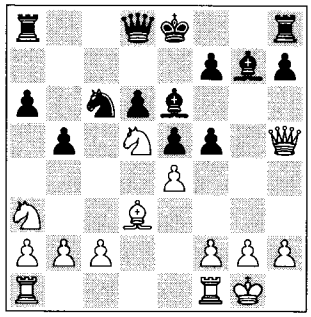
E) **14...♗g7** 15.cxb5 ♘d4 16.bxa6 0-0 As very often in the Pelikan, Black has given up his queenside in order to launch an attack in the centre and on

the kingside starting with ...f5, but his active operations are too slow: 17.♘b5 ♘xb5 18.♗xb5 f5 19.♖c1 (threatening 20.♘c7) 19...♖a7 20.♖c6 (threatening 21.♖xd6) 20...♔h8 21.♘c3 fxe4 22.♖xd6 ♕g5 23.♘xe4+− and there is no compensation at all, Kotronias-Krisafis, Korintos 1998.

O 13...♖g8!? With similar ideas to the previous line. 14.c4 b4 (14...f4 transposes to 13...f4 15.cxb5) 15.♘c2 (15.♕a4 ♗d7!∞) 15...a5 (15...f4 16.♘cxb4±) 16.exf5 ♗xd5 17.cxd5±.

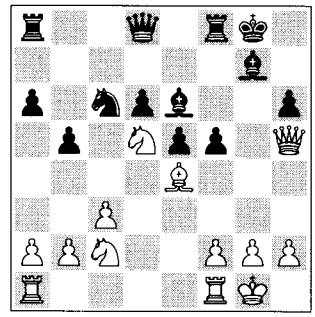
14.♕h5!

White shifts to the classical variation only when the black bishop is already on g7. From h5 the queen exerts strong pressure and almost forces Black to close the centre with ...f4.



14...f4

O 14...h6 15.c3 We keep this move as the main line, though maybe 15.c4!? is even more promising. For example: 15...♗xd5 16.exd5 ♘d4 17.♗xf5 ♕g5 18.♕xg5 hxg5 19.♗d3 f5 (19...e4 is critical: 20.♗xe4 ♘e2+ 21.♔h1 ♗xb2 22.♖ae1 ♘c3 23.♘c2 ♔f8 24.♗d3±) 20.cxb5 (20.f3!±) 20...e4 21.♗c4 ♗e5 22.h3 ♔e7⩲ Karjakin-Milanovic, playchess.com 2004. **15...0-0 16.♘c2** The white knight's tour is about to finish. **16...fxe4?!** This move allows White to take strategic control of the position, because the later push ...f5 fails tactically. The most logical would be to prevent the white knight from getting to e3 by means of 16...f4!? but when the central tension is relieved, White has a free hand to play 17.a4! and Black's queenside collapses: 17...bxa4 18.♖xa4 a5 19.♗c4±. **17.♗xe4 f5?!** This fails, but is consistent with the previous moves. If 17...♖c8 18.♘ce3!± with full control, as we already know.



18.♘f4!± ♗d7?! 18...exf4 19.♗xc6 ♖c8 20.♖fe1 ♗c4 21.♘b4± and White takes control of d5. **19.♗d5+ ♔h7 20.♕g6+ ♔h8 21.♘h5+−** The white pieces have slipped through all the holes and Black loses material. **21...♕e7 22.♘b4 ♘xb4 23.♗xa8 ♖g8 24.cxb4** Spassky-Sveshnikov, Moscow ch-URS 1973.

O 14...0-0? is losing, but it still occurs in 34 games in my database: 15.exf5! ♗xd5 16.f6 e4 17.fxg7 ♖e8 (17...♔xg7 18.♕xd5 exd3 19.♕xc6+−) 18.♕xd5 ♘b4 19.♕b3+−.

O 14...♖c8 A rather unexplored and very natural move. Black tries to play a more useful move than White's before closing the position with ...f4. **15.c3!** And White forgets about c2-c4 to reduce the effec-

tiveness of ...♖c5. 15.♖fd1 f4∞; 15.c4 fxe4 16.♗xe4 ♘d4∞. **15...h6** 15...0-0? 16.exf5+– still gives an edge; 15...f4 16.♘c2 0-0 17.a4±. **16.♘c2 fxe4** 16...0-0 17.♘ce3±; 16...f4 17.a4±. **17.♗xe4 ♘e7 18.♘ce3±** and White has achieved the classical overwhelming control over d5 and f5. Gullaksen-Selmer, cr Norway 1990.

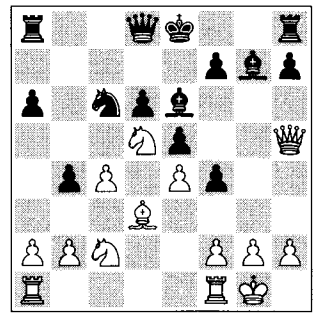
15.c4 b4?!

Closing the queenside seems logical, in order to hold on and later launch an offensive with ...f5, but actually this causes Black to fall into a very passive position, due to the extra support received by the d5 knight. White can choose among many promising plans: he can play on the queenside with b2-b3 and a2-a3, on the kingside with g2-g3, ♔h1 and the g-file, or use the manoeuvre ♘e1-f3-h4 to increase his control of the light squares. This set-up has lost its attractiveness at the top level, but is a logical choice at lower levels, as it restricts the amount of theory and leads to a double-edged fight.

O 15...0-0 is a speculative line, which has failed to achieve the desired respect, but is nevertheless dangerous: **16.cxb5 ♘d4 17.♘c2** It is important to get rid of that dangerous knight. Instead, 17.bxa6 ♗xd5 18.exd5 f5 leaves the initiative in Black's hands. **17...♘xb5?** Somewhat better is 17...♘xc2 18.♗xc2 axb5 but again White gets control with 19.♖fd1± or 19.♗b3±. **18.a4 ♘a7** 18...♘c7?! 19.♘cb4 ♗d7 20.♘xc7 ♕xc7 21.♘d5 ♕d8 22.b4± Prandstetter-Neckar, Ostrava ch-CSR 1976. **19.a5 ♘c6 20.♘cb4! ♘xa5** Or 20...♘xb4 21.♘xb4 ♕c8 22.♘d5 ♗xd5 23.exd5 f5 24.♖fc1 ♕d7 25.♖c6±. Black has some counterplay, but not enough.

O 15...bxc4, the main line, will be analysed in Games 8.06 and 8.07.

16.♘c2



16...a5

The other way to defend the pawn leads to similar positions.

O 16...♖b8 has pros and cons. The main advantage over ...a5 is the extra possibility ...b3. The drawback is that, if White doesn't act quickly on the queenside, the rook will become a mere defender of the b4 pawn. **17.b3** The simplest reply, once it is seen that an immediate 16.a3 b3 is not clear for White. White fixes the b4-pawn and keeps all plans open. Of course, alternative moves such as 16.♖fd1!?, or even 16.g3 (regarded by Sveshnikov as premature), have also achieved good results. And now:

A) **17...a5** is almost a transposition to the main game: 18.♖ad1 0-0 19.g3! The beginning of the thematic plan: by opening this file, White will get good attacking chances. 19...♕d7 20.f3 fxg3 21.hxg3 (21.♘ce3!?) 21...f5 22.exf5 ♗xf5 23.♗xf5 ♖xf5 24.♕g4±. The strong d5 knight is a sharp contrast to the clumsy g7 bishop.

B) **17...h6** 18.♖ad1 (this move appears again in the plan we recommend. The pressure along the d-file is really

effective, in spite of the presence of many pieces there. The rook also leaves the long diagonal and strengthens the g2-g3 plan) 18...a5 19.g3 ♕g5 20.♗e2 (avoiding concessions on the light squares and setting up threats on d6) 20...0-0 21.♔h1 (White gets ready to open the g-file and thus more or less forces the queen swap) 21...♕xh5 22.♗xh5 f5?! 23.♘c7 ♗f7 (the light-squared bishop's swap is a success for White. A further point is that the black pawns are really vulnerable and the g7 bishop won't see the long diagonal opened) 24.♗xf7+ ♖xf7 25.♘b5 fxe4 26.♘xd6 ♖d7 27.♘xe4 ♖bd8±. There are still some technical difficulties to sort out, due to Black's control of the d-file, but White's edge is unquestionable.

C) **17...0-0** 18.♖ad1 (White sticks to the plan no matter what Black plays) 18...♔h8 19.g3! ♕d7 20.f3 fxg3 21.hxg3 (21.♘ce3!?) 21...f5 22.♔g2! (with the black king on h8, playing along the h-file is even more effective) 22...f4 (22...fxe4?! 23.♗xe4+−) 23.♖h1 ♗g8 24.g4± ♕f7 25.♕h4 a5 26.♖h2 ♖b7 27.♖dh1 ♖a8 28.♕g5 ♘e7 29.c5 1-0 Marczell-Branding, cr ICCF 1996.

O 16...0-0 is also possible, since after 17.♘cxb4 ♘xb4 18.♘xb4 Black regains the pawn with 18...♕b6 19.♘d5 ♕xb2, but the white pieces become really active and he has the advantage: 20.♖ab1 ♕d4 21.♖fd1±.

17.♖ad1

Other moves such as 16.b3 or 16.g3 have also been successful, but the text move improves the position of the pieces and leaves all possibilities open.

17...♖b8

With the idea of playing ...♕g5 before castling.

17...h6 has the same intention but is tactically unsound: 18.c5! (this was one of the points behind ♖ad1) 18...0-0 (18...dxc5?! 19.♗b5 ♗d7 20.♘xf4!+−) 19.♗b5 ♘d4?! (19...♘a7 is better, but not free from problems either: 20.♗a4 dxc5 21.♘xf4±) 20.♘xd4 exd4 21.c6+− Tseshkovsky-Bos-Swiecik, Wisla 1992.

18.b3

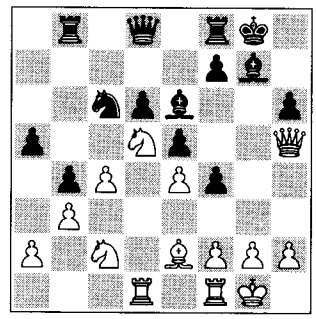
Following the plan we already know.

18...h6 19.♗e2

Pre-empting ...♕g5. 19.g3!? transposes to the note to move 16.

19...0-0

19...♕g5 is a bit ugly in view of the check on c7, but is still playable: 20.♘c7+ ♔e7 21.♘d5+ ♔e8 22.g3±.



20.♗g4!

Trying to exploit as much as possible Black's time-wasting move ...h6, to force the swap of light-squared bishops. Of course, the break g2-g3 is still promising.

20...♖b7

20...♕g5? fails to 21.♕xg5 hxg5 22.♗xe6 fxe6 23.♘c7+−, winning a pawn.

21.♕h3 ♗xg4?!

After this move, which totally surrenders the light squares, White's positional edge is very clear. If Black wants to fight, he must try to keep his bishop on e6: **21...♕d7?!** 22.♗f5± followed by g2-g3; **21...♖e8** 22.♗f5 ♕g5 is the most resilient: 23.♖fe1±.

22.♕xg4 ♕g5 23.♕e2±

White regroups his army and will later choose between playing on the queenside (a2-a3) or, more frequently, on the kingside (g2-g3). But 23.♕f5!? was also very interesting.

23...♖a8 24.♔h1

24.♕d2! must be the most accurate.

24...a4 25.♕d2

This wins a pawn while keeping important positional trumps, but Black gets some counterplay and the tension remains for the rest of the game.

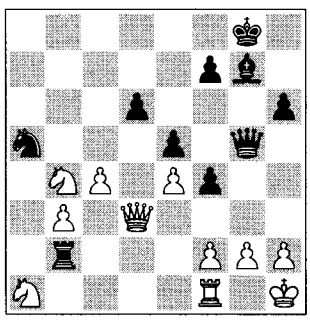
25...axb3 26.axb3 ♖a2 27.♖a1 ♖ba7 28.♖xa2! ♖xa2 29.♕d3

Controlling f3.

29...♖b2

29...♘a5 30.♘dxb4 ♖b2 31.♘a1+–.

30.♘dxb4 ♘a5 31.♘a1!+–



The rest of the game is still complex, but we will offer just short notes because it goes beyond our scope.

31...♕g4 32.♘bc2!

Prepares b3-b4.

32...f3

Desperately seeking counterplay.

33.gxf3 ♕h3 34.♖g1 ♘c6 35.♕d1 ♘d4 36.♖g3 ♕h5 37.♘xd4!? exd4 38.♕c1?!

38.♘c2! ♔h7 39.♘xd4 ♗e5 40.♔g2+– is the most natural, least complicated and best procedure.

38...♖xf2!! 39.♕g1!

39.♖xg7+? leads to a draw: 39...♔f8! (39...♔xg7 40.♕g1+ ♕g5 41.♕xf2 d3 42.♕d4++–) 40.♖g8+ ♔e7 41.♕f4 ♖xf3 42.♕d2 ♖f1+ 43.♖g1 ♕f3+ 44.♕g2 ♖xg1+ 45.♔xg1 ♕d1+ 46.♕f1 ♕g4+ 47.♔f2 ♕f4+= 48.♔e2?? d3+ 49.♔e1 d2+–+.

39...♖a2! 40.♖xg7+ ♔f8 41.♖g8+?! ♔e7 42.♖g3 d3!

42...♕a5 43.♕xd4 ♖xa1+ 44.♖g1+–.

43.b4 ♕e5

43...d2 44.♕d1 ♕e5 45.♘b3 ♕c3 46.♖g2+–.

44.♘b3 ♕b2 45.e5! ♕xb3 46.exd6+ ♔d7?

46...♔xd6!± was more tenacious.

47.♕e3 ♕d1+ 48.♖g1 ♕e2 49.♕f4! ♕e6 50.c5 ♖b2?!

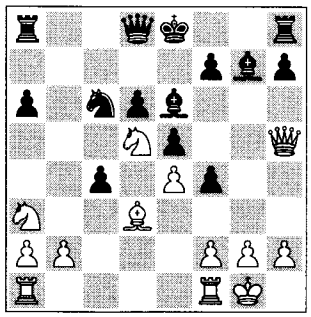
50...♖c2! would still offer stiff resistance. For example: 51.♖a1!? d2 52.♖g1 (52.♖a7+?? ♔c6–+) 52...♕d5 53.♖d1 ♕e6 54.b5±.

51.♕d4+– ♕e2 52.c6+! ♔xc6 53.♕c5+ ♔b7 54.♕c7+ ♔a6 55.♖a1+ ♖a2 56.♕c4+ ♔b6 57.♕xa2 d2 58.♕a7+ ♔c6 59.♕c7+ 1-0

Game 8.06

Short,Nigel
Sax,Gyula
Saint John (m/1) 1988

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e5 6.♘db5 d6 7.♗g5 a6 8.♘a3 b5 9.♗xf6 gxf6 10.♘d5 f5 11.♗d3 ♗e6 12.♕h5 ♗g7 13.0-0 f4 14.c4 bxc4



Thus we get into the variation which was for many years the main line in the Pelikan. It looks suspicious, because the white bishop gets an excellent position and the strong point on d5 seems to last forever. But Black used to get a lot of counterplay by means of the basic themes: the d4-square for the knight, the ...f7-f5 break and the exploitation of the poor position of the a3 knight. Now this line has fallen into disrepute, but there is a large amount of theory on it. White's positional assets have led to success through extremely precise analysis, and the assessments look conclusive.

15.♗xc4 0-0

Castling is the most natural and the most frequent move here, but we must take into account an interesting alternative:

15...♘d4 The idea behind this move may be to forestall the knight swap by preventing ♘c2, or to support an eventual ...f4-f3. Opening books hardly pay attention to it, but its refutation is far from clear: 16.♖fc1! (a preparation for ♘c2) 16...0-0 17.♘c2 ♘xc2 18.♖xc2 ♔h8 19.♖ac1 ♖c8 20.♖c3± and it is hard to shake off White's grip on the key squares, Pedzich-Wehmeier, Miedzybrodzie Open 1991.

16.♖ac1

White intends to develop the rook along the third rank and also exploit the fact that the ♘c6 is unprotected, as well as to meet ...♘d4 with ♘c2. Playing immediately ♘c2 would run into ...f7-f5. Black is now at a real crossroads.

16...♘e7

In any case, trying to swap the ♘d5 rather than the ♘a3 (as in the ...♘d4 line) seems more logical. Let us consider the alternatives:

○ 16...♘d4 just plays into White's hands: 17.♘c2 ♘xc2 (17...♘b5 18.a4 ♘c7 19.♘cb4±) 18.♖xc2 ♔h8 19.♖fc1 ♖c8 (19...f5? fails again to 20.♘xf4; 19...♖a7 20.b4 f5 21.♘xf4 exf4 22.♗xe6 fxe4 23.♗f5 ♗f6 24.♖c8 ♕e7 25.♗xh7 ♔g7 26.♗f5 ♗b2 27.♕h7+ ♔f6 28.♖xf8+ ♕xf8 29.♕g6+ ♔e5 30.♕e6+ Perenyi-Sorm, Decin B 1978) 20.b4 (preparing to capture on a6; 20.♗xa6?! ♖xc2 21.♖xc2 ♕a5∞) 20...a5 21.a3± – with

a passed pawn on the queenside and total control of the position, we cannot question who has an edge here, Ulibin-Jiri Nun, Sochi 1989.

O 16...♖a7 The rook defends against any knight forks and gets ready to play against the white castled position in the future, but for the moment it will be awkward here. 17.♖fd1 ♕b8 (17...f5? 18.♘b4!+–) 18.b3 ♘d4 (18...f5? 19.exf5+–) 19.♘c2 ♘b5 20.♘cb4! (there is no way to avoid material losses, while White keeps full control of the position) 20...♕b7 21.♗xb5 ♕xb5 22.♘c6 ♖b7 23.a4 ♕xb3 24.♘a5+– Sion Castro-Remon, Havana B 1991.

O 16...f5?! fails to 17.♘b4!±.

O 16...♔h8 occurs frequently but more often than not just transposes to the main line after 17.♖fd1! ♖b8 18.b3.

O 16...♖b8 17.b3 is the main line and will be studied in Game 8.07.

17.♖fd1

Leaves the door open to capture on d5 with a piece.

17...♖c8

There is an almost unanimous consensus that this is the right move here, as it poses difficulties for White's manoeuvres. But some of the alternatives are logical as well.

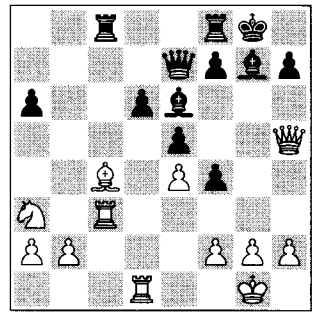
O 17...f5? now fails due to 18.♘c7+–;

O 17...♖a7 18.♖d3 ♔h8 19.♖cd1± Boudre-Erdogan, Ramsgate B 1979;

O 17...♖b8 18.♘xe7+ ♕xe7 19.b3± Van der Wiel-Haakman, Haarlem 1992.

18.♘xe7+ ♕xe7 19.♖c3!

The rook gets ready to double along the d-file and also to create threats against the enemy castled position along the third rank.



19...♔h8

A necessary preparation for ...f5. There are some alternatives, but only one is serious.

O 19...♖c6?? 20.♗xe6 ♖xc3 21.♗f5+–;

O 19...f5? 20.exf5+–;

O 19...♖fd8!? This is a useful move to overprotect d6 and prepare an eventual ...d5. **20.♕e2** The queen contributes to the fight for the light squares while hitting c4 and a6. 20.b3?! was one of the points behind Black's move: 20...d5! 21.exd5 ♗xd5 22.♖cd3 ♗xc4 23.♘xc4 e4 with good counterplay. Kuniyuki-Bauer, cr 1991. **20...♔h8!** This is directed against ♗xe6 and also prepares ...f5. For example: 20...a5?! 21.♗xe6! fxe6 (21...♖xc3?! 22.♗xf7+) 22.♖xc8 ♖xc8 23.♘c4±. **21.♕d3!** 21.♗xe6 ♖xc3 22.bxc3 ♕xe6∞ The white knight lacks a good support or, rather, it is far away from its support. **21...d5** Perhaps hasty, but White was ready to consolidate his grip with ♗xe6 or ♗d5. **22.♗xd5 ♖xc3 23.♕xc3 ♗xd5 24.♖xd5 ♖xd5 25.exd5 e4 26.♕c8+ ♗f8** (Peter-Rausz, Budapest 1988) and now instead of playing the greedy 27.♕xa6 White can almost force a win with 27.♘c4!, for example: 27...♕b4 (27...♔g8 28.♕g4++–) 28.♔f1 ♔g7 29.b3+– with the idea of ♕g4+.

20.b3 f5

After longing so much for this move, Black finally plays it at a point when it allows some annoying threats on h7. Let's see other possibilities:

O 20...d5? 21.exd5 ♗xd5 22.♖xd5 ♕xa3 23.♗d3+−;

O 20...♗d7!? A suggestion by Short, still untested. The not-very-concealed idea is ...d5, but analysis from Short himself cast doubts upon its soundness. 21.♘b1! avoids all tricks and moves towards d5. 21...f5 22.♗xa6±;

O 20...♖g8 21.♖cd3 ♗f8 (21...♖cd8 22.♗xe6 ♕xe6 23.♘c4±) 22.♗xe6 ♕xe6 (22...fxe6 23.♘c4±) 23.♘c4 ♖c6 24.♕f5 ♕g6 25.♕xg6 ♖xg6 and White has reached the position of control that he wished, Mukherjee-Kruse, cr 1995.

21.♖h3 h6 22.♗xe6 ♕xe6 23.♖hd3±

This round trip of the rook has served to fulfil some strategic goals: the exchange of light-squared bishops, control of the d5-square and support for the ♘c4. It is clear that the outcome of the opening has been favourable for White.

23...♖cd8

23...fxe4 might be the only move which can confuse matters, but after 24.♖xd6 ♕e7 25.♘c4 ♖cd8 26.♕g6± Black is unable to create counterplay.

24.♕e2

Regroups the army to keep absolute control of the important light squares e4 and d5. As a consequence, Black's light-squared bishop will remain inactive. Also correct: 24.♘c4 fxe4 25.♖xd6 ♖xd6 26.♖xd6 ♕e7, but now there is no need to capture the a6 pawn and allow counterplay: 27.♖xa6?! (27.♕g6; 27.h3) 27...e3! 28.fxe3 fxe3 29.♕e2!±.

24...fxe4

24...♕g6 25.f3± keeps control.

25.♕xe4 f3!?

A logical attempt to create complications before the white knight reaches a central position and the game is strategically decided.

26.♘c4!

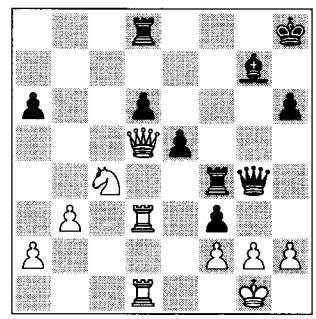
26.♖xf3?! allows 26...d5 with some mess, e.g.: 27.♕h4 e4 28.♖xf8+ ♖xf8 29.♘c2 d4!⩲ 30.♘xd4?! ♕d6 31.♕xe4 ♖d8∓.

26...♖f4

26...fxg2 makes White's task easier 27.♖xd6 ♖xd6 28.♖xd6 ♕f7 29.♕xg2 ♖g8 30.♖g6±.

27.♕d5 ♕g4

After trading queens and the inevitable loss of the d6 pawn, Black's activity is insufficient.



28.♖xf3?!

Leads the game to an ending which is quieter to play, but more difficult to

turn into a win, in view of the ruined pawn structure. 28.♘e3! ♕g5 29.g3 is a simple alternative to keep control of the position.

28...♖xf3 29.♕xf3 ♕xf3 30.gxf3 d5 31.♔f1 ♗f6 32.♘b6 d4 33.♔e2 ♗g5

33...♔g7!?

34.♘c4 ♗f4 35.h3 ♖g8

The rook does nothing here. Somewhat better would be 35...♔g7 36.♔d3 ♔f6 37.♖g1.

36.b4

White prepares to make use of his mobile majority on the queenside.

36...♖g2?

And Black decides to take his pieces to the other end of the world. 36...♖b8± looks better.

37.a4+– ♔g7 38.b5 axb5 39.axb5 ♔f6 40.b6 ♔e6 41.b7 ♖g8 42.♖b1 ♖b8 43.♖b5 ♔d7 44.♘a5 ♔c7

44...♗g5 45.♖xe5 ♗d8 46.♖d5+ ♔e6 47.♖xd8.

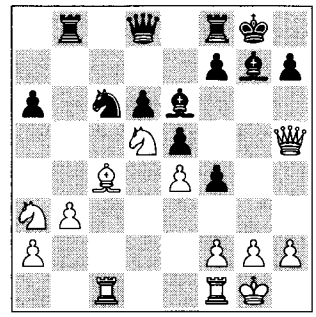
45.♔d3 ♔d6 46.h4 ♔c7 47.♖b2 ♗h2 48.♔e4 ♗f4 49.♖c2+ ♔d7 50.♔d3! ♗h2 51.♖c1 ♗f4 52.♖g1 ♔d6 53.♔c4 1-0

Game 8.07

Rittner,Horst
Privara,Igor
cr ol-10 1982

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e5 6.♘db5 d6 7.♗g5 a6 8.♘a3 b5 9.♗xf6 gxf6 10.♘d5 f5 11.♗d3 ♗e6 12.♕h5 ♗g7 13.0-0 f4 14.c4 bxc4 15.♗xc4 0-0 16.♖ac1 ♖b8 17.b3

With 16...♖b8 we have reached the main line, but the real crossroads will appear at the next move.



17...♕d7

This is the most common move. Black is not threatening ...♗g4 yet (White can reply ♕g5), but this threat is in the air and by defending both the knight and the ♗e6, he is closer to the thematic (and almost essential) break ...f5. The other alternatives have not been that successful:

○ 17...♕a5?! This move only works tactically and enjoyed a brief success at the end of the 1980s. **18.♘c2 ♔h8** The logical follow-up to the previous move would be 18...♕xa2?! but this meets a strong tactical reply: 19.♘cb4!! ♘xb4 (19...♖xb4 20.♘xb4 ♘xb4 21.♗xe6 fxe6 22.♖c7 transposes) 20.♘e7+ ♔h8 21.♗xe6 fxe6 (21...♖b7 22.♗f5 h6 23.♘g6+ fxg6 24.♕xg6 ♔g8 25.♖c3 ♕a5 26.♖fc1 ♘a2 27.♖c8 ♘xc1 28.♗e6++– Khruschiov-Yagupov, Tula 2001) 22.♘g6+ ♔g8 23.♘xf8 ♖xf8 24.♖c7 ♔h8 (24...♕xb3?! 25.♖fc1+– and the threat ♖g7 is unstoppable) 25.♕g4! ♖g8 26.♕xe6 ♖f8 27.♖c8 h6

(Dgebuadze-Vandevoort, Eupen ch-BEL 2008) and now, as previously analysed by Lutz in *Chess Informant*: 28.♖xf8+ ♗xf8 29.♕f7 ♗g7 30.♖c1 ♘c2 31.♕f5+− wins. **19.♖fd1 ♖g8** After giving up all hope of capturing the a2 pawn, Black is punished for his fruitless trip. 19...♕xa2 is the logical alternative, but after 20.♕e2 the black queen is in trouble and the a6 pawn is doomed. 20...♗xd5 (20...♕a5 21.♖a1 ♕d8 22.♖xa6+−) 21.♖xd5 ♕b2 22.♖cd1±. **20.b4! ♕d8 21.♗xa6±**; White should be able to gradually neutralize Black's attempts and finally win thanks to his passed pawn. Short-Kuijf, Wijk aan Zee 1990.

○ 17...♗xd5?! is strategically nonsense, only based on a pawn grab after 18.♗xd5 ♘b4 19.♖fd1 ♘xa2. However, White will eventually regain the pawn, e.g.: 20.♖c6! ♖b6 (20...♕e7 21.♘c4 ♘b4 22.♖xd6 ♘xd5 23.♖6xd5 ♖xb3 24.♘d6± and the white knight heads for f5 with unstoppable attack. Wolff-Bronstein, Wijk aan Zee B 1992) 21.♖xb6 ♕xb6 22.♘c4 ♕c7 23.♘xd6 ♘c3 24.♘f5!± Stean-Sax, Las Palmas 1978.

○ 17...♘d4?! makes White's task easier, as it allows the immediate trade of his bad knight: 18.♘c2! ♘xc2 19.♖xc2 ♔h8 20.g4 (20.♖d1!?±) 20...♖g8 21.♔h1 ♗f8 22.♖g1± Kotronias-Reinderman, Wijk aan Zee (Sonnevanck) 1995.

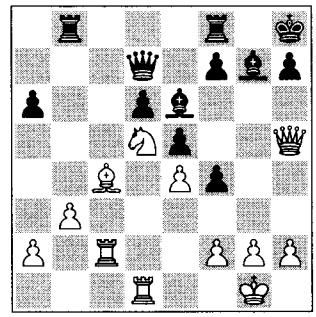
○ 17...♔h8?! is very often played, but not so accurate in this move order: 18.♘xf4 ♗xc4 (18...exf4 19.♗xe6 ♘d4 20.♗c4 f5 Idler-Reichel, cr DDR 1989 and now with 21.♗d3± White keeps his extra pawn without compensation) 19.♖xc4 ♘a5 20.♘d5 (20.♖a4!? may be OK for those not willing to give up material: 20...♘xb3 21.axb3 exf4 22.♖xa6 ♖xb3 23.♕d5±) 20...♘xc4 21.♘xc4± with enormous compensation for the exchange, Tischbierek-Staudler, cr DDR 1990.

18.♖fd1

The most natural move: White's last-but-one piece (let's not forget the knight!) comes into play and the strategic threat ...♗xd5 and ...♘b4, which could follow after other moves such as ♕h4, is prevented. Again, Black has tried many different moves:

18...♔h8

○ 18...♘d4!? 19.♘c2 ♘xc2 20.♖xc2 ♔h8

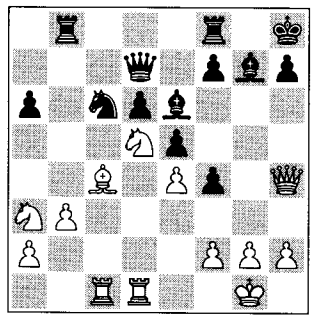


It is hard to find something active without this move, which is the standard preparation for 22...f5 and 22...♗g4. **21.♕h4!** This move, tested almost exclusively in correspondence games, has made Black's set-up fall into disrepute. The queen supports annoying knight jumps to e7 and f6. **21...f5?!** Logical, but tactically unsound. Somewhat better is 21...♗xd5, though it makes big positional concessions and Black's only aspiration here is a draw: 22.♗xd5 ♖fc8 23.♖dc1 ♖xc2 24.♖xc2 a5 25.♕h5 ♖f8 26.g4± Luther-

Nikolaidis, Aegina 1993. **22.♘e7!** The tactical point. **22...♗xc4** 22...fxe4 23.♘g6+ ♔g8 24.♘xf8 ♖xf8 25.♕g4 ♖e8 26.♖cd2 ♔f8 27.♗xe6 ♖xe6 28.♕f5+ ♔g8 29.♕xe4+–. **23.♘g6+ ♔g8 24.♘xf8 ♖xf8 25.♖xc4 fxe4 26.♖xe4 d5** The black pawns' mobilization forces White to pay some attention, but does not offer real compensation. **27.♕h5 ♕e6 28.♖a4 ♕c6 29.♕e2!** Forces Black to give up the a6 pawn to avoid a blockade. **29...e4** 29...♖a8 30.♕d3 d4 31.f3+–. **30.♖xa6 ♕c5 31.b4 ♕xb4 32.♕h5+–** Oskulski-Ivanov, cr ICCF 1994.

O 18...f5?? 19.exf5 ♖xf5 20.♕xf5+–.

19.♕h4



Pre-empting ...♗g4. Now Black can follow two very different paths:

19...f5

The most logical from a strategic point of view. This position has arisen specially in correspondence games and most of the analysis has led to the conclusion that White can control the enemy counterplay. Besides, computers assess this position as a clear edge for White, which discourages potential researchers. However, in practical play this is a dangerous position for White if you lack precise knowledge.

19...♗xd5 shares popularity with ...f5, despite the serious positional concession made. **20.♗xd5 ♘b4** With this move, Black hopes to eliminate the bishop, but 20...♘d4 is also possible, with ideas like ...f3 or ...♘e2: 21.♖c4! (Sveshnikov himself showed the way, which deserves all our trust. White gets ready for the thematic ♘c2) 21...f5 (21...♖bc8 22.♖xc8 ♖xc8 23.♕h5!±, preventing ...♘e2, and ♘c4 will follow; 21...f3 opens the way for the white knight to get to f5: 22.♘c2 ♘e2+ 23.♔f1 ♖fc8 24.♘e3 ♘c3 25.♖d2 ♘xd5 26.♖xd5 fxg2+ 27.♔xg2± with absolute control of the position) 22.♘c2! fxe4 (22...♘xc2 would be somewhat better) 23.♘xd4 exd4 24.♗xe4 ♗e5±. White's task hasn't ended yet, as Black has a passed pawn on d4 and a solidly anchored bishop, but the black pawn structure is too bad, Sveshnikov-Vyzhmanavin, Moscow 1987. **21.♖c3! f5** More delicate is 21...♘xa2!? but after 22.♖h3 h6 23.♘c4 Black has a difficult choice: whether to accept a passive position or to play ...f5 in dubious tactical conditions; for example:

A) 23...♖bd8 24.g4! fxg3 (almost forced in view of the threat g4-g5) 25.♖xg3! ♘b4 26.♘e3± and once again, White has an absolute grip on the key squares.

B) 23...f5 24.exf5 ♕xf5 25.♘xd6 ♕c2 26.♕h5± followed by ♘f7;

C) 23...f6 24.♕h5 (Bessenyei-Kulcsar, cr Hungary 1991) 24...♘b4 25.♕g6 ♘xd5 26.♖xd5 ♕c7 27.♖hd3± and it is impossible to prevent White from capturing d6;

D) 23...♖fc8 24.g4 fxg3 25.♖xg3 with a strong attack in which the knight will take part via e3-f5.

22.♖h3 ♗f6?! 22...h6 is the only alternative, without practical examples so

far. 23.♘c4 ♘xd5 (23...fxe4 24.♗xe4 ♖f6 25.♕xf6! ♗xf6 26.♖xh6+ ♔g8 27.♖xd6+−) 24.♖xd5 ♖f6 25.exf5 ♕xf5 26.♕h5 ♕xh5 27.♖xh5±; and not 26...♕b1+?! 27.♕d1 ♕xa2?? 28.♖d2+−. Black has problems to maintain the material balance. **23.♗e6!** All this already appears in Renet's notes to his game against Kortchnoi. 23...♕e7 (23...♗xh4? 24.♗xd7 ♗e7 25.♗xf5 ♖f7 26.♖d2+− loses a clear pawn; 23...♕a7 24.♕h5 fxe4 25.♗f5 ♖f7 26.♗xe4 ♘xa2 27.♘c4+− with a decisive attack) 24.♕h5 fxe4 25.♘c4 e3 26.♘xd6+− Dominguez Perez-Almeida Quintana, Santa Clara ch-CUB 1999.

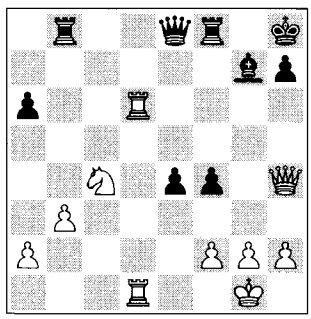
20.♘xf4!

Not only has this tactical approach been successful, but it is the only way to prevent Black from taking control. The next series of moves is virtually forced.

20...exf4 21.♗xe6 ♕xe6 22.♖xc6 fxe4 23.♖cxd6 ♕e8

Now White has many options, but my suggestion is a logical knight turn to the centre of the battlefield.

24.♘c4



It is a good moment to evaluate the situation. White has won a pawn and his pieces are almost ideally placed. Even so, life is not easy because the bishop is very strong in such an open position, and the pair of mobile central pawns can produce a very annoying passed pawn.

24...e3!?

The logical option, almost unanimously played. There is no reason to delay the creation of the passed pawn.

25.fxe3 fxe3 26.♖e1!

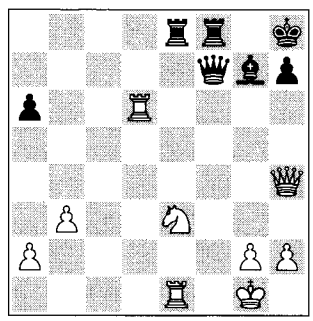
All resources are needed to fight against the passed pawn. Black was already threatening 27...e2 and 28...♕f7, and other defences were more artificial.

26...♕f7

Almost all the games have followed this path. Black rearranges his army in a very logical way: the queen frees the e8-square for the least active rook. My database just records one other move, but let's consider some more.

26...♖b4?! is an artificial way to defend the pawn. 27.♕g3! captures the passed pawn in good conditions: 27...e2 28.♕d3 a5 29.♕xe2+− Almasi-G.Mohr, Croatia tt 1996; **26...e2?!** 27.♖d2!+−; **26...♖d8?!** 27.♖xd8 ♕xd8 28.♕xd8 ♖xd8 29.♘xe3 ♗d4 30.♔f1+− and White flees from the pin.

27.♘xe3 ♖be8



White is two pawns up but the black pieces are so active that we can't rule out any simplification sequence leading to a drawish endgame or even to the capture of the knight if White is careless.

28.♖f1!

Brilliant calculation. White steps out of the pin and simplifies the position. This looks like the best way of converting his material advantage.

28.♘c4?! ♖e4!∞ is an example of where careless play may lead: 29.♕g3 ♗d4+ 30.♖xd4 ♖xd4 31.♕e5+ ♕g7 32.♕xg7+ ♔xg7= Mierzynski-Walczak, cr Poland 1993;

28.h3!? looks good as well, but after 28...♗f6! 29.♕c4 (29.♕f2 ♗g5! 30.♕xf7 ♖xf7 31.♖d3 ♖fe7 32.♔f2 ♖f7+ 33.♔e2 ♖fe7= and it is hard to see how White can break the pin) 29...♗g5! it is difficult to break the pin: 30.♕c3+ ♗f6 31.♕c4 ♗g5 32.♕c3+ ♗f6 33.♕c4 ½-½ Wedberg-Kharlov, Skelleftea 1999.

28...♕a7

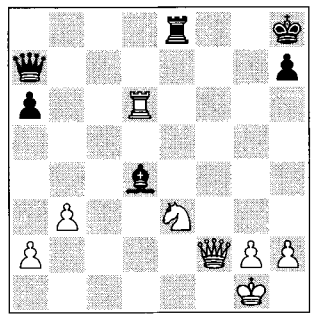
This seems to be the reason why the previous white move was wrong. 28...♕c7 29.♖xf8+ ♖xf8 30.♖d1 ♕e5 31.♕e1 ♕c5 32.b4 ♕b6 33.♔h1 ♖e8 34.♕d2 ♗h6 35.♕b2+ ♗g7 36.♘d5!+– Gallinnis-Toro Solis de Ovando, cr 1989.

29.♖xf8+ ♗xf8

29...♖xf8 30.♕e1 ♖e8 (30...♗d4 31.♖e6) 31.♕f2! ♗d4 32.♖e6! leads to the game.

30.♕f6+ ♗g7 31.♕f2 ♗d4

31...♕c5! is the most resilient. 32.♖d5! ♕c3 33.♘f1 ♖f8, but White keeps the advantage: 34.♕d2! ♕a1 35.♕d1 ♕xa2 36.♘d2± on the way to f3.



32.♖e6!

Only move, but annoying.

32...♕d7

32...♖c8 33.g3 ♕b7 34.♕f5! and the pressure vanishes.

33.♖e4! ♗xe3

Black decides to retrieve one pawn but give up all initiative. Other moves may be worse, but in practice this makes White's task easier.

33...h6 34.♕f4±; 33...♕d8 34.♕f4±.

34.♕xe3 ♕d1+ 35.♔f2 ♕c2+ 36.♔f3 ♖xe4 37.♕xe4 ♕xa2 38.♕c4±

Of course Black has drawing chances, but the situation is unpleasant for the second player.

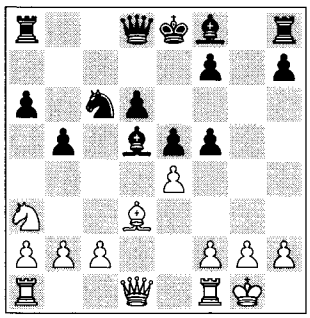
38...♕b1 39.♕d4+ ♔g8 40.♕d5+ ♔g7 41.h4 ♕f1+ 42.♔g4 ♕e2+ 43.♔h3 ♕e3+ 44.♕f3 ♕c5 45.♕f4 ♔g6 46.♕e4+ ♔g7 47.b4 ♕b5 48.♔g3 ♕f1 49.♕g4+ ♔h8 50.h5 ♕e1+ 51.♔h2 ♕e5+ 52.g3 ♕d5 53.♕c8+ ♔g7 54.h6+ ♔f7 55.♕xa6 ♕d2+ 56.♔h3 ♕xb4 57.♕d3 ♕b2

58.♕xh7+ ♔f8 59.♕f5+ ♔g8 60.♔h4 ♕h2+ 61.♕h3 ♕c2 62.♕g4+ ♔f7 63.h7 ♕xh7+ 64.♕h5+ 1-0

Game 8.08

Asrian,Karen
Wang Yue
Khanty-Mansiysk 2005

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e5 6.♘db5 d6 7.♗g5 a6 8.♘a3 b5 9.♗xf6 gxf6 10.♘d5 f5 11.♗d3 ♗e6 12.0-0 ♗xd5



Opening theory moves increasingly faster. Nowadays, in a few years, this line has completely taken over the old variation 12....♗g7. As with most decisions in chess, it has its pros and cons; Black gives up his best bishop but eliminates White's good knight. In the resulting position with opposite-coloured bishops, White will try to prove he is able to develop an attack because Black can't set up a solid pawn chain on the light squares.

However, Black does have trumps as well: there is no need to worry about the d5-square anymore and it will take longer for the white knight to leave its exile on a3. Many players have taken part in the fierce theoretical battle in this line, among them some of the top GMs (Leko, Topalov, Shirov, Kramnik, etc.), but lately it has been replaced by the positional line 9.♘d5, which is the centre of the theoretical debate. This is good for the amateur players, who can get the most from their research with no need to keep a constant watch on the latest games.

13.exd5 ♘e7 14.c3

The most flexible move, and my recommendation. White keeps open the plans of attacking the kingside pawn chain by means of f2-f3 or the queenside pawn chain by means of a2-a4, while getting ready to recycle the knight.

Of course, 14.♘xb5 wins a pawn, and was the main line for a long time, but nowadays the general assessment is that Black gets good counterplay.

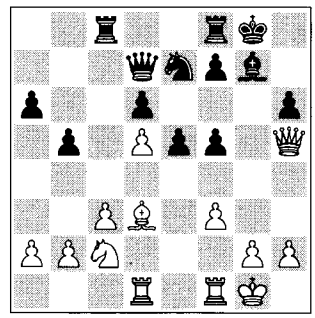
14.♖e1 has recently gained some popularity, but I think it is not so precise, as c2-c3 (partially closing the black bishop's diagonal) seems necessary sooner or later.

14...e4

Black can hardly do without this move, which opens the game for the bishop, harasses the white pieces and mobilizes the phalanx of active black pawns (doubled f-pawns plus the e-pawn) but actually, developing the bishop first of all is more popular, and we'll take that as a secondary line for the sake of clarity.

O 14...♗g7 The natural plan, getting ready to castle before launching active play with the pair of central pawns and the pair of queenside pawns. More often than not, it transposes to 14...e4, but here we will just analyse the independent variations. **15.♕h5** Exerting pressure on f5 and eyeing up the future

black castled position. If Black decides to push the e-pawn, White prepares the break f2-f3 and the knight and the rook come from the other side of the board. This has been the most popular move in recent years, and still is, but the classical plan of immediately recycling the knight by ♘c2 is gaining supporters. I will analyse this possibility in the next game. **15...♕d7** Trying to keep the pawn formation intact. **16.♖ad1** The rook gets ready to defend the d5 pawn. White is confident that he will force the black pawns to move when the knight gets to e3. The alternative 16.♖ae1!?, which involves the sacrifice of the d5 pawn, is also appealing. **16...♖c8** The black rook heads for c5 without allowing White to complete his regrouping comfortably. 16...0-0 is less logical because it allows the white knight to arrive on e3: 17.♗b1! h6 18.g3 ♖ac8 19.♘c2 a5 20.♘e3 e4 21.♔h1! (although f2-f3 is playable directly, White doesn't want to allow a pin) 21...f4?! (Black jumps off the bridge; any other move would meet the reply f2-f3 with good attacking chances) 22.gxf4 f5 23.♖g1± Howell-Arakhamia, Port Erin 1995. **17.♘c2** 17.♗b1 ♖c5∞. **17...0-0** On the contrary, this move is more useful than ...♖c5, as we can see if we compare the text game with this: 17...♖c5 18.♘e3 e4 19.♗b1! 0-0 (19...f4 20.♘g4± and Black can't play ...f5). 20.g3!± preparing f2-f3. The rook just wastes time on c5, Dolmatov-Chekhov, Germany Bundesliga 1991/92. **18.f3** Preparing an attack against the f5 pawn with ♘e3. In contrast with the previous line, the direct attack doesn't work. White can try to prepare it with 18.g3!? e4 19.♗e2 f4 20.f3!↑ with a really interesting position, but the white bishop doesn't occupy its best diagonal, Palac-Verdier, Montpellier 1998. **18...h6** Black tries to get ahead of his opponent, who needs to spend time on ♔h1 before taking the knight to e3. Then, Black would be ready to play ...f4 and then ...f5 with a good position. It is such a logical move that it is the only choice in this position. 18...♖c5? 19.♘e3 ♕a7 20.♔h1+–; 18...♘xd5? 19.♗xf5 ♕a7+ 20.♔h1 ♘f6 21.♕h3 ♖cd8 22.♘b4+–.



19.f4! Lutz prepares a very deep subtlety. In the subsequent position with opposite-coloured bishops, the pawn is much worse placed on h6 than on h7 and that offers White a certain initiative. **19...e4 20.♗e2 ♖c5 21.♘e3 ♕a7 22.♔h1 ♖xc3** This exchange sacrifice was well known with the pawn on h7. Now it is still correct, but doesn't work so well. On the other hand, if Black does not act, he has to face two dangerous ideas after White consolidates his position: the attacking break g2-g4 and the manoeuvre g3-♗f1-h3 besieging the f5-pawn. **23.♘xf5!** 23.bxc3 ♕xe3 24.c4 b4⩲ is really the most promising for Black. **23...♘xf5** There is no experience with the alternative 23...♖c2 but after 24.♘xd6± the passed d-pawn must be dangerous. **24.♕xf5 ♖e3 25.♕h5±** With different-coloured

bishops, the initiative becomes more important. Now White is better prepared to attack Black's castled position, but the battle is very open.

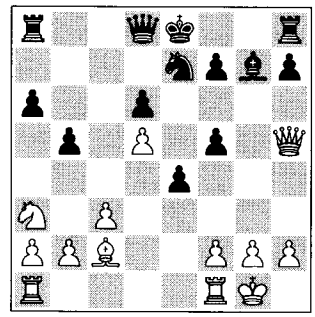
O 14...♕d7 Rogozenco's idea, preparing an ambitious and quite logical plan. The rook will occupy the g-file and the king can later go to h8 if necessary. The black pieces will occupy more aggressive positions. However, White can exploit the drawbacks of the idea, essentially the lack of communication between the black rooks, to speed his queenside attack. **15.♘c2!** I think it makes less sense now to take the queen to h5, where she can be harassed; on the contrary, accelerating the queenside attack is more effective. **15...♗g7** 15...♖g8 16.a4 e4 17.♗e2 f4 18.♔h1! – the black attack is controlled and 19.axb5 is already a threat. 18...♘f5?! 19.axb5 ♘h4 20.♖g1 ♗g7 21.♖xa6+– Talla-Sengupta, Legnica 2006. **16.a4! e4 17.♗e2 0-0 18.axb5 axb5 19.♕d2±** Black has some very clear weaknesses in his pawn structure (b5, the chain f5-e4) and the white knight has excellent outposts (especially b4). Bologan-Ni Hua, Shanghai 2001.

O 14...♖g8 With the same plan as the alternative 14...♕d7 but somehow less logical: now, after an eventual ♕h5, the White queen will face new problems created by the enemy rook. **15.♖e1!** Logical, since now the black king is forced to stay in the centre; also, White frees the f1-square for the bishop to defend the point attacked by the black rook. **15...e4 16.♗f1 ♗g7 17.♘c2** With this natural knight move, White gets interesting prospects on the queenside (with a2-a4) and the centre. **17...♗e5 18.a4!±** Wedberg-Bator, Stockholm 2000.

15.♗c2

15.♗e2!? ♗g7 16.♘c2 0-0 17.a4! Transposing to the next game. White has better chances to deviate; for example: 17.♕d2!?.

15...♗g7 16.♕h5



16...0-0

As usual, the correct order is the most flexible move. Black waits for the white queen's rook to define its position before making a choice between ...♕c8-c5 or ...♖c8-c5. Alternatives:

O 16...♕a5 is a simple pawn-grabbing trip (the threat is 17...♗xc3), which can seriously compromise Black's position against determined play: 17.♖ae1! ♖a7 (17...♗xc3 18.bxc3 ♕xa3 19.♗xe4! fxe4 20.♖xe4 ♖a7 21.♖fe1 ♕xc3 22.♕g5 ♕c7 23.h4± according to the notes by Kramnik himself in *Chess Informant*) 18.♔h1 (the immediate 18.♗b3!? ♗xc3 – 18...0-0 19.♘c2± – 19.bxc3 ♕xa3 20.f3 looks even clearer. 18...♗xc3 19.bxc3 ♕xa3 20.♗b3 ♕b2 21.f3 ♖g8. Kramnik manages to get counterplay, but his own analysis shows that he is still worse after 22.g3 f4 (Polgar-Kramnik, Guarapuava 1991) 23.♕h4!±.

O 16...♕c8 has been tried in even more games than 16...0-0, but it is usually a mere transposition and offers White a good alternative: 17.♖ae1! (17.♖ad1!? Hamdouchi-Handke, Fürth

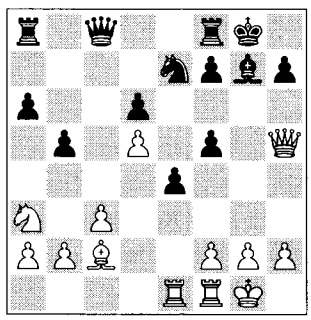
1998, is now possible and interesting) 17...♕c5 (17...0-0 transposes to the main game) 18.♔h1 0-0 19.f3 transposes to the main game, though 19.g4!? may be even stronger.

17.♖ae1!

The most ambitious move. White gets ready to break the enemy pawn chain by means of f2-f3, to transfer the rook to the kingside and to improve the piece circulation on the queenside. Its main drawback is that the queenside is totally surrendered to the black pieces.

17...♕c8

The universal reply, leading to a key position where White has a wide choice.
17...♖c8 fails due to tactical reasons: **18.♗b3! ♖c5** 18...♖b8, in spite of its success in a game, can't be the best option: 19.♘c2 (19.f3! is a direct punishment of Black's hesitation and may be better) 19...a5 20.a3 ♖e8 21.f3 ♘g6 22.fxe4 fxe4 (Timoshenko-Wang Yue, Moscow 2004) and now 23.♕g4 ♕e7 24.♖f2± and Black can't keep his pawn on e4. **19.♘c2 ♕d7** 19...♘xd5 20.♗xd5 ♖xd5 21.♖xe4!±. **20.f3! a5 21.a3 exf3 22.♕xf3 ♗e5 23.g3** and ♘e3 will be possible in a few moves, which would cause the f5 pawn to drop, Kovalev-Palac, Neu Isenburg rapid 1992.



18.f3!?

A still unexplored move, despite being the normal choice for White. Of course, Black can make use of the diagonal that has just opened to harass the white king, but we will see if that is important after all.
O 18.♗b3 has been the trendy move for many years, and we can't say it is refuted, but it has the problem that the bishop leaves the most logical diagonal;
O 18.♔h1 is the most frequent move, in order to prepare f2-f3, but... does it need preparation at all?

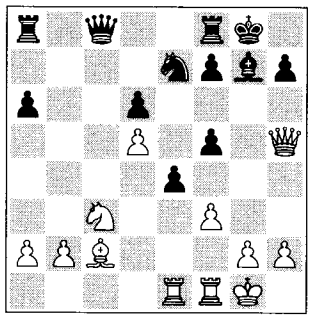
18...b4!

18...♘xd5 19.fxe4 ♕c5+ 20.♖f2 ♘e3 21.exf5± De La Villa Garcia-J.Gomez, Matalascañas tt 1993.
18...♘g6!? is a thematic pawn sacrifice and may become the critical move if this variation gets more popular. I find it very hard to judge the compensation in this position so full of themes. It requires analysis and practical tests. **19.fxe4 f4 20.♗b1** It is hard to choose a move for White, as other bishop moves or even ♘b1 are interesting, but I prefer to keep the bishop on the b1-h7 diagonal and give way to the knight. 20.♖f3!? is the most promising alternative: 20...♕c5+ (20...b4? 21.cxb4 ♗xb2 22.♖h3+–; 20...♖e8 21.♖h3 h6 22.♔h1± is difficult to assess. Black has a strong point on e5, but I don't think that is enough compensation for a pawn and a miserable structure) 21.♔h1 b4 22.cxb4 (22.♘b1!?) 22...♕xb4 23.♖b1± with another weird position) **20...♗xc3** The normal approach seems to be just to regain the pawn and then play with a great knight against a 'bad' bishop. 20...♖e8 21.♘c2 ♖e5 22.♕d1 ♖g5 23.♘d4 and

White must be better, as the bad knight has come back into play; 20...♕c5+ 21.♔h1 b4 22.cxb4 ♕xb4 23.♗d3 ♕xb2 24.♘c4 ♕c3 25.♕e2±. **21.bxc3 ♕c5+ 22.♔h1 ♕xa3 23.e5!** Changing the fate of the minor pieces. **23...dxe5** 23...♕a4? 24.♖e4 ♕a5 25.♖exf4+−; 23...♕xc3 24.e6!→. **24.♖f3!** 24.♖xe5 ♕xc3 25.♖f5 ♖ad8! 26.♖5xf4 ♖xd5! 27.♕xd5 ♘xf4 28.♕d6 ♘e6 29.♕xa6 ♕c4=. **24...♖ae8 25.♖h3** and Black needs to play 25...♔g7, but after 26.♖d1! Black's position is in great danger.

18...♕c5+ 19.♔h1 e3 20.♗xf5 (20.g4!? is more complex but may be stronger) 20...♘xf5 21.♕xf5 ♖fe8 22.♖e2 ♗xc3 23.bxc3 ♕xa3 24.♖xe3 ♖xe3 25.♕g5+ ♔h8 26.♕xe3 ♕xa2 27.♕d4+ ♔g8±.

19.♘b1 bxc3 20.♘xc3!



This is my suggestion. White's attack is dangerous, but it is true that his two minor pieces lack solid outposts.

20...♗xc3

A radical solution to the problem. Other moves are waiting to be tried: 20...♖b8!? 21.♗b3! ♗xc3 (21...♗d4+ 22.♔h1 e3 23.♘e2 ♗xb2 24.♕g5+ ♘g6 25.♕xe3±) 22.bxc3 ♕xc3 23.fxe4 fxe4 24.♖xe4±.

21.bxc3 ♕xc3 22.♗b1

The white attack needs a bigger effort to become a factor. That's why I suggest **22.♖e2!** with similar ideas: 22...♘g6 (22...♖ab8 23.fxe4 fxe4 24.♗xe4± gives White the initiative) 23.♕xf5 exf3 24.♕xf3 (not it's a bit too late to avoid the queen swap) 24...♕xf3 (24...♕d4+ 25.♔h1 ♖ac8 26.♕f5 ♖c7 (preventing 27.♕d7) 27.h3± and the white rooks will get active with threats against the king or the a6-pawn) 25.♖xf3 ♖ae8 26.♗d3! and in contrast to the game, White can keep one rook, which is better able to team up with the bishop, whilst the a6 pawn will become extremely weak.

22...♘g6!

The typical sacrifice, but here it merely gives back extra material, which is better.

23.♕xf5

23.fxe4! f4!∞, but not 23...fxe4?! 24.♖xe4±.

23...exf3 24.♕xf3

Forcing an endgame where rooks and bishop will be stronger, but...

24...♕xf3 25.♖xf3 ♖ae8 26.♖xe8 ♖xe8 27.♔f2

27.♗d3, trying to keep the bishop, makes more sense, but after 27...a5 28.♔f2 ♖b8= the black rook is too active.

27...♖b8 28.♖b3

The only way to fight for an edge.

28...♖xb3 29.axb3 ♘e7!=

The knight intends to set up a barrier on the queenside, together with the a-pawn.

30.♗e4 a5 31.♔e3 ♘c8 32.g4

32.♔d4 ♘b6 and there is no way to advance.

32...h6 33.♔f4 ♔g7 34.h4 ♔f6 35.♗f5 ♘b6 36.♔e4 a4 37.bxa4 ♘xa4 38.♔d4 ♘c5 39.♗c2 ♘a6 40.♔e4 ♘b4 41.♗d1 ♘a6 42.♔f4 ♘b4 43.♔e4 ½-½

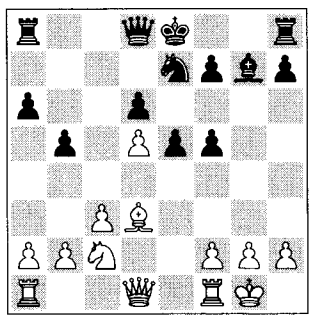
Game 8.09

Sadvakasov,Darmen
Khalifman,Alexander
Sochi 2005

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e5 6.♘db5 d6 7.♗g5 a6 8.♘a3 b5 9.♗xf6 gxf6 10.♘d5 f5 11.♗d3 ♗e6 12.0-0 ♗xd5 13.exd5 ♘e7 14.c3 ♗g7

We shouldn't be misled by the move order. If White wants to follow the plan of this game, he will always answer the pawn push with ♗e2 and if he wants to play as in the previous game, then the reply will be ♗c2, but neither plan can be prevented.

15.♘c2!?



This is the idea. White follows the most traditional plan, that is, to recycle the knight and prepare a2-a4. Its relative merit, compared to ♕h5, is more or less equivalent.

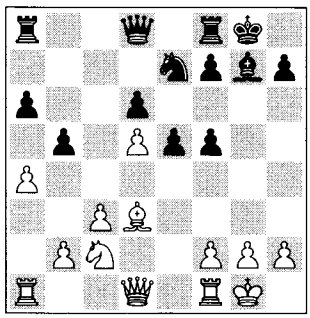
15...0-0

15...e4 usually leads to a transposition, but sometimes it has independent significance: **16.♗e2 ♕b6!?** This is the most logical alternative to 16...0-0, as it makes a2-a4 more difficult. White now has a lot of interesting plans and just 5 games in the database. One idea is insisting on a2-a4 with a preparatory move such as ♕d2 or ♘e3, and some tactics. However, with the black queen on b6, shifting to kingside play makes more sense to me. 16...f4!? is a suggestion by Rogozenco, still untested. Play may continue: 17.a4 0-0 18.axb5 axb5 19.♖xa8 ♕xa8 20.♘b4 with a similar position to the game. **17.♕d2** I consider 17.a4!? bxa4 18.♘e3 0-0 19.♘c4 ♕c5 20.♖xa4 to be slightly favourable for White, but Black has counterplay in some places (d5, b2 and the kingside). **17...0-0 18.♕g5** This move of the white queen is very logical, but it is time to consider other untested plans: 18.g3!? to continue ♕g5 anyway; or 18.a4 bxa4 19.♖fb1∞. **18...♘g6?!** A dubious pawn offer. Defending the knight is more critical: 18...♕b7 19.♘e3 h6 (19...♕d7 fails to defend the pawn: 20.♘xf5! ♕xf5 21.♕xe7 ♕xd5 22.♖fd1 ♕e5 23.♕xd6±) 20.♕h5 f4 (here having the pawn on g3 would have been useful) 21.♘f5 ♘xf5 22.♕xf5 ♖ae8 23.♕xf4 ♕xd5 24.♖fd1 ♕e5 25.♕d2± and White's position is somewhat sounder, though Black's counterplay should be sufficient. **19.♕xf5 ♖ac8** (Galkin-Tregubov, Rethymnon tt 2003) and

White can choose between grabbing a second pawn or the consolidating move 20.♘e3±.

16.a4

Launching a typical assault against the queenside pawns. There is a curious contrast between this plan, where the white bishop stays on the f1-a6 diagonal opposing the a6-b5 pawn pair, and that from the previous game, where it stays on the b1-h7 diagonal, opposing the f5-e4 pawn pair. Which approach is more correct? The answer is difficult, because it probably depends on the effectiveness of the enemy counterplay.



16...e4

Black can't do without this move, but let's see the alternatives tried so far.

O 16...♕d7 In order to defend the potential weakness on b5. **17.♘b4!** Maintaining the pressure and doubling rooks before opening the a-file looks better, though it provokes counterplay. 17.axb5 axb5 18.♘b4 e4 19.♗e2± is sound but somewhat dull. **17...e4 18.♗e2 f4 19.♕c2 f5 20.♖a3 ♕b7 21.♖fa1** The white attack reaches its peak. **21...a5! 22.♘c6 bxa4** On 22...b4? 23.cxb4 axb4 24.♖b3+– wins a pawn. **23.♘xe7+ ♕xe7 24.♖xa4 ♗e5 25.f3!∞** and more analysis is required of the consequences of Black's kingside attack, as White's queenside domination is beyond question.

O 16...♕b6 With similar ideas, but preventing the manoeuvre ♕d2-g5 from the previous note. **17.axb5 axb5 18.♕d2** I think White can exploit the delay of ...e4 with the sequence 18.♕e2! e4 19.♘b4!± and the b5 pawn will drop and the d5 pawn does not seem enough compensation for this loss: 19...♖xa1 20.♖xa1 ♕c5 21.♗xb5 ♘xd5 22.♘xd5 ♕xd5 23.♖d1 ♕c5 24.♗c4±. **18...e4** 18...♕b7 is another way of trading pawns: 19.♘b4 ♘xd5 20.♗xf5 ♖xa1 21.♖xa1 ♘xb4 22.cxb4 ♖a8 23.♖d1± and the opposite-coloured bishops favour White, though this trump looks a token. **19.♗e2 ♘g6 20.♕g5** Again the queen will eventually win a pawn here, which makes me doubt the soundness of the ...♕b6 idea. **20...f4 21.♖xa8 ♖xa8 22.♕f5±** Galkin-Bogosavljevic, Internet blitz 2007.

17.♗e2 bxa4

Defending the pawn with the queen transposes to what we have already seen, whereas defending it with the rook looks rather passive. There is only one way out.

O 17...♖b8?! 18.axb5 axb5 19.♕d2 ♕d7 20.♘b4 ♗e5 21.g3±;

O 17...f4!? 18.axb5 axb5 19.♕d2!±.

18.♖xa4 ♕b6

18...a5 19.♕d2±, giving way to the second rook and deferring the decision of the knight jump to e3 or d4;

18...♘g6!? 19.♖xa6 (19.♕d2!±, preventing ...♕g5, is more cautious, since ...f4 is not possible yet: 19...f4? 20.♖xe4) 19...♖xa6 20.♗xa6 ♕g5 21.♕c1 f4⩲ and Black got decent

counterplay in Ivekovic-Kanmazalp, Heraklio jr 2004.

19.♖b4

19.♕a1!? sets up an interesting and thematic sacrifice: the d5 pawn in exchange for the light squares. It doesn't seem to be enough here, though: 19...♘xd5 20.♖d1 ♘e7 21.♘b4 ♖fd8∞ Klovans-Roiz, Biel Open 2006.

19...♕c5 20.♘e3 ♖ab8

Either rook move to b8 offers Black the best chances for equality.

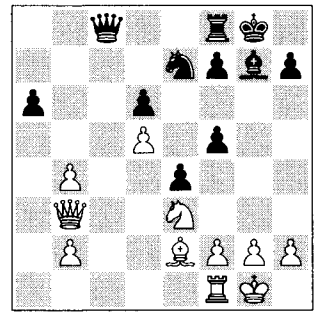
20...♖fb8!? 21.♖c4 (21.♕b3 is less effective now in view of 21...♖xb4 22.cxb4 ♕d4!) 21...♕b6 22.g4 (22.♗h5!?, intending g2-g4, may be better) 22...f4! 23.♖xe4 fxe3 24.♖xe7 exf2+ 25.♔g2 ♕d8 26.♖e3 ♖xb2 27.♖xf2∞ leads to a position with opposite-coloured bishops, difficult to assess; **20...f4?** is premature due to 21.♖xe4!, and preparation with 20...♘g6 isn't possible either.

21.♕b3!?

21.♖c4 is an equivalent alternative: 21...♕b6 (21...♕a5 22.♖a4 ♕c5 23.♕d2 f4 24.♘d1±) 22.♖b4 ♕c5 (Black isn't willing to make concessions to avoid the draw and therefore there is no other way than playing with b2-b4) 23.♖c4 ♕b6 24.b4!? a5 25.g3 axb4 26.axb4 with a double-edged position.

21...♖xb4 22.cxb4 ♕c8?!

The critical variation must be 22...♕b6 (immediately, or inserting 22...♕d4 23.♖d1) 23.♖a1 ♖b8 (23...♖a8 24.b5 a5 25.♘c4±) 24.♖xa6 ♕xb4 25.♕xb4 ♖xb4 26.♖xd6 ♖xb2 27.♖d8+ ♗f8 28.♗f1± and Black still has some problems in this endgame.



23.g3

23.♖a1!? f4 24.♗xa6 ♕a8 25.♘c2 ♕xd5 26.♕xd5 ♘xd5 27.♖d1=; 27.♗b7 ♘f6 28.b5± is, as usual in this variation, rather complex, but the b-pawn looks more dangerous.

23...♘g6

23...f4!? is an interesting suggestion by Rogozenco: 24.gxf4 ♘g6, but now White shouldn't give the pawn back with 25.♕c4 ♘xf4∓, and should prefer 25.f5! ♘f4 26.♗c4± instead.

24.♕c4?!

Why ease the tension? Black would still have to work hard after 24.♘c4!± ♖d8 25.♕e3, as White controls the queenside.

24...f4

24...♕d7?! is weak due to 25.♕c6±.

25.♕xc8 ♖xc8 26.gxf4 ♖b8

Now, definitely there is no more to it. 26...♘xf4 27.♗xa6 ♖b8 28.b5.

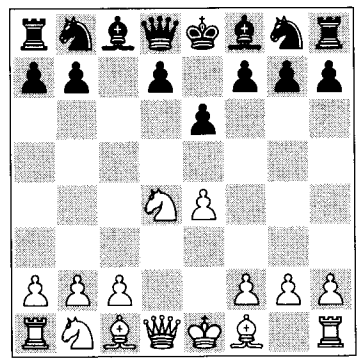
27.♗xa6 ½-½

SUMMARY
1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cd4 4.♘d4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e5 6.♘db5
– 6...h6: solid, but somewhat passive – 7.♗e3! ±
6...d6 7.♗g5 a6 8.♘a3 with the following options:
– 8...d5?!: complicated, but unsound ±
– 8...♗e6!?: White can keep control with accurate play ±
– 8...b5 9.♗f6 gf6 10.♘d5 ♗g7: White manages to control Black's counterplay without much trouble ±
10...f5 11.♗d3 ♗e6 12.0-0 ♗g7 and now:
– 13.♕h5 0-0?: losing, though quite common +–
– 13.♕h5 h6?!: White manages to control the position ±
– 13.♕h5 f4 14.c4 b4?!: passive, White gets a free hand ±
– 13.♕h5 f4 14.c4 bc4 15.♗c4 ♘d4: complicated. There is room for improvement ±
15.♗c4 0-0 16.♖ac1 and now:
– 16...♘d4?!: weak. White gets on top ±
– 16...♖a7?!: no problems for White ±
– 16...♘e7: logical, intending to break White's grip, but falls short ±
16...♖b8 and now:
– 17.b3 ♕a5: complicated, but has lost its initial appeal ±
– 17.b3 ♕d7 18.♖ad1 ♔h8 19.♕h4 ♗d5: fights for the d5-square, but White keeps control ±
– 17.b3 ♕d7 18.♖ad1 ♔h8 19.♕h4 f5: the most resilient line; White keeps a minimal edge ±
10...f5 11.♗d3 ♗e6 12.0-0 ♗d5! 13.ed5 ♘e7 14.c3 and now:
– 14...♖g8?!: ambitious but inaccurate ±
– 14...♕d7: perfecting the previous idea. White has to change plans ±
14...♗g7 15.♕h5 with these possibilities:
– 15...♕d7: solid, sharp and with room for research ±/=
– 15...e4 16.♗c2 ♕a5: speculative and risky ±
– 15...e4 16.♗c2 ♕c8: an imprecise move order ±
– 15...e4 16.♗c2 0-0!: the best. More research is required after 18.f3 ±/=
14...♗g7 15.♘c2 e4 16.♗e2 0-0
– 17.a4!?: a sound and not very explored plan ±/=

Section III

CHAPTER 9

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 moves: 4...♗c5; 4...♕b6; 5...♗c5 and 5...♕b6



Evaluation **

Introduction

I have decided to put all variations starting with ...♗c5 or ...♕b6 (on moves 4 or 5) in the same chapter for many reasons. First of all, my suggestions as refutation lines sometimes transpose; secondly, the basic ideas are common and lastly, there are many transpositions between them, even if White does not follow this book's suggestions and chooses a different approach instead.

My conclusions are far from encouraging for these lines, we could even label 5...♕b6 as refuted, so the individual chapter devoted to this variation has been eliminated. However, it scores quite reasonably. In my view, this is because White players haven't taken these lines seriously and they all have a high potential for counterplay. If White thinks that just retreating the attacked knight is enough and there will always be a small edge, he may be well making a mistake, and not just a psychological one. I think most positions where White just retreats the knight, especially those coming from 4...♕b6, offer Black rich play full of possibilities.

History

The variations 4...♗c5 and 5...♗c5 very often lead to mutual transpositions and have a parallel history. As in so many other Sicilian lines, their inventor was Louis Paulsen, who used them in several games against Morphy. In those years, some other players also used this set-up, but it soon fell out of favour due to the weakness caused on the dark squares.

In the 1970s the iconoclastic player Basman tried to revive it but didn't have many followers. Finally, in the mid-1990s, the Croatian IM Srdjan Sale started to play it regularly with excellent results and even published a Yearbook survey on it. In spite of all that, variations with ...♗c5 haven't made their way to world-class tournament practice.

On the other hand, 4...♕b6, which looks more modern, didn't appear until the 1990s. Its main champion was GM Kveinys, who achieved enviable scores with it. As a consequence, top players such as Judit Polgar, Epishin, Khalifman and Short have occasionally used it, but curiously enough, with very bad results.
The most surprising line is 5...♕b6. It appeared in some games of the Swedish player Bengt Svensson at the beginning of the 1990s. Almost immediately, Spanish GM Juan Manuel Bellon, who in its short history has become the main champion of this set-up, started to play it. In the first games, this provocative idea wasn't taken very seriously and many players tried a direct refutation, without great success. Nowadays this variation is still alive but I think that both suggested refutations are quite convincing.

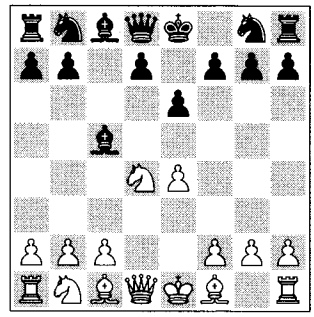
Ideas

Lines with ...♗c5 seem to follow an old strategy: quick development and tactical play. In its modern version, Black tries to keep his bishop on the aggressive a7-g1 diagonal and develop his kingside with ...♘e7, ...0-0 and ...f5, in order to launch an attack along the f-file. If White doesn't take this idea seriously, he can meet an unexpected disaster.
On the other hand, 4...♕b6 and 5...♕b6, in spite of many transpositions, have a more elaborate idea. We can say it is one of those cases where the seemingly secondary aim is actually the main one. Black tries to make White retreat the knight from d4 in order to set up a classical Sicilian development: ...♕c7, ...a6, ...b5, ...♗b7, ...♘f6, ...d6 and ...♘bd7. Problems arise when White refuses to retreat the knight.

Game 9.01

Teske,Henrik
Dobosz,Henryk
Austria tt-2 2004/05

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♗c5



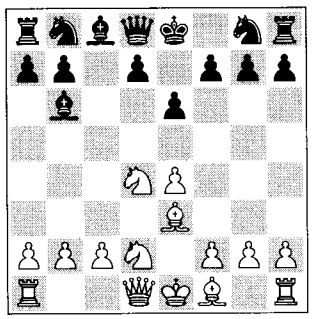
5.♗e3!?

This is the move I suggest, since nowadays the analysis seems to prove that it is hard for Black to stay afloat. However, for players who prefer something quieter, we suggest the following line: 5.♘b3 ♗b6 6.♘c3 ♘e7 7.♗f4, forcing Black to make a difficult choice: whether to allow a white bishop on d6, or to play 7...d5 8.exd5, where White has quite comfortable play against the isolated pawn. This analysis is not exhaustive, but the existing material on this variation is fairly manageable.

5...♕b6

Black must try to force the knight's retreat; other moves are weak:
O 5...d6?! 6.♘c3 ♘f6 (6...♘e7?! 7.♘db5+−) 7.e5 dxe5 8.♗b5+ ♗d7 9.♘xe6±;
O 5...b6?! 6.♘c3 ♘e7?! 7.♘db5 ♗xe3 8.♘d6+ ♔f8 9.♕f3+−.
O 5...♗b6!? gives White a pleasant choice: **6.♘d2** The easiest; 6.♘c3 ♘c6 7.♘cb5± is also promising, but

maybe the best move is the still untested: 6.♘b5 ♗xe3 7.♘d6+ ♔e7 8.fxe3±, though it leads to double-edged play after 8...♕c7 9.♕d4 ♕xd6. Now:



A) **6...♘e7** 7.♘c4 ♗c7 8.e5 ♗xe5 (8...0-0 9.♘b5±) 9.♘b5 ♗f6 10.♘bd6+ ♔f8 11.♗d3⩲;

B) **6...♘c6** 7.♘c4 ♗xd4 8.♗xd4 ♘xd4 9.♕xd4+−;

C) **6...d5** 7.exd5 ♕xd5 8.♕g4±.

O 5...♘f6 Not as bad as it seems, since the obvious 6.♘xe6? is met by 6...♕a5+. So White must play 6.♘c3 ♗b4 after which he has the pleasant choice between transposing to the Pin Variation with 7.e5 (see Chapter 10) or trying something more with 7.♘b5!?, for example: 7...♘xe4 (7...d5 8.e5 ♘e4 9.♕g4 g6 10.♗d3 a6 11.♗xe4 axb5 12.♗d3±) 8.♕g4 ♘xc3 9.bxc3 ♗f8 10.♕g3⩲.

6.♘a3!

A very logical choice, in line with the fight for the dark squares. At this moment I consider this move to be the strongest. I have no reason to think that this move, which was suggested in DLS, has lost its charm, since recent experiences have been rather favourable for White and it can be recommended without worries.

6...d5

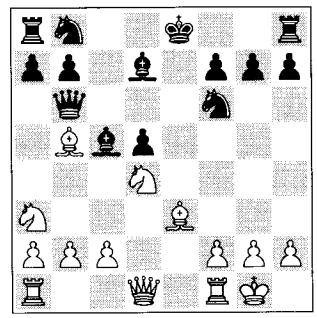
The natural reply, forestalling ♘c4.

O 6...♕a5+?! 7.♗d2 ♕d8 (7...♕b6? 8.♘c4! ♕d8 9.♘b5 d5 10.exd5 exd5 11.♗f4+− is a pure disaster) 8.♘db5 a6 9.♗e3± and there is no way to defend the d6-square.

O 6...♗xa3?! gives up an important bishop and many development tempi. 7.bxa3 ♕a5+ 8.♗d2 ♕e5 9.♘b5 a6 10.♗c3 ♕xe4+ 11.♕e2 ♕xe2+ 12.♗xe2+− Manik-Papp, Austria tt-2 2005/06; and both rooks are threatened.

7.♗b5+ ♗d7 8.exd5 exd5 9.0-0 ♘f6?!

White's reply was difficult to guess. 9...♘e7!? 10.b4 ♗xb4 11.♘f5 ♕f6 is not so clear, but White secures a pleasant edge with 10.♖e1! 0-0 11.♕d2 and now, if 11...a6 then 12.b4!.



10.b4! ♗xb4 11.♘f5 ♕a5 12.♘xg7+ ♔f8

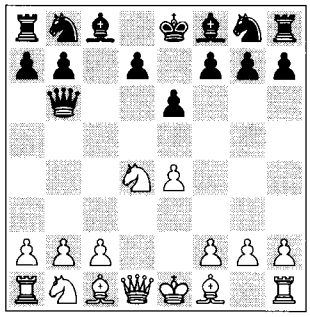
The line 12...♔d8 13.♗g5 ♗e7 14.♘h5 ♘xh5 15.♗xe7+ ♔xe7 16.♕xh5 (16.♕xd5) 16...♗xb5 17.♕e5++− is no improvement.

13.♘h5 ♗xa3 14.♕d4 ♘xh5 15.♕xh8+ ♔e7 16.♗xd7 ♘xd7 17.♕xa8 1-0

Game 9.02

Solak,Dragan
Djuric,Stefan
Vrnjacka Banja 2004

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♕b6



5.♗e3

Here I consider this to be the strongest move too, though in this case there may be a variation that puts this in the shade, for practical reasons: 5.♘c3 ♗c5 6.♘a4 ♕a5+ 7.c3 ♗xd4 8.♕xd4 ♘f6 9.♘c5 ♘c6 10.♕d6! b6 11.♘b3 ♘xe4 12.♕xc6! dxc6 13.♘xa5 bxa5 14.♗e3± with a very comfortable endgame.

5...♕xb2

Black must accept the challenge, but now everything depends on tactical analysis and up to this moment they all seem to favour White.
5...♗c5 is a transposition to the previous game.

6.♘d2 a6

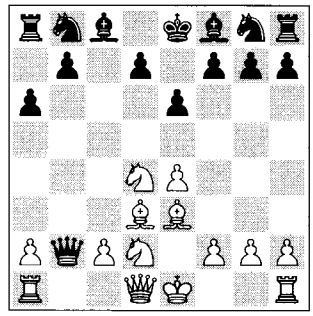
It is necessary to prevent the knight's jump to b5. The following lines show why:
O 6...♘c6?! 7.♘b5 and now there are two options:

A) **7...♕e5** 8.a3 d5 (8...♕b8 9.♘c4±) 9.g3 g5 (9...♕b8 10.exd5 exd5 11.♗f4+−) 10.♘f3 ♕b8 11.exd5 exd5 12.♗xg5+−.

B) **7...♘b4** 8.♖c1 ♘xa2 (8...♕e5 9.♘c4+−) 9.♖b1 ♕e5 10.♘c4 is also winning for White.

O 6...♗b4?! is even worse: 7.♘b5 ♕e5 8.f4! ♗xd2+ (8...♕xe4? 9.♘d6++−) 9.♔xd2+−.

7.♗d3



7...♕c3

7...♘c6 8.0-0! ♘xd4?! (8...b5 9.♘2f3 ♘f6 10.a4⩲; 8...d5 9.exd5 exd5 10.♖e1⩲) 9.♘c4 ♕c3 10.♗d2 ♘f3+ 11.♕xf3 ♕d4 12.♗e3±;
7...♗b4?! 8.0-0±.

8.0-0 ♕c7

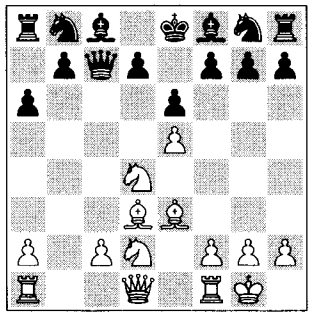
Black doesn't have anything better than to retreat his queen, in view of the dangerous threat 9.♘c4.

O 8...b5 9.a4! b4 10.♘c4±;

O 8...d5 9.exd5 exd5 (9...♕c7 10.dxe6 fxe6 11.♕h5+ ♕f7 12.♕h3 ♘f6 13.♖fe1 ♘c6 14.♘xc6 bxc6 15.♘c4 ♗e7 16.♘b6 ♖b8 17.♘xc8 ♖xc8 18.♗g5+−) 10.♖e1 ♗e7 11.♘2b3 ♔f8 12.♗d2 ♕c7 13.♖c1 ♘f6 14.c4±.

9.e5!

Hindering Black's development looks the best. 9.♖b1!? ♘c6 10.♘xc6 dxc6 11.♗b6 ♕d7 12.♘c4⩲.



9...b5

There isn't much practical experience, but Black has several options, for example:

O 9...♘e7?! 10.♘c4! (10.♗e4 ♘g6 11.f4 d5 12.♗d3 ♘c6 13.♘xc6 bxc6 14.c4 ♕d8 15.cxd5 cxd5 16.♖b1⩲ Plenkovic-Sax, Split 2008) 10...♘d5 11.♕g4 h5 12.♕e4 g6 13.a4 (13.♗f4!?) 13...♗e7 14.a5 ♘c6 15.♘xc6 dxc6 16.♗b6±.

O 9...d6!?, eliminating the outpost, is the critical line. 10.exd6 ♗xd6 11.♘c4 ♗xh2+ (11...♘f6 12.♘xd6+ ♕xd6 13.♖e1 0-0 14.♗g5 ♕d8 15.♕d2 ♖e8 16.♗h4 ♘bd7 17.♖ad1⩲) 12.♔h1 ♗f4 13.♕g4! ♗xe3 14.fxe3 g6 15.♕f4! (the queen is Black's best defender) 15...♕xf4 16.♖xf4 e5 17.♘xe5 ♘h6 18.♗c4 0-0 19.♖af1 ♘c6 20.♘xf7 ♔g7 21.♘d6 ♖d8 22.♘xc8 ♖dxc8 23.♘e6+ ♔h8 24.♗d5±.

O 9...♕xe5?! This makes it easier for the white pieces to get to the dark squares (b6): 10.♘c4 ♕c7 11.♘xe6 dxe6 12.♘b6±.

O 9...d5 gives White a wider choice: 10.c4 (10.exd6 transposes to 9...d6) 10...♘e7 11.f4 ♗d7 12.♖c1±.

10.f4

10.a4!? b4 11.♘c4±.

10...♘e7 11.c4 bxc4 12.♘xc4 ♘d5 13.♖c1 ♘c6 14.♗e4 ♘xe3 15.♘xe3 ♗b7 16.♘xc6 ♗xc6 17.♗xc6 dxc6 18.♕a4±

White has developed all his pieces and exerts strong pressure on Black's position, in return for a mere pawn.

18...♖c8 19.f5?

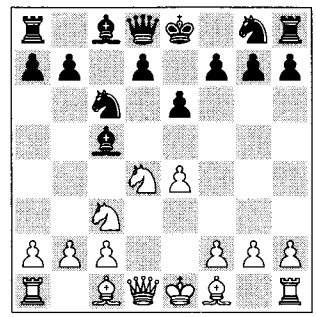
White rushes in, better is 19.♔h1 ♗e7 20.f5! and now the attack is really strong: 20...exf5? 21.♘xf5+–.

19...exf5 20.♘xf5 g6 21.♘d4 ♕b7 22.e6 fxe6 23.♘xe6 ♗b4 24.a3 ♕b6+ 25.♔h1 ♗e7 26.♖cd1 ♕e3 27.♘g7# 1-0

Game 9.03

Galkin,Alexander
Koster,Ramon
Hoogeveen 2001

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.♘c3 e6 4.d4 cxd4 5.♘xd4 ♗c5



6.♘db5!

6.♗e3!? is a less effective option, but its advantage is that it can be applied against all the three variations we have

already seen in this chapter. It leads to a seemingly promising position for White, but extremely complicated. If anyone wants to play this, I recommend him devoting some time to check all the tactical variations with a computer. 6...♕b6 7.♘db5 ♗xe3 8.fxe3 ♔f8 (8...♕xe3+ 9.♗e2 ♔d8 10.♕d6 ♘f6 11.♕c7+) 9.♕d6+ ♘ge7 10.0-0-0 ♕xe3+ 11.♔b1⩲ Y.Vovk-Marszalek, Warsaw 2008.

6...♕b6

Again, the pressure along the diagonal is the most logical approach. The other alternatives are, at the very least, odd:

O 6...d6 7.♘a4! a6 8.♘xc5 axb5 (8...dxc5 9.♕xd8+ ♔xd8 10.♘d6±) 9.♘b3± Rodriguez-Sanclemente, Somontano Open 2001.

O 6...a6? is the most common move in my database, but looks like complete nonsense: 7.♘d6+ ♗xd6 8.♕xd6± (Janowski-Marquez Sterling, Paris 1900) and Black has no compensation at all for the terrible holes in the dark squares.

O 6...♘f6 See Game 11.01.

7.♕d2!

Defending f2 and threatening ♘a4.

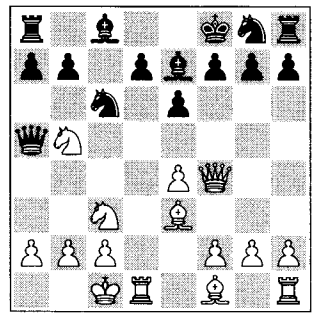
7...♗e7

O 7...a6 8.♘a4+− ♗xf2+ 9.♔d1 ♕a5 10.♘d6+ ♔e7 11.♕xf2 ♔xd6 12.♘b6 1-0 Hamdouchi-Dimitrov, Montpellier 2004.

O 7...♗b4 8.a3 ♗e7 9.♕f4 ♔f8 10.♗e3 e5 11.♗xb6 (11.♕g3! ♕a5 12.0-0-0+− is even stronger) 11...exf4 12.♗c7 a6 13.♘d6 ♘d4 14.0-0-0 ♘e6 15.♗b6 ♗xd6 16.♖xd6 (Ibanez Aullana-Buenafe Moya, Valencia 2003) and Black's position is completely ruined.

O 7...♘f6?! 8.♘a4+−.

8.♕f4 ♔f8 9.♗e3 ♕a5 10.0-0-0



Once again in this variation, Black has a miserable position.

10...♘f6 11.♘d6 ♕e5!?

The queen swap shouldn't be a relief for Black.

12.♕xe5 ♘xe5 13.♘xc8?!

But exchanging this powerful knight for the inactive bishop actually is. 13.h3! was stronger, intending 14.f4. If Black could hold, it would be a miracle.

13...♖xc8 14.♗xa7± ♗b4 15.♗d4 ♗xc3 16.♗xc3 ♘eg4

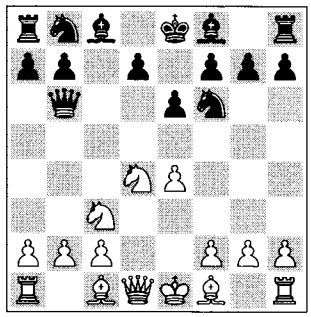
Black tries to restore the material balance, but his position doesn't allow such efforts.

17.♗d4 ♘e8 18.♗b5 ♘gf6 19.e5 ♘d5 20.♗xd7+− ♖c7 21.♗b5 ♖c8 22.c4 ♘e7 23.♔b1 1-0

Game 9.04

Van der Wiel,John
Lammens,Tim
Vlissingen 2000

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 ♕b6?!



Successful for some years, it looks like the end has come for this move.

6.e5! ♗c5 7.♗e3

7.♘db5! is a surprising but very strong move, and we may well consider it a complete refutation:

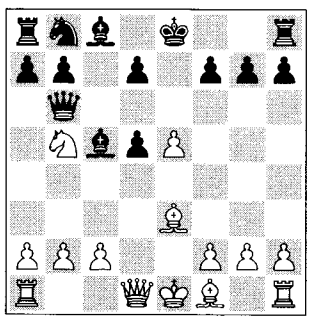
A) 7...♗xf2+? 8.♔e2 ♘g4 9.h3+− ♘xe5 10.♕d6 ♘bc6 11.♘c7+ ♔d8 12.♗g5+ f6 13.♘xe6+ ♔e8 14.♘xg7+ ♔f7 15.♕xf6+ ♔g8 16.♘h5 ♘d4+ 17.♔xf2 ♘e6+ 18.♗e3 ♕xb2 19.♕e7 1-0 Zenklusen-Bozinovic, Biel 2007;

B) 7...a6!? is the most resilient, but there are no practical examples: 8.exf6 axb5 9.fxg7 ♖g8 10.♕e2 ♖xg7 11.♘d5 ♕d6 12.♘f6+ ♔d8 13.♘e4± with the bishop pair, better structure and safer king.

7...♘d5!

7...♘g4 8.♕xg4 ♕xb2 9.♔d2+−.

8.♘xd5 exd5 9.♘b5!



The knight places itself between the enemy queen and the b2 pawn, which makes this infrequent move far better than 9.♘f5?! ♕xb2∞.

9...0-0

9...♗xe3!? looks odd, but it is the last hope in this line. 10.♘d6+! ♔e7 (nobody has tried this, though it is the computer's favourite choice. 10...♔d8 11.fxe3 ♕xe3+ 12.♗e2+−; 10...♔f8 11.fxe3! ♕xe3+ 12.♕e2 ♕xe2+ 13.♗xe2 ♘c6 14.♗f3 ♘xe5 15.♗xd5 f6 16.0-0±) 11.♘f5+ ♔d8 12.♘xe3 ♕xb2 13.♘xd5 (13.♖b1 ♕xe5 14.♗e2 ♘c6 15.0-0 d4!∞) 13...♕xe5+ 14.♗e2 ♖e8 and even though the position must be favourable for White, Black can still pose serious problems.

10.♗xc5 ♕xc5 11.♕d4! ♕xd4 12.♘xd4 ♘c6 13.0-0-0 ♘xe5 14.♘b5± ♘g4 15.♖d2 d6

Trying to hinder White's development with 15...♖e8 would run into 16.♗e2! ♘xf2 17.♘c7 ♘xh1 18.♘xe8 ♘f2 19.♗f3 ♘e4 20.♖xd5 ♘f6 21.♖e5!+−.

16.f3

16.♘c7 ♖b8 17.♘xd5± is also very comfortable.

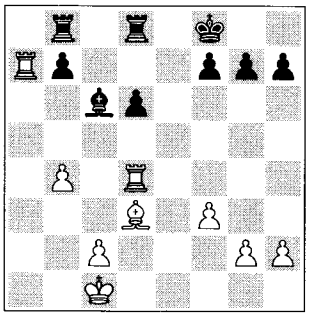
16...♘e3 17.♘c7 ♖b8 18.♘xd5 ♘xd5 19.♖xd5 ♖d8 20.♗d3±

Pressure against an isolated pawn and better development in an endgame: that's as much as we can ever dream to achieve in the opening.

20...♗e6 21.♖d4 ♖bc8 22.♖d1 ♗xa2?

Just creates a new weakness.

23.♖a4 ♗e6 24.♖xa7 ♖b8 25.♗b5 ♔f8 26.♖d4 ♗d7 27.♗d3 ♗c6 28.b4!



All Black's pieces are tied up, so White starts his active operations on the queenside.

28...♔e7 29.b5 ♗d7 30.♖c4 ♖dc8 31.♖xc8 ♗xc8 32.♔d2 ♔d8 33.b6! ♗e6 34.♔e3

And finally the king comes, with decisive effect.

34...♗d5 35.♗b5 ♖c8?! 36.♔d4 ♖c5 37.c4+–

And the b7 pawn drops.

37...♔c8??

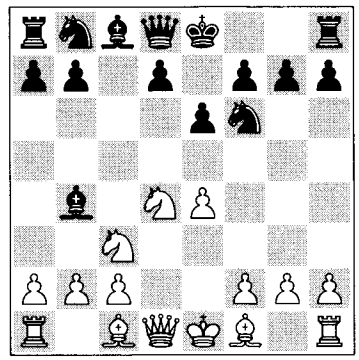
A comical ending to a sad game for Black.

38.♖a8# 1-0

SUMMARY
1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♗c5
Interesting as a surprise weapon, but risky
– 5.♗e3 ♕b6 6.♘a3!: Black suffers a lot on the dark squares ±
– 5.♘b3 ♗b6 6.♗f4: enough for a small edge without complications ±
1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 ♗c5
Similar to 4...♗c5
– 6.♘b5: the ambitious refutation ±
– 6.♘b3 ♗b6 7.♗f4: the positional one ±
1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♕b6
The soundest of the three moves. White must work seriously to get something from the opening
– 5.♗e3: tactically complex ±
– 5.♘c3 ♗c5 6.♘a4: more modest but sufficient for ±
1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 ♕b6?!
Is going through hard times
– 6.e5 ♗c5 7.♗e3 ♘d5 8.♘xd5 exd5 9.♘b5: ± Black is under strong pressure
– 6.♘db5 or 6.e5 ♗c5 7.♘db5: looks like a complete refutation, but there is not enough material for a conclusive assessment +–

CHAPTER 10

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 ♗b4 Sicilian Counterattack or Pin Variation



Evaluation **

Introduction

The Pin Variation is fairly popular among amateur players and can be an interesting surprise weapon in modern tournaments. Sometimes white players are not well prepared to fight in the extremely complex main lines and then Black can equalize or easily seize the initiative.

White can try to avoid this line by playing 3.♘c3, though this limits his options if Black plays for example the Paulsen. He can also meet an undesired transposition to the Nimzowitsch Sicilian. The most economical approach is to study the refutation and use it; other solutions just put off the problem. Those who want to play this line as Black must love risk but, above all, be willing to do research and analysis on their own.

History

Such an active-looking variation could not go unnoticed for long. Aggressive 19th century players like Anderssen or Janowski often used it. In the first part of the 20th century, first-rank players such as Alekhine or Tartakower, who gave it his name for some time, also played it occasionally. From the 1940s it disappeared from tournament practice and remained as a curiosity in opening books. However, around 1980 several players, Nogueiras and Speelman among them, seemed to rediscover the idea previously used by Swedish correspondence player Arne Bryntse, which involved an exchange sacrifice, and that revived the line for some years. Again, 7.♗d2 has cooled the excitement about this variation, but I repeat that it is easy to find it in open or rapid tournaments.

Ideas

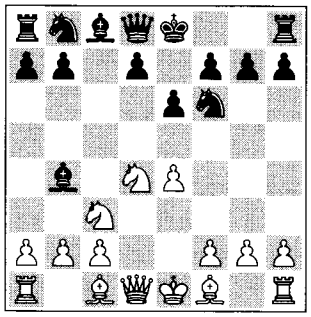
This variation is based on very straightforward chess, on development and direct threats, and it doesn't contain great positional ideas. However, we can mention an exchange sacrifice to get a solid

position and destroy the white structure, and of course the need for both players to pay attention to the initiative rather than material or static factors.

Game 10.01

Krogius,Nikolay
Korelov,Alexander
Erevan ch-URS 1962

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 ♗b4



The starting position for the Pin Variation or Sicilian Counterattack.

6.e5 ♘e4?!

The move we analyse in this game has a bad reputation in opening theory, and we won't contradict this opinion. However, it leads to great complications and that makes it appealing at certain levels and certain rates of play.

O 6...♕c7? After this, a forced line leads to an agonising position for Black. 7.exf6 ♗xc3+ 8.bxc3 ♕xc3+ 9.♕d2! ♕xa1 10.c3 (threatening both 11.♘b3 and 11.♗d3) 10...♕b1 11.♗d3 ♕b6 12.fxg7 ♖g8 13.♕g5! h6 (13...♕d8 14.♕xd8+ ♔xd8 15.♗g5++−) 14.♕f6 ♕d8 15.♕xd8+ ♔xd8 16.♗xh6 f5 17.♘xf5! exf5 18.♗c4 ♖e8+ 19.♔d2 ♘c6 20.♗f7 (20.♖e1!+−) 20...d6 21.♖e1 ♘e5 22.f4 ♔e7 23.g8♕ ♖xg8 24.♗xg8+− Kozakov-Todorov, Valjevo 2000;

O 6...♕a5? 7.exf6 leads to the same position as 6...♕c7;

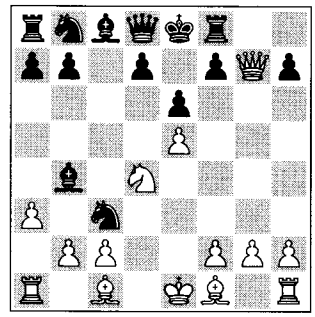
O 6...♘d5 will be examined in Game 10.02.

7.♕g4!

Now 7.♗d2 was not profitable, but this move hits simultaneously g7 and the knight and leads Black to a dead end, albeit one full of dangerous corners.

7...♕a5

O 7...♘xc3 is the most frequent move: **8.♕xg7 ♖f8 9.a3**



9...♕a5 Apart from this move, Black has many alternatives but all of them lead to an absolute disaster without complications.

A) 9...♘c6?! 10.axb4! ♘xd4 11.bxc3 is the most straightforward: 11...♘xc2+ (11...♘f5± is preferable) 12.♔d1 ♘xa1 13.♗g5+− Cabrera-Rodriguez, Camagüey 2000;

B) 9...♘b5+?! 10.axb4 ♘xd4 11.♗g5 ♕b6 12.♗h6! ♕xb4+ 13.c3 ♘f5 14.cxb4 ♘xg7 15.♗xg7 ♖g8 16.♗f6± (Szabo-Mikenas, Kemeri 1939) and in this materially equal position, the wonderful bishop on f6 is a great asset;

C) 9...♗a5? 10.♗h6 ♕e7 11.♘b3!+−.

10.♘b3! Here White must be more careful, but he will also get a decisive edge. **10...♕d5 11.♗d3 ♗e7 12.bxc3 d6?!** Black has some assets, but experience has crudely shown that the flaws in his position are more serious: 12...♘c6 13.♗f4 b5!? 14.a4!+–. **13.♗f4 ♘d7 14.c4 ♕c6 15.♘d4 ♕b6 16.♘b5!+–** Black is really helpless in the face of the threats posed by this knight. **16...dxe5 17.♗xe5 ♘xe5 18.♕xe5 ♕a5+ 19.♔e2 ♗d8 20.♖ad1 f6 21.♕h5+ ♔e7 22.♕xh7+ ♖f7 23.♕g8 a6 24.♗g6 1-0** W.Schmidt-Boidman, Bad Breisig Open 2000.

O 7...f5 was suggested and played by the German Rudolf Elstner in the 1960s.

8.♕xe4

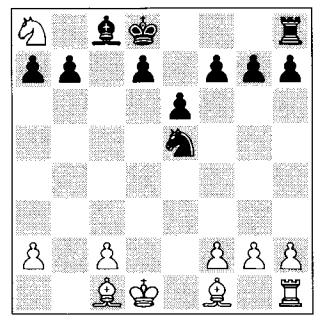
8.♕xg7! looks even stronger: 8...♗xc3+ (8...♖f8 9.♗h6!±) 9.bxc3 ♕xc3+ 10.♔e2 b6 (10...d5!?, suggested in DLS, looks to have been refuted in Advanced Chess: 11.♕xh8+ ♔d7 12.♘b3 b6 13.♗e3! and the white king escapes forward: 13...♗a6+ 14.♔f3+–) 11.♕xh8+ ♔e7 12.♗e3 ♗a6+ 13.♔f3 ♗b7 14.♔g4! ♘c6 15.♘xc6+ ♗xc6 16.♕g7 h5+ (16...♕xa1 17.♗d3 ♕xh1 18.♗xe4 ♔d8! 19.♗xc6 dxc6 20.♔h3! ♔c8! 21.♕f8+ ♔b7 22.♕xf7+ ♔a6 23.♕xe6±) 17.♔xh5 ♕xa1 18.♗d3? (18.f3!+–) 18...♕xh1 19.♗xe4 ♕xh2+ 20.♔g4 ♖h8?? (20...d5!=) 21.♗g5+ ♔e8 22.♕f6 ♕h5+ 23.♔f4 ♕h2+ 24.♔e3 ♔f8 25.♕d8+ ♔g7 26.♗f6+ ♔h6 27.♕xh8 mate Spoelman-Kuling, Tilburg 2008.

8...♗xc3+ 9.bxc3 ♕xc3+ 10.♔d1 ♕xa1 11.♘b5 ♘c6!

Black plays the most reasonable option, which leads him to an inferior but playable endgame.

Most of the analysis up to this moment has focused on the move **11...d5?!** but here it looks as though White has a decisive attack: **12.exd6!** 12.♕b4?! is another official refutation but, as Burguess points out, it may lead to a draw after 12...♘c6 13.♘c7+ ♔d8 14.♕d6+ ♗d7 15.♘xa8 ♕d4+! (provoking the white bishop to move to d3) 16.♗d3 ♕xe5 17.♗f4 ♕a1+!=. **12...♘a6 13.d7+! ♗xd7 14.♘d6+ ♔e7 15.♗xa6 ♗c6** 15...bxa6? 16.♘f5+ ♔f6 17.♕h4+!+–; 15...♔xd6!? is perhaps the move which poses most problems for White, but after 16.♕b4+! ♔c7 17.♕xb7+ ♔d6 18.♔e2! ♕e5+ 19.♗e3 ♔e7 20.♖d1 ♖ad8 21.c4! (with the idea ♗b5) 21...♔e8 22.c5 and Black is helpless in the face of c5-c6. **16.♘f5+ ♔e8** 16...♔d7 17.♕d3+ ♔c7 18.♕d6+ ♔b6 19.♔e2!+–. **17.♕b4! ♖d8+** 17...exf5 18.♖e1+ ♗e4 19.♗b5++–. **18.♘d6+ ♔e7 19.♔e2 ♕e5+ 20.♘e4+ ♔e8 21.♗xb7 ♗xb7 22.♕xb7 f5** The only way to recover material, but the endgame is hopeless. **23.♗g5 ♕xe4+ 24.♕xe4 fxe4 25.♗xd8 ♔xd8 26.♖b1! ♔c7 27.♖b4+–** Klundt-Taeger, Oberursel ch-GER 1972.

12.♘c7+ ♔d8 13.♘xa8 ♕xe5 14.♕xe5 ♘xe5



Quite an important moment. Black has two pawns for the piece and the white knight is trapped in the corner. Black could even win the game, but White has a very precise sequence to help his knight out and get the better chances.

15.♗a3!

The bishop aims at the d6-square to free the knight. **15.♗e3?!** is the automatic move, but after 15...b6! White is forced to give up his knight for two pawns and Black has a more compact structure that makes up for the bishop pair and the passed a-pawn: 16.♔d2 ♗b7 17.♘xb6 axb6 18.♗xb6+ ♔e7∓.

15...d5

This frees the d7-square and casts doubt on White's manoeuvre.
Other moves allow the a8-prisoner to escape easily: 15...b6?! 16.♗d6 f6 17.♘c7 ♘f7 18.♗g3+−.

16.♗d6 ♘g4

Manoeuvres are similar in other lines, for example: **16...♘c6** 17.♘c7 ♔d7 18.♗g3 a6 19.♘a8!± inevitably followed by ♘b6; **16...f6** 17.♔d2! (17.♗b8 ♘c6∞; 17.f4 ♘g4 18.♔e1 b6∞; 17.♘c7!? ♔d7 18.♘b5±) 17...b6 (17...♔d7 18.♗b8 ♘c6 19.♗b5+−; 17...♗d7 18.♘c7+−) 18.♘c7 ♔d7 19.♘b5± and the knight is free.

17.♔e1 ♗d7 18.♘c7 a6 19.♘a8! ♗a4!?

Convinced that he cannot trap the knight, Black captures a third pawn, but the white pieces become active and take control. 19...b5 20.♘b6 ♗c6 21.♗e2 ♘f6 22.♗e5 ♘e8 23.♔d2 f6 24.♗b8 ♔e7 25.a4+−.

20.♘b6! ♗xc2 21.f3 ♘f6 22.♔d2 ♗f5 23.♗e2+−

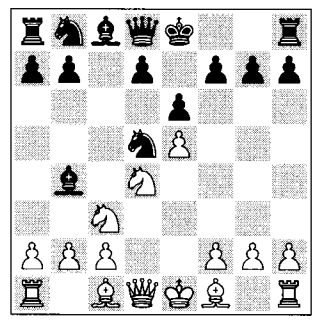
The white rook comes into play and that decides the game. The battle has been really exciting and extremely interesting for opening theory. Now White will still need to play a tough endgame. Fewer technical problems would arise after 23.♗e5!+−.

23...♘d7 24.♖c1 ♘xb6 25.♗c7+ ♔d7 26.♗xb6 ♖c8 27.♖xc8 ♔xc8 28.♔c3 ♔d7 29.f4 ♗e4 30.g4 f6 31.♔d4 ♔c6 32.♗a5 g5 33.♗d8! gxf4 34.♗xf6 f3 35.♗f1 a5 36.a3 b5 37.♗e7 ♗c2 38.♔e3 ♗d1 39.♗d3 e5 40.♗xh7 d4+ 41.♔f2 ♔d5 42.♗g8+ ♔c6 43.♗f6 ♔d6 44.h4 b4 45.axb4 axb4 46.h5 d3 47.h6 d2 48.♗xe5+ ♔c5 49.♗f4 b3 50.♗xd2 b2 51.♗h7 1-0

Game 10.02

Hansen,Sune Berg
Kristensen,Bjarke
Tastrup 1998

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 ♗b4 6.e5 ♘d5!?



The most serious move, which, combined with the idea of sacrificing the exchange, somehow revived the Pin Variation. White's play can't be as straightforward as in the previous line, but results have favoured him in recent years and the attacking plan has been polished up.

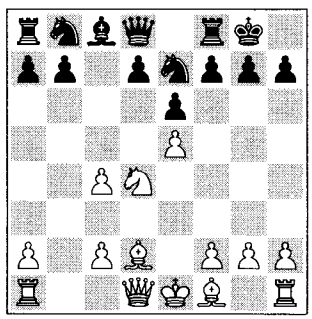
7.♗d2!

This move has made 6...♘d5 fall into disgrace. The old line 7.♕g4 0-0 8.♗h6 g6 used to give Black good counterplay.

7...♘xc3

The most logical reply. Black harms White's structure and at the same time keeps the bishop, which is vital to defend the dark squares. However, the alternative capture has also been tried.

7...♗xc3 8.bxc3 0-0 We have a double-edged position, but it is Black who runs immediate risks due to White's predator bishop pair and attacking prospects. **9.c4** 9.♗d3 has given good results as well. **9...♘e7** 9...♘b6 10.♗b4 ♖e8 11.♗d6±; 9...♕b6!? 10.♘f3! (Khalifman) 10...♘e7 11.♗d3 f5 12.exf6 ♖xf6 13.0-0±.

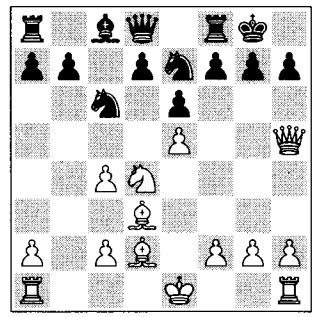


Now:

A) **10.♗b4?!** This move has been recommended but not widely used. Though it seems the most logical option, it meets a standard reply: 10...♘bc6! 11.♘xc6 ♘xc6 12.♗d6 (12.♗xf8 ♕a5+⩲) 12...♘xe5! (12...f6!?) 13.c3 f6 14.♗xf8 ♕xf8⩲;

B) However, the computer's first choice looks very interesting: **10.♗c3!?**, for example: 10...♘bc6 11.♘xc6 ♘xc6 12.♕d6±;

C) **10.♗d3 ♘bc6 11.♕h5!**

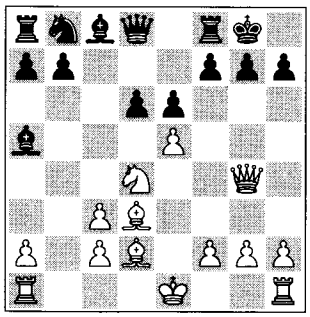


This provokes the weakening of the dark squares, which the bishop can no longer defend. **11...g6** 11...♘g6 12.♘f3! ♕c7 13.0-0 and since Black can't capture on e5, his cramped kingside faces an immediate danger. **12.♘xc6 ♘xc6 13.♕e2±** White just needs to finish his development and keep control, and he will be well on top. **13...f6 14.exf6 ♕xf6 15.0-0 b6 16.f4 ♗b7 17.♕e1** Getting ready to take control of the main diagonal with the dark-squared bishop. **17...d5 18.cxd5 exd5 19.f5!** 19.♗c3 wasn't possible on account of 19...d4, but now the f-pawn seriously damages the black castled position. **19...gxf5 20.♖xf5 ♕d6 21.♖g5+ ♔h8 22.♗xh7 ♖f6 23.♖h5 ♖af8 24.♗d3+ ♔g8 25.♖h8+ 1-0** Aseev-Steffens, Bad Wörishofen 1991.

8.bxc3 ♗e7

The natural and most popular retreat.

O 8...♗a5?! looks more active but leaves the kingside unprotected and White will pounce on this. 9.♕g4 0-0 10.♗d3 d6



11.♗g5!! This fantastic idea was suggested by Byrne and Mednis in *Chess Informant* 29. The bishop wants to join the attack with devastating effect. 11...♗xc3+ (11...♕c7 12.0-0 dxe5 13.♘b5 ♕c6 14.♗h6 g6 15.♕a4 ♗b6 16.♗e4 ♕e8 17.♕c4±) 12.♔f1 f5 (12...♕a5 13.♗f6 g6 14.♕g5 ♗d2 15.f4+−) 13.exf6 ♖xf6?! (Black has some other, highly interesting options here to stay alive, for example 13...♗xd4!? or 13...♕d7!?) 14.♗xh7+! ♔xh7 15.♗xf6 ♕xf6 16.♕h3+ ♔g8 17.♕xc3+−.

O 8...♗f8?! is odd but relatively common: 9.♕g4 a6 10.♗d3 h5 (Yegiazarian-Sulskis, Budapest 1996) and now after 11.♕e2 d6 12.exd6 ♗xd6 13.♘f5 White has a great advantage.

O 8...♗c5?! 9.♕g4 g6 10.♗d3 leaves holes on the dark squares and helps White's attack; for instance: 10...d6 11.♘b3 ♗b6 12.♗g5 ♕c7 13.exd6 ♕xc3+ 14.♔f1 ♘d7 15.♖e1± Ott-Ryba, Germany 2001.

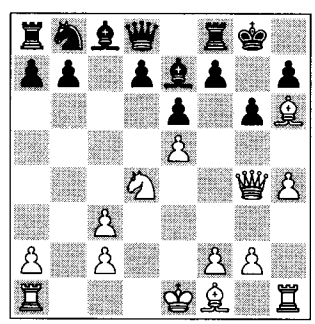
9.♕g4 0-0

Black insists on his thematic exchange offer, and White does better not to accept it. The alternatives to defend the g7-pawn aren't appealing either.

O 9...g6!? is a quite sensible alternative still lacking respect at top-level. Black can hope to castle queenside. **10.♘b5!?**, recommended by Khalifman and DLS, is strategically logical, but wastes time and allows Black counterplay: 10.♗d3! ♘c6 11.♘xc6 dxc6 12.0-0 ♕a5 13.♖fe1 is by far the soundest option and my main suggestion. **10...0-0** 10...♘c6!? 11.♘d6+ ♗xd6 12.exd6± with good attacking chances, though White has burned his bridges and is forced to take concrete action; 10...a6?! 11.♘d6+ ♗xd6 12.exd6 ♕b6 13.♕b4± according to Khalifman. **11.h4! ♘c6 12.♕g3 a6 13.♘d6 ♕c7 14.♗f4 f6?!** 14...♕a5 15.♘c4 ♕d8 16.h5±. **15.h5!±**.

O 9...g5!? A move hardly ever played. 10.♘b5! (the best) 10...h5 (10...d6 11.exd6+−) 11.♕e4! ♘c6 12.♗d3± according to Khalifman.

10.♗h6 g6 11.h4!



White utterly disdains the exchange offer and launches a brutal attack. Up to this day, and despite Black having tried almost everything, White's strategy has been a total success.

11...♕a5

O 11...d6? is the logical central reaction, but too late: **12.h5 ♕a5** 12...dxe5 13.hxg6 fxg6 14.♗xf8 exd4 – 14...♕xf8 15.♘xe6 ♕f6 16.♗c4+– – 15.♗xe7 ♕xe7 16.♗d3! ♗d7 17.♖b1 b6 18.cxd4+– Klovans-Schein, Graz Open A 1999. **13.♘b5!** The key move that delays Black's queenside counterplay just one move, enough for White to round up the enemy king. **13...a6 14.hxg6 fxg6 15.♗xf8 axb5** 15...♗xf8 16.♖h7!+–; 15...♔xf8 16.♖xh7 axb5 17.♕f3++–. **16.♔d2 ♗xf8** 16...♔xf8 17.♖xh7+–. **17.♖xh7!**+– 1-0 Lalic-Sulava, Pula 1997.

O 11...♕c7 12.♕g3 ♖e8 13.h5! (always the same theme) 13...♗f8 (13...d6 14.hxg6 fxg6 15.♘b5+–; 13...♘c6 14.hxg6 fxg6 15.♘b5 ♕b8 16.♘d6+–) 14.hxg6 fxg6 15.♘b5 ♕c5 16.♗d3 ♗xh6 17.♖xh6 ♕f8 18.♖xh7 ♖e7 19.♕xg6+ ♖g7 20.♕h5 1-0 Coelho-Yano, Rio de Janeiro tt-jr 1999.

O 11...♘c6?! hits the centre too, but it is easy to refute as well: 12.♘xc6 bxc6 13.h5 f5 (13...♕a5 14.♕g3! ♖e8 15.hxg6 hxg6 16.♖d1+– followed by ♕h2) 14.♕g3 (14.♕h3!? g5 15.♗xf8 ♗xf8 16.♕e3+–) 14...g5 15.f4 g4 16.♗xf8+– Lawson-Trottier, Quebec-ch 2001.

O 11...♖e8? tries to free the f8-square for the bishop but is also slow. 12.h5 ♗f8 13.hxg6 fxg6 14.♗d3! (no respite for Black) 14...♖e7 15.♗g5 ♕c7 16.♗xe7 ♕xe5+ 17.♔f1 ♗xe7 18.♖xh7 1-0 Hellers-Ziska, Pohja tt 1985.

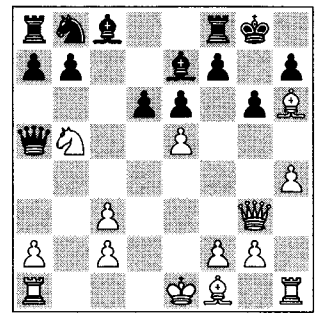
12.♕g3 d6

Black keeps playing with logic. Here there are alternatives as well, though the choice is limited:

O 12...♖d8 13.h5 (this looks more than enough, but White has an even simpler way in 13.♗g5!? ♖e8 14.♘b5±) 13...d6 14.hxg6 fxg6 15.♗f4 dxe5 16.♗xe5 ♖d5 17.f4 ♘d7 (17...♗d6 18.♗xd6 ♖xd6 19.♕h3! h5 20.♕g3+–) 18.♗c4 ♘xe5 (18...♖xe5+!? 19.fxe5 ♕xe5+ 20.♕xe5 ♘xe5 21.♗b3±) 19.♗xd5 ♕xd5 20.fxe5 ♕e4+ 21.♔d2 ♗d7 22.♖ae1 ♕d5 23.♕h3 (23.♖xh7!! ♔xh7 24.♖h1+ ♔g7 25.♕h2 ♔f7 26.♕h7+ ♔e8 27.♕xg6+ ♔d8 28.♖h8++–) 23...♗g5+ 24.♔d1 h6 25.♕d3± Wedberg-Pokojowczyk, Copenhagen 1984.

O 12...♘c6?! This definitely falls short. 13.♘xc6! bxc6 14.h5 d6 (14...♖d8 15.hxg6 fxg6 16.♗d3 ♕xc3+ 17.♔e2+–) 15.♗xf8 ♗xf8 16.hxg6 hxg6 17.♖d1 ♗g7 18.♖xd6 ♗xe5 19.♖d8+ ♔g7 20.♖h7+ J.Willemze-M.Smits, Hengelo jr 1994.

13.♘b5!



The standard way to neutralize the queen. In comparison to previous lines, here Black has forced White to play a more passive move (♕g3) than h4-h5.

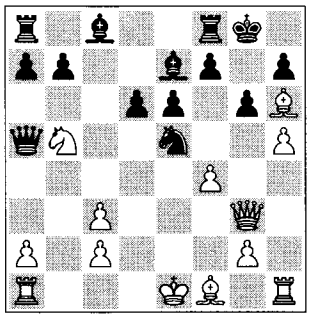
13...♘c6

13...♖d8?! meets a quick finish: 14.h5! dxe5 (14...♘c6 15.hxg6 fxg6 16.exd6±) 15.hxg6 hxg6 (15...fxg6 16.♕xe5+−) 16.♗g5 and the dark squares are full of holes; 16...♗xg5 17.♕xg5+−;
13...♘d7 14.h5! and 14...♘xe5 is forced, transposing.

14.h5! ♘xe5

Against 14...♖d8?! White plays as usual: 15.hxg6 fxg6 (15...hxg6 16.♕h3+−) 16.exd6 ♗xd6 (16...♗f6 17.♕h3+−) 17.♕h3+−.

15.f4!



Before taking on g6, White must drive the knight off.

15...♗d7

Offering material makes a lot of sense and allows Black definitely to free his position. However, we'll soon see that there is not enough compensation for the lost exchange. Therefore, this was the last chance to consider the knight retreats:

O 15...♘c6?! 16.hxg6 fxg6 17.♗xf8 ♗xf8 18.♕h4 h6 19.♕f6+− with an exchange and the initiative.

O 15...♘d7!? 16.♗d3! (preparing the lethal blow on g6. The direct pawn exchange is not so clear, as the rook may then get to f6: 16.hxg6 fxg6 17.♗d3 ♖f6 18.♗g5 ♘c5 19.♗xf6 ♘xd3+ 20.♕xd3 ♗xf6∞) 16...♘c5! (to get rid of the bishop. 16...♗f6?! 17.hxg6 ♗xc3+ 18.♔e2 fxg6 19.♗xg6! ♗xa1 20.♘xd6+−) 17.hxg6 ♘xd3+ 18.♕xd3 fxg6 19.♗xf8 ♗xf8 20.♘xd6± and again there is no compensation for the exchange.

16.fxe5 ♗xb5 17.♗xb5 ♕xb5 18.♗xf8 ♖xf8

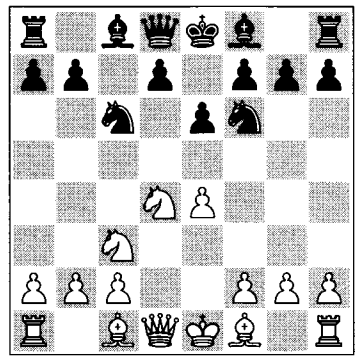
18...♗xf8!? 19.hxg6 (19.exd6 ♖d8 20.♖d1 ♗g7 21.♕d3 Czarnota-Sulskis, Warsaw Ech 2005) 19...hxg6 20.exd6± is similar to the game.

19.exd6 ♗g5 20.♖d1 h6 21.d7 ♕f5 22.♖d3 ♖d8 23.hxg6 ♕e4+ 24.♔f2 f5 25.♕f3 ♕a4 26.♕e2 ♕f4+ 27.♖f3 ♕d6 28.♖d1 ♕e7 29.♖fd3 ♔g7 30.♖e1 ♖xd7 31.♖xd7 ♕xd7 32.♕xe6 1-0

SUMMARY
1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cd4 4.♘d4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 ♗b4 6.e5
– 6...♘e4 7.♕g4 ♘c3: actually unsound, but very complicated +−
– 6...♘e4 7.♕g4 ♕a5: also dubious, though less clear than the previous line ±
– 6...♘d5 7.♗d2 ♗c3: extremely delicate for Black ±
– 6...d5 7.♗d2 ♘c3 8.bc3 ♗a5: very complicated, but offers White a tremendous attack ±
– 6...♘d5 7.♗d2 ♘c3 8.bc3 ♗e7: the most solid line, but White still has a strong attack ±

CHAPTER 11

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 ♘c6



Evaluation ***

Introduction

This variation hasn't made a place for itself among the big Sicilian lines. However, it is played by a wide range of players, from amateurs to grandmasters, including, though not very often, top players. It has its virtues, though. On the one hand, Black can easily seize the initiative against indecisive play. Also, Black has some compensation in the two lines where White is supposed to aspire to get an edge. In the case of 6.♘xc6 Black develops interesting counterplay in several lines and, in the case of 6.♘db5, Black can choose between a transposition to the Pelikan or a somewhat inferior but solid position with 6...♗b4, which is precisely the line we are going to study. If a strong attacking player or a dangerous theoretician plays as White, this variation can neutralize his strong points. Therefore, it is a sensible approach to be a complete player, able to adapt to any position and situation.

History

It is hard to talk about independent history in a variation like this, so full of transpositions. Most players have used it just to switch to their pet system. If we focus on independent lines, we can see that this move order was already highly appreciated in the 19th century and used by Anderssen, Paulsen (who else) and later, Blackburne, Tarrasch and Mieses. After about 1920, its popularity started to decline and it was adopted by second-rate players.

Since 1970, thanks to the Pelikan's popularity, many players took a look at this move order to use it as an alternative to the classical move order, and thus avoid certain lines. This is why some players such as Dolmatov, Nunn, Illescas, Krasenkow, and especially Leko added it to their repertoires, whereas other Pelikan experts like Kramnik never wanted to hear about this order. However, the independent line, the one we study here, is far less

popular, though recently players such as Grischuk and Kortchnoi have given it a try.

Ideas

One of the features of this variation is the possibility to transpose to virtually anything. Actually, perhaps the main idea behind the order ...e6, ...♘c6 and ...♘f6 is to transpose to the Pelikan, whilst avoiding lines such as the Rossolimo. If we focus on the independent lines, an essential virtue of Black's set-up is that, if White plays a 'normal' move, i.e. 6.♗e2, 6.♗e3, 6.♗c4 and others, the pin after 6...♗b4 is really annoying. In the main line, 6.♘db5 ♗b4, Black intends to have free piece play and to prevent the attacks on his king, so typical in other Sicilian variations, though in order to achieve this some important concessions, such as relinquishing the bishop pair, have to be made.

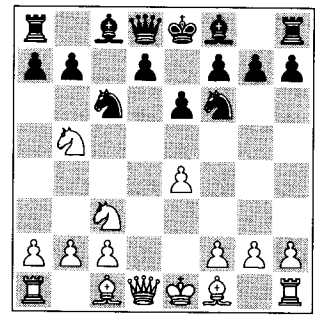
Game 11.01

Ehlvest,Jaan
Romero Holmes,Alfonso
Logrono 1991

1.e4 c5 2.♘c3 e6 3.♘f3 ♘c6 4.d4 cxd4 5.♘xd4 ♘f6

This line is very popular among medium-level players. There are many reasons for this: the simplest one is that it poses specific problems (...♗b4 is coming) that most white moves just can't solve; the most important reason is that White is prevented from developing his classical attacking play in the Sicilian, and black players may be happy about that.

6.♘db5



6...♗b4

O 6...d6 Our suggested move 6.♘db5 allows this transposition to the Pelikan: 7.♗f4 e5 8.♗g5 (see Chapter 8). Players wishing to avoid that variation should be well aware of that.

O 6...♗c5 This variation, championed by Swedish IM Hall, has some sting and is known as the Cobra. White should take it seriously and be content with a small edge. Trying to refute it may be risky. **7.♗f4!** 7.♘d6+ ♔e7 8.♘xc8+ ♖xc8 9.♗d3 is an alternative attempt that I can recommend to those who don't enjoy exploiting small technical advantages. **7...0-0 8.♗c7! ♕e7 9.♗d6 ♗xd6 10.♕xd6** inevitably leading the game to an ending in which White's better structure offers a more pleasant life. **10...♘e8** The move sponsored by the 'champion' of this variation, Jesper Hall. He has never lost with this move, but Black has always suffered. The attempt to maintain the queens on the board leads to a cramped position, due to White's control of the d-file and particularly the d6-square. 10...♕d8?! 11.♘c7! ♖b8 12.♗e2 b6 13.e5! ♘e8 14.♘xe8 ♖xe8 15.f4 ♗b7 16.♗f3 ♘e7 (16...♘a5 is a bit sharper but after 17.0-0! ♘c4 18.♕d4 ♗xf3 19.♖xf3 d5 20.exd6 ♘xd6 21.♖d1± White maintains an

annoying grip) 17.♗xb7 ♖xb7 18.0-0-0± Galkin-Kabanov, Kazan 2005. **11.♕xe7 ♘xe7 12.0-0-0 f5!?** This is the idea. Black's pieces become active after the changes in the pawn structure and it becomes clear that White is not well positioned to set up an adequate blockade of the hanging pawns that arise in the centre. **13.♘d6 ♘xd6 14.♖xd6 fxe4 15.♘xe4 ♘f5 16.♖d2 d5 17.♘g5!** The knight moves to control e5. **17...♗d7** Or 17...b6 18.♘f3 ♘d6 19.♗d3 ♘b7 20.c3 ♘c5 21.♗c2 a5 22.♖e1 a4 23.♘e5± Carlsen-Vidoniak, Gausdal 2005. **18.♗d3 g6 19.♘f3 ♘d6 20.h4** (20.♖e1!?) **20...♗b5 21.♗xb5 ♘xb5 22.h5 ♘d6** The black knight heads for e4. **23.hxg6 hxg6 24.♘g5!±** Tissir-Bellon Lopez, Malaga 2003. It is not much, but we would all prefer to play as White.

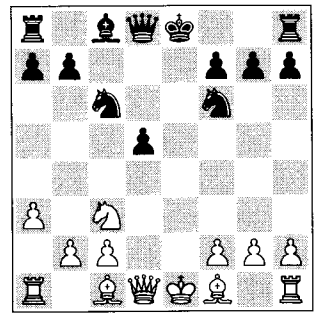
O 6...a6?! has been played a lot in old games, but has no logic whatsoever: 7.♘d6+ ♗xd6 8.♕xd6± and White gets the dark squares for nothing.

7.a3 ♗xc3+ 8.♘xc3 d5

8...0-0 may be a good attempt to improve on the ...♘xd5 variation, for example: 9.♗d3 d5 10.exd5 (10.0-0!? can now transpose to a very sound line, while avoiding the almost level endgame) 10...♘xd5 (10...exd5 transposes to the game) 11.♘xd5 ♕xd5 12.0-0 ♖d8 13.♗e3± and even though Black has a reasonable position, the bishop pair gives White a persistent edge.

9.exd5 exd5

Thus, one of the most controversial positions in opening theory, from a positional perspective, has arisen.



White has the bishop pair and Black has an isolated pawn. In spite of this, a good deal of tournament practice shows that these advantages are not easy to exploit. This is usually attributed to the black pieces' free play, but I think that the bishop pair and the isolated pawn are two advantages which don't combine together very well. Actually, the best scenario for White is to trade his two bishops for the black knights and then place his own knight on d4.

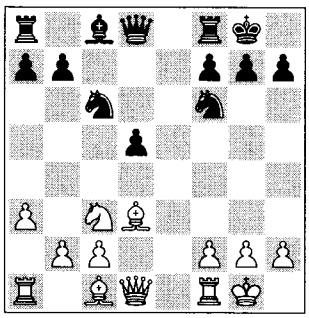
9...♘xd5 is not very popular. Black avoids the isolated pawn, but then a position arises where the bishop pair is actually a real asset: 10.♗d2! 0-0 11.♕h5!? ♘xc3 (11...g6 12.♕h6 ♕b6 13.0-0-0, with a good attack; 11...♘f6 12.♕h4 ♕d4 13.♕xd4 ♘xd4 14.0-0-0±, De Vreugt-Ortega Ruiz, Aviles 2000, and the importance of the bishop pair grows in the endgame) 12.♗xc3 e5 13.♗d3 g6 14.♕h6 ♕f6 15.0-0± Tal-Liberzon, Kislovodsk 1964.

10.♗d3 0-0

10...d4 is far less frequent because, though it simplifies the position further, it also makes it easier for White to exploit his assets. 11.♕e2+! (11.♘e2 ♗f5!= is Black's idea) 11...♗e6 (11...♕e7 12.♕xe7+ ♔xe7 13.♘e2 ♖d8 14.♗g5± makes Black's position

more uncomfortable) 12.♘e4 ♘xe4 13.♕xe4 ♕d5 14.♗f4± Illescas Cordoba-Sorokin, Palma de Mallorca 1989. White's pieces occupy excellent central posts.

11.0-0



11...♗g4

It is not clear that the idea behind this move (provoking f2-f3 or placing the bishop on g6) helps Black, but it is true that it forces White to play somewhat accurately, as we will see.

O 11...d4! is the main move and will be studied in Games 11.02 and 11.03.

O 11...h6?! An odd move, but quite common nevertheless. 12.♗f4! d4 (12...a6 13.♖e1 d4 14.♘e4± Areschenko-G.Kuzmin, Kramatorsk 2003, and the d4 pawn is in danger, for example: 14...♘xe4 (14...♘d5 15.♕f3! ♘xf4 16.♕xf4±) 15.♗xe4 ♕f6 16.♗xc6!±) 13.♘b5 ♘d5 14.♗g3 ♗e6 (14...f5?! has been tried but is too naive: 15.c4! dxc3?! 16.♗c4+−) 15.♖e1 ♕d7 16.♘d6 ♖ad8 17.♕f3. The powerful position of the white knight poses many problems for Black: 17...♕e7 (Polgar-B.Stein, Dortmund 1990; 17...♘de7 18.♕e4 g6 19.♕f4 ♕c7 20.h3±) and now 18.♘c4! intending ♖ad1 and ♘e5, increasing the pressure on the d4 pawn, gives White a very comfortable edge.

12.f3 ♗h5

12...♗e6?! is a strange decision, because f2-f3 is a useful move for White unless the black knight gets to e3 or the check on b6 makes sense, which does not happen here. 13.♗g5! ♕b6+ (13...d4? 14.♘e4) 14.♔h1± ♕xb2? 15.♕d2!+−.

13.♗g5

Preventing the knight from getting to e3 and also preventing the thematic push ...d5-d4.

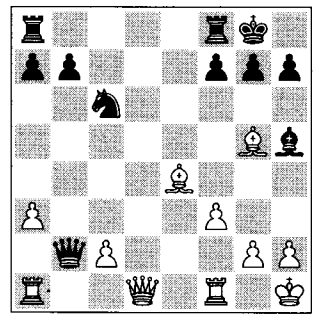
13...♕b6+

This check allows the queen to unpin. 13...♕d6 14.♗xf6! ♕xf6 15.♘xd5± wins a pawn; 15...♕xb2? 16.c3!+−.

14.♔h1 ♘e4

The point of Black's idea, but it merely forces events to arrive at an inferior endgame.

15.♘xe4 dxe4 16.♗xe4 ♕xb2



17.♕b1!

This forces Black to swap queens to avoid the loss of a pawn, which leads to an endgame where the bishop pair and the pressure along the b-file give White a considerable edge.

17...♕xb1 18.♖fxb1 f5 19.♗d3 b6 20.♖b5±

20.♖e1!? may be better in view of the note to Black's next move.

20...♗g6?!

Very passive. 20...♘d4!?, improving the knight's position and preventing the ideal co-ordination of the white pieces: 21.♖b4 (21.♖d5? ♘xf3!=) 21...♘e6 22.♗h4±.

21.♖d1 ♖ac8 22.♖d5

The white rooks are occupying dominant positions and now 23.♗a6 and 23.♖d7 are annoying threats.

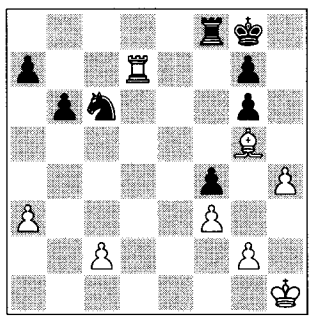
22...f4?!

Again, this unnecessarily forces events. 22...♘a5 23.♖d7 ♖f7 24.♖d4±.

23.♗xg6 hxg6 24.h4 ♖c7

24...♘a5 25.♖d7 ♖xc2 26.♖xa7±.

25.♖d7 ♖xd7 26.♖xd7±



White has consolidated a series of assets and can look to the future with optimism.

26...♖f5 27.♖d6 ♘e5 28.♖d4 ♘c6 29.♖c4!

Cutting out all counterplay. 29.♖xf4 ♖c5∞.

29...♘a5 30.♖c8+ ♖f8

30...♔h7 31.♖c7±.

31.♖xf8+ ♔xf8 32.♗xf4+–

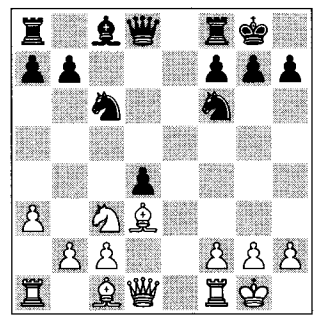
White is a pawn up and has a good bishop: the game is decided.

32...♘c4 33.♗c1 ♔e7 34.♔h2 ♔e6 35.♔g3 ♔f5 36.a4 a6 37.c3 b5 38.axb5 axb5 39.♔h3 ♘e5 40.♗a3 g5 41.hxg5 ♔xg5 42.♗d6 ♘d7 43.g4 ♘b6 44.f4+ ♔f6 45.♗e5+ ♔f7 46.♔g3 ♘c4 47.♔f3 g5 48.♔e4 gxf4 49.♗xf4 ♔e6 50.♔d4 ♘b6 51.♗e5! ♘d5 52.♗h8 b4 53.c4 ♘f4 54.♗g7 ♔f7 55.♗h6 ♘e2+ 56.♔d3 b3 57.♗d2!+– ♔e6 58.♗c3 ♘f4+ 59.♔d2 ♔d6 60.♗f6 ♘e6 61.♔c3 ♘c5 62.♗d4 1-0

Game 11.02

Reinaldo Castineira,Roi
Ortega Ruiz,Jose
Aviles Ech-jr 2000

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 ♘c6 6.♘db5 ♗b4 7.a3 ♗xc3+ 8.♘xc3 d5 9.exd5 exd5 10.♗d3 0-0 11.0-0 d4



The most popular move, for good reasons. Black gains the d5-square for his

pieces, while restricting the c-file and getting a possible outpost on e3. White must be very flexible and use sound, but also concrete, ideas against all possible black set-ups.

12.♘e2 ♖e8

Apart from this natural developing move, Black players have tried virtually all the possible moves in this position:

O 12...h6?! prevents ♗g5, but there is another sharp way of deploying the bishop. 13.b4! (a recurring plan once the pawn has reached d4: all the white pieces can coordinate against the d4 pawn and Black must soon think of searching for counterplay) 13...♗g4 14.f3 (14.♗b2 ♘d5 15.♕d2 ♗xe2 16.♗xe2 ♘c3 17.♗xc3 dxc3 18.♕xc3 ♘d4 (Timoshenko-Begun, Minsk 1996), and now 19.♗g4!± also wins a pawn and compensation is far from clear) 14...♗e6 15.♗b2 ♕d5 16.b5 ♘e5 17.♘xd4!± wins a pawn and Black still has a lot to prove.

O 12...♕d6 lures the bishop to f4, in order that the black queen can occupy the d5-square, without being harassed by the knight. 13.♗f4! ♕d5. An excellent position for the black queen, where she supports ...♗f5 and ...♘e4, but: 14.c4! dxc3 15.♘xc3 ♕d4 16.♘e2 ♕d5 17.♕c2 ♗e6 18.♖ad1± Ivanovic-Guimaraes, Budva zt 1981, and the centre is so open that the bishop pair is a good asset, though the black position is very solid.

O 12...♕b6!? Not very usual, but in no way inferior to other moves. 13.b4 ♗g4 14.♗b2 ♖ad8 15.♕d2 ♖fe8 16.♖fe1± with a certain pressure on the d4 pawn, which White can increase with ♕f4 and ♖ad1.

O 12...♗g4 and **12...♕d5** will be examined in the next game.

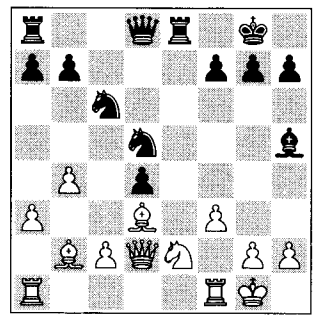
13.b4!?

White gathers an army against the d4 pawn. I think this plan is effective here, but the alternative 13.♗g5!? should be equally strong. The ideas are similar to the 12...♗g4 line.

13...♘d5

The most frequent and logical reply to White's plan. **13...♗g4** 14.f3 ♗h5 15.♗b2 ♘d5 16.♕d2 transposes to the game; **13...a6** 14.♗b2 ♗g4 15.f3 ♗e6 16.♖f2 ♔h8 17.b5 axb5 18.♗xb5± seems to win a pawn, though there is still a lot of work to be done.

14.♕d2 ♗g4 15.f3 ♗h5 16.♗b2



White's pressure is reaching its critical point and therefore Black's decision is crucial:

16...♘e3?!

Only this move has been tried over the board, but I don't think it is the best option:

O 16...♕b6!? 17.♖fe1! (17.♖f2 ♖ad8∞) 17...♖ad8 (17...a6?! 18.♔h1 and the pawn falls: 18...♖ad8 19.♘xd4! ♖xe1+ 20.♖xe1 ♘dxb4 21.axb4 ♘xd4 22.♕f2+−) 18.b5. It looks as if White is winning the pawn, but we still have to analyse further: 18...♗xf3! 19.gxf3

♘e5 20.♔f2! ♕d6⩲ – somewhat speculative, but hard to deal with.

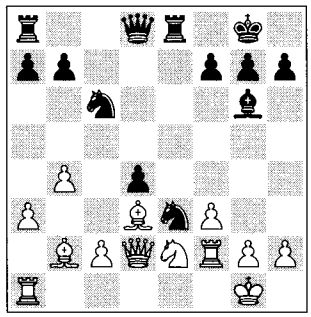
O 16...♗g6!? 17.♘xd4 ♗xd3 18.♘xc6 (18.♕xd3?? ♘f4!–+; 18.cxd3? ♕b6∓) 18...bxc6 19.♕xd3 ♕g5± with some compensation for the pawn.

17.♖f2?!

17.♖fe1! wins the pawn in virtually all lines, with minimal complications: 17...♗g6 18.b5! (18.♘xd4 ♘xd4 19.♖xe3 ♖xe3 20.♕xe3 ♘xc2 21.♗xc2 ♗xc2 22.♕c3 ♕b6+ 23.♔h1 ♕g6 24.♖c1 ♗f5 25.♕c7±) 18...♘e5 19.♘xd4 ♘5c4 20.♗xc4 ♘xc4 21.♕c3±.

17...♗g6!

17...♕b6 18.♘xd4 ♖ad8 19.♖e1 ♘xd4 20.♖xe3 ♘xf3+ 21.♖exf3!+–



18.b5?!

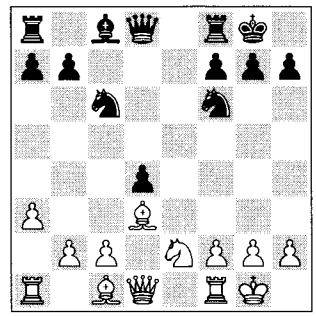
White doesn't seize the second and last chance to get a concrete edge: 18.♗xg6! hxg6 19.♘xd4 ♘c4 (19...♕b6 20.♘xc6 ♕xc6 21.♕d4±) 20.♕c3 ♘xb2 (20...♘6e5? 21.f4! ♘xb2 22.fxe5 ♘a4 23.♕c4 ♕d7 24.♖af1+–) 21.♘xc6 bxc6 22.♕xb2± with an extra pawn but still some technical difficulties.

18...♘e5 19.♗xg6 hxg6 20.♗xd4 ♘5c4 21.♕d3 ♕g5 22.♗xe3 ♘xe3 23.♘d4 ♘d5= 24.♕d2 ♘f4 25.g3 ♖ad8 26.c3 ♘h3+ 27.♔g2 ♕h5 28.♖e2 ♘g5 29.♖xe8+ ♖xe8 30.h4 ♘e6 31.♕e3 ♔f8 32.♘xe6+ ♖xe6 33.♕d3 ♕e5 34.♖d1 ♔g8 35.♖d2 ♕e1 36.a4 ♕a1 37.♕c4 ♖e1 38.♖d8+ ♔h7 39.♕xf7 ♖e2+ 40.♔h3 ♕f1+ 41.♔g4 ♖e4+ 42.f4 ♕e2+ 43.♔h3 ♕f1+ ½-½

Game 11.03

Tiviakov,Sergey
Maliutin,Evgeny
Montecatine Terme 1994

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘c6 5.♘c3 ♘f6 6.♘db5 ♗b4 7.a3 ♗xc3+ 8.♘xc3 d5 9.exd5 exd5 10.♗d3 0-0 11.0-0 d4 12.♘e2



12...♕d5

One of the two most popular moves in this position. Here the queen provokes the knight to jump to f4, so that it hinders the bishop's development.

12...♗g4 is the other main line, even more frequent than 12...♕d5, but we suggest a well-known plan against it: **13.f3!? ♗h5 14.♗g5** Intending to attack the d4 pawn with all the pieces;

now the bishop can do so from f2 and disturb Black in the meantime. Also possible is 14.b4, as in Game 11.02. **14...♕d6 15.♕d2 ♗g6** The most natural option: there is no other place for the bishop. More common is 15...♘d5 but then White has a logical though still untested reply: 16.c4! dxc3 17.♘xc3 ♕c5+ 18.♖f2 ♘xc3 19.♖c1 h6 20.♗e3 ♕e5 21.♕xc3± and White has an ideal position to exploit the bishop pair. **16.♖ad1 ♖ad8 17.♗xg6 hxg6 18.♗e3!?** The most straightforward, but it was also possible to keep the pressure by means of 18.♖fe1. **18...♖fe8 19.♘xd4 ♖xe3 20.♕xe3 ♘xd4** And now: **21.♔f2!?** leads to a more difficult endgame for Black: **21...♕b6 22.c3 ♘c6 23.♕xb6 axb6 24.♖xd8+ ♘xd8 25.♖d1 ♘c6 26.g4±** White has some initiative, though the defensive barrier set up by the black knights seems hard to break.

13.♘f4!

White must take advantage of Black's offer to switch to another plan to use his initiative.

13...♕d6 14.♘h5

The complement to the previous move: the knight leaves its place to the other white pieces.

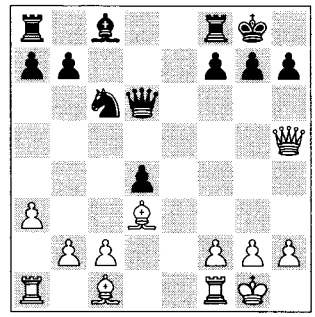
14...♘xh5

The most frequent and logical, though it facilitates White's task. Other moves have obvious drawbacks:

O 14...♘g4 15.♗f4! ♕d5 16.♘g3 ♗e6 17.♖e1 ♘f6 18.♘e4! This move hasn't been tried yet, even though it leads to an almost identical position to that studied in the 12...h6 line: 18...♘xe4 (avoiding the exchange is worse now: 18...♘d7?! 19.c4! dxc3 20.♘xc3 ♕a5 21.♘b5±) 19.♗xe4 ♕d7 (19...♕c5 20.♕d3±) 20.♕h5 g6 (20...h6?! is very risky: 21.♗xh6 gxh6 22.♕xh6 f6 23.♕g6+ ♔h8 24.♖ad1 ♘e5 25.♕h6+ ♔g8 26.♖e3±; 20...f5 21.♗d3±) 21.♕c5± with a very active position and strong pressure.

O 14...♘d5 15.♕f3 ♖e8 (15...♘e5 16.♕g3±) 16.♗d2 ♗e6 17.♖ae1 ♖ad8. The white pieces already occupy excellent positions and can easily improve on the previous games, for example: 18.♖e2!? (18.♘xg7!? deserves more research) 18...♖e7 19.♖fe1 f6 20.♗f4! ♕d7 (20...♘xf4 21.♕xf4!+−) 21.♕g3± posing the threat 22.♖xe6.

15.♕xh5



15...h6

The logical defence. ...g6 weakens the dark squares and ...f5 is really ugly.

16.♖e1 ♗d7 17.♕h4

17.g3!? Anand tried this in a rapid game and it looks like a promising alternative: 17...♖fe8 18.♗f4 ♕f6 19.♕d5 ♗h3 20.♕d6!±.

17...♖fe8 18.♗d2

Better than the more obvious ♗f4.

18...♘e5

18...♖e6 19.♖xe6 ♕xe6 20.♖e1 ♕g4 (20...♕d6?! 21.♕e4±) 21.♕xg4 ♗xg4± gives White his dream ending.

19.♗f4

Threatening ♕g3.

19...♕c5 20.♕g3! ♘g6?

If any other game arrives at this position, which is quite unlikely, play would continue 20...♘xd3 21.♗xh6 g6 22.cxd3±.

21.♗xg6 fxg6 22.♕xg6+–

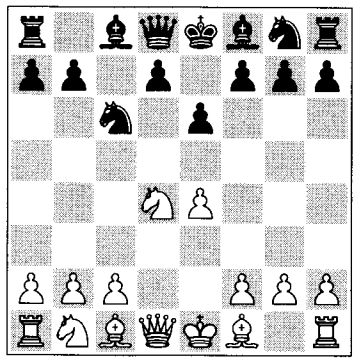
Now White has an extra pawn plus the attack.

22...♖xe1+ 23.♖xe1 ♗f5 24.♕g3+– ♗xc2 25.♗xh6 ♕f8 26.♖e5 ♔h8 27.♗d2 ♕f6 28.h4 ♖c8 29.h5 ♗h7 30.♗g5 ♕f8 31.♖e7 ♖c1+ 32.♔h2 ♖c2 33.♕e5 1-0

SUMMARY
1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cd4 4.♘d4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 ♘c6 6.♘db5
– 6...♗c5: unknown and dangerous, but White can keep a small edge with quiet play ±
6...♗b4 7.a3 ♗c3 8.♘c3 d5 9.ed5 ed5 and now:
– 10.♗d3 d4: White has a comfortable endgame ±
– 10.♗d3 0-0 11.0-0 h6?!: gives the white pieces too much freedom ±
– 10.♗d3 0-0 11.0-0 ♗g4: White gets a better endgame after avoiding some tactical details ±
10.♗d3 0-0 11.0-0 d4 12.♘e2 and now:
– 12...h6 ?!: no problems for White here ±
– 12...♕d6: leads to a better endgame for White ±
– 12...♕b6!?: little known and not worse than the rest ±
– 12...♖e8: one of the most solid lines. White must come after the d4-pawn ±
– 12...♗g4: similar to the previous one, though it involves different plans ±
– 12...♕d5: White can force an interesting initiative ±

CHAPTER 12

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘c6
Taimanov Variation



Evaluation ****

Introduction

The Sicilian order 4...♘c6, which we call the Taimanov Variation, is strongly related to 4...a6 (Paulsen). Both share lots of branches that arise over the next few moves.

The names of these Sicilian Variations aren't completely fixed either. We can find other names such as Kan Variation, especially in Soviet sources. This set-up shares variations with the Scheveningen as well; it is well-known that many players use it to play a Scheveningen while avoiding the Keres Attack (6.g4), or even the English Attack if possible. The main drawback of 4...♘c6 (compared to 4...a6) is that it allows 5.♘b5, leading to a pseudo-Hedgehog set-up not to all players' taste. That's why the move order 2...♘c6 and 4...♕c7 followed by ...e6 is extremely interesting, as it seems to reduce the strength of the white knight's jump to b5. On the other hand, the presence of the black knight on c6 exerts immediate pressure on d4 and hinders the building of a Maroczy formation. For some years the set-up with ♗e3, ♕d2 and 0-0-0 was thought useless here, but in the last two decades not only has its viability has been proved, but this has even become the main line and my recommendation.

History

The move order 4...♘c6 was often used by Anderssen and some other 19th century players, but it soon fell into disuse due to the (apparent) strength of what was then known as the Szen Variation, 5.♘b5, which actually leads to a Maroczy formation. This idea would later be applied in many other positions. It was in 1960 when Taimanov, up to that moment a big supporter of the Paulsen, apparently realized that this move order was not that bad after all and that it also had some advantages. From then on, Taimanov championed

this variation with great energy and in spite of some disasters, like his match against Fischer, he gained supporters among top players. Kasparov used it in World Championship matches, though later he gave up on it. Nowadays, many world-class players have this variation in their repertoires.

Ideas

For the sake of clarity, in this section I will highlight the ideas of this variation in comparison to its twin variation, the Paulsen. They share the basic idea that, thanks to the defence of the e6 pawn (an important weak link in many Sicilian variations), White attacks based on pushing the kingside pawns become somewhat less dangerous.

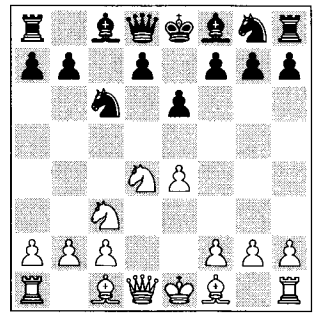
This circumstance makes the Taimanov and Paulsen ideal defences for ambitious positional players. Another common idea is the pressure on e4 along the diagonal, stronger in the Paulsen due to the absence of a knight on c6. Differences include a frequent knight swap on d4 followed by the manoeuvre ...♘ge7-c6 and pressure on d4, preventing an immediate setting up of the Maroczy formation.

Game 12.01

Waitzkin,Joshua
Maiwald,Jens Uwe
Bermuda 1997

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 e6 5.♘c3

Some players prefer to force Black to adopt a Hedgehog formation, but we will focus on this move, which is not only the most frequent, but especially the most consistent with our repertoire.



Now Black has a wide and important choice.

5...a6

O 5...♕c7, the main move in this chapter, will be studied in Games 12.04 to 12.08.

O 5...♘f6 transposes to positions studied in Chapter 11.

O 5...d6 6.♗e3 and now ...♘f6 and a transposition to Chapter 18 would be normal, but in recent games black players have followed different paths to try to reduce the danger of White's kingside pawn push:

A) **6...♗e7** doesn't have independent significance: 7.♕d2 a6 8.0-0-0 and it is hard to play without ...♘f6;

B) **6...♘ge7** 7.♘b3 ♘g6 (7...a6 transposes to the game: 8.f4 ♘g6) 8.f4 ♗e7 9.♕f3 0-0 10.0-0-0 a6 11.h4!→;

C) **6...a6 7.♕d2 ♗d7!?** This is the most frequent independent plan. 7...♘f6 8.0-0-0 transposes again; 7...♕c7 8.0-0-0 b5 9.♘xc6 ♕xc6 10.e5! d5 11.♘e2 is an ideal French for White. **8.f3** This move is not necessary to carry out the plan with 0-0-0 yet, but White intends something different if the knight is not deployed via f6. 8.0-0-0 ♘ge7 9.♘xc6 (9.♘b3! may be a good idea here too) 9...♘xc6 10.♘a4 b5 11.♘b6± and White's bishop pair is almost a sym-

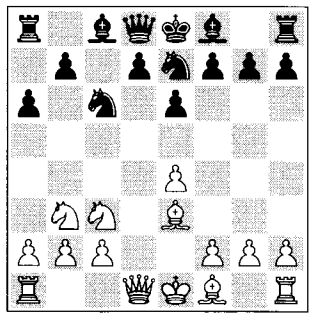
bolic asset. Luther-Bischoff, Halkidiki tt 2002. **8...♘ge7 9.♘b3 b5** 9...♘c8 10.a4 and in this line, the c8 knight has wasted more tempi and does nothing. 10...♗e7 11.♗e2 0-0 12.0-0 ♕c7 13.f4± De la Villa Garcia-Yudasin, Pamplona 1991/92. **10.a4! b4 11.♘a2 ♕b8** 11...♕c7!?; 11...a5?! 12.c3±. **12.♖d1 ♘g6 13.♗c5!±** Reinaldo Castiñeira-De Firmian, Las Palmas Open 1999.

6.♗e3 ♘ge7

O 6...♕c7 transposes to the following games.

O 6...♗b4?! is bad here on account of 7.♘xc6 ♗xc3+ (7...bxc6 8.♕d4±; and 7...dxc6 8.♕xd8+ ♔xd8 9.0-0-0+± are too comfortable for White) 8.bxc3 bxc6 9.♕d6 f6 10.♖b1!± and White's grip on the dark squares is overwhelming: 10...♘e7 11.♗b6 and 1-0 Koller-Luffy, cr 1987.

7.♘b3



Preventing Black's plan, that is, to trade knights and then develop the other knight to c6. Now, sooner or later Black will have to waste more time with the e7 knight, and it probably will end up on a square worse than f6.

7...♘g6

Maybe Black is defining the position of this knight too early. Other moves which have been tried are:

O 7...d6 8.h4!? (of course, moves such as 8.♗e2 planning 0-0, or 8.♕d2 planning 0-0-0, are also satisfactory) 8...b5 9.h5 h6 (Black can't allow the enemy pawn to reach h6, but now his kingside is no longer safe for the king) 10.♕d2 ♗b7 11.0-0-0 ♘c8 12.f4 ♘b6 13.e5 d5 14.♕f2 ♘d7 (14...♘c4 15.♗xc4! bxc4 16.♘c5±) 15.♔b1 ♗b4 16.♘e2 ♕c7 17.♘ed4 ♘xd4 18.♘xd4 0-0-0 19.♖h3± and White has the better prospects because of his kingside space advantage and firm control of the d4-square, Tseshkovsky-Taimanov, Moscow 1999.

O 7...b5?! Now the queenside pawns come quickly in contact: 8.a4! (White has lots of good plans, for example: 8.♕e2!? with clearly aggressive intentions: 8...♘e5 9.0-0-0 Arizmendi Martinez-Corral Blanco, Mondariz tt 2002; or 8.♗c5, but the text variation is forced and simple) 8...b4?! (8...bxa4 9.♘xa4± and the weakness of the b6-square is noticeable) 9.a5! ♘xa5 (9...bxc3? 10.♗b6+−; 9...♗b7 10.♘a4±; 9...♘f5!?, still untested, may be the best move but yet it doesn't solve all Black's problems: 10.♗b6! ♕f6 11.♘a4 ♘h4 12.♕d2 d6 13.f4± and the black pieces are badly placed) 10.♘a4 ♘xb3 11.♗b6 ♘xa1 12.♕xa1± Zaderman-Taimanov, New York 1992.

8.f4

8.♘a4 b5 9.♘b6 ♖b8 10.♘xc8 ♕xc8 11.f4 ♕c7 with the idea ...♘a5-c4 and in spite of the bishop pair, White has no advantage at all.

8...d6

8...b5 9.♕d2 d6 10.♕f2 (White can be at ease, since there is no need to worry about the e4 pawn) 10...♗d7 11.h4 ♗e7 12.h5 ♘f8 13.h6 g6 14.0-0-0± Djurovic-Portisch, Niksic 1962; **8...♗e7** 9.g3 and it is difficult not to transpose to the game.

9.g3±

Planning to push the h-pawn to displace the enemy knight again and provoke weaknesses on the kingside.

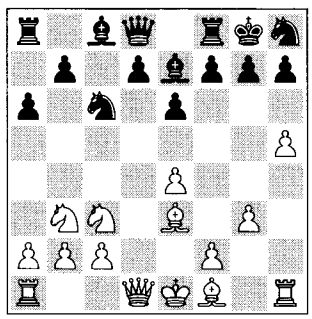
9...♗e7

9...b5 10.h4 ♗e7 11.h5 ♘f8 12.♕d2 ♗b7 13.0-0-0 ♖c8 14.♗h3± Muir-S.Arkell, Plymouth ch-GBR 1989.

10.h4 0-0

A strange decision, driven by the desire to give the knight a square for retreat. In any case White, who has a safe shelter on the queenside and a promising initiative on the kingside, is somewhat better.
10...h5? 11.♗e2; 10...♗f6 11.♕d2±.

11.h5 ♘h8



12.a4!?

An ambitious plan, which tries to exploit the weakness of the b6-square, in conjunction with the offside knight. The position allows this, but natural plans also offer some advantage, for example: 12.♕d2±; 12.h6 g6 13.♕d2±.

12...b6 13.♕d2 ♕c7 14.g4 ♗d7

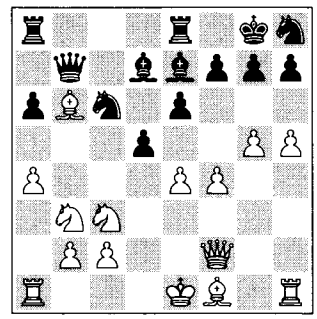
14...♗b7 15.♕f2 (15.0-0-0!?) 15...♗d8 16.g5±.

15.g5 ♖fe8 16.♕f2 ♕b7!?

Black finds a way to dispense with the defence of the pawn, but now White's pawn assault is well advanced and the white king can move to the kingside. 16...♖eb8 17.♗g2±; 16...♖ab8 17.♗xa6±; 16...♗d8 17.♗g2±.

17.♗g2

17.♗xb6?! allows some reaction by means of 17...d5!, for example:



18.e5? (18.♗e3 d4 19.♗xd4 ♘xd4 20.♕xd4 e5!⩱; 18.♗g2!? ♖ab8 19.a5 e5⩲) 18...d4!∓ and suddenly Black wins.

17...b5 18.axb5 axb5 19.0-0 f6?!

Black's desire to bring the knight back into play is understandable (I guess he's now wondering why he didn't develop it on f6 in the first place), but this just doesn't work. Somewhat better was 19...♖xa1 20.♖xa1 b4 (20...♖a8 21.♖xa8+ ♕xa8 22.♘xb5±) 21.♘e2 ♖a8 22.♖xa8+ ♕xa8 23.h6 g6 24.♘ed4±.

20.gxf6 ♗xf6 21.e5!±

This moves opens a diagonal full of black pieces while gaining time.

21...♖xa1

21...dxe5? 22.♘c5 ♕c8 (22...♕c7 23.♘xb5+−) 23.♖xa8 ♕xa8 24.♘xd7+−; 21...♗e7 22.♘a5 ♕c8 23.exd6 ♗xd6 24.♘xb5±.

22.♖xa1 dxe5

22...♗e7 23.exd6 ♗xd6 24.h6 g6?! 25.♕d2!+−.

23.♘c5 ♕c8 24.♘xb5±

White's pieces are really active, though the weakness of the back rank forces him to calculate carefully.

24...♘f7 25.♖d1?!

Inaccurate. There is no reason to move from the wing file. 25.fxe5 ♗xe5 (25...♘cxe5 26.♖a8+−; 25...♘fxe5 26.♘d6+−) 26.♘a7 ♘xa7 27.♖xa7 ♖d8 28.b4±.

25...♖d8 26.c3 ♗e8 27.♖f1 exf4 28.♗xf4 e5 29.♗e3 ♘e7

29...♘d6? 30.♘xd6 ♖xd6 31.♘e4 ♖e6 32.♗h3+−.

30.♘a7 ♕g4

The game has come into a purely tactical stage and it is not clear that White is still in control.
30...♕b8!? 31.♘e4 ♘d5 32.♘xf6+ ♘xf6 33.♘c6 ♗xc6 34.♗xc6±.

31.♘e4 ♗h4 32.♕f3 ♕xf3 33.♗xf3 ♘d5 34.♗c5 ♘f4 35.b4 ♘h6 36.♖d1! ♘e6

36...♖xd1+ 37.♗xd1 ♗xh5 38.♗xh5 ♘xh5 39.b5±.

37.♗f2 ♘f5 38.♖xd8 ♗xd8 39.b5±

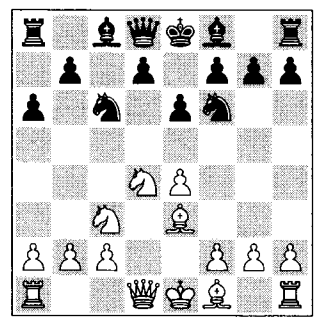
After the heavy pieces are gone, the queenside passed pawns become major figures and decide the game.

39...♘f4 40.♗g4 g6 41.hxg6 hxg6 42.b6 ♘d3 43.b7 ♗c7 44.♘f6+ ♔f7 45.♘xe8 ♔xe8 46.♘b5 ♔d7 47.♗a7 ♔c6 48.♘xc7 ♔xb7 49.♘b5 ♔a6 50.♗e2 e4 51.c4 ♔a5 52.♘c3 ♘g3 53.c5 ♔a6 54.♗b6 ♔b7 55.♗d1 ♘e5 56.♔f2 ♘f5 57.♘xe4 ♘d7 58.♗a5 ♔a6 59.c6+− ♘e5 60.c7 ♔b7 61.♘c5+ ♔c8 62.♗e2 1-0

GAME 12.02

Radjabov,Teimour
Lutz,Christopher
Gothenburg Ech-tt 2005

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘c6 5.♘c3 a6 6.♗e3 ♘f6



This is a cunning attempt to transpose to Taimanov or even Scheveningen lines, while avoiding English Attack set-ups, since now 7.♕d2 would be dubious because of the pin ...♗b4. However, White has very good re-

sources to prevent his opponent from reaching the desired positions.

7.f4!

This is my suggestion. White tries to exploit the drawbacks of Black's move order, above all the lack of control over e5. Now Black can't transpose to normal variations, though he has many alternatives at his disposal:

7...♗b4

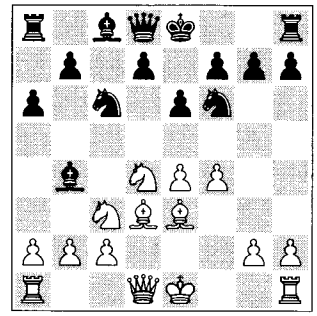
O 7...d6!? is the main alternative, trying to take the game into Scheveningen paths, but 8.♕f3! also exploits the lack of flexibility of Black's set up and transposes to a line where the c6 knight doesn't combine well with ...a6. Also, this line is characterized by violent attacks, just the kind of thing Black was trying to avoid with 6...♘f6. We'll see it in the next game.

O 7...♕b6?! Not tried in practical play yet, but this is the typical annoying move that someone will come up with one day. 8.♕d2! ♕xb2 (inserting the knight jump to g4 wouldn't allow a decent capture on b2 either: 8...♘g4 9.♗g1 ♕xb2 10.♖b1 ♕a3 11.♗e2 ♘f6 12.♖b3 ♕e7 13.e5± and it is hard to believe that Black can survive the attack) 9.♖b1 ♕a3 10.♖b3 ♕a5 (10...♕e7 11.e5 ♘g4 12.♘e4 ♕d8 13.♘xc6 dxc6 14.♕xd8+ ♔xd8 15.♗b6+ ♔e8 16.h3 ♘h6 17.♔f2± and in spite of the queen swap, Black is crushed) 11.♘xc6 dxc6 12.♗b6 ♕h5 13.♗e2 ♕g6 14.e5 ♘d5 15.♘xd5 cxd5 16.0-0± and the queen's bad position will cause Black a lot of trouble.

O 7...♕c7?! and other moves allow e4-e5.

O 7...d5!? 8.e5 ♘d7 transposes to a French variation rather favourable for White, who has an excellent score with 9.♕g4!, for example: 9...♘xd4 10.♗xd4 g6 11.0-0-0 ♕a5 12.h4 h5 13.♕h3 ♗c5 14.♔b1 ♗xd4 15.♖xd4± Dvoiris-Samarin, Podolsk 1992.

8.♗d3



Black is again at a crossroads.

8...d6

O 8...♕c7!? has hardly been played, despite being probably the most logical move. I suggest two different approaches, because some transpositions can be disturbing. White can accept a curious transposition to the Taimanov, depending on the opponent's repertoire, or try a more straightforward approach. **9.0-0** 9.♕f3!? d6 (9...b5 10.♕g3 0-0 11.0-0 ♗xc3 12.bxc3 ♗b7 13.♘xc6 ♕xc6 14.♗d4±; 9...♗xc3+ leads to a double-edged position where the absence of the dark-squared bishop is too dangerous for the second player: 10.bxc3 d6 11.♕g3 0-0 12.0-0 ♗d7 13.e5! dxe5 14.fxe5± ♕xe5?? 15.♘xc6+–) 10.0-0 ♗d7 11.♖ad1 ♘xd4 12.♗xd4 e5 13.fxe5 ♗xc3?! (13...dxe5 14.♕g3!±) 14.♗xc3 ♗g4 15.♕g3 ♗xd1 16.exf6+– Kaiumov-Atamuradov, Uzbekistan ch 1972. Now:

A) **9...0-0?!** 10.e5 ♗xc3 11.bxc3 ♘d5 12.♖f3!↑;

B) On **9...d6** 10.♘a4! is my recommendation: 10...e5 (10...♘xd4 11.c3! ♗xc3 12.♖c1 e5 13.♘xc3⩲) 11.♘b3 ♗g4 12.♗e2 ♗xe2 13.♕xe2 d5 (13...exf4 14.♖xf4±) 14.c3 ♗e7 15.♘b6 ♖d8 16.exd5 ♘xd5 17.♘xd5 ♖xd5 18.f5 0-0 19.♘d2±;

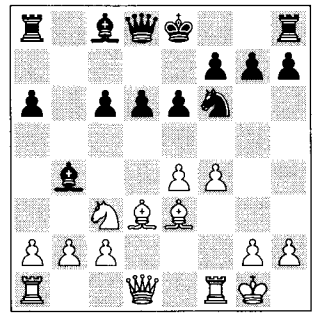
C) **9...♘xd4** 10.♗xd4 ♗c5 11.♗xc5 ♕xc5+ 12.♔h1 d6 13.♕e1! e5 (13...b5?! 14.e5 dxe5 15.fxe5 ♘d7 16.♘e4 ♕xe5 17.♕b4; 13...0-0 14.e5 dxe5 15.fxe5 ♘d7 16.♕e4 g6 17.♖ae1 ♖b8 18.♕h4) 14.fxe5 ♕xe5 15.♘d5±;

D) **9...♗c5!** This is the way to transpose, and the best move: 10.♘f5 ♗xe3+ 11.♘xe3± d6 12.♔h1 b6!.

O 8...♕b6!? This poses very specific problems for White and the odd thing is that it hasn't been played more often. In my opinion, White must reply **9.♘f5!?** This move involves a piece sacrifice we can consider quite promising, until time gives its final verdict. Some computer programs insist on suggesting 9.♔f2!?; I don't quite believe it yet, but I mention it in case someone wants to go more deeply into it. 9...♘xd4 10.e5 is the idea. **9...♕a5 10.♘xg7+ ♔f8 11.♗d2 ♔xg7 12.a3 ♗e7 13.♘d5 ♕d8** (13...♕c5!? 14.♗e3 ♕a5+ 15.b4 ♕d8 16.♗b6 ♕g8 looks terrible for Black) **14.♘xe7 ♕xe7 15.e5 ♘d5** 15...♘e8 doesn't look better: 16.♕h5 and White has a strong attack. I don't think a human player can hold here: 16...d5 17.g4 ♔g8 18.0-0-0 h6 19.♖de1 ♗d7 20.♕h3 ♘g7 21.♕g2 ♖c8 22.♔b1⩲ f5? 23.exf6 (23.gxf5!, opening the file, looks more natural) 23...♕xf6 Motylev-Lutz, Germany Bundesliga 2006/07. **16.c4 ♘c7 17.♕h5 h6 18.0-0 ♔f8 19.f5 ♕c5+ 20.♔h1 d6 21.exd6 ♕xd6 22.fxe6 ♗xe6 23.♗c3** 23.♖ad1! is even better, when there is no good answer to the threat ♗c3. **23...♖g8 24.♗h7!+− ♖g4 25.♗g6 ♖xc4 26.♗xf7 ♔e7 27.♗xe6 ♘xe6 28.♕f7+ ♔d8 29.♖ad1 1-0** Recuero Guerra-Gago Padreny, Padron jr 2008.

O 8...d5?! is consistent with the previous move, but is probably the weakest of all alternatives as well: 9.e5! ♘xd4 (9...♘e4 10.♘xc6 ♘xc3 11.♕g4! bxc6 12.♕xg7 ♖f8 13.♗d2+−) 10.♗xd4 ♘e4 11.0-0 (better was 11.♗xe4! dxe4 12.0-0 ♗xc3 13.♗xc3 ♕xd1 14.♖fxd1 ♗d7 15.♔f2 ♗c6 16.♔e3 ♖d8 17.♖xd8+ ♔xd8 18.a4± with a very unpleasant endgame for Black, whose only aspiration is to hold the position) 11...♗xc3 12.bxc3 ♗d7 13.♕e2 b5± Rudd-Emms, Douglas ch-GBR 2005.

9.♘xc6 bxc6 10.0-0



10...c5?!

After this move, White's task is easier, but Black has trouble anyway in this position, as these variations show:

O 10...e5!? 11.h3 Once again, 11.♘a4!? poses serious problems for Black: 11...♘g4 (11...0-0 12.♗b6! ♗c5+ 13.♗xc5 dxc5 14.♗c4 ♘xe4 15.♕xd8 ♖xd8 16.♘b6 ♖b8 17.♘xc8 ♖dxc8 18.fxe5 ♖c7 19.♖ad1±) 12.♗b6 ♗c5+ (12...♕h4?! 13.h3 ♖b8

14.a3! h5 15.axb4 ♕g3 16.hxg4 hxg4 17.♕e1 ♕h2+ 18.♔f2+–; 12...♕xb6+ 13.♘xb6 ♗c5+ 14.♔h1 ♗xb6 15.♗e2!+–) 13.♗xc5 dxc5 14.♗e2±. **11...exf4** 11...0-0 (Radjabov-Svidler, Fügen tt 2006), and now 12.♘a4 is still interesting] 12.♗xf4 0-0 13.e5! ♗xc3?! (13...dxe5 14.♗xe5 ♘d5 leaves both white bishops aiming at Black's castled position, but also keeps the important dark-squared bishop; 15.♕h5 f5 16.♖ae1→) 14.bxc3 dxe5 15.♗xe5 ♘d5 16.♕h5 f5 17.♖ae1 ♕e8 18.♕h4 ♕d8 19.♕d4!+– ♕d7 20.c4 ♘f6 21.♗d6 ♘e8 22.c5 ♘xd6 23.cxd6 ♕a7 24.♕xa7 ♖xa7 25.♖e7 1-0 Radjabov-Navara, Sochi 2008.

○ 10...♕a5 11.♗d2 and Black has some problems to move his bishop and queen away from the dangerous diagonal.

○ 10...0-0 11.e5 (11.♘a4! and Black has nothing better than ...e5, transposing to the previous line) 11...♘d5 12.♘xd5 cxd5 13.♔h1 ♗c5 14.♗d2 (Shirov-Vega Gutierrez, Benidorm 2008) and now 14...a5 followed by ...♗a6 allows Black to neutralize White's attack.

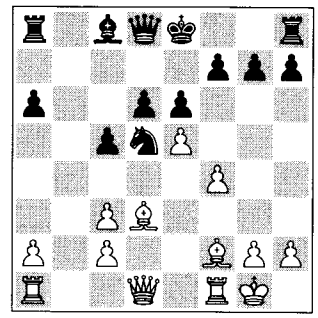
○ 10...♗xc3!? (a radical attempt to prevent the annoying ♘a4) 11.bxc3 e5 12.h3 (a simple improvement is 12.♖b1!? to answer 12...♘g4?! with 13.♗b6) 12...♕c7 13.♔h1 ♘d7 ½-½ Peng Xiaomin-Liang Jinrong, Calcutta 2001; but White must be better with 14.♕g4 0-0 15.f5±.

11.e5!? ♗xc3

11...dxe5? 12.fxe5 ♗xc3 (12...♘d5 13.♕f3 0-0 14.♘xd5 exd5 15.c3+–; 12...♘d7 13.♕f3+–) 13.bxc3 ♘d5 14.♗xc5+–.

12.bxc3 ♘d5 13.♗f2

13.♗d2 is interesting and similar to a variation considered above.



13...♗b7

Capturing on c3 would require important tempi and doesn't solve the core problem of Black's position, that is, the weakness of his dark squares. **13...♘xc3** 14.♕e1 (14.♕g4!?↑) 14...♘d5 15.♗e4 dxe5 16.fxe5 c4 (16...♖b8 17.♗xc5+–) 17.♗c5≅.

Grabbing the other pawn, though it destroys the white centre, opens very dangerous lines for the white pieces. **13...♘xf4?!** 14.exd6 ♗b7 (14...♕xd6 15.♗b5+ ♔e7) 15.♗g3±.

14.♕g4→ ♘e7

Trying to use the light-squared diagonal for the attack. **14...0-0** 15.c4 ♘c3 (15...♘e7 16.♖ad1±; 15...♘b4 16.♗h4+–) 16.♗xh7+ ♔xh7 17.♕h3+±; **14...♕d7** 15.f5 0-0-0 16.♖ab1.

15.♖ad1 h5 16.♕g5 c4?!

16...♘f5 17.♗xf5 ♕xg5 18.fxg5 exf5 19.♖xd6± leaves Black in a very poor endgame, but at this stage, that was relatively the best.

17.♗xc4 ♘f5 18.exd6 ♔d7

Black's defence is crafty, but apart from a bad king, he has less active pieces and a deficit of pawns. The game is completely decided for White, though it still demands some care.
18...♕xg5 19.d7++−.

19.♗d3 g6 20.♕xd8+ ♖hxd8 21.c4 ♗c6 22.c5 ♖db8 23.♖b1 ♗b5 24.♗e4 ♗c6 25.♗xc6+ ♔xc6 26.♖b3 ♖b5 27.h3 ♖ab8 28.♖d1 ♖8b7 29.c4 ♖xb3 30.axb3 ♔d7

30...♖xb3 31.d7; 30...a5 31.♖a1 ♖xb3 32.♖xa5+−.

31.b4+− f6

31...♖xb4 32.c6+ ♔xc6 33.d7+− and the pawn promotes.

32.b5

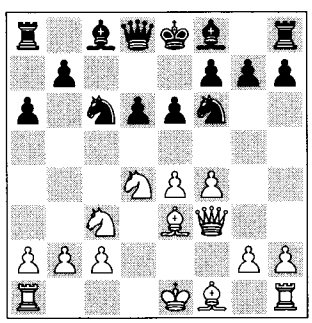
White's pawn mass is unstoppable.

32...axb5 33.cxb5 ♖xb5 34.c6+ ♔d8 35.d7 1-0

GAME 12.03

Lindhom,Eigil
Wicklund Hansen,Gunnar
SNM cr 2002

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘c6 5.♘c3 a6 6.♗e3 ♘f6 7.f4 d6 8.♕f3



Getting ready for 0-0-0 and a quick g2-g4. The black pieces are not in the best positions to oppose this plan, especially the c6 knight.

8...♕c7

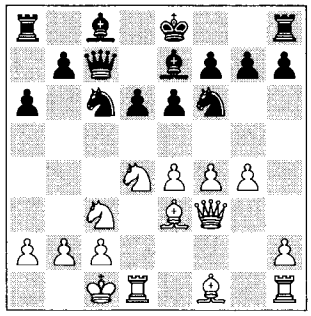
The queen moves away from a potential clash with the white rook. This is the most thematic and frequent alternative, but there are some others:
O 8...♗e7 9.0-0-0 and it is hard to avoid the transposition with ...♕c7 in view of the threat e4-e5;
O 8...♗d7 and again it is difficult to play without ...♕c7, for example: 9.0-0-0 ♖c8 10.♔b1 ♗e7 11.e5! dxe5 12.♘xc6 bxc6 13.fxe5 ♘d5 14.♘e4±;
O 8...e5!? In principle this is the best move to avoid an attacking race, but it leaves Black with a bad structure: 9.♘xc6 bxc6 10.fxe5 (the direct 10.♗c4!? may be better) 10...dxe5 11.♗c4 ♕a5 12.0-0 ♗c5 13.♕f2 ♗xe3 14.♕xe3 0-0 15.h3 ♖e8 16.♗b3 ♗e6 17.♘a4± Shirov-Mamedyarov, Moscow 2008, and it doesn't look as though Black can totally make up for his queenside weaknesses.

9.0-0-0 ♗e7

9...♗d7 is an equally important alternative. **10.g4!** There is no good reply to this quick plan. **10...♘xd4 11.♖xd4 d5** 11...e5 12.♖d2! ♗xg4 13.♕g3!⩲ and Black's defence is difficult: 13...♗d7 (13...♗e6 14.f5! ♗xa2?! − 14...♗d7 15.♗g5± − 15.♘xa2 ♘xe4 16.♕g2 ♘xd2 17.♕xd2±) 14.fxe5 dxe5 Martin-Ravikumar, Hastings 1984/85 and now, instead of the spectacular exchange sacrifice played in the game, 15.♗d4!± regains the pawn with advantage. **12.exd5** 12.e5!? is a simple solution: 12...♘e4 13.♘xe4 dxe4 14.♕f2

♗c6 15.♗g2± and the e4 pawn drops: 15...♗c5 16.♖d2 ♗xe3 17.♕xe3. **12...♘xd5 13.♘xd5** 13.♖xd5 ♗c6!∞. **13...exd5 14.f5** 14.♗g2±. **14...♗c6 15.♗f4 ♕a5 16.♕e3+ ♔d7 17.♗c4 ♗c5** and now I suggest **18.♖hd1! ♗xd4 19.♕xd4±** – White's attack on the dark squares looks crushing.

10.g4!



10...♘xd4

Black is almost forced to accept the challenge; otherwise, the white attack is very quick. **10...♘d7** 11.g5 b5 12.h4 ♘c5 13.h5 ♗b7 14.g6!± (Conquest-Söderberg, Tanta 1997), destroying the black king's refuge; **10...0-0** 11.g5 ♘d7 12.h4 b5 13.h5 ♗b7 14.g6!± and White's attack is much faster.

11.♗xd4 e5

11...0-0?! 12.g5 ♘d7 and White has many ways to speed his attack; one of the easiest may be: 13.♖g1 b5 14.♕h5 b4 15.♖d3 ♖d8 (15...bxc3 16.♖h3+–; 15...♖e8 16.♗xg7 ♔xg7 17.f5+–) 16.♗xg7 ♔xg7 17.f5+–.

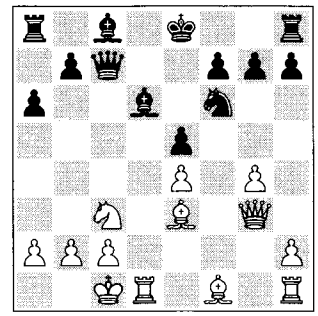
12.fxe5 dxe5

12...♗xg4? is tactically unsound: 13.♕g3! dxe5 14.♗xe5 ♕c8 15.♖g1 ♗xd1 16.♕xg7 ♖g8 17.♕xg8+ ♘xg8 18.♖xg8+ ♗f8 19.♗d6+–.

13.♕g3! ♗d6

13...♘xg4? 14.♘d5 ♕d6 15.♗c3+–.

14.♗e3



14...♗xg4?!

14...♗e6! The most frequent and cautious alternative, but White has a strong blow: 15.♗b5+!? (another option deserving study is 15.♗g5 0-0-0 16.♗xf6 gxf6 17.♘d5±) 15...♔e7?! (15...♔f8! is somewhat better, but Black's position will be uncomfortable, all the while his king doesn't find a refuge: 16.g5 ♘h5 17.♕f2 ♖c8 18.♗a4± Podlesnik-Mijovic, Sutomore tt-2 2004) 16.♗a4 ♕a5 17.♔b1? (17.g5!+– is far stronger) 17...♖hc8 18.♗b3 ♖xc3 19.bxc3 ♘xe4 20.♕h4+ f6 21.♗d2 ♗a3 22.♕xh7 ♗xb3 23.axb3 ♘xc3+ 24.♗xc3 ♕xc3 25.♕xg7+ ♔e8 ½-½ Kinlay-Mestel, London 1978; **14...0-0** 15.♗g5! ♗b4 16.♗xf6 ♗xc3 17.g5!±.

15.h3! ♗xd1

There is no viable alternative for Black. For example: 15...♘xe4?! 16.♕xg4 ♘xc3 17.bxc3 ♗a3+ 18.♔b1 ♕xc3 19.♕d7+ ♔f8 20.♕xb7+–.

16.♕xg7! ♗f3

16...0-0-0 17.♕xf6 and the d1 bishop is still lost in spite of a clever little trick:

17...♗g4 18.♘d5!+− (18.hxg4? ♕xc3−+);
16...♖g8 17.♕xf6 ♗e7 (17...♗h5 18.♘b5!+−) 18.♕f5! winning the d1 bishop.

17.♕xh8+ ♗f8 18.♕xf6 ♗xh1 19.♘d5 ♕d6 20.♕f5+−

After a series of forced moves, Black has kept his extra exchange, but the strong d5 knight can't be harassed, especially since the h1 bishop can't get back into play and is just another tactical weakness.

20...♖d8 21.♗d3 ♗g7 22.♕f1 ♗h6 23.♕xh1 ♗xe3+ 24.♘xe3 ♕h6 25.♕f3 ♔f8 26.♔b1 ♕g6 27.a3 b5 28.♘f5 ♕g5 29.♕f2 ♕f6 30.♕g3 ♖c8 31.♗e2 ♖d8 32.h4 ♖d7 33.a4 bxa4 34.♕a3+ ♔e8 35.♕xa4 1-0

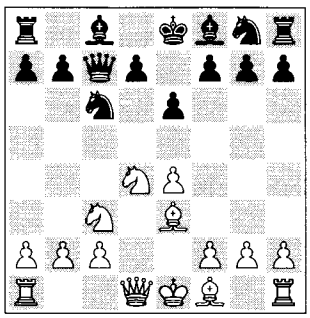
GAME 12.04

Leko,Peter
Ljubojevic,Ljubomir
Roquebrune (blindfold) 2003

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 e6 5.♘c3 ♕c7

The most typical order in Taimanov System, though its inventor prefers ...a6 and then quickly developing the king's knight on e7, as we saw in Game 12.01.

6.♗e3



My suggestion to fight the Taimanov Variation. This system combines perfectly well with the attacking set-up suggested to fight the Najdorf and the Scheveningen. In recent years, this has become a main line, with its theory constantly growing.

6...a6

The almost unanimous reply. Nevertheless, Black players have made some attempts to do without this move and immediately start pressing on e4 by means of ...♘f6 and ...♗b4.

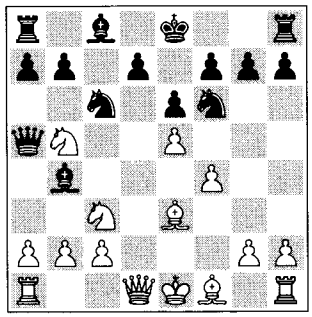
O 6...♘f6!? 7.f4 Here White must change his pre-conceived idea of playing f2-f3, not just because it is less effective, but also because f2-f4, combined with a well-timed jump to b5, is more efficient. An immediate e4-e5 is the threat.

A) **7...♘xd4** 8.♕xd4 ♘g4 (there is no time for 8...a6 in view of the threat e4-e5, and 8...b6!? 9.e5 ♘g4 10.♗g1 ♗c5 11.♕c4± also favours White) 9.0-0-0 ♘xe3 10.♕xe3 ♗c5 11.♕g3 0-0 12.♗d3± White's lead in development must outweigh the bishop pair in an attacking race: 12...a6 13.e5 d6? (13...f5 14.exf6 ♖xf6 15.♘e4!±) 14.exd6 ♗xd6 15.♗xh7++− Raisa-Doda, Leningrad tt 1960.

B) **7...d6** 8.♕f3! and, since it is hard for Black to play without ...a6, this usually leads to a transposition to the previous game.

C) **7...♗b4 8.♘b5 ♕a5 9.e5** 9.♗d2!? is a simpler option that promises some advantage. 9...a6 10.e5 axb5 11.exf6 ♗xc3 (11...gxf6 12.♘xb5 ♗xd2+ 13.♕xd2 ♕xd2+ 14.♔xd2± and White's better structure is a good starting point) 12.♗xc3! b4 13.fxg7 ♖g8 14.♗d4 ♕d5 15.♗e3 ♖xa2 16.♖xa2 ♕xa2 17.♗b5± Kokarev-Grachev,

Novokuznetsk 2008. White has a series of small trumps (bishop pair, dark squares, structure) that make his position preferable, but Black's position also has some counterplay.
After 9.e5 there is:



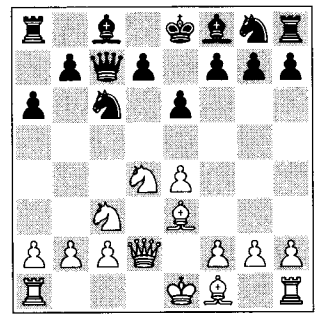
C1) **9...a6?** 10.♘d6+ ♗xd6 11.♕xd6 ♘e4 12.♕d3 ♘xc3 13.bxc3 b5 14.♗e2 ♕c7 15.0-0± and White will soon start to break Black's queenside pawn chain. Beliavsky-Matulovic, Sombor 1972;

C2) **9...♘e4?!** 10.♕d3 ♘xc3 11.♘xc3 ♗xc3+ 12.bxc3 0-0 13.♗e2± doesn't seem to completely solve Black's problems;

C3) **9...♘d5** 10.♗d2 ♘xc3 11.bxc3! (the most ambitious; on 11.♘xc3, 11...d5 12.a3 ♗e7 seems to equalize) 11...♗c5 12.c4 ♕b6 13.♖b1 (looking for a knight jump to d6, but the untested 13.♗d3 deserves attention) 13...0-0 (13...♗f2+?! 14.♔e2 0-0 15.♘d6 ♕c5 16.♖b5 ♘d4+ 17.♔xf2 ♘xb5+ 18.♗e3 ♘c3 19.♗xc5 ♘xd1+ 20.♔g3 ♘c3 21.♗d3⩲ Saric-Matlakov, Vung Tau City jr 2008, and in spite of being an exchange up, Black can't move) 14.♗d3 ♗e3?! 15.♖b3 ♗xd2+ 16.♕xd2 f5 17.♘d6± Sjugirov-Matlakov, St Petersburg 2008; White has the advantage thanks to the strong position of his knight.

O 6...d6 is a not very flexible way to transpose to a Scheveningen set-up (7.♕d2).
O 6...♗b4?! 7.♘b5 ♕b8 8.a3±.

7.♕d2



7...b5

O A common move, very frequently seen in Black's set-up. Though it often transposes to the main lines, it has some points. The most frequent move, **7...♘f6**, will be analysed in the following games.
O 7...♘xd4 has obtained quite good results so far. Probably White shouldn't look for a direct refutation, but should simply follow the usual plans: 8.♗xd4 ♘e7 9.0-0-0 (9.♕e3!?) 9...♘c6 10.♗e3 and now 10...♗e7 (10...b5 transposes to the note to the following move; 10...d6?! makes little sense, as White's attack will easily develop due to the lack of pressure on e4) 11.f4 d6 12.g4 b5 13.♔b1 ♗b7 14.♕f2 0-0 15.h4 ♖fe8 16.g5, Feigin-Werle, Netherlands tt 2007/08.
O 7...d6 8.0-0-0 must end up transposing to positions from Chapter 18 or the first game in this chapter.

8.0-0-0 ♗b7

A seemingly logical development, but this weakens d7 and allows ♗f4 to be far stronger.

8...b4!? 9.♘a4 ♘f6 10.f3 In comparison with normal positions in the English Attack, White's knight can here jump to b6; Black, on his part, can play ...d5 in one go. It is hard to know which factor is more relevant, without a careful analysis of the games played so far. **10...♘e5 11.♗f4** The pin on the knight is very annoying for Black, who has several alternatives here:

A) **11...d6?** 12.♕xb4+−;

B) **11...h6** is too odd, and deserves some respect only because the greatest expert on 8...b4, Bocharov, plays it. 12.♔b1! ♗e7 and now 13.c3! (13.♘b3 was Kurnosov-Bocharov, Khanty Mansiysk 2008) 13...bxc3 14.♕xc3 ♕xc3 15.♘xc3 d6 16.♘a4± leaves White with a pleasant initiative thanks to the black holes on the queenside and his lead in development;

C) **11...♗b7** 12.♘b3 ♖b8 13.♔b1 d6?! 14.♕xb4! ♘fd7 (14...♗xe4 – perhaps Black counted on this move – 15.♕c3! ♕xc3 16.♘xc3 ♗b7 17.♘a5±) 15.♕c3 ♕xc3 16.♘xc3 Motylev-Maletin, Novokuznetsk 2008, and Black doesn't have enough compensation for the pawn.

8...♘xd4 9.♗xd4 ♘e7 (9...♗b7 10.♗e5!) 10.♔b1 ♘c6 11.♗e3 ♖b8 (11...♘e5?! 12.f4 ♘c4 13.♗xc4 ♕xc4 14.♗d4!± Short-Pogorelov, Gibraltar 2004. Once again, development should outweigh the bishop pair in an attacking race) 12.f4 ♗b4 (12...d6 13.g4!) 13.f5 ♘e7 14.♗d3 e5 15.f6 gxf6 16.♕f2!± Lopez del Alamo-Teran Alvarez, Seville 2004, with a really strong attack.

8...♘f6 transposes to the next game.

9.♗f4!

This move is thematic in this line, and here it works extremely well because the d7-square is relatively undefended. 9.♘xc6!?, analysed in DLS, hasn't reached a high level of popularity, in spite of the initial push caused by the game Leko-Movsesian.

9...♕c8

9...e5 10.♘xc6! dxc6? (10...exf4 leads to a favourable endgame by means of a forced line: 11.♘a5 b4 12.♘xb7 bxc3 13.♘d6+ ♗xd6 14.♕xd6 ♕xd6 15.♖xd6±) 11.♗xe5!+− Gritsenko-Herrera Reyes, Herceg Novi jr 2006.

9...♕d8 is solid, but questions Black's plan, because the queen moves back to her starting square while White has improved his position. 10.♘b3! ♗b4 (10...♘f6 11.e5±) 11.a3 ♗e7 12.♗d6 ♘f6 13.♘c5± Boros-Ju.Horvath, Hungary tt-2 2006/07; with an overwhelming positional superiority.

10.f3

10.♘b3 directly may be more precise, and even the new idea **10.♘f3!?** looks strong, for example: 10...♘f6 11.e5 ♘h5 12.♗g5±.

10...♘f6 11.♘b3±

Black's position is cramped, especially because of the influence of the f4 bishop.

11...h6

11...♗e7 12.g4!; 11...b4? 12.♘a4+−.

12.h4 ♗b4 13.a3 ♗e7 14.e5

14.g4 is the natural plan and looks very strong, e.g.: 14...b4 15.axb4 ♘xb4 16.♗e2 followed by g4-g5.

14...♘h5 15.♗h2 b4 16.♘a4

Allowing great complications that finally lead to a blunder. Simple and advantageous is 16.axb4 ♘xb4 17.g4 ♗xf3 18.♖g1± getting two pieces for a rook.

16...bxa3 17.♘b6 ♕c7 18.♘xa8 ♗xa8 19.g4 a5?! 20.♗b5!+– a2 21.gxh5 0-0 22.♖hg1 ♘b4 23.c3 ♔h8 24.♖xg7 ♔xg7 25.♖g1+ ♔h7 26.♕g2 ♗g5+ 27.hxg5 ♖g8 28.g6+ fxg6 29.hxg6+ ♔g7 30.♗f4 ♖h8 31.♔d2 a4 32.♗xa4?

32.cxb4 axb3 is uncomfortable but winning after 33.♕g3.

32...♕c4 33.♘a1??

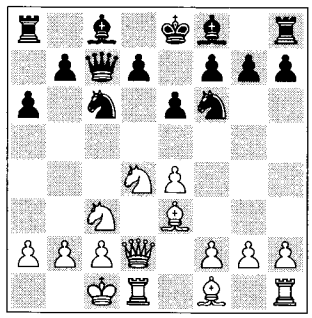
These blunders are not strange in blindfold chess with so little time.

33...♕xf4+–+ 34.♔e2 ♕xe5+ 35.♔f1 ♖f8 36.♗d1 ♘d3 37.♕e2 ♖xf3+ 38.♕xf3 ♗xf3 39.♗xf3 ♕e1+ 40.♔g2 ♕f2+ 0-1

GAME 12.05

Goloschapov,Alexander
Nikolov,Sasho
Nova Gorica 2003

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 e6 5.♘c3 ♕c7 6.♗e3 a6 7.♕d2 ♘f6 8.0-0-0



It was this move, which replaced the old 8.f3, which brought this variation to a new height. Black has tried here virtually all logical moves.

8...b5

Very popular until this game.

O 8...♗b4 is nowadays the main line and we'll see it in the subsequent games.

O 8...♗e7 see next game.

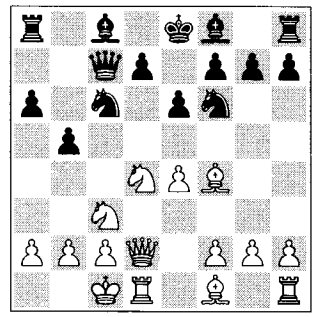
O 8...♘g4 enjoyed a brief popularity in the years 2002-03, especially in the games of Hristos Banikas, but it is now established that it leads to a difficult position for Black. **9.♗f4! ♘ge5** 9...e5? 10.♘d5 ♕d8 11.h3! (Arizmendi Martinez-Collutiis, Aosta 2003) 11...♘f6 12.♘xf6+! ♕xf6 13.♗g5 ♕d6 (other moves are worse) 14.♘f5 ♕xd2+ 15.♖xd2±. **10.♗g3 ♘xd4 11.♕xd4 f6** If Black is forced to play this move, then the ...♘g4 line is altogether suspicious. 11...d6?! 12.♗xe5 dxe5 13.♕a4+ ♗d7? (13...♔e7) 14.♖xd7! ♕xd7 15.♗b5+–. **12.f4 ♗c5 13.♕d2 ♘f7 14.f5!?** Banikas hasn't shown what he thinks about this move yet. Perhaps he will do so in a future game. **14...♕c6** 14...e5?! 15.♘d5±; 14...♘e5± is of course the critical move, but then the question is how Black will manage to finish development. **15.e5!** A violent treatment, justified by White's lead in development. **15...fxe5** 15...♘xe5 16.fxe6 d5 (16...♕xe6 17.♘d5±) 17.♗xe5 fxe5 18.♗c4!±. **16.fxe6 dxe6** 16...♕xe6 17.♘d5! 0-0 18.♔b1 ♖b8 19.♗c4 b5 20.♗b3⩲ and White has enormous compensation for the pawn. **17.♗d3 ♗d4** 17...0-0 18.♗e4 ♕c7 19.♖hf1 and Black's pieces are still tied up, for a ridiculous material gain. **18.♖he1 ♗xc3 19.bxc3 ♗d7** 19...0-0 20.♗e4 (20.♖e4!?) 20...♕a4 21.♕d3⩲. **20.♖e4!** By cunningly trans-

ferring this rook to the attack, White exposes the absence of black units to defend the kingside. **20...♖c8 21.♖g4 0-0 22.♗h4** Intending ♗f6. **22...♔h8 23.♕e2!** Threatening 24.♖xg7. **23...e4 24.♖xg7!! exd3 25.♗f6** And Black is powerless. **25...♕xc3 26.♖g8+ 1-0** Ramesh-Kunte, Torquay ch-GBR 2002.

O 8...♘xd4 9.♕xd4! 9.♗xd4?! e5 10.♗e3 ♗b4 is very comfortable for Black. **9...♘g4!?** An ambitious attempt to get a grip on the dark squares, probably unjustified due to Black's lack of development. Probably 9...d6 is sounder, transposing to an English Attack position where White has captured on d4 with his queen, which is less effective here. There is not much material, though this can quickly change and it is definitely an interesting field for research: 10.f3 b5 11.g4 (11.a4!? is a non-standard idea, but poses some problems: 11...bxa4 12.♘xa4 (capturing with the queen is also possible) 12...♗e7 13.♘b6 ♖b8 14.♕c4±) 11...♗b7 12.♔b1 ♖c8 (Black's idea is to quickly activate his queenside counterplay) 13.g5 ♘d7 14.a3 (14.♕d2!?, giving the knight its ideal square, is a sharp idea: 14...b4 15.♘e2 ♘e5 16.♘d4± Alsina Leal-Recuero Guerra, Mondariz 2007) 14...♘e5 15.♗e2 ♘c4 16.♗xc4 ♕xc4 17.h4 ♕xd4 18.♗xd4 h6! Recuero Guerra-Balazs, Sibenik jr 2007, and Black solves all his problems. **10.♕b6 ♕c6 11.♗d4 e5** Leaves an ugly hole on d5, but it is the only move consistent with the previous plan. **12.♗e3 ♘xe3 13.♕xe3 ♗c5 14.♕g3 0-0 15.♘d5! ♖e8 16.♔b1 b5 17.h4** 17.♗e2 followed by ♗g4 is another idea worth testing. **17...♗b7 18.h5 ♖ac8 19.h6 ♕g6** And now **20.hxg7** keeps a slight initiative for White, e.g.: **20...♗xd5** (20...♕xg3? 21.♘f6+!±) **21.♖xd5 ♕xg3 22.fxg3 d6 23.♗e2 ♔xg7 24.♗g4 ♖c7 25.a3±.**

9.♗f4!

Topalov's 2001 novelty, responsible for the popularity of this variation.



9...♘e5

The most natural reply. Let's see what happens with the rest:

O 9...d6? loses a pawn after 10.♘xc6 ♕xc6 11.♗xd6 ♗xd6 12.♕xd6 ♕xd6 13.♖xd6 b4 14.♘d1 ♘xe4 15.♖d4±.

O 9...e5 has become a respectable alternative: 10.♘xc6 exf4 (10...dxc6? 11.♗xe5+−) 11.e5 dxc6 12.exf6 ♗e6 (12...gxf6 13.♘e4±) 13.♘e4! (an excellent move by Luther, preparing ♕c3 as well as ♘g5) 13...♗d5 14.c4! White does not let his opponent consolidate. 14...0-0-0 (14...♗xe4 15.♕d4! gxf6 16.♕xe4+ ♗e7 17.g3±) 15.♗e2 ♗xc4 16.♗g4+ ♗e6 17.♕c3 ♗xg4 18.♖xd8+ ♕xd8 19.fxg7 ♗xg7 20.♕xg7 ♖g8 21.♕xf7± Nisipeanu-Cosma, Bucharest 2008.

O 9...♕b6!? is the most serious alternative. **10.e5 ♕xd4** 10...♘xd4? is bad due to 11.exf6! ♘c6 12.♘e4 d5 13.♘d6++− Kasimdzhanov-Polgar, Moscow (rapid) 2002. **11.♕xd4 ♘xd4 12.♖xd4 b4!?** Fighting for the d5-square is logical. 12...♘g4 13.♗g3

f5 14.b4!±, preventing ...♗c5 and intending a2-a4. **13.♘a4 ♘d5 14.♗g3 ♗b7 15.♗c4** But White fights for that square too. Now:

A) **15...♖d8** 16.♖hd1 ♗c6 17.♗xd5! The sequence starting now is forced. 17...♗xd5 18.♘b6 ♗c6 19.♗h4 ♗c5 20.♗xd8 ♗xd4 21.♖xd4 ♔xd8 22.♖xb4± De la Paz Perdomo-Rodriguez Guerrero, Mancha Real 2001;

B) **15...♘e7** 16.♘b6 ♖d8 17.♖hd1 ♗c6, Guadalpi-Nikolov, Portoroz 2004, and now 18.♗d3!, preventing ...♘f5 and threatening the b4 pawn, guarantees a comfortable edge for White;

C) **15...♖b8** 16.♖hd1 ♗c6 17.b3 a5 18.♗xd5 ♗xd5 19.♖xd5 (19.f3!?± followed by 20.c4) 19...exd5 20.♖xd5 ♖a8 21.♘b6 ♖a7 22.♘c4± Predojevic-Andonov, Obrenovac 2004.

O 9...♕a5 10.♘b3 ♕b6 11.e5 ♘g4 12.♕e2!± ♘xf2? 13.♗e3+–

10.♘f3 ♘xf3

The original game went on **10...♘fg4?!**, which is worse as it misses the chance to break the pin, which will become increasingly difficult in the next few moves. 11.♗g3 f6 12.♘xe5 (12.♘d4!, making way for some annoying moves such as ♗e2 and f2-f4, looks stronger) 12...♘xe5 13.f4 ♘c4 14.♗xc4 ♕xc4 (14...bxc4 15.f5±) 15.f5 ♔f7?! (15...b4!? is reasonable: 16.fxe6 bxc3 17.exd7+ ♔f7! 18.♕d5+ ♕xd5 19.♖xd5 cxb2+ 20.♔b1 ♗e7 21.dxc8♕ ♖hxc8 22.♖d7±) 16.e5!? (trying to punish the black king immediately) 16...b4 17.♘b1 exf5 18.exf6 gxf6 19.♗d6 ♗xd6 20.♕xd6 ♖e8 21.b3 ♕b5 22.♖he1 ♗b7 23.a4 ♕c6 24.♕xb4± Topalov-Movsesian, Sarajevo 2001.

11.gxf3 ♕c6

11...♕a5 12.♔b1 b4 13.♘e2 d5 14.♗g5 ♗b7 15.♘f4! ♖d8 16.e5 h6 17.♗h4 g5 18.exf6 gxh4 19.♗h3! Aiming at e6; Black cannot hold with his king in the centre of the board.

12.♖g1 ♗b7

12...b4?! sends the knight straight to the desired square: 13.♘e2 d5 14.♘d4 ♕a4 15.♗c4! ♗b7 16.♗b3+–.

13.♔b1!

The move suggested in DLS, 13.♘e2 d5!? 14.♘d4 ♕b6 15.e5, looks advantageous too.

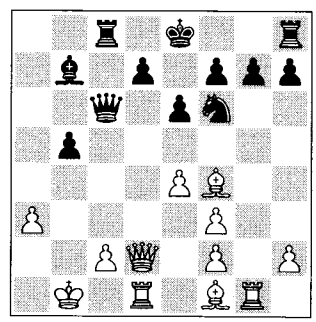
13...♖c8 14.a3 ♗xa3

14...b4 is the other natural alternative: 15.axb4 ♗xb4 16.♗e5 ♗f8? (16...♘h5 17.♕g5!±; 16...d6!? 17.♗xd6 ♖d8, but White breaks the pin with 18.♗xb4! ♖xd2 19.♖xd2 ♕b6! 20.♗d6 ♖g8 21.♗c4 ♘d7 22.♖gd1⩲) 17.♗c4 (17.♕f4 is very strong too) 17...♕xc4 (17...d6 18.♗b3!) 18.♗xf6+– Goloschapov-Mishra, Dhaka 2002.

15.♘xb5!

Creating a weakness on b5.

15...axb5 16.bxa3



The position is really strange, but White has a clear edge due to the open g-file and his strong dark-squared bishop.

16...d5

16...♘h5 17.♗d6!±; 16...0-0 17.♗d6 ♖fe8 18.♖xg7+!+−

17.♗e5 ♘h5 18.exd5

18.♗h3! dxe4 19.♖g5+−.

18...exd5

18...♕xd5, with all its drawbacks, was the lesser evil.

19.♗h3+− 0-0 20.♖g5 f6 21.♖xh5 fxe5 22.♗xc8 ♕xc8 23.♖xe5

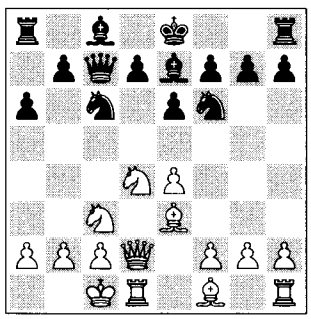
There is no compensation for the lost material.

23...♖xf3 24.♕e2 ♖f8 25.♖e7 ♗c6 26.♖g1 ♖f7 27.♖xf7 ♔xf7 28.♕e5 g6 29.♖g3 ♕d8 30.♖f3+ 1-0

GAME 12.06

Dominguez Perez,Leinier
Zapata,Alonso
Capablanca mem, Havana 2003

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘c6 5.♘c3 ♕c7 6.♗e3 a6 7.♕d2 ♘f6 8.0-0-0 ♗e7



We can explain the historical development of this variation. In its first stage (up to the 1930s), the plan with ♗e3, f2-f3, ♕d2 and 0-0-0 wasn't popular against any Sicilian set-up; Rauzer's efforts turned it into the favourite plan against the Dragon, but it was thought that its success was exclusively due to the break point on h5. Later, it became popular as well against the Scheveningen and extended, by structural affinity, to the Classical Sicilian and Najdorf, but it still didn't seem to work against the Paulsen-Taimanov complex, on account of the b4 bishop pin.
Once it became obvious after many games that the plan was interesting in spite of the pin, it was just a matter of time before somebody had the idea of developing the bishop on e7 and tried to use the move saved by not having moved the d-pawn. Naturally, this new plan can very often transpose to positions examined in Chapter 18; if not, the f6 knight will have to retreat to a less natural square than d7, but even so, many recent games show its independent viability. I'm certain that we will have many more games in the next months and the assessments will change, but I will try to put some order in the new lines.

9.f3

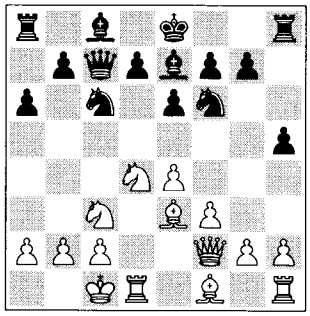
9.f4 may make sense now, since ...d6 is met by ♗e2 and g2-g4, whereas White can answer ...b5 with e4-e5. But this won't be our main line.

9...0-0

The most frequent move, though it can be postponed until White threatens g4-g5. Black has plenty of juicy alternatives.

○ 9...h5!? Macieja has played this no less than 5 times in 3 months. It pre-

vents g2-g4 but forgoes a quiet castled position. **10.♕f2** A classical multipurpose move: it supports a bishop move to b6 and c5, moves the queen away from the would-be open file and prepares h2-h3 and g2-g4 while keeping an eye on the h4-square. 10.♔b1 is interesting too: 10...b5 11.♘xc6 dxc6 (11...♕xc6 12.e5±) 12.♕f2 e5 (12...c5 13.♕g3 ♕xg3 14.hxg3±) 13.♗e2 ♖b8 14.♕g3 ♗e6⇄.



Now:

A) **10...d6** 11.h3! (11.♔b1 ♘e5! 12.h3 b5 13.f4 ♘ed7∞) 11...b5 (11...♘e5 12.f4 ♘ed7 13.f5 ♘c5 14.♕f3±) 12.♘xc6 ♕xc6 13.♗d3 (since it is hard to prepare ...b4, 13.a3!?± may deserve serious attention) 13...b4 14.♘e2 e5 15.g4 ♗e6 16.♔b1± Vachier Lagrave-Macieja, Germany Bundesliga 2008/09, and Black has some problems with the position of his king;

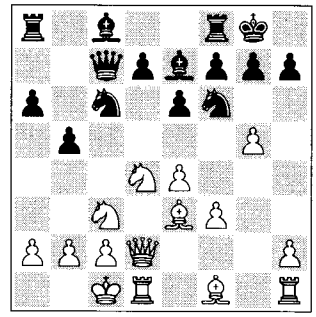
B) **10...♘e5?!** is premature, because White will manage to play f3-f4 before Black plays ...b4: 11.h3 b5 12.f4 ♘c4 13.♗xc4 (13.e5?! ♘xb2!) 13...♕xc4 14.e5 ♘d5 15.♘xd5 ♕xd5 16.♘f5!± with a real feast on the dark squares;

C) **10...b5 11.♘xc6 dxc6 12.♗b6 ♕f4+ 13.♗e3 ♕c7 14.♗b6 ♕f4+ 15.♔b1 ♘d7** 15...0-0 allows the typical plan with h2-h3 and g2-g4: 16.h3! h4 17.♗e3 ♕g3 18.♕xg3 hxg3 19.♘e2 ♘h5 20.e5 ♖d8 (20...♗b7? 21.♖d7) 21.♖xd8+ ♗xd8 22.h4; 15...e5? simply loses due to the bad position of the queen: 16.♗e3!+–. **16.♗d4** 16.♗e3 ♕c7 17.f4!?±; 16.g3 ♕b8 17.♗e3. **16...e5 17.♗e3 ♕f6 18.h4 ♗b4 19.♗g5 ♕e6 20.♘e2** Hard to do, but interesting, is 20.g3!? ♗xc3 21.bxc3±) **20...f6 21.♗e3 ♕e7 22.g4!±** Edouard-Damljanovic, Andorra Open 2008, and the drawbacks of the black king's position constitute a long-range problem.

O 9...d6 transposes to Chapter 18;

O 9...b5 10.g4 and it is difficult to play other than ...0-0 or ...d6, transposing, since 10...b4?! 11.♘a4 adds problems to Black's position, due to the weakness of the b6-square.

10.g4 b5 11.g5!



The most critical. If we agree that the knight will be more annoying on h5, the plan chosen in the following game makes sense: 11.h4!? ♘e5?! 12.h5 ♘e8 13.g5 ♘d6 14.♕h2 f6 15.♗f4± Lopez Martinez-Zherebukh, Plovdiv Ech 2008. But we should find an improvement in this sequence: 11...♗b7 12.h5 ♘xd4 13.♗xd4 e5 14.♗f2 b4 15.♘a4 ♖ac8!.

11...♘h5

In my opinion, the only problem in this variation, though so far the strongest

players, led by Morozevich, have preferred the odd retreat to e8. **11...♘e8 12.♘xc6!** Pre-empting Black's idea, which was to place one knight on e5 and the other on d6. **12...dxc6** and we reach a critical position where White has two equally interesting ways to continue the attack:

A) **13.f4!?** ♘d6 14.♗d3! (preparing e4-e5) 14...♖b8 (not very consistent with the next move, but other moves do not neutralize the strength of e4-e5 either: 14...c5 15.e5! ♘c4 16.♗xc4 bxc4 17.♕e2±) 15.e5 ♘f5? (allowing an unstoppable attack based on the sacrifice on f6. 15...♘c4!? is somewhat better, but 16.♕e2 ♘xe3?! – 16...c5! with some counterplay in exchange for the pawn – 17.♕xe3 c5 18.♕h3 g6 19.♘e4 c4 20.♕h6!+– is also crushing) 16.♘e4 ♖d8 17.♕f2 ♖d5 18.♘f6+!+– Recuero Guerra-Thorfinnsson, Budapest 2008.

B) **13.h4!?** e5 14.♕f2 (14.h5 – Fritz 11) 14...♗e6 15.♗h3 (15.h5!? ♘d6 16.h6 g6 17.♕g3 f6 18.gxf6 ♗xf6 19.♗h3±) 15...♗xh3 16.♖xh3 ♘d6 17.♗c5 ♘c4 18.b3 ♘d6?! (a strange decision; instead, 18...♗xc5 19.♕xc5 ♕b6 20.♕xb6 ♘xb6 21.♖d6 ♖ac8= seems to lead to an equal endgame) 19.f4 ♘b7 20.♗b6 ♗a3+ 21.♔b1 ♕e7 22.f5 a5 23.f6 ♕e6 24.♖hd3 (24.♖f3 ♗b4 25.fxg7 ♔xg7 26.♕g3 ♘d6 27.♖f6 ♕e7 28.♕f2±) 24...g6?! (24...♗b4 25.fxg7 ♔xg7 26.♘e2±) 25.h5 ♗b4 Leko-Morozevich, Moscow 2008; and only the quick rate of play can explain why White didn't finish his opponent off by means of 26.♕h2!+– followed by ♖h1 and hxg6.

12.♘ce2

Harassing the blockading h5 knight is not only an excellent, but an essential idea.

12...g6

Somewhat artificial, but it is hard to find an answer to the threat ♘g3. 12...♖d8 13.♘g3 ♘xd4 14.♗xd4 (14.♘xh5 ♘xf3 15.♕f2 ♘e5 16.♗b6∞ with some compensation for the exchange; 14.♕xd4! ♘f4 15.h4 ♗b7 16.♕b6±) and now 14...♘f4 15.♗e3 ♗xg5 16.♖g1 f6 Mekhitarian-Leitao, Porto Alegre ch-BRA 2008.

13.♘g3 ♘xd4

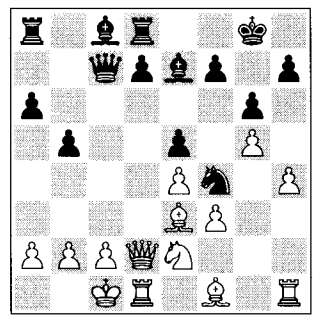
On **13...♘g7,** 14.f4 exposes the drawbacks of Black's plan, and **13...♘xg3?** 14.hxg3 is out of the question.

14.♗xd4 ♘f4 15.h4 e5 16.♗e3 ♖d8

Preparing the break ...d5, in view of the immediate threat of winning a pawn on f4.

17.♘e2

17.♗xf4 exf4 18.♘e2 d5 19.exd5 ♗b7 20.♕xf4 ♕a5 offers good compensation.



17...♘h5?!

17...♘xe2+!? 18.♕xe2 d5! promises some counterplay, but White's threats

along the h-file come quickly, for example: 19.♕h2 dxe4 20.♖xd8+ ♕xd8 21.fxe4 ♕c7 22.h5→.

18.♘c3!

This curious return of the knight to its usual post allows it to take advantage of the recently-created weakness of the d5-square.

18...♗b7 19.♕f2! ♘f4

An important but logical concession, since saving the exchange with 19...♖dc8 20.♗h3!+– creates more serious problems.

20.♗b6 ♕c6 21.♗xd8

Maybe the purely strategic plan is stronger: 21.♘d5! ♘xd5 22.♖xd5 ♖dc8 23.♗h3±.

21...♗c5 22.♕d2

22.♕h2±.

22...♖xd8 23.♘d5 ♘xd5 24.exd5 ♕b6 25.♔b1 ♗e3 26.♕g2 ♕c5 27.h5!

By opening the h-file, White seizes the initiative, which strengthens the role of his light-squared bishop.

27...♕e7 28.hxg6 fxg6 29.♗d3 d6 30.♖h4 ♗xg5 31.♖g4 ♗f6 32.♖h1

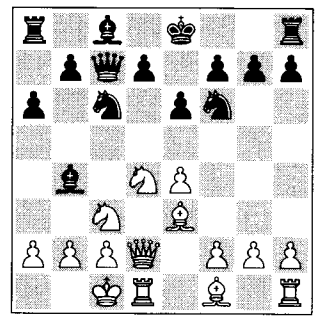
32.♗xg6! and 32.♗f5! were powerful alternatives.

32...♔f8 33.♗xg6 hxg6 34.♖xg6+– ♗xd5 35.♖hh6 ♗g7 36.♖h7 ♖d7 37.♕g4 ♕f7 38.♖gxg7 ♕xg7 39.♖xg7 ♖xg7 40.♕c8+ ♔f7 41.b3 ♖g6 42.♕xa6 ♗xf3 43.♕xb5 ♔e7 44.a4 ♖g2 45.♕d3 e4 46.♕d4 ♖g5 47.♕e3 ♖d5 48.♔b2 ♔d7 49.b4 ♖d1 50.a5 d5 51.♕a7+ ♔e6 52.a6 d4 53.♕b7 1-0

GAME 12.07

Korneev,Oleg
Horvath,Adam
Zalaegerszeg 2004

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 e6 5.♘c3 ♕c7 6.♗e3 a6 7.♕d2 ♘f6 8.0-0-0 ♗b4



The pin is still the main idea in this variation, though it hasn't proved very effective, and nowadays it shares popularity with other moves.

9.f3 ♘e7

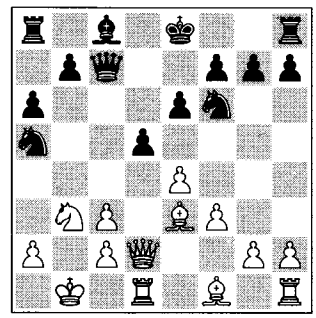
This move, first tried in the 21st century, has become the second most popular option, after 9...♘e5. Its main virtue is that here Black does aspire to double the white pawns on c3 and then play ...d5; its main drawback is that the knight is even less active here than on c6.

In this position, Black has tried virtually all the natural alternatives:

○ 9...b5 This is a more or less standard move, but it doesn't seem to combine very well with ...♗b4. **10.♔b1!** At this moment, this seems to me the best move. After this king retreat, White is

ready to meet ...♘e5 or ...♘e7 by violently unpinning the knight and Black's attack arrives at a deadlock: the b-pawn can't move forward, the c6 knight can't move and a b4 bishop retreat would be a waste of time. The move 10.♗f4, studied in DLS, is still interesting too. **10...♗b7** 10...♗e7 11.g4± and White is playing the same position as in the previous game with the useful extra move ♔b1; 10...♘e5? 11.♘cxb5!+–; 10...0-0?! 11.♘xc6 ♕xc6 (11...dxc6? is impossible because of 12.♘xb5!±) 12.♗d4 ♗e7 (12...♗b7 13.h4±) 13.e5! ♘d5 14.♘xd5 ♕xd5 15.♗d3±. **11.g4** White develops his attack naturally, whereas Black's is blocked. Although there are no practical examples of this position, the attacking race looks favourable for White. **11...♖c8 12.g5 ♘h5 13.♗h3±** threatening ♗g4.

O 9...♘a5 This move enjoyed a brief popularity after two games played by Anand against Grischuk and Topalov, but a Leko-Anand game badly damaged its reputation: **10.♔b1!** One of the typical ideas in this line. White threatens a jump of his pinned knight and doesn't care about his doubled pawns on c3, reckoning that the strength of the dark-squared bishop will be more than enough compensation for all the inconveniences. **10...♗xc3** Forced. **11.bxc3 d5!?** The most logical break, in order to develop the bishop and prevent White's control of d6. 11...b5?! 12.♗f4 ♕b6 (the logical 12...e5?! meets a convincing tactical refutation: 13.♘f5!! exf4 14.e5 ♘e4! (14...♘h5 15.♘d6++–) 15.fxe4 ♕xe5 16.g3! fxg3 17.♕g5!±) 13.♘b3! (with an eye on d6, but other moves like 13.♗e5!?± and 13.g4 also promise good play) 13...♘c4 14.♕d4 d5 (the queen swap brings no relief to Black's position: 14...♕xd4 15.cxd4 d5 16.♘c5±) 15.♗xc4! (forcing the exchange and focusing on exploiting the absolute grip on the dark squares) 15...♕xd4 16.cxd4 dxc4 17.♘a5!± Leko-Anand, Moscow 2004; an unusual disadvantage for a top player after the opening. It is not surprising that this variation has lost its supporters. **12.♘b3** and now:



A) **12...dxe4!?** 13.♗f4! ♕b6 14.♗e5 (threatening 15.♕g5) 14...e3 15.♕e1 0-0 16.♕g3±. It is really hard to answer all the threats posed by the dark-squared bishop; ♗c7, ♗f6 etc.;

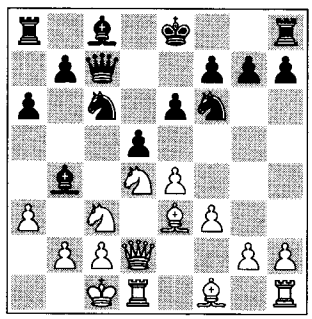
B) **12...♘c6!?** is a quite serious attempt to reactivate the stray knight, but the weaknesses on the dark squares are still noticeable: 13.♗f4! e5 (13...♕e7 14.c4! dxe4 15.♗d6 ♕d8 16.♗e2⩲; 13...♕b6 14.♗d6 – in all these lines, White's dark-squared bishop plays the leading part) 14.exd5 exf4 (14...♘xd5 15.♗xe5! – 15.♕xd5 exf4∓ – 15...♘xe5 16.♕xd5 0-0 17.♕c5±) 15.♖e1+ ♔f8!? (15...♗e6 16.dxe6 ♘e7 17.g3!± and the white bishop will strongly appear on h3) 16.dxc6 bxc6 17.♕d4± – the black king keeps staggering along;

C) **12...0-0** is the most recent move. 13.♗g5! ♘d7?! (13...dxe4 14.♗xf6 gxf6 15.fxe4± looks somewhat stron-

ger, but I doubt that anyone would feel comfortable with such a king) 14.exd5 ♘c4 15.♗xc4 ♕xc4 16.dxe6 (16.♗e7!?± ♖e8 17.d6) 16...fxe6 17.♖he1 ♘b6 18.♖e4 ♕b5 19.♗d8 ♘a4 20.♗c7 b6 21.♗e5 ♗b7 (Corrales Jiménez-Guliev, Manresa 2007) and now with 22.c4 ♕e8 23.♖g4 ♖f7 24.♕h6 ♕e7 25.♖dd4+– White would have added a crushing attack to his extra pawn;

D) **12...♘c4?!** makes White's task easier: 13.♗xc4 dxc4 (13...♕xc4 14.♗d4↑) 14.♘c5 (14.♗f4 is another interesting, even if less ambitious, continuation: 14...♕b6 15.♕d4 ♕xd4 16.♘xd4 ♗d7±) 14...♗d7?! (on 14...b6?, 15.♗f4 ♕e7 – 15...e5? 16.♗xe5+– – 16.♘a4!+– wins material; 14...0-0! is relatively the best: 15.♘a4 ♘d7 16.♕d6 ♕xd6 17.♖xd6 b5 18.♘c5 ♘xc5 19.♗xc5± leads to an endgame that offers Black some drawing hopes) 15.♕d6 0-0-0 (15...♕xd6 16.♖xd6 0-0-0 17.e5±) 16.♕xc7+ ♔xc7 17.♖d4 ♗b5 18.a4! ♖xd4 19.cxd4± Volokitin-Haba, Germany Bundesliga 2004/05.

O 9...d5 is the thematic break in the Sicilian, and here it adds pressure on e4, just symbolically defended by the pinned knight. However, White has a very promising reply **10.a3!** and now:



A) **10...♗a5 11.♘b3!** This is the key to the lack of punch of the thematic break ...d5. Black can't keep his dark-squared bishop on the board, and thus the dark squares are going to suffer:

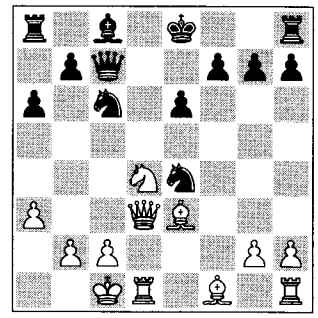
A1) **11...♗b6?!** 12.♗xb6 ♕xb6 13.exd5±;

A2) **11...♗xc3** 12.♕xc3 dxe4 13.fxe4 (13.♗c5!?) 13...0-0 14.♗d3±;

A3) **11...dxe4** 12.♘xa5 ♕xa5 13.♘xe4! is the simplest: 13...♕xd2+ (13...♘xe4 14.♕xa5 ♘xa5 15.fxe4 e5 16.♗b6 ♘c6 17.♗c4±) 14.♖xd2 (14.♘xd2!?± even avoids a position with the isolated pawn) 14...♘xe4 15.fxe4 e5 16.♗c4± M.Pavel-Ladanyi, Balatonlelle jr 2005.

B) **10...♗e7** 11.exd5 ♘xd5 12.♘xd5 exd5 13.♗d3±;

C) **10...♗xc3 11.♕xc3 dxe4 12.fxe4** 12.♘xc6!? also gives very clear compensation for the pawn: 12...♕xc6 (12...bxc6?! 13.fxe4±) 13.♕xc6+ bxc6 14.fxe4 ♘xe4 15.♗d3 ♘f6 16.♗c5⩲. **12...♘xe4 13.♕d3** with the following options:



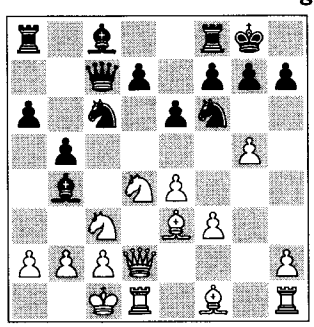
C1) **13...♘f6** 14.♘xc6 bxc6 15.♗c5±;

C2) **13...f5** 14.♕c4 e5 15.♘xc6 ♕xc6 16.♖d5! ♕e6 17.♖a5 ♘d6?! (17...♕e7 may be more resilient, but White's compensation is very clear after 18.♕d5!±) 18.♕c3 (18.♕xe6+ ♗xe6

19.♖xe5±) 18...0-0 19.♖xe5 ♕a2 20.b3 ♕xa3+ 21.♔b1 ♘b5 22.♕e1 ♖d8 23.♗c4+ ♔h8 24.♗d2 1-0 Polgar-Jo.Horvath, Halkidiki tt 2002;

C3) **13...♘c5** 14.♕c4 ♕e5 (14...♘d7 15.♘xc6 ♕xc6 16.♕g4±) 15.♗g1! (odd, but the strongest move) 15...♘xd4 16.♗xd4 ♕g5+ 17.♔b1 ♘d7 18.h4 ♕h6 19.♕b4 e5 20.♗c3 a5 21.♕a4 ♕f4 22.♕xf4 exf4 23.♗b5 f6 24.♖he1+ ♔d8 25.♖xd7+ ♗xd7 26.♖d1 1-0 Recuero Guerra-Lluis, Benasque 2008.

O 9...0-0!? Another trendy variation whose theory has developed quickly in the last two years; all conclusions are provisional. Black simply follows the attacking race and gets ready to retreat his knight to e8, an odd square that nevertheless has some virtues, such as the route d6-c4. **10.g4** 10.a3!? Perhaps in this order the knight retreat to e8 makes less sense: 10...♗e7 11.g4 b5 12.g5 ♘e8?! 13.h4 b4 14.♘xc6! ♕xc6 (14...dxc6 15.axb4 ♗xb4 16.♕d8, forcing a pleasant endgame) 15.axb4 ♗xb4 16.h5 and the white attack goes really fast, but we need good examples to reach a reliable assessment. **10...b5** 10...♘e5?!, trying to avoid a potential exchange on c6, but it is premature: 11.g5 ♘e8 (11...♗xc3 12.♕xc3 ♕xc3 13.bxc3 ♘e8 14.f4±) 12.a3 ♗e7 13.f4 ♘c4 14.♗xc4 ♕xc4 15.f5±. **11.g5**



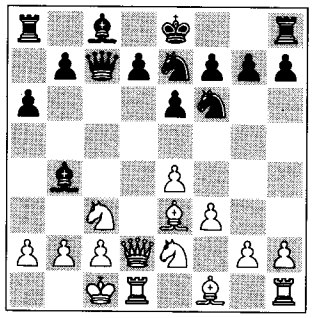
11...♘e8!? This is the trendy move in this variation. The knight is a defender, and moves to d6 in some lines. Black combines the potential possibility of doubling pawns on c3 with the attacking race. 11...♘h5 12.a3 ♗e7 (once again, the bishop can't maintain the pin, and when this happens its trip to b4 becomes a waste of time in the worst of cases, or a subtlety to provoke a2-a3 in the best one. In spite of giving Black a breaking point on b4, a2-a3 is a move with a good side: it strengthens the position of the c3 knight, which controls d5) 13.♘ce2! (now the knight heads for g3 to harass its counterpart on h5, in a similar way to the line examined in the previous game) 13...♘a5 14.♘g3 e5!? (a radical measure in a delicate situation. White's reply is a powerful tactical sequence that looks completely sound. The first player had to calculate it on the previous move) 15.♘xh5! exd4 16.♔b1 dxe3 17.♕d4 f6 18.gxf6 ♗xf6 (18...gxf6!? is the move that forces the most precise calculation, but is objectively worse: 19.♕xe3! ♔h8 (19...♖f7 20.♖g1+ ♔h8 21.♕h6; 19...♕a7 20.♕h6 ♖f7 21.♗c4 ♘xc4 22.♖hg1+ ♔h8 23.♖g7+−) 20.♕h6 ♖f7 21.♖g1 ♕c5 22.♖g7+− Chulivska-Marchadour, Guingamp 2007) 19.♘xf6+ ♖xf6 20.♕d5+ ♖f7 21.♕xa8+− Arizmendi Martinez-Arbakov, Linares 2003. **12.a3 ♗e7** transposes to the note to 10.a3!?; 12...♘xd4!? makes some sense in this move order: 13.♗xd4 ♗d6.

O 9...♘e5 is the main line and we will examine it in the next game.

10.♘de2!

Once White has checked that Black gets a good position by doubling pawns and

immediately playing ...d5, he gets ready to chase and trade the dark-squared bishop.



10...d5

The only alternative is **10...b5!?** (other moves would leave the e7 knight out of place) 11.♗f4! (forces Black to weaken the d5-square) 11...e5 (11...♕b6 12.♔b1 d5 13.♗e5 dxe4 14.♗xf6 gxf6 15.♕f4 exf3 16.♘e4⩲) 12.♗g5 ♗b7 (12...♕c6 is one of the most logical moves that haven't been tried yet, but White has 13.♔b1! in order to answer ...h6 by exchanging on f6 and then unpinning the knight: 13...h6 – 13...♗b7?! leaves d7 weak: 14.♗xf6 gxf6 15.g3± with the idea ♗h3 – 14.♗xf6 ♕xf6 15.♘d5! ♘xd5 16.♕xd5 ♖a7 17.♕b3! ♗c5 18.♘c3 ♗b7 19.♘d5 ♗xd5 20.♕xd5±) 13.♔b1 ♗a5 (13...d5 14.♘xb5 ♕c5 15.♘c7+ ♕xc7 16.♕xb4 ♖c8 17.♕d2 dxe4 18.♗xf6 gxf6 19.fxe4 ♗xe4 20.♘c3±) 14.♗xf6! gxf6 15.♕h6 ♕b6! (15...♘g6 16.g3!; 15...♖c8 16.♕xf6 ♖g8 17.g3! b4 18.♗h3 ♗c6 19.♘d5 ♗xd5 20.exd5 ♕xc2+ 21.♔a1 ♕xe2 22.♖he1±; 15...b4!? 16.♕xf6 ♖g8 17.♘a4! ♖c8 18.♖d2) 16.g3! ♕e6 17.♗h3± Anand-Polgar, San Luis Wch 2005.

11.♗g5!

And now Black can't prevent his kingside from being ruined, which leaves his king without a safe shelter.

11...dxe4

11...♗d7 12.♗xf6 gxf6 13.♕d4 ♗d6 14.exd5± Okkes-Zhaoqin Peng, Hoogeveen 2006.

12.♗xf6 gxf6 13.♕d4 exf3

13...♗xc3?! This bishop is exchanged for a knight anyway, but here it is worse, as it leaves the f6 pawn hanging and the queen check has more drawbacks: 14.♘xc3 e5 (14...♕f4+ 15.♔b1 ♘c6 16.♕c4! 0-0 17.♘xe4±) and there is no compensation for the kingside weaknesses: 15.♕xe4 0-0 16.♕h4! (White attacks the black king for free) 16...♗f5 17.♕xf6 ♖ad8 18.♗e2 ♗g6 19.h4 ♘d5 20.♖xd5 ♖xd5 21.h5!+– Goloschapov-Renette, Leuven 2003.

14.♕xb4 fxe2 15.♗xe2 f5

So far the only try here, and also the best, as it prevents the white knight from getting to e4. Black has managed to get out from the opening with an extra pawn, but his development problems and bad king are quite a headache.

16.♖d6!

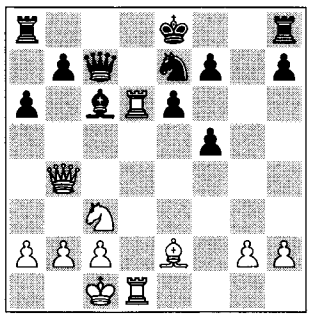
This strong grip on the important central file has been the most successful move so far, but other tries are justified: 16.♗f3!? 0-0 (16...♗d7 17.♕xb7 ♕xb7 18.♗xb7 ♖a7 19.♗f3±) 17.g4! f4 18.♖d6 ♘g6 19.♘e4⩲.

16...♗d7

It seems logical to rush to develop the bishop before White doubles

rooks, thus preventing this for a long time. 16...0-0 17.♖hd1↑ followed by g4.

17.♖hd1 ♗c6



18.♕d4

Forcing Black to castle kingside. 18.♗f3!? is a possible improvement: 18...♖c8 (18...♗xf3 19.gxf3⩲ makes kingside castling impossible) 19.♗xc6+ ♘xc6 20.♕f4⩲ with very clear compensation for the pawn.

18...0-0

18...♖g8 19.♗h5! ♘g6 20.g4±.

19.g4 fxg4?!

Now White's initiative comes easier. 19...♖fe8!? is an interesting improvement by Ribli, but White still has a good attack: 20.h4?! (20.♖g1! is the most interesting move: 20...fxg4 21.♖xg4+ ♘g6 22.h4 ♖ad8! 23.♖xd8 ♖xd8 24.♕f6 ♕d6 25.a3⩲) 20...♖ac8 21.♕f4 ♘d5 22.♕g5+ ♔h8 23.♖6xd5 ½-½ Volokitin-Ribli, Bosnia-Hercegovina tt 2005.

20.♕xg4+ ♘g6

20...♔h8?! 21.♕d4+! ♔g8 (21...f6 22.♖xe6 ♖ad8 23.♕f2 ♖xd1+ 24.♗xd1±) 22.h4+− followed by ♖g1.

21.h4 ♖ad8?!

The logical move would be: **21...h5** 22.♕xh5 ♖ad8 23.♖xd8 ♖xd8 24.♖g1 (24.♖xd8+? ♕xd8 25.♗d3 ♕xh4 26.♗xg6 ♕f4+ 27.♔b1 ♕f1+ 28.♘d1 fxg6 29.♕xg6+ ♔f8∓); **21...♔h8** 22.h5±.

22.♖xd8 ♖xd8 23.♖xd8+ ♕xd8 24.h5±

White wins a piece and the rest of the game, while offering some difficulties, doesn't cast any doubt on the plus obtained in the opening.

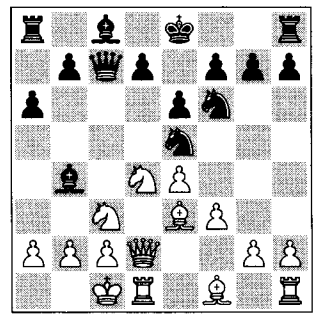
24...f5 25.♕g1! ♕f6 26.a4 ♔g7 27.hxg6 hxg6 28.♕c5 ♕f8?! 29.♕e5+ ♕f6 30.♕c7+ ♕f7 31.♕d6 f4 32.♘e4! f3 33.♕e5+ 1-0

33...♔f8 34.♘g5 ♕f5 35.♘xf3+−.

GAME 12.08

Vachier-Lagrave,Maxime
Vitiugov,Nikita
Plovdiv Ech 2008

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘c6 5.♘c3 ♕c7 6.♗e3 a6 7.♕d2 ♘f6 8.0-0-0 ♗b4 9.f3 ♘e5



This move has been the main line for several years. The knight moves to an

active square and, even if it doesn't threaten an immediate swap on c3, it does strengthen the break ...d5, which we can consider Black's immediate threat now.

10.♘b3

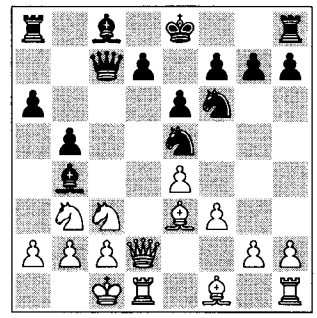
If 10.♔b1, threatening to unpin the knight, 10...♗xc3! 11.♕xc3 ♕xc3 12.bxc3 d5!, with good play, illustrates Black's plan.

10...b5

○ 10...d5!? is a solid alternative which so far hasn't received the attention it deserves. White can exert some pressure by exploiting the exposed position of the knight: **11.♗d4! 0-0** A preparation for ...dxe4, which was not possible yet: 11...dxe4?? 12.♗xe5+−. **12.♔b1** White, for his part, prepares ♕f4, as well as ♕g5 and exd5. **12...dxe4** Virtually the only move. **13.♕f4! ♗d6 14.♘xe4 ♘xe4 15.♕xe4** After a forced sequence, Black can choose between two knight retreats, as the knight will be forced to move after White's next ♗c3. **15...♘g6!?** The most solid, only championed by Pogorelov with mixed results. 15...♘c6?!, the most active, meets a tactical detail: 16.♗b6! ♕xb6 17.♖xd6± Acs-J.O.Fries Nielsen, Germany Bundesliga 2004/05, and White gets a dominant position, although Black's position, without weaknesses, is quite solid. **16.h4!** Taking advantage of the knight's position to win time for the attack is only logical. **16...e5 17.♗c3 ♗e6 18.♘a5!** Concrete play. **18...b5 19.h5 ♘e7 20.h6** Black faces some problems. **20...g6?** 20...f5! is critical; after 21.♕e1! ♘d5 22.♗d2 g6 23.c4 ♘f6 24.♖c1± the weaknesses along the long diagonal offer White more comfortable play. 21.♘b7 f6 22.♗a5 ♕b8 23.♘xd6 ♖a7 24.f4 ♖d7 25.fxe5 ♗f5 26.♕e1 ♘c6 27.♘xf5 ♕xe5 28.♖xd7 1-0 Solodovnichenko-Pogorelov, Albacete 2008.

○ 10...0-0?! is now slow and gives White time to repel the black pieces without risk: 11.a3! ♗e7 12.f4 ♘c4 13.♗xc4 ♕xc4 14.e5 ♘e4 15.♘xe4 ♕xe4 16.♗c5!± Motylev-Tissir, Linares 2001; with an absolute positional grip.

○ 10...♗xc3?! fails now due to: 11.♕xc3 ♕xc3 12.bxc3 d5 13.♗d4 ♘ed7 and now: 14.e5 (14.exd5 ♘xd5 15.♗xg7 ♖g8 16.♗d4±) 14...♘g8 Wiegelmann-Suetin, Berlin 1993.



11.♕e1!

A powerful idea, dating just from 2004. White threatens 12.♘xb5 and gets ready to drive the black knights off as well after the bishop retreat. In a short time, this has replaced the other moves and its theoretical development is still growing. In former trendy lines such as 11.♔b1 or 11.♕f2 many new possibilities have appeared for Black, and the final assessments aren't so clear any more, though they are still valid options for white players. 11.♕d4, recommended by Khalifman, doesn't look very ambitious after 11...♘c6 12.♕b6 ♕xb6 13.♗xb6,

though White can try to squeeze his opponent in this endgame.

11...♗e7

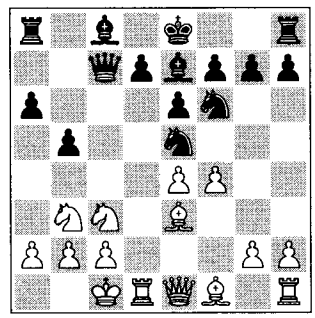
The immediate retreat is the most logical. The other natural alternatives are:

O 11...♖b8!? is a weird reply, but up to this year, this is the move with the best results. **12.♕g3 ♘h5** 12...0-0 is the other way to cope with the tactical threats, but leads to a long forced variation: 13.♗d4! ♗d6 14.f4 ♘h5 15.fxe5 ♘xg3 16.exd6 ♕xd6 17.hxg3 ♕xg3. The skirmish has resulted in a very unusual position. Black has a queen and two pawns in exchange for three minor pieces, but White's pieces are extremely active, especially the dark-squared bishop, which should be enough to win some more material. 18.♖h3! (18.♗c5 ♖e8 19.♗d6 ♕g5+ is less clear) 18...♕g5+ 19.♗e3 ♕e5 20.g3 ♕c7 (Kotronias-Bellon Lopez, Gibraltar 2009) and now 21.♗c5± wins the exchange. **13.♕f2** The white pieces get ready for the attack, but at the same time a diabolical trap is set. **13...♗xc3?!** Falling into White's trap. 13...0-0 must be critical: 14.♔b1! ♗e7 (14...♗xc3 is still bad on account of 15.♗c5±) 15.g4 ♘f6 16.♗a7 ♖b7 17.♗d4± trying to push g4-g5 followed by f3-f4 and White's attack looks faster. **14.♗c5! d5 15.bxc3** 15.exd5! is more accurate: 15...♗a5?! (15...exd5 16.bxc3±) 16.♘xa5 ♕xa5 17.♗d6+−. **15...♗b7 16.♕h4 ♘f4 17.♕g3** (17.♔b1) **17...♘fg6 18.f4 ♘d7 19.♗b4 ♕xf4+?! 20.♕xf4 ♘xf4 21.♗d6±** Karjakin- Stellwagen, Wijk aan Zee 2009.

O 11...♗xc3?! 12.♕xc3 ♕xc3 13.bxc3 d5 14.♗d4! ♘ed7 15.exd5 ♘xd5?! (15...exd5 16.♖e1+±) 16.♗xg7 ♖g8 17.♗d4 and there is not enough compensation. Iordachescu-Macieja, Bermuda 2004.

O 11...♘c4?! Now White's initiative develops a lot easier. **12.♗d4 0-0 13.e5! ♗xc3** It is a pity to part with this bishop but the alternative is 13...♘e8? 14.♘xb5!+−. **14.♗xc3 ♘d5 15.♗d4 a5 16.♘c5 a4 17.a3 f6 18.exf6 ♘xf6 19.♗d3** 19.♕g3 e5 20.♗xc4+ bxc4 21.♕xe5 actually leads to the same position. **19...e5 20.♗xc4+ bxc4 21.♕xe5 d6 22.♕g3! ♗f5 23.♗xf6** 23.♖he1!?, bringing the last reserves into play, seems the best. **23...♖xf6 24.♘e4 ♖g6 25.♕f4 ♖f8** 25...♗xe4 26.♕xe4 ♖b8 27.♖he1 ♖xg2 28.♕e6+ ♕f7 29.♕xd6±. **26.♕d2 ♗xe4 27.fxe4 c3 28.bxc3 ♕c4 29.♕d5+** 29.g3! seems better, just leaving the queen swap for the next move: 29...♔h8 30.♕d4±. **29...♕xd5 30.exd5 ♖xg2 31.♖d2 ♖ff2 32.♖xf2 ♖xf2±** Kryvoruchko-Matsenko, Paleochora 2008.

12.f4



12...♘g6

O 12...♘c4?! Again giving White the option of exchanging on c4 the passive f1 bishop: **13.e5 ♘g4 14.♗d4 ♗b7 15.♗xc4! bxc4** 15...♕xc4? 16.♘a5 ♕c7 17.♘xb7 ♕xb7 18.h3! ♘h6 19.g4± leaves the h6 knight out of play. **16.♘d2** and now:

A) After **16...d5**, the resulting structure is ugly for Black and other moves

simply lose the c4 pawn: 17.h3 ♘h6 18.g4±; 16...d6?! 17.♕e2 dxe5 18.fxe5 ♘h6 19.♘xc4±;

B) **16...0-0** 17.♕e2! ♘h6 18.♘xc4±)

C) **16...♘h6** 17.♕e2! ♖c8 18.♘de4 ♘f5 (18...0-0 19.g4±) 19.g4! ♘xd4 20.♖xd4±. White's pieces are wonderfully centralized, which gives the first player the better attacking prospects, Volokitin-Macieja, Bermuda 2005.

13.e5 ♘g4 14.♘e4 0-0

O 14...♗b7 merely gives White an extra option (♘d6), as 15.♗c5 (15.♘d6+!?) 15...♗xe4 16.♕xe4 ♖c8 17.♗xe7 ♘xe7 18.♖d2 doesn't seem to solve all the problems.

O 14...♘xe3 15.♕xe3 0-0 16.♗d3 ♗b7 (Nezar-Iotov, Differdange 2007) and now 17.♔b1, before launching the assault h4-h5, gives White a nice initiative.

15.♗c5 ♗b7

15...♗xc5 16.♘exc5 f6 17.♕g3! ♘h6 18.♗d3 fxe5! (18...f5 19.♗e2±) 19.♗xg6 hxg6 (19...exf4? 20.♕f3+−) 20.fxe5 a5 21.♘e4± Karjakin-Movsesian, Spain tt 2006. There is no compensation for the doubled pawns and the hole on d6.

16.h3

16.♘d6!? is an interesting alternative which leads to great complications after 16...♗c6 (as well as after 16...♗d5 17.♖xd5 exd5) 17.h3 ♘h6.

16...♘h6

16...♗xe4 is waiting for a practical trial, but it looks as though after 17.hxg4! ♗xc5 18.♕xe4± the h-file should give White the initiative.

17.♗xe7 ♘xe7 18.♗d3

Simple development and a more harmonious piece disposition. This position will be widely discussed in the next few years, but I think the current assessment 'slight white initiative' is unlikely to vary.

18...♘d5

18...f6 19.exf6 gxf6 (19...♕xf4+ 20.♔b1 gxf6 21.♖f1+−) 20.♕h4 ♘hf5 21.♕f2 ♘g7± Ragger-P.Schlosser, Austria tt 2006/07 and White could have tried something more than threefold repetition.

19.♕d2!?

19.♖f1 Nepomniachtchi-Vitiugov, Novokuznetsk 2008, is another line for research; **19.♘ec5** ♘xf4 20.♗xh7+ ♔xh7 21.♖xd7 ♘xg2 22.♖xc7 (22.♕c3 ♕c6 23.♘d4 ♘f4 24.♖h2 ♕c8 25.♖xb7 ♘f5 26.♘xf5 exf5∞) 22...♘xe1 23.♖xb7 ♘f3∞.

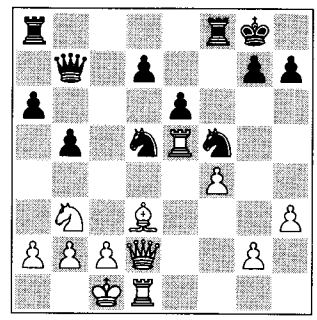
19...♘f5

19...f6 20.exf6 ♘xf6 21.♖he1± and White has a small structural advantage.

20.♖he1 f6 21.♘ec5

21.exf6± is the same as the note to the previous move. The move chosen here is more ambitious.

21...fxe5 22.♘xb7! ♕xb7 23.♖xe5±



Here we have a better structure and Black's knights are unstable.

23...♘d6?!

23...♘fe7 24.♗e4 ♖ac8 25.g3±.

24.f5!

The unsafe position of the black knights is suddenly made clear.

24...♘c4 25.♗xc4 bxc4 26.♘c5 ♕c7 27.♕d4± ♘e7?!

27...d6?! 28.♘xe6! dxe5 29.♕xd5+−; 27...c3!? 28.bxc3 ♖ac8 29.fxe6 dxe6 30.♘xe6 ♕xc3 31.♕xc3 ♘xc3± offers the most resistance, though maybe White can choose more ambitious lines.

28.♘xd7!+− ♖xf5 29.♖xe6 ♘g6 30.♘b6 ♖af8 31.♕xc4 ♖c5 32.♕b3 ♖b5 33.♘d5 ♕b7 34.♕c4 ♔h8 35.b3 ♖c8 36.♖de1 ♖f8 37.♖xg6 hxg6 38.♕h4+ 1-0

SUMMARY

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘c6 5.♘c3

– 5...a6 6.♗e3 ♘ge7: complex. White can keep the initiative, but Black has a lot of play and room for improvement ±

5...a6 6.♗e3 ♘f6 7.f4! and now:

– 7...d6: transposes to the Scheveningen, but White has an extremely aggressive line in 8.♕f3 ±

– 7...♗b4 8.♗d3 d5?!: spoils the position ±

– 7...♗b4 8.♗d3 d6: White gets a nice initiative by exchanging on c6 followed by 0-0 ±

– 7...♗b4 8.♗d3 ♕c7: interesting, even if not much investigated ±

– 7...♗b4 8.♗d3 ♕b6: a source of wild complications ±

5...♕c7 6.♗e3 a6 7.♕d2 and now:

– 7...b5 8.0-0-0 b4: ambitious and complex, plenty of room for research ±/=

– 7...b5 8.0-0-0 ♗b7: solid, although some variations are violent ±

– 7...♘xd4: solid and with plenty of room for research ±

7...♘f6 8.0-0-0 with the following branches:

– 8...♘g4?!: so far, good results, but suspicious ±

– 8...b5: strongly met by the ♗f4 variation ±

– 8...♗e7: nowadays in fashion, very dangerous, attacking races ±

– 8...♗b4 9.f3 b5: White gets a strong initiative ±

– 8...♗b4 9.f3 0-0: very interesting, no final evaluation ±/=

– 8...♗b4 9.f3 d5: doesn't work despite its logic ±

– 8...♗b4 9.f3 ♘e7: solid and very close to equalizing ±

– 8...♗b4 9.f3 ♘a5: original ideas, but not too much to face ♔b1 ±

8...♗b4 9.f3 ♘e5 10.♘b3 and now:

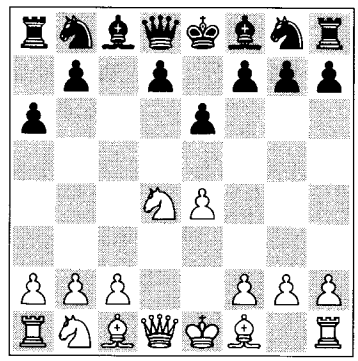
– 10...d5: quite healthy and not very explored ±

– 10...b5 11.♕e1 ♖b8: has held up for a long time, but Karjakin's idea is dangerous for Black ±

– 10...b5 11.♕e1 ♗e7: the solid main line, full of resources for both sides ±

CHAPTER 13

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 a6
Paulsen Variation



Evaluation *****

Introduction

The Paulsen Variation is one of the great systems within the Sicilian Defence. It has a long and successful history, having resisted not only all refutation attempts but even all attempts to guarantee a comfortable, even if slight, plus for White. The typical positions are strategically complex and ideal for playing for a win against all kinds of opponents. White has a wide choice on the 5th move; the most important possibilities are 5.♗d3, 5.♘c3, 5.♗e2 and 5.c4.

Variations involving a quick ♗e3 and 0-0-0 don't work well against the Paulsen. Therefore, I have tried to find a set-up which, while being dangerous for Black, has the same character as the variations we study in the other chapters. I think that my final suggestion fulfils these requirements and poses maximum problems for Black.

History

Louis Paulsen (1833-1891) was one of the great players and theoreticians in the 19th century. Born in Germany, he spent a long time in the United States, where his chess career started. A little eclipsed, first by Morphy and then by Steinitz, he took an active part in theoretical debates and developed his own style. This was characterized by an important defensive skill and, above all, an endless ability to come up with new opening ideas, mainly in the Sicilian Defence. Many Sicilian variations could well bear his name, but the one definitely known as the Paulsen Variation was actually introduced by Anderssen in the 1850s!

Paulsen analysed and started to play it some decades later. Curiously enough, it arose as a refinement on the move order intended to avoid the Szen Variation (1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cd4 4.♘d4 ♘c6 5.♘b5), which had posed serious

problems to the move order eventually revived by Taimanov.

It became part of the repertoire of some masters from the first half of the 20th century, such as Tartakower, but this was perhaps its darkest age. Around 1940 one of the pioneers of the Soviet School, Ilya Kan, started to study and play this set-up, with some success. That's why Russian players give this variation his name. Pretty soon, other famous theoreticians and coaches such as Koblents, Furman and Suetin added to the list, and this variation started being used by a wide group of first-rank Soviet masters, such as Taimanov, Tal and Polugaevsky; some years later they were joined by top players from other Eastern countries, like the Hungarian Lajos Portisch. This was for many years one of the most important weapons of the Soviet School, until the information boom in the last decades of the 20th century made its popularity grow at all levels.

Ideas

We could fill many pages talking about the ideas of this variation, being so rich in complexity and history. However, we can summarize them in two very important themes:

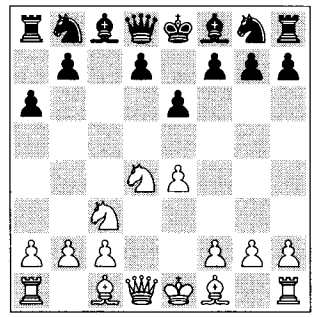
1) By keeping the d7 pawn still for many moves, Black discourages his opponent from carrying out blitz attacks, since the e6 pawn has a second defence. A further point is that the dark-squared bishop can develop to more active positions than just e7.

2) A quick pawn push ...b5, without a knight on c6 closing the long diagonal, creates immediate pressure on the e4 pawn, to the extent that in many lines it is generally acknowledged that the best developing square for White's light-squared bishop is d3 (as opposed to the typical move in other Sicilians, ♗e2) in order to provide a secure defence for the central pawn. The strength of the ...b5 counterattack has even caused a quick ♘c3 to be regarded as inaccurate according to some sources.

Game 13.01

Adams,Michael
Kasimdzhanov,Rustam
Tripoli (m/3) 2004

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 a6 5.♘c3



By choosing this move in all variations, White can open the game with 2.♘c3 or 3.♘c3 and thus toy with different transpositions. However, the main reason for this choice is the type of positions resulting: many of them involve a quick development with 0-0-0 and share some features with the variations chosen in other chapters.

5...b5

A classical move, to put immediate pressure on the e4 pawn. This plan got a new boost thanks to the next move.

O 5...♕c7 is the main move and will be studied in the following games.

O 5...d6 6.♗e3 transposes to Chapter 18.

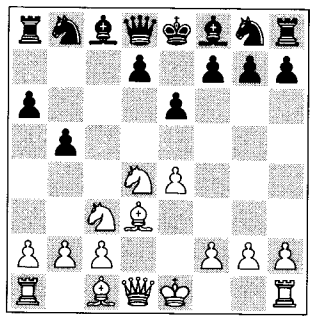
O 5...♘c6 transposes to Chapter 12.

O 5...♘e7 is the typical move intended to take the opponent out of the most theoretical lines; however, it is completely harmless against the general set-up we have designed, from which we would only depart for solid reasons: **6.♗e3!** Following our set-up **6...♘ec6** For 6...♘bc6 see Game 12.01. **7.♘b3** It is logical to avoid the exchange to expose the blockage of the black pieces. Black already has to worry about ♘a4. **7...d6** 7...b5 8.f4 and it is hard not to transpose, taking into account the b8 knight. **8.f4 b5 9.♗d3 ♗e7 10.0-0 ♘b4 11.♗e2!±** Conquest-Giffard, Calvia 2004; with the strong threat a2-a4.

O 5...♗c5?! has to be worse here than earlier on: 6.♗e3 d6 (6...♕c7 7.♕g4! forces Black to make a tough decision) 7.♕d2 ♘f6 8.0-0-0 (threatening some moves with the d4 knight) 8...♘bd7 9.♘b3!± and the d6 pawn suffers.

O 5...♗b4 The idea is correct (pressure on c3 and e4), but it is premature here, as White can develop, while dealing with the problem: 6.♗d2! ♘f6 (6...♘c6 is somewhat better: 7.♘xc6 – 7.a3!? ♗c5 8.♗e3 – 7...bxc6 8.♗d3 d5 9.0-0±) 7.e5 ♗xc3 8.bxc3! and we reach a position from the chapter on the Pin Variation, where Black has wasted one tempo with the useless move ...a6.

6.♗d3



6...♕b6

The idea that revived the ...b5 variation. Black tries to drive the white knight off to a less active position and then go on with normal development. The alternatives are:

O 6...♗b7 The natural move, but it doesn't offer the active play which it seems to promise, unless linked to ...♕c7. **7.0-0** ♘**c6** 7...♕c7 transposes to the next game. **8.♘xc6 ♗xc6** 8...dxc6 9.e5! – this is one of the drawbacks of omitting ...♕c7. The white pawn moves forward, freeing the e4-square for other pieces and hindering Black's development. 9...♕c7 10.♗f4±. **9.♖e1** Preparing a knight jump to d5; there is no good reply for Black. **9...♕b8** Preparing ...♗d6, which counters e4-e5 and allows Black to finish his development with no more setbacks. 9...♕c7? 10.♘d5!±; 9...♗e7 10.e5 and the black pieces can't get out; 9...♘f6 10.e5 ♘d5 11.♘e4±. **10.a4** In order to create a weakness before jumping to d5, although 10.e5 is a good idea too. **10...b4 11.♘d5!** Here the knight seriously disturbs Black's development. **11...♘f6** 11...♗d6 prevents ♗f4, but... 12.♕g4 is very strong: 12...♗xh2+ 13.♔h1 ♔f8 14.♘f4 ♗xf4 15.♗xf4 e5 16.♗g5 with good compensation due to the dark-squared bishop, the development lead and the black king's bad position. **12.♗f4! ♗d6 13.♗xd6 ♕xd6 14.♘b6 ♖b8 15.a5!** 15.e5 ♕d4 gives Black some counterplay. **15...♕f4** The most active. 15...♕d4 16.♗xa6!±. **16.♕f3!±** Berg-Mortensen, Denmark tt 2006; the queen swap highlights the weakness of the a6 and b4 pawns.

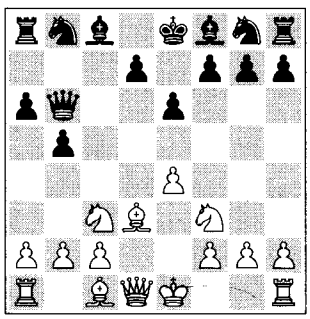
O 6...d6?! This move doesn't combine well with a quick ...b5, as now Black's

queenside pawns can be attacked and the dark-squared bishop can't defend them: 7.a4! b4 8.♘a2 ♘f6 9.0-0 ♗b7 10.♖e1 ♗e7 (10...a5 is more normal, but after 11.c3 Black is still in trouble) 11.♘xb4 Vallejo Pons-Van Wely, Monaco (rapid) 2006, and the b4 pawn has finally dropped.

O 6...♘e7 7.a4 I would consider this the logical move, although its results haven't been good. 7...b4 8.♘ce2 ♘ec6 9.0-0±.

O 6...♗c5 is another way to drive the active knight away, but its drawback is that it leaves the g7 pawn vulnerable. 7.♘b3 ♗e7 8.♕g4 and now Black has no good options. 8...g6 (8...♘f6 may be the lesser evil; 9.♕xg7 ♖g8 10.♕h6 ♘c6 11.♗d2 with insufficient compensation) 9.0-0 d6 and now 10.e5! is very strong because the unprotected black pieces allow some tactical tricks. 10...dxe5 (10...d5 11.♘d4) 11.♕e4 ♖a7 12.♕xe5.

7.♘f3!



An uncommon idea in the Sicilian; the knight obstructs the f-pawn, but this move has proved very efficient in this specific position because it consolidates the lead in development and supports the pawn push e4-e5. Black players have tried virtually all possible moves, but so far they haven't found a completely satisfactory solution. For the moment, Black has to face the positional threat 8.a4 and, if 8...b4 9.a5 followed by an eventual ♘a4-b6.

7...♕c7

The queen retreat is the most natural solution, and it increases the control over e5.

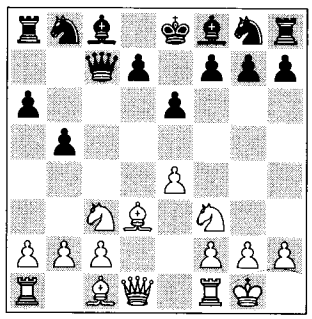
O 7...♘c6 is the other solution, and it also strengthens the control over the key square e5. **8.0-0 ♕b8** Black multiplies the surveillance over e5, and also takes into account the knight jump to d5, but even so, the straightforward approach is still possible: **9.e5! ♘ge7** 9...♘xe5?! has obtained good results in practice, but it is a suicidal pawn grab: 10.♘xe5 ♕xe5 11.♕f3 ♕b8 12.♗f4 ♗b7 13.♗e4 ♗xe4 14.♘xe4 ♕d8 15.a4 b4 Efimenko-Landa, Fürth 1986, and now, according to Efimenko's notes, White gets a significant edge with 16.♗e5! h6 17.c4! bxc3 18.♕xc3 ♖c8 19.♕g3 ♘f6 20.♗xf6 gxf6 21.♖ac1 ♖xc1 22.♖xc1±. **10.♖e1 ♗b7 11.♗e4 ♕c7** 11...f5? 12.exf6 gxf6 13.♘h4!+−. **12.h4!** Restricting Black's kingside play and virtually forcing ...0-0-0. **12...h6** 12...0-0-0 13.♘g5! **13.h5 0-0-0 14.♗e3 f5** (Najer-Smirin, Moscow 2003) and now: **15.exf6 gxf6 16.a4 d5 17.♗d3** with strong complications, in which the black king looks more exposed.

O 7...♗b7?! doesn't meet the threat previously mentioned, and after: 8.a4 b4 9.a5 ♕c7 10.♘a4± White gets a considerable edge, as 10...♕xa5?! runs into 11.♗e3! winning material.

O 7...d6?! has the same drawback: 8.a4 b4 9.a5 ♕c7 10.♘a4 ♘d7 11.♗e3!± ♗b7 12.♘b6 ♘xb6? 13.axb6 ♕c8 14.0-0 ♘f6 15.c3 ♘g4 16.cxb4 ♘xe3

17.fxe3 ♕c6 18.♘d4 ♕d7 19.♗c2+– A.David-Kriventsov, New York 2000.

8.0-0



8...♗b7

O 8...d6?! leaves White a free hand to start queenside operations: 9.a4 (9.♗d2!, preparing the blow, may be even better) 9...b4 10.♘a2 ♘c6 11.♗d2 ♕b7 12.♕e1 ♖b8 13.c3! (as usual, the final result is that the c-file opens...) 13...bxc3 14.♗xc3 ♘f6 15.b4! and White gets a pawn majority on the queenside. 15...e5 16.b5± Landa-A.Onischuk, Düsseldorf 2004.

O 8...♘c6 9.♖e1 d6 The last moves reflect the fierce battle for the e5-square, but now Black's radical solution has meant that again the f8 bishop surrenders control over b4, and White can carry out the alternative plan. **10.♗f4** Threatening e4-e5 for the last time. **10...♘e5** 10...e5? 11.♘d5 ♕b7 12.♗e3±. **11.a4!** The siege of the b-pawn starts. **11...b4 12.♘a2 ♖b8 13.c3** And continues... **13...bxc3 14.♘xc3** The opening of the c-file is a serious problem for Black, as his rooks are far from being coordinated. **14...♖xb2 15.♖c1 ♕a7 16.♖e2 ♖xe2 17.♘xe2 ♘xf3+ 18.gxf3 ♗d7** 18...♕d7 19.♕b3± with the idea of ♕b8. **19.♕b3 ♘e7 20.♗e3 ♕a8 21.♕b6 ♘g6 22.♖c7** White's pieces are getting into Black's position. **22...♘e5 23.♖b7 ♘c6 24.♘d4** Friedel-E.Hansen, Tulsa 2008.

9.♖e1 ♗c5

O 9...♗e7 is the most frequent move, but looks a bit odd as, counting on White's e4-e5, Black dooms his kingside development. **10.e5! f5** Necessary to prevent the white knight's jump to e4. 10...♘c6 11.♗f4±. **11.♗f4** The soundest option, though white players have tested some appealing moves such as 11.♘h4 and 11.♘g5. **11...♘h6** Only Felgaer has championed this move, but it seems the most reliable. This is definitely not the right moment to develop the knight with 11...♘c6?! because of the strong sacrifice 12.♗xf5 exf5 13.♘d5 ♕d8 14.♗e3⩲ with a crushing attack; 11...b4?! sends the knight precisely where it wants to go. 12.♘b1 ♘h6 13.♘bd2. **12.a4!?** Forcing the knight to move to c4, but it is worth waiting for Black's next move and then answering ...0-0 with ♗xh6, and ...♘f7 with a surprise, for example: 12.h3!? ♘f7 13.♗xf5! exf5 14.e6 ♕xf4 15.exf7+ ♔xf7 16.♘e5++–. **12...b4 13.♘b1 ♘f7 14.h4 h6** The most recent try. 14...0-0 15.♘bd2 ♘c6 16.♕e2 ♗c5 17.♘b3 ♗a7 18.♖ac1!± Areschenko-Felgaer, Gibraltar 2007. **15.♘bd2 ♘c6 16.♘c4** The prophylactic 16.h5!± deserves attention. **16...0-0 17.a5 g5** with some counterplay.

O 9...d6?! allows the usual plan 10.a4 b4 11.♘a2±.

O 9...♘c6 hasn't been played in this position, perhaps in fear of a potential knight jump to d5, but it is not clear how this can happen. In any case, this move doesn't forestall e4-e5, which

will lead to positions similar to those studied in other lines: 10.e5±.

10.♕d2

Not the only move to seek an advantage. Also interesting are 10.e5!? and 10.♗g5, but the threat ♕g5 poses some problems for Black and the queen move has other hidden ideas.

10...♗e7!

A radical solution, reckoning that the white queen is worse placed on d2 than on d1, precisely because she doesn't defend the f3 knight.

O 10...♘f6? falls in with White's intentions: 11.♕g5 0-0 12.e5 ♘d5 13.♗xh7+ ♔xh7 14.♕h5+ ♔g8 15.♘g5.

O 10...♘c6?! isn't a good solution either: 11.♕g5 ♗f8 12.♗f4±;

O 10...♘e7 opens the way for the first player's second idea: 11.b4! ♗xb4 12.♘xb5±; and lastly, **10...d6?** makes that second idea stronger. 11.b4! ♗xb4 (11...♗b6 12.a4±) 12.♘xb5±.

11.b3

All the games have followed this path, but other moves deserve a try, such as **11.a4!?** b4 12.♘e2 ♘f6 13.e5 ♘d5 14.♘f4 0-0 15.♕e2↑; or the simple **11.♕e2,** returning to the e4-e5 plan.

11...♘f6

11...d6 12.♗b2 ♘f6 13.a4 b4 14.♘a2 ♘c6 15.c3±.

12.♗b2

12.e5!? ♗xf3 13.gxf3 ♘h5 14.f4, e.g.: 14...♘xf4 15.♕xf4 ♕xc3 16.♗d2 ♕c7 17.a4⩲.

12...d6

12...0-0?! is risky: 13.e5 ♘d5 14.♘e4↑ and all of the white pieces are aiming at the kingside.

13.a4

Conditions are somewhat different, but White automatically answers ...d6 with a2-a4.

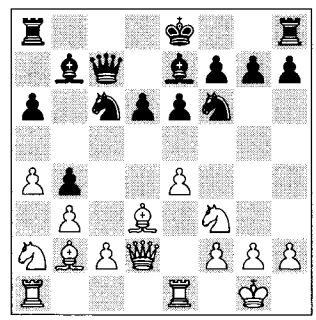
13...b4

13...bxa4? 14.♖xa4 ♘bd7 15.♖c4 ♕b8 16.♗a3 0-0 17.e5 ♘d5 18.exd6 ♗xd6 19.♗xd6 ♕xd6 20.♖h4, and once again, the white pieces are aiming at Black's castled position.

14.♘a2

14.♘e2, transferring the knight to the kingside, is an interesting idea, but the capture of the e4 pawn leads to an unclear position: 14...♘xe4 15.♗xe4 (15.♕f4!?) 15...♗xe4 (Fritz 11) 16.♕d4 ♗xf3 17.♕xg7 ♖f8 18.gxf3∞.

14...♘c6



15.♘d4!

The pawn can't be captured: **15.♘xb4** ♘xb4 16.♕xb4 d5∓; but it is possible to play the typical break **15.c3!?** bxc3 16.♗xc3 0-0, although here Black has been able to get the rooks into communication in time. 17.♕b2 (17.♖ec1

d5!; 17.♘b4 ♘e5) 17...♖fd8 18.b4 d5 19.exd5 ♖xd5∞ Brodsky-Evdokimov, Cappelle la Grande 2006.

15...♘xd4

15...a5?! surrenders the important b5-square and makes the break c2-c3 more appealing: 16.♘b5 (16.♖ac1!?) 16...♕d7 17.c3! bxc3 (17...d5?! 18.exd5 ♘xd5 19.c4±) 18.♘axc3 0-0 19.♖ad1±.

16.♗xd4 a5 17.♖ac1!

White prepares the strong break, but the check on b5 is equally good: 17.♗b5+! ♗c6 18.f3 ♗xb5 19.axb5 0-0 20.c4±.

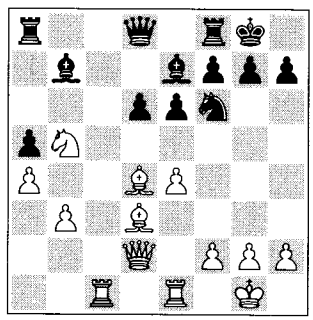
17...0-0

17...e5 18.♗b2 0-0 19.c3 bxc3 20.♘xc3 ♕b6 21.♘b5±, according to Adams' notes.

18.c3 bxc3 19.♘xc3± ♕d8

19...♕b8 20.♘b5±.

20.♘b5



White has consolidated a small but persistent edge, thanks to the outpost his pieces enjoy on the queenside. The rest of the game is very interesting, but we'll complete it with some notes based on Adams' annotations for *Chess Informant*.

20...e5 21.♖c7

21.♗c3!? d5 22.exd5 ♕xd5 23.♗f1 ♕xb3 24.♖xe5 ♗b4 25.♖g5 g6 26.♕d4±.

21...exd4

21...♗a6 22.♗b6 ♕b8 23.♖c6 d5 24.♗c7 ♕b7 25.♖b6 ♗b4 26.♕g5±.

22.♖xb7 d5 23.♕f4 ♗b4

23...dxe4 24.♗xe4 ♘xe4 25.♕xe4 ♗f6 26.♘c7 ♖b8 27.♖xb8 ♕xb8 28.♘d5±.

24.♖d1 dxe4 25.♗xe4 ♘xe4

25...♖e8 26.♗f3 ♖c8 27.♘xd4±.

26.♕xe4 ♕f6?!

26...♖c8 27.g3 ♗c5 28.♘a7 ♖a8 (28...♖c7 29.♘c6 ♕d6 30.♘xa5±) 29.♘c6 ♕d6 30.♘e7+ ♔h8 31.♘f5±.

27.♘c7± ♖ad8 28.♘d5 ♕d6 29.♕xd4 ♕e6 30.g3 ♖d6? 31.♖xb4!+– axb4 32.♘e7+ ♕xe7 33.♕xd6 ♕e2 34.♖d4 h5 35.♕xb4 ♕f3 36.h4 ♖c8 37.♕d2 ♖c3 38.♖f4 ♕c6 39.♔h2 ♖xb3 40.♕d8+ ♔h7 41.♕d1 ♖b7 42.♕xh5+ ♔g8 43.♖d4 ♕f6 44.♖d2 ♖a7 45.a5 g6 46.♕b5 ♔h7 47.♕b6 1-0

Game 13.02

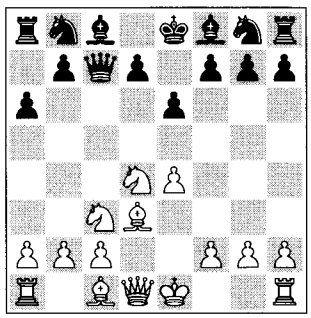
Baklan,Vladimir
Mastrovasilis,Athanasios
Korinthos 2004

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.♘c3 a6 4.d4 cxd4 5.♘xd4 ♕c7

Here the queen controls the e5-square. Black waits for one move to define his set-up, and leaves in the air plans with a

quick ...b5 and ...♗b7, or previous kingside play with ...♘f6 and the various different moves of the dark-squared bishop. This piece is the real main character in this variation.

6.♗d3



White firmly defends the king's pawn, pre-empting the pressure that may come by means of ...b5 and...♗b7.

6...b5

One of the most frequently-seen moves, but probably this is not very effective against ♗d3, as the pressure on the e4 pawn is already neutralized. On the contrary, the d3 bishop is usually clumsy in some attacking lines and it is more useful for Black to start thinking of the importance of the e5-square. The main alternatives 6...♘**f6** and **6...♘c6** will be studied in the next few games. Now we will consider the less common options:

O 6...♗c5?!, with the idea of driving the white knight away, is far worse than usual here, as the recurring drawback of the unprotected g7-square causes an uncomfortable problem. 7.♘b3 ♗e7 (7...♗a7? is even worse: 8.♕g4+− and Black is forced to make important concessions) 8.♕g4! g6 (8...♗f6 is artificial too. Here my suggestion is 9.♗f4! ♗xc3+ − 9...d6 10.♕g3+− − 10.bxc3 ♕xc3+ 11.♗d2 ♕f6 12.f4± with tremendous compensation on the dark squares) 9.♗g5 h5 10.♕h4 d6 11.0-0-0 ♘c6 12.♗xe7 ♕xe7 13.♕g3± Van der Wiel-Nijboer, Amsterdam ch-NED 1996; and Black has left many weaknesses on the dark squares, especially d6 and b6.

O 6...♗d6!? A recent and really interesting move, opposing White's advances on the dark squares (f2-f4). It is usually played after ...♘f6, but Black couldn't play it later against the line we suggest. **7.♕d2!** Another specific reply. White considers that f2-f4 must be prepared at all costs. **7...♘c6** 7...♗e7 8.♕e2 (8.♕f4!? ♗d6 9.♕h4 is an interesting idea, not tried yet, and if 9...♗e7 10.♕g3!± completes an unusual dance by the white queen) 8...d6 and now my suggestion is 9.f4! with similar plans to the main line, e.g.: 9...♘f6 (9...♘c6 10.♘xc6 bxc6 11.0-0±) 10.e5 (10.g4 is interesting) 10...dxe5 11.fxe5 ♘fd7 12.♗f4± and White must be better with his strong e5 pawn. **8.♘xc6 dxc6 9.♕g5! f6 10.♕h5+ ♕f7 11.♕e2** 11.♕xf7+ ♔xf7 12.♗e3± is enough for a better endgame in view of Black's queenside hole. **11...e5 12.0-0 ♘e7 13.♖d1 ♗c5 14.♘a4 ♗a7 15.♗e3!**± Charbonneau-Goletiani, Chicago 2006.

O 6...♗b4?! is less effective when e4 is well defended, as the exchange on c3 is hardly an option: 7.0-0 (7.♗d2!?) 7...♘f6 8.♗d2 ♘c6 9.♘xc6 bxc6 10.f4 followed by e4-e5 with advantage.

O 6...g6!? looks like a joke; however, it has frequently been played. By fixing the weaknesses on the dark squares too early, it makes White's plan easier. Now White can simply aim to exchange the

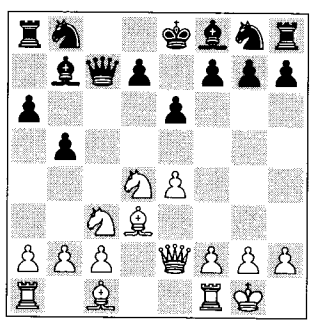
dark-squared bishops, or prepare an attack on the castled position by transferring his queen to h4, as in the stem game: 7.f4! ♗g7 8.♘f3 d6 9.0-0 ♘d7 10.♔h1 ♘gf6 11.a4 b6 (11...0-0 12.a5!?) 12.♕e1 ♗b7 13.♗d2 0-0 14.♕h4 and White has an excellent attacking set-up, e.g.: 14...♖ae8 (14...♘c5 15.f5! ♘xd3 16.cxd3 exf5 17.exf5 ♕c5 18.♘g5 gxf5 19.♖f4 ♕c8 20.♖af1→) 15.♖ae1 ♘c5 (15...e5 16.fxe5 dxe5 17.♗g5 ♖e6 18.♘d2!±) 16.♘g5! h6 17.♘f3 d5 18.e5 ♘fe4 19.♗e3! f5 20.exf6 ♖xf6 21.♘e5 ♘xc3 22.bxc3 ♘xd3 23.cxd3± Iordachescu-Gonzalez Zamora, Calvia ol 2004.

O 6...d6 7.f4 and it is hard not to play 7...♘f6, transposing to Game 13.03.

7.0-0 ♗b7

In case of the flexible 7...♘f6 our suggestion is 8.♕e2, threatening e4-e5 and, if Black doesn't transpose by ...♗b7, then 8...d6 is forced. After that, White starts the typical Paulsen plan of destroying the queenside with a2-a4: 9.♗d2! ♗e7 10.a4! b4 11.♘a2 a5 12.c3!±.

8.♕e2



The same plan (to set up ♘d5) may be prepared with the rook, which is another interesting move. Now Black has many replies, but each of them has a different drawback.

8...♘f6

The most natural move. Let's see the others first:

O 8...♘c6 9.♘xc6 ♕xc6 (9...dxc6 is clearly bad: 10.e5±; 9...♗xc6 (here it stands better to cope with the inevitable jump) 10.a4 b4 11.♘d5 ♕b7 12.♗f4± and in face of the threat ♘c7, new concessions will be necessary.

O 8...♘e7? merely jumps out of the frying pan (♘d5) into the fire: 9.♗xb5!± (9.♖e1!?, Carlsen-Kamsky, is really a strong move, but I see no reason not to play this) 9...axb5? 10.♘cxb5 ♕c5 11.♗e3+– and there is no defence against 12.♘xe6.

O 8...d6?! can be immediately punished in a classical fashion: 9.a4 b4 10.♘a2±.

O 8...♗c5 avoids the immediate problem, but helps White with his plan or, rather, with one of his plans, which is to play e4-e5 to restrict Black's position: 9.♘b3! ♗e7 10.e5! (once again, Black's development is blocked) 10...b4 11.♘d1 (11.♘a4!? may be better) 11...♘c6 12.♗f4 g5!? (a logical reaction in a position without many appealing options) 13.♗g3 h5 14.h3 h4 15.♗h2 g4 (Khusnutdinov-Zubarev, Naberezhnie Chelny 2006) and now 16.♕xg4 ♘xe5 17.♖e1± would give White a great edge.

9.e5

This pawn push is justified if White can later force the enemy bishop to leave its strong position, as will happen thanks to the development lead White enjoys.

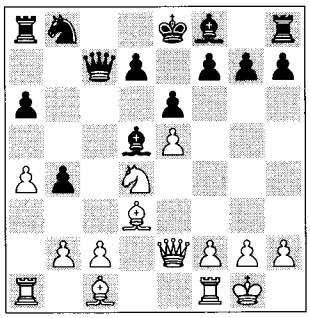
9...♘d5

9...b4 10.♘cb5! axb5 11.exf6 gxf6 12.♘xb5 ♕c6 13.f3± and Black's posi-

tion, even if quite active, lacks the minimum necessary solidity.

10.♘xd5 ♗xd5 11.a4! b4

11...♘c6?! 12.♘xc6 dxc6 13.b3! (threatening 14.c4) 13...b4 14.♗xa6±.



12.c4! bxc3 13.bxc3 ♕xc3

This pawn grab speeds up White's initiative, but otherwise, the pawn would advance to c4: 13...♘c6!? 14.♘f3 ♗c5 (14...♗xf3 15.♕xf3 ♕xe5 16.♗f4 ♕a5 17.♖ab1⩲) 15.♗f4!± threatening c3-c4.

14.♗b2 ♕a5 15.♖fc1 ♘c6 16.♘b5!

16.♘c2 followed by ♘e3 is a quieter, but also effective treatment.

16...♕b6

16...axb5? 17.axb5 ♕d8 18.bxc6 dxc6 19.♖xa8 ♕xa8 20.♖a1⩲.

17.♘d6+

17.♘c3! is far stronger and the d5 bishop lacks a good retreat. Let us see: 17...♗b3 (17...♗c5 18.♘xd5 exd5 19.♖ab1±) 18.♘e4 ♗e7 19.♗c3 0-0? 20.♘f6+!+−.

17...♗xd6 18.exd6 ♘d4?!

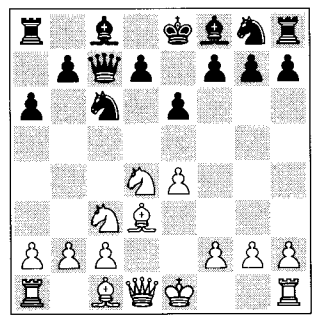
18...0-0? wasn't possible: 19.♗xh7+ ♔xh7 20.♕h5+ ♔g8 21.♗xg7+−; but after 18...♕b4!? the position was still complicated.

19.♕d2! e5 20.♖e1 f6 21.a5 ♕a7 22.♖a4± ♘e6 23.♖h4 ♕b7 24.♗xh7 ♔f8 25.♖b4 ♖xh7 26.♖xb7 ♗xb7 27.♕b4 ♗c6 28.♖c1 ♘d8 29.f4 exf4 30.♕e1 ♖h6 31.♕e7+ ♔g8 32.♕e8+ ♔h7 33.♖xc6 dxc6 34.♗d4 c5 35.♕e4+ 1-0

Game 13.03

Fressinet,Laurent
Vachier-Lagrave,Maxime
Val d'Isere ch-FRA 2004

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.♘c3 a6 4.d4 cxd4 5.♘xd4 ♕c7 6.♗d3 ♘c6



One of the most solid variations in the set-up chosen by White with his last two moves. By attacking the knight, Black provokes a change in the pawn structure. In the main line, the structure tends towards symmetry.

7.♘xc6 dxc6

The best recapture. The alternatives both have drawbacks:

O 7...♕xc6?! The queen loses her grip on e5 and is badly placed on the long diagonal. White can exploit both themes thanks to his development lead.

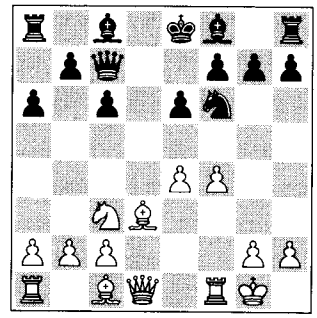
8.0-0 b5 (this exposes the problems of the queen on the diagonal. 8...d6 is met by the classical plan e4-e5: 9.f4 ♘f6 10.♔h1 ♗e7 11.e5! ♘d7 12.♕e2 ♘c5 13.♗e3 ♘xd3 14.cxd3 b5 15.♖ac1+– Papaioannou-Gesos, Athens 2001) 9.e5! ♗b7 10.♗e4 ♕c7 11.♕f3 ♖b8 12.♗xb7 ♕xb7 13.♘e4±.

O 7...bxc6!? This strengthens the centre, but doesn't seem a good combination with the queen on c7. 8.0-0 (8.♕e2!? may lead to the same positions and perhaps works somewhat better against the standard move ...♘f6; a further point is that it forestalls ...d5. 8...♘f6 9.e5!? ♘d5 10.0-0±) 8...♘f6 (8...d5!? is an interesting move order, which we could have avoided by playing ♕e2 first: 9.♕e2 ♗b7 10.b3 trying to transpose to 8...♘f6) 9.♕e2 d5 (9...♗e7 10.e5 ♘d5 11.♘xd5 cxd5 12.♗f4±; 9...♗b7 10.e5!; 9...d6 10.f4 – here it is also interesting to switch to the ♘a4 & c2-c4 plan – 10...e5 11.fxe5 dxe5 12.♗e3 ♗e7 13.♘a4±) 10.b3! (10.♖e1 ♗b7 11.e5 ♘d7 12.♘a4 c5 13.c4 d4∞ is not so clear) 10...♗e7 11.♗b2 0-0 12.♘a4 ♗b7 13.e5 ♘d7 14.c4±. We have reached one of the typical positions in this variation; the white pieces are aiming at the kingside, but also, thanks to the important c4 pawn, are hindering the mobility of Black's centre.

8.0-0 ♘f6

8...e5 9.f4 usually leads to the position as in the game; 8...b5 is an imprecise order, because it allows the interesting push 9.e5!, e.g.: 9...♕xe5 10.♖e1 ♕c7 11.♘e4 ♗b7 12.♕f3 ♘e7 13.♗f4 with enormous compensation.

9.f4



9...e5!

Of course, Black can't allow e4-e5. If Black plays **9...♗c5+** it is because he intends to continue ...e5: 10.♔h1 h5 (10...b5 11.e5 ♘d5 12.♘e4 ♗e7 13.♕h5±) 11.e5 ♘g4 12.♘e4 ♗a7 13.h3 ♗d7 14.♕e1± and White develops his plans, while Black has to pay constant attention to the capture on g4 and can't find a good place for the king.

10.♔h1 ♗c5

10...♗d6 forces White to close the position, but then the bishop will need another tempo to become active: 11.f5 h5 (11...♗c5 12.♕f3 h5 13.♘a4 ♗a7 14.♗e3± with a grip on the queenside dark squares) 12.♗e3! (taking control of the important diagonal) 12...b5 13.a4 b4 14.♘b1 ♕e7 15.♘d2± Lanka-Rodewis, Germany tt 1991/92.

11.♕e1!

Usually reaching the same positions as with f4-f5 followed by ♕f3, but the queen is more flexible here.

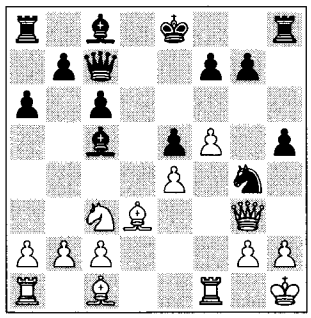
11...♘g4

O 11...b5?! is premature before closing the centre: 12.fxe5! (12.a4 b4 13.♕g3!?∞) 12...♘g4 (12...♕xe5 13.♗f4 ♕e7 14.e5 ♘d5 15.♘xd5 cxd5 16.♕g3± puts Black on the brink of di-

saster) 13.♗f4 ♗e6!? (13...b4? 14.e6!+−; 13...♕e7!? 14.e6! ♗xe6 15.e5± making room for the knight on e4) 14.h3! ♘xe5 15.♘d5! (here we can see one of the virtues of the position of the white queen) 15...cxd5 16.exd5 ♘xd3 17.cxd3 ♕e7 18.dxe6 0-0!± and Black loses a pawn, but there are good drawing chances in the resulting endgame.

O 11...h5!? leaves many options for White: he can try to transpose with f4-f5, or fight for the a7-g1 diagonal by means of ♘a4 and ♗e3, or play fxe5 with similar ideas to the previous line. However, we need practical tests to make a correct assessment of this line.

12.♕g3 h5 13.f5



13...♕e7

Preventing the plan ♗g5 followed by ♗h4 and h3, which can be quite annoying. Black has tried many options:

O 13...b5 14.♗e2! (let's take a pawn!) 14...♘f6?! (Forster-Cacho Reigadas, Leon 1996) and now White really should have captured on g7, with an edge; 14...♗b7 15.♗xg4 hxg4 16.♕xg4 f6± with some compensation.

O 13...♗d7 14.♗g5 f6 15.♗h4 0-0-0 16.h3 ♖h7± reaching a weird position, which is therefore difficult to assess. It looks as though White can make great progress on the queenside, with moves like ♘a4 and b2-b4, whereas Black is somewhat blocked on the kingside and will have to move his knight some day (normally, when White plays ♕e1). However, a conclusive evaluation is risky before we have practical examples.

13...♔f8?! is too artificial; 14.♗g5±.

14.♗e2

As in the ...b5 variation we analysed in the previous note, White simply tries to win a pawn, and this primitive plan looks efficient enough.

14...♗d7 15.♗xg4 hxg4 16.♕xg4 0-0-0 17.♕g3 ♖h5 18.♗e3 ♖dh8 19.h3!±

19.♗xc5 is a strange, though not bad, decision: 19...♖xh2+ 20.♕xh2 ♖xh2+ 21.♔xh2 ♕xc5 22.♖f3 ♕e7 23.♖d1. I think White has slightly better winning prospects, but the game ended in a quick draw: 23...♔c7 24.♖df1 ♕g5 25.a3 ♕d2 26.♖1f2 ♕c1 27.b4 b5 28.♖g3 ♕h6+ 29.♖h3 ♕c1 ½-½ Tseshkovsky-Pikula, Zlatibor tt 2006.

19...g6

19...♗xe3!? 20.♕xe3 g6 slightly worsens the position of the white queen.

20.♗xc5 ♕xc5 21.♕d3

21.♖ad1! gxf5 22.♕d3 is a better move order, because the rook is out of play.

21...gxf5 22.exf5

22.♖ad1! ♕e7 23.exf5±.

22...♕d4 23.♕xd4 exd4 24.♘e4±

And Black can't win the pawn back.

24...♖8h6

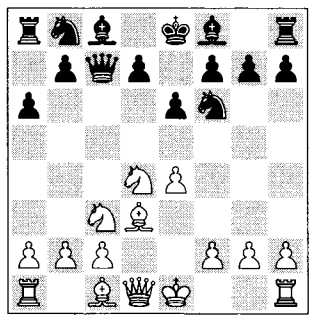
24...♗xf5?? 25.♘d6+.

25.♖ad1 c5 26.♘xc5 ♗xf5 27.♘d3 ♗e4 28.♔h2 ♖g5 29.♖d2 f5 30.♘f4 ♖c6 31.♖ff2 ♖g7 32.♘e2 1-0

Game 13.04

Iordachescu,Viorel
Rublevsky,Sergey
Tripoli (m/3-rapid) 2004

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.♘c3 a6 4.d4 cxd4 5.♘xd4 ♕c7 6.♗d3 ♘f6



At last, the main move. Once the white bishop is placed on d3, Black gets ready to build what we might call the ideal Sicilian structure, which is: ...♕c7, ...♘f6 and ...♘bd7, ...a6, ...b5, ...♗b7 and ...♗e7. White should play actively and prevent his opponent from completing this set-up.

7.f4!? b5

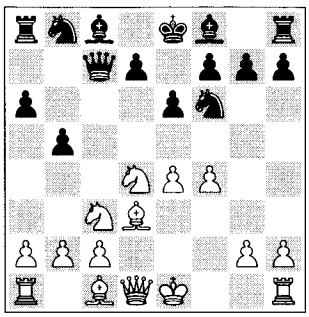
O 7...♗b4!? As we said, this is relatively ineffective when the e4 pawn is well defended, but here it uses the fact the f4 pawn is hanging. 8.0-0 (8.♗d2 doesn't work out well because the f4 pawn is unprotected: 8...♗xc3! 9.bxc3 – 9.♗xc3 ♕xf4 certainly gives White some compensation, but it is not clear – 9...d6 10.0-0 e5 11.♘b3∞) 8...♗c5 (other moves wouldn't justify Black's development, for example: 8...♗xc3 9.bxc3 ♕xc3 10.♘b3 – intending to play e4-e5 – 10...d6 11.♗a3 ♕c7 12.c4 b6 13.♗c2 and Black can't resist the pressure on the dark squares) 9.♘e2 ♘c6 10.c3 d6 11.♔h1↑ Lanka-Wahls, Hamburg 2002.

O 7...♗c5?! Very feeble; it allows White to carry out his plans without opposition: 8.♘b3 ♗b4 (8...♗a7 9.e5±) 9.0-0! d6 10.♗d2 ♘c6 11.a3±, securing the capture of the important bishop.

O 7...♘c6 Far less precise than on the previous move. **8.♘xc6! ♕xc6** Compared with the previous game, capturing with a pawn would be clearly unsound, because the structural goals (...e5 in one case, ...d5 in the other) are not achieved: 8...bxc6 9.e5; 8...dxc6?! 9.e5±. **9.♕e2 ♗b4** 9...b5?! 10.e5 ♘d5 11.♘xd5± and Black can't capture with the queen; 9...♗c5 10.e5 ♘d5 11.♘e4±. The white knight arrives at its ideal square, winning time. **10.♗d2 d6** 10...d5 is the way to maintain the pressure, but trading Black's developed pieces can only favour White: 11.exd5 ♘xd5 12.♘xd5 ♗xd2+ 13.♕xd2 ♕xd5 14.0-0-0±. The development lead is great and White will win even more tempi at the expense of the black queen. - **11.0-0-0** White is building an aggressive set-up, just with natural moves. **11...♕c7** 11...e5?! is the move demanded by the position, but it is tactically flawed: 12.♘d5!± prevents ...♗g4 and poses several threats. **12.♔b1** 12.a3 ♗c5 13.e5 is quite appealing. **12...♗a5 13.♖he1** 13.e5 again deserves consideration. **13...♗d7 14.e5!** At last! **14...dxe5 15.fxe5 ♗xc3 16.♗xc3 ♘d5**

17.♗d2± Kovchan-Shtyrenkov, Noyabrsk 2003; the knight can't stand on d5 and the dark-squared bishop will dominate the board.

7...d6 see the next game.



8.♕e2

Now White plans to play e4-e5. An immediate 8.e5 is an interesting alternative, but Black can keep a complex position with 8...b4.

8...♗b7

8...b4 is logical, yet still untried. Probably, after 9.♘a4 a transposition is Black's best option, but more moves can be considered: 9...♘c6 (9...♕a5?! worsens the queen's position: 10.b3 ♗b7 11.0-0 followed by a2-a3) 10.♘b3 ♗e7 11.♗e3 ♖b8 12.c4±.

9.♗d2

This move can introduce two different plans. The first and most natural is queenside castling followed (or preceded) by a pawn assault on the kingside. The second is the possible breaks (a2-a4 or a2-a3) on the queenside to exploit the early ...b5.

9...b4

The most frequent, though it makes White's queenside task easier. Black has tried virtually all the other possible developing moves:

9...♗c5?! Once again, this encourages White's plan: 10.♘b3 ♗e7 11.e5 ♘d5 12.♘e4± Tiviakov-Akesson, Batumi Ech-tt 1999.

O 9...d6?! has the drawback that the bishop loses control over b4 and thus White's blow on the queenside is stronger: 10.a4! (10.0-0 is also very interesting; it keeps the option of a2-a4 and also a possible ♘f3 and e4-e5) 10...b4 (10...bxa4 11.♖xa4±) 11.♘a2 e5 (what else?) 12.♘b3 ♘c6 (12...a5 13.c3± leads to the powerful and well-known opening of the c-file and the weakening of the b5-square) 13.♘xb4 ♘xb4 14.♗xb4 exf4 (Mortensen-Hellsten, Copenhagen 1997) and now the simple 15.♗d2± would have gained a pawn without compensation.

O 9...♘c6 is one of the most efficient moves here, though Black's knight forgoes its ideal square, d7: 10.♘f3 (10.♘xc6 ♗xc6 doesn't achieve much here, though e4-e5 and ♘e4 is possible; 10.♘b3!?) 10...♘b4 11.0-0 ♘xd3 12.cxd3∞ and White will have play along the c-file.

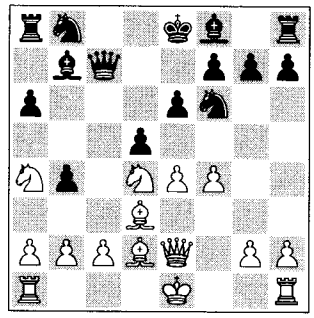
O 9...♗e7 10.e5 ♘d5 hasn't been played, but it is not that strong: 11.♘e4 ♘c6 12.♘xc6 ♗xc6 13.0-0±.

10.♘a4 d5

Allowing an ideal French structure, although the black knight can jump to e4. It is natural to look for more options, but all of them lack practical examples.

10...♘c6 11.♘b3± followed by ♗e3 and the b6-square will cause Black suffering;

10...♗e7 11.c3! with problems along the c-file.



11.e5!

This pawn push is logical, as it closes the b7 bishop and secures the d4-square. White just needs to be wary of the black knight on e4. Let's see.

11...♘e4 12.♗e3 ♘d7

The natural development, keeping a watch on the two sensitive points in Black's position: e5 and b6.
12...♕a5?! provokes b2-b3 but has the eternal flaw of leaving the queen in a terrible position: 13.b3 ♘d7 (13...♗e7? 14.♘xe6 fxe6 15.♗b6+–) 14.0-0 ♗e7 (14...♘dc5 15.f5!±) 15.f5+– and White has a crushing attack, according to Iordachescu's notes in *Chess Informant*;
12...♘c6 13.♘b3!± with too many holes on the dark squares.

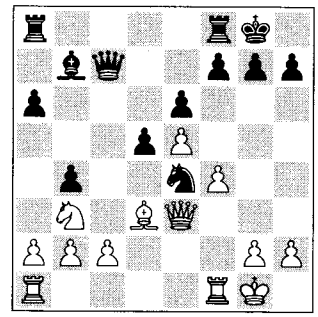
13.0-0 ♘dc5

The knight is too annoying on the edge. Black has to do something about it one way or the other. The other possibility is 13...♗c6, but then: 14.♘xc6 ♕xc6 15.♗xe4 dxe4 (15...♕xa4 16.♗d3± ♘c5 17.f5→) 16.b3 ♗e7 17.♖ac1± followed by c2-c3 and White has an absolute grip on the position.

14.♘xc5 ♗xc5 15.♘b3 ♗xe3+ 16.♕xe3±

White has the d4-square (maybe the c5-square as well) and the better bishop, which can be exchanged at the precise moment for the e4 knight. Nevertheless, the position still requires great skill. Anyway, the truth is that the results of the opening are far from appealing for Black.

16...0-0



17.a3!

A very good plan, opening the game on the queenside for the white rooks and creating new targets.

17...bxa3

17...a5 18.axb4 axb4 19.♕d4 ♕e7 20.♕b6± Iordachescu.

18.♖xa3 ♖ab8

Black soon gives up passively defending his pawns and tries to place his pieces in active positions on the queenside.
Another very different plan would be based on the break ...f6 and kingside counterplay. Iordachescu analyses this plan deeply in *Chess Informant*. His conclusion is that White keeps the advantage with this variation: 18...f6 19.♗xe4 dxe4 20.♘c5 ♗d5 21.c4! ♖ac8 22.cxd5 ♕xc5 23.♕xc5! ♖xc5 24.dxe6 fxe5 (24...a5 25.♖fa1 fxe5 26.♖xa5 ♖xa5 27.♖xa5 exf4 28.e7

♖e8 29.♖e5 e3 30.g3 fxg3 31.hxg3+−) 25.f5±.

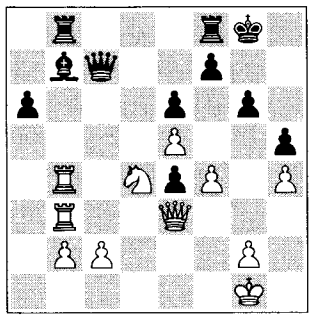
19.♘d4!

With the simple idea ♖fa1 and ♗xa6. The direct 19.♖fa1 is less clear on account of 19...f6!?.

19...♕b6 20.♖b3 ♕c5 21.♖a1 g6 22.h4 h5

22...♘d2 looks like a good try, but makes things easier for White, as it forces the queen swap: 23.♕xd2 ♕xd4+ 24.♕f2 ♕xf2+ 25.♔xf2+−.

23.♖a4 ♕e7 24.♗xe4 dxe4 25.♖ab4 ♕c7



26.♖b6?!

Here Iordachescu gives detailed analysis of 26.f5, the logical culmination of the plan. 26.f5! exf5 (26...a5 27.♖b5 a4 28.♕h6+−) 27.♘xf5 ♕xe5□ 28.♖xb7 ♖xb7 29.♘h6+ ♔h7 (29...♔g7 30.♖xb7+−) 30.♖xb7 ♕g7 31.♘xf7 (31.♕f4 ♕xh6 32.♖xf7+ ♖xf7 33.♕xf7+ ♔h8±) 31...♖xf7 32.♖xf7 ♕xf7 33.♕xe4+−.

26...♗d5!±

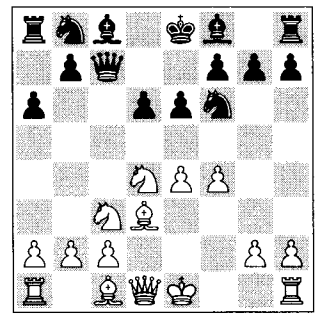
With this move, Black holds the position and leads the game to an endgame, in which White's advantage is difficult to realize.

27.♖xb8 ♖xb8 28.♖xb8+ ♕xb8 29.b3± ♕d8 30.g3 ♕a5 31.♔f2 ♕a1 32.c4 ♗b7 33.♘e2 ♕h1 34.♘c3 ♕h2+ 35.♔e1 ♗c6 36.♘e2 ♕h1+ 37.♔d2 ♕b1 38.♕c3 a5 39.♘d4 ♗b7 40.c5+− ♗d5 41.c6 e3+ 42.♔xe3 ♕e4+ 43.♔d2 ♕g2+ 44.♔c1 ♔g7 45.c7 ♗b7 46.♘c2 ♗c8 47.♔b2 ♕f2 48.♕xa5 ♕xg3 49.♕a8 ♗d7 50.♕d8 ♕d3 51.c8♕ 1-0

Game 13.05

Iordachescu,Viorel
Ahmed,Esam Aly
Bled ol 2002

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 a6 5.♘c3 ♕c7 6.♗d3 ♘f6 7.f4 d6



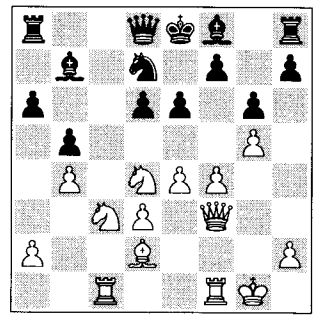
The main line: Black opposes the pawn push e4-e5. White has tried different plans here; some are based on 0-0 and e4-e5 (starting by 0-0 or ♘f3) and others are based on 0-0-0 (starting by ♗e3, ♕e2 or ♕f3). The prophylactic a2-a4 has been given a try as well. Among all the plans, we have chosen one based on 0-0-0 and later g2-g4. We don't guarantee that this is the best option, but it is the one that fits in best with the remainder of the suggested

variations in this book. However, it is true that there are so many plans that it is sometimes possible to shift to another without much study.

8.♕f3!? b5

Clearly the most logical move. Black not only gets ready for a pawn assault, in view of White's predictable 0-0-0, but he also plans to deploy the bishop on b7 to counter the white queen.

O 8...♘bd7 Occupying the f6 knight's natural retreat square just encourages White to launch an assault: **9.g4 ♘c5** 9...h6 is less effective than in similar Najdorf lines, as here the h1 rook is protected: 10.h4! h5 11.g5 ♘g4 12.g6!± Ivanovich Balsinde-Ortega Valle, Cullera 2005. **10.g5 ♘fd7 11.♗d2** In this line, the bishop is usually more efficient on d2 (defending the knight) than on e3. 11.♗e2!?, threatening an immediate b2-b4, as there is no way out for the c5 knight, also looks quite strong. **11...b5 12.b4** Virtually forcing the exchange on d3 and hoping to make use of the c-file, rather than hiding the king on the queenside. White's pieces will be really active and the kingside breaks will expose the black king. However, we mustn't forget that the white king's position will also be very open for the rest of the game. **12...♘xd3+** 12...♘a4 13.♘xa4 bxa4 14.0-0 looks very promising, quickly occupying f5; 12...♘b7 this is a miserable spot for the knight and White has a strong move: 13.a4±, but perhaps the still untried 12...♗b7! is not so bad 13.bxc5 dxc5± winning the piece back, though White can win a pawn on b5. **13.cxd3 ♗b7 14.0-0 g6** Trying to pre-empt the break on f5, always preceded by ♖ac1 and, if necessary, ♗e3. **15.♖ac1 ♕d8**



16.♘d5 Tal style. However, the natural attacking development, 16.f5! and if 16...exf5 17.♕f2, looks really strong. **16...exd5 17.exd5 ♗g7 18.♖fe1+** 18.♘c6!? **18...♘e5?** Black collapses. The refutation of White's sacrifice, if indeed there is one, would be 18...♔f8!?. **19.fxe5 dxe5 20.♘c6±** Stefansson-Velikov, Cappelle la Grande 2005.

O 8...♗e7 9.g4 It is possible that here the quiet 9.♗e3, followed by 0-0-0 and g2-g4, is a more sensible approach. But so far the text move has achieved excellent results. **9...♘c6** 9...b5 10.g5 ♘fd7 11.a3 (11.♗e3 is more in the spirit of this line) 11...♘c6 12.♘xc6 ♕xc6 13.♗e3 ♖b8 14.♘e2?! (come what may, White should have castled queenside) 14...♘c5∞ Iordachescu-Portisch, Linares Open 2000. **10.♘xc6** Since defending the knight fails due to 10.♗e3 ♘xd4 11.♗xd4 e5, logically White opts for the immediate exchange. **10...bxc6** 10...♕xc6 would allow a natural development of White's initiative: 11.g5 ♘d7 12.♗e3 followed by 0-0-0 and kingside breaks. **11.g5 ♘d7 12.b3** Seeing that the b-file is going to open, fianchettoing the bishop is a good plan, though we will see whether Black can make use of the file against standard development. For example: 12.♗e3 ♖b8 13.0-0-0 ♕b7 14.b3 ♕b4 15.♗d2↑ intending ♔b1 and then the knight jump. **12...♕a5?!**

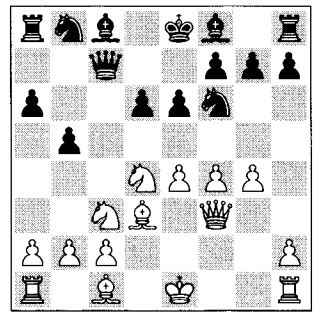
Black's reply justifies b2-b3. **13.♗d2 ♕c7 14.h4 d5 15.h5 ♗b7 16.g6** - 16.0-0-0!, intending to play h5-h6 or a stronger g5-g6 on the next move, is sound and enough. **16...fxg6 17.hxg6 h6** (Yegiazarian-Kalashian, Yerevan ch-ARM 2006) and now **18.0-0-0**, with a strong attack against the enemy king, wherever he tries to hide.

O 8...♘c6 9.♘xc6 As we saw in the 8...♗e7 line, this exchange is satisfactory, though here it was possible to play 9.♗e3!?. **9...bxc6 10.0-0** We show this alternative plan, considering that for the 0-0-0 plan, ♗e3 was more consistent, but it was perfectly possible here as well. **10...♗b7 11.e5!?** 11.♕g3!, preparing e4-e5, is strong, e.g.: 11...e5 12.fxe5 dxe5 13.♗e3 and it is not easy to develop. **11...dxe5 12.fxe5 ♕xe5 13.♘e4 0-0-0** 13...♗e7 seems the best defence: 14.♗f4 ♕d4+ 15.♗e3 ♕e5 16.♖ae1 with good compensation. **14.♗f4! ♕h5** (Ong-Le Quang, Yerevan Wch-jr 2006) and White can now choose between recovering the f7 pawn or continuing the attack.

O 8...g6 9.h3 ♗g7 10.♗e3 ♘c6 11.♕f2 ♗d7 12.0-0-0 ♘b4 13.♔b1 0-0 14.g4↑ Iordachescu-Manolache, Galatzi 2007.

9.g4

The most logical move within the fixed plan. Other possible moves, already tried, are **9.a3**, pre-empting 9...b4, and 9.♗e3, speeding up 0-0-0. Lastly, there is a very interesting and still untested move, though it perhaps means shifting to another plan: **9.e5!?** ♗b7 10.♕g3 dxe5 11.fxe5 ♘fd7 (11...♗b4?! 12.0-0 ♘h5 13.♕g5 g6 14.♘e4±) 12.♗f4↑ and we already know that a strong pawn on e5, together with an open f-file, involves a great danger for the black king.



9...♗b7

The natural development: the bishop aims at the enemy pawn, queen and rook. The alternatives are:

O 9...b4 10.♘ce2 d5 11.e5 ♘fd7 (11...♘e4 12.♘g3! and the knight can't remain on e4) 12.♗e3 ♗b7 13.♕g3 (13.0-0-0!?) 13...♘c5 14.0-0-0 ♘bd7 15.♔b1 0-0-0 16.♖hf1 (16.♖c1 intending c2-c3 is quite consistent with Black's disposition along the c-file) 16...♗e7 17.♘b3± Ganguly-Dudas, Budapest 1998.

O 9...♘c6?! This is far less accurate once Black has played ...b5, as the knight swap displaces the black queen and is therefore useful for White: 10.♘xc6! ♕xc6 11.g5 ♘d7 12.♗e3 ♗b7 13.a3! (now it is important to prevent ...b4 and the black pieces are not well prepared to break on b4; 13.0-0-0 b4 14.♘e2 ♘c5 15.♘g3 ♖c8↑) 13...♘c5 14.f5! 0-0-0 15.0-0-0± Van der Weide-Soderberg, Amsterdam 2000, and White's initiative is overwhelming.

O 9...♘fd7 This simply pre-empts the inevitable push g4-g5 and tries to be more flexible with the rest of the pieces. 10.♗e3 ♘c5 and now White can choose between two plans: a2-a3 and 0-0-0, or 0-0, which also allows pawn breaks like f4-f5 and eventually g5-g6.

10.g5 ♘fd7 11.h4

This move doesn't seem to be very necessary for White's attack, at least at this moment. It was more sensible to complete the development by choosing one wing to castle: 11.♗e3!?; 11.a3!?.

11...♘c6 12.♗e3 ♘c5 13.♘xc6

This is thematic before castling. However, it looks like immediate castling was possible here: 13.0-0-0!? ♘b4 (13...♘xd4 14.♗xd4 b4 15.♘e2 ♖c8 16.♔b1 d5 17.♗xc5 ♗xc5 18.f5↑) 14.♔b1 ♘bxd3 15.cxd3 b4 16.♘ce2± and White will use the c-file.

13...♕xc6 14.a3 0-0-0?!

Giving up all counterplay against White's 0-0-0. White's aggressive display sometimes has a psychological effect. Critical was 14...♘xd3+ 15.cxd3 ♕d7! 16.f5 (16.0-0-0 a5!) 16...exf5 17.0-0∞.

15.0-0-0±

Now White has a free initiative on the kingside. The black king isn't there, but positional threats are important as well.

15...♕c7 16.♔b1 d5?!

Black rushes in again; this tactical manoeuvre backfires. 16...♔b8 17.f5 g6±.

17.exd5 ♖xd5!

17...♗xd5? is worse in view of 18.♘xd5 ♖xd5 19.♗e2+–.

18.♘xd5 ♗xd5 19.♕h3 ♗xh1 20.♕xh1

Black has exposed his castled position and given up his bishop pair. Now he tries to solve the problems by trading queens.

20...♕b7

20...♘xd3? 21.♕a8++–.

21.♕xb7+

Sufficient for a clear edge in the endgame. It was also possible to keep on playing for the attack with 21.♕e1! ♘xd3 22.♖xd3+–.

21...♔xb7 22.♗e2+– ♔c7 23.c4!

Black misses his light-squared bishop.

23...bxc4 24.♖c1 ♔b7 25.♖xc4 ♘d7 26.♗f3+ ♔b8 27.♗c6 ♔c7 28.♗a4+ 1-0

SUMMARY

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 a6 5.♘c3

– 5...b5 6.♗d3 ♗b7: White gives Black a lot of trouble with the idea ♘d5 ±

– 5...b5 6.♗d3 ♕b6: White creates problems with the idea e4-e5 ±

5...♕c7 6.♗d3 and now:

– 6...♗d6!?: interesting idea but ♕d2 forces f2-f4 and White gets something ±

– 6...g6: has certain sting in spite of its odd appearance. White must play vigorously ±

– 6...b5: perhaps a bit hasty, but solid ±

– 6...♘c6: one of the soundest lines, if Black then captures with the d-pawn and plays ...e5 ±/=

6...♘f6 7.f4 and now:

– 7...♗b4: more interesting than its reputation. Complicated positions ±/=

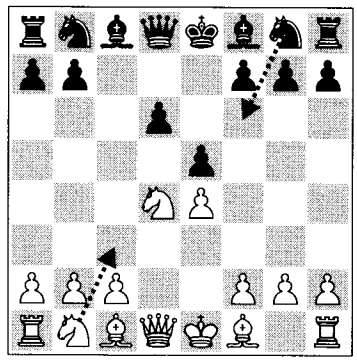
– 7...b5: in spite of the quick counterplay, White manages to keep on top ±

– 7...d6 8.♕f3!?: leads to interesting double-edged positions ±/=

Section IV

CHAPTER 14

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 e5 or 4...♘f6 5.♘c3 e5



Evaluation **

The idea of an early ...e5 in the Sicilian has become popular in more and more positions. In the variation we are dealing with here, however, this move is assessed as incorrect, due to the check on b5. In my view, the highly theoretical lines are not so clear, and Black can get active play even if it costs a pawn. In the suggested line, White is content with a slight edge but Black's chances of counterplay are very limited and that makes ...e5 not very appealing.

This variation appeared in the 1940s and Tartakower played it occasionally. From then on, it has never enjoyed the respect of the top players.

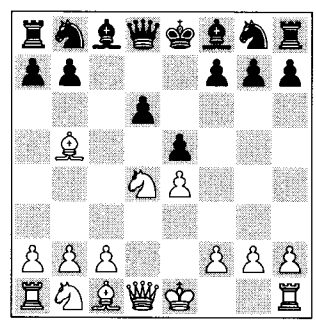
Game 14.01

Khairullin,Ildar
Zviagintsev,Vadim
Tomsk 2006

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 e5

This typical Sicilian move has a bad reputation here, as the weakness of the d5-square may give White's development a clear target. Quite often it ends up transposing to 4...♘f6 5.♘c3 e5, which we will see in the next game, but in this first example we are going to focus specifically on the non-transposing variations. Both lines have experienced some revival in recent years. This is probably due to the fact that the theoretical recipes used to give Black some counterplay.

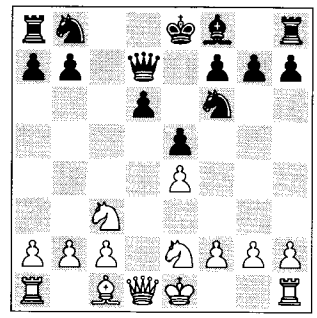
5.♗b5+!



This important intermediate check is the only chance to exploit the move order chosen by Black. Retreating the knight would not mean that White gives up fighting for an opening edge, but this fight would transpose into variations we do not recommend in this book.

5...♘d7

5...♗d7 This move looks anti-positional but allows Black an easy development and it is hard to refute completely. **6.♗xd7+ ♕xd7 7.♘e2!** Against the other, more ambitious, moves, Black players have had certain success by quickly putting some pressure on the e4 pawn: 7.♘f5 ♘f6 8.♘c3 ♘xe4∞. **7...♘f6** 7...♕g4?! is an ideal variation for rapid tournaments but, if White knows the right recipe, Black just loses a lot of tempi. 8.♕d3! (actually, this move defends both pawns) 8...♕xg2? (of course, it is better to play 8...♘f6 9.♘g3 – 9.♘bc3 ♕xg2∞ is less clear – 9...♘c6 10.♘c3± but White has a comfortable grip on d5 for free) 9.♖g1 ♕xh2 10.♕f3+–. The black queen comes immediately into danger and although Black can save her with cunning play, it will be at the expense of serious concessions. 10...g5! (the best) 11.♗xg5 ♗h6 12.♗f6! (12.♖h1 ♕xh1+ 13.♕xh1 ♗xg5 14.♘bc3 ♘c6 15.♖d1 0-0-0 16.♕h5 h6 17.♕xf7 ♘f6 18.♕e6+ ♔b8 19.♖xd6+– and the fate of the game is beyond question) 12...♘xf6 13.♕xf6 ♖f8 14.♕f3?! (14.♘bc3!+– and Black has no good defence against the threats 15.♘b5 and 15.♖d1) 14...♕h4 15.♖h1 ♕g5 16.♕h3 ♗g7 17.♖g1 ♕h6 18.♕c8+ ♔e7 (Cherin-Mateo, Conegliano 2008) and now 19.♕xb7+ ♘d7 20.♘bc3+– would secure a decisive advantage. **8.♘bc3**



A) **8...♕g4** is now less popular, less appealing and less... incorrect. White has a wide choice, but all the moves just lead to a slight plus. 9.♘d5! (not played yet, but it is the simplest way. 9.♘g3±, though eventually White has to move his king, is also sufficient) 9...♘xd5 10.♕xd5 ♘c6 11.♘g3±;

B) **8...♕c6** 9.♘g3 ♘bd7 10.♗g5± Dochev-Bojkov, Pleven ch-BUL 2005;

C) **8...♘c6?!** is not very flexible and allows White's thematic manoeuvre against the d5-square: 9.♗g5 ♗e7 10.♗xf6 ♗xf6 11.♘d5±;

D) **8...h6** Strategically desirable, but somewhat slow if Black wants to equalize. 9.0-0 ♘c6 10.♗e3 d5?! (again, logical, but it simply exchanges one problem for another. 10...♖d8!? 11.♘g3 d5 12.exd5 ♘xd5 13.♘xd5 ♕xd5 14.♕g4± and White's development lead will soon become something more tangible) 11.♘xd5 ♘xe4 12.c4± (E.Pähtz-Petrenko, Plovdiv Ech-tt 2003) with better development, an annoying knight on d5 and the immediate prospect of a rook on d1, which would cause Black trouble;

E) **8...♗e7** 9.♗g5 (9.0-0 0-0 10.♘g3±) 9...0-0 10.0-0 ♕e6 11.♗xf6 ♗xf6 12.♘d5 ♗d8 13.♕d3±

Grischuk-Grachev, playchess.com 2006. White has applied the thematic plan and has a lasting edge based on the grip on the d5-square and the fact that Black's dark-squared bishop is relatively inactive.

6.♘f5

Of course, this is the most ambitious move. Without it, the check on b5 wouldn't make sense at all.

6...a6 7.♗a4!

With even more reason than in its twin variation (inserting ...♘f6 and ♘c3), exchanging on d7 is a very important concession.

7...b5

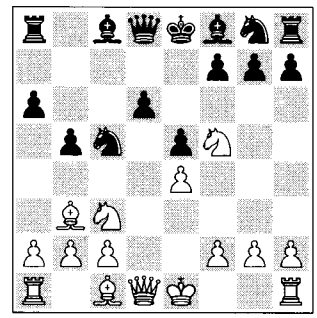
The only move in view of the threat on d6.

8.♗b3 ♘c5

○ 8...♘b6, controlling d5, is the main alternative, and the normal move, on the principle of 'playing for squares'. **9.♘c3 ♘f6** 9...♗xf5 10.exf5 ♘e7 does not work on account of 11.♗g5!± f6? 12.♕h5+ g6 13.fxg6 ♘xg6 14.♕f3+−. **10.♗g5 ♗xf5 11.exf5 ♗e7 12.0-0!** 12.♗xf6 must be enough for a very slight edge: 12...♗xf6 13.♗d5 ♘xd5 14.♕xd5 0-0 15.0-0-0 ♕b6 16.♘e4± Shavtvaladze-Nikolaou, Kallithea 2008; with a pleasant blockade position. **12...0-0** 12...♕d7 13.♕d3 0-0 14.♖ad1±; 12...b4?! 13.♗xf6 bxc3 14.♗xg7 ♖g8 15.♗h6 cxb2 16.♖b1 ♗g5 17.♗xg5 ♕xg5 18.♕f3±. **13.a4! b4** 13...♕d7 14.axb5 axb5 15.♕f3±. **14.♗xf6 gxf6?** A horrible move after which White has a very clear edge, but other moves wouldn't have solved all his problems either: 14...bxc3 15.♗xe7 ♕xe7 16.bxc3±; 14...♗xf6 15.♘e4! d5 16.♘xf6+ ♕xf6 17.a5±. **15.♘d5! ♘xd5 16.♗xd5±** Rodriguez- Cruz Lima, Cuba 1996.

○ 8...♘df6?! is too artificial: 9.0-0 (9.♘c3!?) 9...♗xf5 10.exf5 ♘e7 11.f4 ♘c6?! (11...♘xf5⩲ deserves research although White's compensation is enormous) 12.♗e3 ♗e7 13.♘c3 0-0 14.♘d5± Stefansson-Johnsen, Gausdal 1990.

9.♘c3!?



A more positional approach than the one suggested in DLS. This is grounded on the logic of avoiding theoretical battles in rare lines.

9.♗d5!? ♗xf5 (9...♗b7?! 10.♗xb7 ♘xb7 11.♘c3±; 9...♖a7? 10.♗c6+ ♗d7 11.♘xd6++−) 10.exf5 ♖c8 11.g4!? (this ambitious move must work, but for those who don't like such radical measures against marginal variations, we have something simpler: 11.0-0!?) 11...e4 (11...♘e7 12.♗g2±; 11...h5!?∞ deserves attention) 12.b4!? (12.♘c3! ♘f6 13.g5 ♘xd5 14.♕xd5 ♕e7 15.♗e3± followed by 0-0-0) 12...♕f6! 13.bxc5 ♕xa1 14.♗e3⩲.

9...b4

9...♘f6 transposes to the next game; **9...♗xf5** 10.exf5 ♘f6 is reasonable,

though we don't have practical experiences. The classical plan 11.♗g5 ♗e7 12.♗xf6 ♗xf6 13.0-0 0-0 14.♘d5± offers here a minimal edge, though perhaps enough to discourage Black, as he completely lacks any active prospects.

10.♘d5 g6!?

One of the modern ideas in this variation. Black develops his bishop on g7, 'ignores' the crowd of white pieces controlling d5 and dreams of a future ...f5. Philosophically interesting, but hard to achieve.

The normal **10...♘f6** would meet the classical treatment: some exchanges and recycling a knight to d5: 11.♘xf6+ ♕xf6 12.♘e3± and the e4 pawn is untouchable: 12...♕g6 (12...♘xe4? 13.♕d5! ♕xf2+ 14.♔d1+–) 13.0-0 ♘xe4 14.♗a4+! ♗d7 15.♗xd7+ ♔xd7 16.f4+–.

11.♘fe3 a5

11...♘xe4? 12.♗a4+!+–.

12.♗c4!?

The bishop takes an important diagonal. 12.0-0± is also possible.

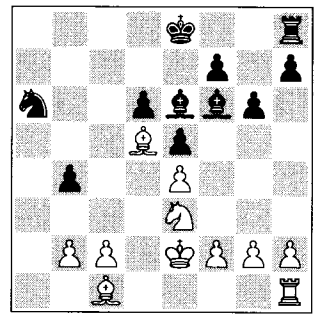
12...♗g7 13.♕f3

Maintaining tight control; 13.♗b5+!?.

13...♘f6 14.♘xf6+ ♕xf6 15.♕xf6 ♗xf6 16.♗d5 ♖a6 17.a3! ♗e6

17...b3!? gives some counterplay: 18.♗c4! (18.cxb3 ♗e6 19.♗c4 ♘xb3 20.♗xa6 ♘xa1∞) 18...bxc2 (18...♖a8 19.cxb3 ♗e6 20.♘d5±) 19.♘d5! ♗d8 20.♗b5+ ♗d7 21.♗xa6 ♘b3 22.♗c4 ♘xa1 23.♗e3± and Black must give a pawn to avoid losing the knight.

18.axb4 axb4 19.♖xa6 ♘xa6 20.♔e2±



After some exchanges, the grip on the d5-square remains.

20...♘c5

20...♗g5!? solves the main problem, but now the white rook can occupy the a-file and create some new ones: 21.♗xe6 fxe6 22.♗d2 ♔d7 23.♖a1±.

21.♗d2 b3 22.♗b4 bxc2 23.♗xc5 dxc5 24.♗xe6 fxe6 25.♖c1±

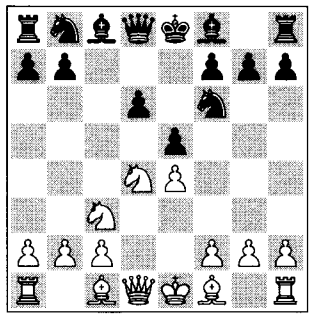
And finally, the continuous transformation of advantages has led to an endgame which, while being very depressing for Black, still offers certain drawing hopes.

25...♔d7 26.♖xc2 ♖b8 27.♘c4 ♔c6 28.♔d2 ♖d8+ 29.♔c3 ♖d4 30.f3 ♗d8 31.♖c1 ♗c7 32.♖a1 ♔b7 33.♘d2 ♗b6 34.♘b3 ♖b4 35.♘c1 ♖d4 36.♘d3 ♖d8 37.♘xe5 ♗c7 38.♘c4 g5 39.h3 h5 40.♔c2 ♖f8 41.♔d3 ♖d8+ 42.♔e2 ♖d4 43.♖c1 h4 44.b3 ♖d8 45.♘b2 ♗d6 46.♖d1 ♔c7 47.♘c4 ♗g3 48.♖xd8 ♔xd8 49.♔d3 ♔c7 50.e5 ♔c6 51.♔e4 ♔b5 52.♘d6+ ♔c6 53.♘f7 ♗f4 54.♘h8 ♔b5 55.♘g6 ♔b4 56.♘f8 ♔xb3 57.♘xe6 c4 58.♘d4+ ♔b4 59.♔d5 1-0

Game 14.02

Liss,Eran
Uritzky,Maxim
Tel Aviv 1996

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e5



This pawn push used to be more popular than the one in the previous game, but they are becoming equally so. In the set-up I propose, variations usually transpose or are at least very similar.

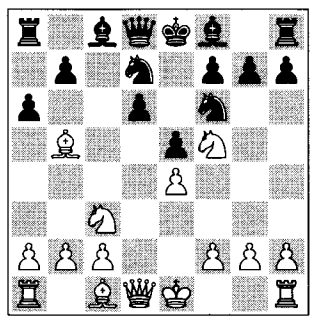
6.♗b5+

Again, the only move that can pose problems.

6...♘bd7

6...♗d7 7.♗xd7+ ♕xd7 8.♘de2!± (Dochev-Bojkov, Pleven 2005) transposes to the notes in the previous game.

7.♘f5 a6



We have reached the key position. My suggestion is a positional treatment where White seems to have good chances of exploiting the weakness on d5. The most theoretical line, which in the end leads to the win of a pawn, offers Black reasonable counterplay.

8.♗a4!

8.♗xd7+ ♕xd7 9.♗g5 ♘xe4 10.♘xg7+ ♗xg7 11.♘xe4 0-0 12.♕xd6 (12.♘f6+?! is the first idea that comes to mind, but it fails on tactical grounds: 12...♗xf6 13.♗xf6 ♕f5 14.♕xd6 ♕e4+ 15.♔f1 ♗h3! – the point! 16.♖g1 ♗e6∞) 12...f6 13.♕xd7 ♗xd7 14.♗d2 f5 (14...♗c6!? is also interesting) 15.♘c5 ♗c6 16.♘e6 ♖f7 17.0-0-0 (Am.Rodriguez-Nijboer, Amsterdam 1989) and now 17...♖e8! gives Black good counterplay: 18.♘g5 (18.♘xg7 ♖xg7∓) 18...♖d7 19.f3 ♗f6 20.♘h3 ♖g7⩲.

8...b5 9.♗b3 ♘c5

9...♘b6 is the only alternative and after 10.♗g5 we reach a variation already analysed in the previous game.

10.♗g5!

Always fighting for the d5-square. This move has the unanimous support of all players, though there are reasonable alternatives like 10.0-0.

10...♗xf5

It is almost impossible to go on playing with the enemy knight on f5, but there is at least one alternative, played by Bator (an expert in this line), that deserves attention: **10...♗b7!?** 11.♗d5 ♗xd5 12.♗xf6 ♕xf6 13.♘xd5 (The specific treatment 13.♕xd5 ♖c8 is not enough to finish

the game: 14.♖d1 ♕e6! 15.♕xe6+ ♘xe6 16.♘xd6+ ♗xd6 17.♖xd6 b4) 13...♕d8 14.0-0 (14.♕f3! is my suggestion for improvement: 14...g6 15.♘fe3 ♗g7 16.0-0 0-0 17.♖ad1±) 14...g6 15.♘g3 ♗g7 16.b3 a5 17.♕e2 ♖b8 18.a3 0-0 and Black has certain activity, Lindberg-Bator, Copenhagen 1984.

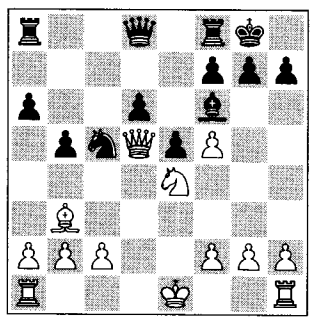
11.exf5 ♗e7 12.♗xf6 ♗xf6

Another critical moment. White has played in the standard way and has reduced Black's counterplay to a minimum. However, now White has to show that his position leads to more than a comfortable draw.

13.♕d5

White shows he is content with a small plus, reducing Black's counterplay to a minimum. It is possible to get a similar edge in the line: 13.0-0 0-0 14.♘d5 e4 (14...♘d7 – intending ...♘b6 – 15.a4! bxa4 16.♗xa4 ♘b6 17.♗b3±) 15.c3 a5 (Lacasa Diaz-Vernay, Salou 2006) and now 16.♗c2! b4 17.♖e1 ♖e8 18.♕g4±.

13...0-0 14.♘e4!



It was necessary to stop ...e4.

14...♕a5+

Black has always played this, and it is logical, as it disturbs the enemy king. Alternatives:

O 14...♘xe4 15.♕xe4 a5 16.0-0 a4 17.♗d5 ♖c8 18.♖ad1±.

O 14...♘xb3?! 15.axb3 ♕d7 16.g4 and there is no way to counter the two centralized white pieces.

O 14...a5 15.a3 ♖c8 16.0-0 a4 17.♗a2 ♘xe4 18.♕xe4 ♔h8 19.♖ad1 ♖c5 20.c3 g6 21.♖d3 ♕e7 22.♖fd1 ♖d8 23.♗d5 ♔g7 24.♖f3 ♖dc8 25.h4 h5 26.fxg6 fxg6 27.♖g3 ♕e8 28.♗a2 d5 29.♗xd5 ♖d8 30.♖gd3 ♖cc8 31.g3 ♖d6 32.♗f7 1-0 Lopez Martinez-Vernay, Salou 2006.

15.♔e2!

The king isn't in great danger here, and for the moment White must do without c2-c3, to avoid making Black's counterplay easier: 15.c3 b4 16.♖d1 bxc3 17.bxc3 ♖ab8 18.♗c4 ♗d8!∞ Zagrebelny-Vasilevich, Alushta 1994.

15...♖ac8?!

Har Zvi regards this move as dubious, as White can capture the pawn. In that case, Black has better, though not appealing, alternatives:

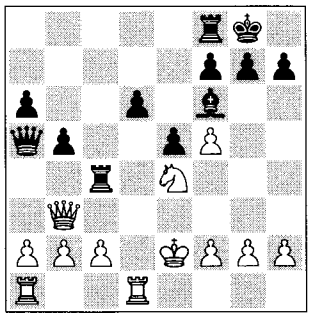
15...♕b4 16.♔f3! ♘xe4 17.♕xe4 ♕c5 18.♖hd1 ♖ac8 19.a4 ♕b6 20.axb5 axb5 21.g3± Soffer-Bykhovsky, Israel 1995; **15...♘xe4** 16.♕xe4 ♕b6 17.♖hd1±.

16.♖hd1

Sufficient for a small edge, but let's have a look at Har Zvi's suggestion. **16.♘xd6!? ♘xb3** 16...♖c7 17.♘xf7 ♘xb3 (17...♖fxf7?? 18.♕a8++–; 17...♖cxf7? 18.♕xc5+–) 18.♘d6+ ♔h8 19.♕xb3 ♕b6 20.♘e4±. **17.♕xb3 ♖c6** 17...♖cd8 18.♖hd1±.

18.♘e4 ♗e7 19.♖hd1 ♖c4 20.f3 ♖fc8 21.c3± and Black can't break through White's position, and therefore the extra pawn is decisive. This line is the key to why the system starting with 5...e5 is in decline.

16...♘xb3 17.♕xb3 ♖c4



18.f3

18.♘xd6? ♖b4 19.♕c3 (19.♕a3? ♕xa3 20.bxa3 ♖a4∓) 19...e4 20.♕d2 e3!∞; 18.♘xf6+?! gxf6 19.♖xd6 ♕c7⇄.

18...♕c7 19.c3 ♕c6?

Giving up the pawns without enough reason; this makes White's task easier. 19...♗e7 20.♖d5 ♖d8 21.♖ad1±.

20.♘xd6 e4 21.♘xe4± ♗e5?!

21...♖xe4+ is the logical follow-up of Black's manoeuvre but after 22.fxe4 ♕xe4+ 23.♔f1± there is not enough compensation.

22.♕c2!

White prevents possible threats and at the same time prepares b2-b3.

22...♕h6

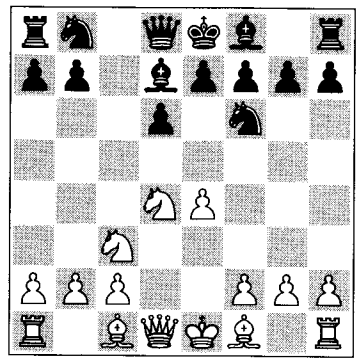
22...b4 23.b3.

23.h3 ♕f4 24.♖d5+– ♗c7 25.♖e1 ♗d8 26.♕d2 ♕b8 27.♖d1 ♗h4 28.♖d6 ♖e8 29.♔f1 ♗e7 30.♖d7 ♕a8 31.♕d5 ♕xd5 32.♖1xd5 ♖cc8 33.♖a7 ♗f8 34.f6 g6 35.♖dd7 b4 36.♖xf7 1-0

SUMMARY
1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 e5
– 5.♗b5+ ♗d7: anti-positional but, however, quite solid ±
– 5.♗b5+ ♘d7 6.♘f5 a6 7.♗a4!: this ends up being passive for Black as well, though for the moment, it leaves more material on the board ±
1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e5
This is a reflection of the previous lines:
– 6.♗b5+ ♗d7: transposes to the variation above
– 6.♗b5+ ♘bd7 7.♘f5 a6 8.♗a4: with similar positions to 4...e5 ±

CHAPTER 15

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 ♗d7 Kupreichik Variation



Evaluation **

The variation starting with 5...♗d7 is relatively new in international tournaments. Its main virtue is that it takes the opponent out of theory quite soon. Also, positions typical of other Sicilian lines can be reached. We should not underestimate this variation, as is reflected in the statistics. However, white players can get quite promising positions if they take it seriously and face it like any other line, with the advantage that deep theoretical researches are not necessary.

History

Lein played it occasionally in the 1960s, but then this variation remained forgotten until it was rescued in the 1990s by Viktor Kupreichik, a player with great tactical skills, who prefers to avoid long theoretical battles. Kupreichik's good results drew the attention of some other players such as Efimov, Kengis (curiously, from a game in which he played as White against Kupreichik and lost), Heberla, Pavel Blehm and Predojevic. Its theory is still getting started but, if we consider the need players have nowadays for wide and varied repertoires, it should develop faster and faster in the near future.

Ideas

It is hard to believe that a move like 5...♗d7, with so little flexibility, has any virtue at all; or at least, that it has some tangible advantage over 5...♘c6, but when you go deeply into it, you can see it indeed has some. For example, Black has the manoeuvre ...e5 followed by ...♗c6 in some variations, and the bishop can even support a pawn assault (with ...b5, ...b4, ...a5, etc.) against the enemy queenside. Nevertheless, I still think that its main idea is just to take the opponent out of theoretical paths and play a relatively normal Sicilian. When choosing 5...♗d7, Black players must be prepared for transpositions to

structures like the Dragon, Scheveningen or Richter, and that demands a great command of the Sicilian.

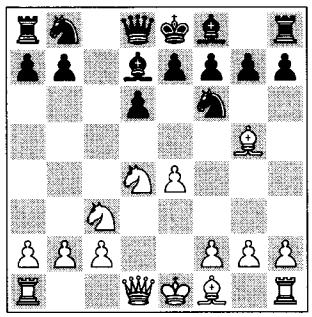
Game 15.01

Zude,Arno
Kupreichik,Viktor
Germany Bundesliga B 1992/93

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 ♗d7

This is a quite normal developing move, but doesn't look very flexible. That's probably the reason why it has never been widely popular. White has tried virtually all possibilities, and Black replies by trying to transpose to classical variations in favourable conditions, in order to take advantage of the move ...♗d7. As in the case of the Classical Variation 5...♘c6, our suggestion is:

6.♗g5



Toying with the possibility of eventually doubling the pawns, but especially keeping the option of reaching similar positions to those in Chapter 17.

6...e6

The normal reply, but Black could also consider:

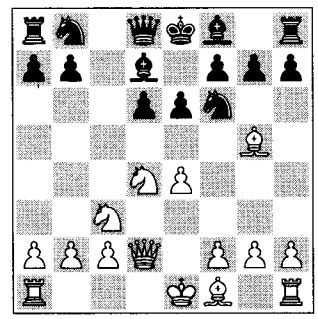
O 6...♘c6 7.♕d2 transposes to Chapter 17.

O 6...♗c6 An odd try by Efimov, who occasionally plays 5...♗d7. 7.♗xf6! gxf6 8.♕h5 (this is an ideal position for the queen in these structures) 8...♘d7 9.♗c4 ♘e5 10.♗b3 ♘g6 11.f4 (White's typical plan runs smooth and fast) 11...e6 12.f5 ♕a5!? (a cunning survival resource, but White's edge is out of the question) 13.0-0-0 (13.♘xc6 bxc6 14.0-0± and the knight can't leave without allowing a disaster) 13...0-0-0 14.♕h3 ♘f4 15.♕f3 ♗h6 16.♔b1 exf5 (finally Black is forced to make important concessions to avoid an immediate defeat) 17.♘xc6 bxc6 18.exf5± Kindermann-Efimov, Portoroz tt 1998.

6...a6?! doesn't seem to combine well with ...♗d7. White has now a pleasant and wide choice, but we can be content to play 7.♕d2. It is hard to see then how to play as Black, apart from ...e6 transposing to the main game, or 7...♘c6 transposing to Chapter 17.

7.♕d2?!

As the alternative 7...h6, analysed in the next note, looks quite sensible, I think the best move order is **7.f3!** a6 8.♕d2.



7...a6

O 7...♗e7 8.0-0-0 ♘c6?! (8...0-0 9.f3) 9.♘db5±.

O 7...h6!? 8.♗xf6 (8.♗e3?! ♘g4 would justify Black's choice of this particular move order) **8...♕xf6!** (8...gxf6?! 9.♘db5 ♕b6 10.0-0-0±) and now none of the two knight jumps offers White much, and other moves leave Black with the bishop pair for nothing:

A) **9.♘cb5** ♘c6! 10.♘c7+ ♔d8 11.♘xa8 ♕xd4∓ and the a8 knight is doomed;

B) **9.♘db5** ♗xb5 10.♗xb5+ (10.♘xb5 ♕xb2 11.♖d1 ♘a6 12.♘xd6+ ♗xd6 13.♕xd6 ♕b4+ 14.♕xb4 ♘xb4 15.♗b5+ ♔e7 16.♖d7+ ♔f6⇄) 10...♘c6 11.0-0 (Simacek-Heberla, Pardubice 2006) and after 11...♗e7, followed by ...0-0, it doesn't appear that Black has any reason to be scared.

8.f3!

This is a key move, and the only way to reach the English Attack set-ups we suggest.

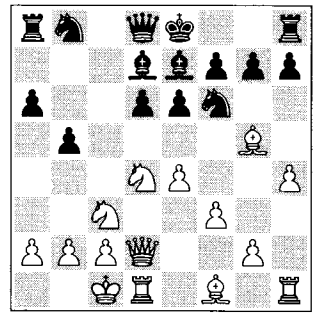
O 8.0-0-0?! h6! 9.♗e3 ♘g4∓. In this variation, ...♗d7 is better than ...♘c6, which would allow an exchange on c6, followed by ♗c5, as we'll see in Chapter 17;

O 8.f4 h6! and White must give up his bishop, which offers Black reasonable play: 9.♗h4? ♘xe4∓.

8...♗e7

8...b5 is the other attempt temporarily to avoid transposition, but Black will end up developing his knight on c6. Let's see: 9.0-0-0 b4 10.♘ce2 ♕b6?! (10...♘c6 11.♘xc6 ♗xc6 12.♘d4±) 11.♗e3± F.Nemeth-Manea, Baile Tusnad ch-ROM 2005.

9.0-0-0 b5 10.h4



10...b4

As on all previous moves, **10...♘c6** is the natural move, transposing to the Classical Sicilian.

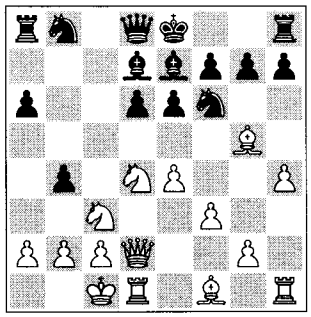
O 10...h6!? 11.♗e3 b4 12.♘ce2 e5 13.♘f5 ♗xf5 14.exf5

A) **14...♘c6** 15.g4 (15.c4, to secure control of d5, or the flexible 15.♔b1, look sounder alternatives) 15...♖c8?! (15...d5!? 16.♗g2 ♕a5 – 16...d4?! 17.f4! – 17.♔b1 d4 18.♗f2± and it looks hard to avoid the effects of g4-g5 or f3-f4) 16.♔b1 d5 Timofeev-Predojevic, Sarajevo 2007, and now, instead of the impatient push g5, 17.♘g3 looks enough to maintain the initiative: 17...d4 18.♗f2 ♕a5 19.♗c4± intending g4-g5;

B) **14...d5** 15.♔b1! Again, flexibility gives the best options: 15...♘c6 (Yemelin-Predojevic, Budva Ech 2009; 15...d4?! 16.♗g1! ♘c6 17.f4 and Black's centre collapses) and now my recommendation is 16.g4± and the threat g4-g5 will soon be ready.

O 10...♕c7 11.♔b1 h6 12.♗e3 b4 13.♘ce2 e5 14.♘f5 ♗xf5 15.exf5 ♘bd7 (it is curious that finally Black justifies his knight having remained on b8 for so long. However, this strategy hasn't been very successful: White's attack is progressing and there is no compensation for the light squares) 16.g4! d5 17.♗g2 d4 18.♗f2 ♖b8 (this leaves

too many pieces along the h2-b8 diagonal. More logical is 18...♖c8!? 19.♗g3! – 19.g5 ♘d5 20.f4 ♘c3+!? justifies Black's idea – 19...♕c5 20.♘c1! ♘d5 21.♘d3 ♕b5 22.♖de1 ♘e3 23.♘xe5 ♘xe5 24.♕xd4 ♘xc2 25.♕xe5 ♘xe1 26.♕xb5+ axb5 27.♖xe1± and it seems that White has excellent compensation for the exchange) 19.♗g3 (19.♖de1! – prophylaxis is usually the best approach. The rook move pre-empts ...♘d5 and prepares g4-g5 as well as ♗g3; 19...♘d5 20.f4±) 19...♘d5 20.♘xd4 ♘c3+ 21.♔a1 ♘xd1 22.♖xd1 ♖d8∞ Diogo-Fernandes, Vila Real 2005.



11.♘b1?!

We have finally reached the critical moment. Zude's move is not a big mistake, and the game will remain unclear for many more moves. However, this is for me the first step on the wrong path.

I suggest a normal, yet untested, move: **11.♘ce2!** a5 (11...e5 12.♘f5 ♗xf5 13.exf5 ♘c6 14.♗xf6 gxf6 15.g4 is clearly better than the scenarios mentioned in previous lines, where the bishop had already retreated to e3; 11...♕a5?! 12.a3; 11...♕b6 12.♗e3 ♕b7 13.g4±; 11...d5?! 12.e5±) 12.♔b1 0-0 (12...♘c6?! 13.♘b5; 12...♘a6 13.g4 a4 14.♘g3 a3 15.♗e3↑) 13.g4 ♘a6 14.♘g3 a4 15.♗e3↑ and the white attack follows already known paths.

11...♕b6

This may seem an odd move, but it is an almost essential preparation for ...a5. **11...a5?!** 12.♘b5±; **11...♘c6** 12.♘xc6 ♗xc6 13.♕xb4±.

12.h5

12.♗e3! is the thematic way, and after 12...♕b7 13.g4∞, but the position of the b1 knight is not very harmonious.

12...h6 13.♗e3 ♕b7 14.♕f2 e5 15.♘b3?!

Encouraging once again the black pawns' assault; White doesn't stand worse after 15.♘f5 ♗xf5 16.exf5 ♘d5 17.♘d2∞.

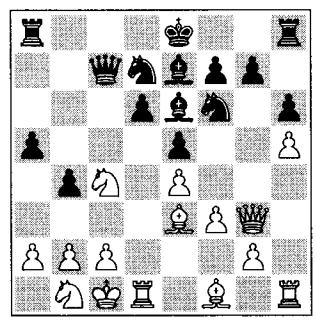
15...a5 16.♕g3 ♗e6

Posing threats against White's castled position and ignoring the white queen's solo raid. Now only tactical resources may keep White afloat.

17.♘3d2

17.♕xg7 ♖g8 18.♕xh6 ♘bd7⩲ threatening ...♗f8.

17...♘bd7 18.♘c4 ♕c7



19.b3?

Allowing the opening of the a-file is a decisive concession, though White's position wasn't in any way comfortable after 19.♘bd2 d5∓..

19...a4!–+ 20.♗d2 axb3 21.axb3 ♘b6 22.♗xb4 ♘xc4 23.♗xc4 ♗xc4 24.bxc4 ♕xc4

Once the white castled position has been destroyed, Black could take it easy and just play 24...0-0–+. Instead, the move played in the game allows White to confuse matters.

25.♕e1?!

25.♗xd6!? ♗xd6 26.♖xd6 0-0⩲ 27.♕xe5 (27.♖xf6? ♖a2–+) 27...♖fc8→.

25...0-0 26.♕c3 ♕b5–+

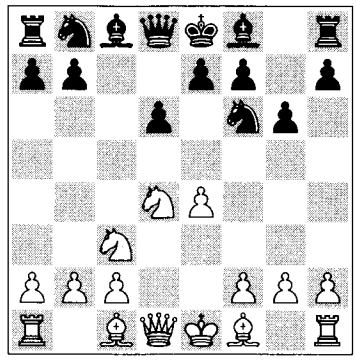
All the lines are open against the white king: that's too much!

27.♗xd6 ♘xe4! 28.fxe4 ♗g5+ 29.♖d2 ♖fc8 30.♕xe5 ♕c4 31.♖h3 ♕xc2# 0-1

SUMMARY
1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 ♗d7 6.♗g5
Slight edge, with positions similar to those studied in the Richter Attack
– 6...♘c6: total transposition to the Richter ±
– 6...♗c6: an odd variation, but not problematic for White ±
– 6...e6 7.♕d2 a6 8.f3 ♗e7: if Black doesn't transpose to the Richter, similar or even more serious problems arise ±

CHAPTER 16

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 g6 Dragon Variation



Evaluation ***

Introduction

The Dragon is one of the most popular variations in the Sicilian Defence. It has been a part of virtually all chess players' repertoires at some stage. It is an ideal weapon when seeking counterplay. Also, Black's Dragon strategy is, by far, more natural than in the Najdorf, the Paulsen or others. Moreover, many transpositions lead to this set-up: black players can use the Accelerated Dragon, Hyperaccelerated Dragon (2...g6), 2 Knights and ...d6, and some other, less orthodox move orders. I dare to say that this would be the main line in the Sicilian were it not for the Rauzer Attack and, in the Accelerated order, the Maroczy Bind, but the virtues of the Dragon decline when facing those powerful walls. Against the classical order, which is what we are going to examine in this chapter, we can't help suggesting the Rauzer Attack, as not only theoretically strong, but also easy to handle. Fischer was one of the first to notice that a medium-strength player can easily beat a master with the Rauzer Attack. We may add that he can do so often, easily and convincingly. This system is so effective that the normal Dragon move order can't be a recommendation for winning games. However, there is no doubt it will be a pleasure for researchers and imaginative players.

Nowadays, there is a debate about the strongest variation for White: 9.0-0-0 or 9.♗c4. I won't enter the discussion here, but I have chosen 9.♗c4 because it is easier to link this line and the transpositions coming from the Accelerated Dragon. I must remind the reader that in the variation we have chosen, Black has violent counterplay and we must be up to date with the latest trends in theory. Nevertheless, the improvements for White are usually more convincing and lasting than the improvements for Black.

History

Once again, the originator of this set-up was Louis Paulsen, around 1880, but then many other players noticed its virtues. It is generally acknowledged that the name comes from the similarity between the pawn structure and the Dragon constellation, but this is not confirmed. Among the first champions, Botvinnik was one of its firmest supporters. He even played it in his World Championship matches. However, the rise of the Rauzer Attack in the 1940s meant a terrible blow for the Dragon and afterwards, this variation would only appear in games among second-rate players. Kortchnoi's attempt to give it a try in his first match against Karpov resulted in a historical disaster.

During the 1970s and 1980s, the zeal shown by players like Miles and the rise of the so-called Soltis Variation, based on stopping White's push h2-h4 by means of ...h5, brought some revival. Later, Kasparov himself surprised the whole world when he adopted it against Anand in their World Championship match. Lastly, already in the 21st century, the rising stars Carlsen and Radjabov have used it in important games. In spite of this, of its pleasant counterplay, of its appealing name and the admiration of many amateurs, the Dragon is still enduring hard times and demands disproportionate efforts from its supporters.

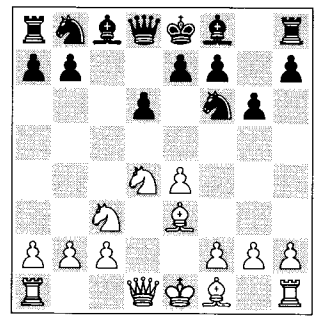
Ideas

The Dragon Variation swarms with counterplay ideas, but the main ones are the purest Sicilian ideas: queenside attack and use of the c-file. Fuelled by the pressure exerted by the g7 bishop, Black's queenside attack is stronger than usual; and easy to carry out. A further point is that the series of tactical tricks on this diagonal and sometimes along the a7-g1 diagonal are multiplied. On the other hand, there is some danger that the dark squares become weak if the bishop is exchanged off, and there is also the weakness of the d5-square, which is difficult to neutralize with ...e6.

Game 16.01

Sutovsky,Emil
Gunnarsson,Jon Viktor
Gibraltar 2007

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 g6 6.♗e3



The starting position of the set-up developed by Soviet theoretician Vsevolod Rauzer; it can also begin with 6.f3.

6...♗g7

It is hard to go on without ...♗g7. It is well-known that Black can't chase the white bishop with **6...♘g4?** due to 7.♗b5+!+–. However, there is an independent idea beginning with **6...♘c6** 7.f3 (as odd as it may seem) 7...e5?! 8.♘b3 ♗e6 9.♕e2! ♗g7 10.0-0-0 0-0 11.♔b1 ♕e7 12.g4!±; White secures control of the d5-square.

6...a6 This is similar to the set-up studied in this game, but here Black delays ...♗g7. It may make sense to take the sting out of ♗h6, but it doesn't fit with the previous move. Even so, this move has enjoyed a certain popularity and white players should take it seriously. 7.f3 ♘bd7 (7...b5?! looks a bit premature in view of 8.a4! b4 9.♘d5 ♘xd5 10.exd5 ♗b7 11.♗c4 ♕c7 12.♗b3 ♘d7 13.♕d2± Anand-Topalov, Wijk aan Zee 1999. This game followed a Najdorf move order with 5...a6) 8.g4 ♗g7 9.h4! (very straightforward. White saves some moves in order to threaten h4-h5 as soon as possible and Black is forced to do something about it) 9...h5 (9...d5 10.h5 e5 11.h6 ♗f8 12.g5↑; 9...0-0?! 10.h5 ♘e5 11.♕d2± and White's attack looks really quick) 10.g5 ♘h7 11.♕d2 b5 12.f4! ♗b7 13.f5± Motylev-Carlsen, Wijk aan Zee B 2006; the h7 knight has problems taking part in the game.

7.f3 a6

An infrequent set-up which is a kind of Najdorf-Dragon hybrid. This move has always been regarded as slow and clumsy against the Rauzer and indeed, it surely is... if it is played later. But by playing it now, Black gets ready for a completely new developing plan: ...♘bd7, ...b5 and ...♗b7, delaying ...0-0. This is a very active and theory-free system, ideal for original players. Perhaps one day this system will have its own place among the 'respectable' Sicilian variations, but so far it has not received the attention it deserves. That may make it more dangerous.

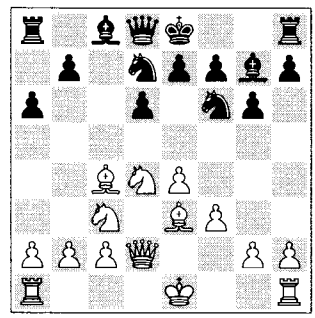
We're going to take a little step to systematize the theory in this variation. If we get all the possible transpositions, the database comes to more than 1000 games. In my view, White should be careful to avoid surprises.

8.♕d2 ♘bd7

8...b5?! is premature due to 9.a4! bxa4 10.♘xa4 0-0 11.♗e2 ♘bd7 12.0-0 ♗b7 13.c4 ♕c7 14.b4 ♖fd8 15.♘b3!± Boleslavsky-Ufimtsev, Leningrad 1947; **8...♘c6** transposes to the next game.

9.♗c4

One of the immediate questions in this variation, where theory is in its first stages, is whether to leave the bishop on f1 or place it along the a2-g8 diagonal (which costs two tempi). The line 9.0-0-0, where White gives up actively placing his bishop, is fully justified. However, I think Black's set-up is rather slow, and it is worth spending two tempi in giving the bishop influence over key squares like d5. In addition, adopting the same set-up against all black plans prevents surprise transpositions.

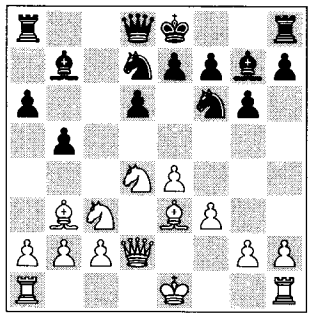


9...b5

9...♕c7 is the main alternative: 10.♗b3 h6?! (this just wastes too much time. 10...h5 11.0-0-0 ♘c5 12.♔b1 ♗d7 13.♗g5±; 10...b5 11.♗h6!±) 11.0-0-0 ♘e5 (11...♘b6? 12.e5! ♘fd7 13.exd6+− Karjakin-Romero Holmes, Pamplona 2003) and here I propose a

new move, 12.♖he1!?, intending f3-f4 and e4-e5: 12...b5 13.f4 ♘c4 14.♗xc4 ♕xc4 15.e5 b4 16.exf6 bxc3 17.♕xc3 ♕xc3 18.fxg7±.

10.♗b3 ♗b7



11.♗h6

Trading dark-squared bishops right away secures White better protection for his king, which is a good starting point. However, it is worth briefly mentioning a completely different plan, which I consider promising too: **11.a4!?** bxa4 (11...b4 looks worse: 12.♘d5 a5 13.♗h6 0-0 14.h4 ♘xd5 15.♗xg7 ♔xg7 16.exd5 ♘f6 17.h5± with a strong attack, Nilsson-Hagman, Sweden cr 1989) 12.♘xa4 ♕c7 13.0-0 0-0± Ostojic-Ivanovic, Yugoslavia 1972 and now, instead of 14.c4, White has several moves to keep good prospects: I would go for 14.♘e2, strengthening the grip on c5 and b6 and manoeuvring towards d5.

11...♗xh6

The only serious alternative would be 11...0-0?! but that doesn't fit in with Black's plan and would fall under a strong attack: 12.h4! ♘c5 13.h5 ♘xb3 14.axb3 e5 15.♘de2 d5 (trying to divert the attention of the white army) 16.♗xg7 ♔xg7 17.exd5 ♗xd5 18.hxg6 fxg6 19.0-0-0+– Erbacher-Lachman, cr 1971.

12.♕xh6 ♘c5

Natural, intending to castle, but there are a couple of alternatives:

O 12...♕b6 13.0-0-0 ♘c5 14.♔b1 ♘xb3 This is necessary, in order to move the king away from the centre, but now the active white pieces will use the open c-file for their advantage. **15.cxb3! 0-0-0 16.b4!** Fixing an important outpost on a5 for the knight. **16...♔b8 17.♘b3 ♖c8** Botvinnik preferred 17...♖hg8 in a game against Krutikhin, Moscow 1963, but it doesn't look necessary yet. **18.♕g7 ♖cf8!** Threatening ...h5 and ...♖h7. **19.♕h6 ♖c8 20.♘a5 ♗a8 21.♖he1** Intending to take the second knight to d5. **21...♕a7?!** Black feels uncomfortable and finally doesn't know what to play. 21...♖hg8 with an eye on g7 in order to play ...♖c7 and double rooks along the c-file, looks like the right way of seeking counterplay. 22.♕g7± Ivkov-Macskasy, Tel Aviv ol 1964.

O 12...b4?! I don't think this is logical: jumping to d5 is White's plan. 13.♘d5 ♘xd5 14.exd5 ♕a5 15.♕g7 ♖f8 16.0-0-0 ♗xd5 17.♖he1⩲ with strong pressure in exchange for the pawn.

13.0-0-0 e5 14.♘de2 ♘xb3+ 15.axb3 b4 16.♘a4

Now White is simply threatening to double rooks on the d-file and win the pawn. Black has two ways to counter this plan:

16...♖c8

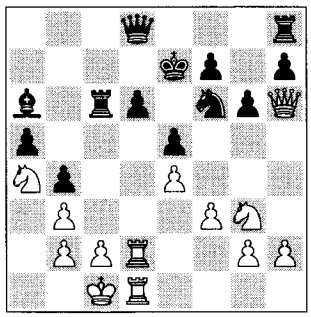
16...♕c7 is a more active attempt: 17.♖d2 d5!? 18.♕g5 ♕e7 19.exd5 (19.♘b6! ♖d8 20.♖hd1 looks as though

it wins a pawn; 20...d4 21.♘c4±) 19...♘xd5 20.♕xe7+ ♔xe7 21.♘c5 ♗c6 22.♖e1± Timman-Shanava, Baku 2008. White exerts some pressure, but Black is not far from consolidating.

17.♘g3

17.♖d2!?± and then doubling rooks, looks more natural.

17...♖c6 18.♖d3 a5 19.♖hd1 ♔e7?! 20.♖3d2 ♗a6



21.f4!±

Opening the game in front of the enemy king. Black has no answer to this.

21...♕c7 22.fxe5 dxe5 23.♕g5 ♖c8 24.♖d7+ ♕xd7 25.♖xd7+ ♔xd7 26.♕xe5 ♖xc2+ 27.♔b1 ♖2c6 28.♔a2 ♘e8 29.♕xa5 ♖b8 30.♕d5+ ♔c7 31.♕xf7+ ♔d8 32.e5 ♖b5 33.♕f4 ♖e6 34.♕d4+ ♔e7 35.♘c5 ♗c8 36.♘xe6 ♗xe6 37.♘e4 1-0

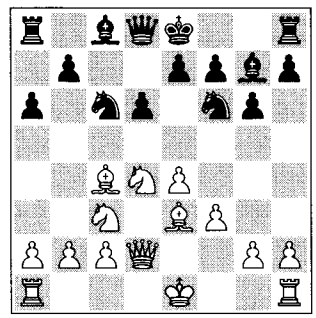
Game 16.02

Ribli,Zoltan
Tabor,Jozsef
Kecskemet 1972

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 g6 6.♗e3 ♗g7 7.f3 a6

In this game we'll deal with those variations combining ...a6 with ...♘c6. I consider this far less logical, and far less dangerous for White, than the set-up examined in the previous game. If Black castles too early, things go even worse. However, we can find many games using this set-up and I think it is more convenient to systematize a little the big transpositional mess, rather than quote a different line every time the alternative ...a6 comes up.

8.♕d2 ♘c6 9.♗c4



Once again, I choose this move as the main line. I think it is a good move, but also, it is the only way to have a uniform reply to all transpositions.

9...0-0

This gives the white army a very clear target, but other moves don't promise much either:

O 9...♕c7 One of the most common alternatives, but it is too slow against the ruthless Rauzer machinery: 10.♗b3 ♘a5 11.0-0-0 ♘c4 12.♗xc4 ♕xc4 13.♔b1 b5?! 14.e5! dxe5 15.b3 ♕c7? (15...♕b4 16.♘c6±) 16.♘dxb5! Benitez-Bauza, Montevideo ch-URU 1962.

O 9...♘e5 10.♗b3 0-0 11.0-0-0 b5. This manoeuvre, intended to exchange

White's light-squared bishop, is slow, but its main drawback is that the open b-file is not as important as the already open c-file: 12.h4 ♘c4 13.♗xc4 bxc4 14.h5± and while White's attack makes quick progress, Black meets lots of problems in using the b-file.

○ 9...♗d7 10.♗b3 ♖c8 11.0-0-0 ♘e5 12.♗h6! (paving the way for the h4-h5 push while preventing 12.h4 h5. White's attack develops in the usual fashion and Black eventually finds that ...a6 was absolutely useless) 12...0-0 13.h4 ♘c4 14.♗xc4 ♖xc4 15.♗xg7 ♔xg7 16.h5 ♖g8 17.♘d5 ♘xd5 18.exd5 f6 19.hxg6 hxg6 20.♘e6+! ♗xe6 21.♕h6+ ♔f7 22.♕h7+ ♔f8 23.dxe6+– Calvo Minguez-Campomanes, Havana ol 1966; a game played a long time before these two men embarked on their off-the-board battle!

10.h4!

Once Black has determined the position of his king, there is no reason to postpone the attack.

10...♘e5

It is more than clear that this is too late. Relatively more resistance is offered by 10...h5 11.0-0-0 ♘e5 12.♗b3 b5 13.♗h6 ♘c4 14.♗xc4 bxc4 and here comes a well-known attacking sequence: 15.g4 hxg4 16.h5!± Gilb. Hernandez-Nadal Bestard, Balaguer 1997.

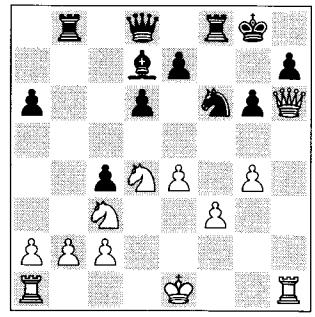
11.♗b3 b5 12.h5 ♘c4

12...♘xh5 13.♗h6 e6 (trying to control the d5-square, to prevent the swap of the h5 knight, which is a key defensive piece) 14.♗xg7 ♔xg7 15.g4 ♘f6 16.♕h6+ ♔g8 17.0-0-0 a5 White has many ways of getting an edge, but he chooses an elegant and thematic path. 18.g5 ♘h5 19.♘f5!+– Rivera Kuzawka-Trujillo, Uruguay ch 1982.

13.♗xc4 bxc4 14.g4

14.♗h6!?.

14...♗d7 15.♗h6 ♗xh6 16.♕xh6 ♖b8 17.hxg6 fxg6



18.g5+–

White's attack runs smoothly and follows a script seen a thousand times.

18...♖f7

18...♘h5 19.♖xh5 gxh5 20.g6+–.

19.gxf6 exf6 20.0-0-0 ♕b6
21.b3 ♕a5 22.♔b2 ♖c8
23.♘d5 ♗e8 24.♖dg1 c3+
25.♔a1 ♕a3 26.♖xg6+ ♔h8
27.♘xc3 1-0

Game 16.03

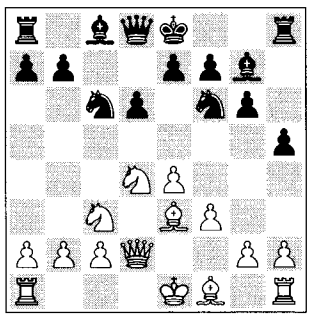
Fischer,Robert
Camara, Helder
Siegen ol 1970

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 g6 6.♗e3 ♗g7 7.f3 ♘c6 8.♕d2 ♗d7

Normally Black plays 8...0-0 but, since he usually continues ...♗d7, this move may very often mean a transposition. And indeed, it usually is when White plays 9.♗c4, and thus Black has avoided the 9.0-0-0 line. Given the current state of theory, this shortcut is nonsense: 9.0-0-0 is stronger against 8...♗d7 than against 8...0-0. Nevertheless, some people play this way. But we are just interested in the cases where Black plays 8...♗d7 in order to quickly activate his queenside play and to delay 0-0. Some years ago, this was an unusual plan, but then it enjoyed a certain success in the last two decades. That's why we are giving it a differential treatment. Besides, we'll have a look at other, secondary ideas:

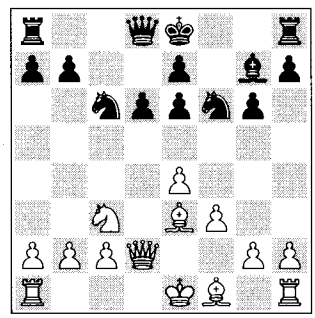
O 8...0-0 will be studied in Games 16.04 to 16.10.

O 8...h5 is a radical measure to hinder the white pawns' assault; it is for enterprising spirits only.



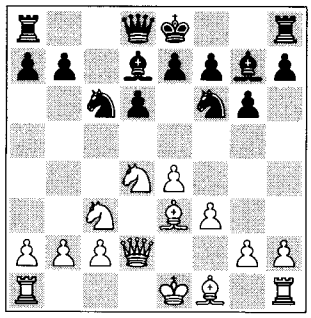
9.♗c4 9.h3 intending 10.f4 is an interesting approach but Black can rule it out with the order 8...♗d7. **9...♗d7 10.♗b3 ♖c8** 10...♘a5!?, to activate the queenside pawns in case of 11.0-0-0, may meet a different reply: 11.0-0! ♖c8 12.♘d5 ♘xd5 13.exd5 ♕c7 14.♕d3 ♘c4?! 15.♘e6! fxe6 16.dxe6 ♗xe6 17.♕xg6+ ♔d7 18.♕xg7+− Becerra Rivero-Shabalov, Virginia Beach 2003) **11.0-0-0 ♘a5** 11...♘e5 12.♔b1 ♘c4 13.♗xc4 ♖xc4 14.♘de2 (central play is usually a good recipe against moves like ...h5) 14...b5 15.♘f4 0-0 Klovans-Starostits, Riga 2005; and now 16.e5! dxe5 17.♘fd5 threatens to win a minor piece and forces Black to make big concessions: 17...♘xd5 18.♕xd5 ♖c7 19.♘xb5 e6 20.♕d2 ♖b7 21.♘d6 ♖c7 22.♘e4±. **12.♔b1 a6 13.h3** After patient preparations, White gets ready to start playing on the kingside and centre, with f3-f4 or g2-g4. **13...h4 14.♖he1 ♖h5!?** Looks odd, but after playing ...h5-h4, the rook can only seek activity here. **15.♘de2 ♘c4 16.♗xc4 ♖xc4 17.b3 ♖c8 18.♘f4** 18.♗d4±. **18...♖e5 19.♘fd5 ♘xd5 20.♘xd5±** The white pieces occupy excellent central positions and some of their black counterparts are in trouble, Khalifman-Shabalov, Moscow 2001.

O 8...♗e6 If you do believe in this move, this is the right moment for it, before White places his bishop on c4. Tiviakov has played it three times, with a certain success, but it is not fully convincing. **9.♘xe6 fxe6**



10.g3!? This is my suggestion. Developing the bishop on c4 is interesting, but then Black may have ...♘a5 to exchange it. It can create more danger from h3.

10...0-0 Allowing a transposition. 10...♕d7 11.♗h3 ♘e5 12.♕e2± doesn't look better. **11.0-0-0** Following the path of the above-mentioned game, but we shouldn't rule out the following idea: 11.♗h3 ♕d7 12.0-0!?±. **11...♕d7 12.♗h3 ♘e5 13.♕e2 b5?!** Black takes desperate measures in view of the overwhelming pressure on e6. **14.f4** (14.♕xb5!?) **14...♘c4 15.e5 ♘e8 16.♗d4 ♘c7 17.♘e4±** The pressure the white pieces exert on Black's central pawns is overwhelming.



9.♗c4 ♖c8

9...0-0 transposes to the next games; **9...♘e5** 10.♗b3 and it is hard to do something other than 10...♖c8 11.0-0-0, which leads to the game.

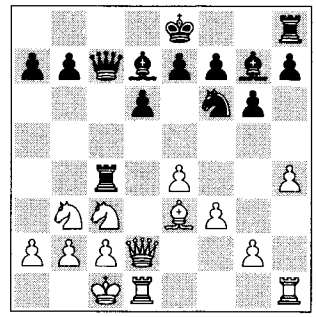
10.♗b3 ♕a5

This is a version of the ...♕a5 variation without ...0-0, which favours White.
The alternative would be the line with a quick ...♘e5-c4 without castling: **10...♘e5** 11.0-0-0 ♘c4 12.♗xc4 ♖xc4 13.♔b1!. Since Black can castle at any moment, for now we stick to the line we are going to recommend: 13...♕a5 14.♘b3 ♕c7 15.g4 h5 16.g5 ♘g8 17.♘d5 ♕b8 (Nunes-De Souza, cr 1978) and now 18.♗d4 ♗xd4 19.♕d3!± and White gets a considerable edge thanks to his development and initiative.

11.0-0-0 ♘e5 12.h4 ♘c4

12...0-0 13.♔b1 transposes to Game 16.11.

13.♗xc4 ♖xc4 14.♘b3 ♕c7



15.♗d4!

With the thematic threat 16.♗xf6 and 17.♘d5.

15...♗c6?!

15...0-0?! 16.♗xf6!±; **15...♗e6** is the other option, but White's attack runs smoothly: 16.g4! (16.e5?! dxe5 17.♗xe5 ♕c8 18.♘a5 ♖b4 19.a3 ♖b6 20.♗d4 ♖d6∞) 16...0-0 17.h5±.

16.e5!

Fischer starts a forced manoeuvre which decides the game.

16...dxe5 17.♗xe5 ♕c8 18.♕e2

The vulnerable position of the rook is the drawback of 15...♗c6?.

18...♗d7

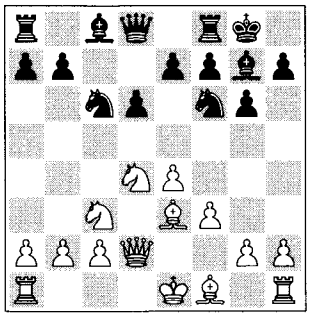
18...b5 19.♘a5+–.

19.♖xd7! ♔xd7 20.♘b5+– ♕c6 21.♖d1+ ♔e8 22.♘c7+ ♕xc7 23.♗xc7 ♖xc7 24.♕b5+ 1-0

Game 16.04

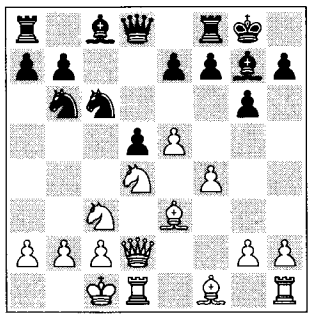
Anand,Viswanathan
Georgiev,Kiril
Belgrade 1997

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 g6 6.♗e3 ♗g7 7.f3 0-0 8.♕d2 ♘c6



After castling, this move is almost obligatory. Even so, there are alternatives:

8...d5?! A really odd move, often played by Afek, with some success. It shouldn't give problems if White reacts accurately. 9.e5 ♘fd7 (9...♘e8 10.f4 f6 11.♘f3 fxe5 12.♘xe5± Zemlyansky-Utnasunov, Elista 2006; the black pawns and the dark squares are now weak without compensation) 10.f4 ♘c6 11.0-0-0 ♘b6



12.♘f3! (with this key move, which puts immediate pressure on d5, Black faces serious problems) 12...♗e6 (12...e6 13.h4 h5 14.♗c5 ♘e7 15.♘b5± and the white pieces take over all the important squares; 12...♘c4 13.♗xc4 dxc4 14.♕e2 ♕c7 15.♕xc4 ♗e6 16.♘d5 ♕a5 17.♘g5±) 13.h4 ♘c4 (13...♘a5 14.♕f2 ♘ac4 15.♗d4±) 14.♗xc4 dxc4 15.♕f2 (15.♕e2!? attacking c4) 15...♕a5 16.h5 ♖fd8 17.♖xd8+ ♖xd8 18.hxg6 hxg6 19.♘g5 (it is possible that Black doesn't have any good defence against 19.♕h4!?) 19...♗f5 20.♕e2 b5 21.g4 ♗c8 (Palac-Afek, Werfen Open 1991) and White wins with 22.♗c5! b4 (otherwise, White simply plays ♖h4 and triples along the h-file) 23.♕xc4!+−.

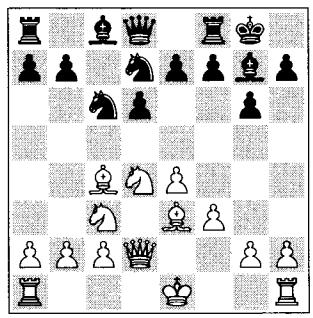
9.♗c4

9.0-0-0 This variation is equally reliable and promising, but Black can avoid this move by choosing an Accelerated Dragon order.

9...♗d7

The main line, which introduces the most important variations. Here Black has tried many options, though most of them are mere transpositions, not very subtle:

○ 9...♘d7

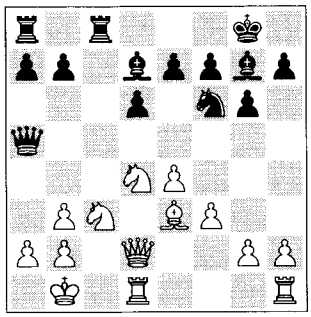


Ambitious and seemingly imprudent. The knight tries to strengthen the grip

on c4, but this wastes time and leaves the king unprotected. Enterprising players such as Larsen, Stein and Kupreichik have used it in the past, but it has now fallen into disuse. **10.h4!** White hurries, in order to exchange on g6 before Black sets a blockade on c4, since White wants to force his opponent to capture with the h-pawn. **10...♘b6** 10...♘a5 11.♗b3 ♘e5 leaves the knights in a worse position and ...♘xb3 is usually undesirable: 12.♕e2! ♗d7 13.h5 ♖c8 (the exchange 13...♘xb3 before 0-0-0 is strange: 14.axb3 a6 15.g4 e6 16.hxg6 fxg6 17.♕h2 ♘xf3+ 18.♘xf3 ♖xf3 19.♕xh7+ ♔f7 Rojas-Felgaer, Santiago 2005; and now 20.0-0-0!± and White has a crushing attack) 14.hxg6 hxg6 15.g4! ♖xc3 16.bxc3 ♕c7 17.♕h2 ♕xc3+ 18.♔f2 ♖c8 19.♘e2 1-0 (Klovans-Cherniaev, Biel 1996) is an impressive victory. **11.♗b3 ♘a5** 11...♘e5 12.♕e2! **12.♕d3!** 12.♕e2?! a6 threatening ...e5. **12...♘xb3** This strengthens White's castled position, but is understandable, as Black removes an important bishop and reacts immediately in the centre. The attacking race is suicide: 12...♗d7?! 13.h5! ♖c8 14.hxg6 hxg6 15.0-0-0 ♘bc4 16.♗g5! ♘xb3+ 17.cxb3 ♕a5 18.♗xe7 ♘e5 19.♕c2! ♖xc3 20.bxc3 ♖c8 21.♔b2!+– Wedberg-Sosonko, Haninge 1989. **13.axb3 d5!?** 13...a6 looks too slow: 14.0-0-0 followed by h4-h5. **14.♘db5 a6!?** An improvement that allows Black to reach a position with prospects. The old move 14...♗e6?! leads to a very strong attack for White: 15.0-0-0 dxe4 16.♕xe4 ♘d7 17.h5 ♕a5 18.hxg6 hxg6 19.♔b1+– and it is hard to stop the combined threats ♕h4 and ♘d4 (among others, less direct). **15.♗xb6 ♕xb6 16.♘xd5 ♕d8 17.♘bc3 b5** Black gets an interesting game, and indeed from this position most of the games are black wins, but in my view there is not enough compensation for the pawn; 17...e6 18.♘e3 ♕xd3 19.cxd3 ♖d8 20.♔e2±. **18.0-0-0 e6 19.♘e3** This looks like the best retreat, as it prepares a potential ♘g4, combined with e4-e5 or h4-h5 and ♘h6. **19...♕a5 20.♔b1 ♗b7 21.♕d6!** Intending b3-b4, e.g.: 21...♗xc3 (or 21...♖ad8 22.♕e7!? ♗c8 23.♕c5± threatening b3-b4) 22.bxc3 ♕xc3 23.♖d3 ♕c6 (23...♕a5 24.♘g4±) 24.♕e7 ♖ae8 25.♕f6 ♕c7 26.♘g4 e5 27.♘h6 mate 1-0 Vehi Bach-Perez Mitjans, Montcada i Reixac 2008.

❶ 9...♘a5 This order may have more venom than the one used in the game because, if White plays ♗e2, Black can do without ...♗d7. **10.♗b3 ♗d7** A flexible move with several ideas behind it. Actually, this position usually arises from the Accelerated Dragon and is the most normal transposition to the Chinese Dragon, without giving the a7 pawn; more precisely, it is a Chinese player, Bu Xiangzhi, who has revived his line. However, Black can have other ideas, mainly exchanging on b3: 10...♘xb3 11.axb3 a6 12.h4!± Spassky-Geller, 8th match game, Riga 1965; 10...a6 11.0-0-0 ♘xb3+ 12.axb3 b5 13.h4 h5 (otherwise, White's attack goes too fast) 14.♗h6 b4 15.♗xg7 ♔xg7 16.♘d5 ♘xd5 17.♘c6 ♕b6 18.exd5±. **11.0-0-0** 11.♗h6?!, recommended in DLS, looks the most natural option, but meets a more and more common move in the Dragon: 11...♗xh6! (after 11...♖c8 12.h4 ♘c4 13.♗xc4 ♖xc4 14.♗xg7 ♔xg7 15.h5!

White's attack runs the usual way, in 'automatic pilot' mode) 12.♕xh6 e5! (the point; ugly but concrete; the white knights can't quickly reach the most favourable squares and Black can play the desired break on d5) 13.♘de2 ♘xb3 14.axb3 b5 15.♕d2 (the queen alone can't checkmate Black, so she comes back to take part in the central play, but even so...) 15...b4 16.♘a2 d5! 17.exd5 a5 18.0-0 ♕b6+ 19.♔h1 Salgado Lopez-Can, Herceg Novi jr 2008. And now 19...♖fd8 recovers the d5 pawn and if 20.c4 bxc3 21.♘axc3 ♗e6∓ Black can't complain about the opening. **11...♘xb3+** 11...♖c8 12.♔b1 and now either the black knight jumps to c4, which leads to the old main line we analyse in the last game of this chapter, or it exchanges on b3, so ...♖c8 is not very flexible. **12.cxb3 ♕a5 13.♔b1 ♖fc8** 13...♖fd8!?



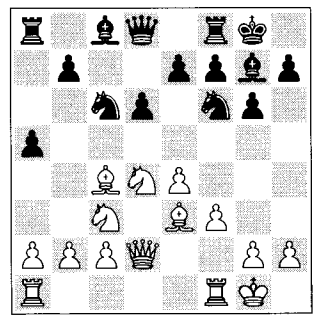
14.g4! b5 And now I suggest **15.a3!**, not played yet, intending b3-b4 and, if **15...b4** 15...♖ab8 16.b4 ♕d8 17.h4± **16.♘a2 e5 17.♘e2 ♕b5 18.a4±** White has managed to close the queenside and therefore can concentrate on his own attack.

O 9...♘e5?! ends up in a transposition to the main lines, but allows White a fast and potentially annoying ♗h6: 10.♗b3 ♗d7 11.♗h6!?.

O 9...♕c7 has no independent interest, as Black ends up playing ...♗d7, though sometimes this happens after ...♘e5-c4 and thus the game transposes to 9...♗d7 and 10...♕c7.

O 9...♕a5 10.0-0-0 and now 10...♗d7 (or 10...♘xd4 11.♗xd4 ♗e6) 11.♗b3 ♖fc8, transposing.

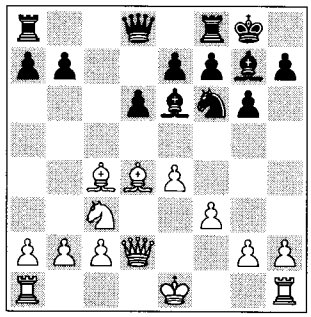
O 9...a5?! This pawn push looks premature, as White hasn't even castled queenside. This is an old line by Donald Byrne, but it hasn't caught on in practice. White stops the black pawn on a5, and then castles kingside and exploits the new weaknesses. As an example, we have a game where the inventor's brother was White. He should know well the weak points of this line. **10.0-0** Anyway, 10.a4! is more accurate here.



10...♘e5?! In the lines with ...a5, it is usually better if Black exchanges the white knight and then moves ...♗c6. Besides, now Black loses the chance of pushing the pawn further. 10...♘xd4 11.♗xd4; 10...a4! **11.♗b3 ♗d7 12.a4!** Now everything is in order. **12...♖c8 13.♕e2 ♘c6 14.♘db5!** Avoiding the exchange. **14...♗e6 15.♘d5 ♘b4 16.♗b6 ♕d7 17.♕d2±** With an absolute positional grip, Byrne-Kaplan, Puerto Rico 1967.

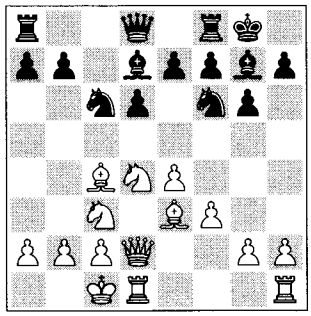
O 9...♘xd4!? This exchange, combined with the development of the bishop on

e6, is surely the most important variation in this group. It was popular in the first stages of the Rauzer, but it later fell into disuse, as it leads to an endgame with few prospects. In some lines, theory has reached and deeply analysed pawn endgames, but without definite conclusions. We must acknowledge that this is a very limited choice for the Black player, but his opponent must be very well prepared if he wants to aspire to get something out of the opening.
10.♗xd4 ♗e6



Other moves can hardly justify the exchange on d4. The most frequent alternative is a transposition: 10...♕a5 11.0-0-0 ♗e6 12.♗b3 leads to the same position.
11.♗b3! White doesn't want to strengthen Black's hold on d5 and, on the contrary, he invites Black to exchange and 'strengthen' the white castled position.
11...♕a5 Black players are almost unanimously loyal to this move. 11...♕d7 (supporting ...b5 or ...a4) 12.h4 a5 13.h5 a4 14.♗xe6 ♕xe6 15.hxg6 fxg6 16.0-0-0 (I think 16.a3!?±, is better; White is content with a more positional treatment) 16...♕f7 17.♔b1 ♖fc8 18.♘d5 ♘xd5 19.♗xg7 ♔xg7 20.♕xd5 ♕f6 21.a3 ♖c5 22.♕xb7 ♖ac8 23.e5 ♕xe5 24.♖de1 ♖8c7 25.♖xe5 ♖xb7 26.♖xc5 dxc5 27.♖h4 ♖a7 28.♔a2± Santo Roman-Parmentier, Plancoët 2002; the white rook is more active; 11...♖c8 12.0-0-0 ♗xb3 13.cxb3 d5 is a quite solid variation: 14.exd5 (14.e5 ♘d7 15.f4) 14...♕xd5 15.♔b1 ♕f5+ 16.♕d3 ♕xd3+ 17.♖xd3±. **12.0-0-0 b5** 12...♗xb3 or 12...♖fc8 can transpose to the main line. The attempts to play in an independent way are very risky, due to the solidity of White's castled position after the 'anti-positional' capture cxb3. However, there is indeed a line worth researching: 12...♖fc8 13.♔b1 ♖c6 (or first exchanging on b3) 14.h4 ♗xb3 15.cxb3 (15.axb3?! ♖a6↑) 15...b5 16.♗xf6 ♗xf6 17.♘d5 ♕xd2 18.♖xd2! (18.♘xf6+ ♔g7!=) 18...♔g7 19.g4 e6 (19...h6 20.f4) 20.♘b4 ♖cc8! (20...♖c7 21.♖xd6 ♗e7 22.♖c6±) 21.f4 with some initiative. **13.♔b1 ♖fc8 14.♖he1!** There is nothing in the endgame 14.♗xf6 ♗xf6 15.♘d5 ♕xd2 16.♘xf6+ ♔g7 17.♘h5+ gxh5! 18.♖xd2 ♖c5= and the attacking race is dangerous: 14.h4 ♗xb3 15.cxb3 b4 16.♘e2 ♖c6!↑.
14...♗xb3 15.cxb3 b4 16.♗xf6 bxc3 16...♗xf6 17.♘d5± **17.♗xc3 ♗xc3** 17...♖xc3? 18.♖e2!! **18.bxc3 ♕xc3 19.♕xc3 ♖xc3 20.♖c1 ♖ac8 21.♖xc3 ♖xc3 22.♖c1 ♖xc1+ 23.♔xc1±** Somborski-Vujadinovic, cr 1992. This is the endgame this variation very often leads to. Despite being a pawn ending, the analysis is not over yet. This book is not intended to give an exhaustive analysis of this position, but to give the best possible practical advice instead. Virtually all the games reaching this position have been correspondence games, and the results greatly favour White. In the few games won by Black, the first players were overambitious. In short: I wouldn't play it as Black, but it takes all sorts.

10.0-0-0



10...♘a5

If Black doesn't move his knight via e5, that means he has other plans than trading it on c4 and it may be worth frustrating them. Let's consider other alternatives first:

O 10...♖b8 will be studied in Game 16.05.

O 10...♘e5 usually transposes to **10...♖c8** or **10...♕a5**, both studied from Game 16.06 onwards.

O 10...♕c7!? Its main idea is typically exchanging on c4 and then leaving the queen there; this, together with the ...b4 push, creates problems on a2. **11.♗b3** and now:

A) It is possible that there is no time to place the rook on c8; more hopes would come from **11...♘a5!?** 12.♗h6 ♘c4 13.♗xc4 ♕xc4 14.h4 b5 15.♗xg7 ♔xg7 16.♔b1 b4, reaching a critical situation where White must give a pawn to maintain the initiative: 17.♘d5! ♘xd5 18.exd5 ♕xd5 19.h5 gxh5? (19...h6 20.hxg6 ♕g5 21.f4 ♕xg6 22.g4±) 20.g4!+− Lammens-Afek, Germany tt 2006/07;

B) **11...♘e5?!** 12.♗g5 ♘c4 13.♕e2±;

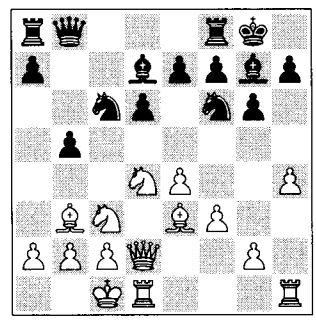
C) **11...♖fc8** 12.h4 ♘e5 13.h5 (it is worth investigating 13.♗h6! because if Black plays 13...♗h8, he runs into 14.h5 ♘c4 15.hxg6!± and 15...fxg6 is not possible, so Black may face a crushing end, e.g.: 15...hxg6 16.♗xc4 ♕xc4 17.♗f8 ♖xf8 18.♖xh8+ ♔xh8 19.♕h6+ ♔g8 20.♘d5 ♖fe8 21.♘xf6+ exf6 22.♖h1+−) 13...♘c4 14.♗xc4 ♕xc4 15.♗h6 ♗h8 16.♗g5! (White's attack is really fast) 16...b5 17.hxg6 fxg6 18.♗xf6 ♗xf6 19.♘d5! ♗xd4 (19...♕xa2 20.♕h6 ♕a1+ 21.♔d2 ♕xb2 22.♘xe7+!+−) 20.♘xe7+ ♔f7 (20...♔f8 21.♘xc8! ♖xc8 22.c3+−) 21.♖xh7+ ♗g7 22.c3!±.

O 10...♕b8 An odd-looking variation, but very appealing for enterprising players. **11.h4** The first stage is an immediate classic assault on Black's castled position. And now:

A) **11...♖c8** 12.♗b3 ♘xd4 (12...a5 13.a4! h5 – 13...♘xd4 transposes to 12...♘xd4 – 14.g4 hxg4 15.h5→) 13.♗xd4 a5 14.a4! b5 15.♘d5! (ECO suggests this refutation and so far nobody has questioned it) 15...♘xd5 (15...e5?! 16.♗xe5! dxe5 17.♘xf6+ ♗xf6 18.♕xd7+−) 16.♗xg7! ♘b4 (16...♔xg7 17.♗xd5 ♗c6 18.h5!+−) 17.h5 ♔xg7 18.hxg6 h5 19.♖xh5 ♖h8 20.♖dh1+−;

B) **11...h5** 12.♗h6 ♖c8 13.♗xg7 ♔xg7 14.♘d5 ♘e5 15.♘xf6 exf6 16.♗e2 b5 17.g4± Swartz-Inarkiev, Artek Children's Olympiad 1999;

C) **11...b5** The immediate idea behind the queen move. **12.♗b3!**



The different pawn grabs lead to a strong initiative for Black. On the contrary, this modest retreat can take advantage of the slightly unnatural 'gathering' of black pieces. And now:

C1) **12...a5!?** is the most menacing move and the one that has provoked the largest amount of analysis. However, nowadays it seems to be out of fashion: 13.♘d5! (posing simple tactical threats against the black pieces) 13...♘xd5 (13...a4? 14.♘xc6! axb3 15.♘xb8 bxa2 16.♘xe7+ ♔h8 17.♕b4 a1♕+ 18.♔d2 ♕a2 19.♖a1+–; 13...♖e8 14.♘xf6+ ♗xf6 15.h5 a4 16.♗d5±) 14.♗xd5 ♖c8 15.h5 (now White resumes his attack, and in Black's castled position the important knight is missing) 15...♕c7 (15...b4 16.hxg6 hxg6 17.♗xc6 – we are following a known analysis by Vulfson, but I can't see any defence against 17.g4!? a4 18.♕h2+– – 17...♗xc6 18.♗h6 ♗e5 19.♘f5 ♕c7 20.♗f4!+–) 16.hxg6 hxg6 and now the simplest is the pawn grab: 17.♘xb5!?±;

C2) **12...♘a5** is far less known, but perhaps this is the last chance to revive 10...♕b8. 13.h5 (if Golubev's next idea can't be refuted, the recommendation 13.♘d5 by Miles and Moskow makes sense: 13...♘xb3+ 14.♘xb3 ♘xd5 15.exd5±) 13...♘xb3+ (suggested by Golubev, but without practical tests. 13...♘c4?! 14.♗xc4 bxc4 15.♗h6 ♕b7 (Hartikainen-Kortelainen, cr Finland 1980) 16.hxg6 fxg6 17.♗xg7 ♔xg7 18.♘d5±) 14.cxb3 (14.♘xb3!?) 14...b4 15.♘d5 ♘xd5 16.exd5 ♕b7 17.hxg6 hxg6∞ is an unclear position which requires some tests;

C3) **12...♖c8** 13.h5 ♘a5? (thematic, but too late here. 13...♘xd4 14.♗xd4 e5 15.hxg6 exd4 16.gxf7+ ♔f8 17.♕xd4±; 13...b4 14.♘d5 ♘xd5 15.♗xd5 a5 16.hxg6 hxg6 17.g4± with the unstoppable threat ♕h2; 13...♘xh5 14.g4 ♘f6 15.♘d5±; 13...a5 14.hxg6 hxg6 15.♗h6 ♗h8 16.♗f8!+– a common manoeuvre) 14.hxg6 ♘xb3+ 15.♘xb3 fxg6 (15...hxg6? 16.♗h6 ♗h8 17.♗f8!!+–) 16.♘d5!+–, changing the defenders, always winning time to prevent the curtain of black pawns reaching their destination, Pavlovic-Karapanos, Panormo zt 1998.

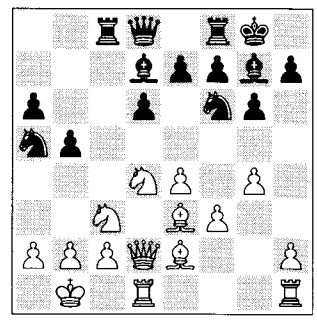
11.♗e2!?

Trying to make the knight's manoeuvre useless; naturally Black can go back to theory by exchanging on c4. There is no reason to completely reject going to b3 but, in comparison with the recently studied 10...♖b8 line, Black can exchange on b3 and play something more useful. 11.♗b3 transposes to the note to 10...♘a5.

11...♖c8 12.♔b1 a6?!

Black tries to keep out of the theoretical paths at all costs... and he slips. 12...♘c4 13.♗xc4 ♖xc4 14.g4 transposes to Game 16.07.

13.g4 b5



14.h4

As we have seen many times, the black plan ...a6, ...b5, ...b4 is slow and does not combine well with the bishop on d7 and the rook on c8. In the meantime, White's attack runs the usual way.

14...e6

Black controls the d5-square in order to play ...b4. It looks menacing, but White has an adequate reply and in the end Black has simply created more weaknesses.

14...♘c4 15.♗xc4 ♖xc4 16.h5± and neither ...a6 nor ...b5 look very useful for Black's attack;

14...b4 15.♘d5 ♘xd5 16.exd5±.

15.a3!±

This is not a typical move, but here it is really useful, as it rules out the threat ...b4.

15...h5

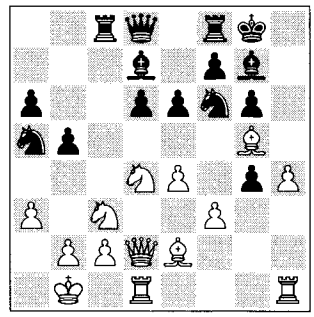
Once his threat has been stopped, Black decides he can't allow h4-h5; let's see why: **15...♘c4** 16.♗xc4 ♖xc4 17.♘b3! (attacking d6) 17...♘e8 18.♗h6±; **15...e5** 16.♘b3 (16.♘f5!?) 16...♘xb3 17.cxb3 ♗e6 18.♔a2± (18.♕xd6!?).

16.♗g5!

By pinning the knight, the threat gxh5 becomes stronger.

16...hxg4

Allowing the standard chain break in these attacks. The alternative is unpinning the knight: **16...♕b6** 17.♗xf6 ♗xf6 18.gxh5 ♘c4 19.♗xc4 bxc4 (19...♖xc4 20.♘b3±) 20.hxg6±; **16...e5** 17.♘d5! (17.♘b3!?) 17...exd4 (17...♘c4 18.♗xc4 bxc4 19.♘e2±) 18.♗xf6 ♗xf6 19.♘xf6+ ♕xf6 20.♕xa5±.



17.h5! gxh5

We have reached the stage of concrete variations. None of them saves Black: 17...♕b6 18.h6! ♗h8 19.♗xb5!+− (19.h7+!?) ; 17...gxf3!? 18.♘xf3 ♖xc3 (18...gxh5 19.♕xd6+−) 19.♗xf6 ♗xf6! 20.bxc3±.

18.♖xh5 ♖c5

18...g3 19.♖h3!+−; 18...e5?! 19.♗xf6! ♗xf6 20.♘d5 ♖e8 21.♕h6+−; 18...gxf3 19.♗xf3 (19.♘xf3 ♖xc3 20.♗xf6 ♕xf6 21.♕xc3 ♕xc3 22.bxc3±) 19...♘c4 20.♕g2 ♘xa3+ 21.bxa3 ♖xc3 22.♖h6!+−.

19.fxg4!

A practical move. White restores material equality while keeping the threats and adding some new ones like ♘f5.

19...♖xc3!?

Trying to exploit the 'recent' weakness on e4, but this will meet a simple reply.

20.♗xf6!

20.♕xc3 must give advantage as well, but it allows some complications: 20...♘xe4 21.♕e3±.

20...♕xf6

20...♖xc2 21.♖h8+!; 20...♗xf6 21.♕xc3 ♖e8 22.♖dh1+−.

21.♕xc3 ♘c4

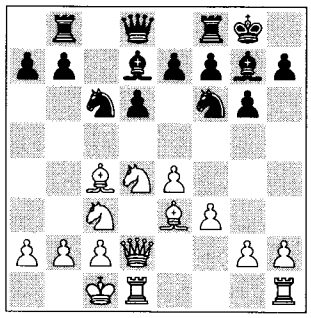
Black is content to eradicate White's attack, but it is difficult to find compensation for an exchange and a pawn.

22.♗xc4 bxc4 23.♕xc4+– ♖c8 24.♕xa6! ♕e7 25.♖h3 ♗f6 26.♖b3 ♗e5 27.♘f3 ♗f4 28.♖b4 d5 29.exd5 ♕c5 30.c3 1-0

Game 16.05

Dominguez Perez,Leinier
Carlsen,Magnus
Linares 2009

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 ♘f6 4.♘c3 cxd4 5.♘xd4 g6 6.♗e3 ♗g7 7.f3 0-0 8.♕d2 ♘c6 9.♗c4 ♗d7 10.0-0-0 ♖b8!?



Known as the Chinese Variation, this is the line with the greatest rise in popularity in the last few years. It is hard to trust the position of the rook, behind the pawn. However, analysis and results back this idea.

11.♗b3 ♘a5

This complements the previous move: the knight will be exchanged for the bishop and the b-pawn will move forward.

11...♘e5 is illogical, as the knight can't find support on c4: 12.f4! ♘eg4 13.h3 ♘xe3 14.♕xe3 and though White has lost his dark-squared bishop, the push e4-e5 will disrupt Black's position: 14...e6 (14...e5 15.fxe5 dxe5 16.♘f3±; the g7 bishop is buried and White has a good square on d5) 15.e5! dxe5 16.fxe5 ♘e8 (16...♘d5 17.♘xd5 exd5 18.♗xd5 ♕a5 19.♘f3±) 17.♘f3±.

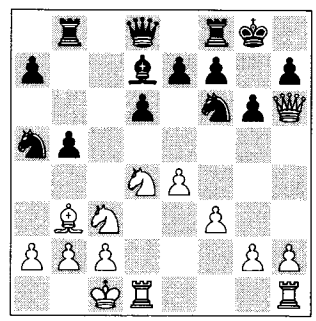
12.♗h6

Trading bishops is again the most logical plan for White.

12...♗xh6

Displacing the queen from central play is useful. **12...b5** 13.♗xg7 (13.♘d5?! tries to transpose to the note to move 15, but 13...♘c4! 14.♘xf6+ exf6 15.♗xc4 ♗xh6 16.♕xh6 bxc4 17.c3 ♕a5∓) 13...♔xg7 14.♘d5 ♘xd5 (14...♘c4 may be the best, but it is not appealing: 15.♗xc4 bxc4 16.♘xf6 exf6 17.♕c3 and it is clear that nobody wants to emerge from the opening like this, Rodriguez Guerrero-Charbonneau, La Roche sur Yon 2006) 15.exd5 ♘c4 16.♗xc4 bxc4 17.♕c3 ♔g8 18.♖de1 (pressing along the semi-open file isn't a bad idea, but it is not clear that this is the right rook. 18.♖he1±; 18.h4! is another sound and ambitious plan, e.g.: 18...♕c8 19.h5 ♕c5 20.♖he1± ♕xd5? 21.♘e6+–) 18...♖c8 19.h4 ♖c5 20.h5! ♖xd5 21.hxg6± Pranav-Arribas Lopez, Kemer jr 2007.

13.♕xh6 b5



14.g4!?

This move has enjoyed success for some years, but precisely the text move casts some doubts on White's edge. The idea is to give support to an eventual ♘f5.

14.♘d5!? is a positional treatment, less ambitious, but maybe enough to make Black uncomfortable, for example:

A) **14...♘xb3+** 15.♘xb3 e5 doesn't look very healthy;

B) **14...e6** 15.♘xf6+ ♕xf6 16.h4± and White has a better structure and a slightly safer king: 16...♖fd8 17.h5 ♕g7 18.♕g5 ♕e5 19.♕xe5? dxe5 20.♘e2 ♗c6 Burnoiu-Georgescu, Bucharest jr 2008;

C) **14...♘xd5?!** 15.exd5± and White will have comfortable pressure along the e-file;

D) **14...e5** 15.♘f5 ♘xb3+ 16.axb3 ♗xf5 17.exf5 ♘xd5 18.♖xd5 ♖b6 19.fxg6 fxg6 20.♖hd1± A.Kovacevic-Cebalo, Borovo 2005; and White's better structure promises a pleasant future.

14...b4

O 14...♘xb3+ 15.♘xb3 and it is difficult to avoid the transposition, e.g.: 15...a5 16.e5! dxe5 17.g5 ♘e8 18.♘c5 ♘d6 19.♖xd6 exd6 20.♘3e4 f5 21.♘f6+ ♖xf6 22.gxf6+−.

O 14...e5? justifies White's idea: 15.♘f5! gxf5 (15...♗xf5 is relatively the best: 16.exf5 ♘xb3+ Casares Cabanas-Argandona Riveiro, Leon 2006; 17.axb3! ♔h8 18.♘e4±) 16.g5! ♘xb3+ 17.axb3 ♘e8 18.♘d5+− Gopal-Li Chao, Martuni 2007.

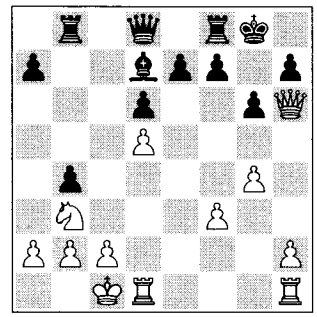
15.♘d5 ♘xb3+

15...e6 is a strange move, not so easy to refute: 16.♘xf6+! (White has only tried 16.♘e3 but after 16...♔h8!∞ threatening 17...♘g8, White loses tempi in reorganizing) 16...♕xf6 17.h4 and Black must pre-empt the classical plan of opening the h-file with 17...♕g7! 18.♕g5 ♕e5 19.♕e3± but White's position is sounder.

16.♘xb3 ♘xd5

16...e5 and now, instead of 17.h4, as in Petr-Porat, Brno 2006, allowing the exchange on d5, I propose 17.♘e3!, preparing the attack h4-h5 and setting up ♘f5. For example: 17...♗e6 (17...♗b5 18.♖hg1 followed by ♘f5; 17...♕e7 18.h4 a5 19.h5 ♖b5 20.♘d2 ♖c8 21.g5 ♘xh5 22.♘dc4 d5 23.♖xh5! gxh5 24.♘d6+−) 18.h4 ♕c7 19.h5 ♖bc8 20.♖d2 ♖fd8 21.♕g5 ♘e8 22.f4 f6 23.♕h6 g5 24.fxg5±.

17.exd5

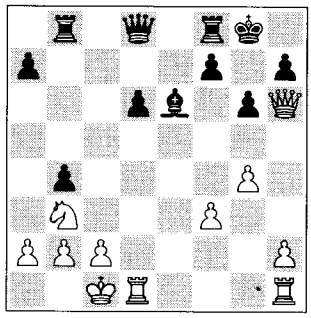


17...♖b6!

The latest improvement for Black in this line, putting the ball in White's court. The rook defends d6 in order to play ...e7-e5 and then take with the pawn on e6. At this moment there are just a few games with this move (only 3 in my database as I write this), but it is easy to see that this line will soon be critically analysed.

O 17...a5?! Now the attacking race isn't favourable: 18.h4 a4 (18...f6) 19.h5±;

O 17...e5 is the main alternative, but it leaves a clear target on d6: **18.dxe6 ♗xe6**



19.♔b1! The modest solution, as White hasn't succeeded with the ambitious knight jumps: 19.♘d4!? ♗xa2! 20.♖he1 (20.b3 ♕a5 21.♖d3 ♖bc8 22.♖e1 ♕a3+ 23.♔d1 ♗b1 24.♕c1 ♕a1 25.♔e2 ♖fe8+ 26.♔f2 ♖xe1 27.♕xe1 ♕b2 28.♕xb4 ♗xc2 29.♕d2 ♕b1 30.♖c3 ♖xc3 31.♕xc3∞ is still difficult to assess) 20...♗e6 21.♘c6 ♕c7 22.♘xb8 ♖xb8 23.♕d2 b3!⩲; 19.♘c5 ♕c7! (an exchange sacrifice similar to the previous line) 20.♘a6 (Ninov-Cabrera Trujillo, Pamplona 2007) and now 20...♕a5! 21.♘xb8 ♖xb8⩲ and again, White loses the a-pawn. **19...♗xb3** Black can't allow the knight to get to d4, with an absolute positional grip. **20.axb3 ♕c7 21.♕d2! ♖fc8 22.h4** The difference between this position and the rest of this variation is fairly obvious. Black's counterplay has been reduced to a minimum and White has a better structure and a menacing pawn assault. White just has to be wary that Black may try to transfer his heavy pieces via a6 and a5. **22...♕c6 23.f4 ♖b5 24.♖h2!** Already threatening 25.♕xd6. **24...d5 25.♕d3** (25.h5 ♖a5 26.♕xb4 ♕a6⇄. **25...♖a5 26.♖e2±**.

O 17...♗a4 is somewhat artificial and White won't allow his knight to be exchanged: 18.♘d4! ♕a5 19.h4! ♖fc8 (19...♕xd5? 20.h5+–) 20.♔b1! ♕xd5 21.b3 ♗d7 Kritz-Jianu, Plovdiv Ech 2008 and now 22.♖he1! threatening both 23.♘f5 and 23.♖xe7; Black has no reply.

18.♖he1?!

Only visually opposing ...e5.

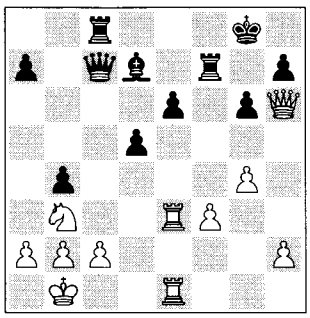
18.h4!? looks the most logical option, as White can't prevent ...e5. After **18...e5** White has two very different plans: one is based on exchanging pawns and then exploiting Black's weaker structure; the other, on keeping the current structure and transferring the knight to the attack. Only the first plan has been played and analysed, but probably the second plan is more promising: **19.♘d2!?** 19.♔b1 with the same idea is paradoxical, since after this king move, White won't be able to transfer the knight to the attack: 19...f5!; 19.dxe6 fxe6 20.♖d3 was played in the game Maslak-Porat, Pardubice 2008; or 20.♖h3 ♕f6 21.h5 ♗e8 22.♕d2∞; 20.♘d2 is recommended by Khalifman, and now there can follow 20...d5!, leading to a complex position. **19...♖a6 20.h5** (20.♘e4 only leads to a draw: 20...f5 21.♘g5 ♕e7 22.h5 ♖f6 23.♔b1 ♕g7 24.hxg6 ♕xh6 25.♖xh6 ♖xg6 26.♖xh7 ♗e8 27.♖dh1 ♖xg5 28.♖h8+ ♔f7 29.♖1h7+ ♔g6! 30.♖h6+ ♔f7=. **20...g5 21.♘e4 f6 22.♔b1** The white queen is trapped, but she can't be captured and the attack will be decisive if the rooks can back it up; therefore, Black has to trade queens. **22...♖f7 23.♖he1 ♕f8 24.♕xf8+ ♖xf8 25.♖e3 ♔g7** 25...f5!? 26.♘xg5 fxg4 27.fxg4 ♖f4 28.♘e6±; 25...h6 26.a3 f5 27.gxf5 ♗xf5 28.axb4±. **26.a3 bxa3 27.♖xa3**

♖xa3 28.bxa3± and Black must create quick counterplay, as d6 is really weak.

18...e5! 19.dxe6 fxe6 20.♖e3 ♖f7 21.♘d2?!

White should have aimed for equality with 21.f4 ♕f6 22.♖ed3 ♕xf4+ 23.♕xf4 ♖xf4 24.♖xd6 ♖xd6 25.♖xd6=.

21...d5 22.♘b3 ♕c7 23.♔b1 ♖b8 24.♖de1 ♖c8∓



Black clearly seizes the initiative.

25.♖1e2

25.c3 a5 26.♖c1 ♕b6∓.

25...♕b6!

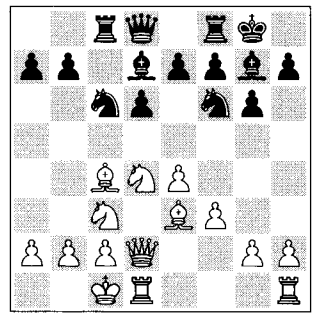
25...a5?! 26.♘d4.

26.h4 d4 27.♖e5 d3! 28.cxd3 ♖xf3 29.d4 ♗b5–+ 30.♖2e3 ♗d3+ 31.♔a1 ♕xd4 32.♖xe6 ♖f1+ 33.♖e1 ♕xg4 34.♖xf1 ♕xe6 35.♘c5 ♕e2 36.♖c1 ♗f5 37.♕f4 a5 38.h5 ♕e7 39.♕c4+ ♗e6 40.♕c2 ♕g5 41.hxg6 hxg6 42.a3 bxa3 43.♕c3 axb2+ 44.♔xb2 ♕d5 45.♖c2 a4 46.♔a1 a3 47.♕e3 ♗f7 48.♕c3 g5 49.♕e3 ♖e8 50.♕c3 ♖e2 51.♘b3 ♖xc2 52.♕xc2 ♕e5+ 53.♔b1 ♔g7 54.♕d2 ♗xb3 0-1

Game 16.06

Kotronias,Vasilios
Ristic,Nenad
Cutro 2004

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 g6 6.♗e3 ♗g7 7.f3 0-0 8.♕d2 ♘c6 9.♗c4 ♗d7 10.0-0-0 ♖c8



This variation replaced the classical 10...♕a5, studied in Games 16.09 and 16.10. The success of 10...♖c8 was based on several complicated systems, especially the so-called Soltis Variation (with ...h5), successfully championed by Miles and other masters, but now it is in crisis too.

11.♗b3 ♘xd4 12.♗xd4 b5

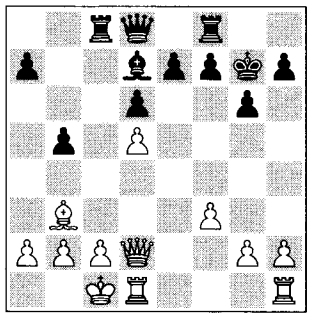
This line was relatively rare some years ago, but it enjoyed a certain success, until it became the main alternative to 11...♘e5, the move we will study in the next games. There could hardly be a more logical idea: to trade knights and immediately launch the queenside pawns. This line leads to very tense positions.

13.♘d5

I recommend this positional approach because the attacking race sometimes seems to favour White but then some-

times leads to unclear positions, which are promising for Black.

13...♘xd5 14.♗xg7 ♔xg7 15.exd5



The position White is aiming at. The d5 pawn exerts strong pressure on Black's play and White can combine two plans: an assault along the h-file and pressure along the central semi-open file. Black understands that his long-term chances are poor and so he goes on with his queenside attack at the same vibrant pace as in the main line with h2-h4.

15...a5 16.a3 b4

This pawn sacrifice is the critical way. It may seem hasty, but other moves have not achieved good results.

O 16...♗f5?! 17.g4! a4 (otherwise, ...♗f5 is a waste of time) 18.♗xa4 bxa4 (18...♗xg4 19.fxg4 bxa4±) 19.gxf5±.

O 16...♕b6 17.♖he1 ♖fe8 18.♖e2! ♖c7 19.g4 ♖ec8 20.♕f4 (the black king looks strikingly alone. The e-file divides the black camp into two isolated sectors) 20...♗e8 21.♔b1 ♖b8 22.♖d4 (White takes measures against ...a4 followed by ...b4. Black won't be able to break White's castled position, so he is doomed in the long run) 22...f6 23.h4 ♗f7 24.h5 (24.g5!? may be better) 24...♕c5 25.c3 g5 26.♕e4± Bruzon-Felgaer, Bled ol 2002.

17.axb4 axb4 18.♕xb4 ♔g8

The most flexible. Other possibilities:

18...♕c7 19.♖he1 ♗f5 20.♖e2 ♖b8 21.♕c3+!± with a clear edge in the endgame;

18...♖b8 19.♕c3+! ♔g8 20.♖d4 (20.♖he1± is the most natural) 20...♕b6 21.♖hd1 ♖fc8 22.♖c4 ♖xc4 23.♗xc4 ♕f2 24.g4 ♕xh2∞ Jakubowski-Mamedov, Baku Ech-jr 2002.

19.♖he1 ♖e8 20.♖d4!

With a double aim: transfer the rook to the e-file or the h-file. 20.♖e3!? may be similar, but it hasn't been tried at top level.

20...♖c5

20...♖a8 21.♔d1!±; **20...♖b8** 21.♕c3 ♕b6 22.♔d1 ♗b5 23.♖de4!±.

21.♔d1 ♕c7

21...♕a8 22.♔e2 ♕a7 23.♕d2 ♖b8 (Korneev-Carlsson, Dos Hermanas 2006) and White has to choose between keeping the tension with 24.♕e3!?, or going into an endgame where he only has a symbolic edge after 24.♖b4?! ♗b5+ 25.c4 ♗a6 26.♖xb8+ ♕xb8 27.♕d3 ♕xb3! 28.♕xb3 ♗xc4+ 29.♕xc4 ♖xc4=.

22.♕d2 ♖a8 23.♔e2

The king must keep on running, but he will soon find a safer place on the kingside. 23.♖e3! is an interesting suggestion in *Chess Informant*: 23...♖a1+ 24.♔e2 ♗f5 25.c3 ♖h1 (25...♖b5 26.♗c4! ♖c5 27.♗d3±) 26.♔f2!±.

23...♗f5 24.c3!

24.♕h6?! is interesting, but not completely clear: 24...♗xc2! (24...e5 25.dxe6 ♗xe6 26.♔f1! ♗xb3 27.cxb3 ♖c2 28.♖h4 f5 29.♕e3 ♖xb2 30.♖a4 ♖xa4 31.bxa4±) 25.♖h4 g5! 26.♕xg5+ ♗g6∞.

24...♕b7

24...♖b8 25.♗a4± and White is close to consolidating his position on the kingside (♔f1) as well as the queenside (♗c6 and b2-b4).

25.♗c4?

It is impossible to play accurately for many moves in such an uncomfortable position. 25.♖b4! looks better: 25...♖b5 and now: 26.♗c4! (26.♔f1 ♖b8 Housieaux-Bijaoui, Condom 2005) 26...♖xb4 27.cxb4 ♖b8 28.b3 (28.b5 ♗d7) 28...♕xb4 29.♕xb4 ♖xb4 30.♔d2 ♔f8 31.♔c3 ♖b8 32.♖a1± and the endgame clearly favours White .

25...e5! 26.dxe6 ♖xc4 27.♖xc4 ♕b5 28.exf7+ ♔xf7 29.♕f4 g5?!

29...♖c8! 30.b3 d5 puts White in a critical state.

30.♕xd6 ♕xc4+ 31.♔f2 ♖a7 32.♕e5 ♔g6 33.g4 ♗c8?!

33...♗d3∞.

34.♕d6+ ♔f7?

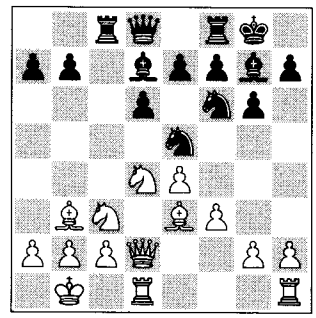
Now it is Black who has an uncomfortable position and was probably in time trouble too; 34...♔g7.

35.♕h6 ♕c5+ 36.♔g2 ♖c7 37.♕xh7+-+ ♔f6 38.♕h8+ ♔g6 39.♖e8 ♕c4 40.♖g8+ ♔f7 41.♖g7+ ♔e6 42.♕h6+ 1-0

Game 16.07

Bologan,Viktor
Fedorov,Alexey
Calcutta 1999

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 g6 6.♗e3 ♗g7 7.f3 ♘c6 8.♕d2 0-0 9.♗c4 ♗d7 10.0-0-0! ♖c8 11.♗b3 ♘e5 12.♔b1!



This is my recommendation; two decades ago, it was eclipsed by the universal move 12.h4. Its popularity has gone sky-high and nowadays, it seriously questions the soundness of 10...♖c8. Another positive point is that this line frees you from the need for thorough preparation in a more and more intricate theoretical jungle. Its point seems to be that this is a useful move in most variations and forces Black to show his hand first.

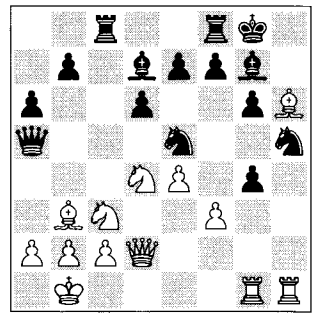
12...♘c4

Still the most frequent move, but Black hasn't scored well, 31% against 47% in **12...♖e8!?** which is nowadays Black's main hope and will be studied in the next game. **12...♕a5** leads to similar lines to 10...♕a5, in worse conditions.

O 12...a5 Threatening 13...a4; this provokes a closer game and more positionally-based play, but White is

still on top thanks to his excellently-placed knights. **13.a4! ♘c4 14.♗xc4 ♖xc4 15.b3 ♖c8 16.♘db5!** Strengthening the grip on d5 and preventing some tactical tricks based on the unprotected knights. For example: 16.g4 (more frequent) 16...♕c7 17.♘db5 ♘xe4!? 18.♘xe4 ♗xb5 19.axb5 d5 20.♘f2 a4 with some confusion, Cornette-T.L.Petrosian, Heraklion jr 2002. **16...♗e6 17.h4 h5 18.♗d4 ♕d7 19.♖he1** Perfect centralization; White gets ready to occupy d5. **19...♔h7 20.♖e2** 20.♘d5 looks possible at once: 20...♘xd5 21.♗xg7 ♔xg7 22.exd5 ♗f5 23.♘d4±. **20...♕d8 21.♘d5 ♘xd5 22.♗xg7 ♔xg7 23.exd5 ♗d7 24.♘d4±** Lanka-Bindrich, Leutersdorf 2001.

O 12...a6 This move is hard to believe, as in the previous line we have regarded it as unsound; however, it has achieved a certain respect after Radjabov played it once and Carlsen has repeatedly used it. Even so, it still looks suspicious to me. **13.h4 h5** The only logical reply: if Black allowed h4-h5, the game would lead to lines where ♔b1 is a useful move and ...a6 a complete waste of time. **14.g4 hxg4** Virtually forced as well, though Black might consider 14...♖xc3. **15.h5** Thematic. **15...♘xh5** 15...♖xc3 16.h6 ♖xb3 17.axb3 ♘xf3 18.♘xf3 ♘xe4 **16.♖dg1 ♕a5** Trying to improve over 16...♖c5 17.♗h6 ♔h7 18.♗xg7 ♔xg7 19.f4! ♘c4 20.♗xc4 ♖xc4 21.f5 (with the threat 22.♖h5) 21...e5 (Topalov-Carlsen, Bilbao 2008; 21...♖h8 22.♖xg4±) and now 22.fxe6! fxe6 23.b3 forces Black to give up the exchange and after 23...♖xc3 (23...♖c5 24.♖xg4±) 24.♕xc3 e5 25.♘f5+ ♗xf5 26.exf5 ♖xf5 27.♖xg4± the attack goes on. **17.♗h6**



17...♗f6 Very risky, but the alternatives look worse:

A) **17...♖xc3?!** 18.♗xg7 ♔xg7 19.♖xh5 ♖xb3 20.♕h6+! ♔f6 21.♕g5+ ♔g7 22.♘xb3 ♕a4 23.♖gh1 ♖g8 24.♖h7+ ♔f8 25.♕h6+ ♔e8 26.♖h8;

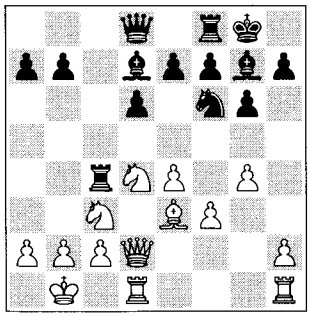
B) **17...♗h8?!** This seems to lead, almost by force, to an undesirable endgame for Black: 18.fxg4 ♘xg4 19.♖h4 ♕c5 20.♖gxg4 ♗xg4 21.♗e3 ♗e6 22.♘xe6 ♗xc3 23.bxc3 ♕xc3 24.♘xf8 ♕xd2 25.♗xd2±.

18.fxg4 ♗xg4 (18...♘xg4 19.♘f5! with a crushing attack, for example: 19...♗xf5 20.exf5 ♗xc3 21.♕g5 ♕xf5 22.♕xg4! ♕xg4 23.♖xg4+– and it is impossible to defend all the attacked pieces) Karjakin-Radjabov, Sochi 2008; and now, instead of the move played in the game, 19.♗xf8, with **19.♗f4!** White could secure a clear edge: **19...♘c4 20.♕h2 ♗xd4 21.♖xg4 ♔g7** (21...♗g7 22.♖g5! e5 23.♖xh5+–) **22.♕xh5±** and once again, Black does not get enough compensation for the piece.

13.♗xc4 ♖xc4 14.g4!

Apparently, one more in the long list of White's attacking options, but perfectly directed against Black's ideas ...h5 and ...b5, as only concrete analysis can prove. Black has tried virtually every reasonable move in this position, but at

this moment, it looks like the solution must be found earlier.



14...b5?!

Despite appearing as the main line, due to the amount of theory, this pawn sacrifice (which won't be accepted) may be regarded as dubious. Let's have a look at the alternatives:

O 14...♕c7?! As a preparation for the attack, this is perfect, but in this age of computer analysis, we can't go leaving pawns unprotected in the way we did in the old times. 15.g5 (15.h4!? ♖c8 16.h5 b5?! 17.hxg6 fxg6 18.g5 ♘h5 19.♘d5 ♕d8 20.b3 ♖4c5 21.♘f5! (Rhodes-Matthew Paul, cr 2000) does not look bad either, but we should pay attention to 16...♖xc3!?) 15...♘h5 16.♘d5 ♕d8 17.♘e2 (White threatens ♘g3, so Black can't defend the a7 pawn) 17...♗e6 18.♗xa7! Bologan-Chatalbashev, Bourbon-Lancy 1998 and other games. There is not enough compensation for the pawn.

O 14...♗e6?! The idea is similar to 14...♕c7: gathering pieces against the enemy castled position; however, it is slow. 15.h4 ♕a5 16.♘b3 ♕a6?! (16...♕c7 may be better, but it hasn't been tried yet. 17.♘b5 ♕d7 18.♘5d4 looks favourable for White) 17.♗h6! (before the rook leaves f8) 17...♗xh6 18.♕xh6 ♖xc3 19.bxc3 ♖c8 20.h5 (the exchange sacrifice hasn't cooled the attack: now White has some themes on the back rank too) 20...♖xc3 21.♖h2! (trying to avoid complications, as after 21.hxg6 fxg6 22.g5 ♖xc2!! Black can't lose) 21...♕a3? (21...♖xf3 22.hxg6 fxg6 23.e5 ♗xb3 24.cxb3 dxe5 25.g5 ♖f1 26.♖xf1 ♕xf1+ 27.♔b2 ♘h5 28.♖d2±) 22.hxg6 fxg6 23.e5!+− Llobell-Gallagher, Lausanne 2001.

O 14...♕b8!? One of the most reasonable alternatives, given its idea and its results. Black intends ...♖fc8 followed by the thematic sacrifice ...♖xc3. **15.h4 ♖fc8 16.h5 ♖xc3!?** After this move, there is a quite a consensus. Probably Black doesn't have enough compensation, but in practical play this is not easy to play as White, and Black usually scores well. The other possibilities just bring suffering: 16...b5 17.hxg6 fxg6 18.♘d5± ♘xd5 19.exd5 ♕b7 20.♕h2 h6 21.♗xh6 ♖xd4 22.♖de1 ♗f5 23.♗xg7 ♔xg7 24.♕h7+ ♔f6 25.gxf5 gxf5 26.♖e6+ 1-0 Al Sayed-Somev, Dubai 2001. **17.bxc3 ♕c7 18.hxg6 fxg6 19.♘b3 ♗e6** Black is not prepared to regain the pawn: 19...♕xc3?! 20.♕xc3 ♖xc3 21.♖d3!± and Black has to choose between exchanging the rook or letting White regain the pawn. **20.♗d4 ♗f7** 20...a5 21.g5 ♘h5 22.♗xg7 ♘xg7 23.f4 a4 24.♘d4 ♗f7 25.♕d3± in order to play f4-f5. **21.♕h2!** Intending e4-e5. **21...e5 22.♗e3 a5** 22...♕xc3 23.♖d3 ♕b4 24.g5 ♘h5 25.♕d2± **23.♕d2 a4 24.♘c1 d5!?** Trying to get some activity, but without much success. Other moves allow Black to keep the tension, though it is hard to believe that he gets enough compensation (24...♘e8!?).

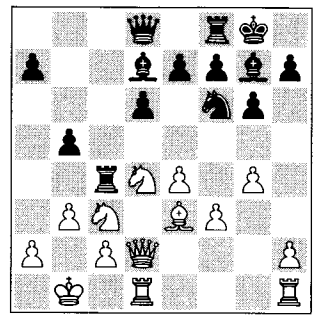
25.g5! ♘e8 26.exd5 ♘d6 (Tseshkovsky-Kopenkin, Presov Open 2000) **27.♕d3 ♘c4 28.♘e2±**.

O 14...a6?! Again, this is slow. 15.h4 b5 16.h5 b4 17.♘d5 ♘xd5 18.exd5 ♕a5 19.hxg6 fxg6 20.♕h2 ♔f7 21.♘f5 (21.♕e2!+– ♖c7 22.♖xh7) 21...♗xf5 22.gxf5 ♖h8 23.♕g2 1-0 Rodriguez-Benvenga, ICCF Jubilee Email 2001.

O 14...♕a5?! Trying to reach the 10...♕a5 variation, but one where White has played g2-g4 and ♔b1. White can secure an edge with vigorous play: 15.♘b3 ♕a6 16.e5! (the most straightforward) 16...♘xg4 (16...♘e8 17.♘d5±) 17.fxg4 ♗xg4 (17...♗xe5? 18.♘d5 ♖e8 19.h3+– and Black has no compensation, Bauer-Van Wely, Enghien les Bains 2001) 18.♖df1! (looks stronger than 18.exd6 ♗xc3!∞) 18...dxe5 (18...♗xe5 19.♘d5 ♖e8 20.♗d4±; or 19...e6 20.h3!±) 19.♘d5! (19.♖hg1 ♗f5 20.♗h6 ♗xh6 21.♕xh6 e6 22.♘d2 ♖b4 23.♖g3 ♖d8 24.♖gf3 ♕b6 25.♘de4 ♖xb2+ 26.♔a1 f6 27.♘xf6+ ♔f7 28.♕xh7+ Kaiumov-Solovjov, Alushta 2002) 19...♗e6 20.♘xe7+ ♔h8 21.♖d1 ♖e8 22.♘d5±.

O 14...h5!? The (maybe only) unquestionable merit of this move is that it hasn't been deeply analysed yet. Black is active, as usual, and White needs some moves to rearrange his position to exploit the new weaknesses: 15.gxh5 ♘xh5 16.♘de2! (solidifying c3 and preparing the exchange of dark-squared bishops) 16...♗e6 17.♗h6 ♕a5 18.♗xg7 ♔xg7 19.♖hg1 ♖fc8 20.♘d4! (pre-empting the threats on a2) 20...♖xc3?! 21.♘xe6+ fxe6 22.bxc3 ♕xc3?! (22...♖xc3) 23.♕xc3+ ♖xc3 24.e5!? (With this manoeuvre, not only does White keep material superiority, but he also seizes the initiative. 24.♖d3!?) 24...d5 (24...♖xf3 25.exd6 exd6 26.♖xd6+–) 25.♖d3 ♖c7 26.♖d4!+– Macieja-Gallegos, Curaçao 2002.

15.b3!



This novelty by Topalov brought a complete change in the evaluation of the move 12.♔b1!: from harmless to crushing.

15...♖c8

15...♖c5? is a trap into which many have fallen: 16.♘e6!+–

16.♘dxb5! ♕a5

The most frequent move. This loosens White's castled position, but the queen may fall into some tactical tricks. Other tries:

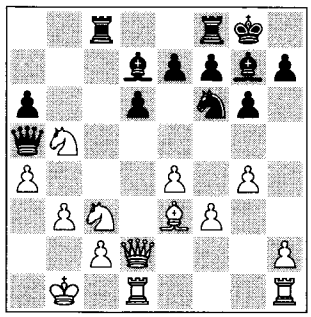
O 16...a6 17.♘d4 ♕c7 18.♘de2! ♗e6 19.♗d4 (by regrouping his army, White neutralizes Black's pressure on the castled position) 19...♘d7 20.♗xg7 ♔xg7 21.h3 ♘b6 22.f4± Goloschapov-Korobov, Nizhnij Novgorod 1999;

O 16...♗xb5?! 17.♘xb5 a6 18.♘a7 ♖a8 19.e5!+–;

O 16...♘xe4? 17.fxe4 ♗xg4 18.♘e2+– is completely insufficient.

17.a4 a6

17...♕a6 The queens stay on the board, but this move just sets tricks: 18.h4 (18.♘xa7?! ♖xc3 19.♕xc3 ♘xe4≅) 18...♖b8 19.h5 ♗xb5 20.axb5 ♖xb5 21.hxg6 fxg6 22.♗h6? (22.♘xb5!+− ♘xe4 23.♕d5+ ♖f7 24.♗d4) 22...♖a5 23.♗xg7 ♖a1+ 24.♔b2 ♕a3# 0-1 Villalba Izquierdo-Vallejo Diaz, Spain jr 1999.



18.♘d5!

Now some complications will arise which have led to White's advantage in many games; computer programs don't give Black any hope either.

18...♕xd2 19.♘xe7+ ♔h8 20.♖xd2! ♖ce8

The only alternative is 20...axb5 but after 21.♘xc8 ♖xc8 22.♖xd6+− White already has a rook and three pawns against two black pieces, and he can easily trade a pair of rooks or the dark-squared bishop.

21.♘xg6+!

It looks as though this move can secure some advantage and **21.♘f5** is interesting but less clear. However, I think the following line is more convincing: **21.♘xd6!** ♖xe7 22.♗c5 ♖e5 23.♗a3 ♗e6 (23...♗c6 24.♘c4 ♖e6 25.♗xf8 ♗xf8 26.♖d8 ♔g7 27.♘a5+− Bakre-Singh, Calcutta 2002) 24.♘b7 ♖c8?! (24...♖b8 looks better, and if 25.♗d6?! ♘xe4!∞. But White can play more strongly: 25.♖d8+ ♖xd8 26.♘xd8+− and there is no way to stop ♗d6) 25.♗b2 (25.♖d8++−) 25...♘d7 26.♖hd1 ♖c7 27.♘d8 ♘f8 28.♗xe5 ♗xe5 29.♘xe6 ♘xe6 30.♖d7+− Kolev-Hernandez, Catalunya-ch 2000.

21...fxg6 22.♘xd6 ♖e6 23.♗c5!±

White's edge is beyond question: four pawns for the piece and the more solid position; however, Black still has some activity.

23...♗c6

23...h5 24.g5 ♘h7 25.♘f5!+−.

24.♘c4 ♖b8 25.♖d6 ♖xd6 26.♗xd6 ♖d8 27.♗e7 ♖b8

27...♖e8 28.♗a3±.

28.♖d1! ♗xa4 29.♗d6 ♖b7 30.♘a5 ♖b5

30...♖b6 31.♗c7 ♖b4 (31...♖b5 32.♖d4 ♖c5 33.♗b6 ♖b5 34.♗d8+−) 32.♔a2 ♗e8 33.♖d8+−.

31.♗c7 ♘g8 32.♔c1 ♗h6+ 33.♔b1 ♗g7 34.♖d3 ♖c5 35.♗b6 ♖b5 36.♘c4 ♖b4 37.♘d6!

White succeeds in carrying out a plan to exploit the fact that the a4 bishop is misplaced, and consequently, so is its heroic defender the rook.

37...♘f6 38.♗a5+− ♖b8 39.♗c7 ♖b4 40.♔a2 ♗b5

40...♗c6 41.c3+−.

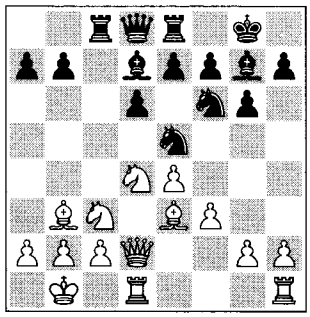
41.c4 ♗c6 42.e5 ♘d7 43.e6 ♘e5 44.♘f7+ ♘xf7 45.exf7 h5

46.♖d8+ ♔h7 47.♗e5 ♖b7 48.f8♕ ♗xf8 49.♖xf8 ♔h6 50.h4 hxg4 51.fxg4 ♖h7 52.♖g8! 1-0

Game 16.08

Ponomariov,Ruslan
Tiviakov,Sergey
Moscow (m/2) 2001

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 g6 6.♗e3 ♗g7 7.f3 0-0 8.♕d2 ♘c6 9.♗c4 ♗d7 10.0-0-0 ♘e5 11.♗b3 ♖c8 12.♔b1 ♖e8



Regarded by some as 'mysterious', this is the move that has best coped with 12.♔b1. The idea may well be: if White plays a useful non-committal move, Black tries to do the same. But actually 12.♔b1 looks far more useful than 12...♖e8.

13.h4!

The most precise order, on account of the exchange sacrifice. 13.♗h6?! ♗xh6 14.♕xh6 ♖xc3!∞

13...h5

13...♘c4?! 14.♗xc4 ♖xc4 15.g4 ♕a5 (leading to similar positions to those in the old line; see Game 16.09) 16.♘b3 ♕a6 (16...♕c7 17.e5!; 16...♕e5 has achieved excellent results, but the position doesn't seem to justify that: 17.♗d4 ♕e6 18.h5± with a crushing attack in Rachels-M.Wierzbicki, USA 1991) 17.e5 ♘xg4 18.fxg4 ♗xg4 19.♖dg1 dxe5 (19...♗xe5 20.♗d4!±) 20.♗h6 ♗f3 (Kokarev-Rozkov, Kazan 2008) and now 21.♗xg7! ♔xg7 22.♖h3 ♖g4 23.♖e1→.

14.♗h6!

After the insertion of 13.h4 h5, it is the right time to trade bishops quickly.

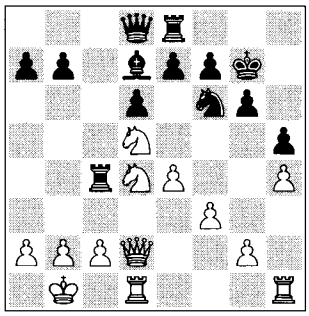
14...♘c4

O 14...♗h8?! 15.g4 and White attacks as usual: 15...♕a5 (15...hxg4 16.f4 ♘c4 17.♕e2 ♘a5 18.h5→ J.Willemze-Molinari, Dieren 1999) 16.♖dg1 (16.gxh5!?) 16...♕c5 17.gxh5 ♘xh5 18.♗e3± ♘c4 19.♗xc4 ♕xc4 20.♖g5 ♔h7 21.♘d5 f6? 22.b3 ♕a6 23.♕g2!+– fxg5 24.♕xg5 ♖c5 25.♖g1 ♗g4 26.♖xg4 ♕f1+ 27.♗c1 Kodric-Malakhov, Bled 2001.

O 14...♕a5 15.g4! The straightforward treatment looks the strongest. 15...♖xc3 16.♗xg7 ♔xg7 17.bxc3 ♖c8 18.gxh5 (18.g5?! – computer programs insist on closing the position in these attacking races, which is hard to understand) 18...♘xh5 19.♖hg1 ♕xc3 20.♕g5 ♘f6 21.h5± Andres Gonzalez-Gonzalez Vidal, Oviedo 2008. White is an exchange up and his attack looks hard to stop.

15.♗xc4 ♖xc4 16.♗xg7 ♔xg7 17.♘d5!

We have reached a key position which can also arise in the order 13.♗h6. Let's go deeper into it.



17...e5

17...♘xd5 18.exd5 e5 19.dxe6 ♗xe6 20.♖he1 ♗d7 21.♖xe8 ♗xe8 22.♕f4± Prié-Derieux, Cap d'Agde 2002, with a better structure and a strong knight on d4; **17...e6** 18.♘e3 ♖c8 19.♘b3±.

18.♘xf6 ♕xf6 19.♘b3!

19.♘e2 is a more normal knight route, and it seems to offer good prospects too: 19...♗e6 (19...♖c6 20.♘c3 ♗e6 21.♕e3 ♖ec8 22.♘b5±) 20.♕xd6 ♖ec8 21.c3 ♖a4 22.♘c1 ♖a6 23.♕d2 ♕e7 24.b3 Salgado Lopez-Arribas Lopez, Spain jr 2007; it appears that the compensation is insufficient.

19...♖e6

19...♖c6 20.♘a5!±; **19...♗e6** 20.♕xd6 ♖ec8 21.c3 ♖4c6 (21...b5 (Leko-Carlsen, Miskolc rapid match 2008) is weaker, as Black isn't threatening either ...a5 or ...b4. For example: 22.♖d2! b4 23.cxb4 ♖8c6 24.♕d8±) 22.♕d2±. Black must have some compensation for the pawn, but probably not enough.

20.♕a5!

20.♕e3!? b6 21.♘c1 ♗c6 22.b3 ♖c5 23.♘d3 ♖a5 24.c4± Zorko-Nithander, Herceg Novi jr 2005. But I have a feeling that Black can play better.

20...♖a4

20...a6 is the other way to defend. After 21.♕b6 d5 22.♕xb7 ♗c6 23.♕xa6 ♗a4! 24.♕a7 dxe4± White remains a pawn up, but Black has compensation.

21.♕c3?!

And now Ponomariov and Komarov suggest 21.♕c7! ♗c6 22.♖d2± which seems to guarantee White much more comfortable play.

21...♕d8!

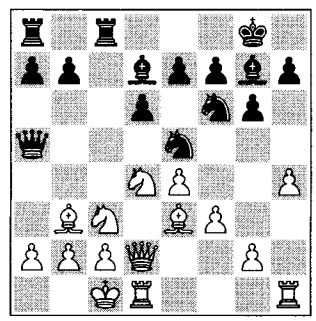
With this manoeuvre, Tiviakov improves the position of his queen and equalizes.

22.♖d2 ♕b6 23.♘c1 ♗b5 24.b3 ♖a6 25.♖hd1 ♕d8 26.g3 ♖c6 27.♕e3 ♕b6 28.♕xb6 ♖xb6 29.♔a1 f5 30.♘e2 fxe4 31.fxe4 ♗xe2 32.♖xe2 ♖f6 33.♔b2 ♖c6 34.♖d3 ♔f7 35.♖g2 ½-½

Game 16.09

Golubev, Mikhail
Cebalo, Miso
Grächen ch-SUI 1999

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 g6 5.♘c3 ♗g7 6.♗e3 ♘f6 7.♗c4 0-0 8.♗b3 d6 9.f3 ♗d7 10.♕d2 ♕a5 11.h4 ♘e5 12.0-0-0 ♖fc8



One of the oldest and maybe most pleasant set-ups in the Dragon. All the black pieces occupy natural positions for the attack against the enemy king. Even the rook leaves a free square for the black king, in case he needs to flee from the castled position. It has been discussed for many decades and, though it has had its ups and downs and has real fanatics for its cause, nowadays this line is undergoing a period of crisis.

13.♔b1

The universal move in all Rauzer lines.

13...♘c4

Thousands of games have followed this old attacking recipe, outshining the other alternatives, but now it doesn't seem to be the best move. Apart from paying special attention to the trendy alternative, let's look at the other moves:

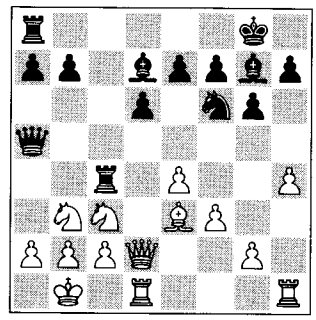
O 13...♖c4?! A thematic idea, not very popular here. 14.♕e1! is my suggestion. White threatens to capture the rook without losing the important dark-squared bishop (14.♗xc4 ♘xc4 15.♕c1 ♘xe3 16.♕xe3⩲). Now Black has to face an uncomfortable choice: whether to retreat the rook, which has only just arrived on c4, or to lose the exchange with dubious compensation. 14...♖c5 (14...♖ac8 15.h5 ♘xh5 16.♘d5 ♕xe1 17.♖hxe1 ♔f8 18.♗xc4±) 15.h5 ♘xh5 16.♘f5!±.

O 13...h5 This move, so popular in the 10...♖c8 variation, makes little sense here. The reason is the exposed situation of the black queen and the vulnerability of e7. **14.♗g5!** The threat is ♗xf6 followed by ♘d5. **14...♖c5** 14...♘c4 15.♗xc4 ♖xc4 16.♘b3! and depending on the square chosen by the black queen, the next move for White may be ♗xf6 followed by ♘d5, or e4-e5: 16...♕e5 (the only way to prevent both threats, but the queen is exposed here) 17.♖he1± preparing to harass the black queen. **15.♗xf6! exf6** As the pawns will become weaker in any case, Black wants to keep the bishop at least; 15...♗xf6 16.♘d5 ♕xd2 17.♘xf6+±. **16.f4!** But this pawn push buries the black bishop. **16...♘g4** 16...♗h6 17.♘de2 ♘c4 18.♗xc4 ♖xc4 19.♕xd6 ♗g4 20.g3 ♗xe2 21.♘xe2 ♖xe4 22.♘c3 ♖e6 23.♕d7± Stellwagen-Almeida Saenz, Morelia 2007. **17.f5 ♗h6 18.♕e2 gxf5 19.♘xf5±** Galkin-Malakhov, St Vincent Ech 2000.

O 13...♖c5 Another interesting and logical idea (preparing to double rooks), which hasn't received much attention: 14.h5 ♘xh5 (slightly better is 14...♖xc3! 15.♕xc3 ♕xc3 16.bxc3 ♘xh5±) 15.♘f5! ♗xf5 (15...gxf5? 16.♖xh5! ♘c4 17.♗xc4 ♖xc4 18.♗h6! ♗f6 19.♕f2 ♔h8 20.♖dh1 ♖b4 21.♗d2+–; 15...♖xc3? 16.♘xe7+ ♔f8 17.♕xd6+–) 16.♗xc5 dxc5 17.exf5±. As in many other Dragon positions, Black has certain compensation for the exchange, but White must get the upper hand if he maintains the initiative.

O 13...b5!? is Black's latest try in this line, and so it will have an independent game, 16.10.

14.♗xc4 ♖xc4 15.♘b3!



Hassling the black queen, and at the same time opening the d-file, therefore preparing tactical tricks. This has become a nightmare for black players, who have unsuccessfully tried all possible retreats.

15...♕a6

Together with 15...♕c7, the most popular move here; the queen stands on an aggressive spot, but somewhat far from the central play. Let's see the others:

O 15...♕e5?! Here the queen becomes a target, and correspondence games have sentenced it to death: 16.♗d4 ♕e6 17.♖he1 ♖ac8 18.e5! (very straightforward and fairly convincing, though not the only way) 18...♘d5 (18...dxe5 19.♖xe5 ♕d6 20.♕e2±) 19.exd6 ♘xc3+ 20.♗xc3 (an obvious move, improving on a previous game of Fleetwood himself as Black) 20...♗xc3 21.♖xe6 ♗xd2 22.♖xe7 ♗f5 23.♖xd2+− Edelstein-Fleetwood, cr 1993.

O 15...♕d8?! Black hasn't been able to recover from a couple of refutations in the 1960s. Instead the second player is suffering new blows: 16.♗h6 ♗h8 (16...♕f8 17.♗xg7 ♕xg7 18.g4 ♗e6 19.♘d4 ♘d7 20.h5 ♖ac8 21.hxg6 hxg6 22.♘ce2 ♖4c5 23.c3 ♘f8 24.♖dg1± Karpov-Whiteley, Bath Ech-tt 1973; with the threat f4-f5) 17.h5 ♖ac8 18.hxg6 fxg6 19.e5! ♘e8 (19...dxe5 20.♘d5+−) 20.exd6 e6 21.♗g5 ♘f6 22.g4+− with material advantage and attack, Ciocaltea-Drimer, Romania 1968.

O 15...♕c7 16.g4! (less clear is 16.♗d4 ♗e6 17.h5 a5 18.a4 b5!?⇄) 16...♗e6 (necessary, as White was threatening e4-e5 followed by g4-g5) 17.h5 a5 (17...♖c8 18.♗d4!± exploiting the drawbacks of the 16th move) 18.♘d4! (a strong move, possible thanks to the fact that the d4-square is not occupied) 18...♖xc3?! (too radical, but other moves do not solve Black's problems either: 18...♗d7 19.hxg6 fxg6 20.g5 ♘h5 21.♘d5±) 19.♘xe6! fxe6 20.♕xc3 ♕xc3 21.bxc3 ♘d7 (21...gxh5 22.g5+−) 22.♗d4 ♖f8 23.♖df1 g5 24.h6 ♗f6 25.♗e3 ♖c8 26.♖h5+− Macieja-Salmensuu, St Vincent Ech 2000.

16.h5 ♖ac8

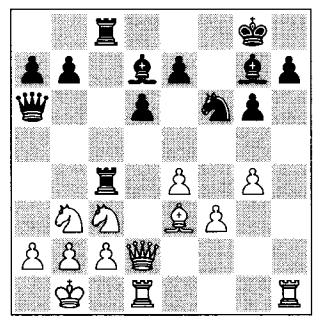
16...♘xh5 is rather rare, but not so easy to refute: 17.♘d5! (17.g4?! ♘g3!∞) and there is no good defence for e7, e.g.: 17...♖e8 (17...♔f8 18.g4+−) 18.g4 ♘g3 19.♖hg1±; 16...♖xc3 17.♕xc3! ♘xe4 18.♕e1 ♘f6 19.hxg6 fxg6 20.♗g5+− and White has a material advantage and the initiative.

17.hxg6 fxg6

17...hxg6? is a well-known mistake: 18.♗h6 ♗h8 19.♗f8!+− ♘h5 20.♗xe7 d5 21.♖xh5 gxh5 22.♕xd5 ♗e8 23.♘c5 ♖xc3 24.♘xa6 ♖xc2 25.♕g5+ ♔h7 26.♕xh5+ Michiels-Roemhild, Bad Wildbad 2003.

18.g4

With many ideas: an eventual e4-e5 followed by g4-g5, or g4-g5 and ♘d5, or transferring the queen to h2.



18...b5

18...♗e6 looks the most logical move: now the bishop is not exposed and occupies an aggressive diagonal instead. 19.♗d4 b5 (19...♗f7 has been played a lot, but I don't quite see the point of it: 20.g5 ♘h5 21.♗xg7 ♔xg7 22.f4± with a huge difference between the safety of both kings) 20.g5 ♘h5 21.♗xg7 ♔xg7 22.♘d5! ♗xd5 (22...♖xc2? 23.♕d4+ ♔f7 24.♘b4+−) 23.♕xd5 ♖f8?! (23...♖xc2? fails to 24.♘d4 and the rook lacks a good retreat, e.g.: 24...♖g2 25.♘e6+ ♔h8 26.♖xh5+−. The most resilient may be 23...♕c6 24.♕e6 ♕e8 but White is still on top after 25.♖h2±) 24.♘d4 ♘f4 25.♘e6+ ♘xe6 26.♕xe6 ♖c7 27.♕h3+− Socko-Sylvan, Helsingor 2008.

18...♖xc3 is the classical resource, but insufficient here: 19.bxc3 ♗e6 20.♕h2 ♖xc3 21.e5! ♖xe3 22.exf6+− Tamayo Romay-Hoffman, Ourense 2008.

19.♗h6

19.e5! is an energetic push that seems to refute the whole variation, but there aren't valid examples yet: 19...♘xg4 (19...dxe5 20.g5 ♗f5 21.gxf6 exf6 22.♕d5+! ♗e6 23.♕d6+−) 20.fxg4 ♗xg4 21.♕d5++−

19...♗h8 20.♗g5!

Intending ♗xf6 and ♘d5.

20...♗e6

20...b4?! 21.♗xf6 ♗xf6 22.♘d5 ♖xc2 23.♘xf6+ exf6 24.♕h6+−.

21.♕h2 ♔f8 22.e5

In his notes to a previous game Istratescu-Golubev, Istratescu recommended 22.♖d2!? but it is interesting that Golubev himself chose the line in the game.

22...b4 23.♘d5 ♗xd5 24.exd5±.

22...dxe5 23.♗xf6 ♗xf6 24.♕xh7 ♗f7 25.♖d7

Once again, Istratescu recommends 25.♖d2, whereas Golubev follows the game.

25...♕c6?!

25...♖d4!? was Istratescu-Golubev, Lucerne 1994, and now comes Istratescu's recommendation: 26.♖xd4! exd4 27.♘e4±.

26.♖hd1 ♖d4 27.♘xd4 exd4

27...♕xd7 28.♘dxb5 ♕b7 29.g5 ♗xg5 30.♘e4 ♗f6 31.♕xf7+!+−.

28.♖7xd4 ♗xd4 29.♖xd4+− ♕xf3 30.♕h8+ ♗g8 31.♕h6+ ♔e8 32.♕xg6+ ♗f7 33.♕h6 ♕f1+ 34.♖d1 ♕c4 35.♕h8+ ♗g8 36.♕h5+ ♗f7 37.♕xb5+ ♕xb5 38.♘xb5 a6 39.♘d4 ♖c5 40.b3 ♗g6 41.♔b2 ♖e5 42.♖d2 ♖e4 43.♘c6 ♔f7 44.♖d4 ♖e2 45.♖f4+ ♔e8 46.♖c4 ♖g2 47.♘e5 1-0

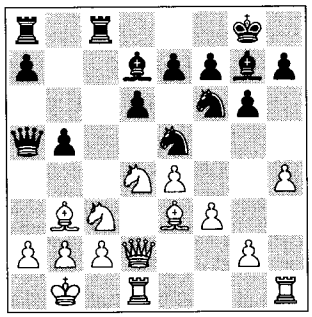
Game 16.10

Polzin,Rainer
Roos,Michel
Dresden Open 1999

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 g6 6.♗e3 ♗g7 7.f3 0-0 8.♗c4 ♘c6 9.♕d2 ♗d7 10.h4 ♘e5 11.♗b3 ♕a5 12.0-0-0 ♖fc8 13.♔b1 b5

Kortchnoi's move, or so it is said. This pawn sacrifice is thematic in the Dragon and usually not very successful. The

Dragon expert Chris Ward has worked a lot on this line, quite successfully, but objectively it appears that White stays on top.



14.♘cxb5! ♕xd2

It is quite a relief to see that Black prefers to trade queens and then prove the compensation. We must take into account that the g-pawn hasn't moved yet and White's pawn structure is solid. Though we shouldn't despise the activity of the black pieces, it can be neutralized with good play.

O 14...♕a6 is the original move, but the queen is misplaced here. 15.♘c3 ♘c4 16.♕d3 ♖ab8 17.♗c1. White sets up a real wall of pieces in front of his king, while not forgoing the attack: 17...♖b4 18.h5 ♕b7 19.hxg6 hxg6 20.♗h6± Karpov-Garcia Martinez, Ljubljana-Portoroz 1975.

O 14...♕d8 is a more recent approach and somewhat more dangerous than the text: 15.♗h6! ♗xh6 (15...♗h8 16.h5 – 16.♘c3 may be better – 16...♘xh5 17.♖xh5 a6?! (17...gxh5 18.♕g5+ ♘g6 19.♗xf7+ ♔xf7 20.♕d5+ e6 21.♘xd6+ ♔g8 22.♘xe6 ♗c6 23.♘xd8+ ♗xd5 24.♘xc8 ♗c4 and we may question White's edge) 18.♘xd6 exd6 19.♗g5 ♕b6 20.♖xh7!+– Zelcic-Forster, Portoroz tt 1998) 16.♕xh6 ♖ab8 17.a4 a6 18.♘a3 ♖b4 19.h5 ♘xh5 20.♘f5! ♗xf5 21.exf5 ♕f8 22.♕g5 ♘f6 23.fxg6 ♘xg6 24.♕a5± Wang Lei-Ward, Beijing Open 1993.

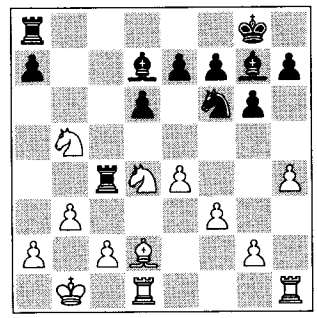
15.♗xd2!

I'd like to recommend this move which defends c3, an important theme in some tactical lines.

15...♘c4

This move and the more complicated **15...♖ab8** are of equal popularity amongst Black players. 16.♘c3 ♘c4 puts White at a crossroads: 17.♗xc4 (the alternatives ♗g5 and ♗c1 are interesting, but I think White should try to simplify the position, as long as there is nothing against it) 17...♖xc4 18.♘b3 ♗e6 19.♗e3 a5?! 20.♖d4! and Black is forced to ease the pressure, Parker-D.Tan, Hastings 1995.

16.♗xc4 ♖xc4 17.b3!



After White reorganizes his position, Black's compensation for the pawn is just symbolic, i.e. the bishop pair and not much more. White's position is solid.

17...♖c5

17...♖cc8 18.c4 a6 19.♘c3±.

18.c4 a6

The most common move. Other possibilities: **18...♖b8** 19.♗e3 a6 20.♘a3±; **18...e5** in order to capture on b5: 19.♘e2 ♗xb5 20.cxb5 ♖xb5 21.♗e3± and White has a great positional edge.

19.♘c3 ♘g4

Seizing the last-but-one chance of exploiting the vulnerability of the d4 knight. **19...♖b8** is very similar: 20.♔c2 ♘g4 21.fxg4 ♗xd4 (Reeh-Ward, Bern Open 1993) and now 22.♘d5!±.

20.fxg4 ♗xd4 21.♘d5 ♗xg4

21...♖e8? 22.♗b4+–.

22.♘xe7+ ♔g7 23.♗h6+ ♔xh6 24.♖xd4±

After all the complications, White is a pawn up.

24...♖e5 25.♘d5 ♔g7 26.♔b2 f5 27.♘c3 ♖d8 28.exf5 gxf5 29.♖f1 ♔g6 30.b4 ♔h5 31.♖h1 ♔g6 32.c5 d5 33.a4 ♔f6 34.b5 ♔e6 35.♖c1 axb5 36.axb5 ♖c8 37.b6 ♗e2 38.b7 ♖b8 39.c6 ♔d6 40.♘b5+ ♗xb5 41.c7 ♖xb7 42.c8♕ ♖e2+ 43.♔a1 1-0

SUMMARY

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 g6 6.♗e3 ♗g7 7.f3 and now:

– 7...a6: a modern treatment, reasonably sound, which opens a new field for research ±

– 7...0-0 8.♕d2 a6: with kingside castling included, Black's set-up is too risky ±

– 7...♘c6 8.♕d2 ♗d7: postponing castling may be useful, but it doesn't work against correct preparation ±

7...♘c6 8.♕d2 0-0 9.♗c4 and now:

– 9...♘d7?!: speculative and risky ±

– 9...♘a5!?: a quite unknown line and not easy to refute ±

– 9...♘xd4 10.♗xd4 ♗e6: solid, but eventually passive ±

9...♗d7 10.0-0-0 and now:

– 10...♕c7: one of many attempts to get counterplay. Interesting but insufficient ±

– 10...♕b8: has given some results, but it is quite risky ±

– 10...♖b8: perhaps the most solid line at this moment ±/=

– 10...♘a5: as at move 9, little used and not that bad ±

– 10...♖c8 11.♗b3 ♘xd4: a modern line, dangerous for both players ±

10...♖c8 11.♗b3 ♘e5

Main line years ago, but in serious trouble due to 12.♔b1, and now:

– 12...♘c4: White's attack runs smoothly ±

– 12...♖e8: relatively the best, with room for research ±

10...♕a5 11.♗b3 ♖fc8

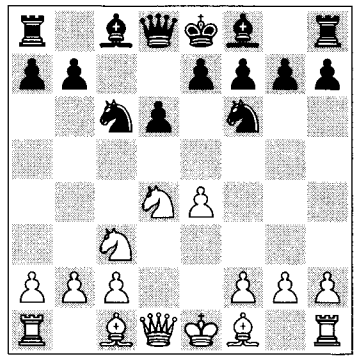
Used to be a main line as well, but is in trouble too: 12.♔b1 ♘e5 13.h4, and now:

– 13...♘c4: White's attack comes really easy ±

– 13...b5: gives some counterplay, but not enough to equalize ±

CHAPTER 17

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 ♘c6 Classical Variation



Evaluation ****

Introduction

In this chapter we are going to study the Classical Variation which, from Black's point of view, is a thick network of transpositions. Many players use it to reach their pet variations, while avoiding the most annoying lines. By choosing 6.♗g5, White avoids the transpositions and gives the game an independent, but also sharp, character. This may lead many Black players to avoid this set-up when they expect to face this move. Within 6.♗g5, this book focuses especially on those set-ups where White plays f2-f3, which leads to similar positions to other lines, while keeping some particular features. This set-up with an f3-pawn is becoming more popular. However, they are still far less common than the lines where White plays f2-f4. Since this variation is virtually a crossroads, we will leave out the section devoted to history and, within the section about ideas, we will focus on the white player.

Ideas

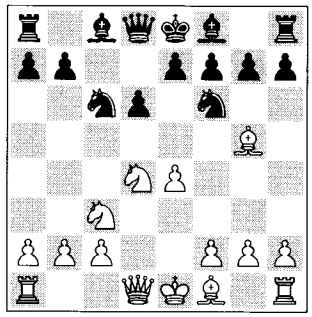
The set-ups with queenside castling and f2-f3 present a series of common ideas which we already mentioned in the general introduction to the book. The move 6.♗g5 leaves its own imprint: Black has to be aware that White can exchange on f6 and then capture the d6-pawn, though very often it is not worth the loss of the dark-squared bishop.

Another independent feature is that the push ...d5, whether directly or preceded by ...e5, is far more difficult with the enemy bishop on g5. The white plan often consists of keeping the bishop on g5, exerting some pressure on the black position, until the moment comes to move it back to e3 and thus open the way for a direct attack.

Game 17.01

Lahno,Kateryna
Atalik,Suat
Dresden 2007

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 d6 6.♗g5

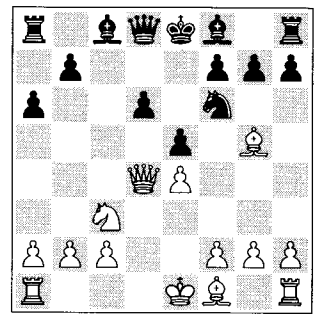


6...♗d7

By far the most important secondary line. Black accelerates his queenside development, especially ...♖c8, and tries to set up a quick attack if White castles there. Exchange sacrifices on c3, an eventual ...e7-e5 and, if White takes on f6, the hope of playing ...f5 with the support of the bishop, are some distinctive features of this variation. Virtually all the remaining alternatives have already been tried:

O 6...h6!? A marginal line, but one that makes a lot of sense. Black wants to force the opponent to take on f6 before the move ...e6. Thus he can later play ...f5 and get rid of the doubled pawns. The drawback of this plan is that the development is seriously impaired but, if White is unable to exploit this, the first player can easily end up in an inferior position. **7.♗xf6 gxf6 8.♕d2 ♕b6** Black has to drive the knight off d4 and then play ...f5. 8...♗d7 transposes to 6...♗d7. **9.♘b3 f5** 9...e6?! 10.♘b5 ♗d7 11.♘xd6+ ♗xd6 12.♕xd6 0-0-0 (Palac-Bernal Moro, Montpellier 1997) 13.♕c5!±; 9...♗g7 10.♗d3!± and ...f5 is definitely ruled out. **10.♘d5!** Here comes the fight for development: **10...♕d8 11.♗b5** Threatening 12.♕c3 as well as 12.♘a5. **11...♗g7** 11...a6? 12.♕c3+– **12.♘d4!** With a double attack on c6 and f5. **12...♗xd4** An important concession. After 12...♗d7?! 13.♘xf5 ♗xb2 14.♖b1 the bishop has no good retreat, so 14...♗xf5 15.exf5 ♗g7 16.f6!± with a strong initiative. **13.♕xd4 0-0 14.♕e3!** Development is momentarily equal, but White just needs to castle and will be ready to start exploiting the weakness of Black's castled position. **14...e6** 14...♕a5+ 15.♘c3± **15.♘c3 ♕g5 16.f4 ♕h4+ 17.g3 ♕f6 18.0-0-0±** Szefer-Kowalska, Warsaw 1996.

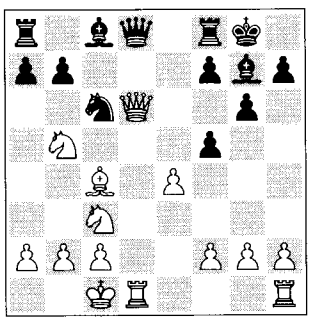
O 6...a6 A normal move with no clear refutation; applying the principle of economy, we'll be content with a transposition. **7.♕d2 ♘xd4** The only way to disturb White's plans, but of course 7...e6 occurs far more often and leads to the main line in the Richter. **8.♕xd4 e5**



It seems that Black wins a tempo in comparison to other lines, but actually Black is not ready for this yet. **9.♕a4+! ♗d7 10.♗xf6!?** The sharpest order, but

10.♕b3 b5 11.♗xf6 is equally good, as 11...♕xf6?! 12.a4! also creates problems. **10...♕xf6?!** Somewhat better looks 10...gxf6 11.♕b3 b5± and now White has a pleasant choice between 12.♘d5, 12. ♗e2 or even an immediate 12.a4. **11.♗b5!** The point! After trading light-squared bishops, White gets an indisputable grip on d5. **11...♕d8 12.♗xd7+ ♕xd7 13.♕b3 ♗e7 14.♘d5±** Kotronias-Kovalev, Debrecen Ech-tt 1992.

O 6...g6?! An odd move; Black reckons that his dark-squared bishop makes up for his ruined pawn structure. Indeed, White has to play carefully but at the same time vigorously, but this can be enough for a considerable edge. **7.♗xf6 exf6 8.♗c4** Ftacnik offers an excellent analysis of this alternative in *ChessBase Magazine*. My advice follows his. 8.♗b5 is a recent and simpler alternative that hopes to disturb Black's development. 8...♗d7 9.♗c4±. **8...♗g7 9.♘db5** The pawn drops and Black can choose between a certain long-term compensation based on the bishop pair, or entering complications to try to regain the pawn. **9...0-0 10.♕xd6 f5** 10...a6, in spite of being suggested by some computer modules, is a poor alternative. 11.♕xd8 ♖xd8 12.♘c7 ♖a7 13.♘7d5 b5 14.♗d3± and there is not much for the pawn. **11.0-0-0** and now:



A) **11...♕g5+** is the 'old line': 12.f4 ♕xg2 13.e5 ♕g4 (13...♗h6 14.♖hf1 ♕xh2 15.♔b1 – the threat is 16.♘d5 – 15...♘a5 16.♗d5±; 13...♖d8?! 14.♗xf7+! ♔xf7 15.♕c7+ ♔g8 16.♖xd8+ ♘xd8 17.♕xd8+ ♗f8 18.♖d1 b6 19.♘c7 ♖b8 20.e6 ♔g7 21.♘e8+ ♔g8 22.♘f6+ ♔g7 23.♕c7+ 1-0 Kartsev-A.Smirnov, Dagomys jr 2004) 14.♖hf1 ♘xe5? (14...♗xe5 15.♗xf7+ ♖xf7 16.fxe5±) 15.♗e2!+– Garcia Gonzales-Estevez Morales, Camagüey 1987;

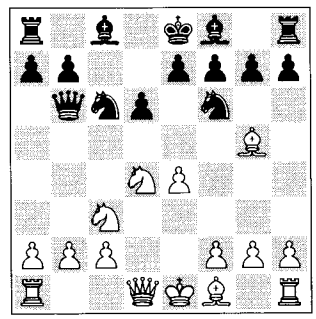
B) **11...♕xd6** 12.♘xd6 ♗xc3 13.bxc3 fxe4 14.♘xe4± and White's development is more important than the extra pawn;

C) **11...♕a5** is the most debated move in recent times, but doesn't seem to be enough either: 12.♕c7! and now:

C1) **12...♗xc3** 13.bxc3 a6 (13...♕a4 14.♘d6 ♗e6 15.♗b3 ♗xb3 16.axb3 ♕a1+ 17.♔d2 ♕a3 18.b4!! ♕a2 19.♕xb7 ♘e5 20.♕d5! ♕xd5+ 21.exd5 ♖fd8 22.♘b7 ♖xd5+ 23.♔e2+–) 14.♖d8 ♕xc7 15.♖xf8+ ♔xf8 16.♘xc7 ♖a7 17.♗d3 b5 18.♘d5 ♗e6 19.♔b2 ♘e5 20.♘f4 ♗c4 21.exf5 g5 22.♖e1 ♖e7 23.♘e6+ ♗xe6 24.♖xe5+– Carlsen-D.Gurevich, Rishon Le Zion blitz 2006;

C2) **12...fxe4** 13.♕xa5 ♘xa5 14.♗d5 ♗g4 15.♖de1± Volokitin-Carlsen, Biel 2006.

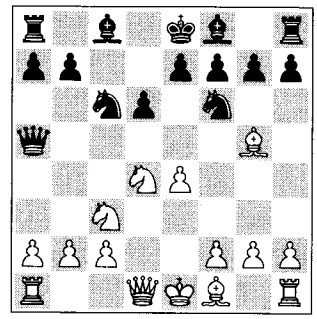
O 6...♕b6



One of the most serious alternatives in this section. Black wants to displace the enemy knight from the centre, which limits the strength of White's set-ups involving f2-f3. Also, Black is not afraid of doubled pawns on the f-file. **7.♘b3 e6 8.♗f4!** With these curious stepped movements, the bishop exploits the drawbacks of the position of the black queen on b6. This is the simplest and most direct way of creating problems. Also promising, but more studied and typical of Black's intentions, is 8.♗xf6!? gxf6 since the queen is still on the d1-h5 diagonal and White can play ♕h5 or ♗e2 and maybe ♗h5. **8...♘e5** 8...e5?! leaves an ugly hole on d5 and the queen is misplaced. **9.♗e3!** White gets ready to gain time on the knight recently 'invited' to move to e5. **9...♕c7 10.f4** ♘**c6** 10...♘eg4?! 11.♗g1 and the knight is in trouble; 10...♘c4 11.♘b5! ♕c6 12.♗xc4 ♕xc4 13.♕d3± and Black has problems on c7. 10...♘ed7!? is scarcely played, but very logical. White must follow the same plan with 0-0-0, ♕f3 and g2-g4. **11.g4!** The sharpest move, though other possibilities such as 11.♕f3 and 11.0-0-0 are also appealing. **11...d5** The most logical if Black wants to prevent his opponent from setting up the ideal attacking system, e.g.: 11...a6 12.g5 ♘d7 13.♕d2 (13.♕f3!?) 13...b5 14.0-0-0 ♗b7 15.f5 ♘ce5 16.fxe6 fxe6 17.♘d4 ♘c5 18.♗h3± Vorobiov-Ramesh, Moscow 2006. **12.e5** ♘**d7** 12...♘e4? 13.♘xe4 dxe4 14.♗g2 ♘b4 15.♗xe4 ♕c4 16.♘d2+– and there is no compensation for the pawn. **13.♘b5** ♕**b8** 13...♕d8 14.h4 a6 15.♘5d4 ♘xd4 16.♕xd4± Ivanchuk-Delgado Ramirez, Havana 2007 **14.g5!** This is important to prevent an eventual ...g5,which would blow up White's centre. **14...a6 15.♘5d4 ♕c7 16.♕f3!?** This is not bad, but White can avoid complications with the more natural move 16.♗d3. **16...♘xd4 17.♘xd4 ♗b4+ 18.♔f2!** Now this short walk is necessary. **18...♗e7 19.h4±** Topalov-Smirin, Burgas 1994. White has a standard position with a spatial advantage and the d4-square, but the king would be safer on b1.

O 6...e5?! Perhaps naively hoping to transpose to a Pelikan. 7.♗xf6! (the precise move order) 7...gxf6 (7...♕xf6? 8.♘d5 ♕d8 9.♘b5+–) 8.♘f5 ♗xf5 9.exf5± Geller-Ozsvath, Budapest tt 1970. Black has given up the d5-square with nothing in exchange.

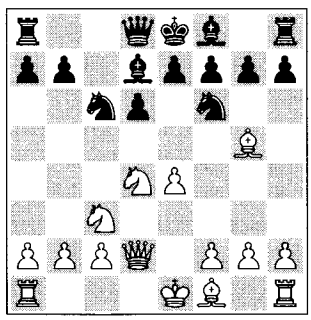
O 6...♕a5!?



Very secondary, but the Spanish player Juan Antonio Corral Blanco has shown at high level that it has its virtues after all. First, White has to take a decision regarding his g5 bishop. **7.♗b5!** This allows White to take the game into standard Richter set-ups. **7...♗d7 8.♘b3** Now the black queen is expelled again to its original square. **8...♕d8** 8...♕c7 9.♗xf6 gxf6 10.♘d5 ♕d8 11.♕h5± S.Nikolic-Gufeld, Kislovodsk 1968. **9.♗xf6 gxf6 10.♕h5** The white queen occupies an ideal position in this pawn structure, and at the same time

prevents an immediate 10...f5. **10...♖g8** 10...a6 is the natural reply, but the white bishop doesn't have problems to retreat after its mission on b5 is completed: 11.♗e2 ♖g8 12.0-0 ♘e5 (12...e6 13.a4 ♖g6 14.f4 ♖h6 15.♕f3 ♕c7 16.a5 0-0-0 17.♕f2 ♔b8 18.♖fd1± Campora-Mendoza, Bogota 1980) 13.f4 ♗g4 14.♗xg4 (14.♕xh7!? ♖g7 15.♕h4 and the compensation for the pawn is hard to see) 14...♕b6+ 15.♔h1 ♘xg4 16.♕h4 e6 17.♖f3 ♗e7 18.♕e1 h5 19.a4 ♖c8 20.a5 ♕a7 21.♖d1 b5 22.axb6 ♕xb6 23.h3± Perez Candelario-Korneev, Elgoibar 2006. **11.g3 ♖g5** It is important to displace the enemy queen, but this will allow White to gain time when playing the desired push f2-f4. **12.♕e2 a6** 12...f5?! 13.f4 ♖g6 14.exf5 ♗xf5 15.♘d4±. **13.♗d3 e6** Black definitely forgoes his plan involving ...f5. **14.f4 ♖g7 15.♕h5 ♕b6 16.0-0-0 0-0-0 17.♔b1±** And White has achieved a very favourable position in this structure. **17...♔b8?!** Allowing a forced tactical sequence that wins a pawn. **18.♕h4! ♗e8** 18...♗e7 19.♕h6 **19.♕xf6 ♖g4 20.♕h8 ♗g7 21.♕xh7 ♗xc3 22.bxc3 a5 23.♗e2 ♖g6 24.f5 ♖g5 25.♕h6+−** Topalov-Corral Blanco, Spain tt 2000.

7.♕d2



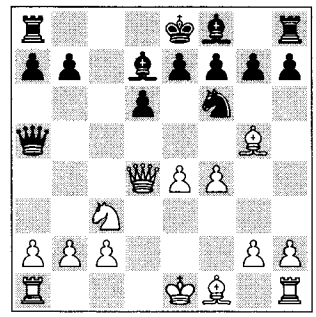
7...♖c8

Following the most popular counterplay line; the rook aims at the enemy castled position. Also tried:
7...♘xd4 8.♕xd4 and now:

A) **8...♖c8?!** 9.f4 leads to a transposition, but maybe capturing a7 is possible;

B) **8...h6** This is a recent try by Malakhov, but it is too slow: 9.♗xf6 gxf6 10.♗b5 ♗c6 11.0-0 ♗g7 12.♖ad1 ♔f8 13.♕d3 ♕a5 14.♗xc6 bxc6 15.♘e2! (White starts his attack by transferring the knight to the kingside, specifically to f5) 15...f5 (15...♕xa2 16.♖a1 ♕e6 17.♘d4 ♕d7 18.♖a6±) 16.exf5 ♕xa2 17.b3 ♕a5 18.♕f3 ♖c8 19.♘g3± Black has no compensation for the bad position of his king, Grischuk-Malakhov, Elista 2007;

C) **8...♕a5 9.f4** and now:



C1) **9...♖c8** 10.e5 transposes to the text;

C2) **9...h6** Malakhov and Dreev have also tried this move, but White gets a perfect set-up again: 10.♗xf6 gxf6 11.0-0-0 ♖c8 12.♔b1 ♕c5 13.♕d3 f5 14.exf5! ♗xf5 (14...♕xf5 15.♕d4 ♖g8 16.♕xa7 ♗c6 17.♕b6 ♗g7 18.♘b5 ♔f8 19.♘a7 ♖a8 20.♘xc6 bxc6 (Inarkiev-Malakhov, Spain tt

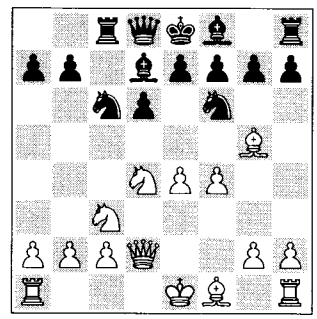
2007) and now after 21.g3!± the position is quite complicated, but White has the stronger trumps, though he should keep an eye on the b-file) 15.♕g3 ♕b4 16.♖d5 ♗e4 17.♕g4!± Motylev-Dreev, Spain tt 2007. Black struggles to play actively, but his king in the centre is a constant headache.

C3) **9...e5!?** 10.♕d2 ♗e7 11.0-0-0 ♗c6 12.♔b1! (a preparation for the usual tactical tricks which punish the premature sortie of the queen to a5) 12...exf4 (12...♕c7 13.♘b5!±; 12...0-0 13.♘d5 ♕d8 14.♘xe7+ ♕xe7 15.♗d3±) 13.♗xf4 0-0? (now this is worse than on the previous move; 13...0-0-0 14.♗c4±; 13...♕c5 14.♗xd6 ♗xd6 15.♕xd6 ♕xd6 16.♖xd6± ♘xe4? 17.♖xc6 ♘f2 18.♗b5+–) 14.♘d5!+– ♗d8 15.♘xf6+ gxf6 16.♕e3 Leko-Scarella, Buenos Aires tt 1994.

O 7...a6 will probably end up in a transposition: 8.0-0-0 ♖c8?! (8...e6 is the normal move and leads to other games in this chapter) 9.f4! h6 (it is too late for 9...e6 10.♘f3!± and the threat e4-e5 is annoying) 10.♗xf6 gxf6 11.♗e2± (Black has wasted a lot of time and has given up queenside castling. His strategy seems to be a mixture of incoherent ideas. Now White is threatening to place his bishop on the ideal square h5) 11...h5 12.♔b1 e6 13.♖hf1 b5 14.♘xc6! (after this exchange, f4-f5 won't allow a black knight onto e5) 14...♖xc6 15.♗f3 ♖c5 16.f5 ♕a5 (16...b4 17.fxe6 fxe6 18.♘e2±) 17.fxe6 fxe6 18.e5! (in comparison with similar positions, here Black is doomed because the king is in the centre) 18...♖xe5 (18...fxe5? 19.♕g5+–) 19.♕f4⩲ (19.♘e4!? ♕xd2 20.♖xd2±) 19...♖f5 (19...♗e7? 20.♘e4 ♖f8 21.♘xd6+ ♗xd6 22.♖xd6 ♖e1+ 23.♖d1+–) 20.♕g3⩲ Spassky-Bilek, Moscow 1967.

8.f4!

This is my recommendation. 8.0-0-0 is more orthodox but it allows Black a wider choice and more dangerous counterplay based on the exchange sacrifice on c3.



8...♘xd4

O 8...h6 is a good opportunity to avoid the complications of the main line, which seem to favour White: 9.♗xf6 gxf6 10.♘f5! (this is the main drawback. Black now has problems developing the dark-squared bishop, unless he gives up the light-squared one) 10...♕a5 (10...♗xf5 11.exf5 with a strong grip on the light squares) 11.♗d3 e6 12.♘e3 a6 13.0-0 h5 14.♔h1 ♗e7 15.a3! (once again, Black's problem is the king in the centre. Now White starts an attack to open lines on the queenside) 15...♕c5 16.♘e2 b5 17.b4 ♕b6 18.c3. And now White regroups his pieces in order to put pressure on the centre, while a3-a4 or c3-c4 will always be hanging over the black player's head: 18...h4 19.h3 ♖h5 20.♗c2 ♖d8 21.♗b3 ♗f8 22.♘g4 ♗e7 23.f5! (the threat is to exchange

pawns and then take on f6) 23...e5 24.♘h6 ♔f8 25.♘xf7 1-0 Kulaots-Krakops, Mezezers 2000.

8...♕a5 without trading knights has its drawbacks: 9.♘b3! ♕c7 10.0-0-0 h6 (10...e6? is not possible due to 11.♗xf6 gxf6 12.♘b5+−; 10...a6 is very slow after 11.♗e2 e6 12.♗xf6 gxf6 13.♗h5±) 11.♗xf6 gxf6 12.♗e2 (12.♘d5!?) 12...h5 (to prevent 13.♗h5) 13.♔b1 a6 14.♘d5 ♕d8 15.♕e3! b5 16.f5 (very committal, though White maintains a strong initiative as the enemy king is stuck in the centre. It was simpler to remove the light-squared bishop: 16.♘b6 ♖b8 17.♘xd7±) 16...♘e5 17.♕a7 ♗c6 18.♕xa6 e6 19.♘b4± Fluvia Poyatos-Fernandez Romero, La Algaba 2001.

9.♕xd4 ♕a5 10.e5

Now Black has to transpose to a line within the 8.0-0-0 variation, which has a bad reputation.

10...dxe5

10...♘e4? was even worse: **11.b4!+−** Khukhashvili-Matnadze, Tbilisi ch-GEO jr 2002.

There is no tactical solution for Black, as we will see: **10...♖xc3?! 11.bxc3!** (11.♕xc3!? would allow complications, but Black has good compensation after 11...♕xc3+ 12.bxc3 ♘e4∞) **11...♘e4** This forces the way to c3, but Black is dangerously behind in development, and White is going to exploit this in brilliant fashion.

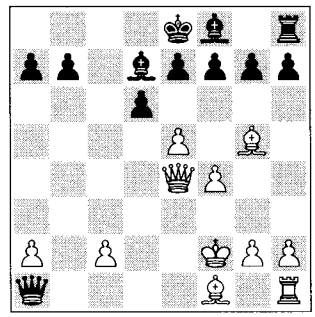
There is a slightly more solid alternative: 11...♘d5!? 12.exd6! White is not afraid of the discovered attack after the capture on c3, and so he has time to destroy Black's structure before castling. And now:

A) 12...♘xc3?! 13.dxe7!+−;

B) 12...e6 13.♗c4 ♕xc3+ (13...♘xc3 14.0-0+−) 14.♕xc3 ♘xc3 15.f5! ♗xd6 (15...exf5 16.♗f4±, defending the important d6 pawn) 16.fxe6±;

C) 12...f6 13.♗c4 ♘xc3 14.0-0 fxg5 15.♖ae1 ♕b6 16.♕xb6 axb6 17.♖f3 ♘e4 18.♖xe4 ♗c6 19.♗b5 ♗xb5 20.dxe7 Shabalov-Van der Weide, Willemstad 2003.

12.♕xe4 ♕xc3+ 13.♔f2 ♕xa1



14.♗b5! 14.♕xb7 ♕d4+∞ **14...♕b2** The most resilient is 14...♕c3 15.♗xd7+ ♔xd7 16.♕xb7+ ♕c7 (16...♔e6 17.♖e1+−) 17.♖b1!± with a winning endgame. **15.♕xb7! ♕xc2+ 16.♔g3 ♕c3+ 17.♔h4! ♗xb5 18.♕xb5+ ♔d8 19.♖d1!!+−** Gallego-Franco Ocampos, Ciutat d'Elx 1985.

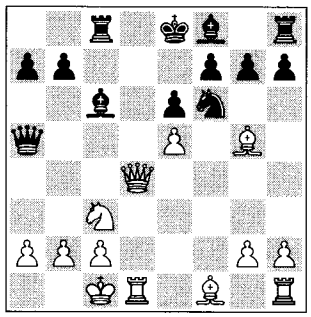
11.fxe5 e6!

11...♗c6? is a common mistake. After 12.b4+− Black loses a piece.

12.0-0-0 ♗c6

12...♖xc3 looks appealing, but White has a very precise refutation: 13.♗d2! ♕xa2 14.♗xc3 g6 15.b4! ♘d5 16.♗c4 ♗h6+ (16...♕a3+ 17.♗b2 ♕e3+ 18.♔b1 ♕xd4 19.♖xd4 ♘b6 20.♖hd1+−) 17.♖d2! ♕a3+ 18.♗b2 ♕xb4 19.♗xd5! ♕xd2+ 20.♕xd2

♗xd2+ 21.♔xd2 exd5 22.e6!+– Beliavsky-Ubilava, Ordzhonikidze tt 1978. A long and precise variation.



13.♘b5!?

13.♗b5!? is promising too.

13...♗xb5 14.exf6

The previous moves have been quite forced, but now Black has to make a very important choice.

14...♗c6

14...♗a4?! looks more logical, but actually the attack on c2 is illusory: 15.h4! (15.♗d2!? wins the exchange, but it doesn't look enough to claim a noticeable edge: 15...♖xc2+ 16.♔b1 ♖xd2!=) 15...g6 (15...♖xc2+? 16.♔b1+– and there is no defence against all the threats) 16.♗d3 (16.♗d2 is somewhat better than before, as it preserves the f6 pawn, but even so, 16...♖xc2+ 17.♔b1 ♖xd2!± offers Black quite a lot of play) 16...♗c5 17.♕g4 ♕b4 (17...h5 18.♕e2 and there is not much difference with the ...♗c6 line. Black has to live with the eternal insecurity of his king) 18.♕xb4 ♗xb4 19.h5!±. Just in time; this break, together with the threat ♖h4, poses a serious problem for Black, I.Almasi-Nogradi, Budapest Spring Open 1996.

15.h4 g6

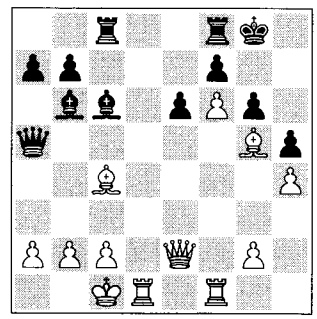
15...♕xa2? is not possible in view of 16.fxg7 ♕a1+ 17.♔d2 ♕a5+ 18.♔e2+–;
With **15...♖g8**, Black gives up castling rights, and his exposed king brings unfortunate consequences: 16.♗c4 gxf6 17.♖he1 fxg5 18.♗xe6! (see the previous note!) 18...fxe6 (Kupreichik-Yudasin, Frunze ch-URS 1981) 19.♕f6! with a decisive attack.

16.♗c4 ♗c5 17.♕g4 h5 18.♕e2 0-0 19.♖hf1!±

With the threat g2-g4; Z.Varga-Robatsch, Bükfürdo tt 1995.

19...♗b6

This move keeps the bishop active and leaves the c-file open for the black rook to play. **19...♗b4** looks worse, as the bishop is an obstacle to the queen instead of a support for it: 20.♔b1 (20.a3! forces the bishop to come back to the same square: 20...♗c5 21.♖d3±) 20...♗xg2 21.♕xg2 ♖xc4 22.♕xb7 ♗c3 (22...♕e5!, intending 23...♖b8, is far stronger) 23.bxc3?! Sikula-Abergel, Nancy 2007.



20.♗h6?!

Missing Black's subtle threat.

20.g4?! is a little late now: 20...hxg4 21.♕xg4 ♕a4 with an unpleasant pin which forces 22.♕e2 ♗f3! 23.♖xf3 ♕xc4 and Black has no problems.

But the prophylactic move **20.♔b1!**, intending g2-g4 as well as ♗h6, is difficult to meet. For example: 20...♗xg2 (20...♕c5 21.g4! – 21.♗h6!? ♖fd8 22.♗d3 threatening ♗g6 and the idea g2-g4 – 21...♗f3 22.♖xf3 ♕xc4 23.♕xc4 ♖xc4 24.gxh5 gxh5± and a complex endgame arises which looks better for White but needs practical examples for a proper assessment) 21.♗xe6 ♗xf1 22.♕e4 ♔h7 23.♗xc8 ♖xc8 24.♖xf1 and the black king's bad position is an important feature, in the middlegame as well as in the endgame.

20...♗xg2! 21.♕xg2

21.♗xe6? ♗xf1 22.♕e4 ♔h7 23.♗xf8 ♖xf8 24.♖xf1 ♖e8 is good for Black.

21...♖xc4 22.♗xf8 ♕xa2!

With the lethal threat 23...♗e3+.

23.♗h6 ♕a1+

23...♗a5!, renewing the mating threat, was decisive: 24.c3 ♖xc3+ 25.bxc3 ♕xg2–+.

24.♔d2 ♕xb2 25.♔e1?!

25.♖c1 is the most resilient, but after 25...♖d4+ 26.♔e1 ♖g4 27.♕f3 g5!–+ there can be little doubt that Black has a huge advantage.

25...♕e5+ 26.♕e2 ♖e4 27.♕xe4 ♕xe4+ 28.♔d2 ♗a5+ 29.c3 ♕d4+ 30.♔e2 ♕e5+ 31.♗e3 ♗b6 32.♖d3 ♗xe3 33.♖xe3 ♕h2+ 34.♖f2 ♕xh4 35.♖d3 ♕c4 36.♔e3 e5 37.♖d8+ ♔h7 38.♖d7 ♕c5+ 0-1

Game 17.02

Bologan,Viktor
Ye Jiangchuan
Beijing 2000

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 ♘c6 6.♗g5 e6

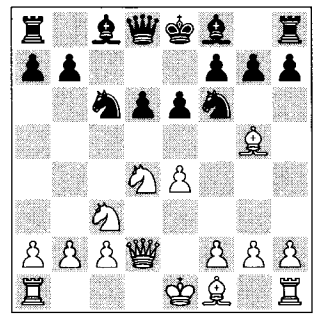
The most popular move here. Black avoids doubled pawns for the moment. Then he has a wide choice of plans, which we can divide into two groups:

1 - Leaving the king in the centre and playing for quick queenside counterplay, or

2 - Orthodox development: ...♗e7 followed by ...0-0 and then counterattack.

In this first game, we are going to focus on the second plan, but we will also see some less important lines.

7.♕d2



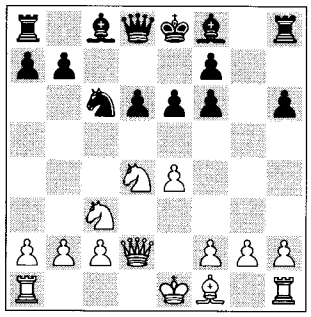
7...♗e7

Black gets ready for an immediate ...0-0. Alternatives:

O 7...a6 will be examined in the last games in this chapter.

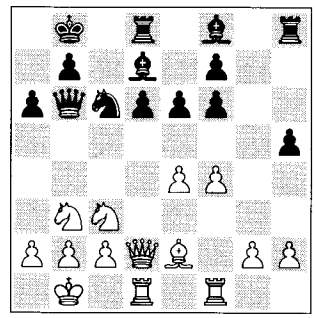
O 7...h6 This move has very specific intentions. Black wants to take the game to a position with doubled pawns, and considers that then the white queen will be misplaced on d2, as ♕h5 is not

possible. Even so, White's position is very flexible and there are good plans for the first player: **8.♗xf6 gxf6**



9.♗e2! Personally, I prefer the plan with 0-0, as in my opinion the king is safer on h1, and also helps defend the kingside. Of course, the plan with 0-0-0 has been played too, and both have approximately the same value. **9...h5 10.0-0 a6 11.♔h1!** The sooner the king leaves the dangerous diagonal, the better. **11...♗d7 12.f4 ♕c7** 12...♕b6 13.♘b3 0-0-0 is another plan, but White can disturb his opponent by transferring the rooks along the third rank and fighting for control of the b6-square. 14.a4 ♗e7 15.a5 ♕a7 16.♘a4±. **13.♖f3! ♘xd4** 13...0-0-0?! has to face the thematic manoeuvre: 14.♘xc6 ♗xc6 15.♘d5!±. **14.♕xd4 ♗e7 15.♖d1 h4 16.♖fd3** With e4-e5 ideas. **16...♖d8!** (Van der Wiel-Piket, Leiden 1986) and now Van der Wiel suggests **17.♗f3±**, keeping a slight edge.

O 7...♕b6!? One of the trendy lines. Black seeks to play the endgame. White can just play 8.0-0-0 and be content with a small edge in the endgame, or try more ambitious plans: **8.♗xf6!** White leads the game into a well-known structure, reckoning that the queen will have to waste at least one tempo in moving to a more convenient square than b6. 8.♗e3 ♘g4!∞; 8.♘db5 a6! 9.♗e3 ♕a5=; 8.0-0-0!? is perfectly sound but, after the exchanges on d4, just promises a small edge in the endgame. **8...gxf6 9.♘b3 a6** Reaching a position that may also arise via the Najdorf. 9...♗d7 10.0-0-0 0-0-0 11.f4 ♔b8 12.♔b1 ♘a5 13.♗e2 ♘xb3 14.axb3 ♕c5 15.f5 ♕e5 16.♗h5 ♗e8 17.g4 ♖g8 18.♖he1± (18.♖hf1!) 18...♖g5 19.♕f2 ♕a5 (Mchedlishvili-Benidze, Tbilisi 2009) and here the white player missed the thematic push 20.e5!±. **10.0-0-0 ♗d7 11.f4 0-0-0 12.♗e2 h5 13.♖hf1 ♔b8 14.♔b1**



White carries out a very straightforward plan to exploit the problems of the enemy position. The rook may play along the third rank and attack the h-pawn. **14...♗e7** By trading knights with 14...♘a5, Black frees his position a little, but 'activates' White's a-pawn: 15.♖f3 ♘xb3 16.axb3 ♕a5 17.♕d4 ♖g8 18.b4 ♕c7 19.♘d5!± Smirin-Melia, Athens 2008, with a strong attack) **15.♖f3 ♖dg8 16.♗f1 h4 17.♕e1±** Kamsky-Ponomariov, Khanty-Mansiysk 2007. The queen will now join the siege of the h-pawn. Black has some resources, but is clearly under pressure.

O 7...♗d7?! Not very logical, as it leaves the d6 pawn exposed; however, it

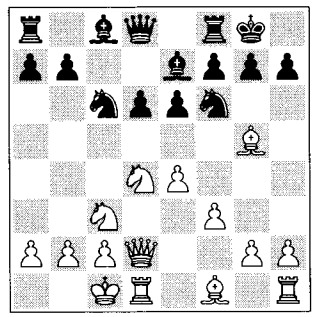
has occurred relatively often and it is not so easy to refute. **8.♘db5! ♕a5 9.♗xf6** 9.0-0-0! 0-0-0 10.♕e3± is even stronger. **9...gxf6 10.♘xd6+ ♗xd6 11.♕xd6 0-0-0 12.0-0-0 ♘b4 13.a3 ♘xc2 14.♗b5 ♗xb5 15.♕c5+ ♔b8 16.♕xb5 ♘a1!** An astounding move to the corner, but insufficient to equalize. **17.♖xd8+** 17.♕c4! ♖c8 18.♕a2 ♖xc3+ 19.bxc3 ♕xc3+ 20.♔b1 ♘b3 21.♕b2 ♕c4 22.♖he1 and Black does not have enough compensation for the exchange) **17...♖xd8 18.♖d1 ♖xd1+ 19.♔xd1 ♕d8+** Barczay-Szilagyi, Budapest ch-HUN 1964.

O 7...♘xd4 This move makes little sense without leading to 7... ♗e7 and ...a6. **8.♕xd4 ♗e7?!** Allows White to force a transposition to a slightly favourable endgame. 8...a6 9.0-0-0 ♗e7 leads to Game 17.03. **9.♗b5+ ♗d7 10.♗xd7+ ♕xd7 11.0-0-0 h6 12.♗xf6 ♗xf6 13.♕xd6±** and Black can only play for a draw.

8.0-0-0 ♘xd4

This is almost more popular than the main line, 8...0-0, since it rules out ♘b3, which has been White's main weapon for a couple of decades. Nowadays, however, ♘b3 should not scare Black, nor is it the move we are going to recommend.

O 8...0-0 before trading knights, gives Black some extra options we should consider. **9.f3!** This is my recommendation. Not so often played as 9.f4 or even 9.♘b3, some sources regard it as dubious due to the immediate reaction 9...d5. However, I think 9...d5 doesn't fully equalize, and our move consistently fits in with the rest of the variations suggested in this book.



Now:

A) **9...♘xd4** leads to the main game;

B) **9...♕b6** is no longer convenient in view of 10.♗e3;

C) **9...♕a5** isn't logical either on account of 10.♘b3;

D) **9...♕c7 10.h4 a6 11.♔b1 ♖d8** 11...♘xd4 is again a transposition; 11...b5 12.♘xc6 ♕xc6 13.♘e2 doesn't quite justify Black's failure to trade knights on d4. **12.g4 ♖b8 13.h5** Intending h5-h6 and delaying as long as possible the bishop retreat to e3, typical of this line. **13...h6 14.♗e3 d5!?** Other moves would have met the strong reply 15.g5. **15.e5!?** An interesting pawn sacrifice to keep the d-file closed, as White launches the offensive on the enemy castled position. It looks like the only chance to aspire to an edge, since 15.exd5 ♘xd5 16.♘xd5 ♖xd5 17.♗c4 ♖d8 18.♕e2 ♘xd4 19.♗xd4 b5 20.♗b3 ♗b7 is comfortable for Black. **15...♘xe5** 15...♕xe5? 16.♘xc6 bxc6 17.♗f4+−; 15...♘d7 16.f4±. **16.g5 hxg5 17.♗xg5 ♘c4** Black can't try all moves at the same time, and this position has occurred just once. The most logical alternative seems: 17...b5 18.h6 b4 (18...g6? 19.♕f4 ♘h5 20.♖xh5 gxh5 21.♗xe7+−) 19.hxg7, with multiple threats. **18.♗xc4 dxc4 19.h6 g6** Now White should play 20.h7+ ♔h8 21.♕f4!+− ♕xf4 22.♗xf4 ♘d7 (22...♖a8 23.♗e5) 23.♘xe6 fxe6

24.♖xd7 1-0 Arzumanian-Sharapov, Alushta 2001.

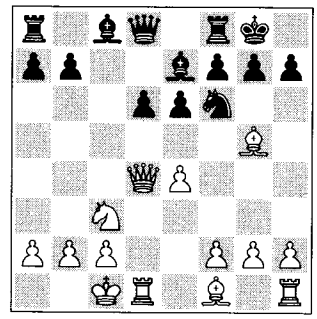
E) **9...a6** 10.h4 and now Black has to choose between a transposition with 10...♕c7 or defending the knight in order to play ...b5: 10...♗d7 11.♔b1 b5 12.♘xc6! (this thematic manoeuvre is ideal here: the second knight moves to d4, gaining time, and then White launches an attack on the kingside) 12...♗xc6 13.♘e2 ♖c8 14.♘d4 ♗b7 15.g4 d5 16.e5 ♘d7± Fedorchuk-Bernard, Paris 2008.

F) **9...d5 10.exd5 ♘xd5 11.♗xe7 ♘dxe7** 11...♕xe7 gives White a small edge after 12.♘xd5 exd5 13.♗b5±. With 11...♘cxe7, despite its solid appearance, Black has trouble finishing his development: 12.♘xd5 ♘xd5 13.♗c4± ♘b6 14.♗b3 ♗d7 15.♕f4 ♕f6 16.♕xf6 gxf6 17.f4± Inarkiev-Czarnota, Cappelle la Grande 2004. **12.♘xc6 ♘xc6** 12...♕xd2+ 13.♖xd2 ♘xc6 14.♗b5± Semenova-Ivanova, Serpukhov 2003. **13.♗b5** Again, Black is on the verge of equalizing, but due to some minor problems in finishing development, his prospects are reduced to half a point. **13...♕b6 14.♗xc6 ♕xc6 15.♕d6 ♕xd6 16.♖xd6** Curiously enough, Popov evaluates this position as a clear edge for White in *Chess Informant*, and later sources state equality. The truth may be in the happy medium. **16...e5 17.♘d5 ♗e6?!** Popov suggests 17...b6 18.♖e1 f6 19.♖e3 ♗b7 without evaluation, but here 20.♘e7+ ♔h8 21.♖a3± poses some problems. **18.♘c7 ♖ad8 19.♖xd8 ♖xd8 20.♘xe6 fxe6 21.♖d1±** Radulov-Inkiov, Sofia ch-BUL 1980/81.

O 8...a6 is usually followed by ...♘xd4 and leads to this game or to the next one, but White has an extra option, hitherto underestimated: **9.♗xf6** My recommendation. 9.f3 ♘xd4 transposes to the game. **9...gxf6** 9...♗xf6 10.♘xc6 bxc6 11.♕xd6 and there is no compensation for the pawn. **10.♗c4!** The bishop is excellently placed here to fight the doubled pawns, as it will support the pressure exerted on e6 by the f5 pawn. **10...♘xd4 11.♕xd4 b5 12.♗b3 ♗d7 13.f4 ♕c7 14.f5 ♕c5 15.♕d3 ♕e5 16.a3 0-0 17.♕f3 a5 18.♘d5!±** Luther-Schweda, Oberwart 2003.

9.♕xd4 0-0

In the next game we will analyse 9...a6, which is more popular.



10.f3!

The recommended move. White prepares the classical pawn assault h2-h4, g2-g4 etc. The g5 bishop adds some special features: the pawns find an obstacle in their way, but sometimes the pressure on f6 poses different problems for Black. Very often we see that the bishop ends up retreating, to threaten g4-g5.

10...a6

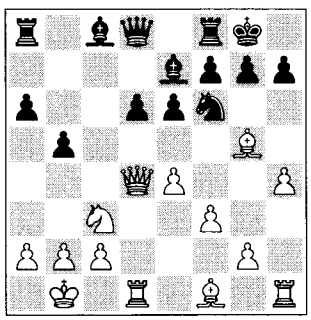
In this order, this is the most popular and usually Black has to play this sooner or later. The alternative **10...♕a5** occurs quite frequently as well, but I think it is premature. 11.♗d2 (11.♕d2 followed by ♔b1 is promising too) 11...♕c7

(11...♕d8 12.♗e3 a6 transposes to a well-known position in the English Attack; 11...e5 12.♕d3 ♗e6 13.♘d5 ♕d8 14.♘xe7+ ♕xe7 15.♗b4±; 11...♕c5 is perhaps the most solid, for example: 12.♕xc5 dxc5 13.♗f4±) 12.♘b5! ♕d8 (12...♕b8 13.♗b4 e5 14.♕xd6!±) 13.♗b4 d5 (13...e5 14.♕c3±) 14.♗xe7 ♕xe7 15.e5 ♘d7 (De La Villa Garcia-Vera, Leon 1996) and now, instead of taking on a7, White must be content with a small plus, similar to French variations, with 16.♗d3±.

11.h4 b5

The most natural, most flexible and surely the best. Black players have tried to move the queen to different squares: **11...♕a5?!** 12.♔b1 ♖b8 13.♕d2! (trying to find drawbacks in the premature queen sortie) 13...♔h8?! (13...♕c7 would be to acknowledge the waste of a tempo; 14.g4±) 14.h5! h6 (14...♖d8 15.h6+−) 15.♗e3 (15.♗xf6 is tempting: 15...♗xf6 16.♕xd6 ♗d7! 17.♘d5! exd5 18.e5 ♗xe5 19.♕xe5±) 15...b5 16.g4 b4 17.♘e2 ♗b7 18.♘g3 ♖fc8 19.♗d3± Hyldkrog-Stepanov, Konstantinopolsky mem cr 9398. White's attack looks more menacing; **11...♕c7** 12.♔b1 b5 transposes to the stem game.

12.♔b1



White chooses the most flexible move too; we reach an important crossroads.

12...♗b7

O 12...♖b8 An idea by Aseev which hasn't received much attention. Black simply prepares ...b4, followed by a wild pawn push. Actually, the pawns quickly reach their destination. **13.♕d2** Freeing the d4-square for the knight, but in fact the other natural move, 13.g4, may lead to the same position in a few moves. 13.e5!? hasn't occurred in practice yet: 13...dxe5 14.♕xe5 ♗d7 (14...♕b6?! 15.♘e4; 14...♘d7 15.♕g3) 15.♗d3 b4 16.♘e4± with some annoying threats. **13...b4 14.♘e2 a5 15.♘d4 ♗d7 16.g4** with an uncertain race: **16...a4 17.♗e3 ♘e8?!** 17...a3!?∞ **18.g5 ♘c7 19.f4 ♔h8 20.h5 f5 21.exf5 e5 22.h6 1-0** Naiditsch-Polajzer, Celje tt 2004.

O 12...♕a5 is now justified, as an eventual ...b4 will block the typical discovered attacks with ♘d5 if the white queen moves to d2. **13.♕d2!** The threat is 14.♘d5. **13...b4 14.♘e2 e5** 14...♗b7 15.♘d4 ♖fc8 16.♗d3 ♕c7 17.g4 a5 18.♗e3 e5 19.♘f5± Ibarra Jerez-Chapar, Peñiscola jr 2002. **15.c4! ♗e6 16.♘g3 ♖fd8 17.♗d3 ♕c7** Against the other popular move, 17...♖ac8, Arizmendi proposes the same plan: 18.♘f1! ♗xc4 19.♗xc4 ♖xc4 20.♘e3⩲. **18.♘f1 a5 19.g4 ♔f8 20.♘e3±** Arizmendi Martinez-Ermenkov, Andorra Open 2005. The grip on the d5-square secures a positional advantage, but also better attacking prospects.

O 12...♕c7 This is another way to prepare ...d5: Black will play ...♗b7 and ...d5 now that the black queen controls e5. We are following Bologan's recipe.

13.♕d2! Again, the queen frees d4 for the knight. And now:

A) **13...♖d8** is a serious alternative: 14.♘e2 ♖b8 (14...b4 15.♕xb4! and there is no compensation; on 14...e5 the white knight comes back to control d5: 15.♗xf6 ♗xf6 16.♘c3±) 15.♘d4 e5 16.♘f5 ♗xf5 17.exf5 d5 18.g4±;

B) **13...b4** 14.♘e2 d5 15.e5! Very important. This pawn can't be captured and White gets a favourable structure: 15...♘e8 (15...♕xe5? 16.♗f4 ♕f5 17.♘g3 ♕g6 18.♗d3+–) 16.♗xe7 ♕xe7 17.♘d4±.

13.♕d2!

13.g4?! is a dubious move order on account of 13...♖c8 14.♕d2 b4! 15.♗xf6 (15.♘e2 ♘xe4∓) 15...♗xf6∓ Huerga Leache-Recuero Guerra, Mondariz Balneario 2006.

13...♕c7

13...♖c8 14.♗d3 ♘d7 (14...♕c7 15.♘e2 ♖fd8 16.♘d4 transposes to the game) is a somewhat strange idea: 15.a3! f6 16.♗f4 ♘e5 17.h5 ♕c7 18.h6 g6± Salgado Lopez-Malakhov, Pamplona 2008.

14.♘e2 ♖ac8 15.♘d4

White completes the standard manoeuvre. It is hard for Black to play ...d5, whereas White is ready for the classical pawn assault.

15...♖fd8

15...d5 16.e5! ♘e8 17.♗xe7 ♕xe7 18.f4 f6 19.♖e1±.

16.♗d3 ♘e8!?

This is an odd move, very unlikely to be the best option, but we lack examples from actual games.

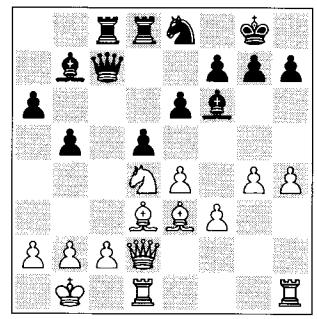
16...h6 17.♗e3 d5 18.e5! ♘d7 19.f4 ♘c5 20.g4 looks like a dangerous attack;
16...d5 17.e5±;
16...e5 17.♘f5 d5 18.♕e1!±.

17.g4 ♗f6 18.♗e3!

18.♗xf6?! ♘xf6 19.♕e2 (19.h5 d5 20.h6 dxe4 21.♕g5 ♘e8–+; 19.g5 ♘h5 20.f4? e5) 19...♕b6 20.♘b3=.

18...d5!?

The standard reaction, but here it meets an unexpected reply. If 18...e5 19.♘f5 d5 20.♕f2±.



19.e5!!

With this excellent pawn sacrifice, White achieves two goals: the central files won't open for the black pieces and White takes the lead in the attacking race.

19...♗xe5

19...♕xe5 20.g5+–; 19...♗e7 20.g5±.

20.f4 ♗d6

20...♗xd4 21.♗xd4 ♘d6 22.h5 ♘c4 23.♕f2±.

21.g5 e5 22.fxe5 ♗xe5 23.g6

23.h5! looks simple: 23...♘d6 24.g6 ♘c4 25.gxh7+ ♔h8 26.♕f2± with an

unquestionable edge, thanks to the d4-knight and the files open against Black's castled position. The rest of the game is a lesson in attack and we present it with some notes by Bologan in *Chess Informant*.

23...♘d6!?

23...hxg6 24.h5 gxh5 (24...g5 25.♗f5) 25.♖dg1! ♘f6 (25...g6 26.♖xh5) 26.♕g2 ♘g4 27.♖xh5 ♘xe3 28.♕h3 g6 29.♘e6! fxe6 30.♖xg6+ ♔f8 31.♕xe6+−.

24.gxf7+ ♕xf7 25.♖hf1 ♕d7?

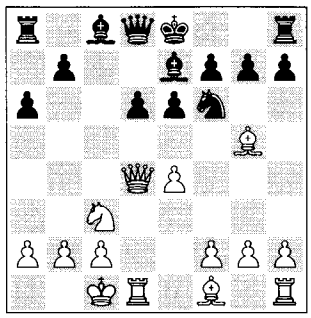
25...♕e8 26.♗f5 ♘xf5 27.♖xf5 ♖d7 28.♖e1⩲.

26.♘f3 ♗f6 27.♘g5 ♘c4 28.♗xh7+ ♔h8 29.♕e2 ♕e8 30.♖xf6! gxf6 31.♗d4+− ♖c6 32.♕f2 ♕f8 33.♗d3! ♖d7 34.♕f5 ♖e7 35.♘h7! ♗c8 36.♕h5 ♕f7 37.♗g6 1-0

Game 17.03

Korneev,Oleg
Baches Garcia,Guillermo
Spain tt 1999

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 d6 6.♗g5 e6 7.♕d2 a6 8.0-0-0 ♘xd4 9.♕xd4 ♗e7



A curious mixture of plans. One would say that Black is waiting for his opponent to decide between f2-f3 or f2-f4 before himself deciding between ...0-0 and ...b5.

10.♔b1!

A suitable moment for this king move that toys with ideas derived from e4-e5 and usually leads, after a future f2-f3, to positions similar to the other recommended lines.

O 10.f4!? has been the usual move here, and for a time, it even looked like the definitive refutation, but the variation has again become playable against this line too: 10...b5 11.♗xf6 gxf6 12.e5 d5 13.♔b1 and now both 13...♖g8 and 13...♗d7 offer tough resistance to White's refutation attempts.

O 10.f3!? usually leads to a transposition to the previous game, and it is possible, with little effort, to complete our repertoire, analysing the few lines where Black doesn't castle. 10...b5 11.h4 ♗b7 12.♔b1 0-0 is the standard transposition.

10...b5

This helps White's idea, but other moves have some problems too:

O 10...♗d7 The bishop is misplaced here when White plays a set-up with f2-f3, as it occupies the knight's retreat square. 11.f3! ♗c6 12.h4 h6 (12...♕c7 13.g4 b5 14.♗e3 0-0 15.g5± De La Villa Garcia-Lugovoi, Aosta 1999, with the classical attack in this line) 13.♗c1 h5 (13...d5 14.exd5 ♘xd5 15.♘xd5 ♗xd5 16.♗c4±) 14.♗g5 ♕a5 15.♗c4 ♕c5 16.♕d3 ♘d7 17.♗xe7 ♔xe7 18.♗b3± Korneev-Garcia Ilundain, Leon 1998.

O 10...0-0 11.h4! (11.f3 seems a mistake, as it allows 11...♘xe4, but it is not

clear that after 12.♘xe4 ♗xg5 13.♘xg5 ♕xg5 14.♕xd6 ♗d7! 15.h4 ♕a5 16.♗d3 Black has fully equalized: 16...♗c6 17.h5 h6 18.♖h4 ♖ad8 19.♕g3 ♖d5 20.♖g4) 11...h6?! (trying to make use of the g4-square; 11...b5 12.f3 transposes to the previous game) 12.e5! dxe5 13.♕xe5 ♗d7 14.♖h3± with a really powerful initiative on the kingside, and also in the centre.

11.e5!

This is the idea behind 10.♔b1. The push e4-e5 is always hanging over Black's position and here the scenario is ideal for it.

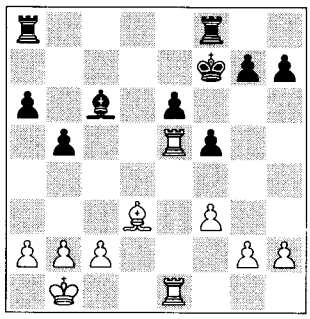
11...dxe5 12.♕xe5 ♗d7

12...♕b6 13.♗e2! ♗b7 14.♗e3 ♕a5 15.♗f3 ♗xf3 16.gxf3 0-0 17.♖hg1 with a crushing attack.

13.♘e4 ♘xe4 14.♗xe7 ♕xe7 15.♕xe4 0-0 16.♗d3 f5

16...g6 is more or less the same: 17.h4! b4 18.h5 ♗b5 19.hxg6 fxg6 20.f3 ♖fe8 21.♕e5 ♗xd3 22.♖xd3 a5 23.♖hd1± Ibarra Jerez-Lupulescu, Peñiscola jr 2002.

17.♕e5 ♗c6 18.f3 ♕f6 19.♖he1 ♕xe5 20.♖xe5 ♔f7 21.♖de1



We have reached an unusual position in this variation with opposite castled positions. White has a slight advantage in the endgame due to the grip on e5. Black's position is solid, but lacks prospects.

21...♖fe8 22.a4!

Trying to create another weakness.

22...♖ab8 23.♖c5 ♖ec8 24.♖ee5 ♗d5

24...bxa4 25.♗xa6 ♗b7 26.♗c4 ♖xc5 27.♖xc5 ♔f6 28.♖b5+–.

25.♖xc8 ♖xc8 26.♗xf5! ♖c4 27.♗e4?!

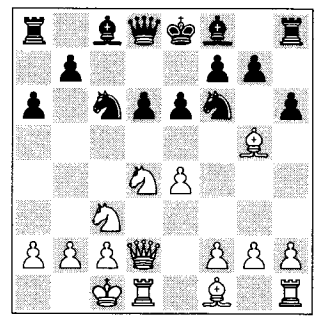
27.axb5 axb5 28.♗d3 ♖h4 29.♗xb5 ♖xh2 30.c4+– would have been the logical finish of this game.

27...♗xe4 28.♖xe4 ♖xe4 29.fxe4 ♔f6 30.c4 bxc4 31.♔c2 ♔e5 32.♔c3 ♔xe4 33.♔xc4 e5 34.b4 ♔e3 35.b5 axb5+ 36.axb5 e4 37.b6 ♔d2 38.b7 e3 39.b8♕ e2 40.♕b2+ 1-0

Game 17.04

Fressinet,Laurent
Bacrot,Etienne
Vichy ch-FRA 2000

1.e4 c5 2.♘c3 ♘c6 3.♘f3 d6 4.d4 cxd4 5.♘xd4 ♘f6 6.♗g5 e6 7.♕d2 a6 8.0-0-0 h6



This variation reached its highest popularity in the last two decades of the previous century, when several top players added it to their repertoires. Nowadays, it has entered a period of crisis, as White has been finding interesting attacking systems, such as the one we study in this game. Though this move very often just leads by transposition to 8...♗d7, its independent idea is the plan ...♘xd4, ...e5 and ...♗e6, in order to launch a thematic and very natural attack on White's castled position.

9.♘xc6!?

This move, in combination with the next, constitutes quite an original approach in this position. However, it looks completely justified by White's development and so far it has scored really well. It is one of the lines whose evaluation has remained stable in recent years, which proves the strength of White's plan.

9...bxc6 10.♗f4

This is the key move: White attacks the d6 pawn and, as ...e5 is impossible, the next black move is forced.

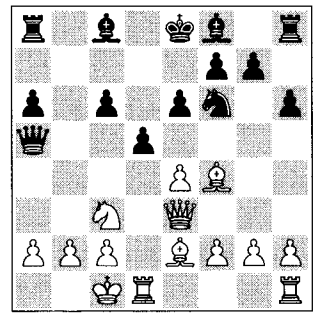
10...d5 11.♕e3

This pins the d-pawn and makes way for the queen to reach an active position, facing the black castled position. Black is now at an important crossroads.

11...♗e7

This is the most common move. Developing the bishop looks logical; the main doubt is whether the bishop should instead go to the most active spot (b4).

○ 11...♕a5 unpins the pawn and therefore prepares an eventual ...dxe4 followed by ...♘d5; another side idea is increasing the pressure on c3 with ...♗b4. **12.♗e2!**



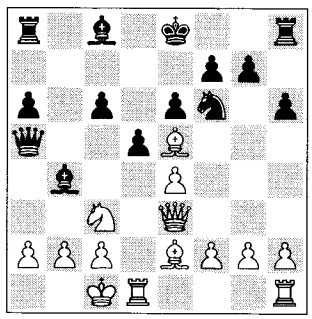
Again this move, which completes White's development and prepares ♕g3, and now:

A) The immediate **12...dxe4!?** has provoked White, so far, to sacrifice a pawn; White gets fairly strong, but not completely clear, compensation. **13.♕g3 ♘d5 14.♘xe4!** The most ambitious and the best, assuming the capture on a2 does not work, as seems to be the case. 14.♘xd5 is the usual move here: 14...cxd5 15.♔b1 ♗d7 16.f3 ♗b5 17.♖he1 ♗xe2 18.♖xe2 ♕b5 (Newman-Otenweller, cr 2000; 18...exf3 19.♕xf3⩲ was Zaragatski-Rau, Willingen jr 2003) and now 19.♖e3! exf3 20.♖xf3⩲. **14...♕xa2** 14...♘xf4 15.♕xf4 ♖a7 16.♘d6+!+−. **15.c4!** 15.♘d6+ ♗xd6 16.♗xd6 ♕a1+ 17.♔d2 ♕xb2 18.♗e5 ♕b4+ 19.c3 ♕b2+ 20.♔e1 ♖g8 21.c4 ♕b4+∞ (Simmelink-Shishkin, LSS 2007) is less clear, though it may be worth some research if 15.c4 is not convincing. **15...♕a1+** 15...♘xf4 16.♕xf4 ♕a5 17.♘d6+ ♗xd6 18.♕xd6 ♖a7 19.♗f3 f6 20.♗xc6+ ♔f7 21.♖he1± with a strong initiative. **16.♔c2 ♕a4+ 17.♔b1 ♘b4 18.♘c3 ♕c2+ 19.♔a1** So far the black queen

and knight have been really impressive, but now the attack goes up in smoke and White's counterattack begins: **19...a5 20.♖d2 ♕b3** 20...♕h7 21.♗f3 ♗e7 22.♘e4 0-0 23.♗d6+–; 20...♕g6 21.♕xg6 fxg6 22.♗e5±. **21.♗e3!** Giving the queen a path to c7. **21...♗d7 22.♔b1 a4 23.♕c7 ♖d8 24.♗b6+–**;

B) **12...♗b7!?** is an odd idea, as the bishop blocks the b-file and doesn't occupy a very active position. However, after many games where the black king was checkmated, there was someone, somewhere, who had the idea of castling queenside. Usually bizarre ideas are not correct, but so far this has given reasonable results. **13.♔b1** 13.♕g3!? 0-0-0 14.♔b1. **13...0-0-0 14.♗g3!** With the immediate threat 15.♕f4. **14...♘d7 15.♕f4 d4** 15...f6? 16.exd5 cxd5 17.♘xd5 ♗xd5 18.♖xd5 exd5 19.♗xa6+ is a hot finish. **16.♗c4±** Freeing the square for the knight and hitting e6. **16...dxc3?? 17.♖xd7 ♔xd7 18.♕xf7+–**;

C) **12...♗b4 13.♗e5!** and now:

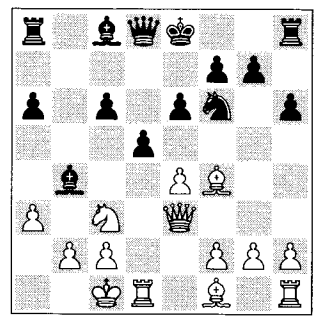


C1) Again, we must consider **13...dxe4** but here 14.♕g3! looks very strong: 14...♗xc3 15.♗c7!? (15.♗xc3 is enough to get a favourable ending) 15...♗xb2+ 16.♔xb2 ♕b4+ 17.♔a1 ♘d5 18.♕xg7 ♕f8 19.♕d4 ♗d7 20.♗g3± Ponomariov-Bu Xiangzhi, Lausanne 2001. In spite of the extra pawn, Black is in serious trouble, because his king lacks a safe refuge and White's dark-squared bishop dominates the board;

C2) **13...♗e7** looks the best move here, which is enough reason for its having been played before: 14.exd5 cxd5 15.♕g3 0-0 16.♖d4± Antal-Magyar, Zalakaros 2001. White has a promising piece disposition, but it is true that by relinquishing the centre the first player has assumed certain risks and is now forced to play concretely and accurately;

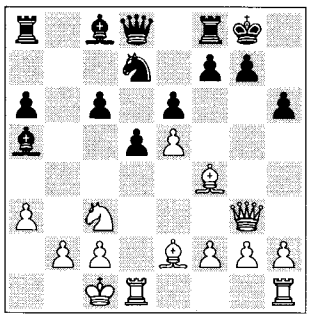
C3) **13...♗xc3** 14.♗xc3 ♕xa2 15.♗d3! (preparing the strong threat 16.♕g3, which highlights Black's vulnerability on the dark squares) 15...dxe4 (15...♕a4?! 16.♕g3! ♘xe4 17.♗xe4 ♕xe4 Zawadzki-Y.Vovk, Warsaw rapid 2007, and now 18.♕d6!+–) 16.♕g3! exd3 17.♕xg7 ♖g8 18.♕xf6 d2+ (18...♕a1+ 19.♔d2 ♕a4 20.♔e3!±) 19.♔xd2 ♕d5+ 20.♔c1 ♕g5+ 21.♕xg5 hxg5 22.♗f6 ♗b7 23.h4± Balashov-Makarov, Smolensk tt 2000.

O 11...♗b4 In principle this is more active than the main line, but if the threat on e4 is illusory, then it isn't very useful after all. **12.a3!** This logical move forces events. Now we have reached a position similar to the main game.



A) **12...♗xc3** Critical, but Black needs an improvement in this line. 13.♕xc3 ♘xe4 14.♕xg7 ♕f6 15.♕xf6 ♘xf6 and White has the bishop pair and a more flexible structure, although Black has scored well in this endgame. Let's see: 16.♗e5! ♔e7 17.g4 (17.♖d4!?) 17...♖g8 18.f3 a5 19.h4 h5 (Baklan-Cvek, Austria tt 2007/08) and now: 20.g5 ♘d7 21.♗g3 ♗a6 22.♗g2 e5 23.♖he1 f6 24.f4 e4 25.♗xe4! dxe4 26.♖xe4+ ♔d8 27.♗e1±;

B) **12...♗a5** From this spot the bishop may be transferred to c7, with pressure on White's future e5 pawn, but Black's castled position becomes dangerously unprotected: **13.♗e2!** Intending 14.♕g3. **13...0-0** 13...♗b7 14.♕g3± **14.e5** ♘**d7** **15.♕g3** and now:



B1) **15...♗c7** 16.♔b1! (preventing ...f6) 16...♗b8. This position has arisen in just two games, with two victories for Black; still, the clumsy position of the black pieces is suspicious. White must be better, e.g.: 17.♗d3 (17.h4!?) 17...♔h8 (17...f6? 18.♕g6+−) 18.♕h3 f5 19.♖he1± followed by g2-g4;

B2) **15...♔h8** 16.♕h3 ♔g8 (16...f6 forces White to prove the strength of his threat: 17.♗xh6! ♘xe5 and now 18.♗e3+! ♔g8 19.f4 (19.♗c5!? ♖f7 20.♕e3) 19...♗xc3 20.bxc3 ♘f7 21.♗d3, with a strong attack) 17.♖he1! (getting ready to overprotect the e5 pawn, before transferring the rook along the third rank. The immediate 17.♖d3 is not so clear after 17...♗c7! 18.♖g3 ♘xe5 19.♕xh6 ♘g6∞) 17...♗c7 18.♗f1.

C) **12...♗e7** 13.♗e2 (again, intending 14.♕g3) 13...0-0 14.♕g3 (14.h4!? ♗b7 15.♖h3 c5 16.♗xh6± Belikov-Babaev, Alushta 2004) 14...♔h8 15.♗e5 (15.e5!?) 15...♗d7 16.exd5 cxd5 17.♖d4 ♘e8 18.♗d3 ♖c8 19.♖e1. All the white pieces are aiming at the enemy castled position, though in a seemingly artificial fashion: 19...♖xc3?! (19...♕a5∞) 20.bxc3 ♗xa3+ 21.♔d1 ♗e7 22.♖e3 (White continues transferring pieces) 22...♕b6 23.♖g4 ♖g8 24.♖g6 (24.♕f4!) 24...♗f6 25.♖xf6 gxf6 26.♕h4 ♖g7 27.♕xh6+ ♔g8 28.♖h3+− Fedorchuk-Vuckovic, Calicut Wch-jr 1998.

12.♗e2 0-0

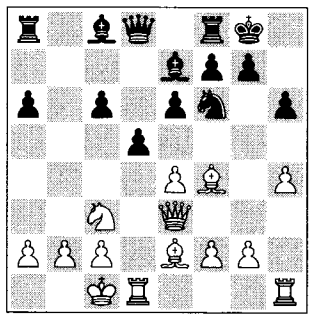
Providing a shelter for the king before moving freely the central or queenside pawns is a respectable option, but its drawback is that it allows a direct attack on the castled position. Other possibilities:

O 12...♗b7 13.♕g3 (the key move in this variation) 13...g6 14.♗c7! ♕c8 15.♗f3 0-0 16.♘a4 ♘d7 17.♔b1 a5 18.c4± (Schekachev-Pochikeev, Smolensk 1997) and White dominates the whole board.

O 12...♘d7, intending 13...♗g5, has been played quite a lot, but the results are terrible: 13.h4 ♗b7 (13...0-0 transposes to 12...0-0) 14.♕g3 ♔f8

15.♔b1 ♗f6 16.♗c7 ♕e8 17.f4± with a strong attack, Kudrin-Finegold, San Diego ch-USA 2006.

13.h4



This is a multi-purpose move: it not only prepares an eventual transfer of the rook along the third rank and a g2-g4-g5 break, but also toys with a sacrifice on h6. Black has tried many defences, but so far the second player is suffering.

13...♖e8

O 13...♘e8 14.♔b1 ♘d6 15.♗d3 ♖e8 16.♕g3 ♔h8 17.♗e5 ♗f8 18.♖he1± with an excellent attacking position, Schekachev-Lopushnoy, Tomsk 1998;

O 13...♗b4 14.e5 ♗xc3 15.♕xc3 ♘e4 16.♕e3 f6 17.f3 fxe5 18.♗xe5 ♘f6 19.g4± with a very straightforward attack, Gofshtein-Khasin, Rishon-le-Zion 1997/98;

O 13...♘d7 14.♕g3 ♔h8 15.♗c7 ♕e8 16.♖he1 ♗b7 17.♗h5 ♕c8 18.♗d6 ♗xd6 19.♕xd6 ♘f6 20.♗f3 ♖d8 21.♕f4 ♔g8 22.g4± again, with an excellent attack, Bluvshtein-Krush, New York 2003;

O 13...♕a5 14.♗xh6! gxh6 (14...♘xe4 15.♘xe4 dxe4 16.♕g3 ♗f6 17.♔b1±) 15.♕xh6 ♘h7 (Pfrommer-Oud, Bad Wörishofen 2003) 16.♖h3! ♔h8 17.exd5 cxd5 18.♖g3 ♖g8 19.♗d3 f5 20.♖xg8+ ♔xg8 21.♕g6+ ♔h8 22.♗xf5 exf5 23.♕c6 ♗a3 24.♕xa8 ♕xc3 25.♕b8 ♘f6 26.bxa3 ♕xa3+ 27.♕b2±.

14.♕g3

14.g4 leads to a very promising attack too, e.g.: 14...♘d7 15.♕g3 e5 16.♗d2 ♘c5 17.g5 d4 18.gxh6 ♗f6 19.hxg7 dxc3 20.♗xc3 ♕e7 21.♕e3 ♔h7 22.♗d2 ♗xg7 23.♖dg1 ♕f8 24.♖xg7+ ♕xg7 25.♕xc5+– Ziatdinov-Zabotin, Vladimir 2008.

14...♔h8 15.♗c7!

With this thematic move, a trademark in this variation, the bishop displaces the enemy queen before occupying the aggressive spot e5.

15...♕d7 16.♗e5 ♗f8

Trying to improve on one of the first games in this line; in practice, as we will see, the improvement is successful. Black had played 16...♖a7 17.f4 ♖g8 18.♕f2 ♗b4 19.♗f3 ♕e7 20.♖he1 ♖d7 21.exd5 cxd5 22.g4± Botvinnik-Kaz, Israel 1997.

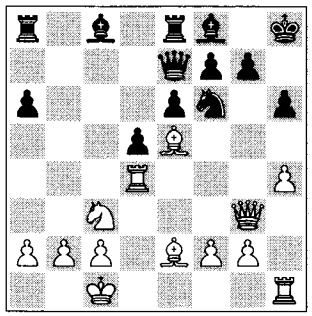
17.exd5⇄

Probably it is not a good idea to open lines before we see Black's reply to the strong blow 17.♕f4! with a threat on f6, and more especially, preparing the thematic push g2-g4-g5; e.g.: 17...♘g8 (17...♕e7 18.g4± Ragger-Ernst, Oberwart 2007) 18.♗h5! ♖a7 19.g4±.

17...cxd5 18.♖d4

Still good was 18.♕f4 ♗b7 19.g4!±.

18...♕e7



19.♗d3?!

It is clear that Fressinet didn't want to play ♕f4, still a strong move which would offer him the advantage.

19...♘d7!

Since White has missed the strongest move, Black, on his part, prepares to push his centre by means of ...f6 and ...e5 to expel one enemy bishop, and to play ...♘c5xd3 to eliminate the other.

20.f4 ♗b7

20...♘c5!?.

21.♕g4?!

White continues going astray and his attack is gradually diluting; in the end, Black's better structure will prevail. 21.♖e1!?.

21...♘c5 22.♘a4

White starts playing only moves, as Black was threatening 22...f6.

22...♘xd3+ 23.♖xd3 f6 24.♗d4 ♕b4?!

24...e5!? would be the logical culmination of Black's strategy: 25.♗c5 ♕c7∓.

25.♘b6 ♖ad8 26.a3 ♕d6 27.♖c3?

Allowing 27...e5 again; this time the consequences are terrible. 27.♖e1! was required and if 27...e5?! 28.fxe5 fxe5 29.♖de3 e4 30.♖f1±.

27...e5! 28.♗c5 ♕xc5!

It looks unlikely, but White must have missed this move.

29.♖xc5 ♗xc5 30.♘a4 ♗e3+ 31.♔b1 ♗xf4

A rook, a minor piece and a pawn is enough material compensation for the queen, but the strong pawn centre, the powerful bishops and the organized rooks constitute an unstoppable army.

32.♘c5 ♗c8 33.♕e2 e4 34.♖d1 d4 35.g4

35.h5 ♗g5∓.

35...e3⇄

35...♖e5!?∓.

36.♘d3?∓

36.♘b3!? ♗g3 37.♖xd4 ♖xd4 38.♘xd4 ♗xh4∓.

36...♗g3 37.♖h1

The impulsive 37.g5 may be met by 37...♗xh4 38.gxh6 gxh6 39.♕h5 ♗g5∓.

37...♗b7−+ 38.♖h3 ♗d6 39.g5 ♗e4

39...f5!?.

40.gxf6 gxf6 41.♖f3??

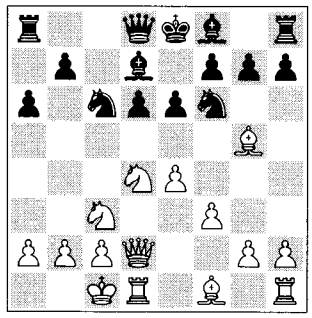
This move is hard to understand, but White's position was already difficult. ≥ 41.♘e1!.

41...♗xf3 42.♕xf3 ♖e6 43.♕g4 ♖de8 44.♕g6 ♗f8 0-1

Game 17.05

De La Villa Garcia,Jesus
Estremera Panos,Sergio
Zamora ch-ESP 1996

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 ♘c6 6.♗g5 e6 7.♕d2 a6 8.0-0-0 ♗d7 9.f3



This is my recommendation. First, because this is the most consistent with the rest of the lines recommended in this book. Second, because White scores far better than with the alternative 9.f4 (57% against 51%). In the excellent book on the Richter-Rauzer written by Wells & Osnos, the authors stress the success and the ignorance of this variation before 1995. A lot of water has passed under the bridge since then, and the popularity of 9.f3 has skyrocketed, but the results are still good.

In my view, one of the reasons is that White's plan is simple and dangerous: just to push the kingside pawns and crush the future black castled position, or trap Black's king in the centre. Due to the different black strategies set to cope with this plan, White is forced to vary the execution, but the thematic manoeuvres are just a few and their versatility has been proved for a long time. When examining these games, we are going to meet them again and again, but it is worth mentioning some of these themes as an introduction:

- Retreating the bishop to e3 in order to prepare g4-g5,
- Trading knights on c6 (when Black can't recapture with a pawn) followed by the transfer of the other knight to d4;
- Developing the bishop on d3 to meet ...♘e5 and still have the c4-square protected if the white knight is driven from c3 to e2;
- Closing (with e4-e5) or opening the centre (with exd5) as a suitable reaction to any ...d5;
- The grip on the d5-square (if Black plays ...e5), with an efficient support from the g5 bishop,
- And sometimes, the exchange on f6 to double pawns, take on d6 or simply speed up g4-g5.

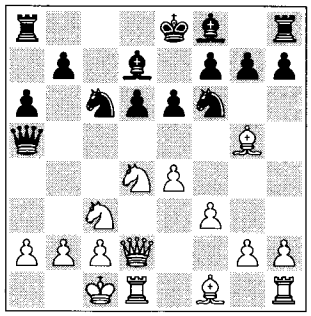
The lines we are going to study in this game spring from this position and in general ...h6 is never a transposition, but Black plays it with a specific goal in mind. Many lines are internal transpositions, so the most important thing is not the correct order; instead, we must assimilate the thematic ideas and be ready to apply them when the moment comes.

9...♗e7

We take this move as the main line, because Black plays it sooner or later and it is easy to see the transpositions; however, it is not better or worse than some other alternatives:

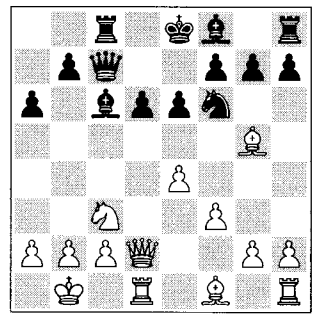
9...♕a5?!

David Garcia Ilundain often experimented with this idea, but the queen move doesn't look flexible.



10.h4 This protects the bishop; the alternative, very interesting, is 10.♗e3. **10...♖c8** 10...b5 11.♔b1 ♘e5 is the other standard way of playing, but the queen doesn't help much here on a5 either: 12.♗d3! (the natural reaction against ...♘e5, as it allows the knight to retreat to e2 without leaving the c4-square unprotected) 12...♗e7 13.g4 ♖b8 14.♗e3 (giving way to the g-pawn) 14...b4 15.♘ce2 d5?! (this is hasty, but otherwise g4-g5 is coming) 16.g5 dxe4 (16...♘h5 17.exd5 ♕xd5 18.♗e4±) 17.gxf6 exd3 18.fxe7 dxe2 19.♘xe2± Rodriguez-Garcia Ilundain, Castellon 1995. **11.♔b1 ♘xd4 12.♕xd4 ♗e7 13.g4 0-0 14.♕d2!** With the threat ♘d5!. **14...♕c5 15.h5 b5 16.♗e3 ♕c7 17.g5** The white pawns win the race to the enemy castled position. **17...b4 18.♘e2 ♘e8 19.♘d4 a5 20.g6** (... f5,) **20...♗f6!** (20...fxg6 21.hxg6 hxg6 22.♗h3±) **21.♗h3** (21.♘b5!?±) **21...♕c4 22.♕h2 a4 23.♗f1 ♕c7** (Sutovsky-Tratar, Portoroz 1997) and now **24.h6!** offers White a decisive attack.

❍ 9...♕c7 10.♔b1 An almost automatic move in this variation. White tucks his king out of harm's way and leaves the opponent to show his intentions first. **10...♖c8** Not very logical, as the potential displayed along the c-file is almost pointless. 10...♗e7 transposes to 9...♗e7; 10...b5 is too provocative, as the circumstances are ideal for the sacrifice of the minor piece for three pawns: 11.♗xb5 axb5 12.♘dxb5 ♕b8 13.♘xd6+ ♗xd6 14.♕xd6 ♕xd6 15.♖xd6±. **11.♘xc6** 11.h4 is of course the move that fits in with our plan and can't be bad, but we need concrete examples. **11...♗xc6**



12.♗xf6! We should always be ready to switch to this structure in favourable circumstances. **12...gxf6 13.♗d3 h5 14.♖he1 ♕a5 15.♗c4!±** Leko-Piket, Tilburg 1996. The white bishop occupies an excellent diagonal and the black king is stuck in the centre; plans with f4-f5 or ♘d5 are on the agenda.

❍ 9...♖c8 A transposition to 9...♗e7 is almost inevitable, as after 10.♔b1 other moves make little sense, for example: 10...♘e5?! (10...♗e7 transposes; 10...b5 11.♘xc6 ♗xc6 12.♘e2±) 11.f4 ♘c4?! 12.♗xc4 ♖xc4 13.e5+−.

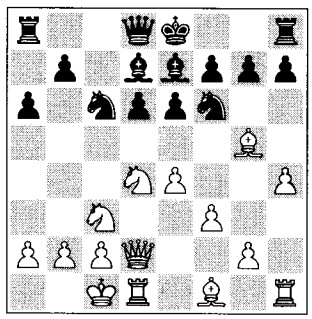
❍ 9...♘xd4 This move, which forces the recapture with the queen, is not bad in itself, but doesn't look very logical after 8...♗d7, as this exchange is normally combined with ...e5 and ...♗e6. **10.♕xd4 ♗e7 11.h4 b5 12.g4 ♗c6 13.♗e3 0-0** And we have almost reached a position in the English Attack (which we'll see in the corresponding chapter), but the black bishop is on c6

instead of being on b7, which is no big deal. **14.g5 ♘d7 15.♕d2!?** To take maximum advantage of placing the knight on d4. The move proposed in my book *El Ataque Inglés*, 15.♔b1, must be good too. **15...♘e5** 15...b4 16.♘e2 d5 17.♘d4 ♗b7 and here, compared with the game Short-Ljubojevic in *El Ataque Inglés* (there is a black pawn on b5), both ♗h3 and h4-h5 must be good. **16.f4! ♘c4 17.♗xc4 bxc4 18.h5±** with a strong attack, Gipslis-Martinovic, Vrnjacka Banja 1975.

O 9...b5 10.♔b1 and again this normally transposes to ...♗e7 or ...h6, e.g.: 10...♘a5 (10...♘e5 11.f4!) 11.♗d3 ♘c4 12.♗xc4 bxc4 13.f4 h6 14.♗h4 ♖b8 15.♔a1 ♕b6 16.♖b1±. White's castled position is a fortress, Speelman-Cardon, Holland 1990.

10.h4

By defending the bishop, this move rules out some tricks, which makes it the most popular here.

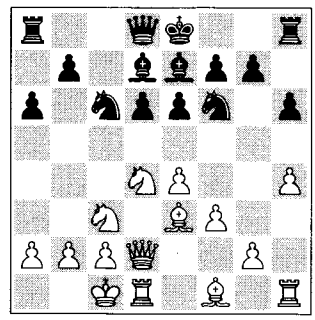


10...♖c8

The black rook declares its intentions, that is, placing a knight on c4, but the problem is a certain lack of flexibility: ...0-0-0 is now out of the question and in some lines the a6 pawn is left unprotected after the inevitable ...b5-b4. Actually, Black has tried virtually all logical moves in this position and we have to look at all of them:

O 10...h5 is a weaker version of 10...h6 11.♗e3 h5 (a sequence we will see in the next paragraph), since after ...h5 the bishop is extremely well placed on g5: **11.♔b1 b5 12.♘xc6 ♗xc6 13.♘e2** A thematic manoeuvre, but we should wonder whether ♗d3 would be a better order. **13...♗b7 14.♘d4 ♕b6 15.♗d3 ♔f8 16.♘b3±** Lanka-Redmann, Hamburg 2001.

O 10...h6 would normally be a transposition to the lines studied in the previous game, but recently black players have come up with an idea that justifies its inclusion at this moment. **11.♗e3**



11...h5!? A very interesting idea which is gaining supporters and which radically changes the strategic map. The white kingside pawns are paralysed and the break g2-g4 is very difficult to carry out. The dark sides of this idea are important too: the white bishop stands firm on g5, (we recommend that it immediately returns there), ...0-0 is difficult to play, and f3-f4 eventually followed by e4-e5 or f4-f5 is strengthened. **12.♗g5** Moving the bishop immediately back to its place is my recommendation; however, 12.♔b1 may transpose and 12.♘xc6 followed by ♗g5 rules out one

of Black's possible plans, so both are worth considering. **12...♘e5** has become Black's favourite move, as his position could be totally dry without this knight. 12...♕c7 13.♘xc6! (I think that removing this knight right away is the most precise) 13...♗xc6 14.♔b1 b5 15.♗d3 b4 16.♘e2 ♕b6 17.♖he1 a5 18.♗c4 ♖c8 19.b3 ♗b5 20.♗xb5+ ♕xb5 21.♘f4 a4 22.♖e3± e5?! (Black is suffering the consequences of being unable to castle) 23.♘d3 0-0 24.♕xb4 ♕c6 25.♕d2± Short-Murariu, Bazna 2008. **13.♔b1 b5 14.♗d3 b4** 14...♕b6 15.♘ce2! and usually 15...b4 leads to a transposition, though this is not forced. **15.♘ce2 ♕b6 16.♕e3** 16.♖he1 a5↑. **16...♕b7 17.♘g3 a5 18.♕e2** If White doesn't play 18.f4!? he probably fears 18...♘eg4 but after 19.♕e2± followed by e4-e5, White's initiative is promising. **18...♘xd3 19.♖xd3 ♗b5 20.♘xb5 ♕xb5 21.f4 ♖b8 22.♖e1 g6 23.♕d2 ♖d8 24.e5 dxe5 25.♖xd8+ ♗xd8 26.♘e4 1-0** Berelovich-Decoster, Netherlands tt 2007/08.

○ 10...0-0?! To fix the king's position in front of White's avalanche is too dangerous. **11.g4 ♖c8** 11...♘xd4 12.♕xd4 b5 13.♗e3 ♕a5 14.♔b1 b4 15.♘e2 e5 16.♕b6!± Gaponenko-Boidman, Trier 2002. **12.♔b1 b5 13.♗e3 ♘e5 14.♗d3 ♘c4 15.♗xc4 ♖xc4 16.h5** and White's attack is rolling, Korneev-Scherbakov, Novgorod 1995.

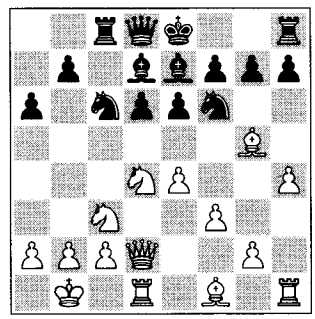
○ 10...♕c7 Slightly more flexible than the move played in the game, as it keeps open the possibility of ...0-0-0. **11.♔b1 ♘xd4** If 11...b5 the reply 12.♗xb5!± is annoying. **12.♕xd4 b5 13.g4 ♖b8 14.♗xf6!?** Once again this plan, which apparently is to Bologan's taste. Black has neither a knight nor any chance to castle kingside. The games played so far show that White has the better chances, for example: **14...gxf6 15.♘e2 ♕c5 16.♕d2 b4 17.♘g3 a5 18.b3! ♖c8 19.♗c4±** Bologan-Van der Wiel, Wijk aan Zee B 1997.

○ 10...♘xd4 has been played a lot but, as we have already said, this doesn't combine well with ...♗d7: **11.♕xd4 b5 12.♔b1 ♖b8 13.g4 b4 14.♘e2 ♕a5 15.♗e3** Of course, Bologan's plan 15.♗xf6 is playable here too: 15...gxf6 16.♘g3±. **15...e5 16.♕d2 ♗e6 17.♘c1 0-0 18.g5 ♘h5 19.♗h3±** De La Riva Aguado-Abreu Delgado, Havana 1998.

○ 10...b5 11.♔b1 My recommendation, and the most typical and flexible move here. The alternative 11.♘xc6 followed by ♘e2 has given White very good results. **11...♘e5 12.♗d3 0-0 13.g4 ♖b8 14.♗e3!** It is time to open the way for the pawns. **14...♕c7 15.h5 ♖fc8 16.g5 ♘e8** (Am.Rodriguez-Short, Lucerne Wch-tt 1997) and now, apart from the interesting move chosen in the game, 17.♖dg1, other moves like 17.f4 and 17.g6 offer good attacking chances.

11.♔b1

This is not necessary yet, and therefore other moves such as 11.g4 are possible. However, it is unlikely that White can do without this move for long, so for flexibility reasons, this is a very clear option now.



11...b5!?

Again, the most flexible move, but here Black has tried all alternatives and some of them, such as those intending to lead the knight to c4, seem to fit well with 10...♖c8.

O 11...♘e5 is logical, but White is not forced to play 12.♗d3 yet and therefore, after 12.g4 b5, play leads to the main game.

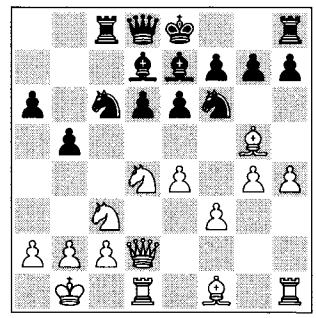
O 11...♘a5 hasn't been widely played, and White hasn't applied the same plan as with the enemy knight on e5, which is what we recommend here: 12.g4 b5 13.♗d3±.

O 11...h5 leads to similar play as 10...h5 and it is somewhat weaker than the move presented in the next paragraph.

O 11...h6 12.♗e3 h5 is a less flexible version (because the rook has already defined its position on c8) of the idea 11...h5 that was mentioned among the alternatives to the previous move. Again, I think that the best is: 13.♘xc6 ♗xc6 14.♗g5 ♕c7 (intending 15...d5, which would be met now by e4-e5) 15.♗d3 d5 16.exd5 ♘xd5 (Movsesian-Kozul, Sarajevo 2005) and now 17.♘xd5! ♗xd5 18.c4 ♗c6 19.♖he1±.

O 11...0-0 has enjoyed a certain success, though I always distrust the premature placing of the king: 12.g4 b5 13.♗e3 ♘xd4 (13...♘e5 14.a3!) 14.♕xd4 ♗c6 15.g5 ♘d7 16.h5! (this pawn sacrifice opens the way for a very strong initiative for White) 16...♗xg5 (16...b4!?; 16...♘e5?! 17.h6!±) 17.♗xg5 ♕xg5 18.h6 ♘e5 19.hxg7 ♕xg7 20.♗e2 ♖fd8 21.a3±. The rooks have very clear targets on the right side of the board, Magem Badals-Campos, Manresa 1997.

12.g4



12...♘e5

Completing the logical plan started by ...♗d7. Black threatens 13...b4 followed by ...♘c4.

Another, less orthodox idea has been tested as well: **12...h5!?** Disrupting the organized march of the white pawns, but the black king will no longer have a safe refuge: 13.gxh5 ♘xh5 (13...♖xh5 14.♗xb5?! – a bit violent, better 14.♖g1!± – 14...axb5 15.♘dxb5 ♘e5 16.♘xd6+ ♗xd6 17.♕xd6 ♘c4 18.♕d4 e5∞ Yaremko-A.Vovk, Lvov ch-UKR jr 2006) 14.♖g1 g6 15.♘xc6 ♖xc6 (15...♗xc6 16.♗xe7 ♔xe7 17.♗d3±) 16.♗d3 b4 17.♘e2 ♕b6 18.♗xe7 ♔xe7 19.e5!± Ibarra Jerez-D'Costa, Peñiscola jr 2002.

13.♗d3 b4

13...h5 14.gxh5 ♖xh5 15.f4 ♘xd3 16.cxd3 (16.♕xd3!? b4 17.♘ce2↑) 16...b4 17.♘ce2 ♕b6 18.♘f3 b3 19.axb3 ♕xb3∞ Del Rio Angelis-Romieux, Metz 2006.

14.♘ce2 a5

Black keeps on moving forward in the most logical way. Other alternatives: **14...d5?** 15.♗xf6!; **14...♘xd3** strength-

ens the white centre: 15.cxd3 ♕b6 16.♗e3 ♕b7 17.h5; **14...♘c4?!** 15.♕xb4.

15.♗e3 ♕c7

15...d5? 16.g5! dxe4? 17.gxf6 exd3 18.fxe7+−.

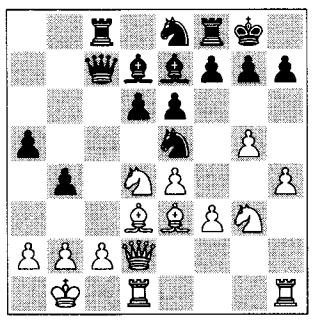
16.♘g3!

Here the important thing is to prevent the blockade of the white pawns; to achieve this goal, this move seems to work tactically. 16.g5 ♘h5∞.

16...0-0

16...d5?!, trying to exploit the unprotected situation of the g3 knight, fails to 17.g5 ♘xe4 (17...♘xd3 18.cxd3 ♕xg3 19.♗f4+−; 17...dxe4 18.gxf6 exd3 19.fxe7+−) 18.fxe4 ♘xd3 19.cxd3 ♕xg3 20.♗f4 ♕g4 21.♖dg1 ♕h5 22.exd5 exd5 23.♖e1⩲.

17.g5 ♘e8



18.f4!

This pawn runs, gaining time to break Black's castled position on f6.

18...♘c4

18...♘xd3 19.cxd3 leads to a similar position, but here the e4 pawn is protected and Black has fewer breaking points.

19.♗xc4 ♕xc4 20.f5 a4

20...e5 21.f6! gxf6 22.♘df5 with a strong attack.

21.f6!

This is the most damaging break for Black's castled position. White's initiative is really strong and, from the point of view of the opening, the results can be regarded as satisfactory for the first player, though Black still has plenty of resources, as the game shows.

21...gxf6 22.gxf6?!

22.♘h5! is far stronger, and now 22...f5 (22...a3 23.gxf6 ♗xf6 24.♘xf6+ ♘xf6 25.♗h6+−; 22...e5!? 23.gxf6 ♘xf6 24.♘xf6+ ♗xf6 25.♖dg1+ ♔h8 26.♗g5+−; 22...♔h8!? 23.♕f2⩲) 23.♖hg1 fxe4 (23...♔h8 24.♘xf5 exf5 25.♗d4+ f6 26.gxf6 ♘xf6 27.♕h6+−) 24.♘f6+ ♗xf6 25.gxf6+ ♔h8 26.♗h6+−.

22...♗xf6 23.♘h5 ♗e5 24.♘f3! b3! 25.♘xe5! bxc2+ 26.♔a1 cxd1♕+ 27.♖xd1 dxe5

27...♕b5? 28.♗d4! dxe5 29.♘f6+! ♔h8 30.♕h6 ♘xf6 31.♕xf6+ ♔g8 32.♖g1#.

28.♗h6

28.♗c5!? ♕xc5 29.♘f6+ ♘xf6 30.♕g5+ ♔h8 31.♕xf6+=.

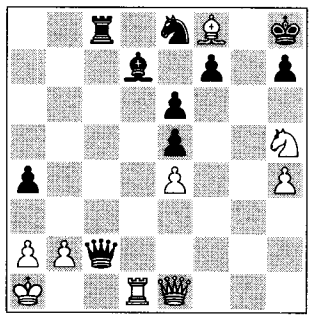
28...♔h8

28...f6?? 29.♕g2+! ♔f7 30.♖xd7#.

29.♗xf8

29.♖g1 ♕c5 30.♕g5 ♕xg1+ 31.♕xg1 ♖g8∓.

29...♕c2! 30.♕e1



30...a3?!

30...♗c6 31.♕g1 ♗xe4 32.♗g7+ ♔g8 33.♗xe5+ ♗g6 (33...♗g2 34.♘f4±; 33...♕g2 34.♕xg2+ ♗xg2 35.♖g1 ♔f8 36.♗c3±) 34.♘f4 f6∓.

31.♗xa3 ♗a4 32.♖b1 ♗b5! 33.b3 ♕c3+ 34.♕xc3 ♖xc3 35.♗b2± ♖f3 36.♗xe5+

36.a4 ♗c6 37.♖c1 ♗b7 38.♖d1 ♗c6 39.♖d8 f6 40.♘xf6! ♖xf6 41.♗xe5 ♔g7±.

36...f6 37.♗b8! ♔g8 38.♖g1+ ♔f7 39.♖g3 ♖f1+ 40.♔b2 e5 41.♖c3 ♖f2+!± 42.♔a3 ♖h2 43.♘g3 ♖xh4?

43...♗d7!.

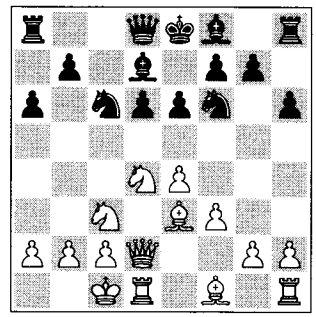
44.♔b4!+– ♗a6 45.♔a5 ♗b7 46.♔b6 ♗a8 47.♔a7 ♗xe4 48.♖c4! f5 49.♘xf5 ♖f4 50.♗xe5 ♖xf5 51.♖xe4 ♔e6 52.♗b8+! ♔d7 53.a4 ♖f7 54.b4 ♘f6 55.♖f4 ♔c8+ 56.♔a8 ♔d7 57.♗e5 1-0

Game 17.06

Vallejo Pons,Francisco
Caruana,Fabiano
Wijk aan Zee B 2009

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 d6 6.♗g5 e6 7.♕d2 a6 8.0-0-0 ♗d7 9.f3 h6 10.♗e3

This is the position we are going to study in this game, but there are frequent transpositions with the previous one, which are difficult to systematize, so we must take them into account on every move.



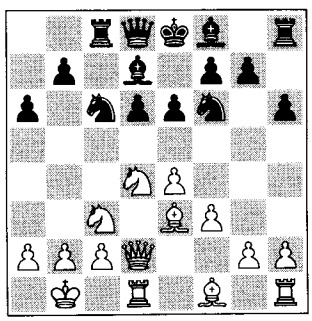
10...b5

Not just the most frequently-played move, but also the most convenient to pick as the main line, because it comfortably reflects all transpositions. It is difficult for Black to do without this, which is of course a preliminary move for an eventual ...b4, before or after the c6 knight is traded on d4 or jumps to e5. But other moves have been tried:

○ 10...♗e7 In this order, this is too slow, as 9...h6 has encouraged White's kingside assault. **11.g4!** From White's perspective, the good side of the early expulsion of the bishop is that this push is stronger. **11...b5** After 11...♖c8?!, there is no time for Black to oppose White's expansion: 12.h4! ♘xd4 13.♗xd4 e5 14.♗e3 ♕a5 15.♗h3! (White has saved on ♔b1 and is preparing g4-g5 without worrying about the threats to his castled position) 15...b5 16.g5 b4 17.♗xd7+ ♔xd7 18.♘b1!

hxg5 19.hxg5 ♘h5 20.a3 b3 21.♘c3!± De La Villa Garcia-Sanchez Guirado, Torrevieja ch-ESP 1997. **12.♔b1** 12.h4?! allows the typical reaction 12...♘xd4 13.♗xd4 b4 14.♘e2 e5 15.♗e3 ♕a5 16.♔b1 ♗e6 and Black manages to play ...d5 and seize the initiative. **12...♘xd4** 12...♘e5 meets the thematic 13.♗d3, intending h2-h4 and g4-g5. **13.♗xd4 b4** 13...♗c6. **14.♘e2 e5 15.♗e3 ♗e6** Apparently, in time to prepare ...d5, but White has a brilliant tactical resource: **16.♘g3 d5 17.♘h5! ♘xh5 18.exd5**±.

O 10...♖c8!? This doesn't look like a very flexible move, as Black says goodbye to castling queenside or using this rook on another file. Indeed, it lacks flexibility in the ...♘e5 plan, but it is rather suitable if Black intends to play ...♘xd4, ...e5, ...♗e6 and ...♕a5; this order has achieved good results. **11.♔b1** is often the best move, since it is useful in all variations and waits one more move for Black to commit himself (the immediate 11.g4 allows Black to carry out the following thematic manoeuvre: 11...♘xd4 12.♗xd4 e5 13.♗e3 ♕a5 14.♔b1 ♗e6 and it seems that Black has no problems: 15.♘d5 ♕xd2 16.♖xd2 ♘xd5 17.exd5 ♗d7= Van der Wiel-Bologan, Tilburg 1992). And now:



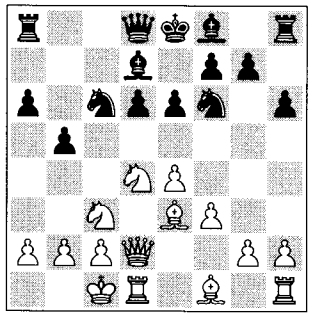
A) **11...♘e5?!** 12.g4 b5 13.♗d3 is a thematic path that favours White in this position;

B) **11...♗e7** (unnecessary in this plan) 12.g4 ♘xd4 13.♗xd4 e5 14.♗e3 ♕a5 (14...♗e6 15.♘d5! ♘xd5 16.exd5 ♗d7 17.h4± Milos-Ubilava, Elgoibar 1993) 15.h4 ♗e6 16.♗h3! and Black is almost forced to give up the exchange: 16...♖xc3 17.♕xc3 ♕xa2+ 18.♔c1 d5 19.♗c5 d4 20.♕a3 ♕xa3 21.♗xa3± Kosteniuk-Nijboer, Wijk aan Zee B 2005;

C) **11...♘xd4** 12.♗xd4 e5 13.♗e3 ♗e6 14.h4 ♕a5 15.g4 b5 16.a3! ♗e7 (16...♖xc3!? is thematic but does not give full compensation: 17.♕xc3 ♕xc3 18.bxc3 d5 19.a4 dxe4 20.axb5±) 17.♗e2 (intending g4-g5) 17...♘d7 18.♘d5± Marinkovic-Mijatovic, Belgrade 2004.

O 10...♘xd4 At this moment, this exchange is not very logical, as it is usually combined with ...e5 and ...♗e6 and here the bishop has already wasted one move. Besides, it doesn't have the 'excuse' of forcing White to recapture with the queen; even so, it is still playable. **11.♗xd4 e5?!** 11...b5 12.♔b1 transposes to 10...b5. **12.♗e3 ♗e6** and it is 'official' that Black has wasted one tempo in comparison with other Richter lines.

O 10...h5?! allows a transposition to other lines, studied in the previous game, where ...h5 is more frequent; this generally occurs when White has already played h2-h4, but here the first player has the extra possibility of playing something specifically oriented to exploit the drawbacks of ...h5, e.g.: **11.♔b1 ♕c7 12.♘xc6 ♗xc6 13.♘e2 d5 14.e5 ♘d7 15.f4**± Cheparinov-Al Modiahki, Sochi tt 2008.



11.♔b1!

This is my recommendation. White lets his opponent commit himself and, depending on Black's choice, the game will take very different paths. 11.♘xc6 is equally correct.

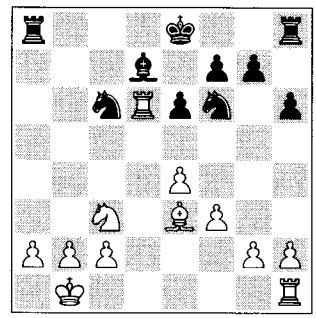
11...♘e5

Once Black has played ...b5, this plan is more justified than trading knights on d4, and the most flexible is to play it immediately, as the analysis of the alternatives shows:

O 11...♖c8 is an interesting attempt to play in the centre without wasting a move on ...♗e7: 12.g4 ♘e5 13.♗d3. This is the thematic move, keeping control of c4, but in my opinion 13.a3!? is justified here: 13...b4 14.♘ce2 d5 15.exd5 ♘xd5 16.♘f4 with attack, A.Toth-Abbasov, Budapest 1997.

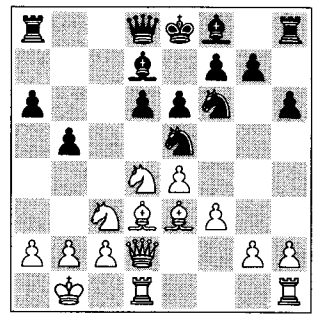
O 11...♘xd4?! combines better with a quick ...e5, but it is too late here: 12.♗xd4 b4 13.♘e2 e5 14.♗e3 ♕a5 (14...♗e6?! 15.♕xb4!±) 15.c4!± Lanka-Berthelot, Montpellier 1995.

O 11...♕c7?! allows a favourable version of the standard piece sacrifice for three pawns: 12.♗xb5! (12.g4 is of course possible) 12...axb5 13.♘dxb5 ♕b8 14.♘xd6+ ♗xd6 15.♕xd6 ♕xd6 16.♖xd6±.



So far Black has always been able to hold this endgame, but with lots of suffering, for example: 16...♘a5 17.b3 ♖c8 18.♘e2 e5 19.♖hd1 ♗c6 20.c4 0-0 21.♘c3 ♖b8 22.♔c2 ♖fc8 23.♗a7 ♖a8 24.♗b6 ♘b7 25.♖6d2 ♗e8 26.♔b2 ♔f8 27.♗e3 ♔e7. The three pawns offer good winning chances, but White ran out of patience and played 28.♘d5+!? in Iordachescu-Baklan, Baile Tusnad tt 2005. 28.a4±, keeping the trio and making progress step by step, looks better.

12.♗d3



Again, keeping an eye on the c4-square, to allow the knight retreat to e2.

12...♕c7

O The main alternative is an immediate **12...b4!?** 13.♘ce2 d5 14.exd5 ♘xd5 15.♘f4 and the white pieces look menacing, but so far the practical examples are minimal and there is no definite evaluation: 15...♘xe3 (15...♘xf4

16.♗xf4 ♘xd3 17.♕xd3 ♗e7 is weaker, since after 18.♖he1 Black can't cope with the pressure of White's heavy pieces along the central files: 18...0-0 19.♘f5 exf5 20.♕xd7± Almasi-Templier, France tt 2005) 16.♕xe3 ♗d6 17.♗e4! (17.♘dxe6!? ♗xe6 18.♘xe6 fxe6 19.f4 ♘xd3 20.♕xd3! 0-0 21.♕xd6±; 17.♘fxe6? fxe6) 17...♖b8 18.♕e2 ♕b6 19.♘c6!±.

O 12...♘xd3 Illogical: this strengthens the enemy centre and opens the c-file for White's queenside operations. 13.cxd3 b4 14.♘ce2 e5 15.♘b3 (15.♘f5 d5!) 15...a5 16.d4± Iordachescu-Bagaturov, Enakievo 1997.

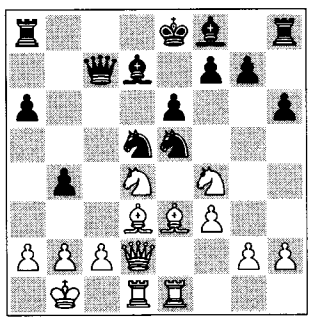
13.♖he1

The idea is to prevent the thematic central break. White calmly prepares his pawn assault on the enemy castled position. This seems to me more natural than the known plan, g2-g4.

13...♖b8!?

Probably the sharpest and subtlest option. Black 'acknowledges' that the straightforward plan consisting of ...b4 and ...d5 doesn't work and prepares an extra theme, ...♘c3+, which renews his strategic threat.

O 13...b4?!, opening the centre, looks premature, but deserves serious attention: 14.♘ce2 d5 15.exd5 ♘xd5 16.♘f4.



All the white pieces are gathering in front of the black king. 16...♘xe3 17.♕xe3 ♘xd3 and now:

A) 18.♖xd3?! ♖c8! and now the sacrifice just leads to a draw: 19.♘fxe6 ♗xe6 20.♘xe6 fxe6 21.♕xe6+ ♗e7 22.♕g6+ De La Villa Garcia-Perez Rodriguez, Sanxenxo 2006;

B) 18.♕xd3! is winning: 18...♗d6 19.♘dxe6 fxe6 (19...♗xe6 20.♘xe6 fxe6 21.♖xe6+ ♗e7 22.♖de1+−) 20.♘xe6 ♗xe6 21.♖xe6+.

O 13...♗e7!? closes the file once again and prepares ...b4: 14.g4 b4 15.♘ce2 d5 16.exd5 ♘xd5 17.♘f4 ♘f6?! (this makes White's task easier. Worse is 17...♘c4? 18.♗xc4 ♕xc4 19.♘f5!; but 17...♘xe3! is critical: 18.♕xe3 ♘xd3 19.♖xd3 0-0∞) 18.h4 ♘xd3 19.♕xd3 g5? (19...0-0? 20.g5+−; 19...♖c8 20.g5±) 20.hxg5 hxg5 21.♘fxe6 ♗xe6 22.♘xe6 fxe6 23.♕g6++− Volzhin-Gasimov, Linares Open 1997.

O 13...♘c4 14.♗xc4 ♕xc4. This produces a more typical attacking race: 15.g4 b4 16.♘ce2 a5 17.h4 g6 18.g5 hxg5 19.hxg5 ♘h5 (Del Pilar-Ashley, Philadelphia 1996), but now 20.♘b3! a4 21.♘c5 exposes the instability of Black's position.

14.f4!

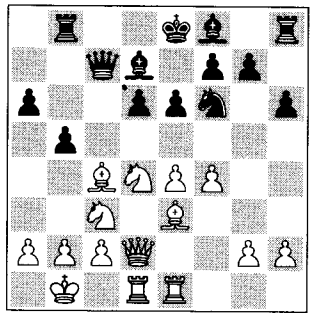
White chooses central play to clarify Black's intentions. Also interesting was 14.♔a1, preventing ...b4 and ...d5. By contrast, 14.g4?! allows Black to complete his plan: 14...b4! 15.♘ce2 d5 16.exd5 ♘xd5! (Fernandez Romero-Baklan, Lorca 2006), threatening ...c3 and seizing the initiative.

14...♘c4

14...♘xd3 will possibly be an emergency alternative, but in this position

White is happy to strengthen the centre with 15.cxd3±.

15.♗xc4



15...♕xc4?!

15...bxc4!? leads to a well-known structure, usually harmless for White as threats along the b-file can be countered with a few units, but in this case the double attack posed by ...♕b7 is not easy to counter: 16.♗f2 (16.♔a1?! ♕b7) 16...♕b7 17.b3 a5 18.e5↑.

16.b3 ♕c7 17.e5!

The central break is the logical culmination of the previous moves; now the game will be completely ruled by tactics, and it doesn't look as though that is going to favour Black.

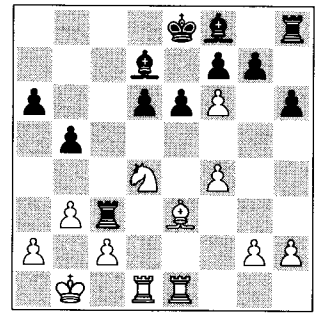
17...♖c8

17...b4 is the standard move to prevent the knight from jumping to e4, but after 18.exf6 bxc3 19.fxg7 ♗xg7 20.♕f2± it is clear that the black king is more exposed;
17...dxe5?! is even worse: 18.fxe5 ♘h7 19.♘e4 ♕b7 20.♗f4 ♗e7 21.♕f2 0-0 22.♕g3+–.

18.exf6

This leads to an endgame which is far more pleasant for White.

18...♕xc3 19.♕xc3 ♖xc3



20.♘f5!± gxf6 21.♘xd6+ ♗xd6 22.♖xd6 ♖c6 23.♖d3

With the simple threat of doubling along the d-file.

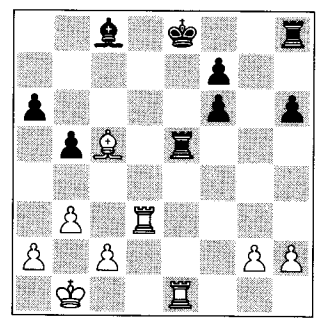
23...♗c8

23...♖c8! is the most resilient: 24.g4! ♗c6 25.♗d4 ♖g8 26.h3±.

24.♗d4 e5?!

24...♔e7 25.♗c3±.

25.fxe5+– ♖e6 26.♗c5 ♖xe5



27.♖ed1 ♖xc5 28.♖d8+ ♔e7 29.♖xh8 h5 30.♔b2 1-0

SUMMARY

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 ♘c6 6.♗g5 and now:

– 6...a6: solid, ends up in a transposition
– 6...h6: quite unknown, it has a certain sting ±
– 6...♕b6: tries to disturb, but it is not the most suitable moment ±
– 6...♕a5: similar to 6...h6. Quite unknown but poisonous ±
– 6...♗d7: the most popular alternative to ...e6, but theoretically not better than others ±

6...e6 7.♕d2 with several options:

– 7...h6: forces the game into a concrete structure, but not in the best conditions ±
– 7...♗e7 8.0-0-0 0-0: Black takes all challenges. Sound and ambitious ±/=
– 7...♗e7 8.0-0-0 a6: a very subtle order which looked refuted but is playable again ±

6...e6 7.♕d2 a6 8.0-0-0 and now:

– 8...h6: trendy for some time, questioned by 9.♘xc6 ±
– 8...♗d7 9.f3 ♕a5: doesn't fit well with ...♗d7 ±
– 8...♗d7 9.f3 ♘xd4: seems inconsistent with ...♗d7 too ±
– 8...♗d7 9.f3 ♖c8: more logical. Lots of counterplay, lots of fight, lots of pending research ±
– 8...♗d7 9.f3 ♗e7 10.h4 ♖c8: looks slow. White's attack is very strong ±
– 8...♗d7 9.f3 ♗e7 10.h4 h6 11.♗e3 h5!?: very positional idea. It needs more examples ±
– 8...♗d7 9.f3 b5: the most flexible line. Usually transposes to 9...h6 and the theoretical battle must continue ±/=

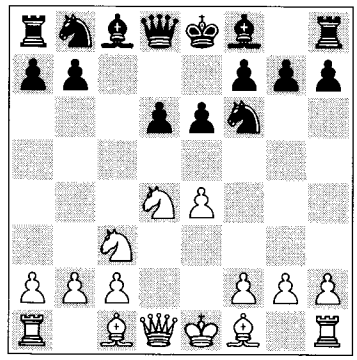
8...♗d7 9.f3 h6 10.♗e3

Usually a reflection of the variations without ...h6, and now:

– 10...♗e7: here it is slow, as g5 is an open breaking point ±
– 10...♘xd4: usually this exchange doesn't combine with ...♗d7, but it is solid ±
– 10...♖c8: interesting and little researched, but not the most flexible ±
– 10...b5 11.♔b1 ♘e5 12.♗d3 ♕c7: this is the critical variation. The theoretical battle goes on, but the plan 13.♖he1 looks really dangerous for Black ±/=

CHAPTER 18

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e6 Scheveningen Variation



Evaluation ****

Introduction and ideas

The Scheveningen Variation is obviously related to the Najdorf, which is nowadays the main Sicilian system, and which we will study in the next chapter. Probably the slight preference the Najdorf enjoys comes from two reasons: first, the Keres Attack 6.g4 against the Scheveningen, and second, Black keeps the possibility of playing ...e5, whereas he is unlikely to do without ...a6.

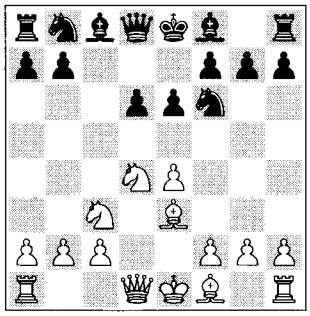
Our suggestion to fight both systems is the set-up with f2-f3 and 0-0-0, generally known as the English Attack. Both defensive systems are merged into one in this variation. In this chapter we will deal with those lines where Black plays ...e6, and in the next one we will study those lines where Black plays any other move, usually ...e5.

The most frequent ideas in the Scheveningen are the queenside minority attack and the pressure on the e4 pawn. By virtue of the set-up chosen by the first player, the pressure on e4 becomes less important; opposite castled positions or the black king stuck in the centre make Black's queenside play livelier. Besides, the freeing break ...d5, almost universally preceded by ...b4, is on Black's agenda, even though sometimes it opens lines on the black king, still in the centre. Both sides must also concern themselves with the manoeuvres carried out by one, or even the two knights, towards the c4-square.

Game 18.01

Socko,Bartosz
Gonzalez Garcia,Jose
Beijing rapid 2008

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e6 6.♗e3



Our starting position in this chapter. In this first game we are going to deal with those lines where Black delays ...a6 for a long time, and in the next games we will study the main theoretical current, which includes ...a6.

6...♘c6

6...♗e7 usually leads to the same positions, but in my view this order is less precise, as White can favourably switch to the Keres Attack by playing 7.g4. **7.f3** Virtually a transposition to the game, but let's see the independent moves: **7...0-0** 7...e5 8.♗b5+!±; 7...d5 8.♗b5+! ♗d7 9.e5±. **8.♕d2 d5** Despite losing a tempo, 8...e5 is not stupid, because Back has total flexibility to develop his army. My recommendation is the still unplayed 9.♘de2! (9.♘b3 ♗e6 10.0-0-0 a5 is the most popular line and leads to positions studied in the next chapter) 9...♗e6 (9...♘c6 10.g4 and Black has to forget about ...d5, and then the c6 knight is poorly placed; 9...♘bd7 10.g4 ♘b6 11.g5 ♘h5 12.♘g3 ♘f4 13.0-0-0 and the white attack can run easily, since 13...♗xg5 14.♘h5! is very favourable for White) 10.0-0-0± followed by g2-g4 and ♘g3. **9.e5 ♘fd7 10.f4 ♘c6 11.0-0-0±** with a typical French Defence structure, where White has a small edge due to the grip on d4, Ilincic-Bischoff, Prague 1989.

7.♕d2!

The most precise order. 7.f3 may lead to the same positions, but we must take into account two disturbing moves: 7...d5 and 7...♕b6.

7...♗e7

After this bishop move, the still premature knight jump to g4 becomes a threat.

7...♘g4?! 8.♗g5 ♗e7 (8...♕b6?! 9.♘db5!± a6? 10.♘a4+−) 9.♗xe7 ♕xe7 10.♘db5 (10.0-0-0!?) 10...d5?! (10...0-0 11.♗e2! ♘ge5 12.0-0-0 ♖d8 13.f4 ♘g6 14.♘xd6±) 11.♕e2! ♘f6 12.exd5+−.

8.f3 0-0

O The most natural move apart from **8...a6,** which occurs in the following games, but let's see the alternatives:

O 8...d5?! Premature. This leads to a position with an isolated d-pawn and few assets to offer compensation. 9.♗b5! ♗d7 10.exd5 exd5 (it doesn't look logical to trade pieces with an isolated pawn: 10...♘xd5 11.♘xd5 exd5 12.♘b3 a6 13.♗xc6 ♗xc6 14.0-0-0 0-0 15.♕a5± Cs.Horvath-Rossiter, Oakham 1988) 11.0-0-0 0-0 12.♘b3 a6 13.♗e2 ♗e6 14.g4± Milov-Zatulovskaya, Berlin 1994.

O 8...♗d7?! has occurred in several games, but is clearly bad in view of 9.♘db5!±.

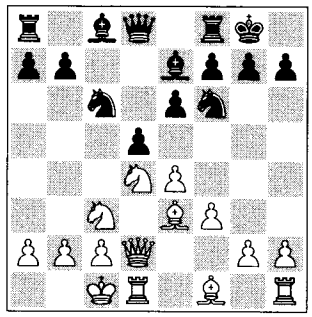
O 8...e5 is less justified now, as Black has already determined the position of his knight on c6: 9.♘de2 0-0 10.g4±.

9.0-0-0

Notice that 9.g4 doesn't prevent 9...d5! either, though it is true that this is lately White's choice. The reason why I don't

recommend this move is that I think that its assessment depends on small tactical details and varies every day. But it is natural to investigate this path.

9...d5!?



The main idea behind this move order. Black plays the thematic break before his opponent puts the screws on with g4. The fight to prove that White gets something from here is still open, but this variation will never be really popular, as White can choose simplifying lines which leave Black very few chances of active play. Alternatives:
9...a6 transposes to the next games; **9...♘xd4** 10.♕xd4 e5 11.♕d2 ♗e6 12.♔b1 a6 13.f4! ♘g4 14.f5± Garbisu de Goni-Cortes, Pamplona 1995.

10.exd5

Certainly not the most ambitious move, and moving quite far away from the ideal attacking system suggested in almost all the games presented in this book. In some ways, Black may be content to move White away from his primary plans, but at the expense of giving up part of his own ambitions too. So, I recommend this move for the sake of pragmatism: I reckon that White gets reasonable prospects for a slight edge and, right now, I don't trust the alternatives.

10.♕e1 is the most ambitious path and my former recommendation, but 10...e5! 11.♘xc6 bxc6 12.exd5 cxd5!, still with little practical experience, looks extremely dangerous to me, especially the variation 13.♗g5 ♗e6 14.♕xe5 (14.♗c4 ♗b4 15.♕xe5 ♗xc3 16.bxc3 ♘d7=) 14...♕a5 (14...♖b8!?, not tried yet, seems to me another dangerous option) 15.♘xd5! (15.♗c4? ♘d7! 16.♕g3 ♗xg5+ 17.♕xg5 h6∓ Zhang Pengxiang-Balogh, Taiyuan 2007) 15...♘xd5 16.♗xe7 ♖fc8 17.♗d3 ♕xa2 18.♗a3 a5 (18...♘c3!? 19.♖de1 ♖ab8∞) 19.♔d2 ♘b4 20.♗xb4 axb4 21.♖a1 ♕xa1 22.♖xa1 ♖xa1 23.f4∞ Pinol Fulgoni-Antal, Barcelona 2003.

10...♘xd5

Black is interested in trading some pieces and in not creating structural weaknesses. **10...exd5?!** 11.g4!± exposes the problem for Black to find comfortable moves for his pieces.

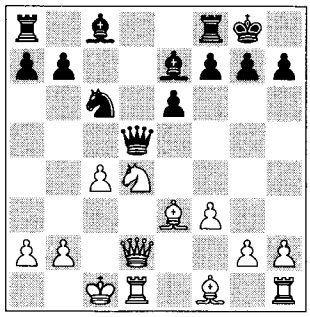
11.♘xd5 ♕xd5

11...exd5 is a little sounder than on the previous move, but 12.♔b1 (and also 12.♗b5±) must be enough for at least a light pressure: 12...♖e8 13.♗b5 ♗d7 14.♘b3!± Am.Rodriguez-I.Sokolov, Pancevo 1987.

12.c4

We will see if the 'hypersolid' approach poses real problems for Black: **12.♔b1!?** ♘xd4 (12...♖d8 13.♘xc6! bxc6 14.♗c4 ♕xd2 15.♖xd2± is clearly more pleasant for White, though the winning chances aren't really high) 13.♕xd4 ♕xd4 14.♗xd4 ♖d8 15.♗b5 a6 16.♗e2 b5 17.♗b6 ♖e8 18.c4!± Perunovic-Sedlak, Vrnjacka Banja 2005;

it is obvious, though, that this kind of advantage is not completely satisfactory, because the drawing chances are very high.



12...♕d6

The most natural spot, to prevent damage to the structure (if White plays ♘xc6) and to prepare to retreat the queen to b8. There is at least one alternative with a similar value.

O 12...♕a5?! There is no reason to make structural concessions. 13.♘xc6! ♕xd2+ 14.♖xd2 bxc6 15.c5± Shulman-Drogoon, Minsk 1995;

O 12...♕e5!? 13.♘xc6 (13.f4 ♕c7 14.♘b5 ♕b8 15.♗e2 – 15.♕f2!± – 15...♖d8 16.♕c2 ♗d7= Vallejo Pons-Anand, Monaco (rapid) 2004) 13...bxc6 14.♗f4! ♕f6 15.h4 h6 16.♕e3± Pashikian-Seeman, Moscow 2005.

13.♘xc6

13.♘b5 ♕b8 14.♗d3 may deserve more attention, but I can't see how White can cope with the following unpleasant pawn sacrifice in a convincing way: 14...a6 15.♘c3 b5!?↑.

13...♕xc6 14.♗d3 e5

After **14...♖d8** 15.♕c2± White's position is somewhat more free, but it is true that Black has a solid position and can neutralize White's edge and put the game to sleep: 15...h6 16.♔b1 (16.♗h7+! ♔h8 17.♖xd8+ ♗xd8 18.♗e4±) 16...♗d7 17.f4 ♗e8 18.♖he1 ♖d7 19.♗h7+ ♔h8 20.♗e4 ♖xd1+ 21.♖xd1 ♕c7 22.♕e2 ♖c8 23.♗d3 ♖d8 24.g4 ♔g8 25.g5 hxg5 26.fxg5 ♕e5 27.h4∞ Vorobiov-Shipunov, Moscow ch-city 2000.

15.♕c2 f5 16.♖he1 ♗c5?!

This exchange looks natural, but actually facilitates White's pressure on the e5 pawn, which can thus drop.

Better is **16...♗e6** 17.♗f2 ♗d6 and now White may continue with the pressure by means of 18.c5! (18.♔b1 was Socko-Movsesian, Kallithea tt 2008) 18...♖ac8 (18...♗c7 19.♗c4 ♗xc4 20.♕xc4+ ♔h8 21.♔b1±) 19.cxd6 ♕d5 20.♗c4 ♕xc4 21.♕xc4 ♖xc4+ 22.♔b1 e4 23.b3 ♖c6 24.♗h4±.

17.♗xc5 ♕xc5 18.♕c3 ♖e8 19.♗c2!

19.♔b1 isn't bad either, e.g.: 19...b6 20.♗c2 ♗b7 (20...g6 21.♖d5+–) 21.♗xf5+–.

19...♕c7 20.♖d5

There is no way to defend the e5 pawn.

20...e4 21.fxe4 fxe4 22.g3±

Defending h2 before capturing the pawn.

22...♗e6 23.♖d4 ♗f5 24.♗xe4 ♗xe4 25.♖dxe4 ♖xe4 26.♖xe4 ♖f8 27.♕d4 a6 28.a3 h6 29.♔b1 ♔h8 30.♔a2 b5?!

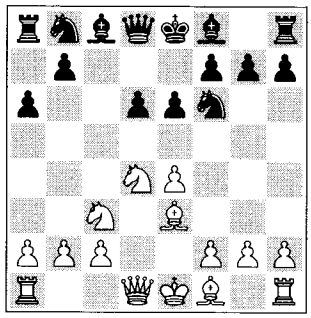
30...♖d8±

31.♖e6 ♔h7 32.♖xa6 bxc4 1-0

Game 18.02

Littlewood,John
Shamkovich,Leonid
London 1987

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e6 6.♗e3 a6



This and the next game in this chapter will deal with the position arising from this diagram. In all cases, White goes on with his routine: f2-f3, ♕d2, 0-0-0, g2-g4 etc. Black, for his part, has two main plans: one is based on ...♘c6, ...♗e7 and a quick ...0-0 and then launching queenside counterplay; the other involves an immediate ...b5 and speeding up the queenside counterplay before castling. These plans will be studied in the last games of this chapter. In this game and the next ones we'll deal with some infrequent lines.

7.♕d2

In my opinion, a bit more accurate than 7.f3, though almost interchangeable. White even wishes to avoid some lines involving a quick ...d5.

7...♕c7

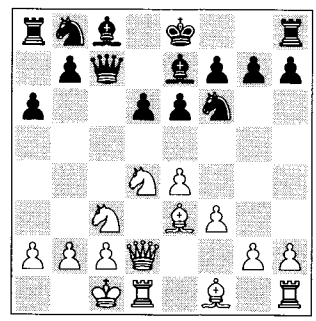
This queen development may be regarded as premature and relatively inflexible in this variation, but it frequently occurs on this move or the next ones, and we'll try to examine in this game all the lines involving it. Black has a wide range of alternatives, but the four main ones, that is, ...♗e7, ...b5, ...♘c6 and ...♘bd7, appear in or transpose to the next games.

7...♘g4 is harmless for White. Rather the opposite: 8.♗g5 ♕c7 (8...♗e7? leaves the d6 pawn extremely weak and 8...♕b6 9.h3 ♘f6 10.0-0-0 is a rather favourable version of any other line) 9.♕e2! ♕c5 10.♕xg4 ♕xd4 11.♗e3 ♕b4 12.0-0-0 ♘c6 13.f4 b5 14.♗b6 d5 15.exd5 ♘e5 16.♕g3 ♘c4 17.♗xc4 bxc4 18.dxe6 ♕xb6 19.♘d5 ♕c5 20.f5 ♖a7 21.e7 f6 22.♖he1 ♖d7 23.♘c7+ 1-0 Sax-Salazar Jacob, Dubai ol 1986.

8.0-0-0 ♗e7

In these variations, economising on the tempo ...♗e7 is interesting, e.g.: **8...b5** 9.f3 ♘bd7 10.g4 ♘e5?! (10...h6) 11.g5 ♘fd7 12.f4 ♘c4 13.♗xc4 ♕xc4, but it looks better to carry out the whole plan just with the knights, as we'll see later. Now White's attack runs fast: 14.b3! ♕c7 15.f5 ♘e5 16.♖hf1! ♗d7 17.♘ce2! (the knight heads for f4 and the sensitive spot e6 has no defence) 17...♕b7 18.♘f4 ♕xe4 19.fxe6 fxe6 20.♗g1 0-0-0 21.♘dxe6+– Bindrich-Mozny, Germany Bundesliga 2006/07.

9.f3



Again, a wide range of choices for Black.

9...♘bd7

O 9...b5 10.♔b1 Preparing the knight sacrifice, but at the same time this move is useful in all lines. Of course, 10.g4 is normal. **10...♗b7** 10...0-0 fixes the black king's position too soon; 10...♘bd7 allows the same sacrifice and 10...b4 11.♘ce2 d5 is premature on account of 12.e5!. Finally, 10...♘c6 transposes to 9...♘c6. **11.♘dxb5 axb5 12.♘xb5 ♕c6 13.♘xd6+ ♗xd6 14.♕xd6 ♕xd6 15.♖xd6** and in this thematic ending White has an ideal situation: a firm kingside pawn structure, the bishop pair and a grip on the dark squares, Sharapov-Stromsky, Moscow 2001.

O 9...0-0 10.g4 b5 11.h4 b4 (11...♘c6 transposes) 12.♘ce2 ♕a5 13.♔b1 ♖d8 14.g5 ♘h5 15.♗h3± with the idea of ♗g4, Dutreeuw-Lutz, San Bernardino 1998.

O 9...♘c6!? The most important alternative, because this position may arise via many different orders. **10.g4 b5** 10...0-0?! – to fix the king's position so early looks dangerous: 11.g5 ♘d7 12.h4 b5 13.g6! (13.♘xc6!? ♕xc6 14.♘e2±) 13...♘f6 (13...hxg6 14.h5) 14.gxh7+ ♔xh7 15.♘xc6 ♕xc6 16.♗d3± and it is clear that the white attack has taken a great lead, Adams-Sheldon, Hove ch-GBR 1997. **11.♘xc6** This is the simplest, as the transfer of the other knight to d4 is inevitable in this variation, but some other move orders lead to positions of a similar content, e.g.: 11.h4 ♗b7 12.♔b1 0-0 13.h5 ♖ac8 14.g5 ♘d7 15.g6 with a strong attack, Savko-Batakovs, Riga 1994. **11...♕xc6 12.h4** This is my recommendation: not to push the black knight to e5 too soon. For example: 12.g5 ♘d7 13.h4 ♘e5∞ with some trouble defending f3. **12...♗b7 13.♘e2!** The standard manoeuvre. The knight is ideally placed on d4 in this line: it hits e6, allows the reply e4-e5 against ...d6-d5, defends f3 and wins time here. **13...♕c7** 13...d5 14.♘d4 ♕c7 15.e5!±; 13...0-0?! 14.g5 ♘d7 15.♘d4 ♕c7 16.g6!±. **14.♘d4 ♖c8 15.♔b1 d5 16.e5!** The thematic move to reach the French structure. **16...♘d7 17.f4 ♘c5 18.♗d3±** Vorobiov-Veliev, St Petersburg 2000.

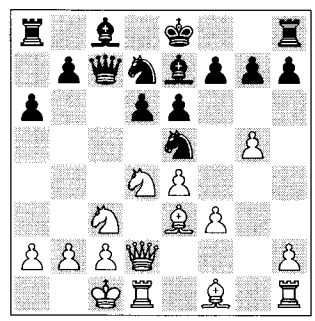
10.g4

Now the black knights obstruct one another and Black has to worry about the threat g4-g5.

10...♘e5

Let's see the other solutions: **10...♘b6** 11.g5 ♘fd7 12.f4 ♘c5 13.h4 ♗d7 14.♔b1 0-0-0 15.♕f2± De La Villa Garcia-Mateo, San Juan 1987; **10...h6** 11.h4 b5 (11...♘e5 12.♗e2! followed by g4-g5) 12.♖g1! ♗b7 13.g5 hxg5 14.hxg5 ♘h5 15.g6+– Barissever-Esengin, Saraybahce 2002; **10...b5** 11.h4 ♘b6 12.g5 ♘fd7 13.h5 ♘c4 14.♗xc4 ♕xc4 15.b3 ♕c7 16.g6!± Dib-Lukianenko, Kharkov 2003.

11.g5 ♘fd7



White pursues his attack with maximum speed.

12.f4! ♘c4 13.♗xc4 ♕xc4 14.f5 ♘e5

14...e5 15.♘de2± thanks to the d5-square; **14...♘c5!?**.

15.f6 gxf6 16.gxf6 ♗xf6 17.♖hf1 ♗g7

17...♗e7 18.♗g5 ♘d3+ 19.♔b1 ♗xg5 20.♕xg5 ♕xd4 21.♕h5 (21.♖xd3! ♕e5 22.♕h4± Littlewood's analysis) 21...♖f8 22.♖xd3 ♕e5 23.♕h4± Garbisu de Goni-Leko, Pamplona 1993/94.

18.♘f5!!

The real key to the position. As the computer modules confirm, there is no satisfactory defence for Black.

18...exf5 19.♕xd6 ♗e6

19...f6 20.♘d5+–.

20.♘d5?

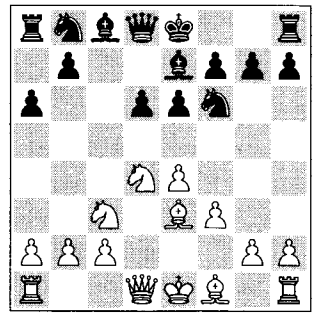
Obvious, but wrong. White has at least one decisive move. 20.exf5! is the most convincing: 20...♘c6 21.fxe6 ♕xe6 22.♕xe6+ fxe6 23.♘e4+–. Despite the simplification, Black can't help losing at least a pawn.

20...♗xd5–+ 21.♖xf5 ♕c6 22.♖xe5+ ♗e6 23.♕d4 ♕c7 24.♗f4 ♖d8 25.♕a4+ b5 26.♖xd8+ ♕xd8 27.♕xa6 0-0 28.♖g5 ♕f6 0-1

Game 18.03

Baramidze,David
Rotstein,Efim
Austria tt 2005/06

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 a6 6.♗e3 e6 7.f3 ♗e7



This move usually introduces one of the two main plans in this position: the one involving a quick ...0-0. However, in this game we will deal with the mixtures of plans, very frequent in practice but quite harmless for White.

8.♕d2 b5

Apart from this move and ...0-0, which usually ends up in a transposition, Black has tried other alternatives here, but they don't look really inspired:

○ 8...♘bd7?! This leaves the other knight without its natural retreat square and after 9.g4 Black is forced to move the knight again or play the undesirable ...h6: 9...h6 (9...♘e5?! 10.g5 ♘fd7 11.f4! ♘g4? 12.♗g1+– is too risky for the black knight) 10.0-0-0 ♕c7 (10...b5?! 11.♘c6) 11.h4 b5 12.♗d3± and g4-g5 is coming.

○ 8...♗d7?! is again dubious because of 9.g4±.

○ 8...d5 9.e5 ♘fd7 10.f4 leads to a French structure in very comfortable conditions for White: 10...♘c6 11.♗e2 ♘xd4 12.♗xd4 b5 13.a3± Hellers-Ljubojevic, Amsterdam 1988.

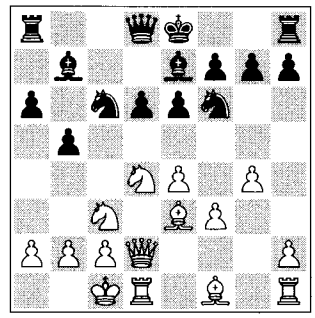
○ 8...0-0 9.g4 and now Black is unlikely to play other than 9...♕c7, transposing to the previous game, or 9...b5 transposing to the note to the next moves, or 9...♘c6, transposing to the next game.

9.g4 ♗b7

O 9...h6?! is an attempt to prevent the break on g5 but says goodbye to ...0-0, so it doesn't really fit with ...♗e7, which is precisely a preparation of kingside castling. In any case, 10.0-0-0 ♗b7 11.h4 ♘c6 12.♘xc6 ♗xc6 13.♗h3! ♘d7 14.g5± gives White a strong attack, Beshukov-Obukhov, Sochi 1993.

O 9...♘fd7!? is a very interesting idea, successfully played by Krum Georgiev. It combines the transfer of the two knights to some spots where they control c4 (that is, b6 and e5), with the arrangements for kingside castling. As with many other marginal ideas, there is no clear refutation and it is impossible to know why it hasn't come into fashion. On the contrary, its twin sister (the same idea without ...♗e7) has become one of the main lines. **10.0-0-0 ♗b7** Far less frequent, but equally interesting, is the immediate 10...♘b6?!, speeding up the disturbing threat ...♘c4. However, there is a direct problem. 11.♕f2! threatens a discovered attack and exploits the fact that Black can't play 11...♘8d7 due to 12.♘c6: 11...♘6d7 12.♗d3±. **11.g5 ♘b6** There is no point to 11...♘c5, as the knight is useless here: 12.h4 ♘bd7 13.♔b1 b4 14.♘ce2 ♕b6 15.h5 0-0-0 16.♖h3!± intending g5-g6, De La Villa Garcia-Modr, Barcelona 1992; 11...♘c6 is quite inconsistent with the previous moves. White replies in the usual fashion: first knight swapped, second knight recycled to d4: 12.♘xc6 ♗xc6 13.♘e2 ♘e5 14.♘d4 ♖c8 15.♖g1 0-0 16.h4 d5 17.f4 ♘c4 18.♗xc4 dxc4 19.♘xc6 ♖xc6 20.♕d7± Akopian-Gislason, Kallithea tt 2008. **12.h4 ♘8d7 13.h5!?** White decides to ignore the 'threat' 13...b4, as his attack is fast enough. Although the next moves are less natural than usual, this strategy is successful. 13.♗d3 ♖c8 14.♔b1 leads to a position already considered in Game 18.05. **13...b4** 13...♘e5!? is a recommendation by Nikitin leading to a double-edged position after 14.f4 ♘ec4 15.♗xc4 ♘xc4 16.♕d3, but probably the preventive 14.b3! is a more effective solution. **14.♘b1** Now this is the only possible retreat. **14...d5 15.♕g2 dxe4** (15...e5 16.♘f5 d4 17.g6!+−; 15...♘c5 16.g6→) **16.fxe4** And now White replies 17.g6 to any move: **16...♕c7 17.g6!±** Anand-Kr.Georgiev, Palma de Mallorca 1989.

10.0-0-0 ♘c6



The main alternative to 10...0-0 and far more flexible in my opinion. Black usually transfers his knights to b6 and e5, but White can deal with this plan.

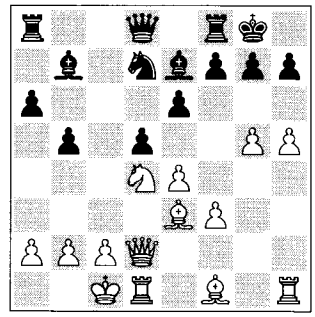
O 10...♕c7 transposes to the previous game.

O 10...b4?! is premature, as it exposes the pawn and forces an immediate 11...d5: 11.♘ce2 d5 (11...a5 12.♘b5±; 11...♘bd7?! 12.♕xb4±) 12.e5 ♘fd7 13.f4 ♘c5 14.♗g2 ♘bd7 15.♔b1 ♘b6 16.♕e1 ♘c4 17.♗c1 ♕b6 18.f5 0-0 19.♘f4 ♖fc8 20.♖f1±.

Despite staying on the first ranks, the white pieces are already launching a very strong attack on the enemy king, Korneev-Sanchez, Spain 1994.

O 10...h6?! is clearly inadequate: the break g4-g5 is delayed for one move but when it comes, it comes with greater effect: 11.h4 ♘bd7 12.♖h3!? (other moves preparing g4-g5 are strong too; 12.♗h3!?) 12...♘f8 13.g5± ♘6d7 (13...hxg5 14.hxg5 ♘h5 15.♗d3± followed by f3-f4) 14.gxh6 gxh6 15.♗xh6+– Potkin-Kachar, Moscow ch-city 2000.

O 10...0-0 A very committal decision. White's pawn assault is perfectly arranged and Black now has to trust in a central reaction, as it is clear that the attacking race is lost. We still have to see whether speeding up the counterplay before defining the position of the king offers better results: **11.h4 ♘c6** Black can hardly go on without this move, which allows White's thematic manoeuvre: 11...d5?! 12.g5 b4 13.♘ce2 ♘fd7 14.♗h3; 11...♘bd7 12.g5 ♘h5 13.♗h3 followed by ♗g4. **12.♘xc6 ♗xc6 13.g5 ♘d7 14.♘e2!?** Not the only possibility, but indeed the most logical, as the knight must make it to d4 in time to defend f3. **14...d5** 14...♘e5 15.♘d4 ♗d7 (15...♗b7 16.h5 and g6→; 15...♖c8 16.♖h3±) 16.♖g1 ♖c8 17.f4 ♘c4 18.♗xc4 bxc4?! (18...♖xc4 19.f5→) 19.♕c3!±. Black's attack is paralysed for a long time and the mass of white pawns is about to destroy the enemy fortress, Torrecillas-Esteban Mendez, Benasque 1997) **15.♘d4 ♗b7** (Short-Ljubojevic, Reykjavik 1987) and now, according to Nunn's analysis, White has a clear edge with **16.h5!** with the following options:



A) **16...♘e5** 17.g6! hxg6 18.hxg6 ♘xg6 19.♕h2±;

B) **16...♘c5** 17.g6! fxg6 (17...dxe4 18.h6!+–) 18.hxg6 h6 19.♗h3+–;

C) **16...dxe4** 17.♘xe6 fxe6 18.♕xd7 ♗d5 19.♖xd5 exd5 20.♕e6+ ♔h8 21.h6 ♗xg5 (21...♖g8 22.♗d4 ♗xg5+ 23.♔b1 ♗f6 24.hxg7+ ♔xg7 25.♖g1+ ♔h6 26.♗e3++–; 21...♖xf3 22.hxg7+ ♔xg7 23.♗d4+ ♔f8 24.g6+–) 22.hxg7+ ♔xg7 23.♕g4 ♖f5 (23...h6 24.f4±) 24.♕xf5! ♗xe3+ 25.♔b1 h6 26.fxe4±.

11.♘xc6!

Preventing the dance of the black knights and luring the bishop to a spot from which it will later be expelled, gaining time with the standard manoeuvre (second knight to the d4-square). Even so, Black has some resources based on the long light-squared diagonal.

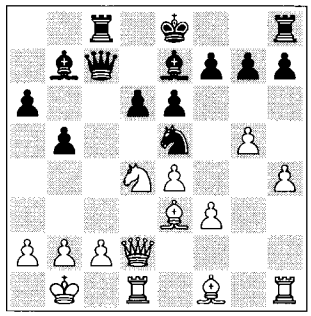
11...♗xc6 12.♘e2 ♖c8 13.♘d4 ♗b7 14.h4!

A frequent subtlety: g4-g5 is delayed in order not to push the enemy knight to a desirable spot: 14.g5 ♘d7 15.h4 ♘e5!∞. Now Black threatens 16...♘xf3 and disturbs White's normal development.

14...♕c7 15.♔b1 ♘d7

Finally the knight leaves of its own free will. 15...d5 16.e5!±; 15...0-0 16.h5± followed by g4-g5-g6.

16.g5 ♘e5



17.♕g2!

An excellent multi-purpose move: the queen prevents the threat ...♘xf3, defends the rook in order to play the break g5-g6 and stands opposite Black's future castled position.

17...♘c6

17...♘c4 18.♗xc4 ♕xc4 19.h5± followed by g5-g6.

18.h5 d5?!

Black opts for a curious strategy: by creating new problems in his own position, he diverts White from the attack! 18...♘xd4 19.♖xd4 d5 is more resilient, though White must be better thanks to the break g5-g6, the Sword of Damocles over Rotstein's head.

19.exd5 ♘xd4 20.♗xd4 ♗xd5

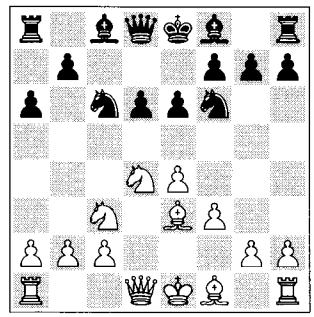
20...0-0 21.g6! fxg6 22.hxg6 h6 23.♗d3.

21.h6! e5? 22.hxg7+– ♖g8 23.♗c3 ♖d8 24.♕e2 ♗c4 25.♖xd8+ ♕xd8 26.♕e1 ♗xf1 27.♕xf1 ♖xg7 28.f4 ♗d6 29.fxe5 b4 30.exd6 bxc3 31.♕xa6 ♖xg5 32.♖d1 ♔f8 33.d7 f6 34.♕c8 ♔e7 35.♕xc3 ♖e5 36.♕d3 h5 37.a3 ♔f7 38.♕h7+ ♔e6 39.a4 ♖g5 40.♕e4+ ♖e5 41.♕c4+ ♔e7 42.a5 ♖g5 43.a6 1-0

Game 18.04

De La Villa Garcia,Jesus
Del Rio de Angelis,Salvador
Andorra Open 2006

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e6 6.♗e3 a6 7.f3 ♘c6



This is the most precise order to carry out the second most popular plan that Black has to cope with White's set-up. Though the near-universal follow-up is ...♗e7 and ...0-0, Black keeps other options open (some of them very interesting), which we will mention in the notes to the next moves.

8.♕d2 ♗e7 9.0-0-0 0-0

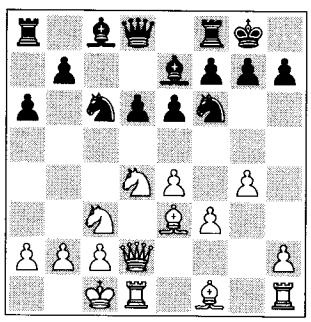
The first stage of Black's plan is completed. Once the king is safe, all energies will be focused on creating counterplay against his opposite number. The main resources for this are: pushing the b-pawn, the break ...d5 and the knight manoeuvres via the squares e5 and c4. The remaining possible Black options are either transpositions or weak moves:

O 9...d5?! is premature: 10.♕e1! and Black is in trouble due to the position of his queen, in line with the white rook, for example: 10...e5 (10...♗b4 11.a3 ♗xc3 12.♕xc3±; 10...0-0 11.g4±; 10...♗d7 11.exd5 exd5 12.g4±) 11.♘xc6 bxc6 12.exd5 (12.♕g3!?) 12...cxd5?! (12...♘xd5 13.♕g3 ♗f6 14.♘e4±) 13.♗g5+– and Black loses a pawn without compensation, Magem Badals-Lesiège, Matanzas 1993.

O 9...♗d7?! 10.g4 ♖c8 11.g5 ♘h5 (the misplaced bishop forces the knight to stand on this problematic spot) 12.♘xc6 ♗xc6 13.f4! b5 14.♗e2 b4 15.♘d5± De La Villa Garcia-Ljubojevic, Szirak izt 1987.

O 9...♘xd4!? looks like an innocent transposition to ...0-0, and indeed it is, if White captures with the queen; however, there is an interesting idea behind this exchange if White recaptures with the bishop. Let's see: 10.♗xd4 (10.♕xd4!) 10...b5 11.g4 ♕a5 12.♔b1 b4 13.♘e2 e5 14.♗e3 ♗e6 15.♘c1 h6! (after a long sequence of semi-forced moves, Black prevents g4-g5 and so he wins a tempo to prepare ...d5 with ...♖d8) 16.g5 (16.h4 ♖d8 17.♗d3 d5∞) 16...hxg5 17.♗xg5 ♖d8 18.♕d3 d5 19.♕xa6 ♕xa6 20.♗xa6 dxe4 21.♗b5+ ♘d7 22.♗xe7 ♔xe7 23.fxe4 ♘c5 and Black's activity compensates for the pawn.

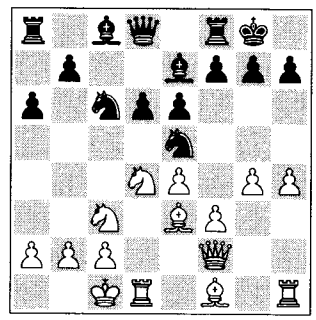
10.g4



Once White has castled, his pawn assault starts. We have reached one of the basic positions of this variation, which is an important crossroads for Black.

10...♘xd4

O 10...♘d7 is the main alternative to trading knights on d4. Black wants to play ...♘e5 first and disturb the normal development of White's attack thanks to the pressure on f3. The white queen has to move to defend f3, but the question is to which square. **11.h4 ♘de5** This is the idea behind 10...♘d7, other moves just transpose. Now White has to make an important decision; up to 4 ways of defending the f-pawn have been tried, but the two most natural seem to be the best as well. **12.♕f2** I choose this move, which has the advantage of keeping an eye on the b6-square and has obtained the better results, though 12.♕g2 is appealing too. And now:



A) **12...♕c7 13.g5 b5 14.♖g1** 14.♔b1!? intending h4-h5 is an equally interesting option: 14...♖b8 15.♘xc6 ♕xc6 16.♘e2 ♘c4 17.♗c1 e5 18.♘g3 b4 19.♗xc4 ♕xc4 20.♘f5± Howell-Weindl, Hamburg 1995; 14.♘xc6 ♕xc6 15.♘e2?! meets 15...♘c4∓; 14.h5!? ♘xd4 15.♖xd4 is possible too.

A1) Nikitin's recommendation **14...♘a5** 15.♔b1 ♘ec4 16.♗c1 b4

17.♘ce2 ♗b7 may be answered by 18.h5! and if 18...d5?! 19.exd5 ♗xd5 20.♘f4 followed by g5-g6!;

A2) **14...b4** poses some problems for White, and may be an argument for choosing 14.♔b1: 15.♘ce2 (15.♘xc6?! bxc3! 16.♘xe7+ ♕xe7 17.bxc3 ♖b8≅) 15...♘c4 16.♘xc6 ♕xc6 17.♘d4 ♕c7 18.♗xc4 ♕xc4 19.♔b1 and White is ready to continue h4-h5 and g5-g6.

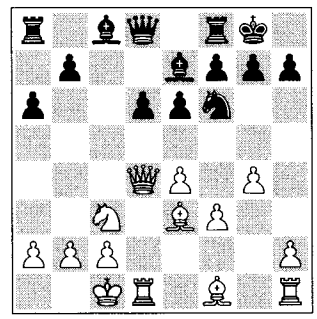
A3) **14...♘c4?!** 15.♗xc4 bxc4 16.f4 ♖b8 17.f5 ♘e5 (17...♕b7 18.♘xc6 ♕xc6 19.f6±) 18.f6!± Georgiev-Har Zvi, Mamaia 1991.

B) **12...b5 13.♘xc6 ♘xc6 14.g5 ♖b8** Necessary to control the b6-square. **15.f4 ♕a5** Necessary to play ...b4; 15...b4 16.♘a4±. **16.♔b1 b4 17.♘e2 ♗d7** (Vatter-Borriss, Germany 1992) And now **18.f5** and if 18...♘e5? 19.f6! and White has a strong attack.

C) **12...♗d7** With an eye on the a4-square, which is important because the white knight must go through it on its way to b6. **13.g5 b5** 13...♖b8 may have the merit of delaying the exchange on c6 one more move, but after 14.♖g1 b5 15.f4! ♘xd4 (15...♘c4 16.♗xc4 bxc4 17.f5→) 16.♗xd4 ♘c6 17.♗e3 ♕a5 18.♔b1 ♖fc8 19.h5 the mass of white pawns is ready to hit the enemy castled position, De La Villa Garcia-Wang Pin, Ubeda 1997. **14.♘xc6 ♗xc6 15.♗d4?!** More natural is 15.♔b1!? to free the c1-square for the bishop and prepare the typical knight transfer c3-e2-d4 as well; 15.♖g1 looks justified by tactical details, e.g.: 15...b4 16.♘e2 ♘c4 17.♗d4 e5 18.♘g3! ♗b5 19.♗c5±. I consider both moves more natural than the choice in the game. **15...♕b8 16.♖g1** White is not ready for 16.f4 on account of 16...b4!∓. **16...b4 17.♘e2 a5** It would be nice to have the d4-square free for the knight, but Black has counterplay, Dvoiris-A.Lundin, Balatonbereny tt 1994.

O 10...♖b8 In the beginning, this line had an impact because Kasparov played it. Nowadays, it has lost its charm and it is only used for transpositions. **11.h4 ♘xd4 12.♗xd4 ♘d7 13.♗a7!** This way, White relocates his bishop without waste of time. On e3, the bishop defends the g5-pawn in order to play h4-h5, and frees the d4-square for the knight. **13...♖a8 14.♗e3 b5 15.g5 ♕c7 16.h5 ♖d8 17.g6±** and White's attack has arrived much faster. De La Villa Garcia-Suba, New York 1989.

11.♕xd4!?



The move on which Spanish players have focused their studies. Time goes by and 11.♗xd4 is still more popular, but 11.♕xd4 gets slightly better results. In short, both moves are acceptable, but I think that studying the queen move is more economical.

11...b5

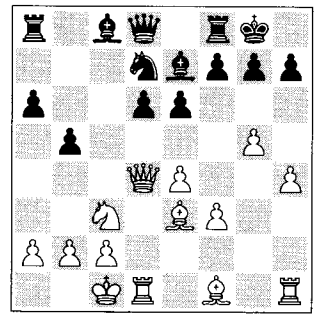
The most flexible alternative, and the main move; however, speeding the arrival of the knight to e5 is also very logical, in order to exploit the uncomfortable position of the white queen.

11...♘d7 12.h4 ♘e5 The logical follow-up. 12...b5 13.g5 leads to the main game. **13.♗e2 b5 14.♔b1** An important prophylactic measure, instead of 14.g5 ♘c6 15.♕d2?! (15.♕b6=) 15...♕a5 and White is in trouble in view of the threat ...b4. **14...♖b8** Intending ...b4. Less precise is 14...♗b7 15.g5 ♖c8 16.h5! and Black has to take a complicated decision: whether to capture the pawn and open a dangerous file, or allow that very pawn to hit the castled position by moving forward to g6: 16...♘c6 17.♕d2 ♕a5 18.♗d3! (freeing the e2-square for the knight) 18...b4 19.♘e2 ♘e5 20.♘d4 d5 21.g6!± Magem Badals-Kalesis, Berga 1995; 14...♕a5!? (threatening ...b4) 15.f4 ♘c6 16.♕b6±. After the queen swap, Black would have problems with the d6 pawn and the b6-square (in the case of ...b4). 16...♗d7 (Garbisu de Goni-Krush, France tt-2 2004/05) and now 17.♕xa5! ♘xa5 18.♗b6 ♘b7 19.♗f3±. **15.f4 ♘c6 16.♕d2 ♕a5** 16...♕c7 17.h5! ♖d8 18.h6±. **17.♗f3 ♕c7 18.h5** 18.g5!? (Nunn) 18...♘a5 (18...b4 19.♘e2 ♘a5 20.b3±) 19.b3 b4 20.♘e2 ♗d7 21.h5±. **18...♘a5 19.b3 ♗b7 20.♘e2 ♖fc8 21.♗d4 e5 22.♗b2 ♘c6** (Nunn-Ribli, Lucerne Wch-tt 1985) and now **23.h6!** is really promising, e.g.: 23...exf4 (23...g6 24.f5±) 24.♗xg7 ♘e5 25.♖hf1 ♘xf3 26.♖xf3 ♗g5 27.♘xf4 ♗xe4 28.♖c3 ♕d8 29.♕d4 ♖xc3 30.♕xe4⩲.

12.g5 ♘d7

12...♘h5 doesn't usually work in this kind of position, but in this case it fails to a very concrete refutation: 13.e5! d5 (Arizmendi Martinez-L.Guliev, Linares 2001) 14.♕h4! g6 15.♘e4 ♕a5 (15...♕c7 16.♘f6+ ♗xf6 17.exf6±) 16.♘g3! ♘g7 (16...♕xa2 17.♘xh5 gxh5 18.♗d3 with a crushing attack) 17.♔b1±. It looks easy for White to retreat the queen and just play h4-h5.

13.h4



13...♕a5

The most active and complex move. It threatens 14...b4 but keeps an eye on the g5 pawn. There are some other interesting options:

O 13...♖b8 The most logical alternative to ...♕a5, intending ...b4 too. **14.♔b1** As in the 13...♗b7 variation, White prepares the push h4-h5, offering a pawn, but 14.♕d2 is possible too. **14...b4 15.♘e2 ♗b7?!** Since this bishop is not going to do great things along the diagonal and this move leaves the d7 knight unprotected (which is important in the lines where the g5 pawn is sacrificed), this is unlikely to be the best option. 15...♘e5 16.f4 ♘c6 17.♕d2 a5 18.h5± Pinol Fulgoni-Weindl, Switzerland tt 2002; 15...a5 16.♕d2 ♗b7 17.h5 d5 18.g6 ♗f6 19.♘f4 ♘e5 20.gxf7+ ♖xf7 21.♘xe6± Brodsky-Levin, Hamburg 2001; 15...♕a5 transposes to 13...♕a5; 15...♘c5 16.h5 e5 17.♕d2 ♗e6 18.♘c1 ♘a4 19.♘b3 a5 20.g6± Rodriguez Vila-Ricardi, Villa Ballester 1996. **16.h5!** The pawn sacrifice works perfectly here, and thus

White can speed up his attack. **16...a5** 16...♗xg5 17.♗xg5 ♕xg5 18.h6± e5?! 19.♕xd6 g6 20.♗h3!+−. **17.g6 ♗f6 18.gxf7+ ♖xf7 19.♕xd6 ♕e8 20.♗h3±** De La Villa Garcia-Morozevich, Pamplona 1994/95.

O 13...♗b7 14.♔b1 Paving the way for the g5 pawn offer. **14...♖c8** 14...♘e5 15.f4 ♘c6 16.♕d2 ♖c8 (Llobel Cortell-Tissir, La Roda 2004) 17.h5!± followed by h5-h6 or g5-g6. **15.h5!** 15.♕d2, in order to play g4-g5 without giving a pawn, is also good. **15...♗xg5 16.♗xg5 ♕xg5 17.h6±** Black's castled position becomes seriously damaged, e.g.: 17...♖fd8 18.hxg7! ♘e5 19.♗e2 ♘g6 20.♕f2 b4 21.♘a4 h5 22.♗d3 ♖c6 23.♖dg1± Shomoev-Askarov, Sochi tt 2005.

O 13...♘e5?! Not bad, but Black could have played this on the previous turn and then it was more irritating, so... 14.f4 ♘c6 15.♕d2 ♕a5 16.♔b1 b4 17.♘e2 ♗b7 18.♗g2 (18.♘g3 and ♗d3 looks a more logical set-up) 18...♕c7 (Kutuzovic-Medak, Croatia tt 1994) and now 19.h5, to play g5-g6, is the normal follow-up.

O 13...b4?! 14.♕xb4 and though this has been played now and then, it does not look as though there is compensation for the pawn;

O 13...♕c7?! 14.h5 and the white pawns are coming.

14.♔b1

Respecting the threat 15...b4, though, as shown in my analysis in my book on the English Attack, White can provoke a great tactical storm playing immediately 14.h5!? b4 15.h6 gxh6 16.♖g1 h5!∞.

14...♗b7

14...b4 causes some lack of coordination among the white pieces: **15.♘e2** and now:

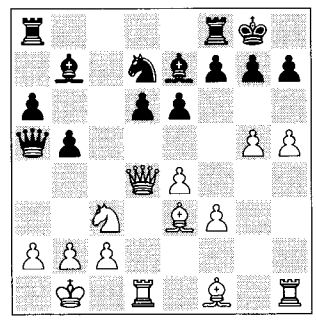
A) **15...e5** 16.♕d2 ♘c5 17.♘c1! ♗e6 18.♗h3 ♕c7 19.h5 ♗xh3 20.♖xh3 ♘e6 21.g6± Rodriguez Vila-Milos, Santos 2005;

B) **15...♘e5** 16.f4 ♘g4 (16...♘c6 17.♕d2± and White's attack goes on) 17.♗g1 (17.♕b6!? ♕xb6 18.♗xb6±) 17...e5 18.♕d2 exf4 19.♘xf4 ♗b7 20.♘d5± De La Villa Garcia-Jimenez, Pamplona tt 1997;

C) **15...♗b7** 16.h5 ♘e5 17.h6 leads to the stem game;

D) **15...♖b8** 16.♕d2 (here the standard g5 pawn sacrifice is less clear: 16.h5!? ♗xg5 17.♗xg5 ♕xg5 18.h6 e5! 19.♕xd6 ♖b6 20.♕c7 ♖xh6 21.♖xh6 ♕xh6 22.♖xd7 ♗xd7 23.♕xd7 ♕h1∞ with a very complex position, but I don't think this is bad for Black) 16...♘c5 (16...♘e5 17.♘d4±) 17.♘d4 ♗d7 18.h5 ♖fc8 19.g6± and once again, White's attack has arrived first, De La Villa Garcia-Guliev, Linares 2003.

15.h5!



The thematic sacrifice; the idea is to open lines and weaken the black castled position. Some tactical details require the pieces on d7 and b7 to be unprotected.

15...b4

No reasonable alternative can be seen: **15...♘e5** 16.h6!±; **15...e5** 16.♕d2 b4 17.♘d5±.

16.♘e2 ♘e5

16...e5 17.♕d2 ♘c5 18.g6 fxg6 19.hxg6 hxg6 20.♘f4!+–;
16...♗xg5 17.♗xg5 ♕xg5 18.h6 – the point! The only move to prevent the pawn exchange is 18...e5, and it fails on tactical grounds: 18...e5 19.♕xd6 g6 20.♗h3! ♘b8 21.♕xb4+–; 18...♕e5 19.hxg7±; or 18...♖fd8 19.hxg7 ♕f6. Black plans to use the enemy pawn as a shield for the king, and answer 20.♕xb4 with 20...♕xf3, but if White focuses on his attack he shouldn't have much trouble securing a big advantage: 20.♕e3!± De La Villa Garcia-Bauer, Lausanne 2001.

17.h6!

Pinning the black knight on e5 and threatening f3-f4.

17...♕c5

17...♖fc8 18.♘g3! (again, threatening f3-f4) 18...gxh6 19.gxh6 f6 20.f4 ♘f3 21.♕d3 d5 22.♗h3 ♔h8 23.♗xe6 dxe4 24.♕b3 ♖d8 25.♗d7 ♖f8 26.♕e6 b3 27.axb3 ♗b4 28.♗b6 1-0 Smirnov-Predojevic, Moscow 2006.

18.hxg7

18.f4!? ♕xd4 19.♖xd4 ♘c6 20.hxg7 ♔xg7 21.♖d2± f6 22.gxf6+ ♖xf6 23.♘g3 ♖g6 24.♖h3 ♔h8 25.f5 exf5 26.♘xf5 Almasi-Cvitan, Sibenik tt 2006.

18...♖fc8!

18...♔xg7 19.f4+–.

19.♕xc5 dxc5 20.♗g2 ♖d8

20...♔xg7 21.♘g3±.

21.♘g3

21.b3! (preventing the knight jump to c4) 21...♔xg7 22.♘g3 leads to the same position while limiting Black's options.

21...♖xd1+

21...♘c4!?.

22.♖xd1 ♔xg7 23.b3 ♖d8 24.♖xd8 ♗xd8 25.♗xc5±

White has secured an endgame with an extra pawn, though Black has good drawing chances due to the weakness of White's kingside.

25...♗xg5 26.♗xb4 ♘g6 27.♗d6 f5 28.exf5?!

There was no need for bigger material gains. 28.♗f1 fxe4 29.♘xe4±.

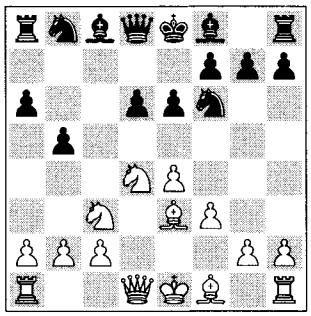
28...exf5 29.♘xf5+ ♔f6 30.♘d4 ♗e3 31.c3 ♘h4 32.♗h1 ♗xd4 33.cxd4 ♘xf3 34.♔b2 ♔e6 35.♗b8 ♗d5 36.♗g2 ♘xd4 37.♗f1 a5 38.♔c3 ♘c6 39.♗h3+ ♔e7 ½-½

Game 18.05

Grischuk,Alexander
Palac,Mladen
Kallithea tt 2008

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 a6 6.♗e3 e6 7.f3 b5

The main line from the point of view of both statistics and results.



Black's general idea is to speed up queenside counterplay; Black's specific ideas are realized in the push ...b4 followed by ...d5 and the knight manoeuvres towards the c4-square. The theory of this variation is still developing and the assessment of the different lines may change fast. Even so, White's general plan is very stable and the first player can succeed with just a good understanding of the position and a bit of research.

8.♕d2

This is my recommendation nowadays, as the immediate 8.g4 (to hinder the plan ...♘bd7-b6) has other drawbacks, especially the line 8.g4 b4 9.♘ce2 h6∞.

8...b4

Topalov made this popular from the year 2005. Black forces the white knight to define its position before it can comfortably retreat to e2. The other variations, less important, are:

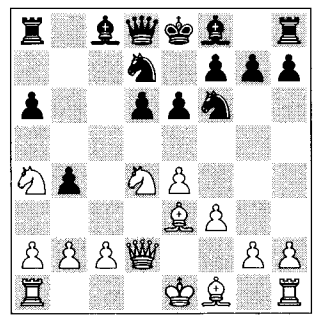
O 8...♕a5 prevents 9.0-0-0, but here the queen is poorly placed for other plans, for example: 9.♗d3! (White immediately switches to 0-0) 9...♗b7 10.0-0 ♘bd7 11.b4! (an excellent strategic idea based on a tactical detail: White's attack on Black's queenside pawns gets faster) 11...♕c7 (11...♕xb4?! 12.a4 ♖c8 13.♘de2 d5 – only move, in view of the threat 14.♖fb1 – 14.♖fb1 ♕d6 15.axb5±) 12.a4 (inserting 12.♖fb1 may be better) 12...bxa4?! (12...d5!?) 13.b5 axb5 14.♘dxb5 ♕b8 15.♖xa4 (15.♘xa4! ♗e7 16.♘b6 ♖xa1 17.♖xa1 0-0±) 15...♖xa4 Tiviakov-Nisipeanu, Wijk aan Zee B 2000.

O 8...h5 An idea widely used in recent times to prevent g2-g4, but it doesn't seem the ideal solution in this position, as once again White hasn't committed to 0-0: 9.a4! b4 10.♘a2 d5 (10...e5?! 11.♘b3 d5 12.exd5 ♕xd5 13.♘xb4 ♕xd2+ 14.♗xd2±) 11.e5 ♘fd7 12.f4 with the standard and favourable French structure: 12...♘c5 13.♗d3 a5 14.0-0 g6 15.♘c1 ♗d7 16.♘cb3 ♘ba6 (16...♘xa4? 17.♘xe6!+–) 17.♗xa6! ♖xa6 18.♘xc5 ♗xc5 19.♘b3 ♗e7 20.♗c5 ♗xc5+ 21.♘xc5 ♖c6 22.♘b3 ♕b6+ 23.♘d4± De La Villa Garcia-Spraggett, Spain tt 2007.

9.♘a4

After 9.♘ce2 e5 10.♘b3 both white knights are somewhat misplaced, which allows 10...d5!=, although 10...♘c6 has occurred more frequently.

9...♘bd7



9...d5 is premature on account of 10.e5!, but after the text move White

always has to concern himself with the central break. Now White has to make an extremely important decision.

10.0-0-0

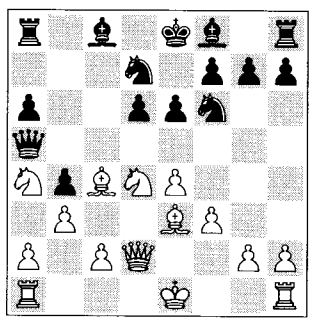
The variation with 10.0-0-0 fits best with the typical plans of this set-up, but the premature advance of Black's queenside pawns fuels the cause of kingside castling. Therefore, I propose a second possibility:

10.♗c4!? Intending 11.0-0 followed by a2-a3 or c2-c3, and now:

A) **10...d5?!** justifies White's plan: 11.exd5 ♘e5!? (11...exd5 12.♗b3±) 12.♗b3 ♘xd5 13.0-0-0 ♗d7 14.♖he1± and the white army is fully developed;

B) **10...♕c7** 11.♗b3 ♗b7 (11...♖b8 12.c3 bxc3 13.♘xc3± and the black queen must waste more time) 12.0-0 d5 13.exd5 ♘xd5 14.♗xd5! (by exchanging the bishop for the strong knight, White is able to establish a firm grip on the dark squares) 14...♗xd5 15.c4!? ♗b7 16.♖fd1±;

C) **10...♕a5 11.b3!** and now:



C1) **11...d5** 12.exd5 ♘e5 (12...exd5? 13.♕e2 ♗e7 14.♘f5→; 12...♘xd5 13.♘c6 ♕c7 14.♗xd5 exd5 15.♘xb4±) 13.♕e2 ♘xc4 14.♕xc4 ♗d7 15.dxe6±;

C2) **11...♘e5** 12.♗e2 ♗e7?! 13.a3 d5? 14.♘c6!+–;

C3) **11...♗b7** (adding more fuel to ...d5, in view of White's threat a2-a3) 12.a3 d5 13.exd5 ♘xd5 (Ewaldt-Ftacnik, Hamburg 2005) and now my suggestion is 14.♗xd5! ♗xd5 15.0-0 ♖c8 16.♖fe1 ♗d6 17.♘f5!±; or 16...♗e7 17.♘f5 exf5 18.axb4; or 16...♘e5 17.♘f5±.

10...♕a5

The black queen comes to exploit the dubious position of the white knight too.

O The original move **10...d5?!** opens the game too soon and offers White good chances against the black king: 11.exd5! ♘xd5 12.♗c4 ♘7f6 13.♗g5 ♕c7 (13...♗b7 14.♖he1 ♗e7 15.♘f5! 0-0 16.♗xd5 ♗xd5 17.♘xe7+ ♕xe7 18.♘b6 ♖ad8 19.♘xd5 ♖xd5 20.♕xd5+–) 14.♗xd5 ♘xd5 15.♖he1 ♗b7 16.♕e2! ♕d6 17.♔b1 (17.f4! ♘xf4? 18.♕g4 ♘d5 19.♘xe6) 17...h6 (17...g6!?) 18.♗h4 ♘f4 19.♕f2 ♕c7 (Leko-Topalov, San Luis Wch 2005) and now White could have finished his attack with 20.♘b6! ♖b8 (20...♕xb6 21.♘xe6 ♕xe6 22.♕a7!!) 21.♘f5 ♗c6 22.♕d4 ♖g8 (22...♘g6 23.♗g3 ♕xb6 24.♕xb6 ♖xb6 25.♗c7+–) 23.♘c4 g5 24.♗g3 ♖d8 25.♘cd6+ ♗xd6 26.♘xd6+ ♖xd6 (26...♔f8 27.♗xf4 gxf4 28.♖xe6!) 27.♕xd6 ♕xd6 28.♖xd6 ♗b5+–.

O 10...♕c7 is slow; White can now carry out his classical attack: 11.g4! h6 12.h4 d5 (Lastin-Petrushin, Sochi 2005) and now 13.♗g2! dxe4 14.g5+–.

11.b3 ♗b7

Preparing ...d5, which is not possible yet: 11...d5? 12.e5! ♘xe5 13.♘xe6 ♗xe6 14.♗b6+–.

12.♔b1

Preparing a2-a3, as well as ♘b2.

12...e5

This is a way to prepare ...d5, but the second knight gets a good square.

O 12...♗e7 (Erdogdu-Sasikiran, Beijing blitz 2008) 13.a3!±;

O 12...d5? still fails on tactical grounds: 13.e5! ♘xe5 14.♘xe6 fxe6 15.♗b6 trapping the queen;

O 12...♘c5 13.a3 ♘xa4 14.axb4 ♕c7 15.bxa4± looks somewhat better for White than the line we will see in the next game but, even so, this should become the critical variation.

13.♘f5! d5 14.exd5 ♗xd5

14...♕xd5 15.♗c4 ♕xd2 16.♖xd2± White has a great lead in development; **14...g6** doesn't solve anything either: 15.♘h6 ♗xd5 16.♘g4! ♘xg4 17.fxg4 ♗c6 18.♗c4±.

15.f4

15.♗d3±, simply completing development, offers White the better game.

15...♗c6

15...e4, trying to close the position, allows the assault 16.g4!

16.♘d6+ ♗xd6 17.♕xd6 ♗xa4 18.bxa4 ♕xa4

Black is unable to castle and the white army is fully developed: a pawn is a mere consolation.

19.♗c5

19.♗d3+– followed by fxe5.

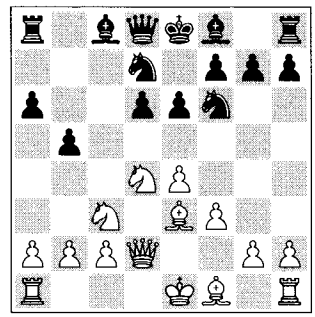
19...♘xc5 20.♕xc5 ♘d7 21.♕c7 ♖d8 22.♗c4 0-0 23.♗b3 ♕b5 24.fxe5 1-0

Black can't keep the knight.

Game 18.06

Mamedov,Nidjat
Suba,Mihai
Bucharest 2008

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 ♘f6 4.♘c3 cxd4 5.♘xd4 e6 6.♗e3 a6 7.f3 b5 8.♕d2 ♘bd7



This knight move introduces the two best known plans in this variation.

8...♗b7?! This order is less precise, as the most Black can get is a transposition, whilst White has a couple of appealing ideas. We suggest the transposition by means of 9.0-0-0, but both 9.a4 and 9.g4 ♘bd7 10.h4 are dangerous for Black.

9.g4 ♘b6

The first knight keeps an eye on the c4-square and leaves d7 for its partner, as a possible stop on the way to e5 and also c4. Of all the alternatives shown in this chapter, this knight dance is probably the one with most energy and potential.

O 9...h6 transposes to the next game;

O 9...♗b7?! doesn't make sense due to 10.g5;

O 9...♘e5 10.g5 ♘fd7 11.f4 ♘c4 (11...♘g4 12.♗g1±) 12.♗xc4 bxc4 13.0-0-0±.

10.0-0-0 ♗b7

10...♘fd7 leads to a position which arises more frequently through the old move order: 8.g4 ♘fd7 9.♕d2 ♘b6 10.0-0-0 ♘8d7. For some time, the sacrifice on b5 looked like a refutation, but Black has finally managed to survive. Normally White tries to transpose, but Black has at least one interesting option: 11.♗d3 ♘e5 deserves more practical tests: 12.♔b1 (12.♗g5, still untested, has certain venom, e.g.: 12...♕c7 13.f4 ♘xg4 14.♖hg1 ♘f6 15.f5⩲) 12...♘bc4 13.♕e2 ♘xe3 14.♕xe3 ♗b7 15.♗e2 followed by f3-f4 with initiative, but Black's options shouldn't be underestimated.

11.g5

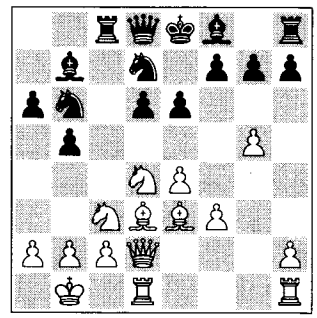
We take this order as the main line, though this move pushes the knight exactly where it wants to go. It wouldn't be a surprise if starting with ♗d3 or even ♔b1 were more exact: 11.♗d3 ♖c8 12.♔b1!?.

11...♘fd7 12.♗d3 ♖c8

This is the universal move in this line: it hinders ♕f2 because of the exchange sacrifice on c3, but the order chosen by White offers Black an extra option, one that has been object of little research despite its undeniable interest:

12...♘e5 13.f4 ♘bc4 (13...♘xd3+?! 14.cxd3 strengthens White's centre; 13...♘ec4 14.♕f2 ♘xe3 15.♕xe3± and in spite of losing its important bishop, the white army is ready for the offensive) 14.♕e2 ♘xd3+ 15.♕xd3 (15.cxd3 b4 16.♘a4 ♘xe3 17.♕xe3 e5! looks satisfactory for Black) 15...♖c8 16.♔b1 ♕c7∞ with mutual chances.

13.♔b1



13...♘e5

The critical move, and also the most consistent with the previous strategy; nevertheless, Black has tried many others:

○ 13...♗e7 is natural, but it looks a bit too slow: 14.h4 ♘e5 (14...b4!? 15.♘ce2 d5 16.h5!± and White is ready for g5-g6) 15.f4 ♘ec4 16.♕f2 ♘xe3 17.♕xe3 b4 (17...♖xc3!? is thematic and acceptable here, but probably doesn't fully equalize: 18.bxc3 ♘a4 19.♘e2±) 18.♘ce2 ♕c7 19.h5 ♘c4 20.♕g3! (provoking 20...0-0) 20...0-0 21.♕h3!? (21.g6 ♗f6 22.gxh7+ ♔h8 23.♗xc4 ♕xc4 24.e5±) 21...♖fe8 22.g6± De La Riva Aguado-Gofshtein, Castellar 1995.

○ 13...b4 Seeking the thematic liberation, but this may be premature: 14.♘ce2 d5 15.exd5 ♘xd5 16.g6!? (16.♘f4!?, preparing blows on g6 and e6, deserves a try) 16...hxg6 17.♘xe6 ♕a5! (a necessary intermediate move; 17...♕e7 18.♘2f4 ♘xe3 19.♕xe3 g5 20.♕a7 gxf4 21.♕xb7 ♖b8 22.♕c7 ♖h6 23.♘xf8+−; 17...fxe6 18.♗xg6+ ♔e7 19.♘d4±) 18.♘xf8 ♔xf8 19.♗d4 ♘7f6± (Dembo-Vasilevich, Yugoslavia 2002). This position is impossible to assess with just one example, but White has more assets: bishop pair, connected rooks. 20.h4 ♕c7 21.♗f2 ♔g8 22.♘d4∞.

14.♕e1!

Mamedov's speciality: the Azeri player keeps on scoring well with it. **14.f4** is the most straightforward, but after 14...♘bc4! (less precise is 14...♘ec4?! 15.♕f2 ♘xe3 16.♕xe3 ♘c4 17.♕h3!± intending g5-g6, which would give White a good initiative) 15.♕e2 ♘xd3 16.cxd3 b4 17.♘a4 ♕a5 (De La Riva Aguado-Simutowe, Istanbul ol 2000) Black is better.

14...b4

O 14...♘ec4 allows White to regroup: 15.♗c1! g6 16.h4 ♗g7 17.♘ce2 d5 18.h5 ♕e7 and now 19.h6! is strong (19.hxg6 Papaioannou-Graf, Bled ol 2002): 19...♗e5 20.f4 dxe4 (20...♗c7 21.e5±) 21.♗xc4 ♗xd4 22.♗xb5+ axb5 23.♘xd4±;

O 14...♗e7 15.h4 d5!? is one of the moves that has given Black better results, but in my opinion White gets good attacking chances after 16.♕g3 (16.exd5 ♘xd3 17.♖xd3 ♘xd5 Korneev-Corrales Jimenez, Bergamo 2009), for example: 16...♘bc4 17.exd5 ♘xe3 18.♕xe5 ♘xd1 19.♖xd1 0-0 20.dxe6 with great initiative; or 16...♘xd3 17.cxd3 0-0 18.h5 with attack.

15.♘ce2 d5

The natural reaction, but in the future we'll see other Black moves: **15...♘xd3** 16.cxd3 d5 17.h4↑; **15...♘bc4?!** 16.♕xb4!±.

16.h4

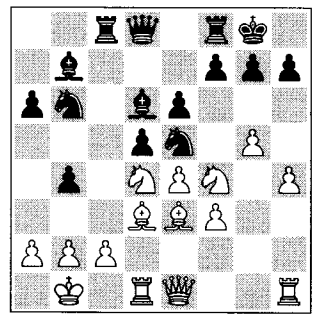
Just speeding up the attack.

16...♗d6

16...dxe4 17.♗xe4 ♗xe4 18.fxe4± and in spite of the strong post on e5, White's initiative is really strong.

17.♘f4 0-0

17...dxe4 18.♗xe4 ♗xe4 19.fxe4 0-0 20.♘dxe6!±.



18.g6!?

This leads to great complications, but puts Black on the defensive.

18.♘fxe6 leads to terrible complications too: 18...fxe6 19.♘xe6 ♕e7 (19...♕e8 20.♘xf8 ♘xd3! – 20...♕xf8 21.♗xb6+– – 21.cxd3 ♘a4 22.♘xh7 ♔xh7) 20.♘xf8 ♘bc4.

18...♘a4?!

This makes e6 too weak. 18...hxg6 19.h5 g5 is critical, but the black king is running a great risk after 20.h6!→.

19.gxf7+ ♖xf7 20.♘fxe6 ♕e8 21.♖g1±

It is clear that White, apart from his material advantage, has the initiative as well.

21...g6 22.h5 ♖f6 23.hxg6 ♘xg6

23...hxg6 24.♘g5+– followed by ♕h4 and ♖h1.

24.♘g5 ♗e5 25.♘xh7!

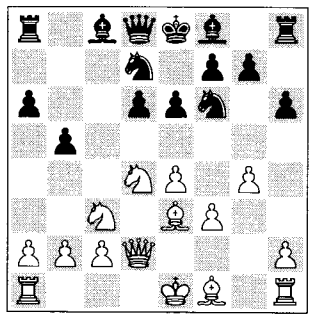
This knight continues its destructive task in Black's pawn mass.

25...♔xh7 26.exd5 ♗xd5 27.♕h4+ ♔g8 28.♗xg6+– ♖xg6 29.♖xg6+ ♕xg6 30.♖g1 ♕xg1+ 31.♗xg1 ♖e8 32.♕g5+ ♔f8 33.♗e3 ♗f7 34.♘c6 ♗g7 35.♗c5+ ♘xc5 36.♕xc5+ ♔g8 37.♘e7+ ♔h8 38.♕g5 1-0

Game 18.07

Zhigalko,Andrey
Krämer,Martin
Pardubice 2006

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 a6 6.♗e3 e6 7.f3 b5 8.♕d2 ♘bd7 9.g4 h6



The idea of this move is to delay the push g4-g5. This has been the main line for many years and still today the most frequent choice according to my database, though the sounder 9...♘b6 is replacing it. The drawbacks of moving the pawn are evident: Black virtually gives up ...0-0 and weakens the g6-square, so when the white pawn gets there, the consequences will be serious. There is a lot of theory, and it is all about very concrete variations: there is no way to escape with a marginal idea.

10.0-0-0 ♗b7

Black continues his preparations for the liberating move ...d5. This patient attitude is justified, as the black king will stay in the centre. Let's see the alternatives:

O 10...b4?! 11.♘ce2 d5 may backfire, as Black is not fully developed. Despite many tries, the second player has scored terribly. **12.exd5 ♘xd5 13.♘f4** and White, who is threatening 14.♘xe6, turns the opening of the centre in his favour. **13...♘7f6** 13...♘xe3 14.♕xe3 (threatening 15.♘xe6) 14...♕b6 15.♗c4 (15.♘fxe6! fxe6 16.♕e4 ♗b7 17.♕g6+ ♔e7 18.♗c4 looks winning) 15...♗b7 16.♗xe6 fxe6 17.♘fxe6 ♔f7 18.♕b3 ♔f6?! 19.h4+– K.Szabo-Guliev, Zalakaros 2008. **14.♗c4 ♘xe3** 14...♗b7 15.♖he1 ♘xf4 16.♗xf4 ♗c5 17.♗e5± Vorobiov-Gabrielian, Moscow 2007; White has a strong attack, both in the centre and on the enemy kingside (if ...0-0, then g4-g5). **15.♕xe3 ♗c5** At least one of the deadly knights must be pinned. For example: 15...♕c7? 16.♗xe6! fxe6 17.♘dxe6+–; 15...♕a5? 16.♘c6+–; 15...♕b6!? 16.♖he1 ♗e7 17.♗d5 ♖b8 18.♗c6+± Nevednichy-Vasiesiu, Bucharest 1997. Now **16.♕e5 ♗xd4 17.♖xd4 ♕e7 18.♖e1!±** and Black is unlikely to stop all the threats, h2-h4 and g4-g5, ♘d5 etc.

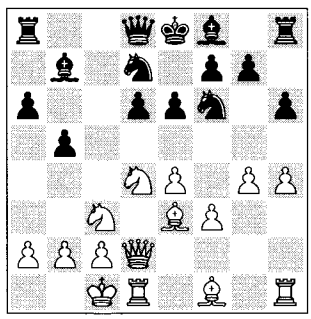
O 10...♕c7, with similar ideas to the previous line, looks slow in an attacking race: **11.h4 b4 12.♘ce2 d5 13.exd5 ♘xd5 14.♘f4 ♘7f6 15.♗d3** Again the threats of sacrifices on e6 and the push g4-g5 are in the air.

O 10...♘e5 Since White is preparing to push his kingside pawns, this move doesn't interfere with his plans; instead, the knight will become a target of the f-pawn. The Cuban player Ortiz Suarez has championed this plan. **11.a3!?** It is

OK to consolidate the position of the c3 knight, but I suggest the more ambitious and untested 11.♕g2!?, e.g.: 11...b4 (11...♗b7 12.h4; 11...g5!? 12.h4±) 12.♘b1 ♕a5 (12...♗b7 13.h4 g6 14.g5 hxg5 15.hxg5 ♖xh1 16.♕xh1 ♘h5 17.f4 ♘g4 18.♗g1 e5 19.♕h4!±) 13.f4 ♘exg4 14.e5 ♘d5 15.♕xg4 ♘xe3 16.♕f3 ♘d5 17.♗c4 (17.f5!?) 17...♗b7 18.f5! (with a strong attack) 18...0-0-0 19.fxe6 ♘b6 (19...♘c3 20.♕h3!) 20.♘c6 ♕c5 21.♗xa6+−. **11...♘fd7** 11...♗b7 12.♖g1 d5 13.f4!± ♘exg4?! 14.e5 ♘xe3 15.♕xe3 b4 (15...♘d7 16.f5±) 16.exf6+− Berescu-Dumitrache, Bucharest 2005. **12.♖g1** 12.h4 may be more accurate. **12...g5 13.h4! ♖g8 14.♗e2** 14.hxg5 hxg5 15.♖h1± looks the logical follow-up. 14...♗b7 15.♔b1 ♖c8 16.hxg5 hxg5 17.♖h1 ♗e7 18.♖h6 ♘c4 19.♗xc4 ♖xc4 20.♕h2 ♘f8 21.♕d2? ♘g6 22.♘de2 ♘e5 23.♖h3 ♖c8 24.b3 ♕a5 25.♔b2?! d5 26.exd5? ♘c4+ 0-1 J.Sanchez-Ortiz Suarez, San Juan 2008.

11.h4!?

This seems to be the strongest move, according to the experience gathered after many games. In my opinion, 11.♗d3 is still promising too.



11...b4

The only way to question White's fast offensive. Black has always scored badly with the alternatives:

O 11...♘e5 12.♗e2! (I think this is the best move, intending an immediate g4-g5 followed by f3-f4, but 12.♖g1 is similar) 12...♕a5 (12...b4 13.♘a4 ♕a5 14.b3± and 15.g5 is coming; 12...♖c8 13.a3!±, getting ready to push the g- and f-pawns consecutively) 13.g5 hxg5 14.hxg5 ♖xh1 15.♖xh1 ♘fd7 16.a3 0-0-0 17.f4 ♘c5!? 18.♘b3! ♘xb3+ 19.cxb3± The black king is weak and White has a strong attack, De La Villa Garcia-Novikov, Pamplona 1990/91.

O 11...♕a5 The idea is to take the a4-square away from the white knight; this strengthens the variation involving ♘ce2. For example: 12.♔b1 (12.♘b3!? ♕c7 13.♗e2) 12...b4 13.♘ce2 d5 14.♗h3! (with violent threats of sacrifices on e6) 14...dxe4 15.g5 hxg5 16.hxg5 exf3 17.♘g3 (Magem Badals-Vera, Barcelona 1990). The game has reached a critical moment, and here Black decided to give a piece; otherwise, White would have a fierce initiative: 17...♘d5 18.g6! fxg6 19.♘xe6→.

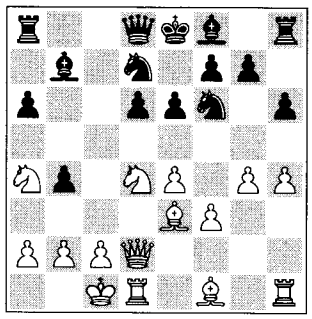
O 11...♘b6 is an idea tried by Malisauskas, with some links to the line studied in the previous game: Black takes control of the a4-square and threatens ...b4 followed by ...♘c4, but above all, Black gets ready to transfer his second knight to e5. However, in this case the knight manoeuvre is less sound due to the weakness of the kingside: 12.♗d3 ♘fd7 13.♕f2 (13.♘b3!?, intending to jump to a5, is a thematic idea that can work well here) 13...♖c8 14.♘ce2 ♕c7 15.♔b1 ♘a4 (Shabalov-Sorkin, Foxwoods 2007) and now: 16.♘g3 ♘e5 17.♘h5 and White's at-

tack becomes more dangerous: 17...♘c4 18.♗xc4 bxc4 19.c3.

O 11...♖c8 does nothing to stop the white offensive: 12.♗h3! (13.g5 is coming) 12...♘e5 13.g5 b4 14.♘a4 (14.♘ce2!? ♘fd7?! 15.♕xb4±) 14...♕a5 15.b3 ♘fd7 16.♔b1 ♘c4?! (16...♘xf3 17.♘xf3 ♗xe4 18.♘d4 (18.g6!?) 18...♗xh1 19.♖xh1 hxg5 20.hxg5± and two minor pieces are far superior to a rook in the middlegame) 17.bxc4 ♕xa4 18.g6!± and White's initiative allows him to exploit the weaknesses created around the enemy king, V.Sergeev-A.Pavlov, St Petersburg 2000.

12.♘a4

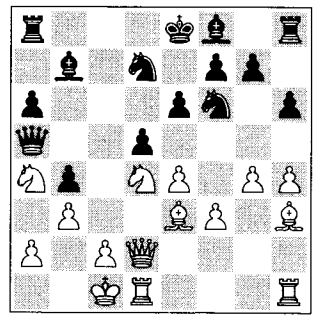
The most logical choice and, judging from experience, the best.



12...♕a5

Again the most critical reply, trying to exploit the drawbacks of White's knight on the edge.

Another very logical alternative is **12...d5** but this meets **13.♗h3!** and Black has failed to solve the problems produced by the threat g4-g5-g6: **13...♕a5** An immediate 13...g5 would not improve things: 14.♗g2 (threatening 15.hxg5) 14...gxh4 15.♖xh4 dxe4 (15...♘xe4 16.fxe4 ♕xh4 17.exd5 exd5 18.♗xd5! ♗xd5 19.♘f5+–) 16.g5 ♘d5 17.♖xe4 Kasparov-Van Wely, Wijk aan Zee 2000; and even though this position is extremely complex, it seems that Kasparov had everything under perfect control, as he has been able to show a refutation for all moves suggested for Black, e.g.: 17...♕a5 18.♘xe6! fxe6 19.♖xe6+ ♔f7 20.♕d3!!+– ♔xe6 21.♕e4+ ♘e5 22.♗h3+ ♔d6 23.♗c5+ ♕xc5 24.♘xc5 ♔xc5 25.♗e6+–. **14.b3** and now:



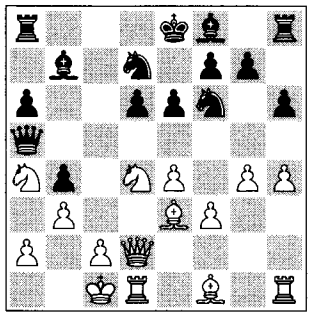
A) **14...♘c5?!** 15.g5 ♘xa4 16.bxa4 hxg5 17.hxg5 ♕xa4 18.♔b1! ♘d7 19.g6± (Butunoi-Dumitrescu, Romania tt-2 2000) and once again the black king's refuge is devastated;

B) **14...g5** 15.hxg5 hxg5 16.e5! ♘xe5 17.♗xg5 ♘fd7! (17...♗e7 18.♖de1 ♘c4 19.♕e2 followed by 20.♘xe6) 18.♕e2→ ♗c6 19.♘xc6 ♘xc6 20.f4 ♗e7 21.♗xe7 ♘xe7 22.f5 e5 23.g5± and White has a crushing attack without any material investment, for example: 23...♕b5 24.♕g2 (24.♕f3!) 24...f6 25.gxf6 ♘xf6 26.♕g7 (26.♕g3!) 26...♖f8∞ Zawadzka-Akesson, Warsaw rapid 2006;

C) **14...dxe4** Allowing White just to play g4-g5 is suspicious, but this position requires some tactical displays: 15.g5 hxg5 16.hxg5 exf3 (16...♘d5?

allows the classical coup de grace on g6: 17.g6!+− ♖xh3 18.♖xh3 ♘7f6 19.♖h8 0-0-0 20.gxf7 ♘c7 21.♕f2 ♕d5 22.♘b6+ Gaisin-Gabrielian, Internet 2006) 17.♘xe6! fxe6 (17...♖xh3? 18.gxf6 ♘xf6 19.♗b6+−) 18.♗xe6 ♖xh1 19.♗xd7+ ♔f7 20.♖xh1 ♘e4 (20...f2?! 21.♖f1 ♘e4 22.♖xf2+ ♔e7 23.♕d4 ♘xf2 24.♘c5+−) 21.g6+! (this position is extremely complex for over-the-board play, but after this move I don't think anyone will like to try Black's position again. 21.♕h2 ♗d6 22.g6+ ♔e7∓) 21...♔xg6?! (21...♔e7!? 22.♕d4 ♕d5 23.♕xd5 ♗xd5 24.♘b6 ♖d8 25.♖h5! ♖xd7 26.♘xd7 ♔xd7 27.♖xd5+ ♔e6 28.♖d4 ♔f5 29.♔d1 ♗e7 30.♔e1 ♗f6 31.♖c4±) 22.♕h2 ♔f7 23.♕f4+ ♘f6 24.♘b6 ♗e4 Lutz-Sammalvuo, Calvia ol 2004; and now, according to Lutz's analysis, White can get a clear edge with 25.♗d4!±.

13.b3



13...♘c5

Once again, the most critical. It seems that White is in trouble due to his unprotected a2 pawn but, with great efforts, he manages to gain a pawn and keep the initiative, even at the enormous expense of seriously weakening his castled position.

O 13...♗e7!? Interesting, in spite of its slow appearance; this is a subtle attempt to improve Black's position and leave White to declare his hand. So far no refutation has been found, and it may be an alternative to the hyper-analysed 13...♘c5. **14.♖h3!?** This is my choice, coming from an obscure e-mail game, aware that theory may move forward in any direction but unconvinced by the alternatives: 14.♗h3 g5! 15.♗g2 ♖g8∞; 14.♔b1 ♘c5 15.a3 ♘xa4 16.axb4 ♕c7 17.bxa4 d5 18.e5 ♘d7 19.f4 ♘b6⩲ Costantini-Arlandi, Montecatini Terme ch-ITA 2001. **14...♖c8** 14...♘c5?! 15.a3! and the rook is OK on h3; 14...0-0-0?! 15.g5 ♘h5 16.g6!±. **15.g5 ♘g8** 15...♘h5 16.♔b1 and White is ready to meet 16...♘c5 with 17.♘b2 and now resume his offensive, whereas the black king seems more exposed. **16.a3 d5 17.♔b1** 17.exd5 ♗xd5 18.♘f5 is very promising too. **17...♖d8?! 18.g6 ♖b8 19.gxf7+ ♔xf7 20.♖g3** and White has a strong attack, Pugh-Jankowitz, e-mail 2000.

O 13...d5 14.♗h3! transposing to the note to the previous move.

O 13...e5 hasn't been much tried, but seems to open lines for the enemy attack: 14.♘f5 d5 15.exd5 ♗xd5 16.♗g2± and White clearly has the initiative.

O 13...♖c8 14.♔b1! White even makes extra preparations before taking decisive action, though an immediate 14.♗h3 is interesting. **14...♘c5 15.♘xc5!** Now White has this alternative. **15...dxc5** 15...♖xc5 16.♗g2!± followed by 17.g5. **16.♘e2 ♗c6 17.♘g3** 17.♘f4!? followed by ♗c4 and g4-g5 is promising too. **17...♘d7 18.f4 ♗e7 19.♗d3 ♘b6 20.♕f2 ♘a8 21.g5± ♘c7 22.♘h5 ♘b5 23.♗xb5 axb5**

24.♘xg7+ ♔f8 25.♘xe6+ fxe6 26.f5 ♔e8 27.fxe6 1-0 Shirov-Svidler, Moscow tt 2002.

14.a3

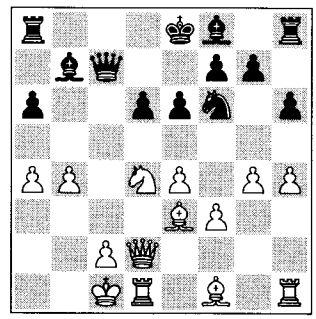
Only this move, which wins a pawn, can justify White's previous play.

14...♘xa4

O 14...♖c8 The first instance of this move dates from 2000, and it has quickly become an important and tremendously popular alternative. **15.♕xb4! ♕c7** 15...♕xb4 16.axb4 ♘xa4 17.bxa4 d5 18.b5 ♗a3+ 19.♔b1 dxe4 20.bxa6 ♗a8 21.g5 ♘d5 22.♗d2 e3 23.♗a5 ♔f8 24.♗b5± Zivkovic-Jadelholm, Olympiad cr 2000. The position is extremely complex but there is a feeling that white's messy queenside pawns are more dangerous. **16.♘xc5 dxc5 17.♕a4+ ♘d7 18.♘e2** White has won a pawn, closed the c-file and blocked the black pieces. It is unlikely that Black has enough compensation, but there have been many attempts to prove it. **18...c4** The most straightforward, but probably not the best. After 18...♗c6!? 19.♕xa6 ♖a8 20.♕c4 ♖xa3 (Gu Xiaobing-Sergeeva, Athens Wch-jr 2001) the position is complicated, but it looks as though the black pieces are unable to pose problems for the white king. For example: 21.♔b2! ♕a5 (21...♕a7 22.♘c3 ♘b6?! 23.♕d3 ♗e7 24.♗xc5+–) 22.♕c3 ♖a2+ 23.♔b1 ♕a7 24.♘c1±. **19.♗f4! ♕c6 20.♔b2! ♕xa4** 20...cxb3 21.♕xc6 ♖xc6 22.cxb3±. **21.bxa4 ♗e7 22.♗e3** I prefer this move played by Timoshenko, though Anand-Kasparov is not completely satisfactory for Black: 22.♘c3 ♗f6 23.♗e2 ♘b6 24.e5 ♗e7 (Anand-Kasparov, Moscow rapid 2002) and now 25.♔a2! ♘d5 26.♗d2 ♘xc3+ 27.♗xc3 ♗c6 28.a5±. **22...♘e5 23.♘d4 0-0 24.♗e2 ♖fd8 25.g5±.** Here a draw was agreed in Timoshenko-A.Maximenko, Halkidiki tt 2002, but in my opinion White has several small assets, although his last move could have been replaced by 25.♔a2, intending ♖b1.

O 14...♕c7?! doesn't work: 15.♕xb4 simply wins a pawn.

15.axb4 ♕c7 16.bxa4



This is an extremely tense situation, and very important for the evaluation of the whole system. White's castled position is very weak, but he has an extra pawn and attacking prospects against the enemy king in the centre. The theoretical debate has been tense for years but seems to have calmed down lately.

16...d5

A central strike is the logical reply.

O Apart from this, only **16...♘d7!?** has been tried: the idea is to transfer the knight to the queenside, and also to prepare ...d5 without allowing White to close the centre by means of e4-e5. This line is one of the most natural and the most dangerous for White. So far there is no clear refutation, though the stronger players have avoided it. **17.♔b1!?** is my suggestion. The king improves his posi-

tion a little and leaves the c-file for his pieces to use. Although many moves have been tried in this position, and this one is logical, it hasn't been tried yet, and we'll need many games before we can evaluate its virtues. 17.♘b3 is the most frequent try so far. The white pieces gather near the king to minimize weaknesses: 17...d5 18.♔b2 ♖c8?! (18...dxe4 looks more natural; 19.f4± with an extremely complex position, but White may have a better ending – ♕c3 is on the agenda –, attack with g4-g5 and a lead in development) 19.c3 (the immediate 19.exd5!? looks more logical but meets with 19...♗xb4! 20.♕xb4 ♕xc2+ 21.♔a3 ♕xd1∞ and this position needs a deep analysis) 19...♗e7 20.exd5 ♗xd5 21.♗xa6 (Cioara-Vorobiov, Pardubice 2001). White will have to get over many complications but his material advantage seems decisive. **17...♘b6** 17...♘e5 18.♗e2 ♗e7 (18...♖b8 19.♘b3±) 19.♗f4 0-0 20.g5 h5 21.♖hg1 ♖ab8 22.g6± and despite the open position of his king, it is White who possesses the initiative. **18.a5!** Forcing the knight to declare its intentions. **18...♘c4** After 18...♘a4 19.c4!± White's castled position is resilient, even if unusual, and the black knight is in trouble) **19.♕c3 ♖c8 20.♗xc4 ♕xc4 21.♕b3! ♕xb3+ 22.♘xb3 d5** 22...♗e7 23.h5 ♖c4 24.♖d4±. **23.♘c5! ♗xc5 24.♗xc5 dxe4 25.fxe4 ♗xe4 26.♖he1±** and the disparity in bishop activity makes the difference.

O 16...e5?! has a certain logic, because Black would like to play ...d5 without allowing e4-e5, but for the moment opening the centre like this just means a further exposure of the black king: **17.♘b3!** Here the knight is a good defender and may jump to important posts such as a5 and c5 (since Black is going to play ...d5). **17...d5 18.exd5 ♖d8** 18...♗xd5 19.♘c5 ♗xc5 20.♗xc5 ♗xf3 21.♗g2 ♗xd1 22.♖xd1± and the white bishops control the board, D.Mastrovasilis-P.Smirnov, Patras Ech-jr 2001. **19.♖e1! ♘xd5 20.♗c5!** The strong point c5 defends the white king, whereas his black counterpart won't find refuge in the centre, nor on the kingside. **20...♗xc5 21.♘xc5 0-0 22.g5±** with a very strong attack, Ivarez-Siefring, cr 2000.

17.e5

Logically White closes the centre and strengthens the outpost on d4 for his knight.

17...♘d7

17...♕xe5? 18.♗f4+–.

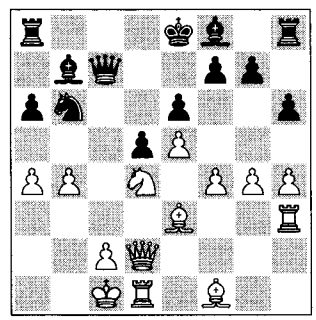
18.f4

Now the threat f4-f5 is hanging over Black and it is hard to decide which king is safer.

18...♘b6

The knight hits the two weaknesses in White's camp. Of course, White would like to play 19.b3 but, unless his opponent goes miles away from the board...

19.♖h3!



Transferring the rook to the queenside is not only full of logic, but so far the most effective. 19.f5!? has been analysed over and over and looks like a draw.

19...♖c8

○ 19...♘c4?! Black is blocking his own attacking lines; this move has lost support. **20.♕c3! ♖c8 21.♗d2** 21.♗f2!? **21...♗e7** 21...♘xd2 22.♕xd2 ♕b6?! 23.a5 and now Black can't take on b4, which is the ♖h3's 'fault'. **22.♗e1±** After consolidating his queenside as much as possible, White is ready to inflict damage on the potential black castled position. **22...♖b8** Logical, aiming at b4, but this loosens the grip on c4. 22...♕d7!? 23.♕b3 0-0. **23.f5 ♗c8 24.♗xc4 dxc4 25.♕f3! ♗d7** The only move to renew the threat on b4. **26.fxe6 fxe6 27.g5 hxg5 28.hxg5 ♖xh3 29.♕xh3 ♕xe5 30.♕h5+ ♔f8 31.♘f3 ♕e3+** (Kasparov-Topalov, Wijk aan Zee 2001) and now Kasparov's notes in *Informator 82* state that he should have played **32.♗d2!** with an edge in the two critical lines: 32...♕a3+ 33.♔b1 ♖xb4+! (33...♗d6? 34.♕h8+ ♔f7 35.g6+ ♔f6 36.♗g5+ ♔xg6 37.♘h4++–) 34.♗xb4 ♕xb4+ 35.♔c1 ♕a3+ 36.♔d2 ♕b2 37.♕h8+ ♔f7 38.♔e3 ♗c6?! 39.♕h5+ ♔g8 40.g6+–.

○ 19...♘xa4!? It is hard to find something more logical than the pawn grab, taking control of the c3-square as well. **20.♗f2** Making way for the flying rook. **20...♖c8 21.♗e1** Strengthening the grip on the points c3 and b4, and now:

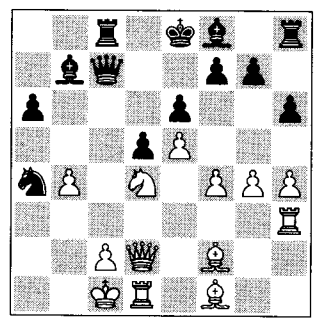
A) **21...♖b8?!** 22.♖a3! ♕d7 23.f5± with a clear initiative;

B) **21...♗e7!?** may be the best: 22.b5! ♖a8 (22...0-0 23.bxa6 ♗c6 24.♕a5±) 23.♕a5 ♕xa5 24.♗xa5 axb5 25.♗xb5+ ♔f8 26.♗xa4 ♖xa5 27.♖b3 ♖xa4 28.♖xb7± and the bad position of the black king allows White to claim some advantage;

C) **21...h5** 22.f5 hxg4 23.♖a3 ♘b6 24.fxe6± Libiszewski-Arlandi, Pula tt 2003;

D) **21...♘b6?!** (heading for c4) 22.f5! (more energetic than 22.♖a3, White's first choice) 22...♘c4 (22...♕xe5?! 23.fxe6 fxe6? 24.♖e3+–; 22...♗e7!? 23.fxe6 fxe6 24.♕d3 and although White's 'material' threats are strong, the black king can hide at some cost: 24...0-0∞) 23.♗xc4 ♕xc4 24.♖b3 (24.fxe6 fxe6 and the move suggested in DLS, 25.♖f3!?, waiting before taking on e6, remains untested; the only good reply is 25...♗e7! (25...♔d7? 26.♕f4+–; 25...♕a2?! 26.♕d3±; 25...♖c7? 26.♘xe6) 26.♕d3 ♕xd3 27.♖dxd3 ♔d7 28.♖f7 g5 29.♖df3±) 24...♗c6 25.fxe6 fxe6 (Kovchan-Benza, Sochi tt-2 2007) and now 26.♕f4!, with the threats ♖f3 and ♖c3, puts Black in trouble: 26...♗b7 27.♖f3 ♕c7 28.♗d2 (to triple along the f-file) 28...♕e7 29.♖df1 ♗c6 30.♕g3 ♗b5 31.♖f7+–.

20.♗f2 ♘xa4



20...h5!? is an attempt to loosen (or close) the kingside before developing an initiative on the other wing, but it

loses a tempo. **21.f5!** Leading to terrible complications, analysed in a correspondence game. Perhaps the simple 21.g5 keeps everything in order for White. **21...hxg4** 21...♘c4 22.♗xc4 hxg4 23.♗xa6 gxh3 24.♗b5+ ♔d8 25.fxe6 ♕c3 26.♕xc3 ♖xc3 27.exf7 ♗xb4 28.♖f1 h2 29.♗e1 ♗a3+ 30.♔d1 ♖h3 31.♖h1± L.Jakobetz; 21...♘xa4 22.fxe6 hxg4 23.exf7+ ♔xf7 24.♕f4+ ♔g8 25.♕xg4 ♖h6 26.♗e1 ♕xe5 27.♖a3 ♘b6 28.♗d2 ♖f6 29.♖e1± Jakobetz. **22.♖b3 ♘c4** 22...♗e7?! 23.fxe6 fxe6 24.♕e2 0-0 25.♗g3±. **23.♕e2 exf5 24.♘xf5 ♕d7** 24...♘xe5 25.♗d4 f6 26.♖c3 ♕xc3!? 27.♗xc3 ♖xc3 28.♗g2±. **25.♘d6+!** 25.♕xg4 ♕xa4 26.♗xc4 ♖xc4 27.♘xg7+ ♗xg7 28.♕xg7 ♕xb3 29.♕xh8+ ♔d7 30.♖d2 ♕a2 (30...♕a3+ 31.♔d1 ♖xb4 32.♕f6 ♕a1+ 33.♔e2 ♖e4+ 34.♔f3 ♕xe5 35.♕xf7+=) 31.e6+ fxe6. **25...♗xd6 26.exd6+ ♔f8 27.♖d4! ♖h6 28.♕xg4 ♕xa4 29.♗xc4 dxc4 30.♖g3!±** Jakobetz-Cardelli, cr 2002.

21.c4!

Though the old move 21.♗e1 (see the second note after 19...♖c8) did its work, the rise of this surprising move, hard to understand without computer modules, is likely to dispose of 19...♖c8. White closes ranks around his king... by moving forward all the pawns in the castled position!

21...dxc4

Otherwise the pawn would reach c5: 21...♗e7 22.♕c2 ♘b6 23.c5 ♘d7 24.♖a3±.

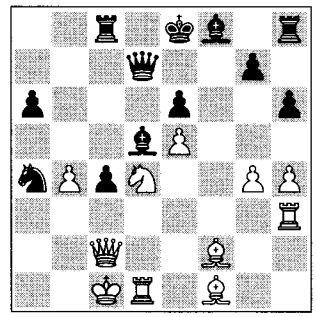
22.♕c2!

Actually a wicked attack on the king and the g6-square.

22...♕d7

22...♘b6 23.♘xe6! fxe6 24.♗xb6 ♕xb6 25.♕g6+ ♔e7 26.f5+−.

23.f5 ♗d5 24.fxe6 fxe6



25.♖a3

25.♖f3!? is equally effective: 25...♔d8? 26.♕g6 ♔c7 27.♖f7+− ♗e7 28.♘f5 ♖ce8 29.♖xd5 ♕xd5 30.♘xe7 ♕h1 31.♘d5+ ♔c8 32.♘e3 ♕c6 33.♗g2 ♕b6 1-0 Alsina Leal-Tattersall, Leon 2006.

25...♗xb4 26.♖xa4 a5

In a position like this, being a piece up is not enough reason to be at ease.

27.♕g6+! ♕f7?!

27...♔f8 (ugly but necessary to force White to prove something) 28.♖a2! c3 29.♘c2+−.

28.♕xf7+ ♔xf7 29.♘c2 ♖b8 30.♖d4 ♖hc8 31.♗e1 ♗c6 32.♖a1 ♗d5 33.♘xb4 axb4 34.♖a4 b3 35.♗xc4!+−

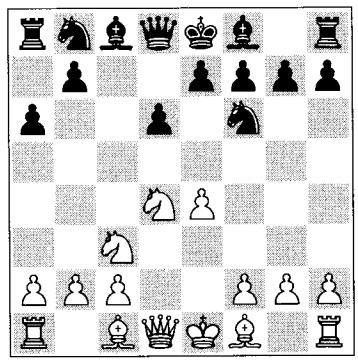
And now, yes, White's extra piece is decisive.

35...♖c5 36.♔b2 ♗xc4 37.♖dxc4 ♖xe5 38.♖c7+ ♔g8 39.♗c3 ♖e2+ 40.♔b1 e5 41.♖aa7 1-0

SUMMARY
1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e6 6.♗e3
– 6...♘c6 (without ...a6): very solid, though somewhat passive ±/=
– 6...a6 7.f3 ♕c7 (and its transpositions): Black's counterplay is slow. Comfortable for White ±
6...a6 7.♕d2 ♘c6 8.f3 with the following options:
– 8...d5: solid, but passive ±
– 8...♗e7 9.0-0-0 d5: passive and slightly incorrect ±
– 8...♗e7 9.0-0-0 0-0 10.g4 ♖b8: not very flexible ±
– 8...♗e7 9.0-0-0 0-0 10.g4 ♘d7: complex, but White's initiative looks stronger ±
– 8...♗e7 9.0-0-0 0-0 10.g4 ♘xd4: one of the main lines, but so far 11.♕xd4 has set Black many problems ±
6...a6 7.♕d2 b5 8.f3 and now:
– 8...b4!?: modern, enterprising and complex. Room for research ±/=
– 8...♕a5: an interesting idea, but White develops a dangerous initiative ±
– 8...h5: wants to prevent g2-g4, but White can switch to plans with 0-0 by playing 9.a4! ±
6...a6 7.♕d2 b5 8.f3 ♘bd7 9.g4 ♘b6
The most reliable line. Against it, good preparation is necessary to get something, if that is possible at all ±/=
6...a6 7.♕d2 b5 8.f3 ♘bd7 9.g4 h6
The main line, though it looks in crisis. White should play 10.0-0-0 ♗b7 11.h4 and now:
– 11...♘e5: risky, White's attack is very strong ±
– 11...♕a5: more dangerous than the previous line ±
– 11...♘b6: a clever new idea, but White's attack is still dangerous ±
– 11...♖c8: similar to the previous lines ±
– 11...b4 12.♘a4 d5: logical reaction, but Black is still in danger ±
11...b4 12.♘a4 ♕a5 13.b3 and now:
– 13...♗e7!?: an interesting idea, not very analysed and solid ±/=
– 13...e5?!: provokes a very dangerous opening of the game ±
13...♘c5 14.a3 with the following branches:
– 14...♖c8: perhaps the most solid, but White secures a better ending ±
– 14...♘xa4 15.axb4 ♕c7 16.bxa4 ♘d7: not very analysed yet, but after 17.♔b1! White stands better ±/±
– 14...♘xa4 15.axb4 ♕c7 16.bxa4 d5: the main variation. Hyperanalysed and still very complex, but difficult for Black ±

CHAPTER 19

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 a6 Najdorf Variation



Evaluation *****

Introduction

The Najdorf Variation is acknowledged as the most important Sicilian system, and its great merit has kept this appreciation for some decades. Can we state the reasons for this? For sure, its theoretical viability is one, but also its apparently inexhaustible potential to lead to positions rich in tactical and strategic themes, which guarantee hard-fought games and chances to play for a win as Black.

Our recommendation against the Najdorf is the usual set-up with f2-f3, ♗e3, ♕d2 and queenside castling, which again competes with 6.♗g5 for the preferences of White players. Its theoretical development is enormous, and one has to keep up-to-date with the latest contributions, specially those from elite tournaments.

History

Probably the 19th century players regarded 5...a6 as very passive because, unlike most Sicilian variations, it does not appear in any game played by the pioneers, such as Paulsen or Anderssen. The first instance in my database is Yates-Tartakower, Budapest 1926, but Tartakower soon played ...g6 and thus the game went to typical Dragon positions, a more appreciated set-up in those times. Then, we have games of the Dutch players Van den Bosch and Noteboom, in which already appear ideas of a quick ...b5, and even ...e5. From there the system was adopted by Czech players, specially Opocensky, who insisted on ...e5. In the 1940s, the just naturalized Argentinean Miguel Najdorf started using it regularly, achieving good results and, with his extraordinary personality, spreading the idea to his fellow countrymen and some other players.

Curiously enough, the Soviet School (despite some experiences of Kotov and Alatortsev), took the white side in the beginning. Its best representatives de-

veloped the formidable attack 6.♗g5, which was for decades the scourge of the Najdorf. However, the definite rise to the position of main variation within the Sicilian, which the Najdorf still enjoys today, was due to Fischer, who adopted this defence as his main weapon against 1.e4. The formidable attack 6.♗g5 had to face a great many new developments, but it found trouble, above all, against the bold Poisoned Pawn variation. In this line Black loses a lot of time with the queen and boldly captures the b2 pawn. It wasn't until the 1980s that a group of English players, particularly Nunn, Short, Adams and Chandler, made popular a new set-up. This set-up managed to outshine the old main line and was named the English Attack. That is our recommendation in this book.

Ideas

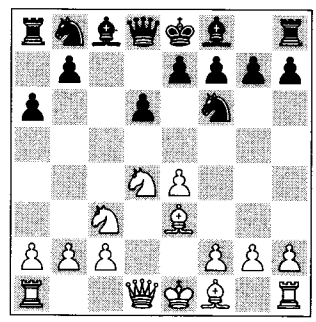
The original idea of ...a6 is to control the b5-square, thus allowing an eventual ...e5, to fight for the centre in favourable conditions. Also, it supports a potential ...b5, launching the classical minority attack, typical in the Sicilian. What its first users couldn't foretell was that those simple ideas would develop so far and it would become for many decades the basis of the plans of counterplay for the best chessplayers in the world.

In the set-up we propose for White, the most frequent ideas are similar to those shown in other chapters, though with some distinctive features. The d5-square is weak, so very often White doesn't rush his kingside attack, but rather focuses on queenside control. This is specially so in positions where the pawn structure is modified when White recaptures with a pawn on d5 after a white knight is exchanged off. Black has developed some set-ups (above all, ...h5) which can be met by a non-standard plan: 0-0 combined with the move a2-a4. However, attacking races with opposite castled positions, though infrequent among experienced players, are the basis of both sides' thinking at all times.

Game 19.01

Svidler,Peter
Grischuk,Alexander
Mexico City Wch 2007

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 a6 6.♗e3



This is the position we will study in this chapter. White's plan is already well-known: defence of e4 by means of f2-f3, queenside castling and a pawn storm on the kingside; the exact details may vary. At this moment, White could avoid the 6...♘g4 variation by inserting 6.f3. Both moves are possible and may be used depending on our repertoire and our opponent's. I have chosen the 6.♗e3 move order because of some small details. Nowadays, 6...♘g4 is in trouble due to the new idea 10.h3, whereas against 6.f3, both 6...♕b6 and 6...b5 seem to me quite sound.

6...♘g4

Since in this game we are going to study other moves than 6...e5 and 6...e6, it is only logical that we take this knight jump as the main line. After all, its interest exceeds by far that of the rest of moves. Even so, we'll have a look at those alternatives; some of them have a certain interest.

O 6...♕c7 A preparatory move, as 6...b5 has some drawbacks; another idea is to try to manage without ...e6. White can follow the usual plans, and Black will probably have to end up playing ...e6 or ...e5, transposing to known positions. However, White must be alert to reach favourable transpositions and prevent a timely ...e5. **7.♕d2 b5** 7...e5 8.♘b3 transposes to the next game and 7...e6, to the previous chapter. **8.f3 ♘bd7** 8...e5 9.♘f5!±. **9.0-0-0 ♗b7 10.g4! ♘e5** 10...h6!? 11.♔b1 (11.a3 e6 12.h4 with the classical assault). **11.g5 ♘fd7 12.f4 ♘c4 13.♗xc4 ♕xc4 14.b3 ♕c7 15.♘d5!±** Finally, sparing ...e6 has proved a drawback. **15...♗xd5 16.exd5 ♖c8 17.♖he1 g6 18.♘c6+−** Zecevic-Kavsek, Portoroz 1994.

O 6...b5?! Logical, but premature on tactical grounds: **7.a4! b4** 7...e5 8.♘b3 b4 9.♘d5±; 7...bxa4 8.♖xa4± leaves an eternal weakness on a6. **8.♘d5 ♘xe4?!** The pawn grab looks suspicious and leads to disaster. Somewhat better is 8...♘xd5 9.exd5 ♗b7 10.♗c4 ♕c7 11.♗b3 ♘d7 12.0-0 ♘b6, but White has a clear grip: 13.♖e1 (13.♘f5±) 13...♘xd5 14.♗xd5 ♗xd5 15.♘b5 axb5 16.♕xd5 ♖b8 17.axb5+− M.D.Tseitlin-Durban Piera, Benasque Open 1993. **9.♘b5! ♗b7 10.♘c7+ ♔d7 11.♘xa8 1-0** Edwards-Berzanskis, cr 1988.

O 6...♘bd7 is another attempt to prepare ...b5 and start counterplay without the move ...e6. This move has drawn the attention of researchers like Larsen and Ivanchuk. **7.g4!** But this is the problem! Now the d7 knight is taking the natural retreat square from its colleague. **7...d5!?** 7...h6 is the other logical choice: 8.♖g1 g6 9.h4 with initiative, Z.Varga-Tate, Budapest 1997; 7...♘c5 is an idea championed by Larsen, but the knight is pointless here against a well-defended e4 pawn: 8.f3 h6 9.♕d2 e5 10.♘b3 ♗e6 11.0-0-0 ♕c7 12.♔b1 ♗e7 13.h4 0-0-0 14.♘d5!± Cu.Hansen-Larsen, Taastrup ch-DEN 1998. **8.♘b3!** This move has pushed the 6...♘bd7 variation out of play. The d5 pawn is threatened and events are speeded up. **8...♘xe4** 8...dxe4 9.g5±; 8...h5!? 9.g5 ♘g4 10.g6!± De la Paz Perdomo-Gongora Reyes, Santa Clara 2000. **9.♘xd5 ♘d6** 9...e6 10.♘b6!± **10.♕e2 e6 11.♗f4 ♘b6 12.♘xb6 ♕xb6 13.0-0-0±** Sax-Radulov, Baile Herculane zt 1982.

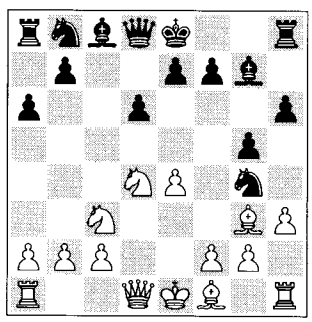
O 6...♘c6 Another rare move, but really logical and especially more flexible than the others. Black keeps the option of trading knights on d4 and then playing ...e5, or ...e6, or even a direct ...d5, depending on White's reply. **7.f3** White waits before moving his queen too, and forces Black to commit himself further. **7...d5!?** This is sound and close to equality. With 7...♘xd4?! 8.♕xd4 the queen is developed to d4 in one go; 7...g6 transposes to a weak Dragon Variation; 7...e5 8.♘b3 ♗e7 9.♕d2 leads to a position that may arise in the 6...e5 variation, but the knight is poorly placed on c6: 9...0-0 10.0-0-0 ♗e6 11.♘d5!± (the fact that the black knight is on c6 multiplies the strength

of this standard move) 11...♘xd5?! 12.exd5 ♗xd5 13.♕xd5 ♘b4 14.♕d2 d5 15.♔b1 d4 16.♗f2+–. There is not enough compensation, Hoffman-Gajate, cr 1999. **8.♕e2!** The only serious attempt at refutation. **8...e5** In case of 8...♘xd4?! 9.♗xd4 dxe4 10.0-0-0± White has enormous compensation; after 8...dxe4 9.♘xc6 bxc6 10.♘xe4±, development and better structure are White's trumps; 8...e6 is perhaps the most solid: 9.0-0-0 ♗b4 10.exd5 ♘xd5 11.♘xd5 ♕xd5 12.♘xc6 ♕xc6 13.♕c4±. **9.♘xc6 bxc6 10.exd5 ♘xd5 11.0-0-0 ♗e6 12.♗d2!?** An interesting improvement, pre-empting what Sutovsky probably had prepared. 12.♕c4!? ♕c8 13.♘xd5 ♗xd5 14.♕a4± was Llobel Cortell-Daubenfeld, Halkidiki jr 2001. **12...♕c7 13.♖e1** The key move, which more or less secures the bishop pair for White. **13...♗d6** 13...f6?! 14.f4. **14.♘e4 ♗e7** 14...f6?! 15.♘xd6+ ♕xd6 16.f4±. **15.♘g5 ♗xg5** 15...♗d7 16.f4. **16.♗xg5 f6 17.♗d2±** Shabalov-Sutovsky, Istanbul ol 2000.

O 6...e6 transposes to the previous chapter on the Scheveningen;

O 6...e5 appears in the rest of the games of this chapter.

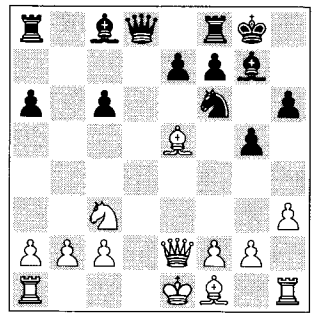
7.♗g5 h6 8.♗h4 g5 9.♗g3 ♗g7 10.h3!?



The most recent move and, in my opinion, the one that sets the most problems. 10.♗e2 and 10.♕d2 used to be the most frequent choices.

10...♘e5

10...♘f6 has been especially Judit Polgar's pet move, but the plan chosen by White in this game is straightforward and clear: **11.♕e2!?** We still have few examples, which always casts some doubts and makes us be alert, but the queen looks far better placed here than on f3. **11...♘c6** 11...♗d7 12.0-0-0 ♘c6 13.♘xc6± equally followed by e4-e5; 11...♘bd7?! 12.♘f5±; 11...♕b6!? 12.0-0-0 ♘c6 13.♘f5 ♗xf5 14.exf5 0-0 15.h4∞ may be the subject of theoretical debates in the future. **12.♘xc6 bxc6 13.e5 dxe5 14.♗xe5 0-0** and now:



A) Tireless analyst Lubomir Ftacnik suggests a modest but healthy positional approach, which nobody has adopted so far: **15.g3** ♗e6 (15...a5!? is not so strong here due to 16.♗g2 ♗a6 17.♕e3 ♕d7 18.♕d4 ♕xd4 19.♗xd4 e5 20.♗xe5 ♖fe8 21.f4 gxf4 22.gxf4 ♘d5 23.♗xd5 ♗xe5 24.fxe5 ♖xe5+ 25.♗e4 f5 26.♖g1+ ♔f7 27.0-0-0 fxe4 28.♖d7+±) 16.♗g2 ♕b6 17.0-0-0 (17.♖b1 followed by 0-0 and an eventual b2-b3 looks good too) 17...♖fd8 18.f4±;

B) Leinier Dominguez may have even improved this idea with **15.g4!?**; apart from making way for the bishop, this prevents ...♗f5 and fixes the black pawn on g5 in order to attack it. But after 15...a5, 16.h4!? is perhaps too ambitious (16.♗g2 ♗a6 17.♕e3 ♕d7 18.♕d4± secures a small edge): 16...♗xg4 17.f3 ♗f5 18.hxg5 hxg5 19.♕e3 a4 20.♕xg5 ♗g6 21.♗d3 a3! and after this annoying pawn push, Black secured some counterplay, though this position is still interesting for White.

11.♘f5

The most ambitious choice: White immediately occupies one of the holes in the enemy position and forces the second player to give up one bishop. In the resulting position Black has active piece play, but it doesn't seem to compensate for the serious weaknesses on his light squares.

11...♗xf5 12.exf5 ♘bc6

12...♘bd7 helps control the f6-square, but doesn't solve all the problems: 13.h4! ♕a5 (13...♕b6 14.♘d5!) 14.♕d5! ♕b4 (14...♕xd5 15.♘xd5 ♖c8 16.0-0-0± and there is no real compensation for the bishop pair) 15.♕b3 ♘c6 16.0-0-0 ♖c8 17.♘d5 ♕xb3 18.axb3± ♘d4? 19.f6! ♖xc2+ 20.♔b1 ♘xf6 21.♘e3+– Areschenko-Nitin, New Delhi 2009.

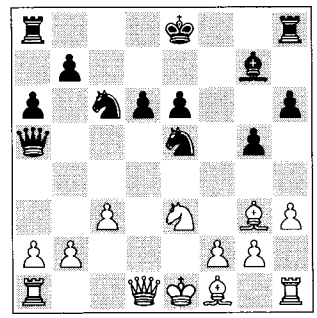
13.♘d5 e6

13...0-0 14.♗e2 e6 15.fxe6 fxe6 16.♘e3 transposes to 13...e6.

14.fxe6 fxe6 15.♘e3 ♕a5+

15...0-0 16.♗e2 d5 (16...♕e7 17.0-0 ♖ad8 18.♗h5! ♔h8 19.♖e1 – 19.c4!?± – 19...d5 20.a4 ♘c4?! 21.♘xc4 dxc4 22.♕g4± Kasimdzhanov-Anand, San Luis Wch 2005; Black is going through hell because of the missing light-squared bishop) 17.0-0 ♘g6 18.c3! (18.c4 d4!∞ and Black may have some activity) 18...♘f4 19.♗g4! ♕e7 20.♖e1 ♘e5 (Cheparinov-Sakaev, Dos Hermanas 2003) and now 21.♘c2!, opening the e-file and heading for the d4-square: 21...♘xg4 22.hxg4 ♕c5 23.♘d4±.

16.c3



16...♘f3+?!

Played several times by Ibarra Jerez in games not found in databases and, finally, against Cheparinov in Roquetas 2004, this move enabled Topalov to surprise and score an important victory in the San Luis World Championship. Of course, new analysis appeared and we have to mark it as dubious. Grischuk's decision to play the same line against Svidler himself looks reckless.

O 16...0-0-0 17.♗e2 h5 18.a4 h4 19.♗h2 ♕b6 20.b4!± and the black king looks quite insecure;

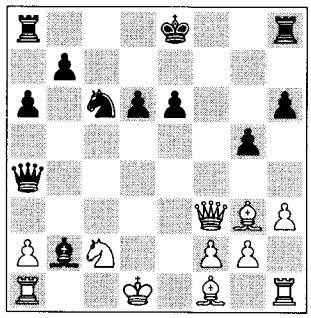
O 16...d5 17.♗e2 0-0 18.0-0 ♖ad8 19.♕b3!± (Anand-Gelfand, Haifa rapid 2000) is probably the soundest, but the weakness of the light squares in Black's

camp is an unpleasant and recurrent problem.

17.♕xf3 ♗xc3+ 18.♔d1 ♕a4+

18...♗xb2?! and now:
A) 19.♖c1!? ♗xc1 20.♘c4 ♕xa2 21.♕f6 ♕b1 22.♕xe6+ ♘e7 23.♘xd6+ (Cheparinov-Ibarra Jerez, Roquetas de Mar 2004) 23...♔d8!=;
B) 19.♕e4! ♗xa1 20.♕xe6+ ♔d8 21.♕xd6+ ♔e8 22.♕e6+ ♔d8 23.♗d3+–.

19.♘c2 ♗xb2



20.♖c1!

And here comes Svidler's inevitable novelty. The famous game Svidler-Topalov, San Luis Wch 2005, continued: 20.♕b3 ♕xb3 21.axb3 ♗xa1 22.♘xa1 ♔e7 23.♗d3 ♖ac8 24.♖e1 ♘d4∞ and the black pieces took up dominant positions.

20...♗xc1?!

Black takes all risks.
20...♔e7 is probably the best and after 21.♕b3 ♕xb3 22.axb3 ♗xc1 23.♔xc1± the position is similar to Topalov's San Luis game, but the white pieces are more active; **20...0-0-0** 21.♕g4!±.

21.♕f6 ♔d7

Another possibility would be 21...♗b2 22.♕xb2 e5 23.♗d3 and White has coordinated his minor pieces and has a menacing position.

22.♔xc1 ♕xa2

22...♖ac8 23.♗d3 ♘b4 24.♕g7+ ♔c6 25.♘xb4+ ♕xb4 26.a3 ♕xa3+ 27.♔d2.

23.♗d3 ♖ac8 24.♖d1

After completing his development, White is ready to resume his attack on the enemy king, and I doubt there is any defence for Black.

24...d5

24...♘b4? 25.♗b5+ axb5 26.♖xd6++–; 24...♔c7 25.♗xd6+ ♔b6 26.♕c3±.

25.♗f5 ♖he8 26.♕f7+ ♔d8 27.♖e1!!

After this move, Black's bastion on e6 falls, whereas the heroic c2 knight defends the queen checks and is supported by the bishop.

27...♕a3+

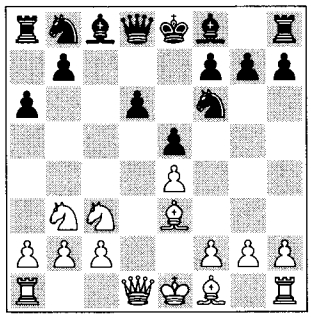
Provoking a hopeless simplification, but the aggressive alternatives were worse.
27...♘b4? 28.♕f6+ ♖e7 29.♕f8+ ♔d7 30.♗xe6+ ♖xe6 31.♕g7+ ♔d8 32.♕g8+ ♔d7 33.♕xe6+ ♔d8 34.♕e7 mate;
27...♘d4 28.♕f6+ ♔d7 29.♕xd4+–.

28.♘xa3 ♘e5+ 29.♔d2 ♘xf7 30.♗xe6+– ♖c6 31.♗xf7 ♖xe1 32.♔xe1 b5 33.♔d2 b4 34.♘c2 b3 35.♘d4 ♖b6 36.♔c1 a5 37.♗xd5 a4 38.♗e5 b2+ 39.♔b1 a3 40.♗a2 ♖b7 41.♗d6 ♖d7 42.♘b5 1-0

Game 19.02

Anand,Viswanathan
Kasimdzhanov,Rustam
San Luis Wch 2005

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 a6 6.♗e3 e5 7.♘b3



In the first stage of the English Attack 7.♘f3, leading to a more positional play focused on the control of d5-square, was considered to be better; however, the text move, which prepares the classical kingside pawn assault combined with 0-0-0, has become the main line. Play is very different here from the games in the previous chapter. The black pawn on e5 and above all the weakness of the d5-square introduce new themes for both sides.

7...♗e6

Black can hardly do without this move: it is essential to keep control over the d5-square and the bishop's development on b7 meets problems, as we'll see in the alternatives.

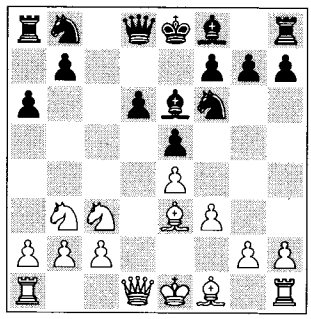
○ 7...♕c7 The black queen may come here later, but now this just makes it easier for White to control d5: 8.♕d2 ♗e7 (8...♗e6 9.f4 ♗e7 10.f5±; 8...b5 9.f3 ♗b7 10.0-0-0 ♘bd7 11.♕f2±) 9.0-0-0 (9.f4!?) 9...0-0 10.f4 ♘bd7 11.g4!± Smagin-Bukhtin, USSR 1982. The presence of the black queen on c7 fuels White's attack.

○ 7...♗e7 is perfectly playable, but more often than not it is a transposition to 7...♗e6: **8.f3 0-0** 8...♘bd7 9.g4! ♘b6 (9...h6 10.♕d2 b5 11.0-0-0 ♘b6 12.♘a5±) 10.♕d2! Since Black can no longer play ...b5 and it is not easy to play ...d5, White doesn't rush into g4-g5, which would just send the black knight to its desired spot (h5). 10...0-0 (10...♗e6 is the standard move, transposing to 7...♗e6; 10...d5?! 11.♗xb6 ♕xb6 12.exd5±) 11.0-0-0 and Black is unlikely to play other than 11...♗e6, transposing. **9.♕d2 ♘bd7!?** The only really serious alternative would be 9...♗e6. The white queen on d2 allows Black a consistent reply against the advance of the g-pawn. **10.g4 b5 11.g5 b4** Without this tactically complex move, Black's plan would be innocuous. 11...♘e8 12.0-0-0±; 11...♘h5 12.♘d5±. **12.gxf6** If this doesn't work, the retreat to e2 seems to be the best: 12.♘e2 ♘e8 13.♘g3±. **12...bxc3 13.♕d5 ♘xf6 14.♕xa8 cxb2 15.♖b1** White has captured a whole rook and Black's compensation is probably insufficient, but in practice this position is difficult to handle. **15...d5 16.♕c6?!** 16.♗d3! dxe4 17.♗xe4 ♘xe4 18.♕xe4± **16...dxe4 17.♗b6 ♕d5!** and after this unexpected move, things are far from easy: **18.♕xd5 ♘xd5 19.♗c5 ♗h4+∞ 20.♗f2?** ♘c3!−+ Wang Zili-Lin Weiguo, Shenzhen 1992.

○ 7...b5?! is premature 8.a4 (8.♘d5 is good too) 8...b4?! (8...bxa4 9.♖xa4±) 9.♘d5 and Black loses at least a pawn. 9...♘bd7 10.♘xb4+− Thorhallsson-Angelov, New York Open 1997.

O 7...♘bd7?! is an imprecise order: 8.g4! h6 9.h4 b5 10.a3 ♘b6 11.♖g1 ♗e6 12.g5± De La Villa Garcia-Epishin, Dos Hermanas 1998.

8.f3



8...♘bd7

Black opts for activating his queenside play instead of arranging castling. Both plans are equally popular in practice.

O 8...♗e7 speeds up kingside castling and White has no time to play g2-g4. We'll examine this in the remaining games of this chapter. Other moves are less interesting:

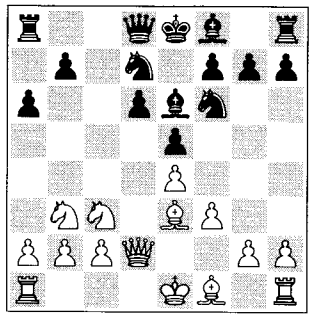
O 8...d5 is solid but White can maintain a slight plus without any risk: 9.exd5 ♘xd5 10.♘xd5 ♕xd5 (10...♗xd5 is similar: 11.c4! ♗c6 – 11...♗b4+ 12.♔f2 – 12.♕xd8+ ♔xd8 13.♘a5 ♗b4+ 14.♗d2 ♗xd2+ 15.♔xd2± Vescovi-Cappellano, Americana 2000) 11.♕xd5 ♗xd5 12.0-0-0 and Black has problems in avoiding the loss of the bishop pair: 12...♗e6 (12...♗xb3 13.axb3±; 12...♗c6 13.♘a5±) 13.♘a5! ♗c8 14.♘c4±;

O 8...♘c6 prepares ...d5, but White can prevent it and the knight will be misplaced on c6: 9.♘d5! ♗xd5 10.exd5 ♘e7 11.c4± Shirov-Shabalov, North Bay 1994.

9.♕d2

For years, White has struggled to refute this system with the more straightforward 9.g4, which still makes sense, even though it hasn't achieved its main goals. However, this approach, more positional, has obtained the best results in recent times, thanks to the thematic idea shown in this game.

9.g4 ♘b6!? and White can't go back to the right track: 10.♕d2 d5!.



9...b5

O For **9...h5**, see the next game.

O 9...♖c8 is very popular, but not very flexible, as the rook is often better placed on a8 or b8. The most Black can get is a transposition to other lines, and in the worst scenario White will be able to exploit its drawbacks somehow. **10.0-0-0 ♗e7 11.g4 0-0** 11...b5 12.g5 ♘h5 13.♘d5! ♗xd5 14.exd5 ♘b6 15.♘a5± similarly to the other line. **12.♔b1** A useful waiting move, inviting Black to declare whether he will play ...b5 or not. **12...b5** After 12...♘b6 the attacking race starts: 13.h4! ♕c7 14.h5! (14.g5 ♘h5 is less clear) 14...♘fd7 15.♖h2 (again, prophylaxis before g4-g5: White overprotects c2) 15...♖fd8 16.♘d5! (White has to prevent 16...d5 before continuing with his attack; 16.g5?! d5!) 16...♗xd5

17.exd5 e4!? (17...♘c4 18.♗xc4 ♕xc4 19.g5± with a great lead in the attacking race) 18.fxe4 ♘e5 19.♕g2 (19.♘d4±) 19...♘ec4 20.♗d4 h6 21.♕f2 ♘d7 22.♗xc4 ♕xc4 23.♕f5 ♕c7 24.♖f1 ♖f8 25.♗e3 ♖ce8 26.♖g2 ♗g5 27.♗xg5 ♖e5 28.♗xh6 ♖xf5 29.gxf5 ♔h7 30.♗xg7 ♖g8 31.♖fg1 ♕d8 32.♘d2 ♘c5 33.f6 ♕e8 34.♖g6 1-0 Motylev-Obolenskikh, Kazan 2005.

13.g5 Once the c6-square has been weakened, White follows the standard plan: a knight will jump to d5 and after its exchange, White's d5-pawn will support the other knight on c6. **13...♘h5 14.♘d5 ♗xd5 15.exd5 ♘b6 16.♘a5 ♕c7 17.♗h3!±**, followed by ♗g4. In all these variations, the black rook proves useless on c8.

O 9...♘b6?! is less effective than after 9.g4, where it has become a trendy alternative: **10.0-0-0 ♗e7 11.♕f2! ♘fd7** 11...♘c4 is not what Black has in mind: 12.♗xc4 ♗xc4 13.h4! and free from ...d5 and from annoying knight jumps, White can launch his pawn assault while Black has to worry about the threat of ♘a5, e.g.: 13...b5 14.♘a5!±. **12.f4 ♖c8 13.f5 ♗c4 14.f6 gxf6 15.♗xc4 ♖xc4 16.♖d3 h5 17.♘a5** Shirov-Ivanchuk, Monaco rapid 1999.

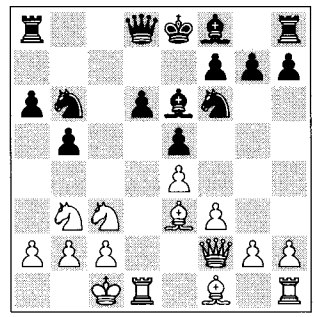
10.0-0-0

10.a4 was the old, 'logical' variation, exploiting the premature 9...b5, but concrete analysis has led to the conclusion that it is satisfactory for Black: 10...b4 11.♘d5 ♗xd5 12.exd5 ♘b6! 13.♗xb6 ♕xb6∞.

10...♘b6

10...♗e7 11.♔b1 11...0-0 12.g4 transposes to Game 19.06; 11.♘d5 ♗xd5 12.exd5 ♘b6 13.♗xb6 ♕xb6 14.♘a5 ♖c8 15.♘c6 ♘xd5 16.♘xe7 ♘xe7 17.♕xd6 ♕xd6 18.♖xd6 ♘c6 19.c3± Leko-Anand, Morelia/Linares 2008; it is not much, and it is not regarded as dangerous for Black, but the ending is more pleasant for White and some readers will like it.

11.♕f2!



This idea has at least questioned the black knight's quick jump to b6.

11...♘c4

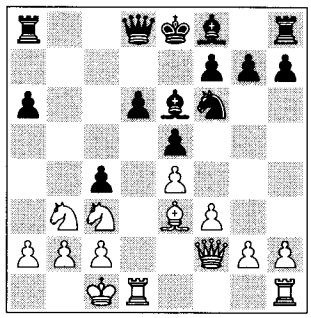
O 11...♘fd7 meets the vigorous reply 12.f4! ♖c8 13.f5 ♗c4 14.♗xc4 ♖xc4 (14...♘xc4 15.♘d5±) 15.♕d2 ♕c8 16.♘a5 ♖c7 17.g4 and White has successfully managed to trade light-squared bishops without time loss and has a great lead in the attacking race; 17...♗e7 18.g5± Svidler-Gelfand, Moscow tt 2004;

O 11...♖b8?! allows 12.♘c5 hitting a6: 12...♗c8 13.♘d3± and the 'bad' knight has been recycled without loss of time.

12.♗xc4 bxc4

As the enemy knight has nice spots, I consider **12...♗xc4** more logical, though it hasn't been tried much. White can choose between the posi-

tional approach and the immediate pawn assault: 13.♘a5! (also possible here is 13.g4?! b4 14.♘a4 ♘d7∞; 13.h4!? b4 14.♘a4 ♘d7 15.♘b6 ♘xb6 16.♗xb6 ♕d7 17.f4±) 13...♗e6 14.♘c6 ♕c8 15.♘b4± with the standard grip on the d5-square.



13.♘a5

The knight dances its way towards d5. The old move 13.♘c5!? has a similar idea.

13...♖c8

O 13...♘d7 14.♘c6 ♕c7 15.♘b4 ♕b7 16.♘bd5 ♖b8 17.b3 cxb3 18.cxb3 ♗e7 (Bologan-Gelfand, Spain tt 2005) and now Sakaev suggests: 19.♘xe7 ♔xe7 20.♘d5+ ♗xd5 21.♖xd5 ♖hc8+ 22.♔b2±.

O 13...♕xa5? 14.♗b6 ♕b4 15.a3+−.

O 13...♕d7 tries to cut off the enemy knight's routes, but takes the natural square from the black knight as well, and after 14.g4 ♗e7 (14...h6 15.h4 just turns g4-g5 into a bigger threat) 15.g5 ♘h5 16.♘d5 Black has serious problems to deal with the white knights, and the forcing move 16...♕a4!? does not seem to solve them: 17.♕e1! ♕xa2 18.♕b4 ♗xd5 19.exd5 0-0 20.♘c6 ♖fe8 21.♖he1± and the black queen is in trouble.

O 13...♕c8 is probably the best move, but even so: 14.♘d5 ♘xd5 (14...♗xd5 15.exd5 c3 is an untried move; 16.b3 ♗e7 17.♖d3± and the c3 pawn is weak) 15.exd5 ♗d7 16.f4!± (Sadvakasov-Zhou Jianchao, Hyderabad Ach 2005) with a strong initiative and immediate kingside threats (♖hf1, ♕g3).

14.♗b6 ♕d7 15.g3!?

Preparing f3-f4. Everybody has followed this recommendation; however, other ways to carry out this logical push are worth checking:

15.f4?! has the typical flaw 15...♘g4 16.♕f3 exf4 17.♕xf4 ♗e7∞ and the black knight can go to e5.

On the other hand, **15.h3!?**, when 15...♗e7?! 16.f4 exf4 17.e5± is really annoying.

15...g6!?

15...♗e7 16.h3! followed by 17.f4.

16.♖d2?!

Too much prophylaxis: 16.f4!? ♗h6 17.♔b1±, threatening 18.f5, was already possible.

16...♗h6 17.f4 ♘g4?!

17...♘h5?! wasn't good either: 18.♖hd1 exf4? 19.g4!±; but the critical move is **17...0-0!** 18.♖hd1 ♗g4 19.♖xd6 ♕e7 20.♘c6 ♖xc6 21.♖xc6 exf4∓ and Black has excellent compensation. This variation just stresses the need for an improvement on White's 16th move.

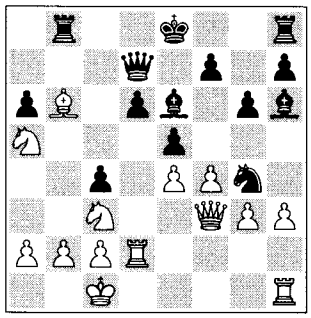
18.♕f3 ♖b8?

Black completes his wrong plan. **18...♘f6!** 19.h3! ♗xh3 20.♗e3! ♗g4 21.♕f1 ♘h5 22.♖xh5 ♗xh5 23.♘xc4

♖xc4 24.♕xc4 0-0 25.♕f1± and White has some assets, above all the square d5 and the pressure along the open file, but Black's active bishop pair still has a lot to say; **18...exf4?** 19.gxf4 ♘e5 20.fxe5 ♗xd2+ 21.♔xd2 dxe5+ 22.♔c1±.

19.h3!

It is the knight which matters, and not the d6 pawn: 19.♗c5?! exf4! 20.gxf4 ♘e5 21.♕f2 0-0 22.♗xd6 ♘d3+ 23.cxd3 ♕xd6 24.e5 ♕c7 is less clear.



19...♘f6?

As several annotators pointed out, Black still had an extraordinary resource which would have offered the greatest resistance: 19...♘h2!

20.♗c5!

It is all over now.

20...exf4 21.gxf4 ♖c8

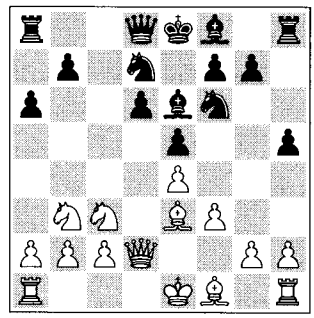
21...♗f8 22.f5! gxf5 23.exf5 ♗xf5 24.♖e1+ ♔d8 25.♘c6++–; 21...0-0 22.♗xd6 ♕c8 23.♘d5+–.

22.♗xd6 ♕d8 23.♗b4 ♕b6 24.a3 ♘h5 25.♔b1 ♗xf4 26.♘d5! ♗xd5 27.♖xd5 ♗b8 28.♖hd1 c3 29.♖d7 1-0

Game 19.03

Leko,Peter
Topalov,Veselin
Wijk aan Zee 2008

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 a6 6.f3 e5 7.♘b3 ♗e6 8.♗e3 ♘bd7 9.♕d2 h5!?



This move has the simple idea of preventing (or at least hindering) g2-g4 and its popularity is growing more and more. This is not so strange, as the same move, with the same goal, has achieved a prominent position in the Saemisch Variation of the King's Indian defence, or the Rauzer Attack in the Dragon. White has tried very different plans, but so far we can't say that there is a clear path to an advantage for the first player.
For those familiar with Geller's or Karpov's games in the 6.♗e2 variation, the plan involving 0-0 seems to have devastating logic. Let's see for instance this game: 6.♗e2 e5 7.♘b3 ♗e6 8.0-0 ♘bd7 9.a4 ♗e7 10.a5 0-0 11.♗e3 ♖c8 12.f3 ♕c7 13.♕d2 ♖fd8 14.♖fd1 d5 15.exd5 ♘xd5 16.♘xd5 ♗xd5 17.♕xd5 ♘f6 18.♕c4 ♖xd1+ 19.♖xd1 ♕xc4 20.♗xc4 ♖xc4 21.c3 ♔f8 22.♔f2 ♔e8 23.♔e2 ♖c7 24.♖d3 ♖d7 25.♗c5 ♖c7 26.♗a7 ♖c6 27.♔d2 ½-½ Geller-Ivkov, Palma de Mallorca izt

1970. What would have been Geller's face if his opponent had played ...h5 around the 12th or 13th move? And yet it would have simply led to the positions we are going to study. So I recommend the plan with 0-0: White will get at most a small positional edge, but I think it is the most logical approach to exploit the drawbacks of Black's move.

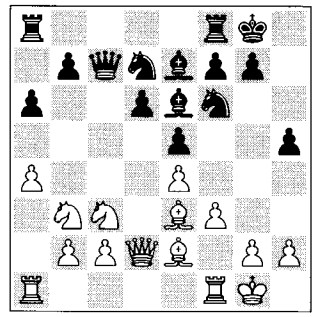
10.a4!

If White is going to switch to 0-0, it is best to start with this move, which restricts Black's queenside play.

10...♗e7

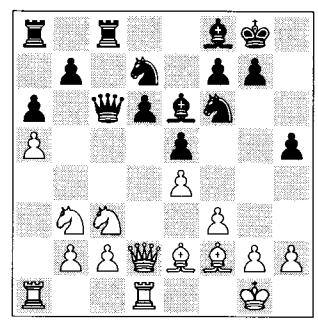
10...♖c8 is less flexible: **11.a5 ♗e7** 11...♖xc3 12.♕xc3 d5 occurred in Grischuk-Topalov, Monaco (blind) 2006; but there does not seem to be enough compensation after 13.♗f2 dxe4 14.♗c4±) **12.♗e2 0-0 13.0-0 ♕c7** 13...♘c5 has occurred in several games and is solid, though not very ambitious: 14.♘xc5 dxc5 15.♖fd1 ♕xd2 16.♖xd2 c4 17.g3 ♖fd8 18.♖xd8+ ♖xd8 19.♔f2±) **14.♖fc1!** Exploiting the lack of flexibility of ...♖ac8, White prepares ♘d5 in time. 14.♖fd1 would lead to positions similar to the next note; 14.♖ac1!? is possible too. **14...♕c6 15.♖d1 ♖fd8 16.♖ac1** Now the queen is slightly worse on c6 than on c7. **16...♗c4** 16...♕c7 17.♘d5!± **17.♗xc4 ♕xc4** White has achieved an important strategic goal, that is, the exchange of light-squared bishops; now he can change plans again. **18.♗g5?!** The exchange on f6 is less effective with the pawn on f3; 18.♖a1!± intending ♖a4. **18...♘c5 19.♗xf6 ♗xf6 20.♕d5 ♕b4=** Almasi-Areschenko, Spain tt 2007.

11.♗e2 ♕c7 12.0-0 0-0



13.♖fd1!?

As long as the black rook stays on a8, sparing a4-a5 makes a lot of sense, so that a possible reaction with ...b5, as we will see in the game, meets obstacles. Even so, the alternative 13.a5 is critical: **13.a5!? ♖fc8** Preventing 14.♘d5. 13...♖fd8 14.♘d5 ♘xd5 15.exd5 ♗f5 16.c4±; 13...♖ac8 transposes to 10...♖c8. **14.♖fd1** 14.♗f2 is an acceptable prophylactic measure, but we lack practical examples; 14.♖fc1!? ♕c6 15.♖d1 as in the Almasi-Areschenko game mentioned above, has a problem: 15...h4 16.♖ac1 b5! 17.axb6 ♘xb6= and the rook is clearly useful on a8. **14...♕c6 15.♗f2** 15.♖ac1 still fails due to 15...b5 16.axb6 ♘xb6 17.♖a1 d5!⇄; 15.h3!?, improving the position before carrying out the thematic manoeuvres – ♖ac1 intending ♘d5, or ♘c1 intending ♘a2-b4 – is worth a try. **15...♗f8** and now:



A) **16.♔h1** g6 17.♗f1 ♔h7 18.♔g1 ♕c7 19.♗e3 ♖e8 20.♘c1 ♖ac8 21.♗e2 (21.♘d3!? d5 22.exd5 ♘xd5 23.♘xd5 ♗xd5 24.♘f2 ♗e6 25.♘e4 ♗e7∞) 21...♖ed8 22.♔h1 ♗e7 23.♕e1 ♕c6 24.♕d2 ♕c7 25.♕e1 ♕c6 26.♕d2 ♕c7 27.♕e1 ½-½ S.Zhigalko-Tihonov, Minsk ch-BLA 2007. This is a curious game in which there is the feeling that White is close to consolidating his edge but his play is not completely accurate;

B) **16.♘c1!?** is one of my suggestions; its virtue is that now 16...b5?! is bad on account of 17.axb6 ♘xb6 18.♖xa6±;

C) **16.♖ac1** b5 17.axb6 ♘xb6 18.♕e3 ♘c4 19.♗xc4 ♕xc4 20.♖a1 ♗e7∞.

13...♖fd8!?

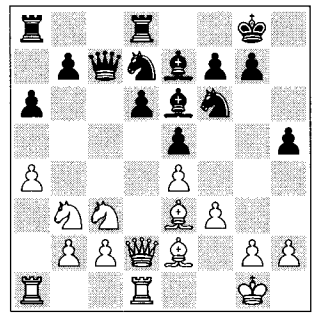
Black gets ready for ...d5.

13...♘b6 is another very common idea in this variation, but I don't see the logic in allowing the trade of the passive light-squared bishop for another minor piece with more influence on d5: **14.a5! ♘c4 15.♗xc4 ♕xc4** (15...♗xc4 16.♕f2±) and now White has three interesting alternatives:

A) **16.♘a4** is the least convincing: 16...♖ad8 17.♘b6 ♕b5 18.♕d3 ♕xd3 19.♖xd3 d5!= 20.♗c5 dxe4 21.fxe4 ♖xd3 22.cxd3 ♖e8 23.♗xe7 ♖xe7 24.♘c5 ♖c7 25.b4 Rytshagov-Astrom, Gothenburg 1999;

B) **16.♗c5!?** is indeed an interesting idea, but we may still question whether Black can set up a fortress after sacrificing his queen: 16...dxc5 17.♖a4 ♕xb3 (17...♕xa4 18.♘xa4 ♖fd8 19.♕e2 ♖xd1+ 20.♕xd1±) 18.cxb3 ♗xb3 19.♖aa1±;

C) **16.♗b6** must be the best: 16...♕c6 17.♘c1! (starting Geller's thematic manoeuvre) 17...♘d7 18.♗e3 f5 19.♘d3 fxe4?! (19...♘f6 20.♘b4 ♕d7 21.♘bd5±) 20.♘b4 ♕c4 21.♘xe4+− Anand-Svidler, Monaco (rapid) 2007.



14.a5?!

This helps the liberation plan conceived by Topalov. It is time to check if White has any move to maintain the pressure. **14.♘d5!?** is thematic: 14...♗xd5 (14...♘xd5 15.exd5 ♗f5 16.c4 ♖ac8 17.♖ac1 ♘f6 18.♗d3 ♕d7 19.♗xf5 ♕xf5 20.♕d3 ♕d7 21.a5±) 15.exd5 ♘b6 16.♕a5 ♕xc2 17.♗xb6 ♕xe2 18.♗xd8 ♗xd8 19.♕c3 ♗b6+ 20.♔h1±.

14...b5!?

A pawn offer that Leko will decline but which will succeed in freeing Black's position anyway. After this move we can say that White has failed in his attempt to achieve an edge in the opening.

15.♘d5

15.axb6 ♘xb6 16.♖xa6 ♖xa6 17.♗xa6 d5! 18.♘b5 ♕b8 19.♘a5 ♗d7 20.exd5 ♘fxd5⩲.

15...♗xd5

15...♘xd5 looks sufficient for equality too: 16.exd5 ♗f5=.

16.exd5 ♖ac8 17.c3 ♕b7 18.♖a3 g6 19.♘a1

Leko goes after the c6-square, but Black manages to set up some counterplay on the dark squares.

19...♖e8

19...e4!? is another good suggestion by Ftacnik, e.g.: 20.f4 ♘e5!? 21.fxe5 dxe5 22.d6 (22.♖a2 ♘xd5∓) 22...♖xd6 23.♕xd6 ♗xd6 24.♖xd6 ♘d5∞.

20.♘c2 ♗f8 21.♘b4 ♗g7 22.♖c1 e4! 23.f4

23.fxe4? ♘xe4 24.♕e1 f5∓.

23...♘g4 24.♗xg4 hxg4 25.♕e2

25.♘c6 ♘c5 26.♗xc5?! dxc5 27.♖e1 ♕d7∓; 25.♖f1 f5 26.♖aa1∞.

25...♘f6 26.♖d1 ♖c4 27.♕d2 ♕c8 28.♖aa1 g3!

Black's initiative is becoming dangerous.

29.h3

29.hxg3?! ♘g4! 30.♘c2 ♕f5 31.♔f1 g5!∓.

29...♘h5 30.♖ac1 ♗h6 31.b3

31.♘c6?!, to trap the rook, is too ambitious: 31...♘g7! 32.b3 ♖xc6 33.dxc6 ♕xc6 34.c4 ♘f5∓.

31...♖c7 32.♘c6?!

32.f5 ♗xe3+ 33.♕xe3 ♕xf5 34.♘xa6 is less clear.

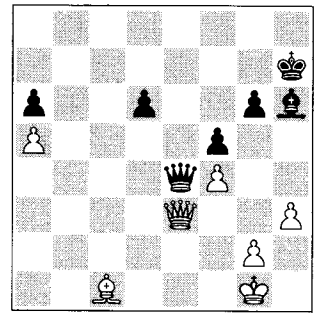
32...♘g7 33.c4 bxc4 34.♖xc4 ♕d7 35.♕c2 ♖b7 36.b4

36.♖xe4 ♖xe4 37.♕xe4 ♖xb3 38.♗b6 ♘f5 39.♖e1 ♔h7∓.

36...♘f5 37.♗c1 e3

Again, Topalov seizes his opportunity of pushing another pawn.

38.♖e1 ♖b5 39.♕d3 f6 40.♖e4 ♖xe4 41.♕xe4 ♕f7 42.♘d4 ♕xd5 43.♕e8+ ♔h7 44.♘xf5 ♕xf5 45.♕xe3 ♖xb4 46.♕xg3 ♖e4 47.♖xe4 ♕xe4 48.♕e3 f5



49.♕xe4?

Finally Leko collapses under Topalov's continuous pressure. He could have still maintained equality with 49.♕a7+! ♗g7 50.♔h2 ♕c2 51.♗e3=.

49...fxe4 50.♔f2 d5–+

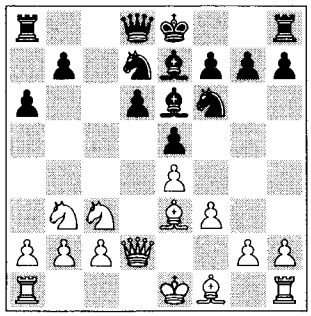
Now the ending with the two central passed pawns, perfectly coordinated with the bishop, is hopeless.

51.g4 d4 52.♗b2 ♗g7 53.♗a3 ♔g8 54.h4 ♔f7 55.♗c5 ♔e6 56.h5 gxh5 57.gxh5 d3 58.♔e3 ♗h6 59.♗b4 ♔d5 60.♗d2 ♗f8 61.♗c1 ♗c5+ 62.♔d2 ♔c4 63.h6 ♗f2! 64.♔d1 e3 65.♗xe3 ♗xe3 66.h7 ♗d4 0-1

Game 19.04

De Vreugt,Dennis
Calotescu,Ana-Cristina
Kavala 2002

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 ♘f6 4.♘c3 cxd4 5.♘xd4 a6 6.♗e3 e5 7.♘b3 ♗e6 8.f3 ♗e7 9.♕d2 ♘bd7



Black's last two moves, ...♗e7 and ...♘bd7, usually introduce different plans; however, its mixture is really common and creates a real maze of transpositions and parallel variations. For the sake of clarity, we devote this game to those variations where both ideas are combined and ...0-0 is delayed, and the subsequent games will deal with the ...♗e7 and ...0-0 lines.

10.g4

10.0-0-0 is normally a transposition, but there is an extra option for Black: 10...b5 11.g4 ♘b6, though 12.♕f2 is appealing.

10...h6

The most frequent, as well as the most consistent with postponing castling. But the other natural moves have also been tried:

O 10...♖c8 11.0-0-0 ♘b6 12.h4 will be examined in Game 19.07. White does well not to rush into g4-g5 before Black has played ...♘c4.

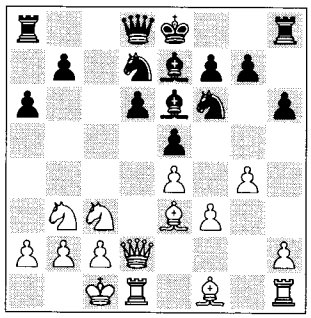
O 10...♕c7 This move can lead to many transpositions, but at this moment is not very flexible. 11.0-0-0 (or 11.h4, or even 11.g5 ♘h5, though this justifies Black's plan: 12.0-0-0 0-0 13.♔b1 transposes to the penultimate game of this chapter) 11...0-0 (11...♖c8 12.h4; 11...♘b6 12.h4) 12.g5 transposes to the penultimate game of this chapter.

O 10...♘b6?! is again less logical here than on the previous move, against g2-g4, as White can prevent ...d5 by castling and there is no need to rush into h4-h5: **11.0-0-0! 0-0** 11...♖c8 12.♔b1 ♕c7 13.h4± and the planned 13...d5? is not possible due to 14.♗xb6! ♕xb6 15.g5 d4 16.gxf6 dxc3 17.fxg7 ♖g8 18.♕h6+− Prokopchuk-Kogan, Moscow 2002. **12.h4 ♖c8** 12...d5?! 13.g5 d4 14.gxf6 ♗xf6 15.♘xd4±; 12...a5!?. **13.h5!** White has prevented his opponent from installing an annoying knight on h5, and is ready for the decisive breaks. We just need to check that the thematic break doesn't work: **13...d5 14.g5 d4?!** Somewhat better is 14...♘xe4 (Gashimov-Dvoiris, Istanbul Ech 2003) and now 15.fxe4 d4 16.♕g2 ♘d7 17.♘xd4 exd4 18.♗xd4 ♗xg5+ 19.♔b1±. **15.gxf6 ♗xf6** 15...dxc3 16.♕xd8! cxb2+ 17.♔b1 ♗xd8 18.fxg7 ♔xg7 19.♖g1+ ♔h8 20.♖xd8!+−. **16.♘xd4 exd4 17.♗xd4±** There is no compensation for the pawn.

O 10...b5?! This looks the same as without ...♗e7 and ♕d2, but actually, it is quite different. **11.a4!** A very old recommendation by Nunn. In general, I'm against this push when the kingside is already compromised due to g2-g4, but here the analysis confirms that it works, even though few players dare to give it a try. 11.g5 b4 12.♘e2 ♘h5 13.♘g3± is also better than in the other line, but maybe 11...♘h5 is more precise. **11...b4 12.♘d5 ♗xd5 13.exd5 ♕c7** 13...♘b6?! shows us the difference with the parallel line: 14.a5 ♘bxd5? 15.g5 and White wins a piece; 13...0-0 14.g5 ♘h5 15.♖g1 f5 16.♕xb4 f4?! 17.♗f2 ♗xg5 18.♕e4 with a clear

edge because of the light squares, Nunn-Morris, Manchester 1980; 13...h6!? 14.0-0-0 ♘b6 15.♗xb6 ♕xb6 16.h4 ♘d7 17.♔b1 (Stocek-Neverov, Prerov 2001) and a very interesting battle arises between opposite-coloured bishops: we need more practical examples. So far both Ftacnik and Stocek have recommended here 17...♘c5! 18.♘xc5 ♕xc5 19.♗d3 g6 with equality, but 20.f4!, both here and on the previous moves, offers a dangerous initiative for White. **14.g5 ♘h5 15.0-0-0** White's castled position looks solid despite the a4 pawn. **15...♘f4 16.h4 h6 17.♖g1 hxg5 18.hxg5 ♖h4 19.♔b1 ♕d8** 19...♘b6? 20.♕f2! ♘bxd5 21.♗xf4+–. **20.♘d4!±** Nunn-Sadler, London 1993.

11.0-0-0



11...b5

The logical follow-up to ...h6. However, several other moves have been tried here:

❍ 11...♖c8 12.h4 b5 (12...♘b6?! transposes to 11...♘b6) and now I recommend the untested 13.♕g2 (intending g4-g5. 13.♔b1 ♘b6 14.♕f2 allows the interesting and also untested 14...♖xc3∞) 13...♘b6 (13...♖xc3 is far weaker now: 14.bxc3 ♘b6 15.g5! and White's attack runs faster) 14.g5 ♘fd7 (14...hxg5 15.hxg5 ♘h5 16.♕g1 ♘c4 17.♗xc4 bxc4 18.♘c5±; 14...♘h5 15.♘c5!) 15.gxh6 gxh6 16.f4, with a violent fight, but the black king seems to be in greater danger.

❍ 11...♕c7 may combine, regardless of the move order, with ...♖c8 and ...♘b6, but this plan is weak in combination with ...h6. However, it has an independent significance if it is preparing ...0-0-0: 12.h4 ♘b6 (12...b5 13.♔b1 – 13.♕g2!?, defending the rook and therefore preparing g4-g5, questions this order – 13...♘b6 14.♕f2 ♖b8 transposes to 13...♖b8) 13.♔b1 0-0-0 14.♕f2 ♘fd7 15.♘d5 ♗xd5 16.exd5 ♔b8 17.c4± Lastin-Kunin, Moscow ch-city 1999.

❍ 11...♘b6?! 12.h4 ♖c8. This plan is far weaker with the pawn on h6: 13.♔b1 ♘fd7 14.♗d3 ♕c7 15.g5 h5 16.f4± Gagunashvili-Yildiz, Turkey 2002.

12.♔b1!

I recommend this order, even though I don't see a big difference between this and 12.h4, which will lead to the same position after White's 14th move: 12.h4 ♘b6 (12...b4 might be the problem with 12.h4) 13.♕f2 ♘fd7 14.♔b1.

12...♘b6

12...b4 only makes sense if Black intends to capture the future d5 pawn: 13.♘d5 ♗xd5 14.exd5 ♘b6 15.c4!? (15.♕xb4 looks good too) 15...bxc3 16.♕xc3 0-0 17.♕a5± Tseshkovsky-Doroshkevich, Krasnodar 1996;

12...♕c7 13.h4 ♘b6 14.♕f2 ♖b8 transposes to 13...♖b8.

13.♕f2!

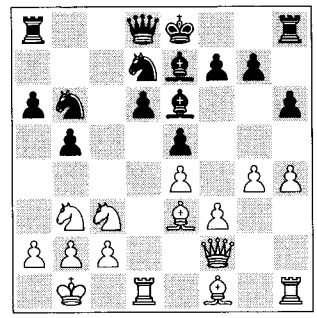
This move virtually forces Black to 'loosen' the grip on d5 and is the whole point of White's play.

13...♘fd7

O 13...♘c4 is quite playable here and may be an argument for the order 12.h4, as it is clear that in this line the pawn on h4 would be more useful than the king on b1: **14.♗xc4 bxc4 15.♘c5 ♕c7** 15...♘d7 16.♘xe6 fxe6 17.♕f1 (17.f4!? intending 18.f5, and if 17...exf4 18.♗xf4 0-0 19.♕g3 e5 20.♗e3± with total white domination) 17...♕c7 18.♕h3 ♖b8 19.g5± Sengupta-Evdokimov, Moscow 2006. **16.♘5a4** 16.♘xe6! fxe6 17.h4 – though still untested, I think this is the move that poses the most severe problems for Black. **16...♖b8 17.h4 ♕c6** 17...♘d7 has given Marjanovic good results, but after 18.g5 h5 19.f4± White has a strong initiative. **18.g5 ♘d7 19.gxh6 gxh6** (Timman-Van Wely, Breda m-10 1998) **20.h5±**.

O 13...♖b8 14.h4 Keeping all the options, as the immediate 14.♘c5 is not completely clear due to 14...b4! 15.♘xe6 fxe6 16.♘e2∞. **14...b4** looks natural, but meets an unexpected regrouping of the white pieces. 14...♕c7 is the other way to prevent 15.♘c5. White has tried many moves. Which is best? Of course, one that prepares g4-g5: 15.♖g1 (15.♗h3!?) 15...♘c4 16.g5 ♘xe3 17.♕xe3 ♘h5 18.gxh6 gxh6 19.♕d2± with a complex position where the black king will suffer more. **15.♘e2! ♘c4 16.♗c1 a5 17.♘g3 a4 18.♘f5! ♗xf5** 18...axb3 19.♘xg7+ ♔f8 20.♘xe6+ fxe6 21.♗xc4+–. **19.exf5 ♘xb2** (19...axb3 20.♗xc4±) **20.♗xb2 axb3 21.cxb3±** Bologan-Lutz, Germany Bundesliga 1997/98.

14.h4



14...♖c8

O 14...♕c7 is a slightly different plan, in which one rook stays on the a-file and the other rook is expected to be transferred to the queenside. White's reaction is the usual one, partly due to the lack of options: **15.♘d5! ♗xd5 16.exd5 ♘c4 17.♗c1 a5** 17...♕b6 18.♕e1 a5 and now I propose 19.♕c3! a4 20.♗xc4 bxc4 21.♘d2 0-0 22.g5 h5 23.♘xc4±. **18.♗d3 a4 19.♘d2 ♖b8 20.♘e4±** White's minor pieces are well placed and the break g4-g5 hangs over Black's castled position, so it is clear that White's prospects are more promising, Svidler-S.Savchenko, Maikop tt 1998.

O 14...♘c4 15.♗xc4 White may transpose by playing 15.♗c1 followed by ♘d5. **15...bxc4** 15...♗xc4 16.♘d5± **16.♘c1** Black has opened the b-file, but White can easily defend b2 and the c4 pawn acts like a defender of white's castled position because it prevents other black pieces from coming. This kind of position occurs fairly often and allows White to calmly prepare his offensive, as in this game: **16...♖b8 17.♘1e2 ♕c7 18.♗c1 ♖b7 19.♔a1 ♕c6 20.♕g3 ♘b6 21.f4! f6 22.g5±** A nice example of White's strategy, Adams-Szekely, Hastings 1987/88.

15.♘d5

Necessary, in view of 15...♖xc3.

15...♗xd5

Black parts with the light-squared bishop; this is an important decision, but apparently nobody has questioned it so far.

15...♘c4!? 16.♗c1 a5 17.♘d2 and there aren't many alternatives for Black, apart from taking on d5 and transposing;

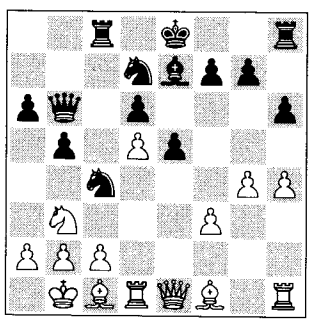
15...♘a4?! 16.♘xe7 ♕xe7?! 17.♕d2 winning a pawn.

16.exd5 ♘c4 17.♗c1 ♕b6

The queen takes a good diagonal, as trading queens would solve the black king's problems.

O 17...a5 18.♘d2 (the white knight heads for e4) 18...♘xd2+ 19.♗xd2 b4 20.♗d3 0-0 21.♗f5 (21.f4!?) 21...♖b8 (Konguvel-Gallagher, Calcutta 2001) and now, though the move chosen in the game, 22.g5, is not bad either, 22.f4! looks stronger: 22...exf4 23.g5 h5 24.♗xf4±.

18.♕e1



18...♕c7

Both 18...b4 and 18...a5 are logical but have not worked out in practice. Let's see:

O 18...a5?! 19.♗xc4! bxc4 20.♘xa5 c3 21.♘c6 cxb2 22.♗e3 ♕a6 23.♕b4 (Kasparov-Khuzman, Tel Aviv clock simul 1998). The powerful ♘c6 smothers Black's attack and the endgames favour White, e.g.: 23...♖a8 24.a4! ♕xa4 25.♕xa4 ♖xa4 26.♔xb2± followed by ♖a1;

O 18...b4 19.♗d3 ♕b5 20.♘d2 ♘xd2+ 21.♖xd2 ♕b7 22.♗e4 ♘c5 23.♖g2± Garcia-Cuartas, Medellin ch-COL 2001.

O 18...♘c5 19.f4!.

19.♗d3 g6

Pre-empting the threat g5-g6.

19...a5, from a correspondence game, is the most logical: 20.♘d2! (my suggestion) 20...♘xd2+ (20...♘db6 21.♘xc4 bxc4 – 21...♘xc4 22.b3± – 22.♗f5 ♖a8 23.f4±) 21.♗xd2 b4 22.f4±;

19...h5 (Solovjov-Yandarbiev, St. Petersburg 2003) tries to destroy White's structure but after 20.g5! g6 21.f4 White's attack is hard to stop.

20.f4!

The most active, although positional play with 20.h5 leads to an edge for White too: 20...g5 21.♗f5 ♖b8 22.♘d2 ♘f6 23.♘e4±.

20...♗f6

20...a5 21.f5!±; 20...exf4 21.♗xf4 ♘de5 22.♘d4±.

21.g5 hxg5 22.hxg5 ♖xh1 23.♕xh1 ♗g7 24.f5

White's storm is unstoppable.

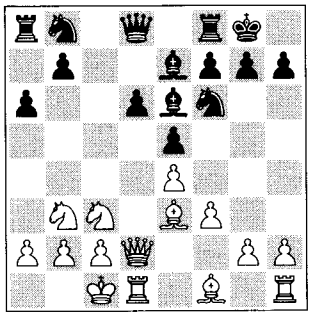
24...gxf5 25.♗xf5 ♖b8 26.♕h7+– ♗f8 27.g6 fxg6 28.♗g5 1-0

Game 19.05

Alonso,Salvador
Röder,Mathias
Madrid 2000

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 a6 6.♗e3 e5 7.♘b3 ♗e7 8.f3 ♗e6 9.♕d2 0-0 10.0-0-0

Here the order 10.g4?! d5!∓ is incorrect.



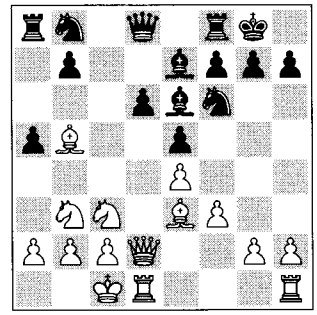
10...b5

Black embarks on the attacking race but leaves the knight on b8, where it keeps an eye on c6. A very natural move, this has been the main line for quite some time.

We will deal with the current main line, **10...♘bd7**, in the subsequent games. But here there are some other serious alternatives:

O 10...a5 This was popular in the first years of life of this variation, and sharp players are still attracted by it; however, it has obvious positional drawbacks, mainly the weakness of the b5-square. **11.♗b5!** My recommendation; White immediately exploits the hole on b5 and prevents ...a4, without for the moment himself creating a weakness by playing a2-a4.

And now:



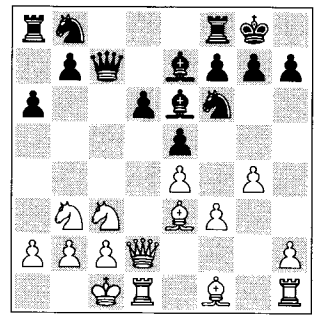
A) **11...♘a6** Intending to chase the bishop and defend the 'supersquare' d5 from c7. **12.♕e2!** Preparing a potential knight jump to c5 and pre-empting the defence of b5. **12...♕b8** has become the main alternative; the queen moves away from the d-file and prepares ...♘c7. 12...♕c8?! 13.♘a4± Sax-Quinteros, Moscow izt 1982 and the hole on b6 is too ugly; 12...♘c7 13.♘c5 ♘xb5 14.♕xb5 ♕c8 15.♘xe6 fxe6 16.♖d3± Lastin-Dvoiris, Moscow 1999. **13.g4!** White starts his attack... **13...♘c7 14.♗a4!** ...and keeps the blockade on b5. **14...♖d8!** 14...b5?! is too impatient: 15.♘xb5 ♘xb5 16.♕xb5 ♕xb5 17.♗xb5 a4 18.♘d2 ♗xa2 19.♗c4 ♗xc4 20.♘xc4 ♖a6 21.♖d3± Inarkiev-Freitag, Cesme 2004; with a very pleasant endgame. **15.g5 ♘h5 16.♔b1 d5!** The only way to free himself. **17.exd5 ♘xd5 18.♘xd5 ♗xd5 19.♖he1 ♕c7** (Anisimov-Kim, St Petersburg 2006) and White can maintain slight pressure with **20.♕b5! ♗c6** 20...♗xf3 21.♖xd8+ ♕xd8 22.♕xe5± **21.♕c4±**.

B) **11...♘bd7** The knight can help from b6. **12.♕f2!** And that's why White prevents it. 12.a4 ♘b6 13.♗xb6 (13.♕f2 ♘c4 14.♗xc4 ♗xc4 15.♗b6 ♕c8 16.♘xa5 ♗e6⩲) 13...♕xb6. **12...♖c8!?** Exploiting the white queen's

absence, to set up the threat 13...♖xc3. 12...♘e8 looks too artificial: 13.♔b1 ♘c7 14.a4 ♘xb5 15.♘xb5 (the white pieces occupy ideal squares. It is clear that the ...a5 strategy has failed) 15...♕c8 16.♘xd6 ♗xd6 17.♖xd6 (Vallejo Pons-Abreu, Capablanca 1999). Black has neither compensation for the pawn, nor a way to recover it: 17...♕c4 18.♖hd1 ♕xa4? 19.♖xd7 ♗xd7 20.♘c5+–. And now I propose: **13.♕e1!** 13.g4 ♖xc3! this exchange sacrifice is a good practical decision and it is likely to get enough compensation: 14.bxc3 a4! 15.♗xa4 ♕a8 16.♗xd7 ♘xd7 17.♔b1 ♕a4 18.♗c1 ♖a8↑ (Mista-Jakubiec, Warsaw 2004) with a strong initiative. **13...♕c7** 13...♘b6 14.♘xa5!; 13...♖a8 14.♔b1 ♘b6 15.♘c5!± – this is the point. **14.♔b1** And now all the aggressive or liberating moves involve a pawn sacrifice (...♘b6, ...a4, ...d5) and maybe the best option is 14...♖a8 15.♕f2! and then the pawns move forward.

C) **11...♘c6 12.♔b1** In this case the most flexible move is also the most effective. **12...♘a7!?** Oddly enough, this is infrequently played, though so far White has proved nothing clear. (12...♕b8, Stangl's pet move, creates rather a claustrophobic impression: 13.♘d5! ♗xd5 14.exd5 ♘b4 15.c4. It looks as though White's attack can make progress without opposition, as the queenside is frozen. 15...b6 16.g4 ♕c7 17.h4 ♘a6 18.h5 ♘c5 19.♕c2 ♘fd7 20.♘d2 ♖a7 21.g5± Ramos-Craig, e-mail 1997; 12...♘e8 is Loginov's pet move) **13.♗d3** (13.♕e2!± was my suggestion in DLS, but 13...♘xb5 14.♕xb5 ♗d7! gives Black good counterplay: 15.♕b6 ♕c8 16.♗g5 ♖a6 17.♕e3 a4↑ Czarnota-Kempinski, Warsaw 2005. **13...♘c6** Perhaps this unnecessary repetition can explain the low popularity of ...♘a7. **14.a3!?** Untested, but logical: the black a-pawn is stopped before it gets to a3. **14...a4** 14...d5? is not possible yet. **15.♘c1 ♖a5 16.♕f2±**.

O 10...♕c7 usually transposes to the next game, but played in this move order, it has some sting. **11.g4** 11.♔b1?! d5! and Black has no problems: 12.exd5 ♘xd5 13.♘xd5 ♗xd5 14.♕xd5? ♖d8∓.



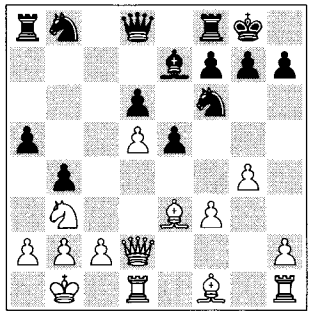
11...♖c8!? Speeding up the pressure on c2 and threatening 12...d5. 11...♘bd7 transposes. **12.g5** 12.♔b1?! It is easy to play shallow moves and fall into 12...d5!. **12...♘h5** 12...♘fd7 is one of the independent alternatives, but allowing the h-pawn to advance looks too risky: 13.h4 ♘c6 14.♔b1! (14.h5 ♘b4⇄) 14...♘a5?! 15.♘xa5 ♕xa5 16.♘d5± Motylev-Navrotescu, Romania tt 2000. **13.♔b1 b5** 13...♘d7 transposes. **14.♘d5 ♗xd5 15.exd5** And, although the knight is defending the c6-square now, it is hard to play anything other than 15...♘d7, transposing to the next game, e.g.: 15...b4?! 16.♗h3!±.

11.g4 b4

O 11...♘bd7 transposes to Game 19.07;

O 11...♘c6?! is usually inaccurate when the d5-square is weak: 12.♘d5 ♗xd5 13.exd5±.

12.♘d5 ♗xd5 13.exd5 a5 14.♔b1



14...♕c7

This move has made its way up as the best alternative.

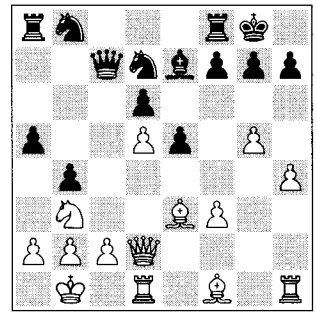
O Black players had tried **14...a4** but the weakness of the b4 pawn is a heavy burden: **15.♘c1 ♖a5** The most popular choice, preventing ♗b5 and attacking the d5 pawn. Other moves pose even fewer problems; 15...♘a6 16.♗b5!± followed by ♗c6; 15...♕a5 16.g5 ♘fd7 (16...♘h5 17.♗h3± and ♗g4) 17.h4 and White's attack goes very fast. **16.♗c4 ♘a6** There is no compensation after 16...♕c7 17.♕xb4 ♘bd7 18.♗b5 ♖b8 19.c4 Tiviakov-Ye Jiangchuan, Beijing 1997. **17.g5 ♘d7** On 17...♘h5?!, 18.♘d3 wins a pawn. **18.♘d3 ♘b6 19.♗xb6!** Tiviakov's improvement over one of his games (against Prasad) has put the 14...a4 variation into abeyance. White, rather than focus on winning a pawn, launches a quick kingside attack exploiting the fact that the black pieces are piled up and passive on the other wing. **19...♕xb6 20.f4 exf4 21.♕xf4 ♘c5 22.♖de1 ♖a7 23.h4 a3?!** 23...b3 24.cxb3 axb3 25.a3 ♖a4 26.♘b4± **24.h5 axb2 25.h6+−** Tiviakov-Bekker Jensen, Gausdal 2000.

O 14...♘bd7 15.g5 ♘h5 16.♗b5 will be considered in the next game.

15.g5 ♘fd7

15...♘h5?! is not so good here as in previous variations, as 16.♗h3 threatens ♗g4, lifting the blockade: 16...f5 17.gxf6 ♖xf6 18.♗g4 ♘f4 19.♘d4!±.

16.h4



16...♘b6

The point of Black's plan is to combine ...b4 with ...♘c4, and thus prevent his attack from being blocked.

O 16...f5!? may help stop the enemy attack on the kingside, but then White will have an undisputed grip on the light squares: 17.gxf6 ♗xf6 18.h5 ♘b6 19.♖g1 ♘8d7 20.♖g4 a4 21.♘c1 b3?! 22.cxb3 ♖fc8 23.♗b5!± Ivanov-Carroll, cr 2000.

O 16...♖c8 17.♗h3 a4 18.♘c1 ♘a6 is one of the latest attempts to resurrect the line, but White's attack arrives fast: 19.h5! ♖cb8 20.g6 ♗f6 21.gxf7+ ♔xf7 22.♗e6+ ♔f8 (Topalov-Van Wely, Wijk aan Zee 2007) and now both Ftacnik and Van Wely recommend 23.♕d3! although their evaluations dif-

fer: 23...♘ac5 (23...b3 24.cxb3 axb3 25.♘xb3±) 24.♕xh7 ♔e7 25.♖hg1 ♘xe6 26.dxe6 ♔xe6 27.h6±. No mercy for the black king.

17.h5 a4

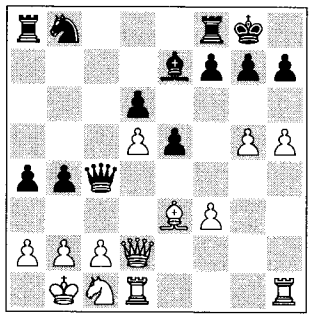
O 17...♘c4 merely gives White more options: 18.♗xc4 ♕xc4 19.♖dg1!? (trying to transpose with 19.g6 is possible, since it is unlikely that Black will play other than 19...a4) 19...a4 20.♖g4 (this small detail blocks the attack) 20...♕a6 21.♘c1 b3 22.g6 and now either White's attack goes faster or he will simply capture Black's pawn, Bruzon-Delgado, Camagüey ch-CUB jr 1999;

O 17...♘8d7 normally ends up in a transposition: 18.g6!.

18.♘c1 ♘c4

It looks as though there is no other way to continue the attack or, at least, nobody has tried any other way. 18...a3 19.b3 and the attack is blocked.

19.♗xc4 ♕xc4



20.g6!

Both sides arrive almost at the same time, but the white pieces are better placed to fulfil the double tasks of defence and attack.

20...♘d7

The knight gives way to the rook and comes over for the defence; it is hard to think of a more efficient move. 20...fxg6 21.hxg6 hxg6 (21...h6? 22.♗xh6+–) 22.♕g2±; 20...b3 21.cxb3 axb3 22.gxh7+ must transpose.

21.gxh7+ ♔h8?!

21...♔xh7 is necessary, but White is still better, for example: 22.♖hg1 a3 23.♖g4 ♕c7 24.♖dg1 ♗f6 25.b3 with a clear advantage.

22.♖hg1

Aiming at g7, but threatening 23.♖g4 too. I see no differences with 22.♖dg1.

22...b3

22...♖fb8 23.♕g2 ♗f8 (23...♗f6 24.♗g5+–) 24.♗h6!+–.

23.cxb3 axb3 24.♖g4!

This virtually forces the black pawn to become a shelter for the white king.

24...bxa2+ 25.♔a1 ♕c7

Against other queen retreats, White's attack just goes on in the same fashion.

26.♖dg1

There is no way to defend g7.

26...♗f6

If 26...♘f6 27.♖xg7, and the threats against the black king (such as 28.♗h6 followed by ♖g8) are really serious.

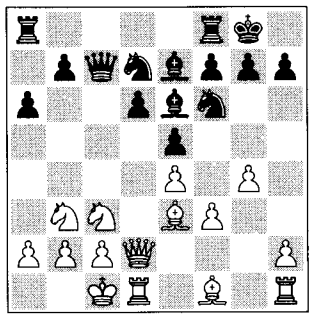
27.♗h6!+– ♕a5 28.♗xg7+ ♗xg7 29.♕g5 ♗f6 30.♕h6

1-0

Game 19.06

Svidler,Peter
Kempinski,Robert
Moscow Aeroflot Open 2003

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 a6 6.f3 e5 7.♘b3 ♗e6 8.♗e3 ♗e7 9.♕d2 0-0 10.0-0-0 ♘bd7 11.g4 ♕c7!?



This move is the beginning of a plan which became the main line in the first years of the new century. It still retains a certain popularity, although it has been replaced by the plan explained in the subsequent games. Black follows a very accurate order: by playing ...♗e7 and ...0-0, he forces White to castle and now prepares the transfer of the king's rook to c8 (sometimes to b8). The idea is to play useful moves for the upcoming attacking race; at the same time, Black doesn't want to compromise his position by weakening the queenside too soon with ...b5, as in that case White often gets good play by moving the knight to d5, recapturing with the pawn and then threatening a potential invasion of c6 by a knight. Another essential point is to stop White's attack by playing ...♘h5; finally, if White plays h4-h5 first, intending to play g4-g5 later, Black will try to take the lead in the attacking race. White, on his part, has also developed several ideas to punish the weak points in the black set-up.

12.♔b1

I'd like to recommend this flexible move, as Black still has to define his position. Playing h4-h5 first looks subtle, but has some problems: **12.h4 b5!** Now Black embarks on the attacking race and if White answers with the positional move ♘d5, Black will try to exploit the weakness on g3:

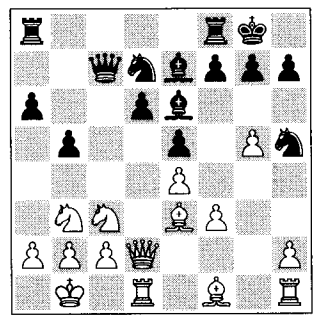
A) **13.♘d5** ♗xd5 14.exd5 ♖fc8 15.♔b1 ♘b6 16.♗xb6 ♕xb6∓;

B) **13.h5** ♖fc8 14.g5 b4 15.♘e2 ♘e8∓ and Black's attack goes very fast now;

C) **13.g5** ♘h5 14.♘d5 ♗xd5 15.♕xd5 ♘b6 16.♕d2 ♘g3 17.♖g1 ♘xf1 18.♖dxf1 ♘c4∓.

12...♖fc8!?

Black insists on the strategy of not weakening his position with ...b5. This move is the actual key to the plan.
The old line was **12...b5 13.g5 ♘h5**



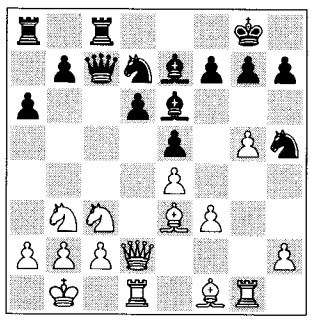
14.♘d5 This move involves a thematic pawn sacrifice in exchange for the control of the light squares. It has become standard in this variation and still looks the best. However, we cannot ignore the excellent results achieved with the following new idea: 14.f4!? exf4 15.♗xf4 ♘xf4 16.♕xf4 ♖ac8 17.♘d4 ♘b6

18.♗d3 ♕c5 19.♘f5 ♖ce8 (19...♗d8 is an improvement suggested by Karjakin, but it is still untested) 20.♘xe7+ ♖xe7 21.e5!± Karjakin-Alekseev, Khanty-Mansiysk 2007. **14...♗xd5 15.exd5** White intends to play ♘a5-c6 with overwhelming control. **15...♘b6 16.♘a5!** In spite of everything. This thematic pawn offer is what has made Black turn to 12...♖fc8. **16...♘xd5 17.♕xd5 ♕xa5 18.c4!** Playing on the queenside. The grip on the light squares seems to offer serious compensation for the pawn. **18...♖ab8** 18...♕b4?! 19.♖g1 ♖ab8 20.cxb5 axb5 21.a3 ♕a4 22.♖g4 (Bologan-Fressinet, Pamplona 2001/02) and now Ftacnik's recommendation is interesting: 22...b4 23.♖c1 ♕d7 24.axb4 ♖fc8, but White still looks to be better, due to his passed b-pawn. **19.♗d3! ♕b4 20.♗d2 ♕a4 21.♖he1 bxc4 22.♗xc4 ♖bc8 23.b3 ♕d7 24.♗xa6 ♖a8 25.♗b5±** (Shirov-Areschenko, Fügen tt 2006) and White has won back the pawn, while keeping his firm grip on the light squares.

13.g5

White is reluctant to choose this move, as the knight will be an obstacle for White's attack from h5, but the attacking race doesn't end well: 13.h4 b5 14.g5 b4∓.

13...♘h5 14.♖g1!



Another mysterious move, but its goal is the same as on the previous ones; White keeps on making useful moves and waits for Black to play ...b5 before jumping to d5. Anyway, an immediate ♘d5 is possible and there is wide room for improvement in this line.

14...a5

Black insists on doing without ...b5, but this move creates a new weakness and I think it is dubious. However, there are two serious alternatives:

O 14...♘b6 This may be the critical move. White has several tries, for example: **15.♕f2! ♗d8** (Topalov-Kasparov, Leon rapid 1998) 15...♘c4 16.♗xc4 ♕xc4 17.♘d5 ♗xd5 18.♖xd5± and White has control over the important spot d5. Now my suggestion is: **16.f4! ♘xf4** 16...exf4?! 17.♗d4± **17.♗xf4 exf4 18.♕xf4 ♘a4 19.♖g3 ♘xc3+ 20.♖xc3 ♕e7 21.♖g3±** intending ♘d4xe6.

O 14...b5 15.♘d5! Now we know why this move is appropriate at this moment. Inserting ♖g1 and ...♖fc8 doesn't harm White. **15...♗xd5 16.exd5 ♘b6 17.♘a5! ♘xd5 18.♕xd5 ♕xa5 19.♗h3** Now 19.c4 looked worse but there is this new theme. 19.♗c4!? is another idea worth studying: 19...♖f8 20.♗b3 ♔h8 (Nunn-D.Popovic, playchess.com 2003) 21.♕b7! ♕d8 22.♗d5±) **19...♖f8 20.♗g4 ♘f4 21.♗xf4 exf4 22.♖ge1±** The white army controls the board.

O 14...g6 15.♕f2! b5 16.♘d5 ♗xd5 17.♖xd5±.

15.a3 ♘b6 16.f4

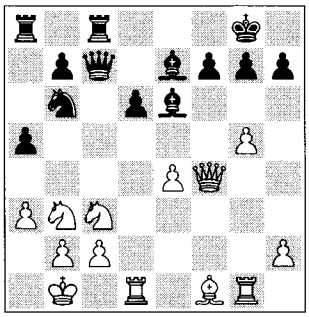
The development of the game is very interesting for White, but I think there is an even better move: **16.♕f2!** ♘c4 (16...♗d8? 17.♘b5+–) 17.♗xc4 ♕xc4 18.♘d5 ♗xd5 19.♖xd5 b5?!

(the logical follow-up) 20.♘c5! (this move traps the queen, though it is true that Black gets a reasonable amount of material as compensation) 20...dxc5 (20...♖xc5 21.b3 ♕c3 22.♖d3±; with 20...b4 21.b3 ♕b5 22.a4 ♕c6 23.♘d3± Black saves his queen, but his position has lost all active prospects) 21.b3 ♕c3 22.♖d3 (22.♗d2!? ♕d4 23.♖xd4 cxd4±) 22...♕xd3 23.cxd3±.

16...♘xf4

16...exf4?! 17.♗xb6 ♕xb6 18.♗e2±.

17.♗xf4 exf4 18.♕xf4



18...♘c4?!

The critical move is **18...♘a4** 19.♖g3 ♘xc3+ 20.♖xc3 ♕b6 (20...♕d8 21.♖g3 d5 is an interesting reaction, but White can still claim some advantage with 22.♘d4! dxe4 23.♗e2 ♗d6 24.♘xe6 ♗xf4 25.♖xd8+ ♖xd8 26.♘xf4±) 21.♖xc8+ (21.♖g3! g6 22.♘d4 ♖c5 23.♘xe6 fxe6 24.♕g4± and White has an overwhelming grip on the light squares) 21...♖xc8 22.♘d4 ♕c5 23.h4 f6 24.♕h2 ♗g4 25.♖d3 Lukin-Zagrebelny, Moscow 2003.

19.♖g3 g6 20.♘d4 ♗f8?!

20...♗d7? 21.♗xc4 ♕xc4 22.♘d5+−; 20...♕b6 21.♘a4 ♕c7 22.♖c3 b5 23.♘xe6 fxe6 24.♕g4±.

21.♘db5

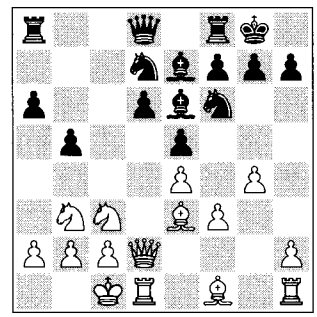
And White wins a pawn, although it won't be easy to realize his material advantage.

21...♕b6 22.♗xc4 ♖xc4 23.♘xd6 ♖d4 24.♖xd4 ♕xd4 25.♘db5 ♕b6 26.♘c7 ♖d8 27.♘3d5 ♗d6 28.♕f1 ♕d4 29.♘f6+ ♔h8 30.♘xe6 fxe6 31.♖d3 ♕e5 32.♘xh7 ♗e7 33.♖xd8+ ♗xd8 34.♕f7 ♕g7 35.♕e8+ ♔xh7 36.♕xd8 ♕e5 37.♕d7+ ♔g8 38.♕c8+ 1-0

Game 19.07

Motylev,Alexander
Odeev,Khandzhar
Linares Open 2001

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 a6 6.♗e3 e5 7.♘b3 ♗e6 8.f3 ♗e7 9.♕d2 0-0 10.0-0-0 ♘bd7 11.g4 b5



Once castled, it seems as though Black should quickly launch his attack, but even here some slower alternatives have been deeply analysed.

O 11...♕c7!? See the previous game.

O 11...♖c8 12.h4 (but not 12.g5 ♘h5) 12...b5 13.h5 ♘b6 (Ponomariov-Shneider, Donetsk zt 1998) and now

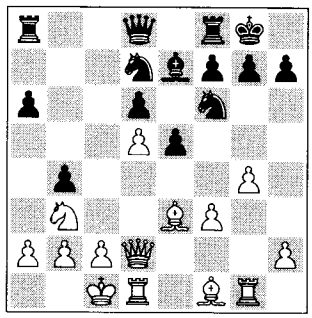
14.g5 b4 15.♘a4! ♘xe4 (15...♘xa4 16.gxf6 ♗xf6 17.♕xb4±) 16.fxe4 ♘xa4 17.♗xa6 ♖a8 18.♗b7 ♖b8 19.♗d5±;

❶ 11...♘b6 12.h4 and now Black has little more than 12...♖c8, which leads to the previous note or to the notes to Game 19.04. For example: 12...♘c4?! 13.♗xc4 ♗xc4 14.g5 ♘h5 15.♘d5±; 12...♕c7?! is an imprecise order and does not transpose in view of 13.h5!→.

12.g5

Now that Black has played ...b5, it does not matter that the black knight jumps to h5 and stops the pawns, because White has a new plan based on the weakness of the c6-square. Nevertheless, 12...♘e8, analysed in the next game, has radically changed the evaluation of this variation and forces us to think that 12.g5 is not as unquestionable as thought some years ago. That is why we offer now a couple of interesting alternatives, though we don't mean to be exhaustive in the analysis:

❶ 12.♖g1!? has achieved a certain popularity and excellent results. The idea is to wait for Black to move before jumping to d5 and to keep the f5-square from the black bishop. **12...♘b6** 12...b4?! justifies White's idea. 13.♘d5! (now Black must give up his bishop) 13...♗xd5 14.exd5 and now:

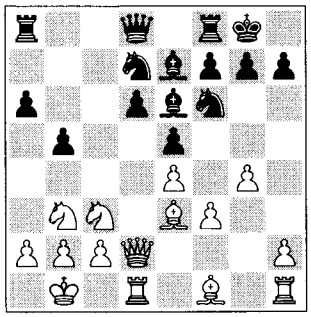


A) 14...♘b6 (in spite of the attack on d5, Black doesn't prevent the white knight from jumping to its favourite spot) 15.♘a5! ♘fxd5 16.♘c6 ♕c7 17.♘xe7+ ♕xe7 18.♗xb6 ♘xb6 19.♕xd6 ♕g5+ 20.♕d2±. The white bishop is better than the knight in the middlegame and especially in the ending;

B) 14...a5 15.g5 ♘h5 16.♔b1 a4 (16...♖b8 17.h4 f5 18.♕e2 a4 19.♘d2 ♕c7 20.♕c4 ♖fc8 21.♕xc7 ♖xc7 22.♘c4 ♖a8 (Anand-Morozevich, Monaco (blind) 2006) and now 23.♗d2! poses quite a lot of problems for Black: 23...♖b7 24.g6 ♘df6 25.♗d3 e4 26.fxe4 fxe4 27.gxh7+ ♔xh7 28.♗e2±) 17.♘c1 ♕a5 18.♘d3 ♖fb8 19.♖g4± (Dominguez Perez-Van Wely, Foros 2007) and Black can't find an adequate defence for the b4 pawn. **13.♘a5!** The knight puts a foot on c6 and keeps an eye on c4. Now White is able to speed up his kingside attack. **13...♖c8!?** 13...♕c7 14.g5 ♘fd7 (here 14...♘e8?! is worse, because the black queen has wasted time: 15.♘d5! ♘xd5 16.exd5 ♗d7 17.f4±) 15.♘d5 ♗xd5 16.exd5 ♘xd5 17.♕xd5 ♕xa5 18.♗d3. White has the typical compensation on the light squares and he quickly translated this trump into a decisive attack: 18...♕c7 19.g6! ♘f6?! (19...hxg6 20.♖xg6 ♘b6 – 20...♔h8 21.♖g3→ – 21.♖dg1!+–) 20.gxf7+ ♔h8 21.♖xg7 ♔xg7 22.♖g1+ ♔h8 23.♗h6 ♘g4 24.♖xg4 ♖xf7 25.♕xa8+ 1-0 Anand-Van Wely, Monaco (blind) 2007. **14.g5 ♘e8** Both 14...♘h5 and 14...♘fd7 are possible, but they haven't been tried yet. **15.a3** If jumping to d5 is impossible, White needs to play this in order to prevent 15...b4. 15.♘d5!? ♘xd5 16.exd5

♗xd5 17.♕xd5 ♕xa5 18.♗h3 ♘c7!∞. The knight comes at the right moment, to dispute the light squares. **15...♕c7 16.♔b1 d5! 17.exd5 ♘xd5 18.♘xd5 ♗xd5 19.♗h3 ♗e6! 20.♗xe6 fxe6 21.♕d7 ♕xd7 22.♖xd7 ♖c7!=** Leko-Svidler, Mexico City Wch 2007.

O 12.♔b1!? This move has not had such good results, nor has it attracted such distinguished practitioners, but it may be played with the same idea as ♖g1, and I consider it an interesting line for research, e.g.:



12...b4 This is now a bit better than against ♖g1. 12...♘b6 13.♘a5 (13.g5!?) 13...♕c7 14.g5 ♘fd7 15.♘d5 ♘xd5 16.exd5 ♗xd5 17.♕xd5 ♕xa5 18.♗d3± (Caspi-Edouard, Kemer jr 2007) and White has the usual compensation. **13.♘e2** 13.♘d5?! ♗xd5 14.exd5 ♘b6 15.♘a5 ♘bxd5 16.♘c6 ♕c7 17.♘xe7+ ♕xe7 18.g5 ♘xe3 19.gxf6 ♘xf1 and now the capture on d2 is with check. **13...a5 14.g5 ♘h5 15.♘g3 ♘f4** (Sutovsky-Sadvakasov, Moscow 2007) and White has the thematic and appealing move 16.♘d4!±.

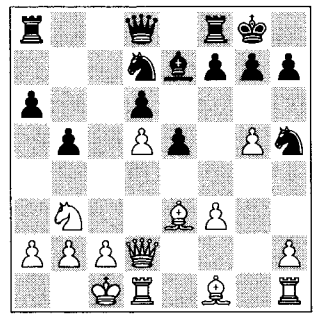
12...♘h5

This has been completely replaced by **12...b4** followed by ...♘e8, which we will analyse in the next game.

13.♘d5

After this and the subsequent exchange, White will have a strong grip on the queenside, especially based on the light squares. The speed of Black's attack will become secondary.

13...♗xd5 14.exd5



14...b4

Preparing ...a5. Virtually all the possible alternatives have been played:

O 14...♖c8?! does not interfere with White's plan: 15.♘a5!±.

O 14...♕c7?! is a bit more subtle: 15.♘a5 ♘f4 16.h4! (offering the d5 pawn when Black has already given his light-squared bishop is a standard positional manoeuvre in this variation; 16.♘c6 ♗xg5∞) 16...♘xd5 17.♕xd5 ♕xa5 18.h5± and the storm on the light squares looks difficult to stop.

O 14...a5?! 15.♗xb5 a4 16.♘a5!±.

O 14...f5!? is a logical reaction: Black is well aware of his queenside inferiority, but has noticed that White's kingside presents weaknesses too. **15.gxf6!** The most logical, in order to exploit White's main asset, that is, the light-squared bishop. But 15.♖g1!? is possible too. **15...♗xf6** The most logical recapture, which has replaced

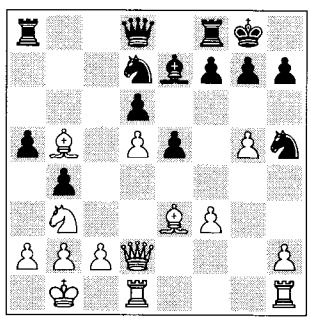
15...♖xf6 16.♘a5 ♘f4 (16...♖xf3? 17.♘c6 ♕e8 18.♗e2+–) 17.♘c6 ♕e8 18.♖e1 (threatening 19.♗xf4) 18...♔f8 (18...♗f8!? 19.♗xf4 ♖xf4 20.♕xf4 exf4 21.♖xe8 ♖xe8 22.♗h3±; 18...♘g6 19.♗h3↑) 19.♖g1 ♕f7 20.♗xf4 ♖xf4 21.♗h3 with a strong initiative for White, Malakhov-Cvitan, St Vincent 2002.

16.♘a5 There is unanimous consent about this move, and so other very logical ideas are untested, such as ♗h3-e6.

16...♘f4 17.♘c6 Once the knight is installed on its outpost and the d-file is blocked, the next step is the positional break c2-c4, increasing the range of the light-squared bishop. **17...♕c7 18.c4 bxc4** 18...♘b8?! 19.♕a5! and Black is in trouble, Svidler-Ponomariov, Sofia 2006. **19.♗xc4** 19.♔b1!? ♘b6 20.♕b4 ♘bxd5 21.♕xc4 ♔h8!∞ **19...♘b6 20.♕a5** Although a bit ugly, this looks necessary: 20.♗b3 a5 21.a4±. **20...♗d8 21.♗b3 ♘d7∞** K.Szabo-Nepomniachtchi, Plovdiv Ech 2008.

O 14...♘b6?! 15.♘a5±.

15.♔b1 a5 16.♗b5!



The drawback of Black's attack, and particularly the drawback of ...♘d7 (from b8, it would watch over c6). White dominates the queenside and in the end takes advantage of Black's attack.

16...a4

O 16...♘b6?! 17.♕f2 ♘c8 18.♗c6 ♖b8 19.♖hg1 ♕c7 20.f4!± Milos-Kuczinsky, Moscow ol 1994.

O 16...f5!? Still a logical and interesting reaction, in need of more practical examples: 17.gxf6 (17.♗c6!? ♖c8 18.h4±) 17...♘hxf6 18.♗c6 ♖c8 19.♕e2?! (19.♖hg1!) 19...♕c7 20.♖hg1 ♘b8 21.♗b5 ♘h5 with an open battle on the whole board, Bauer-Renet, Clichy 2001.

17.♘c1 a3 18.♕xb4

18.b3!? ♖b8 (18...♘c5 19.♕xb4 ♗xg5 20.♗xc5 dxc5 21.♕xc5 yields White an extra pawn, but a certain weakness on the dark squares; however, instead of 19.♕xb4, 19.♗c6! ♖b8 transposes) 19.♗c6 ♘c5 20.♖hg1 ♕a5 21.♖g4 g6 22.♖c4± with a total positional grip, Ganguly-Shanava, Dubai 2004.

18...axb2 19.♘b3±

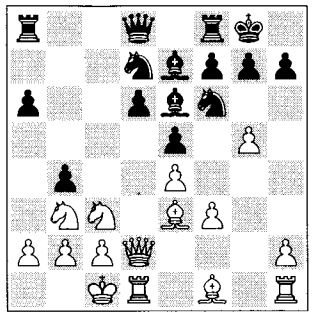
Black can't exploit the weakness of the enemy castled position, because the queenside is controlled by the white pieces.

19...g6 20.♖hg1 ♔h8 21.♖d3 f6 22.♗c6 ♖b8 23.♕a5 ♘b6 24.♘d2 ♘f4 25.gxf6 ♗xf6 26.♗xb6 ♖xb6 27.♖b3 ♖b8 28.♕xd8 ♖fxd8 29.♖e1 ♗h4 30.♖e4 ♗f2 31.♔xb2 ♗d4+ 32.c3 ♗g1 33.♔c2 ♗xh2 34.♖eb4 ♖xb4 35.cxb4 ♘e2 36.♖b1 ♗f4 37.♔d3 ♘d4 38.b5 ♗xd2 39.♔xd2 ♘xf3+ 40.♔d3 ♘d4 41.b6 1-0

Game 19.08

Baramidze,David
Nielsen,Peter Heine
Germany Bundesliga 2005/06

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.♘xd4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 a6 6.♗e3 e5 7.♘b3 ♗e6 8.f3 ♗e7 9.♕d2 0-0 10.0-0-0 ♘bd7 11.g4 b5 12.g5 b4



Making it difficult for the white knight to get to the strong point d5.

13.♘e2!

The knight doesn't jump to d5; it is going to disturb the black knight if the latter goes to h5. After 13.♘d5 ♘xd5 14.exd5 ♗f5 15.h4 a5∓ the initiative is in Black's hands.

13...♘e8!

This move avoids the problems created by ♘g3, but allows f3-f4, and has become the main line in the last years. Just as it was unknown before 2002, maybe nobody will remember it in 2015. Nevertheless, its theory is quickly growing these days and White finds many difficulties to claim even the slightest edge. 13...♘h5?! 14.♘g3 ♘f4 15.h4 a5 16.♔b1 a4 17.♘d4!± was seen in Topalov-De Firmian, Polanica Zdroj 1995.

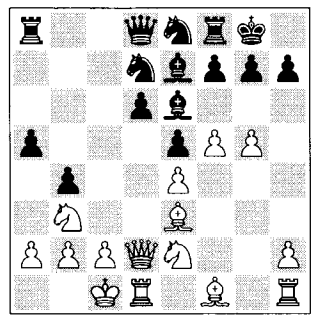
14.f4

Not just the most frequent move, and the favourite of the top players, but also the most logical. White threatens 15.f5 and, if Black takes on f4, White's knight comes back to play.

14...a5

14...exf4 is too indulgent, even though it captures a pawn: 15.♘xf4 (although the knight capture is strategically desirable, the solid bishop capture offers chances for an edge too, e.g.: 15.♗xf4 ♘c5 16.♗g2 ♘xb3+ 17.cxb3 a5 (A.Zaitsev-Loginov, St Petersburg 2003) and now 18.♘d4! a4 19.bxa4 ♖xa4 20.b3 ♖a5 21.h4±) 15...♗xb3 16.cxb3 ♗xg5 17.♕xb4 a5 18.♕d2 ♘ef6 19.♕g2 ♗h6 20.♔b1 ♘e5 21.♖g1±. White's king is somewhat better and his pieces are more active, but Black is solid and enjoys the outpost on e5, Baramidze-Lupulescu, Hengelo jr 2005.

15.f5



15...a4

Although some games with this line existed before 2005, it was in that year when this move (which looks ugly, as it loses the important light-squared bishop) made a strong appearance. At

this moment, this is the most widely-discussed variation at the highest level.

15...♗xb3!? is gaining supporters and at least shows that Black's position is rich in chances of counterplay. **16.cxb3 a4 17.bxa4 ♖xa4 18.b3** The evaluation of 18.♔b1!? depends on the sacrifice 18...♖xa2! (18...♕a8 19.♘c1± ♕xe4+ 20.♗d3 ♕c6 21.♗c2 ♖a8 22.f6±) 19.♘c1 (19.♔xa2 makes Black's task easier: 19...♕a8+ 20.♔b3 ♗xg5 21.♕d3 ♘ef6 22.♗g2 ♗xe3 23.♕xe3 ♕c6 24.♖c1 ♘c5+ 25.♖xc5 dxc5⩲ (Szelag-Bobras, Ustron tt 2007) and Black's position is more pleasant and easy to play) 19...♖a8 and now I propose the interesting 20.♗c4, trying to cover the white king and support the assault on Black's castled position, e.g.: 20...♕a5 (20...♘b6 21.♗b3 ♕c7 22.♕c2 ♕xc2+ 23.♔xc2 ♖c8+ 24.♔d3⩲ and the strength of the b3 bishop offers great compensation for the pawn) 21.♘a2 ♘b6 22.♗b3 d5! (otherwise, White's attack makes a violent start with f5-f6) 23.f6 ♗c5 24.♗xc5 ♕xc5 25.fxg7 ♘xg7 26.exd5 ♘f5 27.♕xb4±. **18...♖a5!** The rook supports the freeing move ...d5. 18...♖a3 19.♔b1± and White has consolidated his castled position, f5-f6 or g5-g6 is coming. **19.♘g3** 19.♔b1 does not prevent 19...d5! either: 20.exd5 ♗c5 21.♗xc5 ♘xc5 22.d6?! (22.f6?! Macak-Bobras, Brno 2008; 22...♘e4! 23.♕xb4 ♖xd5 and Black seizes the initiative; 22.♕xb4!? ♘d6 23.♘c3 is a reasonable attempt for White, but the position is so complex that it is hard to 'predict' who will succeed) 22...♕a8 23.d7 ♘xd7 24.♘g3 ♘c5 25.g6 ♘xb3!∓ and Black seizes the initiative again. **19...d5! 20.exd5 ♗c5 21.♗xc5** 21.♔b1?! ♕a8 22.a4?! (White panics, but I can't find a way to fight seriously for the advantage: 22.♗g1!? ♕a7 23.♗xc5 ♘xc5 24.d6 ♘xd6 25.g6 hxg6 26.fxg6 ♘cb7∞) 22...bxa3 23.♔a2 ♘d6 24.f6 ♖b8−+ Hillarp Persson-Wang Hao, Reykjavik 2008. **21...♘xc5** 21...♖xc5+ 22.♔b1 ♘d6 23.♗d3 ♖e8 24.♖he1 ♕a5 25.♕g2±. **22.d6 ♕a8 23.♕xb4 ♘xd6! 24.♖xd6 ♖xa2** With enormous counterplay. **25.♕xc5 ♖c8 26.♕xc8+ ♕xc8+ 27.♗c4 ♕a8=** forcing the draw.

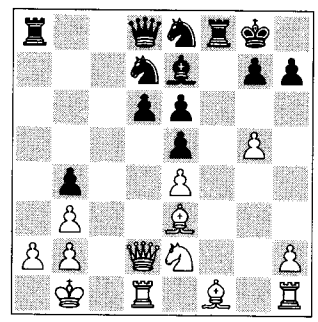
16.fxe6!

16.♔b1?! axb3 17.cxb3 ♖xa2!; **16.♘bd4!?** So far, this is the other line open for research; an example of a long line with concrete moves, only justifiable by analysis, could be 16...exd4 17.♘xd4 b3 18.♔b1 bxc2+ 19.♘xc2 ♗b3 20.axb3 axb3 21.♘a3 ♘e5 22.h4 ♖a4 23.♖h3 ♖xe4 24.♕g2 ♖g4 25.♕b7 ♕c7 26.♕xb3 ♕d7 27.♕c2 d5⇄ and Black finally gets some counterplay, although White may well be able to find an improvement at some moment.

16...axb3 17.cxb3

17.exf7+ ♖xf7 18.cxb3 ♖xa2 19.♘g3 ♖xf1 20.♖hxf1 ♖a1+ 21.♔c2 ♕c8+ 22.♔d3 ♕a6+= leads to a draw.

17...fxe6 18.♔b1



Some years ago, I considered that White had a clear positional edge in this position, but the second player has shown a great ability to create play. The proof is that Black has two very interesting options here. 18.♗h3 is another attempt to prove that the light-squared bishop is a serious asset, but leads to a very unclear position. 18...♖xa2 19.♗xe6+ ♔h8 20.♘g3 ♘c7 21.♗c4 ♕a8 Olszewski-Czakon, Rewal 2007; and if White has any improvement, it must be here: 22.g6!?.

18...♖xa2!

Regarded as best now, but the alternative is also hard to refute:

18...♕a5 19.♘c1 ♘c7 And now, instead of the previous tries 20.♗c4 ♘b6!⩱ (Cvek-Kalod, Brno ch-CZE 2006); 20.♗h3 ♘c5!; 20.h4 ♘c5 21.♗g2 ♘xb3! 22.axb3 ♖fc8−+ I think **20.♗g2!** is more promising: the bishop keeps an eye on d5 and White gets ready to fight for the f-file quickly, with the following alternatives:

A) **20...♘b5** 21.h4 ♖fc8 22.♗h3 and now the bishop exploits the fact that e6 is unprotected: 22...♘f8 23.♖hf1 ♖xc1+ 24.♔xc1 ♕xa2 25.♖xf8+ ♗xf8 26.♗xe6+ ♔h8 27.♕xb4±;

B) **20...♖fc8** 21.♖hf1 ♘b5 22.♗h3! ♘f8 (22...♖xc1+ 23.♔xc1 ♘f8 24.a4!+−) 23.♖xf8+ ♖xf8 24.♗xe6+ ♔h8 25.g6⩱;

C) **20...♘c5** 21.♖hf1 ♖xf1 (21...♘xb3? doesn't work here: 22.♖xf8+ ♗xf8 23.axb3 ♕a1+ 24.♔c2 ♖c8 25.♗f1±) 22.♖xf1 ♕b5 23.♕c2± (preparing the ending with ♕c4) 23...d5 24.exd5 ♘xd5 25.♗xc5 ♗xc5 26.♕d3 ♕xd3+ 27.♘xd3 ♗d6 28.♖e1±.

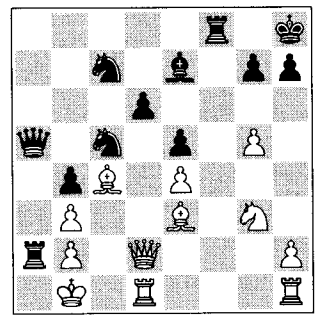
19.♗h3!

Since White can't capture the rook, only this move offers some hopes; 19.♔xa2?! ♕a8+ 20.♔b1 ♕xe4+ 21.♕d3 ♕xh1 22.♗h3 ♕c6 23.♗xe6+ ♔h8∓.

19...♕a5 20.♗xe6+ ♔h8 21.♘g3

21.♗xd7 ♖a1+ 22.♔c2 ♕c7+ (Baramidze-Lahno, Waischenfeld 2006) doesn't offer any advantage.

21...♘c5 22.♗c4 ♘c7



23.♖hf1?!

23.♗xc5 The dangerous knight must be removed; White must focus on his counterplay on the light squares: 23...♖a1+ (23...dxc5? 24.♘f5+−) 24.♔c2 ♖xd1 25.♕xd1 ♕xc5 26.g6!? ♖f4 (26...♘e6 27.♔b1 ♘d4 28.♖f1! and in the game of diagonals, the black king is in more danger) 27.♕h5 h6 28.♔b1 d5!? (28...♘b5 29.♘f5 ♗f8 30.♖c1 ♕b6 31.♕d1± with a crushing attack on the light squares) 29.♗e2↑ and White has many interesting threats, such as 30.♘f5, 30.♖c1 or 30.♕h3. However, improvements for both sides can be found at any moment.

23...♖a8 24.♗xc5 ♕xc5 25.♕f2? ♕xc4 0-1

SUMMARY

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.d4 cd4 4.♘d4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 a6 6.♗e3

– 6...b5?!: dangerously weakening the queenside ±

– 6...♕c7!?: interesting. Forces a more positional approach ±/=

– 6...♘bd7: ambitious, but doesn't achieve its goals due to 7.g4 ±

– 6...♘c6: interesting. This may equalize, if White is not well prepared ±

6...♘g4 gives a lot of counterplay, and now: 7.♗g5 h6 8.♗h4 g5 9.♗g3 ♗g7

– 10.h3 ♘f6: lots of play for both sides, although White has the better chances ±

– 10.h3 ♘e5: the critical line but after 11.♘f5 White's strategic edge is unquestionable ±

6...e5 7.♘b3 with the following possibilities:

– 7...b5?!: weakens the queenside ±

– 7...♘bd7: makes White's attack easier ±

– 7...♗e7 (without ...♗e6): not very explored. It looks unsound, but solid ±

7...♗e6 8.f3 and now:

– 8...d5: solid but extremely passive ±

– 8...♘c6: not very explored. It allows White to get the bishop pair ±

8...♘bd7 9.♕d2

– 9...♘b6: not very effective in this order ±

– 9...♖c8: not very flexible ±

– 9...b5 10.0-0-0 ♘b6 11.♕f2: Black has lots of problems ±/±

8...♗e7 9.♕d2

– 9...b5?!: still premature and weakening ±

– 9...d5?!: still premature and passive ±

– 9...♘c6?!: worse than on the previous move ±

– 9...h5!?: positional and very sound. I suggest switching to a plan with 0-0 =/±

9...♘bd7 10.g4

– 10...b5?!: not the right moment either. Weakening ±

– 10...♘b6?!: limits counterplay ±

– 10...♖c8: again, not very flexible ±

– 10...h6: one of the critical lines, but White has a considerable initiative ±

8...♗e7 9.♕d2 0-0 10.0-0-0

– 10...a5: in spite of its anti-positional appearance, it offers certain counterplay ±

– 10...b5: leads to a violent battle, but Black needs an improvement at some point ±

– 10...♘bd7 11.g4 ♖c8: the same as other instances of ...♖c8 but less flexible ±

– 10...♘bd7 11.g4 ♕c7 12.♔b1 b5: forces White to offer a pawn in exchange for the light squares, but with good compensation ±

– 10...♘bd7 11.g4 ♕c7 12.♔b1 ♖fc8: an interesting refinement. Black plays for the initiative, but White usually gets some control of the key squares ±

8...♗e7 9.♕d2 0-0 10.0-0-0 ♘bd7 11.g4 b5 12.g5

– 12...♘h5: gives White a comfortable initiative ±

– 12...b4 13.♘e2 ♘e8!: the trendy line, in which both 15...♗b3 and 15...a4 offer Black good prospects of counterplay ±/=

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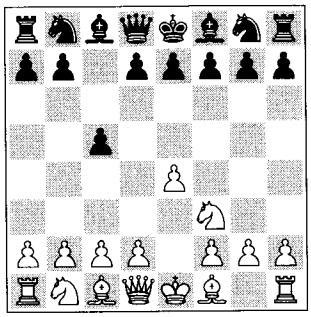
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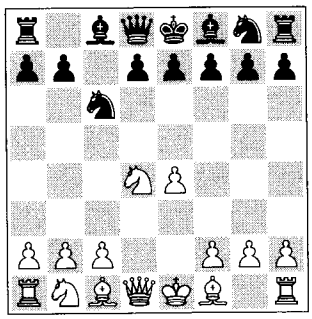
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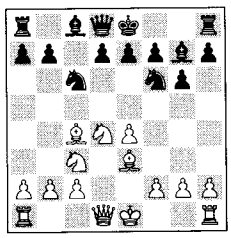
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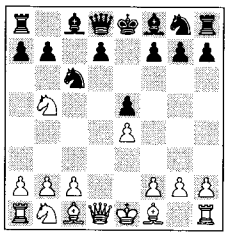
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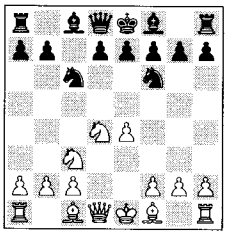
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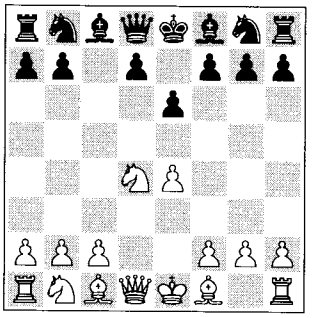
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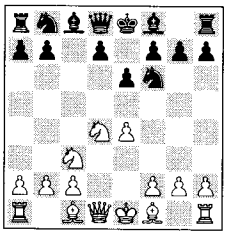
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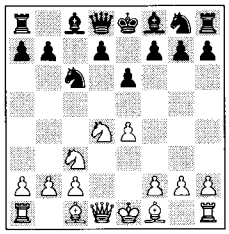
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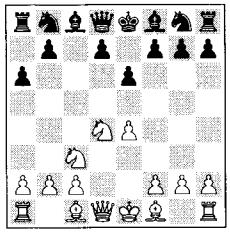
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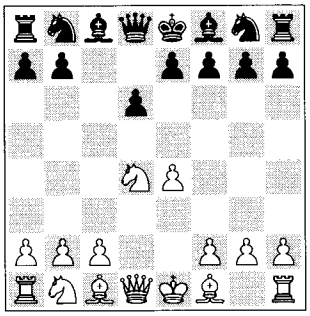


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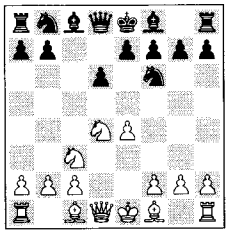
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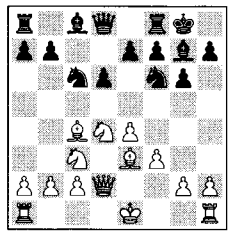
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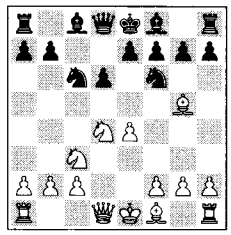
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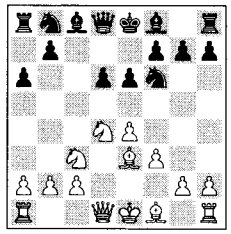
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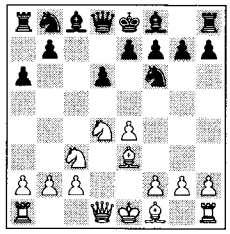
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